Densetsu no Shinobi no Sho

Legend of the Shinobi Scrolls

A Story by Darius Cîmpan

ACT I
ASHES

Chapter 1
Ash

The smoke did not move.

It lay over the village in one long grey shelf, low enough to touch the tops of the pines, and it stayed there. No wind came to take it. Under it the air shook. Heat rose off the ground in slow ripples that bent everything behind them — the road, the black stumps of the houses, the far line of the hills — so that nothing held its shape for long.

Ren stood at the edge of the paddies and watched it shake.

His feet were in the mud of the dike. The mud was warm. It was never warm. Even in the sixth month, even when the stones around the well burned the backs of your legs, the mud at the water's edge stayed cool and smelled of green things. Now it was warm as a bath, and it smelled of the same thing everything smelled of.

The sky had been white when he came up from the river. Now it was red. He did not remember the part between.

His hands were still wet. River water ran from his fingers and dropped onto the dry grass of the dike, and the grass took it without a sound. The grass was yellow. Near the road it was black, in long fingers that reached from the road toward the field and then stopped.

In the pines above the shrine steps, one cicada was singing.

Only one. The rest of the grove was quiet. It sang in long, rising pulses, louder, louder, then cut off. Then it began again. Thinner.

Ren walked.

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The road into the village was the same road. He knew the flat stone that rocked when you stepped on it. He stepped on it. It rocked.

The bamboo fence around the ox pen was gone. Where it had stood there was a row of short black teeth in the ground, each one still glowing orange in its cracks. The oxen were inside. They were lying down. All of them, facing the same way.

He counted them. Three. There had been four.

The fourth was by the road. It was not lying down the same way.

He looked at it. Its eye was open, and dry, and a fly walked across it. The ox did not blink.

He kept walking.

The houses along the road had no roofs. The thatch had gone up and come down again as ash, and the ash lay grey and soft over everything — the step stones, the water barrels, the shapes in the doorways. It did not drift. It lay in a skin so smooth that his feet left marks in it, small and clear, the shape of his toes, and when he looked back he could see the line of them following him down the road. The only marks there.

The posts still stood. Most of them. They were black and split, and some of them ticked as they cooled, a small dry sound, like a fingernail tapping wood. One leaned. As he passed it a piece let go and fell into the ash with a soft breath of sparks, and the sparks rose a little way and went out.

The smell was in his mouth now. He could taste it. Burned straw. Burned wood. Hot iron. Under those, something heavy and sweet, like the autumn festival, where the old man turned fish on sticks over the coals. Under that, something that was not sweet at all, that closed the back of his tongue and turned his stomach over once, slowly, like a fish in a bucket.

He did not know what it was. His body did. It told him to stop breathing through his nose. He stopped.

There were people in the road.

They were lying down. Some were in the doorways, half in and half out, as if they had been going somewhere and decided to rest. Some were in the road itself. One sat against the side of the well with its head forward on its chest and its hands in its lap, and its hair was gone.

Ren looked at the hands. The fingers were curled, black at the tips and pink in the creases. There was something in one of them. A ladle. A wooden ladle for dipping water. It was burned too.

He looked at the ladle for a long time.

Then he looked at the well.

The rope was gone. The bucket was gone. Where the crossbeam had been, a black stick hung by one end. Below it the well opened, round and dark, and when he leaned over it the air that came up was cold. Cold. He leaned further. He could not see the water. He could hear it, far down. A small wet sound. A drop falling into it somewhere in the dark.

His throat was dry. He had not noticed until the cold came up out of the well and touched his face.

He put his hand down into the dark. It found nothing. He stretched. Nothing.

He took his hand back.

Far down, the drop fell again.

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His feet hurt.

He noticed it the way you notice a sound that has been going on for a long time. The ash was hot underneath the grey. Not everywhere. Only where the embers had fallen and hidden themselves. He had been walking on them. When he lifted one foot and looked at the sole, it was white in two places and shining, and there was ash stuck in the shine.

He put the foot back down. He walked on it.

Past the headman's house. Past the place where the dogs slept in the afternoons. One of the dogs was there, sleeping in the same place.

Past the persimmon tree. Its leaves were brown and curled on one side and green on the other. The green side faced away from the road. Small hard fruit hung there, green, too early. One had fallen. He stepped around it.

A red cord in the ash.

He stopped. It was a sandal cord, bright red, the kind a girl ties with a double knot. The sandal it belonged to was a black lump. The cord was not. It lay across the grey in a small, perfect curve, as if someone had just set it down.

He knew whose it was.

He looked at it. Red on grey. The knowing stayed where it was.

He walked on.

The cicada in the pines had stopped. He did not know when. There was no sound now but the ticking of the posts, his own feet in the ash, and somewhere behind him the soft collapse of something giving up its shape.

His breath was loud. It went in and came out, and it scraped. He coughed. The cough hurt his chest, and he coughed again because of the hurt, and bent over with his hands on his knees and coughed until his eyes ran. The water ran down his face and dropped into the ash, and made two small dark spots there, round, like the eyes of something.

He straightened.

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His house was at the end of the road, where it turned toward the hill.

He knew it by the step. A flat grey stone with a crack across one corner. He had sat on that step every evening of the summer to watch the swallows go in under the eaves. There were no eaves now. There was the step, and behind the step a square of black posts and fallen beams, and in the middle of the square, the hearth.

The hearth was still there. The stones were still in their ring. The iron hook still hung from its chain, but the beam that held the chain had come down, and the hook lay across the stones at an angle, and the pot was still on it. The black iron pot. Its lid had fallen off and lay beside it upside down, like a bowl.

He stepped over the step.

Something was under the big beam. The roof beam, the one his whole arm could not reach around. Something long, lying the way the people in the road were lying. The beam was across the middle of it.

Ren looked at the pot.

He looked at the pot, and at its lid, and at the ring of stones, and at the ash inside the ring, which was finer and lighter than the ash everywhere else. White, almost. The old ash of all the fires that had been made in that place, morning after morning.

He did not look at the beam again.

His legs went.

They did not fold. They stopped holding him, both at once, and the ground came up, and he was sitting in the ash beside the hearth with his legs out in front of him and his hands in his lap. The ash was warm. He could feel it through his clothes. Not burning. Warm, the way the floor was warm in winter when the fire had been banked all night and he pressed his back against the stones.

He lay down.

He lay on his side, the way he slept, facing the hearth. The ash shifted under his cheek, then held him. It was the softest thing in the whole village, and it was warm, and it did not hurt.

The sky over him was the color of the inside of a coal.

He watched it.

A crow came down out of the smoke and landed on the last standing post of the gate. It folded its wings. It turned its head and looked at him with one eye, then the other. It did not call. It did not move.

Ren looked back at it.

His eyes were heavy. The ash had gotten into them, and they stung, and every time he blinked the crow was still there and the sky was a little darker. His lips were cracked. His feet had stopped hurting. His hand lay open in front of his face, ash in the lines of the palm, grey in the grey. He looked at it and could not remember what it was for.

He was a small warm weight in a large warm place, and the place was quiet, and the quiet went all the way down.

The crow shifted its feet on the post.

Above the village, the smoke did not move.

Chapter 2

The Man

Someone was breathing.

Not him. His own breath was there too, short and scraped, catching at the top of his chest. This other breath was slower. Long in. A pause. Long out. It did not change. It did not hurry.

Ren did not open his eyes.

Other things came first. Heat on one side of his face, cold on the other. Something heavy over him, rough, that smelled of smoke. Not the smoke of thatch and hair. Wood smoke, clean and dry, and under it oil, and something old, like the inside of a chest no one had opened in a long time. Under him, hardness. Stone, with a thin mat between.

A snap. A hiss. The small bright crack of a knot splitting in the heat.

His whole body went stiff.

He opened his eyes.

The fire was small. It sat in a ring of stones, low and orange, and it stayed there. It did not come toward him. Its smoke rose straight, then leaned, then slid along the rock above and out through a dark opening, as if it knew the way.

Rock overhead. Rock walls, dark and damp where the light reached them. The light reached them, and pulled back, and reached them again.

Across the fire, a man.

He was sitting with his legs folded and his hands on his knees. He was not doing anything. That was the first thing Ren saw. Grown people were always doing something. This one sat the way the rock sat.

His eyes were on Ren.

The breathing was his. Long in. Pause. Long out.

His hair was tied back, black going grey at the sides, loose strands across his forehead that he did not push away. His face was thin and brown and lined at the eyes, and the lines had not come from smiling. His hands were large. The knuckles were thick. There was a pale seam across the back of the left one, old and smooth.

He did not smile. He did not speak. He did not lean forward.

Ren tried to sit up. His arms pushed and shook and gave, and he fell back onto the mat. The man watched it happen.

Ren lay still. His feet throbbed. He looked down the length of the heavy thing over him and saw his feet sticking out the end of it, wrapped in strips of pale cloth, tied neatly at the ankles. He did not remember them being wrapped.

His throat closed on nothing.

The man moved.

It was the first time. He reached to his side without looking, and his hand found a clay jar and a wooden cup in the dark as if they had been waiting exactly there. He poured. The sound of it — water, falling into wood — went through Ren like a hook through a fish. His whole body turned toward it.

The man rose. He came around the fire in three steps, knelt, slid one hand behind Ren's back and lifted him, and set him against the wall as easily as setting down a bundle. The hand was dry and warm and very strong. Then it was gone, and the cup was in Ren's hands.

He drank.

He tipped it all at once. The water came too fast, into his mouth and his nose and down the wrong way, and it came back out of him in a cough, down his chin, onto the blanket. He coughed and coughed and tried to drink through the coughing, and more of it went down the wrong way, and more came back out.

The cup was gone.

The man had it. He had taken it out of Ren's hands, and Ren had not felt it go. He sat back on his heels and held it in front of him, and waited.

Ren reached for it.

The man did not pull it away. He did not bring it closer. It stayed where it was, a little past the ends of Ren's fingers.

Ren's hand stayed out in the air. Shaking. Reaching.

The man looked at the hand. Then at Ren's face. His own face did not change.

The cough stopped. Ren's breath was loud and quick. The man waited. The breath went on being loud, and then, because there was nothing else for it to do, it slowed.

The cup came back.

Ren drank. Fast again. Not as fast. Water ran down his chin to his collar.

The man's hand came and took the cup away.

Ren stared at him. Something rose in his chest, small and hot. He grabbed.

The cup went up. One finger's width. No more. His fingers closed on air beneath it.

The man held it there, and waited.

Ren's hand came down.

The third time, the man did not let go. His fingers stayed on the bottom of the cup. When Ren tipped it, the fingers held, and the cup would only tip so far. One mouthful came. Then the fingers tipped it back level.

Ren swallowed.

It went down. It went all the way down, cold, and he felt it arrive somewhere in the middle of him, and stay.

The fingers tipped the cup. One mouthful. Level. He swallowed.

Once more. Level. Swallow.

Once more.

Then the fingers were gone, and Ren was holding the cup by himself.

He looked at the man. The man looked at him.

Ren tipped the cup. Not far. One mouthful. He lowered it. He swallowed. He breathed. He tipped it again.

The man sat back. His hands went to his knees.

Ren drank the whole cup that way. When it was empty he held it in his lap with both hands. His hands shook less than they had.

The man's eyes moved over him. Not over his face. Over his hands on the cup. His throat. His breath. The wrapped feet. Then back to his hands. The way you look at a roof after a storm, to see where it let the rain in.

Then he rose, went back around the fire, and sat where he had been sitting, and was still again.

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The fire ticked. Beyond the opening it was night. Wind moved somewhere far below in a great many trees, a long sound that rose and fell and never stopped. Insects sang out there in the cold. It was cold. Colder than it had ever been at the end of summer.

Against the far wall, two wooden swords leaned side by side. They were exactly straight. They leaned at exactly the same angle. Above them, on a rack of pegs, lay a long sword and a short one in dark scabbards, and nothing else in the cave was as still as they were.

"Where—" His voice came out cracked. It was not his voice. He tried again. "Where is this?"

The man's eyes did not move from him.

"The mountain."

Ren looked at the opening. The dark. The wind in the trees.

"Why am I here?"

The fire settled. A log slumped and sent up a few sparks, and the man watched them go.

"Because you were not there."

Ren held the cup. He held it tighter.

"There was a fire," he said.

The man looked into the ring of stones. He looked at it a long time.

"Fire does not know what it burns."

Ren looked at the fire too. It was small. It stayed in its stones.

"Everyone was lying down," he said.

The man did not answer. He took a stick from the pile beside him and pushed a log deeper into the coals. Sparks rose, and went out against the rock. The wind came up the mountain and went down again. Ren thought he would not answer at all.

"They will not get up."

The words came across the fire and sat down in front of Ren.

He looked at them.

He looked at the cup in his lap. Its empty bottom, wet and dark. His fingers had gone white on the rim. He looked at his fingers. He did not know how to make them let go.

The man watched him not letting go.

A long time passed. The fire burned lower.

"Who are you?"

The man's eyes stayed on him. For a moment he did not move at all. Not even the breath.

"Takezō."

He turned back to the fire.

Ren slid down the wall until he was lying under the heavy blanket again. It was scratchy against his chin. It smelled of smoke and oil and the old closed chest. He pulled it up to his eyes.

Across the fire, Takezō sat with his hands on his knees and looked into the flames.

Ren watched him until his eyes closed on their own.

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Grey light. The cold of the stone through the mat.

Ren woke, and the fire was already burning.

It was new. The wood in the ring was fresh and pale at the ends, the flames clean and bright, and the stones around it had been swept. There was no ash in the ring. There was only the new fire, and the new wood, and in front of it, sitting exactly where he had sat all night, the man.

Takezō's eyes were closed. His breath: long in, pause, long out.

Beside Ren's mat, set on the stone where his hand would find it, was the wooden cup. It was full.

No one had told him it was there.

Ren sat up. His arms held him. He picked up the cup with both hands.

He tipped it. Not far. One mouthful.

He lowered it. He swallowed. He breathed.

Across the fire, Takezō's eyes opened. They rested on Ren's hands. Then on the cup. Then on Ren.

Ren tipped the cup again. One mouthful.

Takezō looked back into the fire.

Outside, the light was coming up the mountain, slowly, the way the water had come.

Chapter 3

Steel and Silence

The water was heavier than it looked.

It lay in the bucket clear and still, a round piece of sky with a leaf turning on it. Then Ren lifted it, and the sky broke.

He carried it up the path from the stream with both hands on the rope and the bucket knocking his shins. Every step, the water climbed the wall of the bucket and jumped the rim and ran down his legs, cold, into the straw of his sandals. The path was steep. Dry leaves lay on it, and chestnut husks, split and spiny, and he stepped on one and hissed and did not stop.

By the time he reached the cave, half the sky was gone.

Takezō sat on his bench beside the entrance with a knife in his hand and a block of pale wood in the other. Shavings curled off the blade and dropped between his feet. He did not look up while Ren set the bucket down. Then he looked up.

He looked at the bucket. Then past it, down the path, at the dark line of spilled water that ran all the way from the stream to Ren's feet like a thread.

"Again."

It was the first time Ren heard the word from him. It was not loud. It did not sound angry. It sounded like a stone being set down.

Ren stood there. The old man went back to his carving.

Ren picked up the bucket and poured what was left into the big jar by the fire, and went back down the path.

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The mornings grew cold, then colder.

The fire was always burning when he woke. Always new. Takezō was always in front of it with his eyes closed and his hands on his knees, breathing the way he breathed, and the ring of stones was always swept. Ren never heard him get up. He never heard the fire being made. Once he tried to stay awake to see it, and woke with the blanket over his face and the fire already crackling and the old man already still.

After the water, the wood. After the wood, the fish. After the fish, whatever the old man pointed at.

In the afternoons, the stance.

Takezō set him in the clearing outside the cave and moved his feet apart with a thin rod of bamboo. Tap. Wider. Tap. The knee, bent. Tap. The back, straight. Then he stepped away, and Ren stood.

At first it was nothing. Then his thighs began to burn. Then they began to shake, small at first, then larger, until his whole body was trembling like a dog in the rain. His knees wanted to straighten. He did not let them. They straightened anyway, and he sat down hard in the leaves.

Takezō looked at him from the edge of the clearing.

"Again."

Ren got up. Tap, tap, tap. He stood. He fell.

"Again."

That night he lay under the blanket and his legs jumped on their own, as if they were still standing. Across the fire, a sound: long, slow, grinding. Shff. Shff. Takezō sat with a whetstone on his knee and a blade laid along it, drawing the steel toward him and away, toward him and away, the firelight running up and down the edge like water. Shff. Shff.

Ren fell asleep to it. It was the sound of every night after that.

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Winter came down the mountain in one night.

He woke and the air in the cave had teeth. The water in the jar had a skin of ice. At the stream he had to break it with a stone before he could fill the bucket, and his fingers went white and then red and then stopped telling him anything at all. He carried the bucket up with hands he could not feel, and watched them, because it was the only way to know they were still holding on.

Inside, Takezō pointed at the ground beside him, facing the cave mouth.

Ren sat.

The old man breathed. Long in. The pause. Long out. His breath went out of him in a long grey cloud that hung in the cold air and thinned and was gone. Then another. Each one the same length. Each one the same shape.

Ren breathed. His breath came out in puffs, short and quick, one on top of another.

The rod touched his chest. Just touched it.

He breathed again. Short.

"Again."

He watched the old man's clouds. He watched his own. He made his longer, and it ran out halfway and he gasped for the rest. He made the pause, and his chest hurt, and he let go too soon.

"Again."

All that winter. Snow on the ledge outside, blue at dawn. The bare branches of the trees below, black against it. Nights so long that he woke twice and it was still dark both times. Beside the fire, the two breaths going out into the cold, one long and even, one short and broken, and the rod, and the word.

One morning near the end of it, he looked at the cave mouth and saw two clouds going out together. The same length. The same shape.

He did not know when it had happened.

Takezō did not say anything. He did not look at him. He only kept breathing, and so did Ren.

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The river thawed with a sound like something cracking in a wall.

Everything was mud. Mud on the path, mud to his ankles at the stream, mud up the backs of his legs and in his hair. New grass came through the old, green and wet. Down by the water the young bamboo pushed up out of the ground, a hand's width in a night, and he could almost watch it move.

Fish came back into the pools.

He stood in the cold water to his knees and reached for them, and they went through his fingers like thoughts. He grabbed faster. They went faster. He fell in. He came up blowing and shaking and furious, and on the bank the old man sat on a stone with his hands on his knees and did not help him and did not laugh.

He stood still because he was too cold to move. His feet went numb. His hands hung in the water.

A fish came and lay against his wrist.

He closed his hand.

He carried it up to the cave in both hands, its tail beating his arm, and held it out. Takezō looked at the fish. Then at Ren's hands. Then at his face.

He took the fish and turned to the fire.

That was all. Ren stood in the mouth of the cave, dripping, with his empty hands, and something in his chest was so big it hurt, and there was nowhere to put it.

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When the spring rains came, the roof of the cave began to drip.

One place near the back. A drop gathered on the rock, grew, hung, fell, and struck the stone floor with a small wet click, and then another began to gather in the same place.

Takezō put a wooden sword in Ren's hands. It was shorter than the two against the wall. Pale. New. The grip was smooth and the length was right, and it fit his hand as if someone had measured his hand while he slept.

Ren looked at it. He looked at the old man's bench, at the curls of pale wood still lying between the feet of it.

The old man pointed at the drop.

Ren swung. The drop fell past the wood and clicked on the stone.

"Again."

He swung. Too early. Too late. Too early. The drops kept falling, each one exactly as slow as the last, and he kept missing them, and the old man sat on his bench and carved, and every time the drop clicked on the stone the word came from the bench without the old man lifting his head.

"Again."

On the fourth day, the wood met the water.

A small cold spray across his knuckles. That was all.

Takezō looked up from his carving. He looked at the wet on the wooden blade.

"Hm."

Then he looked down again, and the knife went on moving.

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Summer. The cicadas started, and did not stop.

Heat lay on the clearing like a hand. Sweat ran into his eyes and stung and he could not wipe it, because his hands were on the wooden sword and the sword was up, and if it came down the word would come. Mosquitoes found him in the stance and fed on his neck, his ankles, the backs of his hands, and he let them. By evening he was swollen and itching all over and did not scratch.

At the edge of the clearing, on the rock where the sun came first, a snake lay along the stone. Long, the grey-green of old bamboo. It had come out of the rocks below the cave before he took the stance, and it did not move while he stood. When the shadows came across the clearing in the evening it was gone. He had not seen it go.

Some days the old man had him cut. The same cut. From above, straight down. A hundred times. Two hundred. The clearing tipped. The trees leaned. His arms kept going up and coming down, and then the ground came up to meet him, and he was lying on his back in the dry grass with the sky turning slowly above him and the cicadas screaming.

A shadow fell across his face.

"Again."

He lay there.

The shadow did not move.

He got up.

He watched the old man walk back to the bench and sit. He thought: he never works. He watched the old man make the fire, and cook the rice, and sit with his eyes closed for half the morning, and carve his wood, and write his short lines on paper at night with the brush moving so slowly it hardly seemed to move at all. He thought: I carry the water. I carry the wood. I catch the fish. He sits.

He thought it very loudly one evening, and dropped an armful of wood beside the fire so hard that sparks jumped.

Takezō did not look up from the brush.

"Hm."

Ren stood there.

Then he knelt and stacked the wood properly, the way it was meant to be stacked, and went out for more.

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The seasons came around. Then they came around again.

Leaves, and the whetstone at night, and the first cold mornings. Ice on the jar, and white breath, and the long dark. Mud, and bamboo, and fish that did not escape. Heat, and cicadas, and the ground that tipped less each year before it came up to meet him.

His sleeves grew short. The blanket, which had once covered him from chin to toes with room to spare, began to leave his feet out in the cold. The small wooden sword grew small in his hand, and one morning there was a longer one beside his mat, pale and new, and the old one was gone, and no one mentioned it.

One day, halfway up the path, he stopped.

He looked into the bucket. The water lay in it, clear and still. A round piece of sky, with a cloud crossing it. It had not broken. He had not noticed it not breaking.

He looked back down the path. The stones were dry all the way to the stream.

He stood there a while, with the bucket in his hands, looking at the sky in it.

Then he carried it up.

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It rained for nine days in the wet season of his ninth year. Maybe his tenth. He had stopped counting.

It was an ugly rain. Not the clean hard rain of summer storms. A thin grey rain that did not fall so much as hang, filling the air below the cave until the trees were gone, and the valley was gone, and the far ridge was gone, and there was nothing out there but grey, and the sound of water dripping from every edge of the world.

Takezō set out two boards, two brushes, the ink stone, and paper. He sat near the entrance, facing out. He pointed at the place beside him.

Ren sat.

The old man ground the ink slowly, the stick turning in the water on the stone until the water went black. Then he wet his brush and looked out at the rain.

Ren looked out at the rain.

Grey. Grey above grey. Here and there something darker that might have been a tree, then wasn't.

He held the brush. He looked at the paper. He looked at the rain.

"I can't see anything."

The old man did not turn his head.

"Paint what you see," he said. Calmly.

Ren looked again. Grey. The drip from the rock above the entrance, falling in a line. Grey behind it.

"But I can't see anything."

Takezō turned. He looked at Ren. There was nothing in his face at all. Not anger. Not patience. It was the face he wore in front of the fire.

"Paint," he said. Calmly.

He turned back to the rain.

Ren looked at the paper for a long time.

Then he wet the brush, and touched it to the ink, and laid it on the paper, and pulled. A smear of grey. He wet it again, with water only, and pulled it through the grey, and the grey spread and softened and bled at the edges. He made another. And another. Grey on grey. No shapes. No trees. Nothing in it.

When he stopped, it was only smudges.

He looked at it. He looked out at the rain.

It was the same.

Beside him, the old man's brush moved slowly on his own paper. Ren did not look at what he was painting. He never found out.

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In the evenings of that year and the next, there was the board.

Takezō set it between them by the fire: the wooden board with its grid of lines, the small five-sided pieces with their names written on them in his hand. He had shown Ren how each one moved, once, without repeating anything. After that, they played.

Takezō always won.

He won quickly. He won slowly. He won when Ren attacked and when Ren waited. He won without seeming to look at the board at all, his eyes half closed, his hand moving a piece forward one square as if it had moved itself. And every time, Ren looked at the pieces and could not see where it had happened. It had happened long before he knew there was anything to see.

One night in his twelfth autumn, the old man's silver general came forward, and there was nowhere left for Ren's king to go.

Ren stared at the board. His face went hot. His hands were fists on his knees.

"Again!"

The word came out of him loud. It hit the rock and came back.

Takezō looked at him.

Then he began to gather the pieces. Quietly. One at a time. He picked each one off the board and laid it in the wooden box, face up, in rows, the way they always went. Ren watched every one go in. The king. The generals. The small soldiers. When the last one was in, the old man set the lid on the box, and pressed it down, and set the box beside his bench.

He picked up his carving.

Ren sat there with the empty board in front of him.

The fire cracked. The knife moved. A curl of wood dropped between the old man's feet.

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Later, when the old man was sitting with his eyes closed, Ren went out into the clearing.

No moon. The cold coming up out of the ground. Crickets somewhere below, slow now, near the end of their season.

He took the stance. His feet went where they went. His knee bent. His back straightened. No rod touched him.

He breathed. Long in. The pause. Long out. His breath went out white into the dark and hung, and thinned, and was gone.

He lifted the wooden sword and brought it down.

It was wrong. He felt it. His weight had gone forward, a finger's width too far, off the center.

He stood still.

Nobody said anything. There was nobody there to say it.

He set his feet again. He lifted the sword.

In the mouth of the cave, against the firelight, the old man was standing. Ren did not know how long he had been there. He did not come out. He did not speak.

Ren brought the sword down. It was right.

When he looked up, the mouth of the cave was empty, and the firelight lay across the ground where the old man had been.

Nobody had said the word.

He had heard it anyway.

Chapter 4

The Word

He woke before the birds, as he always had.

The cave was black. The boy's breathing came from beyond the fire ring, slow and deep, the breath of someone who had worked until his body stopped arguing. Takezō lay and listened to it for the space of ten breaths. Then he rose.

His knees told him about the cold. He let them.

Last night's fire was a bed of grey in the ring of stones, with a few red eyes in it. He knelt and gathered the ash in his hands. It was warm underneath, and soft, and it clung to the hair on his wrists. He carried it out in his cupped palms to the edge of the ledge and opened his hands, and the dark took it. He went back for the rest. Three trips. Then he swept the stones with the twig broom until they were bare.

Tinder in the center. Split pine around it. He struck the steel against the flint, once, twice, low and close so the sound stayed small, and a spark caught. He bent and breathed on it. The flame stood up. He fed it until it could stand on its own.

Then he sat down in front of it, put his hands on his knees, and closed his eyes.

A while later, the boy's breathing changed.

***

The boy had been with him since the summer of the seventh year of Kan'ei. This was the fourteenth. He was no longer small.

Takezō saw it in pieces. The sleeves, which the boy had let out twice and could not let out again. The wrists, thick now where they had been thin. The shoulders, wide enough that the doorway of the cave had begun to notice them. The voice, which cracked that spring and came back lower and did not go up again. The rice pot, which had to be filled twice now to be emptied once.

The boy did not notice any of it. Takezō noticed all of it.

This spring he had put a second wooden sword in the boy's left hand.

The left hand did not know what to do. It hung. It followed. It was late to everything, a heavy thing the right hand had to carry. For a season the rod went to the left elbow, the left wrist, the left shoulder, over and over, and the word went with it.

"Again."

Then, in the summer, something changed that Takezō did not see happen. He only saw that it had.

He lifted the rod toward the boy's left elbow. Before the rod arrived, the elbow dropped. The rod stopped in the air where the elbow had been.

Takezō looked at the rod. "Hm." He lowered it.

It happened again the next day. And the next. The rod would begin to rise and the boy would already be moving, the fault leaving his body a moment before it was named, as if he had heard the correction coming through the ground.

Takezō lifted the rod less.

Then there were days when he did not lift it at all. He sat on the bench with the rod across his knees and watched the boy work through the forms in the clearing, one sword high and one low, stepping, turning, cutting, and when the boy's weight began to drift forward, it came back before it arrived. When a cut began to open too wide, it closed. The mistakes still came. They were smaller now. A step became a toe's width. A breath late became

half a breath. And the boy caught them while they were still forming, the way you catch a cup that has only begun to tip.

On those days Takezō did not say the word at all.

The boy looked at him sometimes, between forms. Waiting. When nothing came, he went on.

***

In the eighth month Takezō decided the cave needed a shelf.

There were too many things on the floor. The ink stone and the brushes. The paper, which drank the damp. The shogi box. The boy's things, which were few, and his own, which were fewer. Things on the floor were things that could be stepped on.

He chose the place. Against the back wall, where the rock was dry and flat.

"There."

The boy looked at the wall. Then at him.

Takezō sat down on his bench.

He had brought the timber down from the ridge in the spring and let it season. Cedar, straight in the grain. The boy carried it in. The boy marked it where Takezō pointed. The boy sawed it, the blade pulling back through the wood in long strokes, the sawdust gathering on his feet and in the hair on his forearms. The boy planed the faces. Takezō watched the curls come off the plane, thin as paper, and said, "Again," when one came off torn. The boy's jaw set. He planed it again.

The boy cut the joints. Takezō pointed at one.

"Loose."

The boy looked at the joint. He looked at the old man on the bench. He put the chisel down harder than it needed to be put down, and picked it up again, and cut a new joint from a new piece.

It went on that way for four days. The boy sawed, and planed, and chiseled, and carried, and fitted. Takezō sat. He pointed. He said "There," and "No," and "Loose," and once, when the boy set a board against the wall and stood back to look at it, simply, "Hm." The boy's back was wet through. His hands were blistered where the plane rode against them. He did not say anything. His shoulders said it for him, and the way he set down every tool.

The boy thought he was not working. Takezō let him think it.

On the fourth evening the boy tapped the last peg home with the heel of his hand and stepped back.

The shelf stood against the rock. Two boards on two uprights, pegged, no iron in it anywhere.

Takezō rose. He crossed to it and put his eye to the end of the upper board and looked along it, the way you look along an arrow. It was straight. He looked along the lower one. Straight. He set his hand flat on the top and pressed. It did not move.

He took his hand away.

He went back to his bench and sat down and picked up his carving.

Behind him, the boy stood a while longer in front of the shelf. Takezō heard him breathe out through his nose. Then he heard him pick up the broom and begin to sweep the sawdust into a pile.

Nothing went on the shelf that night.

***

Two autumns later, the boy was fifteen.

The leaves came down in the ravine below the cave and lay in the stream in rafts, gold and red and brown, turning slowly in the eddies. The mornings smelled of cold stone and woodsmoke. Takezō took the boy into the clearing with a wooden sword of his own for the first time that year.

He did not fight him. He gave him the forms. Takezō attacked in the old order, the order he had made, and the boy received in the old order. Takezō struck from above; the boy crossed his swords and caught it. Takezō struck from the side; the boy turned it. The old sequence. The wood clacked in the cold air and the sound went out over the ravine and came back.

Takezō struck from above again, the fourth movement, the one where the boy would cross the swords high and step back and reset.

The boy did not cross the swords.

His back foot slid a half step. His hips turned. That was all. Takezō's sword came down through the place where the boy's shoulder had been and passed a finger's width from it, and the boy's right sword was resting against the side of Takezō's neck. The left was already low across his belly.

It had not stopped. There had been no break in it. The sequence had simply finished, earlier than it should have.

Takezō stood still with his sword in the dirt.

He looked at the boy's feet. Where they were. Where the weight sat between them. He looked at the hips. The shoulders. The right sword, the wood cool against his neck.

He had never taught that.

The boy's eyes were on him. His breath came in white clouds, even. He was waiting for the rod, or for the word. His face was already ready for it.

Takezō said nothing.

The silence went on long enough that the boy's eyes moved, once, to Takezō's hands, and back. The wind came up out of the ravine and moved the leaves at the edge of the clearing.

Takezō stepped back. He raised his sword to the beginning.

"Again."

The boy went back to the beginning.

They ran it again. First movement. Second. Third. Takezō struck from above. The back foot slid its half step. The hips turned. The sword passed. The wood touched his neck.

The same.

He had not said the word because anything was wrong. He had said it because he wanted to see it again.

Takezō lowered his sword. The boy lowered his.

"Enough," Takezō said, and walked back to the bench.

The boy stood in the clearing a moment longer with both swords at his sides, looking at his own feet.

***

After that the word did not leave. Takezō said it every day. The boy heard it every day. But the rod stayed across his knees, and when he said it, the boy did not look at his elbows or his feet for the fault. He only went back to the beginning and did it again, and each time a little more of it was his.

Takezō watched. That was the work now. He sat on the bench in the mornings with his carving in his hands and the knife not moving, and watched the boy in the clearing, and did not say anything that did not need saying, which was almost everything.

The first snow came late that year.

***

It was a night in the eleventh month. The fire was low and red and there was no sound outside at all, the snow having taken it. Takezō sat with the whetstone on his knee and the blade along it. Shff. Shff. The boy sat across the fire with his knees drawn up and his arms around them. He had not spoken since the rice.

He spoke now.

"Why did you save me?"

Takezō's hands stopped on the stone.

The boy was looking at him. Not at the fire. At him. His face was older in the firelight than it was in the day.

"That day," the boy said.

The fire ticked. A little snow slid off the ledge outside with a soft sound, and was quiet.

Takezō looked at the blade on the stone. The light lay along the edge in a thin line. He looked at the fire. Its heat on his hands. Its smell. The small bright crack of a knot.

He looked at the boy.

"You were alive."

The boy waited.

Nothing else came. There was nothing else. Takezō looked back down at the stone, and drew the blade along it, toward him and away. Shff. Shff.

After a while, the boy looked into the fire. After a longer while, he lay down on his side under the blanket, which no longer covered his feet, and turned his face to the rock.

When the boy's breathing had gone slow, Takezō set down the blade.

He fed the fire one piece of wood. He sat.

Across the ring of stones, the boy breathed.

Long in. The pause. Long out.

Chapter 5

Protection

The fire was already burning.

It always was. Ren had stopped trying to catch it years ago. He lay under the blanket, which reached halfway down his shins now, and watched the old man through the thin haze of smoke that hung under the rock before it found its way out.

Takezō sat in front of the flames with his eyes closed and his hands on his knees. The light moved on his face. There was more grey in his hair than black now. Ren could not remember when that had happened, either.

The fire ticked. Outside, the birds were starting.

"Why do you make the fire every morning?"

Takezō's breath stopped. Only for a moment. The long breath in, and then no breath out, as if the question had caught it on the way.

The fire went on burning. A knot cracked.

"I like the fire."

He opened his eyes. He looked at Ren.

Ren looked back. He waited for the rest of it. The old man's answers were always short, but there was always something under them, the way there was always cold water under the warm at the top of the stream. He waited for the cold water.

Nothing came.

Takezō's shoulders moved. Once. A breath went out through his nose, short and soundless, and something happened at the corners of his eyes that Ren had seen perhaps three times in nine years. Then it was gone.

Takezō looked back at the fire.

Ren lay there under the short blanket. The birds went on outside. A log settled into the coals and sent up a few sparks, and they went up toward the rock and went out, and the moment went with them.

He got up.

***

They went down the mountain in the afternoon. They needed salt, and paper.

It had rained for three days and stopped that morning, and everything below the tree line was still dripping. The path was running water. The road at the bottom was worse. The ox carts had cut it into ruts and the rain had filled the ruts, and the mud between them was the color of old miso and deep enough to take a sandal.

Takezō walked ahead in the middle of the road with his hands in his sleeves and his two swords at his belt, as if the mud were not there. Ren walked behind with the empty basket on his back and his two wooden swords at his own belt, and his feet found the ridges between the ruts without his asking them to.

The paddies on either side were full to the brim. The sky lay in them in long flat pieces, going orange at the western end. Frogs had started up in the water. Somewhere a heron lifted and flapped away low, legs trailing.

Near the bend, where the road passed a stone Jizō, worn smooth, three men sat under a cedar with a sake jar between them.

Ren saw their swords first. Then their topknots, grown out and ragged. Then their clothes, which had been good once and were not now. Then the jar, which was nearly empty, and the way the tallest one was holding it, upside down over his mouth, shaking it.

The tallest one saw them. He lowered the jar.

He looked at Takezō: a thin old man in a patched coat, grey hair tied back badly, mud to his shins. He looked at Ren: a tall boy with a basket and two wooden swords stuck through his belt like a child playing at samurai.

He grinned.

He got up. The one beside him got up too, slower, one hand on the cedar. They came out into the road and stood in it.

"Old man." The tall one's voice was thick. "That's a heavy basket for a boy."

It was empty. Ren said nothing.

"Pretty swords," said the second one, looking at Ren's belt, and laughed.

The third man had not gotten up.

Ren looked at him. He was the youngest of the three, younger than the others by ten years, and he was sitting very still under the cedar with the jar at his knee. He was not looking at Ren. He was looking at Takezō. His mouth was a little open. His eyes went from the old man's face to his hands in his sleeves, to the two swords at his belt, and back to his face. Back and forth. As if he were trying to read something written there in a hand he half knew.

Takezō stood in the road with his hands in his sleeves and did not say anything at all.

The tall one drew his sword.

He came at Ren. Not at the old man. At the boy, the easy one. He came fast for a drunk man, the blade up and over his right shoulder, his feet splashing, and Ren watched him come, the shoulder, the hips, the weight too far forward, and when the sword started down Ren's back foot slid its half step and his hips turned and the blade went through the air where his shoulder had been.

The tall man stumbled past, off balance, into the ruts.

The second one was already there.

He had not gone where Ren had been. He had gone where Ren would be. He came in low from the left, and Ren saw it late, and turned to meet it, and his back foot went down onto the edge of a rut.

The mud took it.

His foot went out from under him. The sky swung. He came down on his back in the road so hard that his breath left him all at once, and the basket crushed flat beneath him, and cold mud came in through his collar and up the back of his head.

He could not breathe. He could not move. Above him, very clear, was the sky, orange going red, and in front of the sky the second man, legs apart over him, sword raised in both hands. Ren could see the nicks along its edge. He could see the man's face. It was not angry. It was nothing. It was a man about to split a log.

The sword stayed up.

It stayed up, and stayed up, and then it was falling. But it was falling wrong, turning over, slow, and the man's hands were still wrapped around its hilt, and there was nothing past the man's wrists. Nothing past his elbow. The sword and the arm came down together and landed in the mud beside Ren's head with a flat wet sound, and the fingers did not open.

Something warm spattered across Ren's cheek.

The man looked at the end of his arm. He looked at it as if it belonged to somebody else. Then the sound came out of him.

Takezō was standing where the man had been standing a moment before. Not near it. There. His sword was out, low, the point toward the ground. A single line of red ran along the steel and gathered at the tip and dropped into the mud.

Ren had not seen him move.

Under the cedar, the third man was on his feet. His back was against the tree. The jar had tipped and was rolling slowly away from him through the grass. He was staring at Takezō, and his lips moved, and the sound that came out was barely a sound.

"Musashi."

Then he ran.

He ran into the paddy, not the road, straight through the water, and his voice went up and cracked and came out of him raw.

"Musashi! It's Musashi!"

The tall one was already running. The armless one staggered after them, holding what was left against his chest, leaving a dark line along the road that the mud drank as fast as it was made. Their shouts went away across the fields. At the far edge of the paddies a crowd of crows lifted all at once out of the stubble and wheeled, black on red, and settled again farther off.

Then it was quiet.

The frogs started again. One, then many.

Takezō flicked the blade once, sharply, toward the ground. He took a folded sheet of paper from his coat and drew it along the steel, both sides, and let the paper fall. He slid the sword home into its scabbard. The sound it made was very small.

He looked down at Ren.

Ren lay in the mud. The arm lay beside his head, fingers still closed. The sun was going down behind the old man, directly behind his head, so that his face was dark and the light came around the edges of him, around his hair, his shoulders, the line of his arm, and made a burning outline of him against the sky.

"Musashi?" Ren said.

It came out quiet. He was not sure he had said it out loud.

The old man did not answer.

The name went through Ren the way the wind went through the paddies, and moved everything a little, and was gone. It did not stay. What stayed was the arm in the mud beside his head. What stayed was the warm drying on his cheek. What stayed was the old man standing over him with the sun behind him, looking down, his eyes going over Ren the way they had gone over him once in the cave, a long time ago. The hands. The breath. The legs. The head. Checking. Only checking.

He had moved. Ren had not seen him move. But he had moved.

The smile came up from somewhere below Ren's ribs and there was nothing he could do about it. It went across his face and kept going. It went all the way out to his ears. He lay on his back in the mud with a man's arm beside him and grinned up at the old man until his cheeks hurt.

Takezō looked at the grin.

"Up."

Ren got up.

Mud slid off his back in sheets. The basket was ruined. He picked it up anyway and put it back on, what was left of it, and brushed at the mud on his sleeves, which made it worse.

Takezō had already turned. He was walking on toward the village, in the middle of the road, with his hands back in his sleeves.

Ren followed. The way he always did. Behind him, a step to the left.

He did not stop smiling for a long time. When he noticed that he was still doing it, he tried to stop. It did not work.

The old man did not look back. He did not say anything. The sun went down behind the hills, and the frogs sang in the paddies, and the two of them walked on toward the lights of the village.

***

Some nights, Musashi wrote by the fire.

The brush moved slowly. Not often. Not long. The ink stone sat by his knee, and the smell of the ink, sooty and faintly sweet, mixed with the smoke. He would write a little, and stop, and look at the fire for a long time, and write a little more.

Ren once looked at the pages and saw only short lines.

Earth. Water. Fire. Wind. Empty.

"What is that?" Ren asked.

Musashi did not look up.

"Something incomplete."

Ren waited.

"Hm."

Musashi kept writing.

"Bring more wood."

Chapter 6

The Pause

The first cough came on a night in the ninth month.

Musashi was writing. The brush was moving the way it always moved, so slowly it hardly seemed to move at all, and then it stopped. Not at the end of a line. In the middle of a stroke. The ink gathered at the tip and swelled into a bead.

Musashi turned his head away from the paper and coughed into his sleeve. Once. Short and dry, like a stick breaking under a foot.

Then he turned back and finished the stroke.

Ren was sitting across the fire with a length of cord in his hands, mending a sandal. He had stopped pulling the cord. He looked at the old man's face. It was the same. He looked at the old man's hands. They were the same. The brush moved on down the page.

One, Ren thought. He did not know why he counted it.

***

Three days later he was in the clearing in the grey before sunrise, running the forms.

The cold had come early that year. The grass was stiff with it, and his breath went out white, and the maples in the ravine below had turned all at once, so that the whole slope looked as if it had caught fire in the night. Crows worked the stubble in the valley fields. He could hear them from here.

Right sword high. Left sword low. Step. Turn. The cut from above. The half step, the hips, the finish. Again. He did not need to be told anymore. He heard it anyway, the way he always did now, and went back to the beginning.

Step. Turn.

His weight went early. A finger's width. He felt it leave the center before he meant it to, and the left sword came through a fraction ahead of the right, too soon, the way it had when he was thirteen.

He stopped.

He stood where the fault had stopped him, with both swords where they had ended, and waited for the rod. It always came. He could feel it in the skin of his elbow before it touched him. He waited for the word.

It did not come.

The wind moved in the maples below. A crow called in the valley.

Ren turned his head.

Musashi was sitting on the bench by the mouth of the cave with the rod across his knees. He was not looking at the clearing. He was not looking at Ren.

He was looking out over the ravine. Into the distance, at nothing, at the far ridge or the sky over it, his face still, his eyes resting there.

Ren had never seen it. In ten years, he had never once looked up from the forms and found the old man's eyes anywhere but on him.

Something went through him. It started low, below his ribs, and it was cold, colder than the grass, and it went up through the middle of him and out along his arms to the ends of his fingers, and his fingers tightened on the swords.

"Again."

The word came across the clearing the way it always came. Quiet. A stone set down.

Then a cough. Short. Dry.

Ren did not move.

The old man's eyes had not come back from the ridge. The word had come without them.

Ren turned back to the clearing. He set his feet. He lifted the swords.

He went back to the beginning.

***

After that he watched.

He did not decide to. It happened the way everything happened in his body now, before he asked it to. He watched the old man the way the old man had taught him to watch a sword coming: not the blade, the shoulders. Not the shoulders, the breath.

He counted.

Two coughs in the morning, before the rice. One at midday. At night, while the brush moved, three. Then four.

Musashi rose from the bench, and his hand went out to the rock of the cave mouth. Not heavily. Only to touch it, as if to check that it was there. Ren had watched him rise from that bench ten thousand times. His hands had never touched anything.

On the steep part of the path, where the stones were loose, the old man stopped. He stood there with his hands in his sleeves and looked out over the valley, as if something in it interested him. His breath went out white in short pieces. Ren stood three steps below him and looked at the same valley and saw nothing in it but crows and stubble and smoke from the farmhouses.

After a while Musashi went on.

At night, the whetstone. Shff. Shff. Shff. Then nothing. Then shff. The sound had been the same length every night of Ren's life. Now it had holes in it.

Rice left in the bowl. Not much. A few grains stuck to the side. Musashi had never left a grain in his life.

In the tenth month, Ren said it.

They were eating. The old man coughed into his sleeve, a long one this time, four or five dry pieces strung together, and when it was over he wiped his mouth and picked up his chopsticks again.

"Are you sick?"

Musashi lifted a little rice to his mouth. Chewed. Swallowed.

"Smoke."

He looked at the fire.

Ren looked at the fire too. The smoke went up straight from it and leaned and slid along the rock and out through the cave mouth, the way it always had, the way it had the first night Ren woke there. It did not come anywhere near the old man's face.

Ren said nothing else.

***

The first snow came in the eleventh month, and it stayed.

Ren woke in the dark and lay still under the blanket, which reached only to his knees now, and listened.

There was no fire.

He could tell before he opened his eyes. No heat on that side of his face. No small bright cracking. The cave smelled of cold stone and old smoke and nothing else.

He opened his eyes.

The old man was kneeling at the ring of stones.

The ring was bare. Swept. The tinder was laid in the center of it, the split pine around the tinder, exactly the way it always was, every morning of Ren's life, by the time Ren woke. But it was not burning. The old man had the flint in one hand and the steel in the other, and he was striking.

Click. A spark, orange, falling. Dying on the stone.

Click. Nothing.

Click.

The old man's hands. Ren could see them in the grey light from the cave mouth. The flint hand was steady. The steel hand was not. It came down on the flint at the wrong angle and skated off it, and the sound was wrong, a scrape instead of a strike.

Musashi stopped. He breathed. Long in.

The breath broke in the middle. He turned his face away from the ring and coughed into his shoulder, and it went on, and on, deep in his chest now, a sound like wet wood in a fire, and his back bent with it, and the hand with the steel in it pressed flat against the floor of the cave to hold him up.

Ren was sitting up. He did not remember sitting up. The blanket had fallen away from him and the cold was on his arms, and he did not feel it.

The coughing stopped.

Musashi stayed as he was for a moment, bent, his hand flat on the stone. Then he straightened. He wiped his mouth with the back of his wrist. He did not look at the wrist.

He looked at Ren.

"Sleep."

Ren did not lie down.

The old man turned back to the ring. He set the steel to the flint. Click. A spark. It fell into the tinder and sat there, a small red eye, and the old man bent over it and breathed on it, carefully, the breath short, and the eye opened, and a flame stood up out of the tinder, small and yellow, and took the pine.

Musashi fed it. When it could stand on its own, he sat back, and put his hands on his knees, and closed his eyes.

Ren sat in the cold with the blanket around his waist and looked at the fire the old man had made. It was the same fire. It burned the same. It lit the rock the same.

He had seen it being made.

***

That night Ren did not sleep.

He lay on his side with his face to the rock and listened. The fire ticking. The wind outside, working at the snow. The old man's breath: long in, the pause, long out. Then the pause going on too long, and the cough. Then the breath again, shorter.

He counted.

He had counted fish in the pools, and drops from the rock, and breaths going out white into the cold. He counted the way the old man had taught him to see things, without deciding anything about them first. Only the number. Only what was there.

Eleven, before the moon came around to the cave mouth.

He knew what the number meant. It was not hard. The cough had come in the ninth month and it had not gone away. It had not stayed the same. It was not smoke. It would not get better because the old man said it was smoke, or because Ren did not say anything, or because they both went on as if it were not there.

A cut that was not bound did not close. A roof that let the rain in did not stop letting it in.

The medicine for it was not on the mountain. Nothing on the mountain was medicine. There were herbs Musashi knew and roots he dug, and Ren had seen him chew them in the evenings, and they had done nothing. Whoever knew what this was lived down there, somewhere, in the towns, where the road went.

Somebody had to go down.

Twelve.

Ren turned over. Across the ring of stones, the old man sat against the wall with his eyes closed, his own coat around his shoulders, the firelight moving on his face. He looked the way he had always looked. Only thinner. Only older. Only a little further away.

Ren looked past him, at the mouth of the cave. The snow outside was blue in the moonlight. Somewhere below it, under it, the path went down.

He looked at it until the fire burned low.

He did not get up to feed it. That was not his to do.

Chapter 7

The Mountain

The fire was made. The ash was gone over the ledge. Beside Musashi's knee, at the edge of the firelight, lay a long bundle wrapped in old grey cloth, where he had set it down before anything else that morning. He sat in front of the flames with his hands on his knees, as he had every morning for eleven years, and the cave was dark behind him, and he did not need to turn his head to know the boy was awake.

The breathing had changed an hour ago. It had not gone back.

Musashi kept his eyes on the fire.

Behind him, the boy rose. Not the way he rose to his chores: fast, loose, already halfway to the door. Slowly. He folded the blanket first. Musashi heard it, the dry rasp of the old cloth, once, twice, three times. It went down on the mat in a square.

Then clothes. The spare coat, the leggings, the cloth for the feet. Folded. Laid on the square of the blanket. Then taken off it again, and laid on a square of cloth beside it instead. The corners of the cloth brought up and knotted. Pulled once, to test. Not twice.

Musashi watched the fire.

A rustle of leaf. The smell of cold rice, and salt, and the green bite of bamboo sheath. A rice ball, wrapped. It went into the bundle.

Then the boy crossed the cave to the far wall. Musashi heard the two wooden swords come away from the rock, and the soft knock of them going through the sash, one and then the other. The old pair, dark now with years of hands. The boy settled them at his hip. His hands went to them. Then left them.

Then went back.

Once would have been enough, Musashi thought.

He did not say it.

The boy went out.

The cold came in behind him. Grey light, not yet morning. Musashi heard him on the ledge, then on the slope below, then the sound of the axe in the dead pine at the edge of the clearing, the bite and the pull and the bite. It went on for a while. Then the boy came back in with his arms full and knelt beside the fire, and stacked the wood against the rock where the wood always went. Split pine, dry, the ends pale and new. He stacked it the way it was meant to be stacked.

He went out again.

The axe. The bite and the pull.

He came back with more. He stacked it on the first.

He went out again.

Musashi sat. The fire burned. The stack grew. It grew past what a day needed. Past what three days needed. The boy's breath was coming harder now, white in the cold air of the cave mouth each time he came through it, and there was sweat on his neck despite the cold, and he did not stop. He brought another armful. And another. The stack reached the height of Musashi's shoulder where he sat, and went past it, and the boy set the last pieces on top with care, so they would not fall.

More than a week needed. More than two.

The boy stood back from it. Wiped his hands on his thighs.

Musashi looked at the stack.

"Hm."

He looked at the height of it.

Then he looked back at the fire.

***

The boy stood at the mouth of the cave with the bundle on his back and the wooden swords at his waist. The light was behind him now, grey going white, and Musashi could see him at the edge of his sight without turning: the shape of him in the opening. Tall. Taller than the opening had been made for. His shoulders took most of the light.

"I'm going down the mountain."

The fire cracked. A knot, splitting.

Musashi did not look up from it. The flames moved. The heat lay on his hands.

"The river is high this time of year."

"I know."

Musashi's right hand left his knee.

It went down beside him without his eyes following it, and found the grey bundle where it lay, and lifted it, and set it down again a little farther out, on the bare stone between the fire and the mouth of the cave. Where the boy would have to pass it. Then the hand came back to his knee.

He did not look at the bundle. He did not look at the boy.

For a while the boy did not move.

Then his feet came across the stone. He crouched. Musashi heard the cloth: the old knot, stiff, working loose under the boy's fingers; the grey wrapping falling open, fold by fold, onto the floor.

Then nothing.

No sound at all. Not the boy's breath. The fire ticked into the silence, and ticked again, and still the boy did not breathe.

At the edge of his sight Musashi could see what lay on the grey cloth in the firelight. Two scabbards, black, the lacquer worn dull at the mouths and along the edges where hands had held them. Two hilts, wrapped in dark cord, the wrapping shiny with use. Two guards of plain iron.

The same length. Both of them long.

The boy's hand came down and rested on the nearer hilt. It stayed there.

Then he breathed.

He stood. He drew the wooden swords out of his sash, one and then the other, and crossed to the far wall, and set them against the rock. The soft sound of wood on stone, twice. When he stepped back, Musashi let his eyes move, only his eyes, only as far as the edge of what they could reach.

The two wooden swords leaned against the wall, side by side. Exactly straight. Exactly the same angle. The way Musashi had left them there every night since before the boy came.

Musashi looked back at the fire.

The boy came back to the grey cloth. He lifted the first sword, and it went through his sash with a long whisper of lacquer on cloth, and the guard settled at his hip. Then the second, beside it. The two guards touched with a small iron knock.

His hands went to them. The left hilt. The right. A thumb against each guard, testing the draw.

The hands left them.

Then went back.

The left. The right. The thumb against the guard.

Musashi watched the fire.

The boy stood at the mouth of the cave again. Musashi heard his feet settle on the stone, and then the soft sound of cloth folding as he bent at the waist. A bow. Low. Held longer than the first bow of any morning of eleven years.

Musashi did not turn.

The boy straightened. His feet went out onto the ledge, and down.

***

When the footsteps had gone below the lip of the slope, Musashi rose.

He did it without the rock. He did not need the rock. He went to the mouth of the cave and stood in it, where the boy had stood, and looked down.

The path went down through the dead grass of the clearing and into the trees and out of them again along the ravine, and the boy was on it. Musashi watched him the way he had watched him for eleven years: not the face, not the back. The feet. The hips. The breath.

Weight low. Steps even. The bundle riding high between his shoulders without swaying, because the hips did not sway. The two long swords riding level at his waist, their hilts forward, as if they had always been there. Where the path dropped steep and the stones were loose, the boy's feet found the flat ones without looking and did not slow. His breath went out white in front of him in long pieces, the same length, the same shape. Nothing wasted. Nothing waiting to be corrected.

The body was finished.

The rest was not.

Musashi stood in the cold and looked at the boy going down the mountain, and it came into his mind the way it came when he sat with the brush over the paper. Something incomplete.

The cough rose in his chest.

He held it.

It pressed up under his breastbone like a hand. He held it. Below him, the path turned around the old cherry tree at the bend. Its blossoms were already going, brown at the edges, and the ones that had fallen lay in the mud of the path, pressed flat by feet and rain.

Musashi held the cough.

His eyes were watering. He let them. The boy went on down the path, small now, getting smaller.

The boy passed under the tree.

A crow lifted off the branch as he went by. It went up in two heavy beats, black against the grey sky, and a few browning petals came loose and turned in the air behind it.

The boy did not look up.

He did not look back.

He went on past the bend and down to the river. It was high, as he had said it would be, brown and fast and loud with the thaw, and the stepping stones stood out of it only just, their tops wet. The boy crossed without stopping. Stone. Stone. Stone. Stone. He did not put a hand down. He went on along the far bank, up through the young leaves, and the crow settled again on a higher branch of the cherry, and he was not.

"Good," Musashi said.

It was barely a sound.

Then the cough came. It came up out of him long and deep and tearing, and he bent over it with his hand pressed over his mouth, and it went on, and on, and when it let him go he stood with his back against the rock of the cave mouth and his breath coming in short pieces, and he took his hand away from his mouth.

He did not look at the hand.

He wiped it on the rock, and went back inside.

***

Evening. A grey sky, low, no wind.

He took the bucket down to the river himself. The path was the same path. It was steeper than he remembered. At the bottom the river ran brown and quick with the snowmelt, and cherry petals rode on it, pale on the dirty water, hundreds of them, turning slowly as they went, carried down from the valleys where the trees had already let go. He watched them pass. Then he bent and filled the bucket and carried it up.

He cooked the rice.

When it was ready he reached up to the shelf for the bowls. His hand took down two. It had taken down two for eleven years. It did not need him to tell it.

He looked at the second bowl.

He put it back.

He ate by the fire. The rice was the same rice. The fire was the same fire. The cave was quiet around him. On the floor between the fire and the mouth of the cave, the grey cloth still lay where it had fallen open, empty, in the shape of what had been in it. When he was finished, there was nothing left in the bowl. He washed it and put it on the shelf.

Then he took out the paper, and the ink stone, and the brush.

He ground the ink. The stick turned in the water until the water went black. He wet the brush and bent over the page, and the brush moved, slowly, the way it moved.

Earth.

Water.

Fire.

Wind.

The brush came to the last place on the page and stopped above it.

Empty.

It did not come down. The ink gathered at the tip and swelled into a bead, and hung there, and Musashi held the brush above the paper, and the fire ticked, and outside, somewhere far below in the dark, the river went on being loud.

The bead did not fall.

He set the brush down on the stone.

He reached beside him to the stack against the rock, the tall stack, the one that would last more than a week, more than two, and took one piece of split pine from the top of it.

He fed the fire.

Chapter 8

The Road

The town did not hold still.

Ren stood at the end of its one long street with the mountain behind him and the dusk coming down, and watched it move. Everything moved. Everything moved at once, in every direction, and none of it was going anywhere.

A woman crossed in front of him with a pole across her shoulders, two baskets swinging, and stopped in the middle of the street to shout at a boy, and the boy ran, and a dog ran after the boy, and a man with a handcart swerved around the dog and cursed the woman, and the woman cursed him back without turning her head. Smoke came out of every doorway. Grilled fish. Pickled radish. Charcoal. Night soil. Horse. Sake. Wet straw. Sweat. Lamp oil, as the lamps came on one by one down the street, each one at a different time, for no reason he could find.

People talked. All of them. All the time. To each other, to no one, to the dogs. Somebody laughed in a house and somebody else, three houses down, was crying, and nobody in the street turned toward either sound.

He had been walking for four days. He had slept under a pine the first night and in a farmer's shed the second and in the lee of a shrine wall the third. He had eaten the rice ball on the first day. He had not spoken to anyone.

He stood at the end of the street and tried to find the pattern in it, the way he found the pattern in a man's shoulders before the sword came. Where the weight was. Where it would go next.

There was no pattern. There was only the street.

A man walking past with a load of firewood looked at Ren's waist. Looked at the two long hilts side by side. His eyes stayed on them a moment, puzzled. Then he looked at Ren's face, and whatever he saw there made him look away and walk faster.

Ren went down the street.

***

He found the doctor by the smell.

It came out of a doorway near the far end, over all the other smells: bitter, dusty, sweet underneath, like dried roots and bark and something burned on purpose. A wooden sign hung beside the door with characters brushed on it that Ren could read, slowly. Medicine. The door was open. Inside, a lamp, and shelves to the ceiling full of drawers, small ones, each with its own character, and a line of people on the step waiting to go in.

He waited with them.

The line got shorter. It got longer again. A woman with a child with a hot red face. An old man holding his jaw. A farmer who stood with one foot off the ground. They looked at Ren's swords and moved a little away from him on the step and did not look again. When a new one came, they went ahead of him, and he let them, because he did not know yet how it worked.

It got dark. The street emptied. The lamps went out one by one, each at a different time.

Then there was no one on the step but Ren.

The doctor came to the door with a lantern in one hand and a lacquered box under his arm. He was a thin man, not old, grey at the temples, with ink on his fingers and a tired face that looked as if it had been holding its expression all day and had just now put it down. He saw Ren and stopped.

"I'm closing."

"My teacher coughs."

The doctor looked at him. At the swords. Back at his face.

He sighed. He set the box down on the step beside him and held the lantern up a little, so that it lit them both.

"How long?"

"Since the ninth month."

"Dry? Wet?"

"Dry. Then wet."

"Fever?"

"I don't know. He doesn't say."

"Blood?"

Ren thought about it. He thought about the old man at the mouth of the cave with his hand over his mouth, the long tearing sound, the hand coming away. The hand going to the rock.

"He doesn't look at his hand after."

The doctor was quiet.

The lantern moved a little in his grip. The light went up the wall and came back.

"How old is he?"

"Fifty-seven."

The doctor looked at the lantern for a while. Then at the street. Then back at Ren. His face had not changed. That was how Ren knew.

"Bring him to me."

"He won't come."

"Then I can't—"

He stopped. He was looking past Ren's shoulder, into the dark between the houses.

Ren had heard them before the doctor stopped. Three sets of feet. Straw sandals on packed earth, trying to be quiet and not knowing how.

***

They came out of the alley together, which was the first mistake. One with a knife. One with a length of oak, a cart stave. One with a short sword, drawn, the blade dull and pitted in the lantern light. They were young. The one with the knife was younger than Ren. They smelled of sake and cold and not having eaten.

"The box," said the one with the short sword. "Put it down and walk inside, old man."

The doctor's hand closed on the lantern's handle. He did not move.

The one with the stave looked at Ren. At Ren's waist. He laughed.

"Two long ones?" He poked the stave toward Ren's hip. "Who taught you to carry those?"

"My teacher."

The laugh stopped. The stave man looked at Ren's face to see if it was a joke, and found that it was not, and did not know what to do with that.

"You." The short-sword man jerked his chin at Ren. "Walk away. Nobody gets hurt."

Ren looked at him. At his feet. At the knife boy's grip, too far out from the body, the wrist locked. At the stave, held in the middle where it would bend the man's own wrist back when it hit.

"You will get hurt."

He did not say it to frighten them. It was only true. He said it the way he would have said the river was high.

For a moment none of them moved.

Then the knife boy's face went red, and something went out of the short-sword man's eyes and something worse came into them, and the stave man said "What did you—" and they all came at once.

***

The knife first. The boy lunged, arm straight out, the whole of him behind it and nothing under it. Ren stepped off the line and took the wrist as it went past, turned it, and the knife came out of the fingers and rang on the step.

The boy's weight kept going. Ren let it. He had already seen where it would land: the drainage ditch along the front of the house, a stride away, black water and mud. The boy went into it.

The stave was already coming. Ren saw it start: the shoulder, the long swing, all arm. He went inside it, close, where the wood could not reach, and put his elbow into the man's chest below the ribs, and the man's breath left him.

But the stave did not stop. It had been swung too wide to stop. Its far end went on past Ren's back and struck the doctor's lantern out of his hand.

The lantern hit the ground and rolled.

The light went wild. It swung up the walls and across the street and into the sky, the shadows of all of them leaping and turning over, the paper of the lantern catching, flaring orange. For a heartbeat Ren could see nothing at all where it had been, only the flare, and the dark around it made darker.

He heard the short sword come. Not saw it. Heard it: the hiss, left, high.

He dropped under it and came up turning and caught the man's arm at the elbow, and the man twisted, stronger than he looked, and they went sideways together into the doorway.

Into the step. Into the lacquered box.

It went over. The lid came off. Out of it spilled paper packets, dozens of them, folded small and tied with thread, and little clay jars that burst on the stone, and powders, brown and yellow and grey, that went up in the flare of the burning lantern like dust in a shaft of light.

A woman screamed from an upstairs window. A dog began to bark somewhere, and another answered it.

Ren put the man's arm up behind him until the sword fell. He put the man face down on the step, across the spilled packets, and held him there with a knee between the shoulders, and for a moment there was no sound but the man's breathing, and the dogs, and the lantern paper crackling as it burned itself out on the ground.

"Go," Ren said.

He let the man up.

The man went. The stave man was already gone, bent double, one hand on his chest. The knife boy dragged himself out of the ditch, black to the waist, and ran after them, and slipped, and got up, and ran.

The lantern went out.

***

It was dark. Then his eyes found the moon, and it was not so dark.

The doctor was kneeling on his step. He was picking up the paper packets one by one. Some of them had burst. Some of them were soaked where the ditch water had splashed. He picked them up anyway, and looked at each one, and put the whole ones in one pile and the broken ones in another. The broken pile was bigger. There was blood on the back of his hand, a small cut. He did not seem to have noticed it.

Ren stood in the street and looked at it.

He could see every piece of what had happened. The boy, the ditch. The stave, the elbow. That had been right. That had gone where he saw it going. And then the stave had not stopped, and the lantern had fallen, and the light had moved, and the man had been stronger than his shoulders said, and the step had been there, and the box.

None of them had been hurt more than they needed to be. None of them had gotten anything. The doctor was alive and his box was still his.

And the powders were in the mud.

It had worked.

It was not finished. There were pieces of it lying everywhere.

The doctor tied the last whole packet into a bundle with the others. He looked at the broken pile. Then he looked up at Ren.

"There's nothing in these for him anyway."

Ren did not answer.

The doctor stood. He wiped the back of his cut hand on his coat, and saw the blood, and looked at it, and wiped it again.

"In the capital," he said. "There are physicians who treat the great houses. Some of them studied the Chinese books. Some of them have seen things I haven't." He looked at the dark street, where the three had gone. "They don't treat men like your teacher. Not for free."

"I don't have anything."

"No." The doctor looked at the two long swords at Ren's waist, and at Ren's hands, and at the ditch, and back at Ren. "But you could."

He picked up his box, and went inside, and slid the door shut.

Ren stood in the empty street.

Somewhere down it the dogs were still barking. At each other, at the moon, at nothing. A shutter opened above him and a face looked out, and saw him, and closed the shutter again. The smell of the spilled medicine came up off the step, bitter and dusty and sweet, and mixed with the ditch and the burned paper and the night soil and the smoke, until he could not find it anymore.

He looked at his hands.

They were steady. They had done what they were supposed to do.

He closed them, and walked to the end of the street, where the road went on toward the capital, pale in the moonlight, empty, and not one thing on it standing still.

Chapter 9

Misread

The capital was too big to see.

Ren had thought, walking toward it, that he would come over a hill and it would be there, the way the valley was there from the ledge of the cave: all of it, at once, laid out to be read. It was not like that. It came at him in pieces. Roofs first, grey tile, one behind another, more roofs than there were trees on the mountain. Then a gate. Then a street that went on past where he could see, full of people, and another street crossing it, full of people, and a river with a wide stony bed and women beating cloth on the stones, and the sound of all of it, a sound that never stopped and never rose or fell, like the wind in the ravine if the wind had been made of voices.

Temple bells at dusk, from every direction, not together.

He slept under the eaves of a shrine gate and woke with a dog looking at him.

On the third day, at the gate of a walled house in the north of the city, near the palace, a man in good silk stood on the step with his hands behind his back and looked at the swords of everyone who walked by.

Ren stopped.

The man looked at the two long hilts at Ren's waist for a long moment. His mouth went thin.

"Who taught you to carry those?"

"My teacher."

The man's eyes came up to Ren's face and stayed there. Then he turned his head and said something over his shoulder, and a guard came out of the gate with a wooden sword in his hand and a bored look on his face, and stood in the street in front of Ren.

"Show me," said the man in silk.

The guard came at him. Ren took the wooden sword out of his hands and gave it back to him.

It had taken less time than the bells took to finish ringing. The guard stood holding his sword, looking at it. People in the street had stopped.

The man in silk looked at Ren the way the doctor had looked at the broken packets: sorting.

"His lordship goes to Uji in three days. Four of our men. We want five." He named a sum. Silver, at the end. A string of new copper coins now, for sandals. "You walk at the back. You don't speak to him. You don't look at him."

Ren thought about the doctor's step. The powders in the mud. The physicians who treated the great houses.

"Yes," he said.

***

His lordship was younger than Ren had thought a lord could be. Twenty, perhaps. His face was powdered white, smooth as a plate, and his eyebrows had been shaved away and painted back on high on his forehead, two soft grey smudges like thumbprints, and when he spoke to the man in silk his teeth were black. All of them. Black and glossy, like lacquer.

Ren looked at the black teeth, and then remembered that he was not to look, and looked at the palanquin instead.

It was lacquered too. Black, with gold on the edges, and screens of fine bamboo in the windows, and a long pole through iron rings on its roof. Four bearers took the pole on their shoulders, two in front, two behind, and lifted, and his lordship's weight settled it between them, and they began to walk. Four guards went with it: two ahead, one at each side. The steward walked beside the front bearers. Ren walked at the back.

Behind the palanquin, as it moved, the air smelled of incense. Something sweet and smoky and expensive, burned into the silk of his lordship's clothes, so that he left a trail of it on the road like a snail.

They went south, out through the gates, past Fushimi, the road running between rice fields and then into low hills, and the hills were bamboo.

It was late spring. The new shoots had come up out of the ground since the rains, taller than a man now, still wrapped in their brown sheaths, and above them the old canes went up green and straight to where their leaves met overhead and moved in the wind, all of it at once, with a sound like water. The light came down through it green. Bush warblers sang in it. Everywhere. The long rising whistle and the break at the end, over and over, near and far.

Ren walked at the back and listened to them.

Halfway up the second hill, they stopped.

Not the procession. The birds. On the left side of the road, one after another, the warblers stopped, the way the cicada in the village had stopped, and the quiet spread back into the bamboo from the road like water soaking into cloth.

On the right, they went on singing. For a while. Then, farther up, on the right, they stopped too.

Ren looked at the left side. The canes were moving in the wind, all of them leaning the same way, the tops swaying together. Except in two places, where the stems stood still, as if something at their feet was holding them. Farther on, a new shoot lay broken across the ditch, its sheath split, the white inside still wet.

He counted.

Three on the left. Three on the right, farther up. The left would come first. They would come for the guards at the side, to pull them away from the palanquin. Then the right would come for the door.

He walked faster. He came up past the rear bearers to the guard on the right side, the oldest of the four, a thick-necked man with grey in his topknot.

"There are men in the bamboo."

The guard looked at him. Then at the bamboo. It swayed. It was green and full of light.

"Six," said Ren. "Three there. Three ahead, on this side."

"Get back to your place."

"They'll come from the left first."

The guard's face went dark. "Bandits don't touch a court carriage. Get back."

Ren did not get back. He stayed where he was, beside the palanquin, level with its right-hand door, a step out from it. The guard looked at him, and at the steward, and the steward had not heard, and the guard turned his face away and said nothing more.

The palanquin creaked on its pole. The bearers breathed in rhythm, grunting a little on each step. Behind the bamboo screen of the window, his lordship's fan moved slowly back and forth. The incense came through the screen, sweet.

The left side came out of the bamboo.

Three men. Rags and old armor pieces, a spear, two swords. Shouting. They went for the guard on the left and the guard in front, exactly as Ren had seen, and the two guards drew and turned to meet them, away from the palanquin, and the steward shouted, and the bearers stopped.

Ren did not look left. He was looking right.

They came out of the bamboo on the right, ahead, running. Two went for the guards in front. One came down the side of the palanquin toward the door. Toward Ren. A short, thick man with a sword held low, his eyes on the lacquered door and nothing else.

Ren saw all of it. The man's feet. The weight. The sword starting to rise. He saw where the sword would go: the door, the gap between the door and the frame, whoever was behind it. He saw where he had to be. He stepped to it.

His hand went to the right hilt and the sword came out of the scabbard. The first time. The sound of it was long and clean and cold.

The front bearers dropped the pole.

Ren did not see them decide to. He heard it: the clatter of wood, two men running into the bamboo. The front of the palanquin fell. The rear bearers still held their end up, and the whole of it pitched forward and slewed sideways on its corner, one step, toward Ren, and the door slid open with the jolt, and his lordship came out of it.

He came out the way a bundle falls off a cart. White face. Silk. Fan. Straight out and down, into the road, into the space between Ren's sword and the sword that was already falling.

One step.

Ren's cut went where he had seen it going. It went through the bandit's arms below the elbows, and the bandit's sword fell with his hands still on it.

But it fell after. The edge of it had already come down across the white face on the ground. From the cheekbone to the jaw. The powder parted, and under it the skin, and under that the red came up through the white like ink through paper.

The bandit screamed. The young lord screamed. The warblers were silent everywhere now.

***

It did not last long after that. The guards killed two. The others ran back into the bamboo, and one of them was dragging a leg. One guard lay in the road on his back and did not move. The guard from the front sat against a cane with both hands pressed to his side and his face grey.

Two were left standing. The thick-necked one with grey in his topknot, and the youngest.

His lordship sat in the road in the mud with his silk spread around him. His hand was on his face. Blood came out between his fingers and ran down his wrist into his sleeve. His painted eyebrows had not moved. They sat high on his white forehead, calm, above everything.

He took his hand away and looked at it.

Then he looked at Ren.

"You." His voice was high and thin. His black teeth showed. "You were there. You were there beside me."

Ren stood with the sword in his hand. The bandit's blood was on it. He looked at the young lord, at the cut, at the front of the palanquin lying in the road, at the pole dropped in the dirt.

"Your bearers dropped you."

The young lord stared at him. His mouth opened. Nothing came out of it, and then everything did.

"Kill him." He was screaming now. "Kill him. He let them. He stood there and let them. Kill him!"

The steward said something. Nobody heard it.

The two guards looked at each other. The youngest looked at Ren's sword, and at the bandit on the ground with no hands. The thick-necked one looked at his lord, bleeding in the mud, and his face closed like a door.

They came at him.

The thick-necked one first, straight, the sword up high, a good cut, a trained cut, the kind Ren had seen ten thousand times coming down at him in the clearing. Ren's back foot slid its half step. His hips turned. The blade came down through the air where his shoulder had been. His own sword came across and opened the back of the man's sword hand, and the fingers let go.

The youngest came from the side, late, frightened. Ren stepped inside his swing, so close he could smell the man's breath, rice and fear, and put the pommel of his sword into the hinge of his jaw.

The youngest went down and lay in the road.

The thick-necked one knelt with his hand held against his chest, blood running from it, and looked up at Ren. He did not reach for his sword. He was breathing through his teeth.

Behind him the young lord was still screaming.

Ren wiped the sword on his sleeve. He put it back in its scabbard. The sound was small.

He looked at the steward, who was standing by the fallen palanquin with his hands open at his sides and nothing in his face at all.

Then he turned and walked into the bamboo.

***

He did not stop until the sound of the road was gone.

He went up through the canes and down the far side of the hill and across a field and into more bamboo, and through it, and when he came out of it there was a stream, small and fast and clear over brown stones, and the light was going.

He knelt at it and put his hands in.

The cold came up his wrists. The blood came off his fingers in threads and went away downstream, twisting, thinning, into the brown water over the stones, and was gone before he could see where it went.

He looked at the water.

He had seen the birds stop. He had counted six. He had said left, and they had come from the left. He had said the door, and the man had come for the door. He had been standing where he needed to stand. His sword had gone where he sent it.

The bearers had dropped the pole.

One step. The palanquin had moved one step. He had been reading the men with swords. He had not been reading the men with poles.

He turned it over. He turned it over again. It did not come out any different.

The silver was in the steward's sleeve. The copper was in his own, what was left of it. There were two men in the road who would remember his face, and a young lord with a line from his cheekbone to his jaw that would be there for the rest of his life.

He rubbed his hands together in the water. They were clean. He rubbed them again.

The stream ran on over the stones, fast and cold and never the same water twice, and carried everything it was given somewhere he could not see.

ACT II
CROWS

Chapter 10
Heart

The rains had stopped. For days they had come down on the road south of Uji, soft and warm and without end, and Ren had walked in them and slept under whatever would keep them off. Now they were gone, and in two days the road had dried to a pale crust that broke under his sandals and turned to dust.

The dust was on everything. On his feet, on the hems of his trousers, in the creases of his hands. On the long grass at either side, which stood higher than his waist and did not move, because there was no wind. Somewhere in the trees beyond it a cicada started, sawed for a while, and stopped, as if it had tried the sound and not yet decided.

He had nine copper coins. He had counted them that morning, and again at noon.

Where the road bent around a low hill there was a camphor tree, very old, and in its shade the ruin of a roadside hut, three posts and half a roof. In front of the hut, in the dirt, men were sitting in a ring.

Ren heard them before he saw them. A cup rattling. A cup slapped down. Voices going up all together, then down.

He counted as he came level with them. Seven around the ring, squatting on their heels. Rags, sashes, a spear laid in the grass, swords stuck through belts at angles no one had taught them. A short bow leaning on a post of the hut with a quiver beside it. And an eighth in the middle of the ring, where the cup was: a young man, Ren's age or near it, thin, brown from the sun, his hair tied up anyhow and his sleeves pushed back to the elbow. He was laughing. He shook the cup beside his ear, like someone listening for a secret, and slapped it down, and lifted it, and the men groaned, and he swept the coins in the dirt toward his knees with both hands.

Ren kept walking.

"Again," said the one with the spear, and the young man laughed and said, "If you like losing," and shook the cup.

Ren was past the tree when the voices changed.

Not louder. Lower. He heard the cup go over and one die roll out of it across the hard ground. He heard someone say "Look at it," and someone else say "Break it," and a sound like a heel coming down on something small. Then all of them at once, and the young man's voice over them, quick and bright and not frightened enough.

"It's a die. They're all like that. Some of them are heavier on one side, that's how they're made, I didn't make it, I only—"

Something struck flesh. The voice stopped, and started again, thinner.

Ren kept walking.

"You."

He knew it was for him by the way the road went quiet behind him. He stopped. He turned.

Two of them had stood up. The one with the spear, and an older one with a scar that pulled one eye down at the corner. The others had the young man by the arms. There was blood on his lip. He was looking at Ren with great interest, as if Ren were the next throw.

The scarred man's eyes went to Ren's waist and stayed there.

"Two long ones," he said. "Where does a boy get two long ones?"

Ren said nothing.

"Leave them. And the purse. Then walk."

"No."

The scarred man looked at him as if he had not understood the word. Then he smiled with half his mouth, and the men on the ground let go of the young man and began to get up.

Ren watched them get up.

Seven. The spear, the scar, two with swords, one with a stick, one with a knife. And one at the back, small and quick, who did not come toward him with the others but went sideways, around the tree.

Six came. They spread across the road, loose, slow, the way men spread who have done this before to travelers who were afraid.

Ren's hand went to the right hilt.

The spear came first. It came straight, the way Ren had known it would from how the man held it, both hands, weight on the front foot. Ren's back foot slid its half step. The spear went past his hip, close enough that he felt the air of it, and his sword came out of the scabbard and across in the same motion, and the man's hands opened on the shaft, and he sat down in the dust holding his stomach.

Two at once from the left. Ren went toward them instead of away. Inside the first man's swing, shoulder into his chest, the man's breath going out of him against Ren's ear, and Ren's foot hooked behind his heel, and the man went over backward into the road. The second man's sword was already coming down where Ren had been standing. Ren was not there. He cut behind him, low, across the back of the knee, and the man folded and screamed.

The scarred man was better than the others. Patient. He did not come in. He circled with his sword low and his bad eye weeping, waiting for Ren to turn toward someone else.

Behind the scarred man, the young man was up. Ren saw it at the edge of his sight. There was a short sword in his hand, drawn from somewhere, and he did not fight like anyone Ren had seen. He did not stand. He dropped, and rolled, and came up behind the man with the stick and drove a heel into the back of his knee, and as the man went down he cut the stick in half and the hand with it. Then he was gone again, lower and to the left, making the sound a person makes who is almost laughing.

Ren's left hand went to the second hilt.

The scarred man saw it and came in, fast, because he had been waiting for Ren's hands to be busy. The left sword came out underneath the right and met the cut at the hilt and turned it. The right came around.

It was over.

The road was quiet except for the man holding his stomach, who was saying something to himself, over and over, very softly.

Ren stood in the middle of it with both swords out. His breath came long and even. Long in. The pause. Long out. He looked at them one by one. The spear. The knee. The one who had gone over backward, lying in the road with the breath still knocked out of him. The scar. And two more by the hut, where the young man had been: one on his face, one sitting against a post, holding his arm to his chest.

Six.

He turned.

Behind him the camphor tree stood in its own shade, and with his back against its trunk, the seventh man stood with the short bow drawn. The arrow was pointing at the place between Ren's shoulders. It was already pointing there. It had been pointing there while he counted.

Ren saw all of it in the time it takes a drop to fall. The draw. The man's cheek against the string. There was no step that would take him out of it.

Something went past him. A thin sound, like a wasp.

The bowman's head went back against the tree. The string snapped. The arrow went into the grass three paces to Ren's right, and the bowman slid down the trunk and sat among the roots, and something small and dark stood out of his eye, no longer than a finger.

Ren looked at it.

Then he looked at the young man, who was standing in the road with his right arm still out in front of him and the hand open, like someone who has just let go of a bird.

"He was behind you," the young man said, and lowered the arm. "I thought you'd want to know."

***

He went through them like a man going through a house he lived in.

Ren wiped his swords and watched. The young man knelt by each of them, the dead and the not dead, and his hands went into sashes and sleeves and the fronts of robes and came out and went in again, quick and light, never twice in the same place. The man holding his stomach looked up at him. The young man said, "Don't get up," kindly, and took his purse.

He scraped the coins from the dice game out of the dirt with the rest. He found a string of copper on the scarred man, and on the bowman a little cloth bag that clinked, and he opened it and whistled through his teeth. He put his foot on the bowman's shoulder and drew the needle out of the eye and wiped it on the man's sleeve and put it back into his own, somewhere, and it was gone.

Then he sat down in the road, poured it all out in front of him, and began to make two piles.

"One for you," he said. "One for me. One for you. That one's bent, that's mine. One for you."

Ren stood over him.

"You fight strangely," the young man said without looking up. "One, then two. Why only the second one when you need it? Why not both from the start? One for me. And two long ones, not one long and one short. Everyone's going to ask you about that. Who taught you to wear them like that?"

"My teacher."

"He must be a strange man. One for you." He looked up. "Is he?"

"Hm."

The young man looked at him a moment longer, then nodded as if Ren had answered, and went back to the coins.

There were small lumps of silver in the bowman's bag. He broke the heap apart with his fingers and pushed half of it across the line in the dust to Ren's side. Then he sat back on his heels and wiped his hands on his knees.

"There."

Ren looked at the pile.

It was more than he had seen in one place since he came down from the mountain. More than the steward had named for the road to Uji. He thought of the doctor on his step in the lamplight. The physicians in the capital, who treated the great houses and were not free. The cough.

"They're yours," he said.

"Half of them are yours. You did half." The young man tilted his head. "More than half. I'm being generous to myself."

Ren crouched. He gathered the coins and the silver into his hands. They were warm from the sun. He put them into his purse and drew the cord tight and put it inside his robe, against his chest, where he could feel it.

"Thank you."

"Hayate," said the young man.

Ren stood. Hayate stood too.

"That's my name. This is where you tell me yours."

"Ren."

"Ren." Hayate tried it. "Short. Where are you going, Ren?"

Ren turned and began to walk.

"South, then," said Hayate behind him. "Good. I was going south."

Ren walked faster. Hayate's feet walked faster in the dust behind him. Ren stopped. Hayate stopped. Ren turned around.

Hayate had a scrape on his cheek and dried blood on his lip, and he was smiling as if nothing in the world had ever happened to him.

"Don't follow me."

"I'm not following you." Hayate spread his hands. "I'm walking. It's a road. You're on it. I'm on it." He considered. "You're ahead, that's all."

Ren looked at him. Hayate looked back.

Ren turned and walked. After a moment, the feet came after him.

They went south in the late light. The road ran between paddies now, and the water in them was full of sky. Frogs had started in the ditches. Hayate talked. He talked about the dice, which had been weighted, yes, but only a little, and only one of them, and anyway the men had been cheating first with the cup. He talked about a woman in Uji who had given him a melon. He talked about the heat, and about the man with the scar, whom he had liked, a little, before. He talked about Ren's swords, and the way Ren walked, and the way Ren did not talk.

Ren did not answer any of it.

Their shadows went ahead of them down the road, very long. One walked straight. The other waved its arms.

***

Nara was full of deer.

Hayate had known it would be. Everyone knew it. But knowing was not the same as having one follow him the length of a street and try to eat his sleeve. They lay in the shade of the temple gates with their legs folded under them and watched people go by. They walked through the market as if it were theirs, and nobody stopped them. A boy threw a pebble at one, and an old woman caught him by the ear so hard he went up on his toes.

The heat came up off the packed earth of the streets and down from the white sky and met somewhere around Hayate's face. In the temple woods the cicadas were so loud they were not a sound anymore. They were what the air was made of.

A week.

Hayate had counted, though he would never have said so. A week on the road with Ren, and Ren had said perhaps forty words to him. He had counted those too. Eleven had been "no." Three had been "don't." He had not counted "Hm." He was not sure it was a word. Once, on the fourth night, by a fire Ren had made — Ren made every fire; Hayate had tried once, and Ren had taken the flint out of his hands without a word and made it again — once, Ren had said "Your turn," and handed him the fish, and Hayate had thought about it for a whole day.

He had learned other things without words. Ren woke before the light. Ren ate everything in the bowl. Ren did not like to be walked beside, only behind. Ren looked at every man they passed, first at his hands, then his feet, then his face, and Hayate did not think he knew he did it.

And in every town, Ren found the doctor.

He did not ask the way. He smelled for it. Roots boiling, something bitter. He followed his nose down side streets and found the door, and waited outside until everyone else had gone in, and then went in himself, and came out a while later with the same face he had gone in with.

Hayate had gone in with him once. He had stood by the door while Ren said "My teacher coughs," and answered the questions. The doctor had named a price, for a thing that would not cure it, only ease it. Ren had

taken out the purse from the camphor tree and counted it on the doctor's mat, coin by coin, and put it all back, and thanked the man, and left.

Hayate did not go in the second time. Or the third.

Today he sat on the step outside the doctor's house in Nara, in the one strip of shade, with a deer standing in the street looking at him out of its soft black eyes.

"I have nothing," Hayate told it.

The deer did not believe him.

Down the street, the crowd parted.

A man of rank, on foot, in a fine robe the color of wet ink, the two swords at his hip set just so, and the face of a man who had never once in his life stepped aside. Two men walked behind him. One carried a long spear upright in a black sheath. The other carried a lacquered box on a pole across his shoulder. People bowed as they passed and did not straighten until they had gone.

From his sash, on a braided cord, hung a purse of patterned silk. Full. It swung when he walked.

Hayate looked at it.

He looked at the doctor's door, which was closed.

He looked back at the purse.

He did not think about it. That was the thing about it. It never needed thinking. He was up off the step and into the street, and the deer startled and went bounding across in front of the man of rank, and the man checked his stride, and Hayate went by on the other side, stumbling a little, bowing, sorry, so sorry, the heat, and his fingers went along the silk cord the way water goes around a stone.

Then he was past, and the purse was in his sleeve, and it was so much heavier than he had—

A hand closed on his wrist.

Not the man of rank. The one with the box. He had set the box down. Hayate had not seen him set it down.

"My lord," said the one with the box.

The man of rank turned around.

After that everything went very fast, and Hayate's mouth went faster than all of it.

"It fell. It was on the ground. I was bringing it back, I was going to — you walk so fast, my lord, you walk very fast, I couldn't — the deer — did you see the deer? It came right across—"

The man of rank looked at him. He did not look angry. He looked at Hayate the way a man looks at something on the sole of his sandal. Then he looked at the purse, which the one with the box had pulled out of Hayate's sleeve and was holding up by its cord.

"Hold him."

The one with the box twisted Hayate's arm up behind his back until his shoulder cracked, and put him face down in the street, and the street smelled of dung and hot earth. The crowd had made a ring. Hayate could see their feet. Straw sandals. Bare feet. A deer's small black hooves, stepping back.

He heard the spear come out of its sheath.

He heard the man of rank say, quite calmly, "Here. In the street. Let them see it."

Hayate stopped talking.

His hands, which always had something in them, which had never once been empty when he needed them, had nothing. His short sword was under him. His needles were in his left sleeve, and his left arm was twisted up behind his back, and he could not feel his fingers. He turned his face in the dust and looked up, and saw the spear point come down level, bright, and hold above his ribs, and he thought, very clearly, *what a foolish place for it*, and wanted to laugh, and couldn't.

The doctor's door slid open.

Ren stepped out onto the step. He stopped.

His eyes went over the street once. Not quickly. Not slowly. The man of rank. The one with the box, kneeling on Hayate's back. The spear. The crowd, where it was thick and where it was thin. The mouth of an alley between two houses, a little way down. The deer. Hayate had seen men look at a room that way when they were looking for where they had left something.

Then Ren looked at Hayate, lying in the street with a purse that was not his hanging from another man's hand.

Hayate waited for it. For the look. For the thing in Ren's face that would say *you did this*.

It did not come. Ren's face did not change at all. It was the face he wore when he counted coins, when he made the fire, when he gutted a fish.

He came down off the step.

He did not run. He walked into the ring as if it were an ordinary street, and the people in his way were out of it before they knew they had moved. The man of rank saw him, and saw the two long hilts, and his hand went to his own sword.

The one with the spear turned.

He was quick. He was trained. He did what a trained man does when someone walks at him wearing two swords: he struck first, the spear coming off Hayate's ribs and straight out at Ren's chest with all his weight behind it.

Hayate did not see Ren draw. He saw the spear go past Ren, close, as if Ren had simply been standing a hand's width to the left of where the point was going. He saw the light go along the steel once. That was all.

The man with the spear took two more steps. The spear fell out of his hands and rolled, and the black sheath lay in the dust beside it. Then he went down onto his knees, and then onto his face. One of his straw sandals had come off. It lay in the street by itself.

The crowd made a sound. Not a scream. The sound of a great many people breathing in.

The weight went off Hayate's back. The one with the box was standing, backing away, his hands empty.

The man of rank had his sword half out of its scabbard. It stayed there. He was looking at Ren, and Ren was looking at him, and the blade with blood on it hung down at Ren's side, and neither of them moved, and the cicadas screamed and screamed in the temple woods.

Then Ren's free hand took Hayate by the back of the collar, lifted him off the ground, and set him on his feet.

"Walk."

Hayate walked. He went the wrong way, toward the crowd, toward the wide street, and Ren's hand turned him, not hard, the way you turn a horse, and put him into the mouth of the alley. They went down it. Hayate's foot went into an open drain and he grabbed at Ren's robe to keep his feet. Behind them the man of rank was shouting now, finally, for the town guard, for anyone, and his voice went up high and cracked.

The alley turned. Turned again. A back gate stood open onto a temple yard, and Ren went through it as if he had known it would be open. Perhaps he had. He had walked past it that morning, Hayate remembered, and looked at it, and looked away. Across the yard, under great dark trees. A deer lifted its head from the grass and watched them go. A monk sweeping stopped sweeping. Through a gap in a wall. Down a bank. Then there were fields, and the town was behind them, and the shouting was a small sound, and then it was not a sound at all.

***

They did not stop until the sun was low.

The road ran along the foot of the hills with the rice below it, green and still. The evening insects had started in the grass, and the air had begun at last to cool. Ren was a few steps ahead. He had washed his sword in a ditch an hour before. He had not said anything since "Walk."

Hayate walked behind him and looked at his back.

He could still feel the street against his cheek. He could still see the straw sandal lying by itself.

A man was dead. For a purse. For a purse that had not been Hayate's.

"You didn't ask," Hayate said.

Ren kept walking.

"If I took it. You didn't ask me if I took it."

"You took it."

Hayate waited for the rest.

There was no rest. Ren walked on in the evening light, his shadow going out ahead of him long and straight down the road. That was the whole answer.

Hayate stopped walking.

He stood in the road a while.

Then he caught up.

They went on. The insects sang. A crow went over, very high, going home. Hayate looked at the back of Ren's head, at the two long hilts, at the dust on his heels. Something in his chest let go a little, and he did not know what to do with it, so he did the only thing he had ever known how to do.

"There was a monk in Uji," he said, "who kept a deer."

Ren walked.

"An ordinary deer. He fed it and talked to it, and it followed him everywhere. One day a man came and asked him, why do you talk to a deer? And the monk said, because it's the only one in this temple that never interrupts me." Hayate paused. "And the deer said: that's not true."

Silence.

Ahead of him, Ren's shoulders moved. Once. A small hitch, like a cough, swallowed. Then they were still, and he kept walking as if nothing had happened.

"I heard you," said Hayate.

Ren looked back at him over his shoulder. Then he turned around and kept walking.

Hayate slowed and let him go on ahead. Five steps. Six. He counted them.

On the seventh, Ren stopped.

His hand went to his waist. Felt along his sash, where the small knife always sat. Felt again. His head turned a little, down, as if he could see through his own robe. His hand went inside the front of it, against his chest, where the purse had been since the camphor tree, and stayed there.

He did not move.

"Don't worry," said Hayate from behind him. "I stole them from you."

Ren turned around.

Hayate held out both hands. In the left, Ren's purse on its cord. In the right, the little knife in its plain wooden sheath. He was smiling.

Ren looked at them. He took them back, the purse first and then the knife, slowly, as if they might not be his.

"But... why?"

"To see how easy it is?"

Ren looked at him. His mouth opened. Nothing came out of it. It closed.

"Pretty easy," said Hayate, and walked past him, laughing.

He did not look back. He could feel Ren standing in the road behind him, the purse in one hand and the knife in the other, watching him go.

"How?"

It came quietly, from behind. Hayate kept walking.

"I'll show you."

The insects sang in the grass. The light went red, then grey.

After a while, behind him, the footsteps started again.

Chapter 11

Blade

The insects in the long grass had been going so long that Ren no longer heard them. He heard the horses instead.

Far off, down the road. Hooves on packed earth, slow, uneven, four animals at least, and under them the creak of loads shifting on wooden saddles. Then the lanterns came around the bend below the ford, one, two, five of them, swinging on poles, and in their light the dust the horses raised hung in the air and did not settle.

He lay flat in the grass above the ford beside Hayate with his chin on his arms. The grass was taller than a man here and smelled of the day's heat. A month of summer had gone into it since Nara. The stalks had begun to go pale at the tips.

"Four horses," Hayate breathed. "I said four."

Ren counted the lanterns. The men under them. Eight on foot. Spears on six. Two with swords, walking at the front, one older, one younger. On the lanterns, painted on the paper, the same crest again and again: three leaves inside a ring.

"You said six guards."

"Six. Eight. Guards are guards."

That morning, in a teahouse on the Yamato road, Hayate had leaned over his bowl and said the word *silver*, and then the words *the shogun's*, and then a great many others, and Ren had listened to all of them and said nothing until the end. Then he had said, "How much," and Hayate had grinned.

Now the horses reached the water. The first put its nose down to drink, and the man leading it hauled its head up and swore at it, low. The ford was wide and shallow and full of stones. The lanterns doubled in it. The line bunched at the edge, as Hayate had said it would, the front guards already in the water, the rear still on the bank.

Hayate's hand touched Ren's shoulder. Now.

Ren did not move.

On the far bank, where the road came up out of the water between two old cedars, the dark had changed shape.

He saw it before he understood it. A piece of the shadow under the left cedar was standing where no one had been standing. It did not move. The front guards came up out of the water toward it with their lanterns held high, the older one first, talking over his shoulder, and the light went up the trunk of the cedar and across the road and did not find it.

Then the older guard was on his knees in the road.

Ren had not seen the cut. He saw the lantern fall and roll and light the grass. He saw the younger guard turn, and his sword come half out, and then something went into the young guard's throat from three paces off, and he sat down in the ford with a sound like a dropped bucket.

The shadow came out from under the cedar. A man. Young, Ren's height, lean, in something dark that took no light, a straw hat hanging at his back. One sword in his hand. He walked into the lantern light as if he had been expected, and the first spearman who came at him died at the end of his own thrust, and the man stepped over him.

"Who—" said Hayate.

Ren was already up.

He went down the bank through the grass and into the water. It was warm and came to his shins. A spearman on the near bank saw him and turned, too slowly. Ren's sword came out under the lantern light, and the spear shaft split, and the man fell back into the reeds holding his arm. Another. Ren's back foot slid, his hips turned, and the spearhead went past his ribs, and his left hand closed on the shaft behind it and pulled, and the man came

forward onto Ren's knee, and lost the spear and then his feet. Behind him Hayate came down into the water laughing, his short sword out.

Across the ford, the stranger was killing.

Ren saw it in pieces, between his own. The stranger did not guard. He did not wait. Each time a man came at him he went toward the man, one step, one cut, and the man stopped. There was never a second cut. Ren's cuts took hands and knees and spears. The stranger's took throats.

The horses were screaming now. One reared, and a pack slid off its saddle and burst open on the stones, and the lantern beside it lit a spill of something that shone.

Ren stepped for the next man and put his foot on a stone that turned under it.

It was nothing. Half a step. A stone in a riverbed, moss on it, the water moving. His weight went where he had not sent it, and he caught it, and in the time he spent catching it he knew there was someone behind him.

He could not turn fast enough. He knew that too.

Something went past his ear. There was a wet sound behind him, and a grunt, and then the stranger was there at his shoulder, passing him, and his sword went once across the man at Ren's back, and the man fell into the water with a knife standing in his throat.

The stranger stood over the body. He did not look at Ren. He bent, drew the knife out, wiped it on the dead man's sleeve, and put it away somewhere in his sash. Then he straightened and looked at Ren.

The ford was quiet. Two lanterns burned on the ground. One floated, going out. The horses stood where they had stopped, trembling. Hayate was at the far end of the line with his sword down, breathing hard, looking from one of them to the other.

The stranger's eyes went to Ren's feet. Then to his hands. Then to the two long hilts. Then to his face.

Ren's went to the stranger's. The same order.

The stranger's sword came up.

Ren's met it.

It was not a fight. It was four movements, perhaps five. The stranger came in straight, the whole of him behind the point, and Ren was not there, and Ren's answer went into the place the stranger's body should have been, and the stranger was not there either. They turned. Came in. The steel rang once, bright, and the sound went off across the water. Then they were standing an arm's length apart. The stranger's point rested a hair from the side of Ren's neck. Ren's rested a hair below the stranger's ribs.

Nobody moved.

Water ran over the stones. A horse blew through its nose.

Ren looked at him down the length of the two blades. The stranger's face had nothing in it. Not anger. Not interest. His breath came slow, the same as Ren's. His eyes were very dark and very still, and they were not on Ren's face. They were on the place on Ren's neck where the point was.

If Ren moved, the point would go in. Not from anger. Because that was where it was.

Ren lowered his sword.

After a moment, the stranger lowered his.

"Yours?" The stranger tilted his head at the horses.

Ren looked at Hayate.

"Ours," said Hayate, wading up through the water. "Well. Everyone's, now." He held his hands out open, the way he had held them in the road the day they met. "There's more than three men can carry. That's the truth. We could fight over it all night. Or."

The stranger looked at him and said nothing. Hayate seemed to take that as agreement. He went to the burst pack on the stones and knelt and began to make piles.

"One for you. One for me. One for—" He looked up. "What's your name?"

The stranger did not answer. He was watching Ren.

"You didn't have to," said Ren.

The man at his back. The knife. The stranger looked at him a long moment.

"You were slow."

"Yes."

Something moved in the stranger's face. Not a smile. Something that comes before one, that did not finish.

Hayate made three heaps of silver on a saddle cloth in the lantern light. The stranger took the one nearest him without counting it, knotted it into a cloth, and put it inside his robe. He did not look at the others. He sheathed his sword, turned, and walked up out of the ford between the two cedars, and the dark took him back the way it had given him.

Hayate stared after him.

"He didn't count it."

Ren looked at the place where the dark had closed.

Then he looked down at the water around his feet. The stone was there, green with moss, the lantern light moving on it. He set his foot on it again, carefully, and felt it rock.

***

A week later the castle town of Kōriyama was full of people come to watch a man die.

Ren and Hayate came in on the morning road behind a string of pack-sellers and a family carrying a sick grandmother on a door. By the time they reached the main street they could not move. The crowd filled it from side to side and pressed back against the shop fronts, and everyone in it was looking the same way.

"What is it?" Hayate asked a man beside him.

"The Manslayer." The man said it with pleasure. "They caught the Manslayer."

A drum. Then, down the middle of the street, where men with staves had pushed the crowd apart, a horse came walking.

It was an old horse, a pack horse, and there was a man tied on it. His arms were bound behind him, and the rope went around his chest and under the horse's belly and up again, and his feet were tied beneath. His hair had come down. There was dried blood on his temple and on his cheek. The crowd was throwing things at him, and he did not turn his face from any of them.

A man walked ahead of the horse carrying a board on a pole, with writing on it, black and large.

Hayate read it under his breath. He read slowly.

"Kurogane. Called the Manslayer. For the killing of—" He stopped. "It doesn't give a number. It says *many*. And for the robbing of an official transport on the Yamato road." He stopped again and looked at Ren.

Ren was looking at the man on the horse.

A clod hit the man's cheek and burst, and he did not blink. His eyes went along the crowd, slowly. Not searching. Measuring. Ren watched them go over the men with staves, their hands, their feet, the gaps between them, and stop, and move on.

They came to Ren and stopped.

Ren looked back.

He was in the ford again, in the water, the stone turning under his foot, the cold knowing that someone was behind him and he could not turn fast enough. Then the knife going past his ear.

The eyes moved on.

This man shouldn't die here today.

The horse walked on down the street toward the river, and the crowd went after it, carrying Ren and Hayate along.

Not like this.

Hayate was still looking at him. Ren felt it and turned his head.

Hayate's face had changed. The grin was gone. He looked at Ren for a long moment, the way he looked at a purse before he took it, and whatever he saw there, he did not argue with it.

"Oh," said Hayate quietly. Then: "Give me until the drum."

He was gone into the crowd.

***

The riverbed was dry and white and smelled of hot stones.

They took him off the horse there and put him on his knees on a straw mat at the edge of a pit that had been dug that morning. The earth at its rim was still dark. Behind him and to the left stood an awning, blue cloth on poles, and under it two officials sat on stools with fans, and a clerk with a brush. On a low table beside the clerk, laid out in a row the way a merchant lays out goods, were his sword and his three knives. In front of him, across the stones, the crowd stood behind a bamboo rail and pushed against it. Beyond the crowd, along the bank, were the pens of the ox market, and the smell of the animals came down on the wind.

Kurogane counted.

He did not decide to. He never had. Twelve men with staves along the rail. Four with spears around the mat. Two with swords under the awning. The one who would do it, standing on his right with his sword still sheathed, rolling his shoulders: a thick man, sure of himself, his grip too far up the hilt. The spearman at the left of the mat had set the butt of his spear in the stones and was leaning on it.

It changed nothing. His hands were bound. He counted anyway.

The sun was hot on the back of his neck. His hair was in his eyes. The blood on his temple had dried and pulled when he moved his face, so he did not move it.

He had thought about this morning the way a man thinks about rain he can see coming across a valley. It would arrive. There was nothing to do about it. He had not thought much past that.

The drum began. Slow.

The thick man drew his sword. He poured water from a dipper along the blade, and the water ran off the edge and darkened the stones.

The crowd went quiet.

Somebody was walking out of it.

Kurogane saw him before anyone else did, because he had been watching the rail and the rail was where it happened. The bamboo was there, and a staff-man was there, and then the staff-man was sitting down on the stones and a young man was stepping over the rail. Two long hilts.

The one from the ford.

He was not running. He came across the white stones as if he had been sent for.

Kurogane watched him come. The spearman at the left of the mat saw him and lifted the spear out of the stones, and the young man's hand went to his hilt and did not draw. He walked into the line of the point and then was not in it, and his shoulder went into the spearman's chest, and the spearman was on his back and the young man had the spear.

The thick man turned.

The young man threw the spear. Not at him. Onto the mat, in front of Kurogane's knees, the blade toward Kurogane's hands.

Kurogane turned his back to it, laid the rope across the edge, and pulled.

Behind him the officials were shouting. The drum had stopped. The rope parted. He had the spear. He came up off his knees.

The thick man was good with a sword against a kneeling man. He had never stood in front of a standing one. Kurogane took his wrists at the end of the spear, and let the spear go, and caught the sword as it fell.

Then there were only the men in front of him. That was simple.

Three spearmen. He went to the nearest. One step. One cut. The next. He did not look at what was left behind him. The young man was on his left. Kurogane did not look at him either. He knew where he was the way a man knows where his own hand is. When a staff-man came at Kurogane's blind side, the staff-man was already sitting down before Kurogane turned. When a sword came at the young man's back, Kurogane was already cutting it.

The awning was on his way. The officials were gone from under it. He dropped the thick man's sword on the table and took up his own, and his knives, all three, as he passed.

From the bank, the oxen bellowed.

He felt it through his feet before he understood it: twenty animals at once, and under their voices the crack of pens breaking, and then the ground itself. The crowd broke. The rail went down. People ran every way at once, and out of the dust along the bank came the oxen, heads low, horns swinging, running at nothing, a brown wall of them across the white stones. In front of them, dust to his knees, arms waving, whooping, came the loud one.

"The river!" the loud one yelled. "Go! The river!"

The young man touched Kurogane's arm. Once. Then he was running for the water.

Kurogane went after him.

They went through the shallows with the oxen breaking behind them and the officials' voices lost under the bellowing, up the far bank and into the bamboo, and through it, and did not stop until every sound behind them was gone.

***

The young man made the fire.

He made it before the light went, in a hollow under a bank, out of sight of any road. He did it without being asked. The loud one had started to gather sticks, and the young man had taken them out of his hands and done it himself. Kurogane watched. A ring of stones. Tinder. The flint struck twice. A small fire, with no smoke. It was correct.

The loud one talked. About the oxen. About the man who owned the oxen, who would be very unhappy. About the officials' faces. About the shogun's silver. About how no one had ever done such a thing, not once, not anywhere. His arm was scraped raw from wrist to elbow. He did not seem to notice.

Kurogane sat across the fire from them with his back to the dark. His sword lay across his knees. His knives were back in his sash.

The young man was looking at him.

"Why."

Kurogane did not know he was going to say it until it was said.

The young man looked at him across the fire. His face did not change.

"You didn't have to."

The ford. The knife.

Kurogane looked at him a long time. The loud one had stopped talking.

Kurogane looked into the fire.

"Ren," said the young man. He tipped his head to the side. "Hayate."

"Kurogane."

"We know," said Hayate. "It was on the board."

Kurogane did not answer. He lifted the sword off his knees and laid it on the ground beside him, on the side away from them.

They did not ask him to stay. He noticed that. They did not ask where he would go. After a while Hayate lay down with his arm across his face and talked himself to sleep, his voice going softer and the words further apart

until they stopped. Ren sat a while longer. Then he lay down too, on his side, facing the fire. His back was to the dark.

Kurogane watched the dark for a long time. The insects. An owl. The fire going low.

He did not remember lying down.

When he opened his eyes it was grey. Birds. A cold in the ground under him that had not been there before, the first of it, the summer's end.

The fire was burning. Someone had built it up new while he slept, in the same ring. He had not heard it done.

Across it, Ren sat with his swords across his knees, watching the flames.

Kurogane lay still and watched them too.

Chapter 12

Brother

The doctor in Kizu had never heard of anything that would help.

Ren came out of his door into the cold. It had rained in the night, and the road through the town was dark and soft, and wet persimmon leaves lay flat on it, red and orange, stuck to the mud like something painted there. On the trees behind the houses the fruit still hung, bright, with no leaves left around it. The wind came down the valley with an edge on it that had not been there a month ago. He could see his breath.

Three months since the riverbed. The three of them had come through the end of summer and into the cold together, and it had stopped needing to be decided. When they stopped for the night, Kurogane went to where he could see the road. Hayate went to where the water was. Ren made the fire. When they moved on a job, nobody said where to stand. They stood.

And in every town, the doctor.

At the edge of Kizu, where the road left for the pass, there was a notice board under a little roof of its own. Most of the notices were old, gone grey and soft with rain. One was new. The paper was white and stiff, the brush strokes black and heavy.

A band of robbers, eight men, camping in the hills above the pass road. Travelers stopped and taken. A reward for their capture or their heads.

Ren read the sum twice.

It was more than the three of them had seen since the ford. More than the doctor in Nara had named. More than enough.

He took the notice down, folded it once, and put it inside his robe.

***

Hayate read it at the fire that night, holding it close to the light, his lips moving a little. Then he whistled through his teeth and handed it across to Kurogane, who looked at the number and at nothing else and gave it back.

Nobody said yes. Kurogane began to oil his sword. Hayate began to count his needles. Ren sat and looked at the fire.

Three nights later they found the camp.

It was in a hollow above the pass road, under oaks that had begun to drop their leaves, and the leaves lay thick and dry on the ground and would talk under any foot that crossed them. There were two fires, banked low. Horses on a line. Shapes rolled in blankets. At the center of the hollow, between the fires, something square and dark stood on poles, as high as a man's waist.

Ren went through the tree line on the north side, where the oaks grew close and the leaves lay on moss. Hayate went wide, east, around the far side of the horses, and was gone. Kurogane was nowhere. That was where Kurogane always was.

Ren counted. Two on watch, one at each fire. Six sleeping. Eight.

He waited for the one on the north fire to turn his head. It turned.

It went quickly after that. The watchman at the north fire went down without a sound. The one at the south fire half rose and then sat again, all at once, and did not get up, and Ren did not see what had done it. The sleepers came up out of their blankets into the dark and the dark was full of things they could not see. Hayate laughing somewhere by the horses. A blade in the firelight. A man running for the trees who stopped at the edge of them as if he had walked into a wall.

The last was the biggest. He came out of his blanket with a long sword already in his hands, a heavy blade, old, the kind that had been made to cut at men on horseback. He did not shout. He came straight at Ren, and he was strong, and he was fast for his size, and the first cut came down from high with all of him behind it.

Ren's right sword rose to turn it.

He had turned ten thousand cuts like it in the clearing below the cave. He had turned the scarred man's on the road, and Kurogane's at the ford. The angle was right. The timing was right. The heavy blade met his a hand's length from the point and slid, and he felt it slide, and then he felt something else.

A sound like ice cracking on the river in spring.

His sword was lighter. The heavy blade went past his shoulder, close. Something spun away into the dark, turning, catching the firelight once.

The big man's weight came on after his blade. Ren's knee met it, under the ribs, and his left sword was already moving. The big man went down onto the leaves and did not get up.

The hollow was quiet.

Ren stood and looked at his right hand. The hilt. The guard. A hand's length of steel past it. Then nothing. The break was bright and grey and rough, like the inside of a stone.

Hayate came out of the dark, breathing hard, and saw it, and stopped.

Ren walked to the edge of the firelight and searched in the leaves until he found the rest of it. It lay point down, half buried. He picked it up by the flat. It was cold. He held the two pieces a moment, one in each hand, and fitted the edges together, and they did not fit together, not quite. Then he took the cloth from around his waist and wrapped the broken length in it and put it through his sash beside the empty scabbard.

Kurogane came out of the trees on the west side of the hollow with his sword already clean.

Nobody said anything about it.

***

Something was wrong with the camp.

Ren saw it when he turned from the leaves. The dead men's blankets had been rolled in a row, all the same size. The spears were stood together against a tree, points up, in a rack someone had lashed from branches. The horses were tied at even spaces along the line. The cook fire had been banked the way you bank a fire you mean to use at dawn, not the way you leave a fire you don't care about.

He walked to the square thing between the fires.

It was a closed palanquin, the kind for carrying people, but with the carrying poles lashed down and bands of iron around its body and a net of heavy rope over all of it, tied off at the corners. No lacquer. No crest. Nothing on it to say whose it was.

Hayate was already cutting the net. He threw it back and slid the door.

A young man sat inside. His wrists were bound in front of him, and his ankles, and a rope went from his ankles to an iron ring in the floor. He sat very straight, his hands in his lap as if they had been placed there. He was about their age. Thin face. His hair tied back neatly, even now. He looked out at the three of them in the firelight, one after another, and his face did not move.

"My plan worked," he said.

Nobody answered.

The young man looked at Ren.

"You came in through the oaks on the north side. You waited for the watchman at the north fire to turn his head toward the horses. He always did, at the same time, when the horses shifted." His eyes went to Hayate. "You went wide around the east, past the horses, downwind. You killed the man at the south fire from behind the third horse on the line." To Kurogane. "You were at the west edge, by the stream, from the start. I never saw you. The one who ran for the trees ran to you."

He said it the way a man reads out a list of rice sacks. Not proud. Just so.

"There is paper," he said. "Inside my robe. Left side."

Hayate looked at Ren.

"Hm."

Hayate reached in, carefully, the way he reached into anything, and brought out two folded sheets.

The first was the notice. The same notice. The same words, the same sum, the same heavy brush.

The second was a drawing. Ren took it and turned it to the firelight.

The hollow. The oaks. The two fires. The horse line. The palanquin at the center, a small square. And around it, three small circles in ink. One in the oaks on the north side, among the close trees. One wide in the east, beyond the horses. One at the west edge, beside a thin line that was the stream.

Ren looked at the circle in the north trees. Then up, across the hollow, at the place where he had stood and waited for the watchman to turn his head.

It was the same place.

He looked at the young man in the palanquin.

"Why?"

The young man looked back at him.

"They stop here."

He said nothing else.

Ren looked at him a moment longer. Then he stepped up into the palanquin and cut the rope at his ankles, and the rope at his wrists, and stepped back down.

The young man stood. He did it slowly, the way a man stands who has been sitting for days, and he did not stagger, and he did not rub his wrists. He stepped down onto the leaves. His eyes went once to the hilt at Ren's left hip, and to the cloth-wrapped length beside the empty scabbard, and stayed there for a breath. Then they came back up to Ren's face.

"Your name," said Ren.

"Shigure."

That was all.

He turned and walked out of the firelight, up the side of the hollow, through the oaks. The dry leaves did not talk under his feet. He did not look back.

The three of them stood by the open palanquin and listened until there was nothing to listen to.

Hayate opened his mouth. Then he closed it again.

Ren looked down at the drawing in his hand. The small circle in the north trees. The ink was dry. It had been dry for days.

***

Ōtsu smelled of the lake.

Shigure sat at the window of a room above a rice-seller's, with the paper screen slid back a hand's width, and watched the street. Morning. Mist lying on the water past the end of the street, white and flat, so that the boats at the landing seemed to float on nothing. A cold wind off the lake that moved the mist and did not clear it. Porters. A woman with a basket of eels. A monk.

On the mat beside him, on a sheet of paper, was the town. The street. The lake road. The landing. The teahouse on the water where the lord went every night. The lord's residence at the top of the street, its wall, its gate, its gatehouse, its inner hall. Small stones stood on the paper. Six for the lord's escort. One for the lord. One for Shigure, on the gatehouse roof.

He had not gone back west. He had not gone anywhere a man in his position might be expected to go. He had come here, and taken the room, and bought the paper and the ink, and spent two days at a teahouse and a smith's and a bathhouse saying the same things in different words to men who talked.

There was a smith in Ōtsu with old blades. Very old. The best in the province. A man with a good sword and a bad one could leave with two good ones, if he had silver.

Three stones lay to one side of the paper. He had not placed them.

In the street, a little before noon, the mist lifted off the lake all at once, and they came down the road from the west.

Three men. One loud, talking, waving his hands at the eel woman. One silent, a little apart, walking the way a man walks when he knows where everyone around him is. And one between them, with a single long sword at his hip and a cloth-wrapped length beside it, looking at the houses, the signs, the doors.

He was looking for the smith.

Shigure watched him find it. He watched him stop outside and read the sign, and go in.

He picked up one of the three stones and set it on the paper, at the smith's.

The other two he set down where he thought they would be. He was less sure of those. He did not need to be.

***

The lord came out of the teahouse late, as he always did, and drunk, as he always was.

Shigure lay flat on the gatehouse roof of the residence with the tiles cold under his chest and watched the street below. Lanterns at the teahouse door. The lord in the middle of them, laughing, his face red, his steps wide. Six guards. They should have been close around him. They were not. They were talking among themselves and looking at the girls in the doorway.

The quarrel started as Shigure had arranged it. A ronin, paid in the afternoon, very drunk now, stumbled into the guard at the rear and called him something. The guard shoved him. The ronin shoved back. Two guards turned to it. That was all it needed to be. Two guards turned, the escort thinned, the lord's own men hurried him up the street toward the gate with four around him, and the gate, and the hall, and Shigure.

Then the loud one was in it.

Shigure did not see where he came from. One moment the ronin and the two guards, and the next a young man in the middle of them, laughing, talking, taking a guard's purse from his belt and holding it up and asking whose it was. A guard swung at him. He was not there. The guard's fist found the ronin instead. The ronin drew. Someone screamed.

The quarrel became a fight. The fight became something else.

The silent one came out of the dark by the teahouse wall. Shigure saw two guards go down in the lantern light, one and then the other, each of them with one cut. At the hollow he had drawn a circle for that and never seen it happen. Now he saw it.

The lord's men did not go up the street.

They broke. They had the lord by the arms and they ran him the other way, down toward the water, toward the landing and the boats, away from everything. The lake road. From the lake road there was the shore, and the dark, and the whole of Ōmi.

The stones on the paper in the room above the rice-seller's were all in the wrong places now. Shigure lay on the roof and there was nothing on the roof for him to do. He watched it go. Every piece of it true, and none of it in the order he had set.

On the lake road, by the smith's, a door slid open.

A young man stepped out into the road. One long sword at his hip. The wrapped length beside it. He had been inside the smith's the whole evening, it seemed, and come out now because of the noise, and he stopped in the middle of the road with the lantern from the smith's doorway behind him, between the lord and the lake.

He did not draw. He only stood there.

The guards saw him. They saw the one hilt and the dead guards behind them and the young man standing in the road in front of them as if he had been waiting for them all his life. They stopped. They turned. They took the lord back up the street at a run, the other way, toward the only door left to them.

Toward the gate. The hall. Shigure.

The young man in the road watched them go. Then he looked up the street after them. Then he began to walk after them, not fast.

Shigure looked at the place where he had set the stone that morning. The smith's. He had put it there because it was where the man would go. Not because it would matter.

He moved back from the edge of the roof and went down the inner side into the dark of the courtyard.

***

Inside, the hall was lit by one lamp.

The two guards at the inner door had been told to stay at the inner door, and they were there when the lord was pushed through the gate and across the court. They came to meet him. They did not reach him. The first sat down against the doorpost. The second turned, and saw nothing, and lay down on the boards.

The lord came into the hall alone. His escort had stayed at the gate to hold it. He stood in the lamplight, breathing hard, his face wet, his hair come loose. On a stand against the far wall were two swords, a long and a short, their scabbards black and very old. He went toward them.

He looked up.

Shigure was already there.

The lord's eyes went wide. His mouth opened.

A single forward movement.

The strike landed clean.

The body settled, a little at a time, onto the mats, and then was still.

The lamp flame stood straight in the quiet. Somewhere at the gate a man was shouting, and then was not.

Shigure looked at the lord for a while. He did not bend down. He did not touch him.

Then he went to the stand against the wall, and took down the long sword, and drew it a hand's width from its scabbard, and looked at the steel in the lamplight. Grey. A pattern in it like mist lying on water. He slid it home.

The short one he left on the stand.

***

They came in at the gate a little after, the three of them, over the guards who had held it. The loud one first, then the silent one, then the one with the broken sword. They came across the court fast and then stopped.

Shigure was standing outside the hall door, on the step, waiting for them. The long sword was in his hands, flat across his palms.

The three of them looked at him. At the door behind him. At the lamplight on the boards inside, and what lay in it.

Shigure came down off the step and went to the one with the broken sword and held it out to him.

"Very old," he said. "Highest quality."

The young man looked at the sword. He did not take it.

"He won't need it."

The young man said nothing.

"You need a sword, don't you?"

He looked at the sword across Shigure's palms. Then down at his own hip. The one hilt. The empty scabbard. The cloth-wrapped length beside it.

He did not say anything.

He took it.

He did not draw it. He held it a moment in both hands, the weight of it, and then he took the empty scabbard out of his sash, and put the new sword where it had been, and set his hand on the hilt, once.

Shigure stepped back.

The loud one was looking from one of them to the other, and for once he was not talking. The silent one was looking at the hall door.

Nobody said that Shigure should come.

When the three of them went out through the gate into the street, Shigure went out with them.

***

In the morning, on the lakeshore east of the town, the one with the new sword made a fire.

Shigure watched him do it. The ring of stones. The tinder. Two strikes of the flint. It was a good fire. Small, no smoke, in the lee of a rock where the wind off the water could not reach it.

The loud one talked. He said his own name was Hayate, and said it again in case, and said the silent one was Kurogane and the one who had made the fire was Ren. Nobody asked Shigure anything.

Shigure took a pot out of his pack. Rice. A little salt. Pickled plums in a twist of paper. He washed the rice at the water's edge, and knelt at the fire and set it on. None of them said anything. Hayate sat down across the fire to watch, and after a while Kurogane did too.

When it was done, Shigure filled four bowls. Each exactly the same. He handed them around.

Hayate ate his with his eyes closed. Kurogane finished and held the bowl out, without a word, and Shigure filled it again. Ren ate everything in his, every grain, and set the bowl down.

Afterward Shigure took the bowls down to the lake and washed them in the cold water, one by one, and stacked them.

Four.

He looked at the stack a moment longer than he needed to. Then he put them away.

Chapter 13

Artist

The maples on the ridge had turned. Whole slopes of them, red and orange and a dark wine color, and under them the path was thick with leaves that had fallen in the night and lay still wet, the color of rust. The air smelled of them. Of wet bark and cold earth and, from somewhere far down the valley, smoke from a field where the rice stubble was being burned.

Shigure walked first. Ren behind him. Then Hayate, talking quietly to no one about the price of sandals. Kurogane last, where he always was.

The sound came through the trees and into Ren's chest before his ears had it.

A deep thud, like a door the size of a hill closing. The leaves shivered on the branches. Birds went up out of the maples all at once, every bird on the ridge, and the sky over the trees was full of them and then empty.

A second. Closer. The ground moved under his feet, a little, the way a boat moves.

Nobody said anything. Four hands went to four hilts.

A third, and then quiet. In the quiet, far off, someone was singing.

They went toward it.

***

The first body was in the path.

Most of it. It lay on its back in the leaves with its arms flung out, a man in a padded jacket, and below the ribs there was nothing that was still a man. The leaves around it were dark and wet with more than rain. Hayate stepped around it and did not look down again.

There were others. Through the trees, among the trunks, in the ferns. One hung in the low branches of a maple, folded over a limb like washing. Pieces lay where there should not have been pieces. The ground between the trees was broken open in places, raw holes the size of rice tubs, the black earth thrown up around them in a ring, and a smell hung over all of it that Ren did not know, sharp and sour, like a struck flint and like rotten eggs.

Ren counted. He stopped counting.

In the middle of it, where the trees opened into a little clearing, a net hung from a high branch.

It was a heavy net, rope, the kind men use to take deer. It was drawn up tight into a bag, and there was a person in the bag, folded up, knees to chest. The net was swinging. Not the way a thing swings when it has just been sprung. Back and forth, slow and even, like a child on a rope, and each time it reached the top of its swing it stopped there a moment before it came back.

The singing came from the net.

It stopped.

"Right steps," said a voice from inside it. Loud, rough, as if the throat it came from had been breathing smoke for years. "Or death."

Nobody moved.

Something fell out of the maple in front of them. It came down through the branches, hitting them on the way, and landed in the leaves a pace from Shigure's feet. It was a man. Half of one. The top half.

Shigure looked at it.

Then he looked past it, at the ground. At the holes. At the space between them. The clearing was not flat. The leaves lay over it unevenly, in low mounds, as if the earth under them had been turned and put back.

Hayate took a step forward.

Shigure's hand came out and stopped him, flat against his chest.

"Mines."

Hayate looked at the hand. Then at the ground. He stepped back into his own footprint.

Shigure bent and picked up a stone the size of a fist. He weighed it once. Then he threw it underhand, not far, into the leaves between them and the net.

The ground stood up.

The sound hit Ren in the teeth. Dirt and leaves and stones went up in a column and came down on all of them, pattering, and something hot went past his cheek, and the smell was everywhere, flint and rot, and his ears rang like a bell after the striking.

When he could hear again, the net was laughing.

"Smart enough," said the voice.

The net swung. Back. Forth.

"Hesitation?"

The four of them looked at each other.

Hayate looked at Ren. Whatever he saw in Ren's face, he had already seen it at the riverbed. He let out a long breath through his nose and did not argue.

Kurogane looked at the net the way he looked at a road he did not intend to take.

Ren looked at the ground in front of him.

"Follow steps," said the voice.

Ren stepped forward to the edge of the first hole.

"Left foot. The flat stone. No. Flat. That one."

Ren put his left foot on the flat stone.

"Right foot. The root. The big root. Stand on it, don't touch the leaves beside it. Good. Now wait."

Ren waited. The net swung above him. Through the rope he could see a face, upside down, dirt on it, grinning.

"Big step. Bigger. Past the dark leaves. Yes."

He went across the clearing one step at a time. Each step where the voice put it. Toes on a root, heel on a stone, the length of his stride exactly as long as it was told to be, no longer. He did not look at the mounds under the leaves. He looked where his feet were going. The voice hummed between instructions. Once it stopped humming, and said, "Not there," very quietly, and Ren's foot stopped in the air, and came back, and went where it was told.

He reached the tree.

The rope that held the net ran up over a branch and down to a stake by the trunk. Ren drew and cut it, and caught the rope in his other hand as it ran, and let the net down slowly into the leaves.

The net opened.

A boy climbed out of it. Not a boy. Younger than Ren, by a few years, but not a boy. Thin, all wrists and elbows. Filthy. His clothes were patched and scorched and hung off him. His hair stood up in every direction and had bits of leaf in it. His hands were black to the wrist with something that was not dirt. Around his left wrist, coiled tight, was a length of cord, and one end of it was smoldering, a thin grey thread of smoke going up from it.

He looked at Ren. His eyes were very bright and very wide, and they did not stay still. They went to Ren's face, and to his swords, and to his feet, and to the leaves, and back to his face.

He grinned. It took up most of his face.

"Back," he said.

He went first. He went across the clearing without looking at the ground at all, quick and loose, almost skipping, and Ren went behind him and put his feet where the boy's feet had been. At the edge, where the others stood, the boy stopped and turned around.

He took Ren's hand. His fingers were hot, and hard with calluses, and they did not ask. He turned Ren's hand palm up, reached into the satchel at his hip, and put something into it.

Three small balls of clay. Round, the size of plums, fired a dull brown. A short cord came out of each one like a tail.

The boy looked into Ren's eyes. Close. The grin did not move.

"Too close," he said, "and you die."

Then he let go of Ren's hand and turned and went back out into the clearing.

He went from mound to mound. He knelt at each one and brushed the leaves off with the flat of his hand and dug with his fingers, fast, and lifted something out of the earth, a clay pot with its mouth sealed, and set it in his satchel as if it were an egg. He did not hesitate. He went to each one as if he could see through the leaves. Eleven pots. When the satchel was full he tied a second one on his back from the branches of the maple where it had been hanging all along.

Then he walked away into the trees on the far side of the clearing. He did not say anything else.

"Wait—" Hayate called after him. "What's your name?"

The voice came back from among the maples. Loud, rough, cheerful.

"Enji."

Then only the sound of leaves, and then not even that.

Ren stood at the edge of the clearing with the smell of it still in his nose and his ears still ringing.

"Enji," he said. Quietly. To no one.

He looked down at his hand. The three clay balls sat in his palm, warm from the boy's satchel. He closed his fingers over them.

***

Enji stayed.

Not with them. Behind them. Off to the side. Above them, once, in the fork of a pine, when they stopped at noon by a stream and Hayate took off his sandals and put his feet in the water and yelled at how cold it was. Enji watched them from the pine with a square of paper in his hands, folding it, unfolding it, folding it again. His hands had to be doing something. They always had.

He watched them for six days.

He learned their names from listening. Hayate talked, so Hayate was easy. Hayate said the others' names more than they said them themselves.

He learned the rest from watching.

The one called Shigure kept a samurai's coat on over everything, even on the road, with a map folded inside it. He walked the ground before they camped. Every time. He went around it once, slowly, looking at the trees and the slope and the water, and then he said where each of them would sleep, without saying it, just by where he set their packs down, and they slept there. The one called Kurogane never lay down first. He sat with his back to something and watched the dark until the others were asleep, and then a while longer. His sword was never out of arm's reach. Once, on the third night, a fox came to the edge of the firelight, and Kurogane's knife was out of his sash and in his hand before the fox had finished stepping, and then he saw it was a fox and put the knife away. He did not look embarrassed. He did not look anything.

The one called Hayate could not sit still. He went off into the trees and came back with mushrooms, or a pheasant, or nothing and a story. His sleeves were always tied back off his arms, and his hands moved while he talked. Enji liked his hands. Quick. Wrong in a good way. Once Hayate walked past the pine Enji was in, close enough to touch, and stopped, and looked up, and Enji held very still, and Hayate looked right at him for a long time and then grinned and walked on and never told the others.

And Ren.

Ren made the fire. Every night, and every morning, even the morning they left before light and did not need one. Ring of stones. Two strikes. Ren did everything the same way twice. He walked the same way. He tied his sandals the same way. When he trained in the grey before dawn, two swords, alone, the same shapes over and over, every step landed in the print of the step before.

Enji watched the four of them together and it was like watching a thing he had built. Each piece where it should be. Each piece carrying the weight of another. Solid.

He folded the paper in his hands into something with wings and set it on the branch beside him and did not look at it again.

He did not go down.

On the sixth day, in a village at the foot of the hills, Ren went into a doctor's house and came out with a different face.

Enji saw it from the roof of a woodshed across the lane. It was the only time in six days he had seen Ren's face do anything. It was not much. Something around the eyes. As if a door had been opened a crack in a house where all the doors were kept shut.

That night by the fire Ren said more than Enji had heard him say in all six days together. There was a physician at the castle on the hill above the lake road. He had served a great house in Edo. He had treated coughing sicknesses in lords. He lived inside the castle now, in the service of the lord there, and saw no one from outside.

Nobody said anything after Ren had finished. Then Kurogane began to oil his sword. Hayate began to count his needles. Shigure took four stones from his sleeve and set them in the dirt by the fire and looked at them.

Enji, on the roof of the woodshed, took his match cord off his wrist and checked how much of it was left.

***

The castle was small. A hill, a wall of fitted stone, white plaster above the stone, a gate with a heavy roof and iron studs on its doors, a turret at each corner. Pines on the slope. From the top of it, you could see the whole lake road and the lake, grey and flat, going away to the north until it became the sky.

It was not a great castle. It was built the way great castles were built, only smaller. Every gate opened into a court that turned a corner before it reached the next gate. Every court was overlooked from above. Every path inside was narrow, and bent, and watched. Enji understood it the moment he saw it from the pines. It was built to hold men in place so that other men could kill them there.

He saw Ren go up the slope to the gate in the afternoon with the three of them behind him. He saw Ren say something to the guard. He saw the guard's face do what faces did when they were refusing something. He saw the guard open his mouth to say it again.

Ren's sword was at the guard's neck.

Enji had been watching, and he had not seen it leave the scabbard.

The guard went still. The other guard, beside him, went still. The whole gate went still, in the pale afternoon light, like a picture.

The gate opened.

Enji went up the back of the hill through the pines and over the wall where it met the rock, where the plaster was cracked and nobody looked because nobody could climb it, and was on the roof of a storehouse inside the second court before the four of them had reached the first corner.

It went wrong at the second gate.

Somebody in a turret beat a drum. Somebody else answered it. Men came out of doors that had not seemed to be doors, and down from the walls, and out of the corners where the paths turned. More men than the castle looked as if it could hold.

Enji lay on the storehouse roof and watched the four of them try.

Ren went for the next gate, the one that led toward the inner buildings where the physician would be. There was a way through. Ren saw it, Enji saw him see it, and Ren went into it clean, and then it closed, because the corridor bent and there were spearmen at the bend who had not been there a breath before. Ren came back out of it with a man's blood on his sleeve and nothing behind him but a wall.

Shigure stood in the middle of the court and turned his head, left, right, up at the walls. Reading. He said something to Hayate, and Hayate went where he was told, and the men who should have been there were not there, and the men who were there should not have been. Shigure's face did not change. He turned his head again.

Kurogane cut. One man, one cut. Another. But there were men behind the men, in a corridor two shoulders wide, and he could only reach the one in front, and each time one fell the next stepped into his place, and Kurogane's cuts came slower, not because he was tired but because there was no room for his arm. When one came in too close for the blade, Kurogane's elbow took him across the jaw instead, and the next stepped over him.

Hayate went everywhere. Up a wall and down it. Under a spear. Through a gap that was not a gap. It did not matter. Every place he went, the walls went with him.

They were being held. Not beaten. Held. Pressed into the turning courts, the bent corridors, the gates.

Enji looked at it.

He did not look at the men. The men did not matter. The men were only the parts of the castle that moved.

He looked at the corner turret above the second gate, where the drum was. At the timbers where its floor met the wall. At the gatehouse roof, heavy with tile, sitting on four great posts. At the corridor wall, which was plaster over bamboo lath over a frame of beams, and every beam in it carried the one above.

And at the storehouse under him, where it smelled, through the boards, of the same smell as the clearing. Flint and rot. Sulfur. A castle kept its own powder. Of course it did.

He slid down off the roof on the side away from the fighting and went in through the storehouse's back shutter.

It was dark inside, and cool, and the smell was very strong. Casks. Rows of them. Some opened. He did not need to look. His hands knew what was in them the way they knew a sheet of paper.

He worked fast. A sack from a peg, filled. Another. The cord at his wrist. His knife. He went out of the shutter with a sack over each shoulder and the satchel from the clearing on his back, and he went through the castle the way he had gone across the clearing, without looking at the ground.

He did not go where the fighting was. He went where the weight was.

The foot of the corner turret, where the great beams came down into the stone. The four posts of the gatehouse. The base of the long wall of the inner corridor, at the bend. The storehouse itself, one cask with its lid knocked off and a pot from the clearing set on top of it like a lid. He packed each charge tight against the wood with his hands and ran a cord from it, and his hands did not shake, and he was humming again without knowing it.

In the court, the four of them felt it before they knew what it was.

Enji saw Shigure's head come up. Not toward a man. Toward nothing. Toward the air. As if he had been reading a page and a word had changed while he looked at it. Shigure turned slowly, all the way around, looking at the walls, and his face was the same face, but his eyes were not sure of anything anymore.

Ren had stopped too. He was standing in the middle of the court with both swords out, and blood on the right one, and he was looking at the turret. Not at the men on it. At the bottom of it. At the place where the beams went into the stone.

He did not understand it. Enji could see that he did not. But he had seen it.

Enji touched the end of his match cord to the first fuse.

Then the second. The third. He walked along the cords, lighting, not hurrying.

The last one he lit was the storehouse.

Then he climbed back over the wall where it met the rock, and went down through the pines, and sat on a stone, and waited.

It was quiet for as long as it takes to breathe in and breathe out.

Then the turret came down.

It did not fall. It sat down, all at once, into itself, the way an old man sits down when his legs go, and the drum went with it, and the men on it, and the wall under it opened like a mouth. The gatehouse roof went up and came apart in the air, tile by tile, and came down over the second court like black hail. The corridor wall at the bend bowed out and broke along its whole length, plaster and lath and beams, and what had been a corridor was not a corridor anymore. It was a hole full of dust.

And the storehouse.

Enji felt that one in his chest, sitting on his stone in the pines. The sound was so large it was not a sound. The air pushed past him. The pines leaned. On the far side of the castle, a whole corner of it, wall and roofs and the court behind, lifted a little, and hung, and fell outward down the slope in a long slide of stone and fire.

Then there was no structure. There was only a hill with fire on it.

Out of the dust, out of the broken place where the corridor had been, four men came. Running. Not in any order. Not by any plan. Down over the rubble, over the fallen wall, onto the open slope, where there was nothing to stop them because there was nothing left to stop them with. Shigure first, for once not knowing where he was going. Then Hayate, pulling Kurogane by the sleeve. Then Ren, last, with both swords still in his hands, turning at the bottom of the slope to look back, once, at the place where the inner buildings had been.

Where the physician had been.

There was only smoke there now.

Enji watched him look. Then he watched him turn away and run.

***

They came up the next hill through the pines as the light went, and he was already there.

He was sitting on a rock at the top, with his back to them and his face to the castle. He did not turn around when they came up out of the trees. He heard them stop. He heard Hayate draw a breath to say something and then not say it.

Across the valley the castle burned. One side of it was simply gone, slid away down the hill in a long grey fan of stone and timber and ash, and the fire was in what was left, low now, red, working its way along the beams. Smoke went straight up into the still evening air and then, very high, bent east and spread. Below it, on the slope, on the road, in the rubble, there were shapes that did not move. Many. More than Enji wanted to count. He did not count them.

The four of them stood behind him. He could feel where each of them was without looking. Shigure to his left. Kurogane behind. Hayate to his right. Ren in the middle, a little in front of the others, the closest.

His hands were folding something. He did not know when they had started. A square of paper from his satchel, scorched at one corner. Fold. Turn. Fold.

He finished it and set it on the rock beside him.

A bird. Black at the tip of one wing, where the paper had burned.

Ren sat down on the rock beside him.

He did not say anything. He did not look at Enji. He looked at the castle, at the place where the inner buildings had been, and Enji looked at it too, and the smoke went up, and the five of them stayed like that as the dark came down around the hill.

Far off, over the valley, crows were coming out of the evening sky. One. Then three. Then more, a long black scatter of them, calling to each other, coming down out of the grey toward the smoke.

Chapter 14

Belonging

The paddies had been flooded. Out past the last houses of Kusatsu they lay full of water and sky, and in the seedbeds along their edges the young rice stood in close green rows so straight they looked drawn, and the frogs in the water had been going since dusk the night before and had not stopped. Where the two great roads met at the edge of town, the ground was soft from rain, and the mud was printed with the feet of everyone who had come through: porters, horses, pilgrims, a whole procession of some lord's men two days ago who had churned it to paste.

Ren sat on the bench outside a teahouse with a cup of barley tea going cold in his hand, and watched the roads.

Two years.

He did not count them. Hayate counted them, sometimes, out loud, at the fire, and Ren listened. Two springs. Two summers. Two winters in the hills with the snow to their knees and the five of them sleeping in a charcoal-burner's hut with the fire going all night and Kurogane getting up to feed it without anyone asking. A great many roads. A great many doctors. A great many nights like the one that had ended with a castle sliding down a hill, and some that had ended better, and some that had ended worse.

Five ravens sat on the teahouse roof above him, in a row, their feathers blue-black in the thin spring sun. They had come one at a time during that first winter and never left. One for each. Nobody had decided it. They followed on the road, a little behind, a little above, and waited on roofs, and ate what Enji threw them, and when the five of them walked into a town the ravens came in over the roofs first.

People had started to notice.

Inside the teahouse, a man was telling a story. Ren could hear him through the open front. Five of them, the man said. All in black. Nobody knew from where. Ronin, or not ronin. One with two long swords. One who never spoke. One who was a boy and blew up a castle in Ōmi, a whole castle, with his hands. They took jobs nobody else would take and finished them in one night, and the crows came in over the roofs before they did, and when they left there was nothing behind them but the crows.

"Black crows," said somebody else, laughing. "*Kuroi Karasu*."

"Don't laugh," said the man. "My cousin saw them."

Ren drank his cold tea.

At the next table, Hayate put his face in his hands and shook with silent laughter, and Shigure, beside him, looked at the roof where the ravens were and said nothing, and Kurogane did not look at anything, and Enji, cross-legged on the ground by the bench with a square of paper in his fingers, folded a crow and set it on Ren's knee.

***

The man who came for him came up the Nakasendō in the middle of the afternoon.

Ren saw him from a long way off. He saw a man walking alone who did not look at the paddies or the teahouses or the girls at the well. He looked at the benches, one after another, until he came to Ren's, and stopped looking.

He was older than Ren. Thirty, perhaps. A good robe, worn at the hems from the road. His topknot neat. Two swords, a long and a short, the way they should be worn. He walked the way men walked who had trained every day for years: from the hips, his weight low, nothing loose. He came across the mud and stopped in front of the bench.

The teahouse went quiet. The storyteller stopped.

The man looked at Ren's waist. At the two long hilts.

"You are the one," he said. "The one who carries two."

Ren looked up at him.

"Your master killed my master." The man's voice was steady, low. He had said these words before, alone, many times, on the road. "I have to take revenge by killing you."

Nobody moved.

Ren looked at him for a long moment. At his hands, his feet, his face. The man meant it. There was nothing else in him.

Ren set the cup down on the bench beside him. He stood up.

The man stepped back into the road to give them room. His hand went to his hilt. People were getting up from the benches, pulling back against the walls, pulling children behind them. On the roof, the five ravens shifted their feet and were still.

Behind Ren, none of the others got up.

The man drew. It was a good draw. Clean and fast, the blade coming out of the scabbard already moving, the first cut rising from low on the left toward Ren's ribs. He had been taught well, and he had practiced it for years, alone, for this.

Ren's back foot slid. His hips turned.

The cut went past.

The second came down from high. Ren's right sword was out and met it, turned it, and the man's blade went down into the mud. The man pulled it back and came again, and again, and each time Ren was already where the cut was not, and each time the man's face tightened a little more, because he was beginning to understand.

On the fifth cut, Ren stepped in.

Inside the swing. Close. His left hand took the man's wrist and turned it. His right sword came up and across and stopped.

It stopped at the man's throat. Touching. A bead of blood came up under the edge and sat there, bright, and did not run.

The man stood very still. His sword hung from the wrist Ren was holding. His breath came short through his nose.

The frogs in the paddies went on. Somewhere a horse stamped.

Ren looked at him down the length of the blade.

Musashi. On the bench in front of the cave. Watching. Saying nothing.

Your master killed my master.

Ren had not seen him in two years.

He took the sword away from the man's throat.

"Leave," he said. "Now."

The man stared at him. He did not understand why he was still standing.

Hayate had come up beside them at some point. Ren had not heard him. He was smiling, pleasantly, the way he smiled at shopkeepers, and he leaned in a little toward the man, as if he were telling him the way to the nearest inn.

"You don't belong here."

The man looked at Hayate. Then at Ren. Then at the others, still sitting at the teahouse benches: Shigure with his cup, Kurogane with his arms folded, Enji on the ground folding paper. None of them had moved. None of them had needed to.

He sheathed his sword. It took him two tries to find the mouth of the scabbard.

He walked away down the road he had come up. He did not look back. His back was very straight.

Ren sheathed his sword and sat down again on the bench. He picked up the cup. The tea was cold.

He did not drink it. He looked west, over the paddies, toward the mountains past the capital. They were blue with distance and there was still a line of snow on the highest of them.

The ravens on the roof settled their feathers.

***

That night there was work in the hills north of the road, and by the middle of the night it was done.

They were already leaving.

No signal. No command.

Kuroi Karasu moved without adjustment.

Shigure was ahead, already at the gate before the last movement inside was over. He did not look back.

Kurogane passed through the corridor. Two bodies were down before the space between the walls had finished closing. No excess. No second strike.

Hayate came from the wrong direction.

It didn't matter. Nothing shifted to account for him.

Enji was last.

Something behind them gave way. Wood. Stone. Weight.

They did not turn.

Outside.

Open ground. Night.

They stopped because there was nothing left to do.

No one confirmed it.

They moved on.

***

Later.

Fire.

Low. Steady.

The five of them sat around it.

The same order as always. Ren next to Hayate. To their left, Shigure. To their right, Enji. Kurogane in front of them, across the flames.

Hayate was talking.

He had been talking for a while.

Something about a market. A stall. A piece of fruit. He had been eleven. It should have been simple. It wasn't.

Each time he reached the end, something changed. The details shifted. The mistake got worse.

No one interrupted him.

Beyond Hayate, Enji rolled something along the ground.

A small clay ball.

It moved slowly. It stopped near Hayate.

Hayate paused in the middle of a sentence. He looked down at it. Then at Enji.

Enji was looking at the fire.

Hayate picked it up carefully. He set it down beside him.

He went on.

Kurogane spoke.

"That wouldn't work."

Not to Hayate. Not really.
Just into the space.
Hayate stopped. He looked at him.
Then he laughed. Too loud. He kept going.
It made it worse.
Kurogane did not react.
Shigure's eyes rested on Kurogane a moment longer than they needed to.
Then they went back to the fire.
Ren laughed for a moment. Then, slowly, he stopped, watching the fire.
He watched the flames. The way they settled. Shifted. Collapsed into themselves.
He did not speak.
He did not leave.
The fire burned lower.
No one got up.
No one finished anything.
The night held.

Chapter 15

Alive

The road out of the capital climbed into the hills through a morning that could not decide what it was. Sun, and then cloud, and then a thin rain that stopped before it had wet anything. The cherry trees along the lower slopes had finished. Their petals lay in the ruts, pale brown, pressed flat by wheels. Higher up the young leaves were coming on the maples, a green so new it was almost yellow.

Ren walked fast.

He had left the others at an inn below the city two days ago. He had said where he was going, once, and Hayate had nodded, and Shigure had put rice balls in a cloth for him without being asked, and Kurogane had looked at him and looked away, and Enji had been asleep. The ravens had stayed with them. His own had followed him to the edge of the city, and then sat on a gatepost and watched him go on alone.

He knew this road. Not the houses on it, which had changed, or the new bridge at the stream. The road. The way it bent. The places where it steepened. His feet remembered it before he did.

At the second bend there was a man sitting on the bank beside the road.

Something about him was wrong in a way Ren could not place. He was sitting on a flat rock with a wooden box open beside him, and in his lap was a piece of wood he was working with a small knife, and the curls came off it and fell on his knees and he let them lie there. His clothes were a traveler's clothes, faded, patched, the ordinary kind. But they sat on him as if they had been made for someone else. His hair was cut short. His face, when he lifted it, was not a face from here. The bones of it were in different places. The eyes were a color Ren did not have a word for.

He watched Ren come up the road. He did not stop carving.

Ren was almost past him when he spoke.

"You walk too fast," the man said, "for someone with nowhere to be."

The words were wrong too. All of them were words, and they were in the right order, but they came out with their edges in the wrong places, as if he had learned them one at a time from people who spoke differently.

Ren stopped.

He looked at the man. He said nothing. He had somewhere to be. He had been walking toward it for two years.

The man looked back at him, pleasantly, as if Ren had answered. He turned the piece of wood in his fingers and took another curl off it.

"Take it easy."

Ren looked at him a moment longer. At the knife. At the hands, which were a craftsman's hands, scarred across the knuckles, sure. At the box beside him, full of small tools laid in rows, some of which Ren knew and some of which he had never seen.

"I'll be gone for a few days," the man said. He smiled. "But come by my shop. I have something you'd like, young ronin."

He did not say where the shop was.

Ren turned and walked on up the road.

He did not look back. Behind him, for a while, he could hear the small sound of the knife in the wood. Then the road bent, and there was only the stream.

***

He came up the last of the path in the dark.

He had meant to come in the daylight. He had stopped at the river, where the stepping stones were, and stood there a long time looking at the water going over them, and when he looked up again the sun was behind the ridge.

The cherry tree at the bend was still there, in new leaf. Its fallen blossoms were already gone into the mud.

The cave mouth was lit.

He saw it from below, from the last turn of the path: the orange of it, low, steady, the shadows of the rock around it moving a little the way they moved when a fire was fed. The smell came down to him on the cold air before he got there. Wood smoke. Pine. And under it, something he had not smelled in two years and knew before he had put a name to it. The cave itself. Old wood and oil and stone.

He stopped at the mouth.

Everything was where it should be.

The fire in its ring of stones, burning clean, no smoke. The bench against the wall. The shelf they had built, pegged, no iron. The sword rack, and Musashi's swords on it, long and short, their lacquer dark with the firelight moving on it. And against the far wall the two wooden swords, standing side by side, perfectly straight, exactly where Ren had set them the morning he left. Not a finger's width moved. There was no dust on them.

Musashi sat in front of the fire.

He did not look up.

He was smaller. Ren saw that first. Not shorter. Less. As if something had been taken out of him from the inside and his robe had been left to hold the shape. His hair was whiter. His hands on his knees were all bone and cord. He sat as straight as he always had, and it cost him something to do it, and Ren could see what it cost.

Ren stood in the mouth of the cave.

Musashi did not turn his head. He reached for a stick from the pile by the fire and fed it in, and the flames took it, and the light went up the walls.

Ren came in. He took the swords from his sash and leaned them against the wall, by the entrance. He sat down across the fire.

Nobody said anything.

After a while Musashi took down two bowls from the shelf. He did not look at them. He filled them from the pot at the edge of the fire, rice and a little dried fish, and set one on the stone by Ren's knee.

They ate.

The fire cracked. Outside, far down, the river talked to itself over the stones. An owl.

Nothing happened.

When Ren had finished, Musashi took his bowl and washed it with his own and put them both back on the shelf. Then he sat again in front of the fire, and Ren sat across from him, and they stayed like that until the fire burned low. Then Musashi lay down on his side with his back to the wall and his face to the flames.

Ren lay down on the old mat in the old place. The blanket was folded at the foot of it. It smelled of smoke, and oil, and the old chest.

He lay awake a long time listening to Musashi breathe.

Long in. The pause. Long out.

Then, in the dark, a cough. Held. Held. And let go, very quietly, into a sleeve.

***

When he woke, the fire was already burning.

The ring had been swept. There was no ash in it. Musashi sat on his bench at the cave mouth with the grey light behind him, looking out at the clearing.

Ren got up. He took his swords from where he had leaned them by the door, and went out past Musashi, and down into the clearing, where the ground was still packed hard in the places his feet had packed it years ago.

He stood in the old place. He drew.

He ran the forms.

The first one. The second. The two blades moving together, the way they had learned to move on the road, in the ford, on the white stones of the riverbed, in a hollow under oaks. Faster than they had been when he left. Closer. There was nothing in them that did not need to be there.

He finished the sequence and stood.

From the bench, Musashi's voice.

"Again."

Ren ran it again.

He did not look up at the bench. He could feel the eyes on him the way he could feel the sun. On his feet. On his hips. On the angle of the left blade as it came through.

"Again."

He ran it again. The whole morning. The sun came over the ridge and dried the dew in the clearing and the young leaves on the maples shone. Musashi said "Again," and almost nothing else, and once, in the middle of the morning, he got up from the bench and came down into the clearing with the bamboo rod and touched Ren's back foot with it, once, a finger's width. "Hm." Then he went back to the bench. It took him a long time to walk back. He put his hand on the rock at the cave mouth before he sat.

Ren ran it again.

In the afternoon Musashi went inside and did not come out, and Ren sat on the rock at the edge of the clearing with his swords across his knees and looked at the river, and did not go in.

***

Dinner.

They sat by the fire again. The same bowls. The same rice. Musashi ate less than half of his and set it down. Ren watched him set it down.

Ren finished. He set his bowl on the stone.

He looked at it.

Then slowly he lowered his head.

"I asked everyone," he said. "Nobody knows."

The fire moved on the walls.

"Then stop asking."

Ren did not look up.

"Our last chance is the shinobi." His voice was low. "They could help."

Musashi looked at the fire.

"And if they won't help?"

"I'll make them help."

Musashi did not answer at once. He lifted his head, slowly, and tilted it, very slightly, toward the wall by the entrance where Ren's swords were leaning.

"With that?"

Ren looked over at the swords.

At one of them. The one that was not Musashi's. The long black scabbard, very old. Shigure's gift.

He did not say anything.

Musashi got up.

He did it in one movement, and it was the old movement, swift and exact, as if nothing had been taken out of him at all. He crossed to the wall and took up the sword. His hand closed on the hilt. The blade came out of the scabbard with a long, soft sound, and he held it up in the firelight.

He looked at it.

"Why?"

Ren was quiet.

Musashi's eyes went along the blade. Up it, from the guard to the point. Down again. The firelight moved in the steel, and in the grey pattern in it, like mist lying on water.

"Save me?" he said.

A pause. Very small.

"Because you're alive."

Musashi looked at the sword a moment longer. He did not look at Ren. His face did not change.

Then he slid the blade home into its scabbard, and leaned it back against the wall beside the other one, exactly where it had been, and went back and sat down in front of the fire.

The fire cracked.

Ren stood up. He went to the wall and took his swords and put them through his sash, one and then the other, and checked them.

Once.

He went to the mouth of the cave.

"Ren."

He turned around.

Musashi was sitting in front of the fire, the way he always sat, straight, his hands on his knees. He was not looking at the fire. He was looking at Ren.

"Don't hesitate."

Ren looked at him.

Then he turned and went out of the cave and down the path in the dark.

He did not look back.

He passed the cherry tree at the bend. He passed the river, and the stepping stones, and the water going over them, black and white in the starlight. He went on down toward the capital with the cold air on his face and his hand on his hilt.

Behind him, high up on the mountain, the fire in the cave went on burning. He did not have to look to know who was sitting in front of it.

Chapter 16

The Fox

The fog came up out of the valleys of Kōga at night and lay in the folds of the hills like water in a bowl. From the veranda of the house on the ridge you could not see the village below, or the paths, or the fields, or the stream. Only the tops of the cedars, black, standing up out of the white. Somewhere under it a dog barked once and stopped. The frogs in the flooded fields went on and on, muffled, as if they were singing through cloth.

Inside, one candle.

Kikyo stood at the table and read.

The papers had come in over nine days, by nine different hands. A peddler. A monk. A girl who sold charcoal. A boatman from the lake. Each had carried one folded sheet, and each sheet held one thing, and none of the people who carried them knew what the others carried. She had laid them out on the table in a row, in the order they had come. Now she picked them up one at a time and read them again, and set them down again in a different order.

The order they had happened in.

A court noble's face, opened from the cheekbone to the jaw, two springs ago, on the road to Uji. A guard who had stood beside him. Young. Two long swords.

A ford on the Yamato road, a shogunate silver train, eight dead. Kurogane, the one they called the Manslayer, taken for it and then taken back off a riverbed in Kōriyama by a young man who walked out of the crowd. Two long swords.

A lord in Ōtsu, dead in his own hall.

A castle in Ōmi, a small one, on the hill above the lake road, half of it slid down the slope. That one she had seen herself, from the next ridge, the morning after. She had stood a long time looking at it.

A doctor in Nara. A doctor in Kizu. A doctor in Ōtsu, and one in Kusatsu, and one in a village at the foot of the hills below that castle, the day before it fell. The same young man, each time. He waited on the step until the others had gone in. He asked the same questions. A cough. An old man. Blood.

She set the doctors down in a line along the edge of the table, and looked at them.

Then the last sheet. The newest. Two days old. The young man with two long swords was in the capital, and in the villages around it, going from door to door, asking about Kōga.

She read it twice. Something at the corner of her mouth moved and was still again.

Across the table, Takeru sat in his chair with his hands on his knees and waited. He did not read reports. He waited for her to tell him what they said. He had done it that way for years, and it had worked for years, and so he did not change it.

The map lay between them. It was painted on heavy paper, old, the colors gone soft: the provinces in their shapes, the roads in red, the lake a long grey stain, the mountains in small brushstrokes like waves. Kōga at the center, where they were. Iga to the south. The capital to the west, a cluster of tiny squares.

Kikyo put the papers down.

In one movement, without looking at her own hand, she took a long iron needle from her sleeve and threw it.

It went into the map in the middle of the capital, among the tiny squares, and stood there, humming a little, and was still. Its shadow lay long across the paper in the candlelight.

"Movement," she said.

Takeru looked at the needle.

"What kind?"

"Favorable."

"Who?"

"A boy." She looked at the line of doctors at the edge of the table. "Seeks a cure."

"I see."

He lowered his eyes from the needle, slowly, down across the map, south, over the mountains, to Iga. They stopped there and stayed. The candle flame leaned a little in some draft and straightened. Outside, the frogs.

Kikyo watched him look at Iga. She had known he would.

"Something interesting about it," she said. There was something very like amusement in her voice. Not much.

Takeru said nothing. His eyes stayed on Iga.

"Niten Ichi Ryū."

His head came up.

He looked at her across the table, and for a moment his face did something it seldom did. His brows drew together. He looked at her as if she had said a word in a language he had once known and forgotten.

"Raiden also confirmed," she said.

Raiden had been in Kusatsu twenty days ago, at a teahouse where the two great roads met, watching a road. He had watched a man with a good sword come up it and challenge a boy with two, and he had watched the boy take the man's sword out of the fight in five cuts and put a blade to his throat and then not use it. Raiden had written it down in the fewest words he could, the way he wrote everything. *Two swords. One drawn. The old man's style.* And under that, as if he had not wanted to write it: *He let him go.*

Takeru kept his eyes on her.

"Musashi."

The name sat in the room. The candle burned. Kikyo did not move.

"He's going to be a problem," said Takeru.

"He won't."

She looked down at the needle standing in the capital.

"But the boy will."

Takeru looked at her a long moment. Then down at the needle. Then back up at her. His hands on his knees did not move. He had given her orders for many years, and learned in that time which of them she needed and which she did not, and he knew, looking at her face in the candlelight, which this was.

"So be it," he said. "I grant you permission, Kikyo."

She bowed. Low, precise, her hands flat together.

"I will do my best, Master Takeru."

She straightened. She turned.

At the door she stopped for the space of a breath and looked back once at the table. At the doctors in their line. At the map. At the needle, standing up out of the capital, very small, very straight, its shadow reaching across the paper toward the mountains.

She left it where it was.

The corridor beyond the door was dark. She did not take the candle. She walked into the dark, and the dark closed behind her, and in the room the candle went on burning over the map, and the frogs went on singing under the fog.

Chapter 17

Victory

The yard behind the house was the only flat ground on the hill, and they had worn it bare.

Hayate stood at one end of it with a wooden sword in his hand and the morning sun in his eyes. The house was an old farmhouse nobody had farmed from in years, thatch gone grey, one corner of the roof patched with bark, a storehouse at the back that Enji had taken for himself and that nobody else went into. Wisteria had grown over the fence and was coming into flower, long pale purple hangings of it, and the bees were in it already, loud.

At the other end of the yard, Ren.

They came together. Wood on wood, the good hollow sound of it. Hayate went left and came from the right, went high and came low, and Ren was there every time, not moving much, the wooden sword always where it needed to be, and Hayate laughed because he always laughed, and went in again.

Then Ren was not where he was.

He was inside Hayate's reach, close, his shoulder against Hayate's chest, a hand on Hayate's collar and a hip turned under him, and the yard went over, and the sky went past, and Hayate landed on his back in the dust with all the air gone out of him in one sound.

He lay there. Wisteria above him, and the blue sky, and the bees.

Ren stood over him. He was grinning. Not the small thing at the corner of his mouth that he did sometimes. All of it.

"I won."

He laughed, and turned, and walked away across the yard toward the house.

Hayate lay in the dust and watched him go. He still had the wooden sword in his hand.

He got up without a sound. Three steps. Four. He reached out and touched the tip of the wooden sword, very lightly, to the back of Ren's head.

Ren stopped.

He turned around slowly, rubbing the back of his head.

Hayate was standing there with the wooden sword on his shoulder and the biggest smile on his face that his face could hold.

"I won."

***

The shop was at the end of the market street in the village below the hill, and it sold everything the village could not make for itself. Salt. Oil. Lamp wicks. Needles. Rope. Paper. Shigure had a list in his head and went down it.

Kurogane stood by the door. He always stood by the door. He did not come to the village for the shopping. He came because Shigure came.

A girl was behind the counter. Kurogane's age, or near it. Plain blue, sleeves tied back, her hair pulled up out of the way. She was weighing salt on a hand scale and did not look up when they came in, and did not look up when Shigure said what he wanted, and wrote it down with a brush on a scrap of paper without looking at the paper either.

"The lamp oil," said Shigure. "Is it fresh?"

"No."

Shigure waited.

"The fresh comes on the fifth day," she said. "This is what's left."

Kurogane raised his eyes.

She was looking at him. Not at Shigure. Past Shigure's shoulder, at the door, at the man standing in it with his arms folded. She looked at him the way she had looked at the scale. Measuring. Nothing else in it.

He looked back.

It lasted as long as a breath.

"You're in the light," she said to him. "Stand in or stand out."

Kurogane stood out.

Shigure watched him do it. He paid for the salt and the wicks and the rope and the oil that was not fresh, and the girl counted the coins without looking at them, and said nothing else, and Shigure picked up the bundle and went out.

They walked back through the village. The road up the hill between the paddies. The frogs. Neither of them said anything.

At the foot of the path, Shigure said, "She was interesting."

"No she wasn't."

Shigure did not say anything else. They kept walking.

Halfway up the hill, Kurogane looked back once, down at the village. Shigure saw it. He did not say anything about that either.

When they came into the yard, Ren and Hayate were sitting on the veranda with Enji between them, and there was paper everywhere. Squares of it, on the boards, on their knees, in the dust. Enji's hands were moving so fast they were hard to watch, folding, turning, folding, and a crane came out of them, and then a frog, and then a fish. Ren was holding a square of paper very carefully in both hands and doing exactly what Enji's hands did, one fold at a time, frowning. Hayate had made something with too many corners and was holding it up and insisting it was a horse.

Enji looked at it and laughed so hard he fell over sideways.

Shigure set the bundle down on the veranda and began to put things away.

***

Enji watched from the door of the storehouse.

The next day. Afternoon. Shigure had set the shogi board on the veranda in the shade and Ren was sitting across it, and they had been playing since the meal.

The pieces made a small sharp sound on the board. Tak. And then a long quiet. And then tak.

He saw Ren move a silver general and take his hand away. He saw Shigure look at the board for a long time. Then he saw Shigure lay his hand flat on the board, beside the pieces, the way he did when there was nothing left to do.

"Again," said Shigure.

Ren smiled. He got up.

Shigure looked up at him. He started putting the pieces back in the box, face up, in their rows.

"You always need the last win," he said.

Ren went down the veranda steps into the yard. He was still smiling.

Enji went back into the storehouse. It was dim in there, and smelled of clay and damp and powder and paper. His things were everywhere and each one was exactly where it was. On the bench, under a cloth, the thing he had been making for four days.

He took the cloth off.

A figure of clay, a hand high. A young man, standing. Two swords at his hip, both long. His hands at his sides. His head a little down, the way Ren held it when he was looking at a fire. Enji had fired it in the pit behind the storehouse two nights ago when everyone was asleep, and it had come out whole, which they did not always.

He picked it up in both hands and went out into the sun.

Ren was at the edge of the yard by the wisteria. Enji went straight to him and held it up in front of his face.

Ren looked at it.

He took it out of Enji's hands, carefully, the way he had held the paper. He turned it. He looked at the two swords. At the head, bent a little. At the hands.

Then he looked at Enji and smiled.

Enji smiled back. All of it. The whole grin.

The others had come. Enji heard them before he saw them. Hayate first, off the veranda in one jump, and Shigure behind, and Kurogane last, from wherever Kurogane had been.

Hayate looked at the figure in Ren's hands. Then at Enji.

"Just Ren?"

"I don't want one," said Kurogane.

Shigure nudged him with an elbow. Not hard.

"We all want one," said Shigure.

Enji looked at the four of them. Then he laughed, and turned, and ran back across the yard into the storehouse, still laughing, and they heard him in there, knocking things over, looking for more clay.

***

The inn was in the town at the bottom of the valley, on the road where it crossed the river, and it was the kind of inn that had seen better years and remembered them. Hayate liked it. The floors were worn soft. The food was good. And there was a girl who served the tables.

She was not smiling tonight.

Hayate saw it as they came in. He saw everything about faces; it was the thing he was best at, better than needles, better than hands. She was carrying a tray across the room and her face was held together the way you hold a cup that is too full. Her eyes were red at the rims.

The owner saw them come in, and stopped.

He was a round man with thin hair, and he knew them. Hayate could see him knowing them: the two long swords, the silent one, the boy. He came across the room quickly, wiping his hands on his apron, and he did not bow the way innkeepers bow. He knelt. Right there on the boards in front of them.

"Kuroi Karasu," he said.

His voice was shaking. Tears were running down his face and he did not wipe them.

His daughters. Two of them. Fourteen and sixteen. Taken four days ago on the road home from their aunt's, by men who worked for the boss who ran the gambling houses on the river and the boats and half the town. The boss had sent word. The inn, or the girls. The man had gone to the magistrate's office, and the magistrate's office had looked at its feet.

"Please," he said. He put his forehead to the floor.

Ren looked away.

Not at anything. At the wall. At the lamp. Hayate knew that look. Ren looked away when he did not want his face to decide for him.

"No," said Kurogane.

The innkeeper did not lift his head.

Hayate looked across the room at the girl who served the tables.

She had stopped. She was standing by the kitchen door with the tray in her hands, and she was looking at the innkeeper on the floor, and at them, and she was beautiful, and she was sad, and she was trying very hard not to hope.

"We'll do it!" said Hayate.

It was out before he had thought about it. It usually was.

Ren looked at him. Kurogane looked at him.

Then Ren and Kurogane looked at each other.

Ren did not say anything. Kurogane shook his head, slowly, once.

Behind them Shigure had already begun asking the innkeeper where the boss's house was, how many men, which side the river was on, and Enji had sat down on the floor and was going through his satchel.

***

The boss's house stood on the riverbank at the edge of town, and it had been built by a man who wanted everyone to know he could afford it.

Kurogane looked at it from the dark across the road. Two floors. A long front on the street, with a gate. Behind it a maze of wings and corridors running back toward the water, rooms opening into rooms, sliding doors behind sliding doors, lanterns in every passage. Too many doors. Too many corners. Men in the gateway, men on the veranda above, laughing, drinking.

He counted them. He counted the doors. He counted the lanterns, and there were more lanterns than he liked.

Shigure touched his arm. Kurogane went.

At the side door, Hayate slid the panel open a hand's width. Shigure's hand went in low and came out empty. Three small shapes rolled across the boards inside, and then the passage beyond the door was full of white smoke, thick, rolling, and men were coughing in it and shouting, and they went in.

Kurogane went in first. It was where he went.

It was simple for a while. A man in the smoke. One cut. Another. Doors, and men behind doors. He went through them. Ren was on his left, both swords out, not quite visible in the smoke, but Kurogane did not need to see him. Hayate was somewhere above, on a gallery, and men were falling off it. Shigure was behind, calling where, in a voice that did not need to be loud. Enji was last.

They found the girls in a room at the back, near the water, two of them, pressed into a corner with their arms around each other. Hayate got to them first. He was talking to them before he reached them, low and quick and warm, the way he talked to frightened animals, and the older one took his hand.

Then they were coming back, the girls in the middle, and a man came out of a side passage with a spear and Ren turned to meet him, and the butt of Ren's sword, going back, caught a lantern on its stand.

It went over.

Kurogane saw it fall. He saw the paper of it catch before it hit the floor, and the oil go out of it across the straw mats in a long bright tongue, and the mats catch, and the paper doors beside them. All at once. The way dry grass catches.

The corridor was burning.

"Back," said Shigure. "Back, back."

They went back. The fire came after them, faster than a man could walk, along the doors, along the ceiling, a sound like wind in it. The passage they had come in by was already orange. Then a beam came down across it, burning, and the ceiling came with it, and it was gone.

Another way. Shigure knew another way. They ran.

Enji was last. In a fight he was always last.

Kurogane heard it before he saw it. A crack overhead, and he turned his head and saw a beam come down through the smoke behind them, and Enji under it, pinned, one leg under the timber, the fire already along the far end of it.

Kurogane's weight went back toward him.

"Run!" yelled Enji. He was grinning. His face was black. "Don't burn!"

Kurogane stood a breath too long.

Then Shigure had his arm, and he ran. They all ran. The structure came down behind them with a sound like the sky falling, and the heat of it pushed them forward, and they ran.

They ran into a wall.

A room at the end of the last corridor, small, windowless, a storeroom with sacks against the walls. The door they had come through was fire now. There was no other door.

The smoke came in under the ceiling and began to come down.

Kurogane put the younger girl behind him, against the wall. He did not know why. There was nothing behind him to protect her from. Hayate had the older one, his sleeve over her mouth. Shigure was going along the walls with his hands flat on them, feeling, knocking, listening. Ren stood in the middle of the room with his swords in his hands and nothing to use them on.

The air was going. Every breath came in thinner and hotter, and there was less in it, and then there was almost nothing in it at all. The girl behind Kurogane was coughing into his back. His own eyes were streaming. He could not see Shigure anymore. He could see Ren, only just, a shape in the smoke, standing very still.

Hayate said something. Kurogane did not hear what.

The wall on their left came in.

Not burning. Breaking. Outward, all at once, with a sound that went through Kurogane's chest and out the other side, planks and plaster and sacks flying, and cold air coming through it, river air, night air, and in the hole where the wall had been, in the dark, a face.

Black. Grinning. Eyebrows gone.

"Run!" said Enji. "Don't die!"

They ran.

Out through the hole, down the bank, along the river's edge in the dark with the girls between them and the house going up behind them in one great column of fire that lit the whole river orange, up through the reeds, up the slope beyond, to the top of the nearest hill.

They stopped there because they could not go any further.

They lay in the grass. All of them. Coughing. Black with soot to the eyes, clothes burned through in places, hair singed. The two girls sat together holding each other and crying and laughing at once. Below, the house burned all the way down to the water.

Kurogane counted them. He did not decide to.

Five. And two.

Hayate got up onto his knees. He looked at Enji, lying on his back in the grass with his burned leg out in front of him, grinning at the sky. Then he crawled over and put both arms around him and held on, tight, and did not let go.

Enji laughed into his shoulder.

Kurogane looked away at the fire.

***

The innkeeper wept when he saw them come in at dawn with his daughters, and wept again, and would not stop bowing, and said that they must stay the night, all of them, as long as they liked, there was no bill, there would never be a bill.

They slept most of the morning. In the afternoon they ate in the big room downstairs, and the food kept coming without anyone asking for it.

Shigure found a shogi board in the corner, under a stack of cushions, and an old man by the window who had been watching the river for so long it seemed he was part of the window. Shigure set the board between them without a word. The old man looked at it, then at him, and began setting out his pieces.

They played through the afternoon.

The old man was good. He played slowly, and he played deep, and twice he laid a trap that Shigure did not see until he was already in it and had to spend four moves getting out. Shigure liked that. He did not show it. The light moved across the floor. Tak, and a long quiet, and tak.

In the end Shigure won. By a little.

The old man looked at the board for a long time.

"It's rare to find a good opponent," he said.

He began putting his pieces away.

"Next time I'll win."

Shigure bowed to him over the board.

***

That night the lamps were lit in the big room and the innkeeper had sent up sake and would not take money for that either.

Shigure was in the kitchen. Ren could hear him through the doorway, talking quietly to the cooks, and could see his hands moving. He was showing them how to press rice. A little in the palm, wet the hand, a slice of salted fish laid on, press, turn, press, not too hard, not too soft. The cooks were watching him the way the village had watched the castle burn.

Enji had fallen asleep against the wall with his bandaged leg out in front of him and his mouth open.

Hayate was sitting between Ren and Kurogane. He had been talking all evening. He had stopped a while ago.

The girl who served the tables was across the room, collecting cups. She was smiling tonight. Her sisters' faces were in her face somehow, the relief of it.

Hayate was looking at her.

He looked away. He looked back. He looked at his cup, and at the lamp, and back at her.

Ren saw it. On Hayate's other side, Kurogane saw it too.

"Talk to her," said Ren.

Hayate froze.

"You like her," said Ren.

"I—" Hayate said. "I—"

"He won't," said Kurogane.

Ren looked at Kurogane.

Kurogane looked back at Ren.

Something happened in Kurogane's face. Ren watched it happen. It started at the eyes and went down, and it was small, and it took a long time, and it arrived. He was smiling.

Ren smiled back.

They stood up at the same moment.

"What's going o—" said Hayate.

Ren took one arm. Kurogane took the other. They lifted him off the floor between them like a sack of rice, and carried him across the room with his feet off the boards, and set him down in front of the girl, and stepped back.

The girl looked at Hayate.

Hayate looked at the girl.

He was red from his collar to his hair. His mouth was open. Nothing came out of it at all.

Ren leaned over to Kurogane and nudged him with his shoulder.

"Now he doesn't talk."

Kurogane shook his head.

They went back and sat down. Kurogane filled Ren's cup, and then his own. Across the room Hayate was still standing in front of the girl, and after a while she laughed, not at him, and said something, and he said something back, and she laughed again.

In the kitchen doorway Shigure stood wiping his hands, watching.

Enji slept.

They drank, and they laughed, and the lamps burned down, and nobody went to bed until very late.

Chapter 18

The Deal

Yamashina was a small town on the road east out of the capital, a string of houses and teahouses along the highway with rice on both sides and the hills close behind. It had rained in the morning. By afternoon the sun was out and the road steamed, and the eaves dripped slowly onto the stones in front of the doors, and the air smelled of wet earth and the first mint in the ditches.

Ren walked down the middle of the street.

He had been walking streets like it for days. In the capital, and in the villages around it, and on the roads between. At every one he had asked, and at every one the faces had closed, or gone blank, or looked at him too long and then away. Nobody knew anything about Kōga. Everybody knew something. None of it was the same.

His eyes went to a house on the left.

He did not know why at first. It was a house like the others: a low front, a sliding door, a wooden frame around it gone dark with weather. A potted pine beside the step. Nothing about it.

Then he saw.

In the frame of the door, at the height of a man's chest, three shapes of dark iron stood out from the wood. Close together. Driven in deep.

Ren stopped.

He stood in the street and looked at them. The water dripped off the eaves in front of him. Somewhere behind the house a woman was beating a mat.

Three stars of iron, each the width of a palm. He counted the points on the first one with his eyes. Four. The second. Four. The third.

Four.

He walked to the house. He stepped up onto the stone in front of the door, beside the potted pine, and knocked twice on the frame, below the iron.

The door slid open.

A man stood in it. Older than Ren, not old. Plain clothes, the faded dark blue of a merchant's. A calm face, pleasant, forgettable, a face that would not stay in anyone's mind once he had walked past them. But his eyes did not move the way a merchant's moved. They stayed on Ren's.

Ren looked him in the eyes.

Then he looked at the three stars in the doorframe beside the man's shoulder.

Then he looked back at the man.

The man stepped aside.

Ren went in. Behind him the door slid shut, softly, and the light from the street was gone.

***

It was one room. Tatami, old but clean. No lamp. The light came in grey through the paper of a single shutter on the far wall and lay across the mats and did not reach the corners. The room smelled of nothing. Not incense, not food, not people. As if nobody lived in it, or ever had.

In the middle of the room, on the mats, a woman knelt.

She sat very straight, her hands folded in her lap, her robe a plain dark blue. A long iron needle held up her hair. She was not young and not old. Her face was still and smooth and gave nothing. Her eyes were on Ren from

the moment he came through the door, and they did not blink, and there was something at the very corner of her mouth that was not a smile yet.

Against the wall to the right, a man leaned with his arms folded.

He was not much older than Ren. Lean, dark, in the same dark blue, his hair tied back hard. A sword at his hip, one only. He was looking at Ren. Not at his swords, not at his hands. At his eyes. Straight into them, fixed there, without any feeling at all, the way a man looks at a mark on a target. He did not move. He did not seem to breathe.

Ren looked back at him for a moment.

Then he looked at the woman again.

"Welcome," she said. Her voice was soft.

Ren said nothing.

"Kunoichi of Kōga," she said, and bowed, low, her hands flat on the mat in front of her knees.

Ren was still silent.

She straightened. The thing at the corner of her mouth grew a little.

"You found us."

She said it the way you tell someone the tea is ready.

"We have what you need."

"Hm."

"It won't come easy."

"It doesn't need to be easy," said Ren.

She looked at him for a long moment. The grey light lay across the mats between them. Outside, far away, the woman beating the mat had stopped.

"A deal," she said.

Ren was quiet.

He looked at her. The hands folded in her lap, not a finger out of place. The back that did not touch anything and did not need to. Every word she had said, placed. Refinement. Accuracy. Nothing wasted, and nothing given that she had not chosen to give.

He looked at the man against the wall. The eyes that had not left his since he came in. The weight settled back on the wall, and still, somehow, forward. Instinct. Lethal. He would not hesitate. He would not know how.

He looked over his shoulder at the man by the door. Hands in his sleeves. Pleasant. Watching everything and seeming to watch nothing. Calm. Calculated.

He looked back at the woman.

She had not said what they had. She had not said where it was, or what it would cost, or what they would want in return, or what would happen after. She had said four things, and each of them was true, and each of them had a door in it that she had not opened.

He saw that. She saw him see it. Neither of them said so.

"The Iga," she said.

A pause.

"They have something."

Ren paused.

He thought of the cave. The fire. The old man's hand on the rock at the cave mouth before he sat. The rice left in the bowl. The cough held in the dark, and let go into a sleeve.

He did not think about anything else.

Slowly, he nodded.

"A deal," he said. Quietly.

"You can't just walk into Iga."

It came from behind him. The man by the door. Ren did not turn around.

He was silent.

"We get you in," said the woman.

She looked at him a moment longer. Then she bowed again, as low as the first time, her hands flat on the mat.

"You won't hesitate."

Ren looked down at her bowed head.

Against the wall, the other man had still not moved. His eyes were still on Ren's.

***

When he came out into the street the sun had gone behind the hills and the road had stopped steaming. The eaves had stopped dripping. The potted pine stood by the step.

He looked at the doorframe.

The three stars of iron were gone. In the dark wood where they had been there were three small holes, close together, at the height of a man's chest.

He had not heard anyone pull them out.

Chapter 19

The Boys

Kurogane saw him first, because Kurogane was always the one watching the path.

Morning. The mist was still lying in the valley below the house, and the path came up out of it through the bamboo, and a man came up the path with two long hilts at his hip and the mist on his shoulders.

Kurogane did not call out. He stood up from the step.

Behind him, the house knew anyway. Hayate came out of the door with his hair every direction and his mouth already open. Shigure came out behind him wiping his hands. From the storehouse at the back there was a crash of something falling over and Enji came around the corner as fast as his leg would let him, with clay to his elbows.

Ren came up into the yard and stopped.

Hayate reached him first and hit him on the shoulder, hard, and then hit him again, and was talking, and did not stop talking. Enji went around him in a circle, twice, as if checking that all of him had come back. Shigure looked at him the way he looked at a map after the pieces had moved, and nodded once, and went back inside to put more rice on.

Kurogane did not go to him. He went to the corner of the house where the wooden practice weapons leaned in a row. He took down a wooden sword and a wooden knife. He threw the sword across the yard.

Ren caught it without looking at it.

Kurogane stood across from him with the wooden knife in one hand.

Ren held the wooden sword low.

No count.

The knife left Kurogane's hand.

Ren's sword rose.

Wood struck wood and turned aside. The knife went spinning away into the wisteria and hung there in the branches, swinging.

Kurogane looked at it. He looked at Ren. It was a good throw. It had been going exactly where he sent it. Ren had been exactly where it was going.

Hayate, on the veranda, looked over.

"You two ever try speaking?"

A short pause.

Ren burst out laughing. All at once, bent over the wooden sword, the whole of it coming out of him.

Kurogane shook his head. He was smiling. He did not try to stop it.

He went and got the knife out of the wisteria.

***

Hayate had him all afternoon.

He took him down to the stream below the house where there was a flat rock in the sun, and sat him on it, and emptied his own sleeves onto the stone. Needles. A string of copper. A little knife. A die. Three pebbles. A folded paper that turned out to be a frog.

"Watch the hand," Hayate said. "No. The other hand."

He showed him. How to take a coin from a man's sleeve while you bowed to him. How to take a purse off a cord by looking at the man's eyes, not the purse. How to make the right hand busy so nobody saw the left. He had

said *I'll show you* on a road outside Nara two years ago, and he had shown him a little at a time ever since, in bits and pieces, whenever there was a stream and a flat rock and nothing else to do.

Ren tried it. Hayate watched and laughed.

"Your hand's too honest," he said. "It goes straight there. Look at it. It wants to go straight there. Make it go around."

Ren tried again. It went straight there.

"Around!"

Ren looked at his own hand. He looked at Hayate. He tried to make it go around. It went around, and then it went straight there anyway, at the end, as if it did not know any other way to go.

Hayate fell back on the rock and laughed at the sky.

Then he sat up and did it once more, slowly, so Ren could see, and his hand went around and around like water going around a stone, and came away with Ren's knife in it, and Ren had been watching the whole time and still had not seen it.

He handed the knife back.

"You'll get it," he said.

He looked at Ren a moment longer than he needed to. At his face. Then he picked up the paper frog and pressed its back, and it jumped, and landed in the stream, and floated away.

***

The storehouse was dark and cool and smelled of wet clay. Enji had a lump of it on the bench, and he pushed half of it across to Ren without saying anything, and went back to his own half.

Enji watched him out of the side of his eye.

Ren held the clay in both hands and looked at it. Then he began to push at it. He pushed at it the way he did everything, carefully, one thing at a time, and it came out stiff. A body. A head. Two arms. It stood up on the bench in front of him, straight, square, like a post with a head on it.

Enji looked at it and made a sound through his nose.

Ren looked at Enji's half. Enji's hands had been moving the whole time, and under them there was a crow. It had its head cocked. Its beak was a little open. One foot was a little in front of the other, as if it had just landed and had not decided yet whether to stay.

Ren looked at it for a long time.

"How," he said.

Enji grinned. He took Ren's post in his hands, and did something to the shoulders, and something to the neck, pushing with his thumbs, fast, and gave it back.

It was the same figure. But now its head was down a little. Now it was looking at something on the ground in front of it.

Ren turned it in the light from the door.

Enji went back to his crow. His hands did not stop. His face was very close to the clay. He was humming.

On the shelf above the bench, in a row, stood the other figures he had made since the first one. Hayate with his mouth open. Shigure sitting very straight. Kurogane with his arms folded. Enji had not made one of himself.

***

Shigure cooked.

Ren sat on the step of the kitchen and watched him. Shigure could feel it the way he felt a draft. He did not mind. The knife went through the radish so fast the slices lay down in a row like they had fallen asleep. The rice was washed three times, and the water poured off, and the rice set to soak, and Shigure did not look at it again until the

moment it was ready, and then it was ready. Fish, split and salted and laid across the coals. A pot of something with miso in it, and greens from the stream bank, and the smell of it went out through the whole house and brought Hayate in from wherever Hayate was.

Shigure pressed rice between his wet palms and laid a slice of the salted fish across it and set it on a board. Another. Another. Each one the same size as the one before.

Ren was still watching his hands.

"You're staring," said Shigure, without looking up.

"Yes."

Shigure made one more, and held it out to him.

Ren took it. He ate it in two bites. Then he sat very still for a moment, the way he sat when something had been exactly right.

Shigure did not ask. He went on pressing rice.

***

That night there was no work.

It did not happen often. There was always something, somewhere: a road, a job, a name somebody wanted gone. Not tonight. Tonight there was only the house, and the yard, and the fire in the ring of stones in the middle of it, and the five of them around it in the same order as always.

The frogs were going in the paddies below. The wisteria was a dark shape against a darker sky. Hayate was telling a story about a monk and a fox. Kurogane was cleaning a knife that did not need cleaning. Enji was lying on his back with his hands behind his head, looking at the stars, and every so often he laughed at something in the story a long time after everyone else had.

Shigure sat very straight and listened.

Ren watched the fire.

He waited until Hayate had finished the story. He waited until everyone had stopped laughing at it. He waited until the fire had settled into itself, low and red.

"I'm going to them."

Silence.

The fire cracked. Somewhere below, a frog stopped, and started again.

Hayate studied him. He did not smile. His eyes went over Ren's face slowly, the way they went over a crowd, looking for the one thing that was not like the rest.

Then:

"You already sound like them."

A pause.

Ren did not react.

"That's not a good thing."

Ren looked at him. Straight into his eyes. He did not say anything.

Kurogane did not speak. He had stopped cleaning the knife. He was looking at Ren. Not at his face. At all of him, the way he looked at a man coming up a road. Whatever he saw, he did not argue with it. He set the knife down beside him on the ground and went on looking.

Enji got up.

He did not look at Ren. He did not look at anyone. He went across the yard to the storehouse, and in a moment there was a light in it, and the sounds of him working. Grinding something. Tapping something. The same sounds as every night.

Shigure looked at the fire and did not say anything at all.

After a while, Hayate moved in closer to Ren. Close. Their shoulders almost touching. He did not say anything for a long time.

"Does the old man know?"

"Yes."

Hayate nodded.

Ren could feel him looking. Not at what was in his face. At how it sat. The way Hayate looked at a purse before he took it, or a stranger on a road, or a girl across a room.

Hayate did not ask anything else. He did not try to change anything. He sat there beside him, close, until the fire had burned down to coals.

Then he got up and went inside.

The others went in one by one. Kurogane last. At the door he stopped and looked back at Ren, sitting alone by the coals. Then he went in.

In the storehouse, the light burned late.

The fire was still where it had always been. Everyone was still where they had always been.

Ren sat and looked at the coals until they went grey.

***

He woke before anyone.

He knew it without opening his eyes. The house was still. The dark outside the shutters was not dark anymore but not light either. He lay a moment and listened to the others breathing.

Then he smelled it.

Smoke. Wood smoke. Clean.

He sat up.

Through the open shutter, in the yard, in the ring of stones, a fire was burning. Small. New. No smoke. Somebody had built it while he slept, and he had not heard it built.

He looked at it for a long moment.

Then he got up and began, slowly, to make ready for the road. His clothes, folded: a traveler's, not the black. The bundle, tied. His swords, through his sash. He checked them.

Once.

On the low table by the door, something lay that had not been there the night before.

A belt of leather, dark and oiled, made to go across the chest. It had slots and loops sewn into it all along its length, and in the slots, each in its own place, laid in with care:

Long thin iron needles. Hayate's.

Small round shells, sealed, with a cord at the top. Shigure's smoke.

A short blade in a plain sheath, the kind Kurogane wore in his sash.

And three small balls of fired clay, each with a tail of cord.

Ren stopped.

Silence.

Behind him, a voice. Quiet.

"The boys thought you might need some cover."

He turned around.

Shigure was standing in the doorway to the yard, with the new fire behind him.

Ren did not say anything. He looked at Shigure, and at the fire over Shigure's shoulder, and back down at the belt on the table.

"I won't need them where I'm going," he said quietly.

Shigure did not answer. He went past Ren into the house.

Ren stood looking at the belt.

Behind him, he heard a sound. A small, sharp clatter. Wooden pieces sliding in a box.

He turned around again.

Shigure was holding the shogi box in both hands.

"One game before you go?"

Ren smiled.

He sat down. Shigure set the board between them on the step, in the grey light, with the fire going beside them, and laid the pieces out in their places. Neither of them said anything. The pieces went down. Tak. A long quiet. Tak.

Shigure won.

He looked at the board a moment. Then up at Ren.

"Again?"

Ren got up.

Shigure looked up at him. His hands stopped over the pieces.

"Next time," said Ren. "I have to go now."

Shigure looked at him.

Ren looked at Shigure.

Silence. The fire moved. Somewhere in the house Hayate turned over in his sleep and said something nobody would ever know.

Shigure nodded, slowly, as if he understood.

"Come back alive, brother."

A pause.

Ren nodded.

Then he turned around and walked away across the yard, past the fire, past the wisteria, down the path into the bamboo and the mist.

The belt lay on the table where Shigure had put it. The pieces lay on the board where the game had ended.

Ren did not look back.

ACT III
RAIN

Chapter 20
Crossing

The forest in Iga did not let the moon in.

It was old forest, cedar and cypress, the trunks close and straight and very tall, and the canopy met so far overhead that under it there was only a green-black dark that smelled of wet bark and rot and something sweeter, flowers Ren could not see. The air was thick. Warm even at night. Moss on everything, on the trunks, on the stones, on the roots that crossed the path like the backs of animals asleep. Water ran somewhere close, over rock, the sound of it coming from every side at once.

Suzuya walked in front. He had given Ren his name on the Kōga road, and nothing else. He had not spoken since they left the Kōga road three nights ago except to say when to stop and when to go on. He walked without sound. Ren walked behind him without sound. Between them the dark moved and closed.

The path narrowed. The trees came in on both sides until Ren could have touched the trunks with his elbows.

Suzuya stopped.

"Here."

Ren looked around. A narrow path in the woods, a little wider here where a tree had come down across it years ago and been cut away and rotted to a hump of moss. A slope going up on one side into the dark, and down on the other toward the water. Nothing to mark it. Nothing to say it was anywhere.

"Their hunting grounds," said Suzuya.

Ren listened. The water. Insects. Something small in the leaves, far off, and then nothing.

"They will find you soon."

Ren turned his whole body and faced him.

Suzuya looked at him in the dark. The pleasant face, the forgettable face. Nothing in it now at all.

"You know what to do."

Ren nodded.

Suzuya's hand moved.

Ren saw it start. He saw the knife come out of the sleeve, low, and turn, and come up, and he did not move. The edge went across his chest from the left side of his ribs to the right, through the cloth and into him, and he felt it go in and come out, a long line of cold that turned hot behind it.

He did not step back. He did not make a sound. He did not look down.

The blood came. He felt it come, warm, through the torn cloth, down over his stomach, into his sash.

Suzuya was looking at his face. Waiting for something to happen in it. Nothing happened in it. Suzuya's eyes went a little wider. It was the first thing Ren had seen on his face that he had not put there on purpose.

Ren turned around.

He walked a few steps off the path to a cedar with roots like a chair and sat down with his back against it. He put his swords across his knees. He did not look at Suzuya. He looked at the dark in front of him.

After a while he heard Suzuya go. No footsteps. Only the place where he had been, becoming a place where no one was.

Ren sat against the tree.

The blood ran for a long time and then slowed. The cut stung, and then burned, and then settled into a deep steady ache that pulsed with his heart. He breathed slowly. Long in. The pause. Long out. The insects went on. The water went on.

He did not sleep.

***

They were on him before the light was properly light.

Aoi had seen the blood first, on the moss at the edge of the path, dark in the grey. Then the marks where someone had stepped off the path. Then him.

A young man, sitting against a cedar with two swords across his knees. His chest was black with dried blood from his collar to his sash. His head was down. He looked as if he had died there in the night and forgotten to fall over.

She lifted her hand. The six behind her stopped.

His head came up.

He looked at them. Not startled. Not afraid. He looked at them the way a man looks at weather coming over a ridge, taking in the shape of it. Her. Riku beside her. The others spreading out through the trees without being told.

He was about her age. His face was grey with blood lost, and there were dark marks under his eyes, and his eyes were very clear.

Something moved beside her.

Riku's hand, fast, the way it was always fast, faster than it needed to be. A star left it and went flat and spinning through the grey air straight at the young man's head.

He did not flinch.

It hit the cedar above him with a sound like a woodpecker, a hand's width above his hair, and stood there humming. A few flakes of bark came down into his hair.

He did not look up at it at first. He looked at Riku. Then, slowly, he turned his head and looked at the iron star standing in the bark above him.

She saw him count the points.

Six.

He looked back at them.

They closed in. No one said anything. The six of them stood in a ring among the trees with the young man at the center of it, and the light came up grey and green, and a bird began somewhere, and stopped, as if it had thought better of it.

"Your name?" said Aoi.

"Ren."

He lifted his eyes to hers when he said it.

"Ronin," he said.

"Bandits?"

"Betrayed." A pause. "My own crew."

She studied him. His hands, loose on the swords, not holding them. The cut, long and clean and not deep, the edges already closing. Whoever had made it had known what they were doing. His clothes, a traveler's, worn. His feet, bare in straw sandals, calloused like a monk's. His face.

He did not look away while she studied him.

"Kill him?"

Riku, beside her, a band of brown cloth tied around his forehead. His hands were on his swords, both of them, and he had taken a step forward, and then another, closer to the young man, close enough to draw and cut in one movement. He was smiling a little. Riku liked to be the one who asked.

The young man did not look at him. He kept looking at Aoi.

It was the first time their eyes had truly met, and she felt it the way you feel a step that is not where you expected in the dark.

"No," said Aoi.

Riku stopped.

She looked around at the others. She made a sign with her hand, two fingers, down and across. Two of them came forward and knelt beside the young man and got his arms over their shoulders and lifted him. He let them. He came up off the ground without a sound, though his face went a shade greyer, and he kept his swords, and nobody took them from him, because she had not said to.

"Back to Iga," she said.

She looked at Riku.

"Riku. Lead the hunt."

"Do I have to?"

"It's an order."

Riku looked at her. Then at the young man hanging between the two shinobi. Then back at her.

"Understood, Lady Aoi."

He turned away. The rest of them went after him, up the slope into the trees, and were gone.

Aoi turned the other way, toward home, and the two with the young man between them followed.

She did not look back at him. She could feel him behind her anyway.

***

He did not say anything the whole way.

They went down through the cedars to the water and along it, and then up, and the forest changed. Oaks. Maples, the leaves new and red. Bamboo in the hollows, so thick the path went through it like a tunnel. The sun came up somewhere above the canopy and the green went gold in places and the air grew heavy and warm and full of insects. Ren's chest burned with every step. He watched the ground and put his feet where the two on either side of him put theirs.

The mountains closed in. The path went into a cleft between two walls of rock, so narrow the three of them had to turn sideways, the stone cold and wet against Ren's back and chest, and it went on and on, and the light was a thin line above.

Then it opened.

Tall wooden gates, grey with weather, in a wall of timber and packed earth. They were open. A man on the gate looked down at the woman walking in front and nodded, and looked at Ren, and looked at him longer.

They went through.

Ren looked around.

He did not know what he had thought it would be. Something hidden. Something dark. It was a village.

It lay along a valley between wooded hills, with a stream through the middle of it and a wooden bridge over the stream. Houses, thatched and tiled. Fields beyond them, green with young rice. Smoke from cooking fires going straight up in the still air. Somewhere a woman was calling a name, over and over, and a child was not coming. A dog lay in the road in a patch of sun and did not get up for them.

On a flat stretch of ground by the stream, people were training, all of them in the same dark browns. Groups of them, all ages. Old men walking slowly through forms. Young men and women running up a slope and down

again, up and down, not stopping. Children in a row throwing at a post, their small arms coming over one after the other, iron going into wood, tak, tak, tak.

The children stopped throwing and stared at him as he went by. One of them waved. The others hit her.

He watched it all go past, and said nothing.

***

The doctor's house was near the bridge. It smelled of roots boiling and something bitter underneath.

They laid him on a table in the back room. It was hard, and smelled of the vinegar it had been scrubbed with. A wall of small wooden drawers ran along one side, each with a paper label, dozens of them, like the doctor's in the first town he came to off the mountain.

The doctor came in. A thin, quiet man, not old, with long careful hands. He looked at Ren's chest. He began to peel back the torn cloth.

"He's fine, Shin," said the woman.

She was standing in the doorway, with the light behind her.

The doctor looked up at her.

"He'd be dead already," she said.

Shin looked at her a moment longer. Then he looked back down at the cut, and something in his face agreed with her, and he stepped back from the table and went to his wall of drawers and began pulling them out, one and then another, not hurrying.

Ren turned his head on the table.

He looked at her. She was looking back at him. In the light from the door he could see her properly now. Dark brown, plain, a cord knotted at her waist. Her face was calm. Very still. It was a face that watched things, the way his did. But it was not closed.

"Thank you, Aoi," said Ren.

She did not say anything.

She stood in the doorway a moment longer, looking at him. Just for a breath. As if the name, in his voice, was something she had not expected to hear, and needed a moment to put somewhere.

Then she turned around and left.

Ren lay on the table and looked at the empty doorway. Behind him, Shin was grinding something in a bowl, slowly, the pestle going around and around. Outside, far off, the children had started throwing again. Tak. Tak. Tak.

***

Takeda's study smelled of ink and old paper. The lamp was already lit, though outside it was not yet dark, and it lit the low desk and the brushes laid in a row and the shelves of bound books along the wall, and not much else. At the back of the room the heavy door stood where it always stood, dark wood and iron, and Aoi did not look at it, because nobody did.

Takeda did not look up from what he was writing.

"The ronin."

"Cut by someone who knew how," said Aoi. "Long and shallow. Nothing inside touched."

"Bandits."

"He says his own crew."

Takeda's brush went on. It finished the line. He set it down on its rest, exactly parallel to the others.

"Riku is back," he said. "He found the place. Blood. One set of tracks going in. Nothing coming out. No crew."

Aoi said nothing.

Takeda looked up at her then. A long look, even and cold, the look he gave a report he had not decided whether to believe.

"You brought him in."

"Yes."

"Then he's yours." He picked up the brush again. "Where he goes, you know it. Who he talks to, you know it. When he sleeps."

Aoi bowed.

"Understood, Master Takeda."

She went out. The corridor. The courtyard. The gate. The bridge over the stream, where she stopped without meaning to.

Down by the water the lamp was lit in the doctor's back room. A shape moved across the paper of the shutter. Shin, with his bowl. Then only the light, steady, and nothing moving in it.

She stood on the bridge a while and watched it.

Then she went home.

Chapter 21

The Web

Below them, on the lower path, the boy was sitting against a cedar and bleeding.

Raiden did not look. He had watched from the ridge as Suzuya's knife went across and the boy did not move, and he had watched the boy walk to the tree and sit, and he had seen enough. The rest belonged to Iga now. By morning they would find him. By morning he would be inside.

Kikyo touched two fingers to her sleeve. Suzuya was already beside her, come up out of the dark without a sound, and the two of them turned down the slope toward the lower paths, the long way around, the way that went by water and left no marks. They were gone before the leaves had stopped moving.

Raiden went up.

Yoru behind him. Natsume behind Yoru. They took the high path, the narrow one that ran along the spine of the ridge toward Kōga, where the rock came through the soil and the trees grew twisted and low and there was no room for more than one man abreast. It was the shorter way, and the harder, and nobody used it but them.

The drop-off was complete. The movement was not.

He did not think about the boy. He thought about the path, and the dark, and the next step. But the boy was there anyway, behind him, in the shape of the night. Not Kōga. Not Iga. Soon inside the enemy's body, like a splinter under the skin. It would work its way to wherever it went.

The ridge path was strung with webs.

They hung between the low branches across the path, one after another, at the height of a man's face, heavy with the wet of the night. There was a little light now, a thin moon come out between clouds, and it caught in them and ran along the threads. Raiden walked through them. He did not brush them away. They broke across his face and chest and he walked on, and the next one broke, and the next.

Then there was one that was already broken.

He saw it. A web across the path, hanging in two torn halves, its threads drifting.

He did not stop. He did not change his pace. His hand moved to his sword.

It was not silence. The insects were still going, on both sides, in the dark under the trees. It was something else. As if the space ahead of him and behind him had been moved while he was not looking at it, a hand's width, and put down again not quite where it had been.

His hand was on the hilt before the cut came.

It came from behind. From the place just behind his left shoulder, where a man's neck is. It came into that place and found it empty, because Raiden had moved his head a finger's width to the right and his weight a finger's width forward, and nothing more, and the blade hissed past his ear so close it cut a few strands loose from his tied-back hair.

He turned.

There was a man behind him who had not been there. Lean, in grey, a blade in one hand, his face nothing but eyes above a strip of cloth. He was already moving again. His next cut came late. Not slow. Late. Half a beat after it should have come, when Raiden had already answered the one it should have been, so that Raiden's blade met air and the real cut came in underneath.

Raiden gave it his forearm rather than his ribs. It opened the sleeve and the skin under it.

In front of him, something came out of the trees.

He did not hear it come. He saw it, and it was already close, closer than it had any right to be. Another man, taller, in grey. His sword came in from the side, from an angle that should have needed three steps to reach, and it

reached. Raiden twisted away from it and it was still there, as if the distance between them had been a lie he had believed.

He knew them then.

He had never seen them. He had heard about them all his life. Kagetora, the one who made time wrong. Shinmei, one of their elites, the one who made space wrong.

Fūma.

It was fast after that, and it was ugly, and it did not go anywhere.

The one behind came late, and early, and late again, and Raiden could not hear the rhythm of him because there was no rhythm. The one in front was never where he was. Raiden cut at the tall one's chest and the chest was a pace further off than it had been when the cut began. He cut at where the short one would be and the short one had not arrived there yet, and arrived after, and the edge opened Raiden's side above the hip.

He did not try to find a pattern. There was no pattern to find. He did not try to be correct.

He went forward.

Into the tall one, shoulder first, where the distance lied, so that it had to stop lying. Into the short one, blade first, the moment the short one's cut came late, so that the cut arrived to find Raiden already inside it. Ugly. Close. Elbows and the flat of the blade and the heel of a hand. He took a cut on the arm and a cut on the side and gave back enough of his own that neither of them could close.

Around them the path was full of movement. Yoru and Natsume had come up out of the dark behind him and were on the others, the ones who had come with the two, three of them, four, shapes in the thin moonlight. Blades struck and turned. Someone grunted. Someone fell into the brush and got up again. A web broke across a face, silver, and was gone.

Raiden came around, and the tall one came in, and the short one came late.

Then all three of them stopped.

Raiden's blade was at the tall one's throat, just touching, the edge resting in the soft place under the jaw. The tall one's blade was at Raiden's ribs, the point in the cloth, a breath from going in. And behind Raiden, very close, just above the knob of his spine, he could feel the short one's point. He did not need to see it. He could feel where it was the way you feel someone looking at you in a dark room.

No one moved.

Around them the other fights had stopped too, because this one had. Yoru stood with his blade out and a Fūma's blade against it. Natsume had one down on the path with her knee on his back. Everyone was breathing. The moon went behind a cloud and came out again.

No one had won. No one had lost.

The tall one's eyes did not move at all.

Raiden spoke first.

"I have a proposition."

Behind him, a sound. Not a laugh.

"We won't listen to Kōga scum."

The short one's voice. Low, flat, full of contempt, as if the words tasted of something.

Raiden did not react. He did not turn his head. He kept his blade exactly where it was, at the tall one's throat, and his eyes exactly where they were, on the tall one's eyes.

"Your brother will."

The air changed.

It was very small. The point at his spine did not move away. It did not press harder. But the weight behind it shifted. Half a hair. The way a hand changes on a hilt when a man hears his own name called across a crowded street.

Kotarō. Nobody had said it. It was in the space between them now anyway.

Raiden waited. Then he gave them the one thing he knew they would respect, because it was the only thing they had ever respected.

"Same enemy."

Silence. The tall one's eyes had not changed. The point at Raiden's spine had not moved.

"By morning," said Raiden, "Iga takes in a wounded ronin."

Nobody answered.

"He is not ours. He is not theirs. Nobody holds him." He did not say more about the boy than that. There was no more that would help. "He will open a door from inside. No army can open it. No scout. No one on the outside."

The short one said nothing. Raiden could feel him thinking. Not about trust. There was none, on either side, and there would be none. About the shape of it. A door. A way into Iga from an angle nobody was watching.

"Kōga does not ask you to serve us," said Raiden. "We offer timing. The door. The same enemy from another side."

A long silence.

Then the short one's voice, closer, from just behind his ear.

"If my brother doesn't like it," he said, "you lose your tongue first. Then your head."

"Understood," said Raiden.

The tall one stepped back.

He did it without any warning, and without any movement that led up to it, the way he did everything. One moment his blade was at Raiden's ribs and the next he was three paces off among the trees, and then he was further, and then he was not there, and the leaves where he had been were still.

The Fūma on the path let go and went after him. Natsume took her knee off the one under her and he rolled away into the brush and was gone.

The point at Raiden's spine stayed.

It stayed a long time. Raiden stood with his blade still raised at nothing and felt it there and did not move. He could feel the man behind him deciding. Whether this was a thing to take back to his brother. Or whether it would be simpler to end it here, now, on the ridge, with one push.

Then the point was gone.

Raiden turned around.

The path behind him was empty. A web hung across it, unbroken, catching the moon. The short one had not gone through it. Raiden did not know which way he had gone.

He lowered his sword.

Yoru and Natsume came up to him and stopped, one on each side, and waited. Neither of them said anything. Neither of them looked at his arm, or his side.

Only then did he touch it. The wound above his hip. He put his fingers to it and took them away and looked at them. In the thin moonlight they were black.

He wiped them on his sleeve.

He looked once down the slope, the way they had come, toward the lower path and the cedar and the boy sitting against it in the dark with his chest opened and his swords across his knees. Toward Iga.

The boy had not moved when the knife went across him.

Raiden looked a moment longer. Then he turned away and lifted two fingers, and the three of them went on along the ridge toward Kōga, and the webs broke across their faces one after another, and hung torn behind them, in the dark.

Chapter 22

Watching Eyes

The morning after, Ren walked.

Shin had bound his chest in clean cloth and said he could walk if he walked slowly, and Ren walked slowly. Along the stream. Over the bridge. Up one street and down another. Iga was a village like any village. A woman beating rice in a mortar in her doorway, the pestle going up and coming down, up and down, and her baby asleep in a sling on her back through all of it. An old man mending a basket. Two girls carrying water on a pole between them and arguing about something, and laughing, and arguing again. Swallows going in and out under the eaves. The smell of pickles, and woodsmoke, and wet thatch drying in the sun.

People looked at him. The looks were not unfriendly. They were the looks a village gives to anything that has not been there before. A new dog. A stranger with two long swords and a bandage showing at the neck of his robe.

He came to the training ground by the stream and stopped.

It was a long flat stretch of packed earth, bare and pale, with the hill rising behind it and the water running along its edge. Groups of people were at work on it, spread out, each group to its own patch. Old men walking slowly through forms with their eyes half closed. Boys running up the hill and down. A row of children at the post, throwing. And near the stream, a group of eight, young men and women, moving together through a sequence with short wooden blades.

In front of them, Aoi.

She stood very still. She did not demonstrate. She watched. Her eyes went from one of them to the next, and the next, down the line and back, and when something was wrong she did not say so at once. She waited until the sequence came around again, and watched it be wrong again, and then said one word, quietly, and it was not wrong the third time.

Ren watched with her.

The eight were good. Their movements were clean. Every step went to its place. Every blade came through at the angle it should. They were so clean that nothing was left over, nothing loose, nothing of themselves. They could have been one person, eight times.

Something at the corner of Ren's mouth moved.

The group finished the sequence and stopped. In the stillness after it, Aoi's eyes came up off her students and went across the ground, past the throwers and the old men, to him.

She looked at him for a moment. From a long way off.

Then she looked back at her students and began to correct them.

***

Two mornings later Aoi went to the training ground before the light.

She went because she always went, a little before the others. And she went because Takeda had said *where he goes, you know it*, and she did not yet know where he went in the hour before dawn, and she did not like not knowing.

The mist was lying on the stream. The ground was grey and wet, and the hill behind it was a darker grey, and there was no one on it.

Then there was someone on it.

At the far end, near the water, a figure. Moving. Slowly.

She stopped at the edge of the ground and watched.

It was him. He was alone, and he had two wooden swords, and he was moving through something. Not a form she knew. Not a form anyone in Iga knew. He moved gently because of the wound, she could see him keeping his chest still. But nothing else about him was careful. Every step went down exactly where it should. Every cut came through the mist with his whole weight balanced under it, and the two swords moved together, and apart, and together, one answering the other, as if they were having a conversation in a language she did not speak.

She did not move.

It was the stillness first. How little of him moved when he moved. Then how much happened with that little. His left sword went low and his right went high and he turned between them, and it was over before she understood that it had begun.

None of it belonged.

Not to Iga. Not to the forms she had learned since she could walk, or the forms her father had learned, or his father. Every movement came from somewhere she had never been.

She watched until the light came up and the mist began to lift off the stream, and he stopped, and stood with both swords lowered, breathing, looking at the water.

She went back the way she had come before he turned around.

***

Two days after that, she came to the ground early and he was already there.

Not training this time. Standing at the edge of the stretch where her group worked, near the stream, with two wooden swords in his hands, waiting. As if he had been told to be there. As if he had been there for some time.

He looked at her when she came up. He did not say anything.

She looked at him. At the swords. At the place where he was standing, which was not in anyone's way, and was exactly where he could see all of it.

She nodded. Once.

She did not know why. It was not permission. It was not anything she could have explained to Takeda. It was the same thing that had made her stand at the edge of the ground in the mist two mornings ago and not go home.

The group came. They took their places. She began.

He did not join in. He stood at the side and watched. For a long time. She could feel him watching the way you feel sun on the back of your neck. Not their faces. Their feet. Their hips. The way the blades came through.

She corrected a boy's wrist.

She looked across at him.

She corrected a girl's step.

She looked across at him.

She told the whole group to go again from the beginning, and while they did it she found that she was looking at him again, and that she had not seen the girl's step at all, the one she had just corrected, whether it had gone right or wrong. She had been looking the other way.

She did not let it happen again that morning.

***

She was careful after that.

She did not go to him. She did not ask him to join. But she found reasons. She walked the line of her group past where he stood and said, without stopping, "How is the cut?"

"It hurts."

She waited for more. Something to cover it. There was nothing to cover it.

Another morning she dropped a wooden blade near his foot as she went past, the way a hand drops a thing by accident. Most men flinched. Some men caught it. Some men pretended it had not happened.

He looked down at it. He looked up at her. He did not pick it up.

She picked it up herself and went on.

She moved her group closer to where he stood so that when she walked the line, she walked through the edge of his space. He stepped aside for her exactly as far as he needed to, and no further, and then stood where he had been standing.

"How old are you?"

"Nineteen."

"Where is your crew now?"

"Gone."

He answered everything. He answered it at once, without looking away and without looking for anything in her face first. He did not ask her anything back. Not her age. Not her name, which he already had. Not why she was asking. There was nothing in him pushing against her questions, nothing working to steer her somewhere else. There was nothing in him at all that she could find.

It took her several mornings to understand what she was not finding.

She had been looking for the thing he was hiding. She had been trained to look for it. Everyone hid something, and the shape of it showed in how they held everything else.

He was not hiding anything. There was no shape. There was only a way of standing, and a way of answering, and a way of moving that did not come from anywhere she knew. The thing she was looking for was not there, and something else was, and she did not have a name for it.

She stopped looking for what he was hiding.

She started looking at what he was.

***

On the seventh morning she took a short wooden blade from the rack by the post, and walked across the ground to where he stood.

"Spar with me."

He looked at the blade. At her. Then he walked out onto the packed earth with a wooden sword in each hand, and turned, and waited.

The group stopped to watch. She did not tell them to go on.

She came in.

He was fast, even hurt. He took her first cut on his right sword and turned it without seeming to move his feet. She came again, low, and he was not where she had put the cut. She came again. He answered it, and for a moment there was a wooden edge at her ribs, and she turned and it was gone. Each exchange he was a little further inside what she was doing, as if he were learning her while she learned him.

On the next exchange, he stepped in.

She saw it coming. She let it come.

She feinted high with the blade and dropped under the line of his left sword, and turned, and her right hand went to the small of her back and came away with the dagger, the real one, and she was inside, close, closer than anyone stood, and the edge was at his throat.

She stopped it there. Touching.

Nobody moved.

He stood with both wooden swords still raised a little, and the steel against his neck, and he looked at her. His eyes had gone very still. Not afraid. Not angry. Taken. The way a man looks at a thing he has never seen before and did not know could be done.

She held it there a moment longer.

"You're not a shinobi," she said.

She could hear it in her own voice, the thing that was almost a smile.

She took the dagger away from his throat. She stepped back.

For a moment he only stood there.

Then he laughed.

It came out of him all at once, low, surprised, as if it had been waiting somewhere for a long time. His head went back a little. It was not a big laugh. But it was the whole of him, and she had not seen the whole of him before.

"No," he said. "I'm not."

Aoi stood very still.

Behind her, the group was silent. Behind them, further off, at the edge of the ground near the old men, someone else had stopped to watch. A broad man in faded brown, with grey at his temples and a long spear resting on his shoulder, standing with his feet apart, looking across the ground at the stranger with two swords. Beside him, a narrower man in dark brown, with his hands folded in his sleeves. Takeda. Neither of them said anything.

Aoi saw them. She saw her father's eyes go from Ren to her and back.

She put the dagger away.

***

After that she did not wait to find reasons.

She did not go to him. Not openly. But she was there. At the ground in the morning, when he was there. Crossing the bridge when he was crossing it. On the bench outside Shin's house when he came to have the cut dressed, with a basket of something beside her that did not need to be there.

He did not ask why. He looked at her each time, the same way, and nodded, and went on.

She watched him. Not from a distance anymore. Close. The way he stood. The way he ate, every grain. The way he stopped sometimes in the middle of the street for no reason and looked at nothing, at the hills to the west, for a long moment, and then went on.

She did not know what she was looking for now. She was not looking for anything.

She was only looking.

Chapter 23

Structure

Outside, Osaka was loud with noon. Carts on the bridges, boatmen shouting on the canals, hammers in the yards where the timber came in from the river, the whole city a great wheel turning in the heat. The sound came in through the walls as a single low murmur, like water far off.

Inside, the room was dark and still.

It was a long hall with a floor of polished boards and no windows. The only light came in through slats high up under the roof, in thin bars that lay across the floor at an angle and did not move. The air smelled of cedar, and oil, and nothing else.

Four figures moved in it.

Hanzō stood at one end and watched them.

They were working through a sequence he had set them three days ago, and they had worked through it every day since, from before light until the light came through the slats at this angle. Four of them, in black edged with dark grey, four points of a square that turned and closed and opened and turned again. A man in the east corner went low. A man in the north came over him. Two in the west and south crossed behind, and the square was a square again, one step further along the floor.

No one was out of place. No one was early. No one was late. Each foot went down where he had drawn it, in the plan, in ink, on the paper that was folded in his sleeve and that he no longer needed to look at.

He followed them with his eyes. Not their faces. Their positions. The spaces between them, and how the spaces changed, and whether they changed the way they should.

They did.

A door slid open at the far end of the hall. Light came in, white, and a man came in with it, and the door closed. The man crossed the edge of the floor, not the middle, not through the square, and knelt a few paces from Hanzō with his head down.

"Master Hanzō."

He held up a folded paper in both hands.

Hanzō turned.

He took the paper. He opened it. Five lines, in a small plain hand he knew.

A ronin taken into Iga at dawn, eleven days past. Wounded in the chest, not deep. Two swords, both long. Trains alone before light. A style no one in Iga knows. Kōga was on the ridge the night before. Fūma were on the ridge the same night.

He read it.

He read it again. Not the words. The shape of it. Kōga on the ridge. Fūma on the ridge. A boy in the valley between them, bleeding, the next morning.

Three pieces had moved on a board that had not moved in years. And one of them was a piece he did not have a name for.

He stood a moment with the paper in his hand. Behind him, in the hall, the square turned and closed and opened. He could hear it. He did not need to look.

"Thank you," said Hanzō.

The messenger bowed, rose, and went back along the edge of the floor, and the door opened, and the white light came in, and went out.

Hanzō folded the paper along its creases, once, twice. He put it inside his sleeve with the plan.

He turned back to the hall.

The man in the east went low. The man in the north came over him. The square closed, and opened, and moved one step further along the boards, exactly where it should.

He watched it until the light had moved off the floor and onto the wall.

***

The house was on a quiet street behind the castle, where the sound of the city did not reach at night. It was an ordinary house. Nothing on the gate to say whose it was.

One lamp lit the room where they ate. It stood on the floor between them and made a small round world of light that held the two trays, the two of them, and not much else. The hearth at the end of the room was cold. It had been cold for a long time. They did not use it.

Yukino had cooked. Rice. Clear soup with a slice of something white floating in it. Grilled fish, the skin crisp, a little salt. She had cooked for him every night for many years and she knew what he would eat and how much. He ate it, all of it, in the order it was placed, at the pace he always ate, and set the chopsticks down across the bowl when he was done.

She was not eating.

She was looking at him. She had been looking at him for a while, and he had let her, because it was her house as much as his and she could look at what she liked.

"Something changed," she said.

He raised his eyes and met hers.

She did not look away. She never had. It was one of the first things he had known about her, a long time ago, before he had known her name.

"There's movement."

"Where?"

"The shinobi."

She looked at him a moment longer. At his face in the lamplight, which did not change. At his hands on his knees, which did not move.

"Are you going to stop it?"

The lamp burned. Somewhere outside, a long way off, a night watchman was walking his round, knocking two sticks together at the corners, and the sound came and went.

Hanzō paused.

"No."

Yukino looked at him. Then she picked up her own chopsticks and began, at last, to eat.

He watched the lamp.

Chapter 24

Training Grounds

The smithy stood at the end of the village where the stream bent, so the water could be carried in by the bucket and the sparks would fall on nothing but stone.

It was open on one side. Inside it was dark and hot and smelled of charcoal and scale and wet iron. The forge was a pit of coals under a hood of clay, and a boy sat beside it working the bellows, a long wooden box with a handle he pushed and pulled, push and pull, and every time he pushed, the coals went from red to yellow and breathed out a little heat into the room.

There were nine of them. Ren and eight others, boys and two girls, fourteen, fifteen, sixteen years old. They stood along the wall and waited, the way the young wait in front of a man who has not spoken yet.

The smith was old. His forearms were bare and spotted with small white scars, dozens of them, like rice scattered on dark wood. He went down the line and put something in each of their hands. When he came to Ren he looked at him once, at the height of him and the two hilts at his hip, and put the same thing in his hands as in the others'.

A square of iron plate, as wide as a palm. Dull and grey. Heavier than it looked.

"Your own," said the smith. "Not your brother's. Not your friend's. Your own." He went back to the forge. "When one is pulled out of a man, Iga knows whose hand threw it."

That was all.

They took turns at the coals. The iron went in grey and came out orange, and they laid it on the anvil and struck it with the small hammers the smith gave them, flattening it, turning it, flattening it again. The sound of it filled the room. Nine hammers, none of them together.

Ren waited his turn. He watched the others.

They all cut the same shape. They laid the hot plate on the edge of the anvil and set a chisel to it and struck, and struck, and the corners came away, and the notches went in between. Six of them. Six points around a hole in the middle. The girl beside him cut hers fast, and cleanly, and filed it, and then took a thin punch and set three small dots near one point, in a row, and that was hers.

Six points. The same as the one that had stood humming in the cedar above his head.

His turn came. He put the plate into the coals and watched it change. He took it out with the tongs and laid it on the anvil and struck it flat. He did not hurry. He set the chisel.

He cut five.

He did not think about it before. The chisel went in, and struck, and went in again, and when he lifted the plate off the anvil there were five points on it, spaced around the middle as evenly as the fingers of a hand held open.

He quenched it. The water hissed and threw up steam into his face. He took it out and held it.

The smith was no longer watching the coals. He was looking at Ren's hand.

He came over. He took the star out of Ren's fingers and turned it in the light from the open side of the shed. He counted. Ren saw him count.

"Iga is six."

"Mine is five."

The smith looked at him. Ren looked back.

The boy at the bellows had stopped. The others had stopped. There was no sound except the coals ticking as they cooled.

The smith turned the star over once more. Then he gave it back.

"Then no one will mistake it," he said, and went back to the forge.

Ren took the file from the bench and sat down against the wall and began on the edges. One point, and then the next, and then the next, the file going across the iron with a sound like breathing. When he looked up, Aoi was standing in the open side of the smithy with the light behind her. He did not know how long she had been there.

She was not looking at him. She was looking at the star in his hand.

He went back to the file.

***

In the afternoon they threw.

The posts stood at the far end of the training ground, where the hill came down. Thick cedar, taller than a man, their faces pale and splintered and pitted with a thousand holes. A line was scratched in the packed earth ten paces off. Another at fifteen. Another at twenty, further back, near the stream.

The nine went to the first line.

Ren watched them throw. The girl with the three dots threw well, from the shoulder, and her stars went in, most of them, near the middle. A boy beside her threw too hard, and his rang off the post and spun away into the grass, and he went red and went to get them. Others threw the way they had been taught, all of them the same way, the arm coming over and the wrist turning down at the end, like a fan closing.

Along the edge of the ground, people had stopped to watch. They always did, on the first day. Old men. A woman with a basket. Two children.

The broad man with the spear was there, with grey at his temples. Beside him, the narrow man in dark brown, his hands folded in his sleeves.

Aoi stood a little apart from them.

Ren stepped to the line.

By the afternoon he had five stars, every one of them cut with five points. He held them in his left hand, fanned between his fingers. He took one in his right.

His hand knew the weight. It had known it for two years. It knew a knife, held by the blade and thrown so the whole arm went with it, the way Kurogane threw, straight, with nothing left over. It knew a needle, thrown from the fingertips, almost nothing, the way Hayate threw when he was laughing. It knew a smoke shell, lobbed high and dropped where it was wanted. It knew a ball of fired clay with a burning cord, thrown in a long low arc so it would not break until it had to.

This was none of them. It was a little of each.

He threw.

It went in at the middle of the post.

He threw again. It went in beside the first, touching it. Again. Again. The fifth went in above the others, and the five stars stood in the wood in a small close ring, so close that their points crossed, and you could have covered all of them with one hand.

The ground had gone quiet.

Ren walked to the post and pulled them out, one at a time, working each one loose. He walked back. He did not stop at the first line. He walked past it, to the second, and turned.

He threw five.

He walked past the second line to the third, near the stream, twenty paces, where none of the others had gone. The post was small from here. He could hear the water behind him.

He breathed. Long in. The pause. Long out.

He threw five.

They went in one after the other, tak, tak, tak, tak, tak, and when he walked back up the ground to the post they were in the middle of it, a hand's width across. Not as close as the first. Close.

He pulled them out.

When he turned around, the broad man with the spear was looking at the narrow man beside him. The narrow man was looking back. Neither of them said anything. The broad man's hand had moved on the shaft of his spear, a little lower.

Then they both looked at Ren.

He looked at them. He did not bow. He did not look away.

Behind them, apart, Aoi was still looking at the post. At the small ring of holes in the middle of it. Her face did not change. But her brows had come up, very slightly, and she was a moment slow bringing them down.

***

Night. No moon. No light except the sky.

The training ground was grey and flat and empty under the stars. The stream went by at its edge, louder in the dark than it ever was by day. The posts were black shapes at the foot of the hill. Somewhere in the village a dog turned over in its sleep and was quiet.

Ren stood in the middle of the ground with both swords drawn.

He ran the sequence.

Step. Turn. The first blade cut clean. The second followed, closer, tighter.

He accelerated into the finish.

Stopped.

The blades hung for a fraction too long.

Nothing moved.

A breath.

"...Don't hesitate."

It was quiet. Not a memory. Not fully a thought. Just something that settled into the space.

He reset.

Again.

This time the transition came earlier. He closed the distance before it fully opened. The second strike landed before the form completed.

The sequence ended.

Not correctly.

Not incorrectly.

Just... finished.

He held it.

He did not move.

***

From the edge of the ground, Takeda watched.

He had come out because Aoi had said the ronin trained before light, and he had wanted to see for himself what that looked like when no one was supposed to be watching. He had not expected him to be here at this hour. He had stood among the dark shapes of the old men's benches since before the first sequence, and he had not moved, and he did not move now.

He had seen the ronin spar Aoi. Hurt, careful of his chest, holding back without seeming to. That had been good.

This was not the same.

The chest was no longer held. The steps went down harder. The cuts came through the dark with all of the ronin's weight under them, and they were no less controlled for it. More. As if the control and the force were the same thing and always had been.

And the structure was familiar.

Takeda had heard it described too often, by too many men, not to know it when he saw it. A blade in each hand, both at once. The way the left answered the right. The way the stance sat low and still, and everything happened from it.

The foundation was clear. Miyamoto Musashi's Niten Ichi Ryū.

But what followed it was not.

The finish broke early. The second blade came in before the form had finished asking for it. It was not a mistake. A mistake would have been different each time.

The ronin ran it again.

Same break. Same early finish.

He stopped. The sequence still unresolved.

Takeda did not breathe differently. He did not move his hands in his sleeves. But he was counting, the way he counted everything. A ronin no one had sent for. A crew that had left no tracks. A wound made by someone who knew exactly how deep to go. Five points where every other star in Iga had six. And this, in the dark, two weeks after he had walked in half dead.

The ronin lowered both blades. He sheathed them, one and then the other.

He turned.

He left, across the grey ground toward the bridge, without a sound, and the dark took him.

Takeda did not follow.

Chapter 25

Focus

They trained by the stream, where the ground was flattest.

Morning. The mist had lifted off the water an hour ago, and the grass along the bank was still wet, and the light came low across the training ground and laid their shadows out long beside them. Behind them the others were at the posts. Tak. Tak. A pause. Tak.

Aoi had a short wooden blade. Ren had two wooden swords.

They were not sparring. They were working through the same exchange again and again, slowly, the way you learn the shape of something before you ask it to be fast. She came in high. He turned it. She came in low. He was not there. She came in again, and this time he answered before she had finished, and she stopped, and they stood a moment, and went back to their places and began again.

She was learning where he would be. It was not easy. He was always slightly somewhere else.

Her father came across the ground.

She saw him before Ren did, because she was facing that way. He came from the posts, not hurrying, a long wooden practice spear on his shoulder, the one from the rack, pale oak worn dark where the hands went. He stopped a few paces off and stood with his feet apart.

He did not look at her. He looked at Ren.

"I'll take him."

Aoi lowered her blade. She stepped back to the edge of the ground, to the wet grass by the water. She did not ask why. Her father did not explain things he had already decided.

Ren looked at her father. At the spear. At the way he stood. Then he turned to face him and let both swords hang low at his sides, the way he always began.

Her father took the spear off his shoulder.

She watched her father first.

She always had. Since she was small enough to sit on this bank with her feet in the water while he trained the others, she had watched him, and everything she knew of how a body should move, she knew from that. He was broad and he was not young, and none of it mattered. The spear lived in his hands. It went out and came back, and the point was always where it should be, and his feet were always under it, and nothing was ever left over.

He came in.

Not fast. A long, testing reach, the point drifting toward Ren's chest to see what would happen. Ren moved his left sword and the point went past. Her father drew it back along the same line it had come. Another reach, lower. Ren stepped. Another.

Clean. Controlled. Complete.

Ren fitted into it. She could see that he was listening to the spear, learning its length, learning how far her father's arms went and how far his feet would carry them. He gave back ground where the spear asked for ground. He turned it where it asked to be turned. Nothing stood out. It could have been any good student with any good teacher.

Her father began to press.

The reaches came faster. They came from different heights. The butt of the spear came around once, low, at Ren's ankles, and Ren lifted his foot out of its way and put it down again in the same place. Her father walked him backward. Not by force. By where he put the point. Each thrust left Ren one safe place to go, and each safe place was a little further back, and a little further to the side.

Toward the stream.

Aoi saw it before Ren could have. She was standing almost on the spot her father was driving him to. The bank there was undercut, the edge soft, a drop of a man's knee height into water that ran fast over stones. Three more steps. Two.

Her father's weight settled.

She knew that. It was what he did before the end of something. The spear drew back a hand's width, and his rear foot turned, and everything in him gathered behind the point. There was one place for Ren to go. Backward, off the bank. Or sideways into the thrust that was already waiting there.

It was correct. It was the way it should be.

The spear went out.

Ren went forward.

Not to either side. Not back. He went down, very low, his back knee almost on the wet grass, and in, under the line of the point as it came, and the spear went over his shoulder close enough to move his hair. His right sword came up flat against the shaft and rode along it, not blocking, only staying there, and his left was already moving.

Her father's eyes changed.

It was very small. Most people would not have seen it. She saw it because she had been watching his face her whole life. The skin at the corner of his eyes drew in. He had meant the thrust to finish it, and it had not finished anything, and the man he had driven to the bank was now inside the length of his spear, where a spear is worst.

He did the right thing. He always did. He pulled the shaft back hard across his body and turned the butt up to take the place of the point, and stepped, and made space, and the space held.

Almost.

Aoi stopped looking at her father.

She did not decide to. It happened the way your eyes go to a sound in the dark. From that moment she was watching Ren, and she did not look away again.

He was not stronger than her father. She could see that. He did not go where her father could not go, or move faster than her father could follow. It was something else. The exchanges ended before they should have. Her father would begin something, a feint and a turn and a thrust, three movements that belonged together the way the parts of a word belong together, and Ren would answer the second one. Not the third. The second. So that the third arrived, and he was already somewhere it had not been built for.

It was not wrong. Every time, she looked for where it was wrong, and every time it was right. It worked.

His left sword went low when a sword should go high. His feet crossed, once, where every teacher in Iga would have told him never to let them cross. He turned his back, for half a breath, to a spear. And each time, the thing that should have happened to him did not, because he had already gone.

She watched his hands. She watched his eyes. His eyes were on her father's hips, not his face, not the spear. Quiet. Almost sleepy. The way a man looks at a fire.

Her father pressed again.

It was good. It was the best she had seen from him in a long time. The spear went out and came back and went out, and the point was a grey blur in the low light, and Ren gave ground, and turned, and gave ground, and then did not give it.

For a moment, the structure did not hold.

She saw it. A fraction. Her father's thrust went out and Ren was not where it went, and her father's hands were a little too far forward on the shaft, and his weight a little too far over his front foot, and Ren's right sword was at his ribs. Not touching. A finger's width. Ren's left was high, across the line of the spear, where it could not come back.

It was there for as long as it takes to breathe in.

Ren did not take it.

He did not push. He did not step in. He stayed exactly where he was, the wooden edge a finger's width from her father's side, and did not move it any closer.

Her father's weight came back. His hands slid on the shaft. The spear came around.

Ren's sword was not at his ribs anymore. He had stepped away, as smoothly as he had stepped in, and they stood a spear's length apart, facing each other, and the point of the spear was at the level of Ren's throat, and both of Ren's swords were low.

Neither of them moved.

The stream went on behind her. At the posts, someone had stopped throwing. She did not look to see who.

Her father lowered the spear.

Ren lowered his swords.

That was all. No one said anything. No one bowed. No one had won. They stood across from each other on the wet grass, breathing, and the long shadows lay out on the ground beside them, and the mist was gone from the water.

Her father looked at Ren for a long time.

"Your sword style."

"Hm."

Her father waited. The spear rested in his hand, point down now, the butt on the grass.

"Where did you learn it?"

Ren looked back at him. He did not look away and he did not look at Aoi, and his face was the same face it always was.

"The mountains."

Her father did not answer. He looked at Ren a moment longer. Then he put the spear on his shoulder and turned and walked back across the ground toward the posts, not hurrying, and the ones who had stopped throwing began again. Tak. Tak.

Ren stood where he was.

Aoi stood where she was.

She was still watching him. She had been watching him since the spear went over his shoulder, and she found that she could not stop, and she did not know yet what it was that she was looking at. Only that it had stopped a finger's width from her father's ribs, and gone no further, and she did not know why.

He turned his head then, and looked at her.

She looked back.

Neither of them said anything.

Chapter 26

Rain

Evening in Iga came down slowly, the way it came in early summer. The light went gold on the thatch and stayed there a long time. Smoke went up from the cooking fires and hung flat above the roofs, because the air was heavy and there was no wind to take it. Frogs had started in the flooded fields beyond the houses. The sky over the western hills was the color of a bruise, and had been all afternoon.

Ren walked.

He walked most evenings now. Along the stream, over the bridge, up one street and down the next, the same way each time, so that by now the village had learned the shape of him going past.

The smith was sitting on a bench outside the smithy with his scarred forearms on his knees, cooling himself. When Ren came by, he looked up. His face broke open. It was not much of a smile. Most of his teeth were gone. But it was there, and it was for Ren.

Ren nodded once.

He went on.

Earlier, at the corner by the shrine, the woman who sold rice cakes from a tray on her doorstep had watched him coming, and when he stopped she had put one on a leaf for him, and then, without saying anything, a second beside the first. She had pushed them both across the tray toward him. When he reached for his coins she had waved her hand at him as if he had said something foolish, and gone back inside.

He had eaten them walking. Both. Every grain.

Near the well, something struck his sleeve. Small. A pebble. He heard it drop into the dust, and behind him, feet, running, and a high breathless laugh. By the time he turned there was no one there. Only the well, and the rope, and the bucket swinging a little on it, and a doorway down the street where a curtain was still moving.

He looked at the curtain.

Then he looked up.

At the end of the street, where it opened onto the training ground, three people were standing together. Aoi. Gensai, with his spear. Riku, with his arms folded.

They were talking. Gensai said something. Riku said something back, short, and laughed. Aoi said nothing. She stood with her hands at her sides and listened.

It went on for the space of a few breaths. Then Gensai turned, and Riku turned with him, and the two of them walked off across the training ground toward the far side of the village. Neither of them looked back up the street. Neither of them had seen him.

Aoi was alone.

She stood where they had left her. She did not follow them with her eyes. She looked down at the ground in front of her feet.

Ren walked up the street.

She heard him when he was a few paces off. She lifted her head, and her eyes met his.

"Ren."

"Good evening, Aoi."

She looked away from him, toward where Gensai and Riku had gone. They were small now, at the far edge of the ground. She looked back.

"My father will take my place tomorrow. In the hunt."

She paused.

Ren looked across the ground. The broad back. The spear on the shoulder. Riku beside it, a head shorter, talking.

"Gensai?"

He looked at her.

"Yes," she said.

Ren did not say anything.

The frogs went on in the fields. Somewhere behind them a door slid shut.

"Do you know about herbs?" she asked.

"Not really. I—"

"Tomorrow you'll learn."

He looked at her. She looked at him.

"Sunrise. Southern gate. Don't be late."

Then she smiled. It was quick, and it was not for anyone else, and she turned around before it was finished and walked away down the street.

Ren watched her go.

For a moment, he smiled.

"You're always late."

She stopped. She turned around.

"What?"

He was already walking the other way.

"Sunrise," he said.

He did not look back. He could feel her standing in the middle of the street, watching him go, the way he could feel a fire in a dark room.

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He was at the southern gate before the sky was grey.

The gate was shut. The man on it was asleep sitting up, with his chin on his chest. Ren stood by the post and waited, and the mist lay in the fields, and the first birds started, one and then a few and then all of them.

The sun came up.

A while after that, Aoi came up the road from the village with two baskets on her arm and her hair tied back. She saw him standing there. She slowed.

She did not say anything. She handed him a basket.

He took it. He did not say anything either.

The man on the gate woke up and looked at the two of them and opened it.

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The forest took them in at once.

Cedar first, and then, higher, oak and chestnut and maple, and ferns everywhere, up to the knee, still beaded from the night. The air was thick and warm and smelled green. Aoi walked in front. She did not walk the way he did, looking for the routes and the ways out. She walked looking down, at the edges of the path, the banks, the roots of trees, and every so often she stopped and crouched and her hands went into the green.

"This one."

A low plant with heart-shaped leaves and small white flowers, four petals each, like crosses. She pinched a leaf and held it under his nose. It smelled of fish, and of something sharp under the fish.

"For swelling. For boils. Shin dries it." She put it in her basket. "Take the leaves. Leave the roots."

He crouched beside her and took the leaves and left the roots.

"This one." Grey-green, the leaves cut deep and soft underneath, like felt. "For bleeding. You chew it and put it on." She looked at his chest, where the healed cut showed at the open front of his robe. "You should have had some."

"I had Shin."

"Shin used it."

He looked at the plant. He picked some.

They went on. She showed him a root that was good for the stomach and one that looked the same and was not. She showed him a moss that stopped blood and a mushroom that stopped the heart. She did not tell him things twice. He did not need her to. By the middle of the morning, when she stopped at a bank and pointed, he had already knelt and begun.

She watched him do it. She went on.

The light changed.

It happened all at once. The green under the trees went darker, and the birds stopped, and a wind came through the tops of the cedars, far above, a long sound like breath going out. The air turned cool on the back of Ren's neck.

Aoi looked up.

The first drops came through the leaves, heavy, far apart, striking the ferns so that they jumped. Then more. Then it was not drops at all but a single sound, everywhere, a roar on the canopy, and the water came down through it in threads and ropes and sheets, and within a few breaths they were both soaked to the skin.

She turned to him. Water was running off her hair and into her eyes. She blinked it away.

"There's a cave," she said. "Up there."

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It was not much of a cave. A cleft in the rock above the path, deep enough for a few people to sit out of the rain, with a floor of dry grit and a smell of old leaves and stone. Someone had used it before. There was a ring of blackened stones near the back, long cold.

Aoi came in behind him and stood just inside the mouth, dripping, holding her arms. The rain was a grey wall outside. The noise of it filled everything.

Ren set down his basket.

He went to the back of the cave where the rock hung over and felt along the floor. Dry leaves, drifted in and left. Twigs. A dead branch jammed in a crack, grey and light. He pulled it out and broke it across his knee, and broke the pieces again, and laid them beside the ring. He took the knife from his sash and shaved one of the thinner sticks, quick short strokes, so the shavings curled and stayed on the stick like feathers. He did three of those. He cleared the old ash out of the ring with the side of his hand and laid the leaves, and the curled sticks on the leaves, and the thin wood over them, and the thicker wood over that, leaning in.

From the pouch at his sash he took the flint and the steel, and a pinch of something dark and dry wrapped in oiled paper.

Two strikes.

The spark went into the dark stuff and it began to glow. He lifted it in his cupped hands and breathed on it, slowly, and it caught, and he laid it in the leaves under the feathered sticks. The leaves took. The shavings took. A small yellow flame stood up in the middle of the ring, and then another, and the thin wood began to crackle.

He sat back on his heels and fed it.

When he looked up, Aoi was watching him. She had not moved from the mouth of the cave. Her arms were still around herself. But she was looking at his hands, and at the fire, and at the pile of wood already broken and

waiting beside it in order of size, and something in her face had gone still in the way it went still when she was learning something.

She came and sat down across the fire from him. She held her hands out to it.

"Did you learn that in the mountains too?"

He stopped.

He looked at her. The water was still running out of her hair, and the firelight was on her face, and she was waiting.

He thought.

He looked back at the fire.

"A man in the mountains."

He was smiling a little when he said it. He did not know he was until it was already there.

Aoi was quiet.

She looked away from him. Up, into the dark of the rock above the fire, where the light moved.

There was a web there. A spider's web, strung across a corner where the rock folded, and the firelight had found it. Every thread of it was lit. It shone red and gold against the dark stone, and moved a little in the warm air rising, and the spider sat in the middle of it and did not move at all.

She looked at it for a long time.

"Do you know the story of the spider's thread?"

"No."

"A thief is in hell." She did not look away from the web. "He was a bad man. But once, on a road, he saw a spider and did not step on it. The Buddha remembered. He let down a single thread of spider silk, all the way from paradise into hell. The thief took hold of it and began to climb." She paused. "Then he looked down, and all the others in hell were climbing up the thread behind him. And he shouted at them that it was his. That they should let go. And the thread broke."

The rain roared at the mouth of the cave.

Ren looked at her. He was smiling.

"Salvation?"

He looked at the fire.

He looked at it a moment too long. The smile stayed on his face while he looked, and then, slowly, it was not there anymore. The fire moved. A stick settled into the coals and threw up a few sparks.

"I only know winning."

Aoi looked down from the web. She looked at him across the fire.

"Winning won't solve anything."

Neither of them said anything.

The rain went on outside, and the fire went on between them, and the light of it moved on their faces, and on the wet stone, and on the web in the corner, where the spider still had not moved.

They looked at each other.

Neither of them looked away.

Chapter 27

Still Water

The rain stopped in the night, and in the morning the pools along the stream were full and flat and so still they held the whole sky.

Aoi sat on the fence at the edge of the training ground and watched him.

He was there before her. She had stopped trying to come earlier, because whenever she came, he was already there, in the grey, alone, with the two wooden swords, and the ground around him was already marked with the prints of what he had done.

She watched the way she had been taught to watch. Hands. Feet. Weight. Eyes.

For weeks she had been looking for the thing behind him. The second face. Everyone who came into Iga from outside had one. It showed in the small places, in the half breath before an answer, in the eyes going somewhere else while the mouth said something true. She had been trained since she could walk to find it, and she had never not found it.

She had not found it in him.

It had taken her until the cave to understand why. She had sat across the fire from him with the rain coming down and watched him say *a man in the mountains*, and smile, and not know he was smiling, and she had understood then. There was no second face because there was no first one. He was not hiding who he was behind something else. He was only that. Whatever he said was what he meant. Whatever he did was what he was.

Not false. Different.

It should have made things simpler. It did not.

Out on the ground he ran a sequence she had seen him run many times now. Step. Turn. The first cut. The second, closer. And then the finish came too early, the way it always did, and he stopped, and held it, and did not move.

Then he reset and did it again. And stopped in the same place.

She had seen him do it at dawn, and in the evening when the others had gone, and once from the bridge, late, in the dark. Always the same place. Always the same break, and the same stillness after it, as if he were waiting for something at the end of the form that did not come.

She did not know what it was. She did not know how to ask.

She reached into her sleeve.

When he finished, and lowered the swords, and turned, she was standing in front of him. She held it out.

A pouch. Deerskin, dark, soft with oil, the size of two hands together, with a flap that tied down and a cord to go through a sash. Inside, she had sewn loops of leather in a row, narrow ones and wider ones, so that things could sit in their places and not knock together when a man moved.

He looked at it.

"For your stars," she said. "And whatever else."

He did not take it at once. He looked at it for a long time, longer than a pouch needed looking at. Something was happening in his face, far back, very small. She could not read it. It was the first time she had not been able to read something in him because there was too much of it, rather than too little.

Then he took it.

He turned it over. He opened the flap and looked at the loops inside, and ran his thumb along them, one after another.

"Thank you, Aoi."

He put the cord through his sash, on the left, behind the swords, and tied it. Then he took the five stars out of his sleeve, one at a time, and put each one in its own place.

She went and got her blade from the rack. She did not look at him while she did it.

***

The market came to Iga on the days that ended in five, when the traders came up from the valley with their packs and set out their things in the open square below the shrine. Salt. Needles and thread. Knives. Dried fish in bundles. Pots. Straw sandals hung on strings like rows of small grey birds.

Aoi went for salt, and for thread, because she had used all hers.

She had her salt and was turning away from the salt man when she saw him.

Along the edge of the square, where the eating stalls were, there was one with a roof of boards and a long counter, and a smell of vinegar and charcoal coming out of it, and a man behind the counter who had been selling rice and soup there since before she was born. And beside him, behind the counter, in the man's own place, with his sleeves tied back, was Ren.

He was talking to the owner. Or the owner was talking to him, and Ren was listening, and nodding once, and saying something short, and the owner was laughing.

She walked over. She came in under the edge of the roof and stood at the counter.

He saw her. He stopped.

"What's going on?"

Ren said nothing.

The owner was a round man with a cloth tied over his head and grains of rice stuck in the creases of his hands. He grinned at her, and jerked his chin at Ren.

"He says he can press rice with fish on it," said the owner. "Better than me."

Aoi looked at Ren.

"You press rice?"

Ren was quiet for a moment.

"My brother does." He said it with a small smile.

"I watched him."

She looked at his hands. They were resting on the counter. There was rice on them. On the board in front of him lay three of them, three small shapes of rice pressed by hand, a slice of salted fish laid across each one, all three exactly the same size.

My brother.

He had told her his crew was gone. He had told her they had betrayed him and left him in the forest to bleed. He had said it looking straight at her. She had believed him, because she had never once caught him saying a thing he did not mean.

And now, here, with rice on his hands, he had said *my brother*, and smiled.

She did not ask.

She did not know why she did not ask. It was the kind of thing she had been trained all her life to ask about. The small crack. The place where two true things did not fit together. But she stood at the counter with the salt in her basket and looked at his face, and the smile was still there, a little, at the corner of his mouth, the way it had been in the cave. He was not thinking about what he had said. He was thinking about whoever had pressed rice like that.

The owner pushed one of the three across the counter to her.

"Try it," he said. "Then tell me he's lying."

She picked it up. She ate it.

It was good. It was very good. It was better than the owner's, and the owner knew it, and was laughing about it.

Ren was watching her eat. He was waiting to see.

She swallowed.

"It's good," she said.

"Hm," he said, as if that was what he had expected, and as if it pleased him anyway.

She took her basket and went to find thread. She did not look back until she was on the far side of the square, and when she did, he had his sleeves tied back and his hands in the rice again, and the owner was watching his hands, and there were two old men at the counter now, waiting.

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The light went gold at the end of the day.

It happened every evening at this time of year, when the rain had passed. The sun came down under the edge of the clouds and lay across the valley from the west, low and warm, and everything it touched turned to the color of honey. The pools along the stream lit up. The thatch lit up. The dust above the training ground hung in the air and shone.

They were leaving the ground together. They did that now. When training ended she put her blade on the rack and he put his swords on the rack, and they walked out the same way, over the bridge, toward the village, without saying that they would.

He walked on her left. He always did. The new pouch was at his sash, behind the swords. She had seen him put his hand on it twice that afternoon, without looking, as if to check it was there.

"Aoi! Wait!"

A girl's voice, high, from far off.

They both turned.

Two children were running toward them along the stream path, kicking up the dust, which caught the light and hung glowing behind them. A girl in front, small, seven or eight, her hair coming loose from its tie. A boy behind her, taller, all knees and elbows, trying not to look as if he was running.

Hina. Takeda's daughter. And Daigo.

They came up breathing hard and stopped in front of the two of them. Hina looked straight up at Ren. She had to tip her whole head back to do it.

"Who is this?" said Hina.

Daigo came up beside her. He looked at Ren, and then at his sister, and then back at Ren, and a slow grin spread across his face that Aoi knew very well and did not like at all.

"Your sweetheart?"

Ren looked at them.

He did not say anything. He looked at the small girl with her head tipped back. He looked at the boy with the grin. Then he turned his head and looked at Aoi.

She felt it come up into her face. All at once. Hot, from her neck to her ears. She could not stop it and she could not hide it, and the low sun was full on her, lighting everything, so that there was nowhere for any of it to go.

He paused. For a moment, he only looked.

Then he smiled.

He turned back to the children.

"I'm Ren."

Hina considered this. Then she lifted her hand and waved at him, a small quick wave, as if they were on opposite sides of a river.

Ren lifted his hand and waved back.

Daigo was still grinning. Aoi looked at him in a way that had worked since he was three, and it did not work, and he grinned wider and grabbed Hina by the sleeve and the two of them ran off again down the stream path toward the village, laughing, the dust going up gold behind them.

Aoi did not look at Ren.

She looked at the stream. At the pools lying flat and still along the bank, full of sky.

Beside her, he did not say anything. He was still there. He was waiting for her, as if there were nothing else in the world he had to do.

When she began to walk again, he walked with her.

On her left. The way he always did.

Chapter 28

The Unseen

The grass on the hill above the stream had grown long enough to lie in.

Ren lay on his back in it with his hands behind his head. Aoi lay beside him, not close, not far, an arm's length of grass between them. The sun was going down behind the western ridge and the sky over them was still light, high and clear and slowly turning, and the clouds were coming across it from the south, one after another, big and slow, lit gold on their undersides.

The cicadas had started a few days ago. The first of the summer. They were in every tree along the stream, and in the trees on the hill behind, and the sound of them came from everywhere at once, a long rising shimmer that swelled and fell and swelled again and never quite stopped.

Neither of them said anything.

A cloud came over, wide in front, with a long thin piece trailing off behind.

"That's a bird," said Aoi.

The cicadas.

Ren looked at it. The wide part. The trailing part. The way the edges went sharp at the front, as if they had been creased.

"More like a paper bird."

The cicadas.

Aoi turned her head in the grass and looked at him.

"Paper bird?"

The cicadas.

He did not answer. He lay a moment longer. Then he sat up.

He opened the flap of the pouch at his sash and took out a square of paper, folded flat, soft at the corners from being carried. He unfolded it on his knee and smoothed it with the side of his hand. Then his hands began.

He went slowly. He had never been fast at it. Corner to corner. Open. Corner to corner the other way. Fold the sides in to the middle and run his thumbnail down each crease. Open it. Lift the bottom point, and the paper rose and flattened into a long diamond, and he turned it over and did the same on the other side. He could feel her watching his hands. He did not look up. There was a place where it always went wrong for him, and he came to it, and it did not go wrong. He folded the two thin points up inside. He bent one down, and pinched it, for the head.

He pulled the wings out, gently, one and then the other, and the body puffed a little in the middle.

He held it up between them against the sky.

A bird. White, against the gold cloud. Its wings a little uneven. Its head a little too large.

Aoi looked at it for a long moment.

"That's not bad."

Ren smiled.

The cicadas.

She was still looking at it. Not at him. At the bird.

"Your brother?" she said.

"No."

He turned it a little in his fingers, so the light went through the paper.

"The best artist I know."

He was smiling when he said it. He could feel it on his face, and he left it there.

The cicadas swelled, and fell, and swelled.

He held the bird out to her. She looked at it, and then at him, and took it. She held it in both hands the way you hold something that could be crushed. Then she lay back down in the grass with the bird resting on her chest and her hands folded over it, and looked up at the sky.

Ren lay back down too.

The cloud had gone on. It was only a cloud now, loosening at the edges, going pink. Another one was coming behind it.

The cicadas.

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The morning after, the sky was grey.

Not rain. Only a low, even grey, pressed down on the tops of the hills, and under it the air was thick and warm and wet, so that it lay on the skin like cloth. Aoi's hair stuck to her neck before they were out of sight of the gate.

Seven of them. Riku in front, because he had asked to lead and her father had let him. Then two of the older men, Kōsuke and Hanbei. Then Aoi. Then Ren. Then two more at the back, Jūzō and the boy Tatsu, who had only been on the hunt twice before.

Riku had not spoken to Ren since they left. He had not looked at him. When Ren came out of the gate behind her, Riku had turned his head and spat, carefully, to one side, and then walked on.

Aoi had the bird in her sleeve. She had folded it flat in the night, very carefully, along the creases he had made, so it would not be crushed when she moved. Twice already she had touched the place through the cloth without meaning to.

They went deep.

Past the hunting grounds. Past the cedar where she had found him bleeding, which none of them looked at. Up into the old forest on the far side of the ridge, where the trees were so tall and so close that under them it was almost dusk, even now, even in summer. The cicadas were screaming. There was no other word for it. The sound came down from the canopy so loud it pressed against the ears, a solid wall of it on every side, and the forest under it was very still.

They walked in it for a long time.

Ren had stopped.

She noticed that before she noticed anything else. He was behind her, and then he was not keeping pace, and she half turned, and he was standing on the path with his head a little raised and his hand on his hilt, and he was not looking at anything. He was listening.

Then she heard it.

She heard nothing.

In this one stretch of trees, the cicadas had stopped. Behind them they were still going, and ahead of them, far off. But here, around the seven of them, in a ring perhaps fifty paces across, there was silence. As if the forest had drawn a breath and was holding it.

A scream from the back of the line.

She turned. Everyone turned. Tatsu was on his knees on the path with his arm held out in front of him, staring at it, and there was nothing at the end of it. His hand was on the ground. It had landed before any of them had finished turning around.

The Iga formed.

It was instant. It was what they were for. Nobody gave an order. Riku came back down the path and Kōsuke and Hanbei went out to either side and Jūzō stepped over Tatsu and put his back to him, and in the space of a breath there was a ring of blades facing outward with the wounded boy in the middle of it. Clean. Correct. Every gap covered. Every angle watched.

It meant nothing.

They came out of the trees and they did not come at the ring. They came at the places between. Not at Kōsuke, but at the space between Kōsuke and Hanbei, and when Kōsuke turned to cover it, they were not there. They were in the space he had left. A blade came out of nowhere and opened Hanbei's sleeve. A figure in grey crossed the path between Riku and Aoi, so close she could have touched him, and she cut, and he was gone, and she did not see where.

There was no rhythm. There was no pattern she could hold. It was like fighting the water in the stream.

Then she saw him.

Far off, in the trees. A tall man, in grey, standing very still between two trunks with a sword held low. Thirty paces. More. He was not coming. He was only standing there, watching.

Riku saw him too. Riku's hand came back and threw. The star went flat and straight and hard, the way Riku always threw, faster than it needed to be.

It hit bark.

The tall man was not between the two trunks. He was not thirty paces off. He was ten. He was five. He had not run. Aoi had not seen him move. The distance between them had simply been a lie, and now it had stopped lying, and he was on the path, walking, not fast, toward the middle of the ring. Toward Tatsu, on his knees, holding his arm.

His sword came up.

Ren was already there.

She did not see him go. He had been behind her, and then he was standing over Tatsu with both swords out, between the boy and the tall man, as if he had always been standing there.

The tall man cut.

Ren met it. Clean. The right sword took the blade and turned it, the sound of it a single clear note, and in the same movement the left sword came through, low and fast and certain, into the place where the tall man's body should have been.

It cut air. Ren let the miss turn him, and his heel drove back into the place where the tall man would have to be, and found air there too.

The tall man was not there. He was a pace to the side. He had been a pace to the side the whole time, or he had not, and there was no way to tell which.

He had not been slow. He had cut where the man was, exactly where the man was, and the man had not been there.

Ren did not stop. He did not step back. He stood over the boy and the tall man came in again, from an angle that should have taken three steps and took none, and Ren met it, and turned it, and answered, and the answer went through nothing. Again. Again. Nothing got past him. Not one cut reached the boy on the ground behind him. But nothing he did touched the tall man. Not once.

Then the tall man stopped.

He stood a sword's length from Ren, with his sword low, and he looked at him.

Aoi saw it. He had not looked at any of them like that. He looked at Ren for a long moment. His face told her nothing. Only his eyes, very still, resting on Ren as if Ren were a thing he had not seen before and wished to remember.

Then his hand moved. Two fingers, a small quick sign, down and away.

And they were gone.

Not running. Not falling back through the trees. She did not see a single one of them go. One breath the grey shapes were there, among the trunks, in the spaces between the seven of them. The next breath the forest was empty, and the leaves were still, and there was nothing on the path but the Iga and their own blood.

For a while, nobody moved.

Then, somewhere above them, one cicada began. Then another. Then the whole forest, all at once, the wall of sound coming back down over them as if it had never stopped.

***

Aoi knelt by Tatsu.

He was grey in the face and shaking and very quiet. She took the cord from her waist and bound it around his forearm above the wrist, tight, tighter, and knotted it, and took a stick from the path and twisted the cord with it until the bleeding slowed. Her hands were steady. She watched them be steady.

Riku stood over her. He was breathing hard. His star was still in the bark of the tree behind him. He had not gone to get it.

"Who were they?"

"Fūma," said Aoi.

Riku did not say anything else.

Jūzō had picked up the hand and wrapped it in a cloth, and was holding it, and did not seem to know what to do with it now that he had it.

Aoi tied off the cord. She looked up.

Ren was standing a little apart, on the path, where he had stood over the boy. He had lowered his swords. He was looking at the left one. He turned it in the grey light, slowly, first one side and then the other.

It was clean. There was no blood on it.

"He was never where he was," Ren said.

He said it quietly. He did not say it to her, or to anyone.

Aoi watched him.

His hands were steady. The sword did not shake in them at all. But his eyes were moving. Over the blade. To the trees where the tall man had stood. Back to the blade. Back to the trees. Looking for something. Going over it and over it, the way she had seen him go over the same sequence in the dark, looking for the place where it broke.

She had watched him for weeks. She had watched him with the stars and with her father's spear and alone in the mist. She had never once seen him not understand something.

She could see it now.

He sheathed the swords, one and then the other, and came and knelt on the other side of Tatsu and got the boy's good arm over his shoulders, and did not say anything else.

***

They carried Tatsu home between them, Ren and Jūzō, taking turns with Kōsuke. It was slow. The grey held. The cicadas screamed and screamed.

They were most of the way back, coming down the last slope above the southern gate, when Aoi put her hand to her sleeve.

It was empty.

She stopped on the path. She felt in the sleeve again, and then in the other. Nothing.

She turned around.

Behind them the path went back up the slope, trodden to mud by seven people and the wet air, and a little way up it, in a footprint, there was something white.

She walked back.

The bird lay on its side in the mud. Someone had stepped on it. One wing was pressed flat into the ground, and the head was bent, and the white paper had gone grey where the wet had come into it.

She looked at it for a moment.

Then she knelt and picked it up anyway, and wiped the mud off it as well as she could with her thumb, and put it back in her sleeve, and went back down the slope after the others.

Chapter 29

The Door

A few days later, in the afternoon, Aoi took him inside.

It was hot. Early summer, and the rain had gone off somewhere else for a while, and the sun stood high over the valley and pressed on everything. The cicadas were loud in the trees along the stream. The dust on the road was warm through the soles of his sandals. Everyone in Iga was moving a little slower than usual, and nobody minded.

Aoi was talking.

She did not usually talk this much. But she had been walking half a step ahead of him since the bridge, turning her head back to him every few words, pointing, and he had found that he did not mind that either.

"That's the outer gate. It's shut at dark. After that you go through the small door in the side, and the man on it has to know your face." She pointed at it as they went through. The man on it looked at Ren and nodded.

"Ren."

Ren nodded back.

Inside the gate there was a courtyard of raked gravel, wide and bright in the sun, with a well at one side and a pine in the middle whose branches had been trained out flat, low over the stones, like a hand held over a fire. Buildings stood around three sides. Long, low, dark-timbered, with deep eaves and verandas of worn boards.

"The archive." A long building on the left with its shutters closed. "Reports go in there. All of them, from all the years. My father says you could read in there for your whole life and not reach the end." She pointed right. "That's where the watch sleeps. And that one is for guests, when there are any. There usually aren't."

Two men were sitting on the veranda of the watch house in the shade, with their legs out and their backs against the wall. One of them lifted a hand.

"Ren. Hot today."

"Yes."

The man laughed as if Ren had said something clever.

A small shape came across the courtyard at a run, out of one door and toward another, sandals slapping on the gravel. Hina. She saw him, and did not stop running, and waved at him as she went, her whole arm, and was through the far door and gone.

Ren nodded after her.

Aoi was still talking. The kitchens were at the back. The bathhouse was past the kitchens. The small shrine in the corner was older than any of the buildings, older than anyone knew. He listened to her. He heard every word. He looked where she pointed.

And his eyes were doing something else.

Two men on the outer gate. Not one; there was another, inside, in the shade of the wall, who had not moved when they came through. Three in the courtyard: the two on the veranda, and one more at the far corner by the archive, standing, who had watched them since the gate and was pretending not to. The men on the veranda had their swords beside them, not on them. The one at the corner had his on.

The sun was high. The watch would change when it went behind the western ridge, or before. There was a bell on a post by the watch house, small, green with age. The gravel was raked in lines, and the lines were fresh this morning, and nobody had walked across the middle since. The boards of the archive veranda were old and cupped and would speak under a foot. The boards of the guest house were newer and would not. Lamps hung under the eaves on iron hooks, one at each corner of each building, and one over each door.

He did not decide to do any of it. He did not tell his eyes to go there. They went, and came back, and went, and every time they came back they brought something with them and set it down in its place.

It was the way Shigure did it. Walking into a yard. Into a teahouse. Into a room where there was a job. Shigure's eyes had gone around a room once, quietly, and after that Shigure knew the room.

Ren noticed that he was doing it.

He looked at Aoi instead. At her hand, pointing. At the side of her face as she turned to see if he was listening.

"—and that's where they dry the herbs, when Shin sends too many."

His eyes went to the drying racks under the eaves. Bamboo. Waist high. A man could crouch behind them.

He brought them back to her.

They went again.

He stopped trying. He let them go where they went, and he kept his face turned to her, and nodded, and walked.

***

The last building was the largest, at the back of the courtyard, with a veranda that went all the way around it and a roof that came down low over the eaves like a hat pulled against the rain.

"Master Takeda's," said Aoi.

She took off her sandals at the step, and he took off his. The boards were cool under his feet after the gravel. The corridor inside was dim and smelled of cedar and of the dust that sun makes on old wood. Aoi slid a door open at the end of it.

"He won't mind. He's gone to the lower fields until evening."

The study.

It was quiet. After the courtyard, after the cicadas, it was very quiet. A low desk in the middle of the room, with brushes laid on a rest in a row, all exactly parallel, and an inkstone, and a stack of paper squared at the corners. Shelves along one wall, full of bound books and rolled documents with paper tags hanging from them. The shutter on the garden side was half open, and the light came in through it and lay on the floor in a long bright shape, and dust hung in it without moving. The room smelled of ink, and old paper, and faintly of the lamp oil from the night before.

Aoi went in ahead of him. She was saying something about the books. About how Takeda read at night, sometimes all night, and her father said he had never once seen the lamp in here go out before the lamp in the watch house.

Ren came in behind her.

At the back of the room, set into the wall where the shelves ended, there was a door.

It was not like the other doors in the house. It did not slide. It was heavy, hung on iron hinges, made of some dark wood gone almost black with age and oil, and banded across with iron, top and middle and bottom. There was an iron plate where a lock would be. There was no handle.

Ren stopped.

Aoi went on a few steps, still talking, toward the shelves. Then her voice stopped, and she turned around.

"Ren?"

He did not answer.

A cough.

Short. Dry. Like a stick breaking under a foot.

The fire in the cave, going low. The stack of wood against the wall, split and dried and laid in order, the long pieces at the bottom, the kindling at the top, the way it had been every day of his life on the mountain. The smell of it. The dark beyond the ring of stones. A man sitting in front of the fire with his hands on his knees.

Don't hesitate.

He stood in Takeda's study with the light lying on the floor and the dust hanging in it and did not move.

Months.

He had been in Iga for months. Rice cakes from the woman at the corner, two instead of one. Pebbles against his sleeve and children running. The smith smiling with almost no teeth. Sunrise on the training ground, before anyone. Aoi, late. The market. The grass on the hill. The clouds.

He had not thought of the mountain in days.

He did not know how many. He tried to find the last time, and he could not find it. Somewhere before the clouds. The cave in the rain, maybe. He had walked past the fire in every hearth in Iga and not once thought of the one on the mountain, going low, with a man coughing in front of it.

That was what took the breath out of him. Not the door. The door was only a door. It was the days.

"Only Master Takeda goes in there," said Aoi.

She had come back to stand beside him. She was looking at the door, and then at him.

Ren nodded.

He did not say anything.

***

They went out the way they had come. Through the corridor. Down the step. Sandals. Across the gravel, where the lines were no longer fresh because they had walked across them. Past the watch house, where the man on the veranda lifted his hand again. Out through the gate.

Aoi kept talking.

She talked about Tatsu, who was sitting up now and eating, and had asked Shin whether a man could learn to throw with the other hand. About the market in five days. About Daigo, who had told half the village something about the two of them that she would not repeat. She looked at him sideways when she said that, to see what he would do.

He answered less.

"Yes." "No." "Hm." A nod. Once, nothing at all, and she looked at him, and he said, "Yes," late, and she did not look away for a while after that.

At the bridge they stopped, the way they always did, where her way went one side of the stream and his went the other.

She looked at him.

He looked back at her. He did not know what his face was doing.

"Tomorrow," she said.

"Tomorrow."

She went. He watched her go. Then he crossed the bridge.

***

That night he did not train.

He sat in his room with the shutter closed and one lamp lit and a sheet of paper on the floor in front of him, and an inkstone, and a brush.

He ground the ink. He dipped the brush.

The outer gate first. Two lines, and a mark for the small door in the side. A dot for the man on it. A second dot for the man inside, in the shade of the wall, who had not moved.

The courtyard. The well. The pine. The watch house on the right, two dots on its veranda. The bell on its post. The archive on the left, and the corner where the third man had stood watching them since the gate. The guest house. The kitchens behind, and the bathhouse behind them. The drying racks under the eaves, waist high.

His hand did not hesitate. Every line went down exactly where it belonged. The brush knew the distances before he thought them. Gate to well, so many paces. Well to archive, so many. The boards that would speak and the boards that would not. The lamps, one at each corner, one over each door.

The large building at the back. The veranda around it. The corridor. The study.

He drew the desk. The shelves. The shutter on the garden side.

He drew the back wall.

The brush stopped.

It stopped above the paper, with the ink gathering at its tip, where the door would go.

The lamp burned. Outside the shutter, the frogs were going in the fields, and far off, one cicada that had not stopped when the others did. A drop of ink came down off the end of the brush and fell onto the paper at the back wall of the study, and spread there, round and black.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he set the brush down on the inkstone. He did not finish. He waited for the ink to dry, and when it was dry he folded the paper, once and then again, along straight lines, until it was small.

He opened the flap of the pouch Aoi had given him. The five stars sat in their loops.

He put the drawing in behind them, and closed the flap, and tied it down.

Chapter 30

Quiet

Kageyori found her in the morning, by the archive.

She had not heard him come. Nobody ever did. He was a small, neat man with ink on the side of his middle finger that never quite washed off, and he stood at the corner of the building in the shade as if he had been standing there all along, waiting for the sun to move.

"Aoi."

"Kageyori."

He did not come closer. He looked past her at the courtyard, at the raked gravel, at the pine.

"One of my people was on the Kōga road this spring," he said. "Before the rains. Three nights out from the hunting grounds." He paused. "He saw two men walking together. One of them carried two long swords."

Aoi did not move.

"The other was Suzuya."

She knew the name. Everyone in Iga who did the work knew the name. A pleasant face. A forgettable face. Kōga's.

Kageyori let it sit in the air between them. He did not look at her while it sat there. He looked at the pine.

"You brought him in," he said.

It was not a question, and he did not wait for an answer. He nodded to her, very slightly, and turned, and went back along the side of the archive, and at the corner he was gone the way he had come.

Aoi stood in the shade.

The cicadas had started in the trees beyond the wall. A man crossed the courtyard with a bucket. The two men on the watch house veranda said something to each other and laughed.

She did not let herself wonder whether Master Takeda knew.

She stood there until the sun came around the corner of the archive and lay across her feet. Then she went to the training ground, the way she did every morning.

He was there before her.

***

She saw them from the bridge, late in the day.

The bench outside Shin's house, in the last of the sun. A shogi board on the bench between them. Shin on one side, very straight, his long careful hands in his lap. Ren on the other, leaning forward, his elbows on his knees, looking down at the pieces.

She walked toward them. She did not decide to.

As she came close Shin moved a piece. A small sound. Tak. Then he sat back and looked at Ren, and something happened to his face that she had not often seen happen to Shin's face. He smiled. Not much. Only at the corners.

He stood, and bowed to Ren. A real bow, from the waist.

"Looks like you can't beat the strongest in Iga."

Then he saw her. He bowed to her too, smaller.

"Aoi."

"Shin."

He took his bowl from the step, and went inside, and slid the door shut behind him.

Ren was still looking at the board.

She came and stood by the bench. The pieces lay where the game had ended. She did not know shogi well enough to see how. Only that his king was hemmed in at the back, and there was nowhere left for it to go.

He looked at the board a moment longer. Then he looked up at her.

The sun was low behind her, across the valley, and she could feel it on the back of her neck and the side of her face. It was the same light as the evening with the children. He was looking at her in it the same way.

For a moment neither of them said anything.

"Are you hungry?" he said. "Rice and fish. At the stall."

She looked at him.

"Yes," she said.

***

They walked to the square.

It was the same walk as every evening. The same street. The same bridge. The smith on his bench, who lifted a hand. The woman with the rice cakes, taking her tray in. Children somewhere, shrieking at a game.

It was the same, and it was not.

Ren walked on her left, the way he always did. He was quiet. He was always quiet. But this was not the quiet she knew. The quiet she knew was full. He was listening to everything in it, and she could feel him listening. This was a different kind. As if he had gone a little way off inside himself and was standing there, looking at something she could not see.

She was quiet too. She noticed it halfway across the bridge. She had not said anything since the bench. She had meant to. There were a hundred ordinary things. Tatsu. Daigo. The weather. She had opened her mouth to say one of them and closed it again, and walked on.

Suzuya.

She did not say it. She had a dozen ways to say it. She had been trained in all of them. The question that sounded like nothing. The question that sounded like a joke. The silence you leave open until the other person falls into it.

She did not use any of them.

She walked beside him to the square and said nothing, and so did he.

***

The stall was nearly empty. One old man at the end of the counter with a bowl of soup, slurping. The owner behind it, wiping down the board with a wet cloth, his head wrapped against the heat.

He saw Ren and grinned.

"Back again."

Ren looked at him. He looked at the rice in its tub, and the fish laid out on the cold stone at the back.

"Can I make some?"

The owner laughed and lifted the flap in the counter and stepped aside.

Ren went behind. He tied back his sleeves. He wet his hands in the bowl, and took rice, and pressed it, and laid a slice of fish across it, and set it on the board. Another. Another.

Aoi sat at the counter and watched his hands.

They were good. They were as good as last time. Every one the same size as the one before. But she was watching his face, too, and his face was not with his hands. His hands did it and he let them. His eyes were on the rice, and then somewhere beyond the rice, on nothing.

The owner said something about the fish, where it had come from, how many days on the road. Ren smiled at him.

It was a smile. It went up at the corners. But it did not get as far as his eyes, and it went away again too quickly, like a hand pulled back from something hot.

She had never seen him do that. She had seen him not smile at all. She had seen him smile without knowing he was doing it. She had never seen him put one on.

He set four on a board and slid it across the counter to her.

"Here."

She looked up at him and smiled.

She felt herself do it. She felt it go on her face and stay there and not mean anything. She had done it a thousand times, to strangers, on roads, at gates. She had never done it to him.

She picked one up. She ate it.

It was good. It was very good.

"It's good," she said.

"Good."

He came out from behind the counter and sat beside her, and they ate. The old man at the end finished his soup and paid and went. The owner cleaned his knife. The light went from gold to grey in the square outside, and someone began lighting the lamps in the doorways along the street, one and then the next.

Once, reaching for the last one at the same time, their hands met over the board. They both stopped. He looked at her. She looked at him.

He smiled. That one was real. She saw it.

Then it was gone, and he took his hand back, and let her have it.

She ate it slowly.

***

They walked back in the dark.

The lamps were lit in the doorways along the street, each one a small yellow room of light with the night around it, and they walked from one into the next and out again. The frogs were loud in the fields. Somewhere a door slid open and a woman called a name, and a child answered, and the door slid shut.

Neither of them said anything.

At the bridge they stopped, where her way went one side and his the other.

She looked at him. In the light of the lamp at the end of the bridge his face was the same face it always was. Still. Watching. Waiting.

She could have said it now. *Suzuya.* One word. She could see exactly how it would go. She could see his face not change, because it never did, and his eyes come to hers, and stay there, and whatever he said next would be true, because everything he said was true.

That was why she did not say it.

"Tomorrow," she said.

He looked at her a moment longer than he needed to.

"Tomorrow."

She went. She did not look back.

On the other side of the bridge she stopped, in the dark between two lamps, where he could not see her, and stood there, and listened to his footsteps go away along the stream.

They were slower than usual.

So were hers, when she went on.

Chapter 31

Waiting

Summer had come to Kōga the way it always came, wet and close, and at night the fog did not lift off the valleys so much as thicken, until the house on the ridge stood in it like a boat on a still sea.

Inside, the lamps were lit. Two of them, one at each end of the table, and between them the map.

Kikyo stood over it.

The papers had come in over the summer the way they always did. One sheet at a time, by different hands. A charcoal girl. A priest going to Ise. A boy who sold eels. She had read them all when they came and she was reading them again now, laid out along the edge of the map in the order they had happened.

Taken in, wounded. Kept at the doctor's.

Walks in the village most evenings. The same way each time.

Made his own star at the smith's. Five points.

Throws better than the ones who taught him to throw.

Went into the forest with the spearman's daughter. Came back after the rain.

Stood over a boy who had lost his hand. Fūma. The tall one. Nothing touched the boy. Nothing touched the tall one.

Was taken inside the headman's house.

Walks with the spearman's daughter. Every evening. On her left.

She read the last one twice.

Across the table, Takeru sat in his chair with his hands on his knees. He waited for her to tell him what they said, and tonight she had not yet told him, and he had waited longer than usual.

Against the wall, to the right of the door, Raiden leaned with his arms folded.

He had been there when she came in. He would be there when she left. He had never once sat at the table. He did not look at the papers, or the map, or at Takeru. He was simply there, in the lamplight at the edge of the room, the way a sword is there on its stand.

The frogs went on outside, muffled by the fog.

Takeru reached across the table and turned one of the papers toward him with a finger. *Fūma. The tall one.*

"Which one is the tall one?"

"Shinmei," said Kikyo. "One of their elites. The distance around him lies. You cut where he is, and he is a pace away."

"You've seen him?"

"No." She did not look up from the map. "Not many people know the faces of the Fūma. Not many get away from them alive to tell it. They wear grey. Nothing else about them is the same." She said the rest the way she would have read it off a sheet. "Raiun, the other elite. Middle height. Nothing to see. He is already where you are going. Kagetora. Short. Lean. His eyes over a strip of cloth. His cuts come late." She paused. "And his elder brother."

Takeru waited.

"Fūma Kotarō. Their leader. Taller than other men by two heads, and broad as a door, with a face you forget while you are looking at it. Nobody has seen him fight the same way twice." She moved the paper back into its place along the edge of the map. "A monster."

Against the wall, Raiden did not move. He had seen two of those faces, in the spring, on a forest path, and walked away. He did not say so.

"It's been months," said Takeru.

Kikyo did not look up from the map.

The needle was still where she had thrown it in the spring. Standing up out of the capital, among the tiny squares, very small, very straight. Its shadow lay out across the paper toward the mountains in the lamplight. She had not moved it. It was not time.

"Are you doubting him?"

Takeru did not answer at once. He looked at the papers along the edge of the map. She could see him weighing it. She had watched him weigh things for many years. He weighed slowly, and he weighed well, and when he was done he said the one thing that was left.

"What if he hesitates?"

She looked up at him then.

She let him see her face. It was calm. It was not the calm she wore for the men who came to this room to be told what to do, which was the calm of someone telling them it would be all right. It was something else. The calm of someone who has already seen how it ends.

"He won't."

Takeru was silent.

She held his eyes.

"His loyalty is greater than his love."

The room held that.

The lamps burned. A moth had gotten in somewhere and was going around the flame at the far end of the table, around and around, and every so often it touched the heat and fell away and came back.

Takeru looked at her a long time. She let him. She had nothing to hide from him, and he knew that, and she knew that he knew it. That was why he was still asking.

"What if he betrays us?"

Kikyo turned her head.

She did not gesture. She did not lift a hand, or say a name, or explain. She only looked. Across the lamplight, past the end of the table, to the wall to the right of the door.

Raiden did not move.

He did not look back at her. He did not look at Takeru. His arms stayed folded, his weight stayed on the wall, and still, somehow, forward. His eyes were on nothing in particular, on the dark by the door, the way they always were.

He did not need to move.

"We already thought of that," said Kikyo.

Takeru followed her eyes to the wall. He looked at Raiden for a moment. Then he looked back down at the map, at the needle in the capital, and the long thin shadow of it lying across the mountains toward Iga.

He did not ask anything else.

Kikyo gathered the papers from the edge of the map. She squared them against the table, once, and set them down in a stack, the newest on top.

Walks with the spearman's daughter. Every evening. On her left.

She looked at it a moment longer. Something at the corner of her mouth moved, and was still again.

Then she turned the stack over, so the words were face down on the wood, and put out the lamp nearest her with two fingers.

The moth went on circling the other one.

Chapter 32

Torn

He did not sleep.

He lay on his back in the dark and listened to the frogs, and then to the frogs stopping, and then to the first birds. When the shutter went grey he was still lying there. When it went white he got up.

He washed his face in the bucket. He tied his sash. He put the swords through it, one and then the other, and checked them.

Once.

He checked them again.

He stood with his hand on the hilt and looked at it. Then he took the hand away and went out.

***

She was already there.

He saw her from the bridge. Standing at the edge of the training ground by the rack, in the grey light, with her short blade in her hand, looking at the empty place near the stream where he always stood. The mist was lifting off the water behind her. She did not move. She was looking at the place where he was not.

He came down off the bridge and across the ground.

She turned when she heard him. Her eyes went to his face and stayed there a moment. He did not know what she saw. He had not looked at his face.

"You're late," she said.

"Yes."

She waited for something else. There was nothing else. He went to the rack and took down two wooden swords.

The others were coming now, in twos and threes, the way they did, the older ones walking, the younger ones running the last of it so as not to be the last. Kōsuke. Hanbei. Jūzō, who had carried Tatsu home. They took their places. The training began.

***

Kōsuke first.

He was older, slower, heavier on his feet. He came in the way he always came in, straight, and Ren had seen it forty times and knew it the way he knew the path to the stream.

He stepped left.

It was the wrong step. He felt it as his foot went down. The ground was where it always was and his foot was not where it should be on it, and Kōsuke's wooden blade came in under his arm and tapped his ribs.

Kōsuke stepped back and looked at him, surprised.

"Hm," Ren said. They went again.

Hanbei. Quick, low, always going for the legs. Ren saw it coming. He saw it the whole way. And he moved a fraction late, not much, a hair, and the blade came across his shin, and Hanbei laughed out loud, and then stopped laughing and looked at him.

Jūzō. Patient. Waiting. Ren went in to meet him and in the middle of going in, for no reason, his weight came back onto his heel, and Jūzō's blade was at his throat.

Jūzō did not laugh. He lowered the blade and looked at Ren for a long moment, and then went back to his place without saying anything.

Ren stood in the middle of the ground with the two wooden swords in his hands.

He looked at his feet. They were his feet. They were standing where he had put them. He did not know why he had put them there.

At the edge of the ground, Aoi was watching him.

She had stopped correcting her group. They had gone on without her, through the sequence, and she had not noticed.

She put down her blade on the rack. She took another from it, a longer one, the same length as his.

She walked across the ground to him.

"Spar with me."

***

He faced her.

She came in. Not fast. Not testing. She came in the way she had learned him over all those mornings, knowing where he would be, and he was there, and it was not enough. Her blade went past his and touched his wrist.

He lowered his swords.

She stepped back. She looked at him.

"Again."

It went into him like a stone set down.

Not her voice. Under her voice. Another voice, older, the same word, on the path from the stream with the bucket knocking his shins. In the clearing with the stance, his legs shaking. By the fire, the whetstone going. *Again.*

They went again. She came in. He answered. He answered what she had done, not what she was doing, and she was already past it, and her blade touched his shoulder.

"Again."

The cave. The wood stacked against the wall. The fire.

Again. Her blade at his side.

"Again."

The cough. Short and dry, like a stick breaking.

Again. Her blade at his neck.

"Again."

The man in front of the fire, not looking at the fire. Looking at him. *Don't hesitate.*

"Again."

It cut.

Something in him went out, all at once, the way a wick goes out, and what was left was only the word, and the word was an order, and he knew how to follow it.

He went in.

He did not go in the way he went in with her. He went in the way he had gone in at the ford, at the castle, at the lord's hall. Everything that had been wrong since the morning was gone. His feet were where they should be. His weight was under him. The first sword took her blade and the second was already coming, and she turned it, and he was already past where she had turned it to, and the first was coming back. He did not stop. He did not let her find where he would be. He was not where he would be. He was only where she was not.

She gave ground. She gave more. He felt her feet go wrong on the packed earth, and he did not wait for them to go right again. His foot took the one she was trying to plant.

She went down.

Her back struck the ground. Her blade went out of her hand and skidded away across the dirt. And his sword was at her throat.

Wood. Only wood. Pressed into the soft place under her jaw, where it would have gone in.

He stood over her.

The ground was silent. He could feel all of them watching. He did not look at them. He looked down along the length of the wooden blade at her face.

She was looking up at him. She was not afraid. She was looking for him, the way she had looked for him that first morning, across the ground, from a long way off, and not finding him.

He held it there.

One breath.

Then something came back into him. From a long way down. The mist on the stream. The grey light. Her hair on the dirt. The wood in his hand, and where it was, and whose throat it was against.

He took the sword away.

He stepped back. His hands were steady. He looked at them.

Aoi pushed herself up onto her elbows. She stayed there. She did not get up.

"Ren?"

He looked at her.

He wanted to say something else. He did not know what it was. It was there, and he could not reach it.

"I'm sorry."

He turned around. He laid the two wooden swords on the rack, side by side, the way they went. He walked off the ground and across the bridge, and he did not look back, and nobody called after him.

***

That night the shutter was open for the heat.

He sat in his room with no lamp. The moon was up, not full, and it came in through the open shutter and lay across the floor and across the low table in front of him, where nothing was.

He sat with his hands on his knees.

He did not train. He did not draw. He did not open the pouch. He sat and looked at the moonlight on the table, and the frogs went on outside, and a long way off, in the watch house, someone laughed at something and was quiet.

Something moved in the shutter.

A shape, black against the moon. A rustle, and the soft knock of claws on the wooden sill. Then it hopped down onto the table, into the light, and folded its wings, and was still.

A raven.

He knew it. He knew the way it held its head, a little to one side. He knew the one feather on its left wing that had never lain flat. The last time he had seen it, it had been sitting on the roof of the house on the hill, watching him go.

It looked at him.

He looked at it.

For a long time neither of them moved. The moon lay on its back and on its folded wings and turned them blue. Its eye was black and very bright and did not blink. It did not want anything. It did not ask anything. It was only there, on the table, in the light, the way it had always been there, a little behind, a little above.

He lifted his hand.

Slowly. The way you reach for anything that might go.

It did not go. He laid his fingers on its head, and then down along its back, over the smooth dark feathers, once. They were cool from the night. He did it again. The raven closed its eyes.

He sat there with his hand on its back.

He did not say anything. There was nothing in the room to say it to.

The moon went on across the sky. The square of light moved off the table, and off the floor, and up the wall, and went out. The frogs went on.

He sat in the dark with the raven under his hand until the frogs stopped, and the first bird started, somewhere out beyond the stream.

Chapter 33

The Message

The moon came up over the bamboo a little before dark, pale and not quite round, and the house on the hill sat under it the way it always did, with the wisteria gone to leaf over the gate and the frogs going in the paddies below.

Hayate was on the veranda with his back against the post and his feet up on the rail, doing nothing, which he was very good at.

In the yard, the fire in the ring of stones was going low. Shigure had made it, and eaten beside it, and gone in. Kurogane was sitting on the step with a knife across his knees and a cloth in his hand, not cleaning it. Enji was lying on his back in the dust by the fire with a square of paper held up over his face, folding it into something, unfolding it, folding it again.

Four of them. It still looked wrong. Hayate had stopped counting the places around the fire after the first month, but his eyes still did it on their own, every night, and every night came up one short.

A sound over the bamboo.

He knew it before he looked. Wings. Heavy, slow, a raven's wingbeat, and it was coming from the east, over the ridge, low.

The four ravens on the roof lifted their heads.

It came down out of the dusk and landed on the rail beside Hayate's feet, and folded its wings, and looked at him with its head a little to one side.

Hayate took his feet off the rail.

"Well," he said. "Look at you."

It had a thread tied around one leg. Tied around and around, neat and tight, and under the thread, pressed flat against the leg, a fold of paper no bigger than a thumb.

Kurogane had stopped not cleaning the knife.

Hayate reached out. The raven let him. He worked the thread loose with his fingernails, the way you undo a knot you do not want to cut, and the paper came away in his hand, and the raven shook itself and walked along the rail and sat down.

Enji was sitting up.

Hayate unfolded the paper. Once. Twice. Again. It opened out bigger than it had any right to, a whole sheet folded down small, and he turned it to the last of the light from the fire.

Lines. Ink.

A wall with a gate in it, and a small mark for a door in the side of the gate. A dot for a man. Another dot, inside, in a corner. A courtyard. A well. Something round in the middle that might have been a tree. Buildings, long, around three sides. Dots on a veranda. A mark for a bell. Small crosses at the corners of every building, and over every door. At the back, one large building with a corridor running into it, and at the end of the corridor, a room.

It was drawn the way Shigure drew. Exactly the way. Hayate had watched Shigure do it a hundred times, on the backs of bills, in the dirt with a stick, on the floor of an inn with a finger dipped in tea. Where the men stood. Where the light fell. Which way the doors opened. Nothing wasted.

But it was not Shigure's hand. The lines were heavier. More careful. Each one put down as if the hand holding the brush did not quite trust it yet.

In the room at the back, beside the door, a drop of ink had fallen and spread, round and black.

And on the back wall of that room, a mark.

A short thick line, laid across the wall. Darker than the others. The ink not quite the same ink. As if the rest had been drawn one night, and the brush had been put down, and then someone had come back to it on another night, and picked the brush up again, and finished it.

Beside it, two words.

Full moon.

Hayate knew that hand too. Square. Plain. The strokes all the same weight. A boy who had learned to write from someone who had learned to write from a sword.

He looked up.

Kurogane was standing now. Hayate had not heard him get up. Enji was on his knees in the dust, halfway to them, the paper he had been folding forgotten in his hand. And Shigure was in the doorway behind Hayate. Hayate had not heard him come either. He was drying his hands on a cloth and he had stopped drying them.

They looked at each other.

Nobody said anything.

Kurogane turned his head. Up, past the eaves, past the bamboo, to where the moon hung pale in the darkening sky, a little lopsided, a little short of full.

He looked at it a long time.

"Three nights."

Shigure came out onto the veranda. He took the paper out of Hayate's hand. He did not ask. He looked at it for one breath, all of it at once, the way he looked at everything, and Hayate watched his eyes go straight to the back wall and the dark short line on it, and stop there.

Then Shigure turned and went inside.

Hayate heard him cross the room. He heard the lid of the chest by the wall come up, and the rustle of the big map coming out, the one painted on heavy paper with the provinces in their shapes and the roads in red. He heard it unroll across the table. Stones set on the corners to hold it flat. One, two, three, four. Then nothing. Then a long quiet that was Shigure thinking.

Enji was already running.

Across the yard, past the fire, to the storehouse, and the door banged open and banged shut, and a moment later there was a light in it, and sounds. Things being pulled off shelves. A jar set down hard. Enji's voice, talking to himself, quick and high, the way it went when something was about to catch fire and he was glad of it.

Kurogane had not moved. He was still looking at the moon.

Then he looked down, at Hayate, for a moment. His face did what it almost never did. Not a smile. The place a smile would be.

He put the knife through his sash and went around the side of the house toward the kitchen, without a word. Hayate heard the rice sack being dragged out. The water jars. The sound of dried fish being counted into a cloth, piece by piece.

Hayate sat on the veranda with his empty hands.

The raven on the rail was watching him.

He reached behind him for his short sword and drew it and laid it across his knees, and took the whetstone out of his sleeve, and spat on it, and began.

Shff. Shff.

The blade went along the stone and back. The fire in the yard settled. Inside, Shigure moved a stone on the map. In the storehouse something went *tak*, and Enji laughed at it. From the kitchen, the soft thump of rice going into a bag.

Hayate drew the steel toward him and away, toward him and away.

He was smiling. He did not try to stop it.

Shff. Shff.

Above the bamboo, the moon went on getting rounder.

Chapter 34

The Truth

Aoi woke in the dark and did not know why.

No sound had woken her. The house was quiet. Daigo was breathing on the other side of the screen, slow and heavy, as if sleep were a thing he was doing with his whole body. Outside, the frogs. Nothing else.

She lay on her back and looked at the ceiling.

You brought him in.

Kageyori's voice. Flat, level, not unkind. The pine in the courtyard behind him. The way he had not looked at her while he said it.

My brother.

Rice on his hands. The smile at the corner of his mouth, for someone who was not there.

The stall. The smile that did not reach his eyes. Her own smile, put on like a robe.

The wooden sword under her jaw, and his face above it, and nothing in his face. Nobody in it. And then somebody, all at once, coming back from a long way off. *I'm sorry.*

He had not come to the training ground since. Every morning she had stood by the rack in the grey and looked at the place by the stream where he was not, and gone on with her group, and not looked again.

She sat up.

The shutter was open a hand's width for the heat, and through it the light came in, and it was the wrong color. She went to it and looked out.

The moon was up over the eastern ridge. Full. Huge and low and swollen in the thick summer air, and red. Not orange. Red, the color of a coal just before it goes grey. It lay over the valley and turned the thatch and the stream and the leaves of the trees a color she had no word for.

She stood and looked at it.

Then she turned to go back to her mat, and saw the pegs on the wall by the door.

The pegs where her father's spear hung.

They were empty.

She went to the other side of the screen. His mat was rolled. It had been rolled for some time; the quilt on top of it was cold when she touched it.

She stood in the dark with her hand on the cold quilt.

Then she dressed. She did not light a lamp. She tied her hair back and put the short blade at the small of her back and went out through the kitchen door, the one that did not stick, into the red night.

***

Ren walked through the inner compound the way he walked through it most nights now.

Not fast. Not slow. The way a man walks who belongs where he is.

The moon was up, and it was red. Everything in the compound had its light on it. The raked gravel. The pine. The long low roofs. The lamps under the eaves were lit, one at each corner, one over each door, and their small yellow light and the big red light lay on top of each other and made the shadows two colors.

The side door in the outer gate. The man on it looked at him.

"Ren."

"Good evening."

The man nodded him through.

The courtyard. The watch house. Two men on the veranda, in the shade of the eaves, the same two as always. One of them lifted a hand.

"Late tonight."

"Yes."

He went on. Across the gravel, where the lines had been raked fresh at sunset. He walked on the edge of the lines, where his feet would not show. He did not decide to. His feet did it.

Halfway across, a snake went over the gravel in front of him, out of the shadow of the pine and away toward the well, not hurrying. He stopped until it had gone. Where it had crossed, the fresh lines were broken by one long curve.

At the far corner, by the archive, where the third man always stood, there were two men now.

They did not look at him.

They stood with their backs to the archive wall and their hands folded in front of them and their eyes forward, on nothing, on the gravel. He passed within ten paces of them. Neither of them turned his head. Neither of them said his name.

He noticed it.

He noticed it the way he had noticed the cicadas stopping in the forest. Not as a thought. As a change in the weight of the air.

He kept walking.

The big building at the back. The step. He took off his sandals and set them side by side, the way they went, and went up onto the boards. The boards here were old. He knew which ones would speak. He did not step on them.

The corridor. Dim. Cedar and the dust of old wood.

Takeda's study.

The door was shut.

He stopped in front of it.

He looked left. The corridor, empty, going back to the step and the red light beyond it. He looked right. The corridor, empty, ending in a wall.

He put his fingers to the edge of the door and slid it open. Slowly. A finger's width. A hand's width. It did not make a sound. He had known it would not.

He looked inside.

The shutter on the garden side was half open, and the red moon came in through it and lay across the floor in a long bright shape. The low desk. The brushes on their rest in a row. The shelves.

And at the back of the room, in front of the dark iron-banded door, standing in the red light, with her hands at her sides.

Aoi.

He froze.

She was already looking at him. Her eyes had been on the door before it moved. She did not move. Her face was calm, the way it had been calm the first morning in the forest, looking at him against the cedar, taking in the shape of him.

He stood in the doorway.

She stood in front of the vault.

They looked into each other's eyes.

The red light lay between them on the floor. Outside, very far off, the frogs. Nothing else.

"You were never here," she said.

Ren did not move. He did not speak. Every part of him that knew what to do had stopped, all at once, the way the cicadas had stopped, and in the silence where it had been there was only her face, and the red light on it.

She did not look away.

"You knew I'd be here."

Silence.

He looked at her. At the calm on her face, which was not calm. At her hands at her sides, which were not quite still. At the vault behind her, which he had drawn on paper, and put the brush down, and come back to, and finished.

"No," said Ren.

It was true.

Something moved beyond her.

Outside the half-open shutter, in the garden, the dark between the shrubs stood up. In the corridor at his back, a board spoke that he had not stepped on. Shapes that had been shadows came up out of the shadows, all at once, as if the night around the room had been full of them from the beginning and had only now decided to show him.

A broad shape, stepping in over the sill of the garden shutter, into the red light. A long spear, level. Grey at the temples.

Gensai.

Behind him, and to the sides, and at Ren's back in the corridor, the others. Blades already out.

They did not speak. They did not call on him to stand, or kneel, or drop anything. They came straight at him.

Chapter 35

Black Crows

He drew.

He did not decide to. His hands were on the hilts and then the swords were out, both of them, and the first blade that came at him out of the corridor met the left one and turned away, and he was already moving.

There was no form in it. There was no time for form. There was only the next thing, and the next. A blade at his neck; he was not there. A blade at his knees; he lifted them. A man came in from the side and Ren put his shoulder into him and felt him go back into the shelves, and books and rolled papers came down around them both like leaves.

He did not cut to kill. He cut to make room. A wrist. A thigh. The flat of a blade across a face. Every time he made room, it closed.

And every time he turned, the spear was there.

He went left, toward the shutter, toward the garden and the red night beyond it, and the point of the spear was in the space he was going to, waiting. He went right, toward the corridor, and the spear came around, low, and swept at his ankles, and he had to jump, and when he landed there were three blades where the corridor had been. He cut at a man in front of him and the man fell back, and behind the man, over his shoulder, the spear.

Gensai did not hurry. He did not shout. He did not need to come close. He stood in the middle of the room with his feet apart and the long shaft in his hands, and wherever Ren went, the point was already there, and Ren was always going back.

Back.

Back.

His shoulders touched wood.

The corner, where the shelves met the wall. There was nowhere behind him. On both sides, blades. In front of him, a half-ring of them, six, seven, eight, the red moonlight on their edges, and beyond them, the spear.

Nobody moved.

Every eye in the room was on him. He could feel them. Eight men, and Gensai, and all of them looking at him, waiting for the next thing he would do, so they could be where it was going.

He did not look at them.

He looked past them. Past the blades, past the spear, past Gensai's broad shoulders, across the room, to the back wall, to the iron-banded door, and the one who was still standing in front of it.

Aoi.

She had not moved. She had not drawn. She was standing where she had stood when he opened the door, with her hands at her sides, in the red light, and she was looking at him. Only at him. Across all of it.

Their eyes held.

The room was silent. The frogs, far off. Someone's breath, fast, close. The creak of a hand tightening on a hilt.

One breath.

The wall exploded.

Not the wall behind him. The side wall, the one between the shelves and the garden. It came in all at once, with a sound so loud it was not a sound but a blow, a flat enormous blow against his whole body, and the floor jumped under his feet, and the plaster and the lath and the timber came into the room in a single grey rolling wave. Dust. Everywhere. In his eyes, his mouth. The lamp in the corridor went out. The red moonlight came in through the hole where the wall had been and turned the dust into a thick red fog, and everyone in the room stopped.

Everyone.

Out of the fog, along the floor, something rolled.

Small. Round. Clicking against the boards. Another. Three. Four. Shells, sealed, with a cord at the top, and the cord burning. They came to rest among the feet of the men in front of him, and spun, and hissed.

Smoke.

It came up out of them white and thick and fast, faster than any fire, rising, spreading, filling the red dust with white until there was no room, no wall, no moon. Only a white-red cloud and the shapes of men in it, turning their heads.

The two men directly in front of Ren fell.

He saw it happen. He saw it slowly, the way he had seen the knife come out of Suzuya's sleeve, every part of it separate and clear. Out of the smoke to the left, flat and turning, a short heavy blade. It went into the first man's head above the ear and stopped there, and the man's knees went. And from the same smoke, a breath behind it, three thin bright lines. Needles. One. Two. Into the second man's face, both eyes. Three. Into his chest, over the heart. He did not make a sound. He folded down onto the boards beside the first.

Almost at once, something came out of the smoke between three of the Iga.

A shape. Black. Low. It did not come at them. It came through them. There was a sound like cloth tearing, three times, very fast, one after another after another, and the three men were no longer standing.

The smoke thinned for a moment around it.

Kurogane.

He stood among them with his sword out and down, and there was nothing on his face at all, and then the smoke closed over him again.

Another shape, from the right, flying. Low. A blade came at it from one of the Iga and it was not there to meet it; it had gone under, almost to the floor, and a short sword came up out of the white and into the man's side between the ribs, all the way.

The smoke pulled back.

Hayate. Still low, on one knee, his face turned up, grinning. Then gone.

Behind two of the Iga who had turned toward the noise, two hands came out of the smoke. Slowly. Almost gently. Each with a knife in it. They came around the two men's throats from behind the way you would put your arms around a friend, and drew across, and let go.

The smoke parted.

Shigure. He stepped forward out of it, clear, for the space of a breath, looking at nothing, his two knives already down at his sides. Another of the Iga came at him, fast, with a cut that should have taken his head. Shigure leaned. Only leaned. The cut went past him. He stepped back into the white and was gone, as if he had never been there.

Somewhere in the smoke, a scream.

Then another. High, and cut off.

Ren looked up. Through a gap in the white, for a moment, a shape: a man staggering, spinning, reaching behind himself, and on his back, riding him, legs wrapped around his middle, one arm around his neck, a small wild figure with its hair every direction and a knife in its fist.

Enji. Laughing.

The knife went into the man's throat. The white closed over both of them.

Ren stood in the corner.

He did not move. The swords were in his hands and he did not lift them. He only watched them, coming in and out of the smoke, one and then another and then another, the way they came out of the dark around a fire at night. Kurogane. Hayate. Shigure. Enji.

All of them.

From the corner of his eye, something moved. Low. Fast. The long line of a spear coming out of the smoke, straight at his ribs.

He dropped.

Under it. Down, onto the boards, the point going over him so close he heard it, and he rolled, out of the corner, across the floor through the dust and the smoke and the legs of men, and came up on his feet.

Two steps.

A man in front of him, turned away, looking for something in the smoke. Ren's right sword went into his back. All the way. He pulled it out and the man went down and another came at him from the side, and his left sword came across, low, and took the man's leg off at the knee, and the man went down screaming.

He stepped back.

The spear came out of the smoke again, at his face. He leaned away from it. It went past. He turned, the whole of him, both swords coming around together in one wide spinning cut, all his weight behind it, at the place where the spear had come from.

Gensai was there.

He took the first sword on the shaft of his spear. The wood rang. And the second was already coming, and he was not there to meet it. He had stepped out of it, one short step, exactly as far as he needed. Ren's second sword went through air.

And Ren was turning, still turning, carried by the weight he had thrown into it, his balance going forward and away from him.

Gensai's foot came up and struck him in the side.

He went down. The floor hit his shoulder and his hip. He rolled with it and was up again on one knee, and then on his feet, both swords still in his hands.

Gensai was gone. Back into the smoke. The spear's point, for a moment, catching the red light, and then only white.

Ren looked across the room.

Through the smoke and the dust, through the gaps where it tore and closed and tore again, the back wall. The iron-banded door.

She was still there.

Aoi. Standing in front of the vault, where she had been standing since he opened the door. She was watching whatever she could see through the smoke. Shapes. Blades. Men falling. She could not have seen much. She did not need to see it. Her face was the face of someone who already knew what it was, and was only waiting for her eyes to catch up.

The floor jumped again.

A smaller sound, sharper, from the middle of the room, and a flash of orange through the white. The smoke bellied out in a ring. And out of it, backward, three of the Iga came flying, arms and legs going every way, and struck the shelves, and the floor, and the red night beyond the broken wall, and did not get up.

Chapter 36

The Sentinel

The spear came out of the smoke.

Ren turned it. The right sword took the shaft and let it slide, and the point went past his hip, and the butt came around behind it, low, at his knee, and he stepped over it. He cut. The spear was there. He cut again. The spear was there.

All around him, in the white, the others were fighting. He could hear them. The clash of steel and the soft sounds after it. A grunt. A body against the shelves. Enji's laugh, far off, and then close, and then gone. Kurogane never made a sound, but the Iga did when he reached them. Shigure's voice, once, one word, and then a man falling.

Ren did not look. There was only the spear.

Gensai came in again.

It was heavier. Ren felt it in his wrists when he took it, the weight of it going down through his arms and into his shoulders and into his legs. He had felt that spear on the bank by the stream, and it had been heavy then. This was more. Or he was less.

He had been fighting since the corridor. He did not know how long. The men in the corner, and the men in the smoke, and the two he had put down, and all of it had gone into his arms and legs and stayed there, and now every time he lifted a sword it came up a little slower than he sent it. Every time he moved his feet it cost him something. He was breathing through his mouth. He could hear himself.

Gensai was not breathing hard at all.

The spear came. Ren dodged. It came again. He parried, and the shock of it went all the way to his teeth. He cut, and the cut was slow, and Gensai was not there. He dodged again, and the dodge was a little shorter than it should have been, and the point went through his sleeve.

Gensai was walking him again. Not into a corner. There were no corners now, only smoke. But the same way. Each thrust leaving one place to go. Each place a little worse than the last.

The spear drew back. Gensai's weight shifted. Ren saw the thrust coming, from the right hand, the point low and turning up toward his belly, and he saw the left side open behind it.

He stepped in. Circling. Around the point, toward the left arm, where the shaft could not come back in time.

The thrust did not come.

It had never been coming. The right arm had only moved the spear. The left hand had let go of it.

Ren breathed in.

It was the wrong breath. Half of one. He knew it as he took it, the way he had known the wrong step on the training ground. And in the middle of it, Gensai's left fist came into the center of his chest.

It was not a large movement. It did not need to be. It went in under the breath, in the soft place below the ribs, and everything in Ren stopped.

He was on the floor.

He did not remember falling. He was on his back on the boards among the plaster and the fallen scrolls, and his swords were still in his hands, and he could not move them. His body was heavy. It was heavier than the floor. He tried to breathe and there was nothing to breathe with. His chest went up and did not fill. It went up again. Nothing.

Above him, through the smoke, Gensai.

He stood over Ren with the spear in both hands. He looked down at him.

Ren looked up.

It was not an angry face. It was not full of hate. It did not want anything back. It was the same face he had seen across the training ground, looking at a boy's wrist, deciding what was wrong with it. A man looking at the end of something, and not minding it, and not liking it, and doing it.

Gensai raised the spear.

The point hung over Ren's chest, catching the red light.

A pause.

Something came out of the smoke low along the floor behind Gensai. Sliding, not running. Ren did not see it. He saw only a shine, a line of light through the white at the height of a man's knees, going across, very fast.

Gensai made a sound.

Not a shout. A groan, low, through his teeth, surprised. And behind him, Ren saw a shape go back into the smoke, and knew the shape. Hayate. Gone.

Gensai went down on his knees.

Both of them. Heavily, onto the boards, the way a tree goes when it is cut at the root. The spear was still in his hands. He was still above Ren, lower now, closer, his face a forearm's length away.

Ren did not move.

He could not. His chest had found half a breath, and then another, and they were thin and they hurt. He lay and looked at Gensai's face and Gensai looked at his.

Gensai lifted the spear again.

His arms were shaking. The point came up, and turned, and found Ren's chest.

Ren's right sword went up.

He did not send it. His arm did it. It came up off the floor from where it lay, straight, the point leading, and went into Gensai's throat under the jaw, and through, and out the back of his neck, before the spear could come down.

Gensai stopped.

His eyes stayed on Ren's. They did not change. There was nothing in them that had not been there before. Then there was nothing in them.

The spear tipped out of his hands and fell across Ren's legs.

Ren drew the sword out.

Gensai went down onto his side on the boards, beside him, and did not move.

Ren lay there.

He lay on his back with the sword in his hand and the spear across his legs, and the smoke moving above him, red and white, and he breathed. In. It hurt. Out. In. It went further this time. Out. The pause.

The fighting went on in the smoke. He heard it the way you hear rain on a roof, when you are lying inside, under the blanket.

In.

The pause.

"Ren!"

Hayate's voice. Close. Sharp.

He got up.

He did not know how. He rolled and got a knee under him and then a foot, and pushed the spear off his legs, and stood, and the room swung once around him and came back. He did not look down at the man on the floor. He looked for the voice.

He ran.

Into the smoke. Through it, blind, the white in his mouth and his eyes, shapes going past him on either side, a blade somewhere near his face that did not reach it. He came out of it on the far side.

The back of the room.

The smoke was thinner here, torn and hanging. The red moonlight came through the broken wall and lay on the floor in front of him.

And in front of the iron-banded door, in the red light, with her hands at her sides.

Aoi.

He stopped.

She was looking at him. She had been looking at the smoke, at whatever was in it, and now she was looking at him, and her eyes went over him once. His face. The blood on his sleeves that was not his. The sword in his right hand, and what was on it.

He did not move.

She did not move.

Hayate came out of the smoke beside him. Ren heard him stop. Heard him take one look, at Ren's face, and then at the woman in front of the door, and then at Ren's face again.

Hayate stepped forward. In front of Ren. Between him and her. His back to Ren, his short sword low, his shoulders square, so that all Ren could see was Hayate's back, and the smoke, and the red light on either side of him.

Enji came out of the smoke on the left. Breathing hard. Grinning. Something round in each hand.

Ren moved.

One quick step to the right, around Hayate. His weight went into it, and his eyes, and the set of his shoulders, all of him going right.

Then left.

He changed in the middle of the second step, the way he had changed against the spear on the bank, and his feet went left and he went with them, past Hayate's other side, running, straight at the door.

Aoi moved to meet him.

She was fast. She came off the wall like water off a rock, her hand going to the small of her back, and she was across his line before he had gone three steps.

Hayate was faster.

He was there. Between them again, in front of her, his short sword coming up, and she had to stop, or go through him, and she stopped.

Enji saw it. His arm was already back.

Ren saw the clay ball go past him in the air, the cord at its tail spitting sparks. He turned his face away and dropped his shoulder.

The door blew in.

The sound hit him and went through him. The iron bands screamed. The dark wood came apart along its grain and went inward in pieces, and the red light went in after it, into the room behind.

Ren went in through the smoke.

It was small. A small room with no window, cool, smelling of cedar and old paper and now of fire. Shelves. Boxes. Chests with iron corners. The moonlight came in behind him through the broken door and lay across the floor.

On the shelf at the back, alone, a long box of pale wood.

He knew it. He did not know how he knew it. It was the only thing on its shelf. It had been set there the way Musashi set a sword on its stand.

He opened it.

Inside, on a folded cloth, a scroll. Rolled and tied. Old. The paper brown at the edges.

He took it out. It was light. It was lighter than anything he had ever held.

He put it inside his robe, against his chest.

Behind him, through the broken door, the sound of steel.

He turned.

Through the doorway, in the red light of the study, Aoi and Hayate were fighting.

Hayate went in fast and low, the way he always went in, from an angle nobody expected. His feet hardly touched the floor. He turned, and turned again, and came up under her guard, and the short sword was in the place where her ribs should have been.

Her eyes changed.

Ren saw it. Only for a moment. Not fear. Not surprise. Something narrower. The look of someone hearing a word in a language they know, spoken in a voice that should not know it.

She was not where Hayate's sword went. She had already moved. She went back and to the side, low, and her dagger came across and opened his sleeve, and his arm, and he twisted away from it, and she was already turning, her whole body coming around, and her foot came out of the turn and struck him in the side of the head.

Hayate went down. Hard. His sword skidded away across the boards.

Aoi stood over him, breathing, the dagger in her hand.

Ren stepped out of the vault.

Chapter 37

Hesitation

Dust. Smoke. Red light.

The moon came in through the broken wall, low and full and red, and lay across the floor in a long shape full of drifting white. Through the hole, outside, the cicadas had started up in the trees of the garden, loud, as if the night were full of them, as if nothing had happened.

The one who had moved like Iga was on the floor where she had put him. On his side. One hand pressed to the side of his head.

Ren stepped out of the vault.

He had one hand flat against his chest, over the front of his robe, where something long and narrow lay against him. The other hand held a sword.

Their eyes met.

Around them, the room was going quiet. Not all at once. The sounds of fighting were coming apart, like a rope unraveling. A last clash somewhere in the white. A groan. Feet on boards, going away. Shapes drawing back into the smoke, toward the hole in the wall, not running, not hurrying. Leaving. On the floor, between the fallen shelves, men who were not getting up.

She looked at him. He looked at her.

Then something behind him, on the floor, took her eyes away.

A spear.

Lying on the boards among the plaster and the scattered papers, in the red light. The shaft dark and worn where the hands went. She knew it. She had known it her whole life. She had sat on the bank with her feet in the water and watched it go out and come back, out and come back, and never once seen the point anywhere but where it should be.

Then beside it, on his side, not moving.

Her father.

Her breath stopped.

Not a sound. Nothing came out of her. Her chest did not go in or out. The room did not move. The smoke hung. The red light hung. Her father lay on the floor with his face turned away from her and one hand open on the boards, as if he had put something down and meant to pick it up again.

Her body moved.

She did not move it. It moved. She was across the room before she knew she was going, the dagger in her hand, going in low, the way she had gone in the first morning they sparred, the same speed, the same angle. Low, and then high, the feint, her shoulder turning to sell it.

Ren moved.

It was not Iga. It was not anything she had ever learned, or seen, or had a name for. He was not where her dagger went. He was not where her feint went. He was already at the place where the exchange ended, before it had begun, standing there as if he had been waiting for her to arrive.

Something struck her wrist.

Her dagger hit the floor.

His blade was at her throat.

Steel. Cold. Resting in the soft place under her jaw. She could feel the edge of it with every beat of her blood.

It was the morning on the training ground, turned around. Her dagger at his throat, his eyes on hers, and the laugh that had come out of him.

He had not hesitated. Not when he went into the vault. Not when he took her dagger. Not once, all night.

She looked at him.

She did not step back from the blade. She did not lean away from it. She stood with the steel against her throat and looked up into his face, into his eyes, and let him see her look.

"Then don't hesitate."

She said it quietly. She was not begging. She was not daring him. It was only true. It was the only true thing left in the room, and she gave it to him.

Ren did not move.

She watched his eyes.

And she saw it. Something she had never seen in them. Not in the mist, alone with his swords. Not on the bank against her father. Not in the forest when the Fūma came and he could not find the tall man. Something that was not precise. That did not know where it was going. It was there in his eyes, and it did not go away.

The blade stayed at her throat. It did not shake.

Almost.

Outside, the cicadas stopped.

All of them, at once. The garden went silent. The whole night went silent, and there was nothing in the room but his breath and hers and the blade between them.

One breath.

Too long.

Ren lowered the blade.

It came away from her throat slowly, and down, and hung at his side.

At the edge of the smoke, to her left, a shape. She saw it without turning her head. A lean man with a face like a shut door, a knife in his hand, and his arm already back.

Ren did not look at him.

"No."

The lean man lowered the knife.

On the floor, the one she had kicked got up. He came up onto one knee and then onto his feet, slowly, his hand still at the side of his head. He looked at her. Then he looked at Ren. His mouth opened, as if it were used to being open, and nothing came out of it. He closed it again.

"Now."

The voice came from the wall. The one with the two knives, who had only leaned when the cut came for him. Standing by the hole, with the red night behind him.

They went.

Through the hole in the wall, into the garden, into the dark. The one with the two knives first. Then the one who moved like Iga, looking back once. Then the small wild one. Then the lean man.

Ren was last.

At the broken wall he stopped.

He stood in the gap with the red moon behind him, and his shape black against it, the sword still in his hand.

He turned his head.

He looked back.

At her.

Then he was gone.

The cicadas started again. One. Then all of them. The whole night filling up with the sound as if it had never stopped.

Aoi stood alone in the dust.

The smoke was thinning. The red light lay on the floor, on the fallen shelves, on the scattered papers, on the men who were not getting up. Somewhere far off in the compound, someone was shouting. Feet were running. A bell began to ring.

She did not hear any of it.

She walked across the room. She did not step over anything. She went around. She came to where the spear lay, and stopped, and looked down at it.

Then she knelt beside her father.

Chapter 38

Blame

They had laid them in a line in the courtyard.

On the raked gravel, under the pine, with white cloths over them. A long line. The cloths did not quite reach the feet of the longest ones, and someone had tried to pull them down and made it worse. The lamps under the eaves were still lit, burning low, and the red had gone out of the moon. It hung over the western ridge now, small and pale, going down.

At the end of the line, beside the last cloth, a spear lay on the gravel.

Aoi walked past it.

There was dust in her hair. She could feel it when she moved her head. There was blood on her right sleeve, stiff and dark from the elbow down, and it was not hers. She did not know whose it was. She had not looked.

The watch at the door of the hall did not say her name. They looked at the ground as she went by.

***

Takeda's hall was lit with every lamp it had.

He sat at the head of it, very straight, his hands on his knees. There was no ink on his fingers tonight. Down both sides of the room, the ones who had come. Riku, standing, because he could not sit still. Kageyori, against the wall, small and neat. Kōsuke, and Hanbei with his arm in a sling, and Jūzō. Old men from the training ground, the ones who walked the forms with their eyes half closed, sitting now with their eyes wide open. At the back of the room, by the door, in the shadow where the lamps did not reach, Shin.

Aoi knelt in the middle of the floor.

Takeda looked at her for a long time.

"Tell it," he said.

She told it.

She told it plainly, the way she would have told a report from the forest. She did not choose the words. They came in the order things had happened. The moon. The empty pegs. The study. Ren in the doorway. What she had said, and what he had said. Her father coming in over the sill. The wall. The smoke. The ones who came out of it. Four of them. How they moved. The vault. The door. The scroll. Her father on the floor. Her dagger. His blade at her throat.

She told them that he had lowered it.

She told them that they had gone through the wall, and that he had gone last.

She did not tell them that he had looked back.

She did not make any of it smaller. She did not make any of it softer. She did not say one word in her own defense, because there was nothing to defend. When she was finished she stopped, and knelt, and looked at the floor in front of her.

Nobody spoke.

Then Kageyori, from the wall.

"I told her."

Heads turned toward the wall.

"Days ago," said Kageyori. His voice was level. He did not look at her while he said it, the way he had not looked at her by the archive. "That he had been seen with Suzuya of Kōga."

Every head turned to her.

She felt them. All of them. The whole room, turning, the way a field of grass turns when the wind comes across it. She did not lift her eyes.

That was the wound. She felt it go in. Not that she had trusted him. They could have forgiven that. Everyone in the room had trusted someone once who had not deserved it. But she had known. She had been told, and she had held it, and said nothing, and gone to the vault alone in the night instead of going to any one of them.

Takeda did not raise his voice. He never did.

"The vault was in my study." He said it slowly, each word set down like a piece on a board. "The ronin was in my compound because you walked him through it."

Neither of them said what had been said in his study, the first night, by the lamp, with the brush going. Neither of them would.

Riku stepped forward.

His face was wet. She had never seen that. His hands were shaking at his sides, and he did not seem to know they were.

"I asked if we should kill him." His voice cracked in the middle and he forced it on. "The first day. In the forest. I asked you." He stopped. "You said no."

She did not answer.

From the side of the room, one of the old men.

"She brought him inside."

"She trained with him every morning."

Hanbei, with his arm in the sling. "Every morning. Everyone saw."

"Everyone saw," said someone else.

It went on. Voices. One after another, from one side of the room and then the other, not loud, not shouting, only true, each one a small true thing set down in front of her. She had walked him through the village. She had put him in her group. She had sat with him at the stall. She had gone into the forest with him alone. She had stood between him and Riku on the first day. She had taken him into the compound. She had shown him the study.

She did not answer any of it.

It was all true.

When it was quiet again, when there was nothing left that anyone could think of to set down in front of her, she lifted her head.

"I know," she said.

That was all. Once.

Takeda looked at her. For a long moment there was nothing on his face at all. Then he looked away from her, at the lamp beside him, as if she were no longer in the room.

"Go," he said. "Bury your father."

She rose.

She turned and walked the length of the hall toward the door. Nobody moved out of her way, because nobody was in her way. Nobody looked at her, and everybody did.

At the back of the room, by the door, Shin.

He was the only one who had not spoken. He was standing in the shadow with his long careful hands folded in his sleeves, and as she came past him he lifted his eyes, and met hers.

He did not say anything. He did not nod. He only looked at her, the way he had looked at the cut on Ren's chest the first day, taking in how deep it went.

Then she was past him, and through the door, and out.

***

The sky was going grey over the eastern ridge.

The lamps were burning out along the eaves, one by one. The air was cool, the first cool morning she could remember in a long time. The pine stood black against the grey. The moon was gone.

Daigo was standing at the foot of the step, looking at the white cloths.

He was not crying. He was only standing there in the half light in his sleeping robe with his feet bare on the gravel, looking down.

He did not ask her where their father was. He already knew.

He turned his head and looked at her.

"Was it him?"

She opened her mouth.

Nothing came out of it.

She stood there in the grey with her mouth open and nothing in it, and Daigo looked at her, and she could see him read it in her face, the way she had taught him to read faces, when he was small, as a game.

He looked at her a moment longer. Then he turned and walked past her, not touching her, close enough that she felt the air move, to the cloth at the end of the line. He knelt down beside it.

Aoi stood alone on the gravel.

She reached into her sleeve.

The paper bird was still there. She took it out and held it in her open hand. It was grey with dried mud. One wing was flattened and would not come up again. The creases had gone soft. The head was bent over sideways, as if it were listening for something.

She looked at it.

She did not close her hand on it. She did not hold it against her. She only held it, in her open palm, in the grey light, and looked.

It was very quiet.

No cicadas. Not one. The trees along the stream were silent, and the trees in the garden. She listened for them, and they were not there. Summer was ending. It had ended in the night while she was not looking.

On the long roof of the hall behind her, along the ridge of it, black against the grey sky, the crows had come.

They sat in a row, and waited, and did not make a sound.

Chapter 39

Blood Moon

They did not stop until the sun was up.

Through the garden and over the wall. Across the fields, where the rice stood high and the water in the paddies had the red moon in it. Up into the trees on the far side of the valley, and over the ridge, and down, and up again, the five of them in a line, Shigure in front and Kurogane at the back, nobody speaking. Behind them, a long way off, a bell was ringing. Then it was not ringing. Then there was only the forest, and their breath, and the sound of their feet.

When the light came, Shigure found a place.

A hollow on the side of a hill, deep in cedar, where a spring came out of the rock and ran away down the slope under ferns. Nobody would come there. Nobody had come there in a long time. Shigure looked at it once, all of it, and nodded, and they stopped.

Nobody said anything.

Nobody said that it had worked. Nobody said that it had gone the way Shigure had laid it out on the table with four stones on the corners of the map. Nobody said the names of the ones who had not gotten up. Kurogane sat down with his back against a cedar and took the cloth from his sleeve and began to clean his sword, the whole length of it, slowly, and then clean it again. Enji lay down in the ferns and was asleep before his head was all the way down. Shigure went to the spring and washed his knives, and then his hands, and then his hands again.

Hayate sat on a stone with a strip of cloth and bound his own arm where she had cut it, pulling the knot tight with his teeth.

Ren stood in the middle of the hollow.

He reached inside his robe and took out the scroll.

It was still tied. The paper was still brown at the edges. There was a little blood on the outside of it that had come through his robe from his sleeve, a small dark mark, already dry.

He held it out.

Shigure came from the spring, drying his hands. He looked at the scroll. He looked at Ren's face. Then he took the scroll out of Ren's hand, the way he would take a bowl or a water jar, and wrapped it in a square of oiled cloth, and tied the cloth, and put it into the bottom of his pack under the rice.

Ren did not watch him do it.

He went to the spring and knelt and put his hands in the water. It was cold. It came up to his wrists. He watched the red come off his hands and his sleeves and go away down the slope into the ferns, thin, and then thinner, and then not red at all.

He knelt there for a long time.

***

Hayate tried at midday.

He came and sat down beside Ren on the bank of the spring with a rice ball in each hand, and held one out.

Ren took it.

"You're welcome, by the way," said Hayate. "For the knees."

Ren ate the rice ball.

Hayate waited. He grinned, a little, at the side of his face, the way he did when he was offering someone a way into a joke and was ready to hold the door for as long as they needed.

Ren finished the rice ball. He looked at the water.

The grin went away, slowly, like the light going off a wall.

"The door went beautifully," Hayate said. "Enji says it's the best one he's ever done. He won't shut up about it. Well." He looked over at the ferns, where Enji was still asleep with his mouth open. "He won't when he wakes up."

Ren did not answer.

Hayate looked at him for a moment longer. Then he looked at the water too. They sat there together, the two of them, looking at the spring, and neither of them said anything, and after a while Hayate got up and went away.

Ren heard him stop, a few paces off, and stand there, and then go on.

***

In the afternoon, Enji woke up.

He sat up in the ferns with leaves in his hair, and yawned, and looked around the hollow with the look he always had when he woke, as if everything in the world had been put there overnight for him to find.

Ren got up and walked over to him.

Enji looked up.

Ren untied the cord from his sash. The pouch. Deerskin, dark, soft with oil, the size of two hands together. He opened the flap. He took out the five stars, one at a time, from their loops, and put them in his sleeve.

Then he held the empty pouch out to Enji.

Enji looked at it.

He looked at Ren.

Ren did not say anything. He held it there until Enji took it.

Then he turned around and walked away across the hollow, to the far side, where the cedars were thickest, and sat down with his back against one of them, and closed his eyes.

He heard Enji behind him turn the pouch over. He heard the flap open. He heard the small silence of Enji's fingers finding the loops inside, one after another, the narrow ones and the wide ones.

Enji did not say anything either.

***

The sun went down behind the ridge.

Ren was on the hill above the hollow, where the cedars thinned and the grass came up long and pale at the end of summer. He had come up here when the light began to go. He sat in the grass with his arms around his knees and looked at the sky.

It was clear. The last of the light was going out of it in the west, green and then grey. In the east, over the ridge they had crossed in the night, the stars were coming out one at a time. And below them, not yet risen, a glow along the top of the ridge, where the moon would be.

In the trees below him, the evening cicadas were singing. Not the loud ones of high summer. The last ones. A thin clear sound, rising and falling, rising and falling, like something being asked over and over and not answered.

He heard Hayate coming up the hill. He did not turn.

Hayate sat down in the grass beside him. Not close. Not far. An arm's length of grass between them.

He did not say anything for a long time.

The moon came up.

It came up over the ridge, one night past full, huge and low and dark, and red. As red as it had been over Iga. It lifted off the ridge slowly and hung there, and the light of it came across the valley and across the hill, and lay on the long pale grass, and on Ren's face, and on Hayate's.

Ren watched it.

He could feel Hayate watching him.

"You're thinking about her," said Hayate.

Silence.

Ren did not move. He did not turn his head. His arms stayed around his knees. His eyes stayed on the moon.

Only the cicadas.

Hayate was still looking at him. At the side of his face, in the red light. The way Hayate looked at a stranger on a road, or a purse before he took it, reading what was there that nobody had said.

"No," said Hayate quietly. "You miss her."

Silence.

The moon went on rising. The red went slowly out of it, the way it does, a little at a time, until it was only a moon.

The cicadas.

Chapter 40

Patience

The cicadas were thinning out.

A week ago they had filled the valleys of Kōga from one ridge to the next, day and night, so that you stopped hearing them the way you stop hearing your own blood. Now there were only a few left in the trees below the house, singing late, one here and one there, with long gaps between. In the gaps you could hear the frogs again, and the stream, and the wind beginning to come down off the mountains at night with something cool in it.

Inside, the lamps were lit. The map lay on the table between them.

Kikyo stood over it. Takeru sat in his chair with his hands on his knees. Against the wall, to the right of the door, Raiden leaned with his arms folded.

The same room. The same places. She had stood here in the spring when the needle went into the capital, and in the summer when Takeru asked her if the boy would hesitate. Nothing in the room had moved since then. Only the season outside it.

The door slid open.

Suzuya came in. He closed the door behind him and knelt on the mats just inside it, and put his hands flat on the floor, and bowed his head. His dark blue was pale with road dust to the knee. He had come a long way, fast.

"Iga's vault is open," he said. "Gensai is dead. Many others. The scroll is gone."

Takeru leaned forward in his chair.

"And the boy?"

"He didn't come."

Suzuya did not lift his head. There was a pause, very short, the kind a man leaves when he has been carrying something for a long way and is about to put it down.

"I waited two nights."

Takeru's jaw tightened. Kikyo saw it without looking at him. She had watched that jaw for many years.

"Betrayal," said Takeru.

"No," said Kikyo.

She did not look up. She said it the way she would have said the lake was to the north. She was looking at the map, at the long grey stain of the lake and the red roads and the small brushstrokes of the mountains, and at the needle still standing up out of the capital where she had thrown it on the first night.

Takeru turned his head and looked at her.

She let him look. She had only one question. She had known what it was since the door slid open.

"The girl?"

Suzuya lifted his eyes for the first time.

"Alive."

Kikyo stopped.

It was very small. The space of half a breath. Her hand, which had been resting on the edge of the table, did not move. Her eyes did not move from the map. Nothing in her face changed at all. Nobody else in the room would have seen it. Takeru did not. Suzuya did not. Raiden, against the wall, was looking at the door.

His loyalty is greater than his love.

She had said it in this room. She had stood where she was standing now and said it to Takeru's face, and she had been right. It had held. It had held through the spring and the rain and the whole long summer. It had held through the vault, and the scroll, and the spearman dead on the floor of his headman's study.

Until it reached the girl.

She did not say any of that.

She reached out across the map and took hold of the needle in the capital. It came out of the paper easily, leaving a small round hole among the tiny squares. She held it up between her fingers in the lamplight. Long. Iron. Very straight.

She looked at it for a moment.

Then she set it down again. Not in the capital. Not in Iga. Further out, beyond the capital, into the brushstrokes of the mountains, where there were no roads drawn and no names written, only the little painted waves of the peaks, one behind another.

She pressed it in.

"He isn't ours anymore."

Takeru looked at the needle in the mountains. Then at her.

"Then he's useless."

"Now he's valuable."

Something at the corner of her mouth moved. It was almost a smile. It did not quite become one.

"A boy we control does what we expect," she said. "This one won't."

Takeru was silent for a long moment. The lamps burned. Outside, one cicada began, far off, and stopped, and did not start again.

"And the scroll?"

"We don't need to hold him."

She put out one finger and touched the map beside the needle. The mountains. The place with no name written on it.

"Only what he holds on to."

Takeru looked at where her finger was. He did not understand it yet. She could see him not understanding it, and deciding that he would, later, the way he always did.

Kikyo turned her head.

She looked at Raiden.

She did not say anything. She did not gesture. It was the same look she had given him in the summer, in this room, across the same lamplight. Only a look.

Raiden pushed himself off the wall.

It was the first time she had seen him move in this room. All summer he had leaned there, his weight on the wall and still, somehow, forward, and now the weight came off the wall all at once and he was standing. He did not look at the map. He did not look at Takeru. He walked across the room to the door, past Suzuya kneeling on the mats, and slid it open, and went out, and slid it shut behind him.

He did not say a word.

Takeru watched the door close. He watched it for a while after it had closed.

"You're sure?"

"No."

Kikyo looked back down at the map. At the needle, standing up out of the mountains, very small, very straight, its shadow lying out across the painted peaks in the lamplight.

"That's what makes it interesting."

She did not move anything else on the map. She did not pick up another needle. She did not lay out the papers or put them in order. She stood with her hands resting on the edge of the table and looked at the one needle in the mountains, and did nothing.

For the first time since the spring, she only watched.

Something landed on the window ledge.

A crow. Black against the dark outside, the lamplight catching the edge of its eye. It shifted its feet on the wood and looked into the room, at the table, at the map, at her.

Then it opened its wings and was gone.

ACT IV
SMOKE

Chapter 41
Taken

The first cold morning came while he was on the road.

He woke under a cedar with his own breath hanging white in front of his face, and the grass around him grey with dew, and for a moment he did not know where he was. Then he knew. He got up and went on.

He had left the others at the house on the hill. He had not said where he was going. He had only gone to Shigure in the dark before he left, and stood in front of him, and Shigure had looked at his face, and then gone to his pack, and taken out the long thing wrapped in oiled cloth, and put it into Ren's hands without a word.

It was inside his robe now. Against his chest. It had been there since the house, and it did not get lighter.

He had not taken it to Kōga.

He had meant to. That had been the whole of it, from the beginning. The house in Yamashina, the steaming road, the man with the forgettable face by the door. A door from inside. Then the scroll in Kōga's hands, and the old man's cure. He had known every step of it the way he knew the path to the stream.

And then the vault. And the spear on the floor. And her face in the red light, and his blade under her jaw, and the look in her eyes that was not afraid.

He could not carry it to them. He did not know why. He only knew that every time he turned his feet toward Kōga, they stopped.

So he turned them toward the mountain instead.

He did not know what he would say. He did not know what he would ask. He only knew that there was one fire in the world where a man sat with his hands on his knees and looked at things until he knew what they were, and that if Ren sat across from it long enough, he would know too.

***

The mountain was turning.

The maples along the path had begun to go at the edges, a little red in the green, the way a coal starts. The chestnuts were dropping. Their husks lay split on the path, spiny and brown, and he stepped over them without looking. The river was lower than it had been in spring, and clearer, and the stepping stones stood up out of it dry on top.

He crossed them. One. Two. Three. Four.

The cherry tree at the bend. Its leaves going yellow.

A pale skin hung from the stones beside the path, empty from mouth to tail. He stepped over it.

The path up through the trees.

He smelled the fire before he saw the cave. Wood smoke, clean, the kind that did not come from anything but dry wood well laid. It came down through the trees to him on the cold air, and his feet went faster without being told to.

The clearing. The ground packed hard in the places his feet had packed it. The rock at the edge where he had sat and looked at the river.

The cave mouth.

Firelight in it.

He went in.

***

Everything was the same.

The fire in its ring of stones, burning. Clean. No smoke. The flames standing up small and steady the way they always stood when the wood was laid right, and the light going up the walls. The bench against the wall. The shelf. The bowls on the shelf, two of them, one inside the other. The sword rack, and the firelight on its bare pegs.

The blanket, folded, at the back.

The stack of wood against the wall, split and dried and laid in order, the long pieces at the bottom and the kindling on top.

He stood in the mouth of the cave and waited for the old man to turn his head.

Nobody turned.

The place in front of the fire was empty.

Ren did not move.

He looked at the empty place. At the flat worn spot on the floor where a man had sat every morning of Ren's life with his hands on his knees and his eyes closed, breathing the way he breathed. Nobody was in it. The fire burned in front of it for no one.

"Musashi," he said.

His voice went into the cave and came back off the walls, small.

Nothing answered it.

He looked at the fire again. It was not an old fire. It was not burning down. Someone had fed it, not long ago, a few hours. There were pieces in it that had not yet caught all the way through.

His eyes went around the cave. He did not tell them to. They went the way they had gone around Takeda's courtyard, on their own, and brought things back, and set them down.

The sword rack. Empty. Both swords gone.

The bowls on the shelf. Clean.

The blanket. Folded.

And against the far wall, where they always stood, the two wooden swords.

One of them was standing.

It stood against the wall exactly where it had always stood, perfectly straight, not a finger's width out of true. The way Musashi stood it. The way Musashi stood everything, so that you could have laid a string along it and found nothing wrong.

The other one had fallen.

It lay on the floor below its place, across the stone, at an angle. As if it had been picked up in a hurry, and used, and let go.

Ren crossed the cave.

He crouched to pick it up. His hand was already reaching for it when he saw what was in it.

Halfway along the blade, driven into the wood so deep that the grain had split on both sides of it, a star.

Iron. Dark. Flat.

He did not touch it. He looked at it.

He counted the points.

Four.

***

He stayed crouched there for a long time.

He did not make a sound. His hand stayed where it had stopped, a finger's width from the hilt of the wooden sword, and did not close and did not draw back.

Four points.

He saw it. He did not have to see it; it was there in front of him all at once, the way the shape of a fight was there all at once. The old man in front of the fire. A sound at the cave mouth, or no sound. The hand going out, not to the rack, not to the real swords, wherever they were, but to the wooden one, the nearest, the one he had put into a boy's hands thousands of mornings ago. The star coming. The wooden blade coming up to meet it, and the star going into the wood instead of into him. And then more of them. Too many. The old man with his cough, and his fire, and his wooden sword, and the ones who came in out of the dark with four-pointed stars in their sleeves.

They had not killed him. There was no blood. The bowls were clean. The blanket was folded. They had not needed to.

They had wanted him whole.

Ren knew why.

It was inside his robe, against his chest. He had carried it away from them, and they had come here, to the one place, and taken the one thing, and left the fire burning so that he would know how little time had passed.

He breathed.

Long in.

The pause.

Long out.

He did not go to the cave mouth. He did not run down the path after them. They were hours gone, into mountains they knew better than he did, and they would be waiting for exactly that. For him to come after them the way he had come into Iga. One boy with two swords.

He had been one boy with two swords in Iga. He had been one boy with two swords in the forest, when the tall man was never where he was. He had been one boy with two swords on his back on the floor of Takeda's study, under Gensai's spear, and he had not been enough. He had been saved.

It would not be enough.

He looked at the fire.

Then he stood up. He left the wooden sword where it lay, with the star in it. He went to the fire and sat down in front of it. Not in the old man's place. In his own. Across from the empty one.

He reached inside his robe and took out the long thing wrapped in oiled cloth, and laid it across his knees.

He looked at it for a while.

Then he untied the cord. He folded back the cloth. He took the scroll out, and untied the band around it, and it loosened in his hands a little, the way paper does when it has been rolled a long time and is let go.

He unrolled it in the firelight.

The first column. Brush strokes, old, gone brown. Small. Close together. Each one set down by a hand that had not hurried.

The fire moved on the page.

Across from him, the empty place.

He began to read.

Chapter 42

Body

The first word was only a word.

He read it. It sat on the page in the firelight, small, brown, a brush stroke set down by a hand that had not hurried. He knew what it meant. It was a word anyone might know.

He read the next one.

It was a word too. But it was not only a word. It sat beside the first in a way that made the first one mean a little more than it had, and the two of them together leaned toward the third. He read the third.

He read on.

He had meant to read a little. A line. He did not know what he had meant. The words drew him the way a slope draws water, one to the next, and each one opened a little onto the next, and he went down the column and up the next one without lifting his eyes.

Then something began.

It was not in his body. He looked at his hands on the paper and they were his hands, still, steady. His chest rose and fell. Nothing in him was cut or struck or burning. And still it hurt. It hurt the way a bone hurts when it is set, deep, and it was nowhere, and it was everywhere, and it grew with every word he read, as if each word were a small hand reaching into him and moving something that had been in one place all his life into another.

He read one more line.

He put the scroll down.

He did not decide to. His hands did it. They let go of the paper and it rolled a little way back on itself on his knees, and he tipped sideways off his heels and lay down on the floor of the cave on his side with his knees drawn up.

He shook.

Not with cold. The fire was warm on his face. He shook the way a horse shakes when it has been run too far, the whole of him at once, in long waves, and he could not stop it, and after a while he stopped trying.

He lay there and watched the fire through his own shaking.

At some point he was asleep.

***

He woke with light in the cave mouth.

Grey. Early. The air coming in was cold and smelled of wet leaves. He lay on his side where he had fallen and did not move, and waited for the pain.

It did not come.

He sat up. His body was stiff from the floor. That was all. He looked at the scroll where it lay, half rolled, by his knee. He did not touch it.

He got up and took his swords and went out into the clearing.

The ground was white with dew. His breath went out in front of him and hung. He stood in the middle of the packed earth, in the place where he had stood every morning for eleven years, and drew both swords, and began.

The first thing he noticed was his breath.

It went in and it went all the way down. Not deeper than before. Cleaner. As if a place in his chest that had always been a little blocked had been cleared out while he slept, and now the air went through without catching. It

came out the same way. Long in. The pause. Long out. He did not have to think about it. He had always had to think about it, a little, somewhere at the back. It simply happened, and it was right.

He moved through the form. Step. Turn. The first cut. The second. The breath went with every one of them, exactly as far as it needed to go and no farther. Nothing was wasted. Nothing caught.

He stopped.

He stood with both swords lowered and his breath going in and out of him like the river going over the stones.

The old man in front of the fire. His eyes closed. His hands on his knees. Breathing the way he breathed.

A spear on a floor.

And under all of it, like a sound too low to hear, the next word. The one after the last one he had read. He did not know what it was. He could feel where it was. It was inside the cave, on the floor by the fire, half rolled.

He sheathed his swords.

He did not decide to. His hands did it, one and then the other, and his feet were already walking. Across the clearing. Into the cave. To the fire. He sat down in front of it, in his place, across from the empty one, and picked up the scroll, and smoothed it open on his knees, and found the line where he had stopped.

He read.

***

It was worse the second time. And it was easier.

The pain came, the same pain, deep and nowhere and everywhere. But he knew it now, and he let it come, and went on reading through it the way he had once stood in the stance with his legs shaking and not sat down. The words opened, one onto the next. He went down the column. Up the next one. Down.

The light in the cave changed. He did not notice.

After a long time he noticed that he could not see the page.

He could see the paper. It was there, pale, in his hands. But the brush strokes on it had gone soft at the edges, and then softer, as if they were sinking into the paper like ink into wet cloth. He lifted his head. The fire had gone soft too. The walls of the cave. The mouth of it, where the light was. Everything had gone into shapes. Light shapes and dark shapes. A bright shape that was the fire. A bright shape that was the day. A dark shape where the old man should have been.

He put the scroll down.

He lay down beside it.

He did not shake this time. He only lay there, with the soft shapes around him, and closed his eyes, and the shapes went away.

***

When he opened them it was morning.

He did not know which morning. He lay and tried to find it, the way he had tried to find the last time he had thought of the mountain, in Takeda's study. He could not find it. His mouth was dry. His stomach was a hollow. The fire was low. It had been fed; he did not remember feeding it. His body knew how to do that without him now, it seemed, the way it knew how to breathe.

He sat up.

His eyes were still soft. The cave mouth was a pale blur. He blinked, and blinked, and slowly it came back, the edges drawing in, the trees outside finding their shapes, the leaves on them finding theirs. By the time he stood up he could see the grain of the wood in the wall.

Two days. It had been two days. He did not know how he knew that. His body knew it.

He went to the cave mouth and stood in it with his hand on the rock.

Something moved in the grass at the edge of the clearing.

His hand moved.

He did not see it move. He felt the star leave his fingers. He had not reached for it; it had been in his sleeve and then it was in his hand and then it was gone, flat and spinning across the clearing, into the long grass by the bushes, and there was a small sound, and then no sound.

He stood in the cave mouth.

He had not thought. There had been the movement in the grass, and there had been the star leaving his hand, and there had been nothing in between. No moment where he saw what it was. No moment where he decided.

He walked across the clearing. Slowly. The dew soaked his feet.

At the edge of the bushes, in the grass, a crow.

It lay on its side with its wings half open. Black, and blue where the light touched it. The head was a hand's length away from the rest of it, in the grass, the eye still open. Clean. The star had gone through the neck and on into the dirt behind it, and stood there, five points, tilted a little, catching the light.

Ren looked at it.

The crow. The head. The star.

He did not pick up the star.

He turned around and walked back to the middle of the clearing, and drew both swords, and trained.

He was faster.

It was not a great deal. A hair. A fraction of a breath. But he felt it everywhere. His feet went down before he had finished sending them. His blades arrived at the end of a cut a little before he expected them. When he turned, there was nothing left over from the turn, no weight that had to be brought back, no moment of settling. He went from one thing to the next and there was no space between them. Every movement was only the movement. Nothing extra. Nothing he could have taken away.

He trained until the sun was high, and then until it was low.

He did not go into the cave.

***

He went in when it was dark.

The fire was low. He fed it. He sat down in his place.

The scroll lay where he had left it. And beyond it, against the far wall, on the floor where it had fallen, the wooden sword. And in the wooden sword, halfway along the blade, the star with four points.

He looked at the star.

He looked at the scroll.

He looked at the star.

His hand went out and took the scroll. He did not look at his hand. He was looking at the star. He opened the scroll by feel, and unrolled it on his knees by feel, with his eyes on the four points in the firelight, split into the wood.

Then his eyes came down to the page.

He read.

He did not remember stopping. He did not remember lying down.

***

A sound woke him.

Outside. Voices. Low. The crack of a stick underfoot, and someone hissing at someone else to be quiet.

He was up.

He did not remember getting up. He was standing, and his swords were in his sash, and he was at the cave mouth, and it was evening. The light was long and orange across the clearing and the shadows of the trees lay across it in bars.

Three men.

Ragged. Road-dirty. One with a spear, one with a sword that had been a good sword once, one with a club and a sack. They were at the edge of the clearing, by the path, looking at the cave. Looking at the smoke from the fire, going up thin into the evening. One of them was pointing.

They saw him.

The first one opened his mouth.

He did not say anything. There was no time. Ren was across the clearing, and his right sword came out of its sheath and down in one line from the man's shoulder to the ribs on the other side, and the man's mouth was still open, and he folded down into it.

The second one had the spear half up. Ren's left sword was already moving. It went in above the man's eye and through, and came out the back of his head, and Ren drew it out and the man was falling.

The third one ran.

He dropped the club and the sack and ran for the path, and Ren was not behind him. Ren was on the path, at the bend, in front of him, where the man was going to be. The right sword went across, level, at the height of a man's neck.

The man's head went into the ferns.

His body took two more steps and went down.

No words. Nobody had had time. There had been three men, and then movement, and then no men.

Ren stood on the path.

He looked around.

The clearing. The long orange light. The ground packed hard where his feet had packed it for eleven years, and now dark in three places, spreading. The ferns by the bend, splashed. His own sleeves. His hands. Both blades, red to the hilt.

The sack had fallen open. Rice was running out of it onto the ground.

Nothing moved.

The birds had stopped. The river, far below, went on over the stones. The smoke from the fire went up thin and straight out of the cave mouth into the still air.

He stood in the middle of it.

Silence.

Chapter 43

The Cold

Hayate had been walking up the wrong mountain for most of the morning before he admitted it.

It was not his fault. Ren had told them where it was exactly once, the first year, in the fewest words a person could use, and Hayate had nodded as if he would remember. North of the capital. A river. Four stones across it. A cherry tree at a bend. That was all. There were a great many rivers north of the capital, and every one of them had stones in it, and half the trees on the mountainsides were cherry trees if you wanted them to be.

He had wanted a lot of them to be.

By midday he was cold, and hungry, and sitting on a rock above a stream that was not the right stream, talking out loud to nobody about how a man who could draw a whole compound from memory could not draw one path up one hill for his brothers. The raven that had come with him from the house sat on a branch above him and did not argue.

Then it flew off.

Not back. North and up, over the next ridge, low, the way it flew when it was going somewhere.

Hayate watched it go. Then he got up and went after it.

***

He came at the place from the wrong side.

Not up the path. Through the trees, along the side of the slope, pushing through ferns that were going brown at the tips, with the cold wind coming down off the peak behind him and finding every hole in his clothes. He heard the river first, below and to the left. Then, between the trunks, he saw rock. A wall of it, grey, going up. And at its foot, a clearing.

He knew it was the place before he saw the cave. He could not have said how. Something about the ground. It was packed flat and hard in a way ground only gets packed by one pair of feet going over it every morning for years.

He came out of the trees at the edge of it, and stopped.

The ground was dark.

Not all of it. Places. Three of them, at least, big ones, and a line of smaller ones going off toward the path, and the ferns at the bend of the path had gone rust-colored in a way that ferns did not go on their own. Blood. Old blood. Days old. Dried into the earth and gone brown and black.

Someone had tried to clean it.

There was a bucket lying on its side near the biggest stain, and the earth around that one was scraped, raked over with something, a branch maybe, and wet sand from the river had been thrown down on it and scuffed in. And then whoever had done it had stopped. The scraping went so far and no farther. The bucket lay where it had been dropped. The rest of the stains had been left as they were.

There were marks going off toward the edge of the slope. Something heavy dragged. Three somethings.

Hayate stood very still at the edge of the trees.

He did not call out.

He looked at the cave. The mouth of it was dark, with a little smoke coming out of the top of it and going up thin into the cold air. Nothing moved there. Nothing moved anywhere. Even the birds had gone quiet, or had never been there.

He crossed the clearing.

He went slowly. He did not step on the dark places. He kept his hands where they could be seen, away from his sleeves, away from his sword. He did not know why. He only knew that every part of him that knew how to walk into places where he was not wanted was telling him to walk slowly now, and to be seen.

The cave mouth. The dark inside it, and the glow of a fire at the back.

He put one foot over the threshold.

Something moved.

A shadow. Only that. A shape in the dark to his left, too fast to be a shape, and then the sky was where the ground had been and the ground was hitting his back, all at once, hard enough to drive the air out of him, and there was a knee on his chest, and cold steel under his jaw.

He looked up.

Ren.

Ren's face above his, very close. Ren's hand on the hilt. Ren's blade at his throat, the edge just resting there, not pressing, not needing to.

And Ren's eyes.

Hayate had looked at a great many faces. He had looked at faces in crowds and on roads and across gambling mats, and he could tell you from a face what a man was going to do before the man knew it himself.

He looked up into Ren's face and there was nobody in it.

Not anger. Not fear. Not even the flat still watching that Ren's face always had, the look of a man taking in the shape of weather. Nothing. The eyes were open, and they were looking at him, and they were looking at him the way you look at a thing. A post. A stone. The place where a cut would go.

Hayate did not move. He did not breathe.

Then it went.

Like a cloud going off the sun. All at once, the eyes were Ren's eyes again. Dark. Tired. Surprised. Something came back into them from a long way down, and they looked at Hayate, and knew him.

The blade came away from his throat.

"Hayate."

Ren said it quietly. He said it the way you say a word you had forgotten you knew.

He took his knee off Hayate's chest. He stood up, and stepped back, and sheathed the sword, and then, after a moment, he reached down with his hand open.

Hayate looked at the hand.

He took it. Ren pulled him up.

They stood in the mouth of the cave, the two of them, with the fire behind Ren and the dark clearing behind Hayate, and the cold wind coming down off the mountain between them.

Hayate looked at him.

Ren was thinner. A week, and he was thinner. His face had gone sharp under the eyes. His clothes were the same clothes he had left in, and they were stiff at the sleeves and dark, and he did not seem to know it. His hair had come loose from its tie. And he was standing the way he always stood, easy, balanced, but there was something wrong with it. Something too easy. As if his body had been taken apart and put back together by someone who knew exactly how bodies worked and had never seen a man.

"Ren," said Hayate. "What happened?"

Silence.

The fire cracked behind him. Ren did not turn his head.

"Kōga," said Ren.

Hayate waited. He knew how to wait for Ren. You waited, and you did not fill the space, and if there was anything more it came.

"They took him."

Hayate did not ask who. He looked past Ren into the cave. At the fire burning at the back. At the place in front of it where nobody was sitting. At a sword rack with nothing on it. At a wooden practice sword lying on the floor by the wall with something dark stuck in its blade. At a scroll, half rolled, beside the fire, on a square of oiled cloth.

He looked at the scroll for a moment longer than he looked at anything else.

"And I'll bring him back," said Ren.

Hayate's eyes came back to his face.

And for a moment, only a moment, the eyes went again. Hayate saw it. The same thing. Nobody in them. Something flat and cold and certain looking out of Ren's face at the words he had just said, the way a man looks down a road he has already decided to walk.

Then it was gone.

Silence.

The wind came down off the mountain. Somewhere in the trees behind the clearing, the raven called once, and did not call again.

Hayate looked at him for a long time.

He did not ask about the blood. He did not ask about the drag marks, or the bucket, or the scroll. He did not ask what was wrong with Ren's eyes. He knew, standing there, that there were a hundred things he could say, and that every one of them would be true, and that none of them would matter.

"When are we going?" said Hayate.

Ren did not move.

For a moment he did not move at all. Not his hands. Not his face. Not his eyes. He stood in the mouth of the cave with the fire behind him and looked at Hayate as if Hayate had said something in a language he had once known, a long time ago, and was trying to remember.

Hayate waited.

Chapter 44

Cracks

They left the mountain in the morning.

Ren did not look back at the cave. He came out of it with his swords in his sash and the long wrapped thing inside his robe, and walked across the clearing, around the dark places, and down the path. He did not stop at the cherry tree. He crossed the four stones without looking at them.

Hayate followed him down.

He talked. It was what he did. He talked about the wrong mountain, and the wrong stream, and how the raven had given up on him and gone on ahead, which was fair, since he would have given up on himself too. He talked about Enji, who had built something in the storehouse while Ren was gone that none of them were allowed to see and that smelled, from outside, like a burning pig. He talked about Kurogane, who had cleaned his sword so many times since Iga that there could not be much sword left.

Ren walked at his side.

That was the thing. He was beside him. His feet were keeping pace. His shoulder was where it always was, a pace ahead of Hayate's, on the side toward the road. If you had seen the two of them from a distance you would have seen two men walking together the way they had walked together a hundred times.

But he was not with him.

Hayate could feel it the way you feel a draft from a door you did not know was open. Ren was walking, and his body was doing all the things a body does when it walks, and none of the rest of him was there. His eyes were on the road ahead, and they were quiet. Not the quiet they had always been, the quiet of a man listening to everything. Quieter than that. As if there was nothing left to listen for.

"Kurogane's going to look at you," said Hayate, "the way he looks at a horse that's gone lame. You know the look."

"Yes."

"And Shigure's going to feed you. He'll just put food in front of you until you stop being that shape."

Ren did not answer.

"Enji's going to want to show you the pig."

"Yes."

Hayate looked at him sideways. Ren's face did not change. He was looking at the road.

Hayate let it go. He kept talking, a little less, and then a little less than that, and by the middle of the day they were walking without talking at all, and the silence between them was a new kind of silence. Hayate did not know its shape. He had known the shape of every silence Ren had ever made, and this was not one of them.

***

In the afternoon the road came down out of the hills and ran along the edge of the paddies.

The rice was heavy and gold and bending, and in some of the fields they had begun to cut it. Men and women bent in the rows with sickles, and the cut sheaves stood in shocks behind them, and the air smelled of straw and mud and, from somewhere, smoke. Harvest. Somebody's harvest was going well, because in the village ahead of them, beyond the fields, there were drums going, and someone was singing badly.

At the edge of the village, by a stall where a woman was selling cloudy sake out of a jar with a ladle, a man was sitting in the dust of the road.

He was a farmer. His legs were bare and brown to the thigh and his hands were split across the knuckles. He was very drunk. He had a cup in one hand and he was not drinking from it, only holding it, and talking to it, and the woman at the stall was pretending he was not there.

He saw them coming.

He got up. It took him two tries. He stood in the road, swaying, and watched them come with his head down like a bull.

Hayate knew the look. He had seen it on a hundred roads. A man with nothing, who had drunk the little he had, and wanted something to be angry at, and had found it walking toward him with two long swords.

"Look at this," said the man. He said it to the whole road. "Look at these. Look at the fine gentlemen."

They walked.

"Swords." The man spat, and most of it went on his own chin. "Two of them. What's a man want with two swords? Can't use one, so he carries another in case?"

Hayate laughed.

It came out of him easy. It was the kind of thing that happened on the road, and it was nothing, and it had always been nothing. Men like this one said things, and you laughed, or you didn't, and you kept walking, and by the time you were past the next bend they had forgotten you and you had forgotten them. Ren never answered them. Or he said one thing, flat and true, the way he said everything, and walked on while the man stood there trying to work out whether he had been insulted. Hayate had seen him do it in Nara, and in Ōtsu, and on the Tōkaidō in the rain.

"Masterless dogs," said the man, as they came level with him. "Both of you. Nobody's dogs. Nobody wants you, so you walk up and down looking at honest men like you're—"

Steel.

Hayate heard it. A single sound, very short, a sound he knew better than his own voice. A blade leaving its scabbard all at once.

He turned.

Ren's sword was at the man's throat.

Hayate had not seen him draw. He had been walking at Ren's shoulder, and he had heard the man's voice, and he had heard the sound, and now Ren was standing in the road with the blade out, level, the edge resting in the soft place under the drunk man's jaw.

The man froze.

His cup was still in his hand. The sake was running out of it over his fingers and dripping into the dust. His mouth was still open on whatever the next word was going to be. He did not close it. He did not move at all.

Hayate did not move either.

The woman at the stall had put down her ladle. Somewhere in the village the drums went on, and someone was still singing.

Nobody spoke.

Ren was looking at the man. Only at the man. His face was the same face it had been all day, quiet, closed. There was nothing in it. No anger. The man had called him a dog and there was not one thing in Ren's face that had heard it.

"Say one more word," said Ren.

He said it calmly. He said it the way he would have said the river was high.

Hayate stared at him.

He looked at Ren's face. He looked at the blade. He looked at the man's throat under it, the skin pale where the steel pressed, a pulse going there, fast, like a bird.

Then he looked at Ren's hand.

It was shaking.

Not much. Almost nothing. A tremor in the fingers where they wrapped the hilt, so small that the blade itself hardly moved with it. Just enough that the light on the edge shivered.

Hayate had never seen Ren's hand shake. Not in Iga. Not at the ford, or in the lord's hall, or on any road. Not once.

"Ren!"

It came out of him loud. Louder than he meant.

Ren did not move.

The blade stayed where it was. The man's breathing had gone short and high, in and out through his open mouth, very fast. Sake ran off his knuckles. The sword did not move from his throat, and the hand on the sword went on shaking, and Ren's face went on being nothing at all.

Hayate took a step. One. Slowly. The way he had crossed the clearing to the cave.

"Ren."

Quieter. The way you say a name to someone who is asleep.

Ren blinked.

It was only that. His eyes closed and opened. And when they opened something had come back into them, the same thing that had come back at the cave, from a long way off.

The sword came down.

It came away from the man's throat and down, and hung at Ren's side, the point toward the dust.

The man stood there for a breath longer. Then he dropped the cup, and turned, and ran. Not well. He went sideways into the stall and knocked the jar and the woman shrieked, and he righted himself and ran on into the village with his bare legs going every direction, and did not look back.

Hayate did not watch him go.

He was looking at Ren.

Ren raised the sword. He did it slowly. He brought the point back to the mouth of the scabbard, and set it there, and slid the blade in, a little at a time, the way you would do a thing with your hands that you had to think about. As if, if he did not watch it all the way home, it might do something else.

It went in. He took his hand off the hilt.

The hand was still.

"Ren," said Hayate. "What was that?"

Ren did not answer.

He did not look at Hayate. He did not look at the stall, where the woman was on her knees picking up the broken pieces of her jar. He did not look at the village, where the drums had not stopped. He looked at the road ahead.

Then he walked on.

After a moment, Hayate walked with him.

***

They did not talk again that day.

They walked along the edge of the paddies, where the rice was being cut, and past the village, and on into the evening, and the road went on in front of them the way roads do. Ren walked where he had always walked, a little ahead, on the side toward the road.

Hayate walked beside him.

But not the way he had in the morning. He did not look at the fields, or the sky, or the people in the rows with their sickles. He did not talk. He looked at Ren. At his shoulders. At his hands. At the side of his face when it turned.

He was not afraid of him.

He knew that about himself, and was glad of it, the way you are glad of a floor under your feet. He had seen Ren's eyes go empty twice now, and his hand shake once, and he was not afraid.

It was something else.

He had always known what Ren would do. From the first day, on the road outside Nara, with the knife and the purse. It had been the simplest thing about him. Ren did what Ren did. You could have set your life by it.

Now Hayate walked beside him in the dusk, and watched his hands, and did not know.

Chapter 45

The Offer

Hayate told them on the second night.

Ren was there. He sat on the step with his back against the post and his hands on his knees, and he did not say anything, and Hayate did not look at him while he talked. Hayate told it plainly, which Ren had never heard him do. The mountain. The cave. The fire still burning with nobody in front of it. The wooden sword, and what was in it. Four points. Kōga. And the old man gone.

He did not tell them about the blood in the clearing. He did not tell them about the road, or the drunk, or Ren's hand.

When he was finished, nobody said anything.

Nobody asked what they would do. Nobody asked whether. The fire in the ring of stones went on burning, and the frogs had stopped for the year, and the only sound was the wind in the bamboo, dry now, rattling.

Then Kurogane got up.

He went inside and came back with his sword and his whetstone, and sat down on the other side of the fire, and began.

That was all.

***

For three days the house was quiet with work.

Kurogane sharpened. Not the way he cleaned a sword, over and over, for something to do with his hands. The other way. Slowly, one side and then the other, stopping to hold the edge up to the light and look along it with one eye closed, and then going on.

Hayate sat on the veranda with his sleeves emptied out onto a cloth in front of him and went through everything. Needles, counted and counted again and tied in bundles. Cord. A little knife, and another little knife. Things that clinked and things that did not. He whistled while he did it, and then noticed he was whistling, and stopped, and then started again.

Enji was in the storehouse. Day and night. The light never went out in it. Sometimes a sound came out of it, a pop or a hiss or a long crackling, and once a thump that shook the shutters, and then Enji's laugh, high and pleased, and then nothing, and then the grinding again.

Shigure had the big map out on the table, with the four stones on its corners. He sat in front of it for hours. He did not move anything on it. He only looked, the way he looked at everything, all of it at once, and every so often his finger went out and touched a ridge, a river, a road, and came back.

Ren trained in the yard.

He trained from before light until after dark, alone, and nobody came to watch him, and nobody told him to stop. He did not speak to them. They did not ask him to. At meals he sat where he always sat, in the same order around the fire, and ate what Shigure put in front of him, all of it, every grain, and put the bowl down, and went back out into the yard.

He could feel them looking at him. Hayate most of all. Kurogane, sometimes, from across the fire, the way he looked at a horse. Enji, who came out of the storehouse black to the elbows and stood in the doorway and watched Ren go through the form with his head on one side, and did not say anything, and went back in.

Shigure did not look at him at all. Shigure looked at the map.

***

They left on the fourth morning, before the light.

The yard was grey. The fire in the ring of stones had been let go down to coals and covered. The packs were on their backs. All five in black. Kurogane was already at the gate, under the wisteria, its leaves going yellow. Enji had a bag over his shoulder that he carried the way you carry a sleeping child, carefully, both arms around it. Hayate was tying his sandals and talking to the raven on the roof.

Ren put his swords through his sash. One and then the other. He checked them.

Once.

He turned toward the gate.

Something touched his shoulder.

A tap. Two fingers, light.

He turned around.

Shigure was standing behind him. He had something in his hands, held up between them.

A belt.

Leather, dark and oiled, made to go across the chest. Slots and loops sewn all along its length. And in the slots, each in its own place, laid in with care, just as they had been laid in on the table by the door on the morning Ren left for Iga. Long thin iron needles. Small round shells, sealed, with a cord at the top. A short blade in a plain sheath. And three small balls of fired clay, each with a tail of cord.

"You're going to need it where we're going now," said Shigure.

Silence.

Ren looked at the belt. He looked at the needles, and the shells, and the short blade, and the three clay balls. He looked at Shigure's hands holding it up.

He took it.

He put it over his head and across his chest, from the right shoulder to the left hip, and pulled the strap through, and drew it tight, and tied it off. It sat against him. It sat well. Someone had measured it for him a long time ago, before Iga, and had not been wrong.

He looked up.

"Thank you, brother," said Ren.

Shigure smiled.

It was a small smile. Not at the corners, the way Shin smiled. All of it at once, and quickly, and then put away again, the way he put a knife away. But it was there, and Ren saw it, and it was for him.

Ren turned around.

They went out through the gate, the five of them, under the wisteria, and down the path into the bamboo and the grey.

***

The forest between the capital and Kōga was old and close and full of fallen leaves.

They had been walking for two days. They walked the way they always walked on a job, in a line, not talking, Shigure in front and Kurogane at the back, and the raven somewhere above them, going from tree to tree. The maples were turning now, red coming through the green. The leaves came down around them when the wind moved and lay thick on the path and whispered under their feet no matter how they put them down.

In the middle of the second afternoon, in a stretch of cedar where the path ran along the side of a slope, something moved.

A sound. Small. A twig, off the path, up the slope to the left. Not a deer. Not a bird. Something that had been careful and had not been careful enough.

Shigure's hand went up.

Ren was already gone.

He did not decide it. He was on the path and then he was off it, going up the slope through the cedars, fast, low, both swords out, before Shigure's hand had finished rising. He heard Hayate hiss his name behind him. He did not stop.

Behind a trunk, a shape. Young. Lean. Black clothes, dark grey at the collar. A short sword coming up to meet him.

Steel on steel. Once. Twice. Three times. Fast. The young man was good. He was very good. He took Ren's first cut and turned it, and the second, and the third came in under his guard and he twisted out of it and was still there, still standing, his eyes wide and bright and not afraid. Ren came in again.

Behind him, on the path, he heard steel come out. All four of them. Karasu.

And around him, all at once, the forest filled up.

They came out from behind the trees. From the bushes. From the ground, it seemed, from under the leaves. Dark shapes in black, dark grey at the collars, a dozen of them, more, not rushing, not shouting, simply there, where a moment ago there had been only cedar. They did not come at Karasu. They stood. In a wide ring, across the slope and the path, every one of them in a place where he could see every other one.

Ren did not look at them.

He was looking at the last one.

A man came down the slope between the trees. Not fast. Not slow. He walked the way a man walks across his own house. Black clothes, plain, a small crest at the breast in dark grey thread. No mask. A face that was not young and not old, still and composed, with nothing in it that he had not put there. He did not have a sword out. His hands were empty at his sides.

Ren left the young one.

He went straight at the man.

Both swords. Everything he had. The first cut came in at the man's neck and the man was not there. He had not stepped back. He had not ducked. He had taken one short step to the side and let the cut go past him, and the step had put him somewhere Ren's second sword could not reach without Ren's feet moving first. Ren moved them. The man was not there either. He was never moving much. He was never moving fast. He was only always standing in the one place the next cut could not go.

Ren came in low. Ren came in high. Ren feinted right and went left, the way he had against Gensai's spear, against Aoi. The man was already on the left. Not waiting. Just there. As if he had known where the fight would go before it began, and had walked to the end of it, and was standing there when Ren arrived.

Something caught Ren's foot.

A shin. Hooked behind his heel, exactly where his weight was going. A hand flat on his chest, not pushing, only turning him, and his own speed did the rest.

The ground came up and struck him.

Leaves. Dirt. The smell of cedar. His swords were still in his hands. He was on his back on the slope, and the man was standing over him, not even breathing hard.

***

Hanzō looked down at the boy.

He had read about him for half a year. Two swords, both long. Trains alone before light. A style no one in Iga knows. The old man's style, and something after it. He had built a picture of him out of those lines, the way he built a picture of anything, from the edges in.

The picture had been right. It had also been small.

Around them the slope was full of steel. The one they called the Manslayer had three of Hanzō's people in front of him and was taking them apart without a word. The small wild one had something in his hand with a cord hanging from it and was grinning. The one with the knives had found the only tree on the slope that could not be come at from more than one side, and was standing against it. The loud one had Jin by the collar.

Jin, who had followed the ravens for three days and been proud of it.

Hanzō lifted one hand. Two fingers. Down and out.

His people stepped back. All at once, the way they had been taught, each to a place that had been chosen for him before any of this began. The steel stopped. The slope went quiet. The Manslayer did not step back. He did not step forward either. He stood where he was with his sword out and his face shut like a door.

Hanzō looked back down.

The boy was looking up at him from the leaves. Hanzō looked into his eyes.

"Your master."

Something happened in the boy's eyes.

It was very quick. Hanzō had seen many things go out of many men's eyes, and this was not like any of them. It did not go out. It went away. As if someone had been standing in a doorway, and had stepped back into the dark behind it, and left the doorway empty.

The boy moved. From the ground, all at once, the left sword coming up at Hanzō's knee.

Hanzō's foot was already moving. It met the boy in the chest, flat, and put him back down in the leaves.

The eyes came back.

Hanzō waited a moment. He let the boy breathe.

"You want him back."

Nobody on the slope said anything. Not his people. Not the boy's. The wind came through the cedars and a few leaves came down, red, and turned, and lay.

Hanzō looked around him. At the Manslayer. At the small one with the thing in his hand. At the one against the tree, who was looking back at him with the eyes of a man who had already counted everything on the slope and come to the same number Hanzō had. At the loud one, who had let go of Jin.

"But you will all die."

Silence.

He let it stay. He had learned a long time ago that the pause after a true thing did more work than anything said after it.

"We can help."

He looked down at the boy again.

"I want what you took from Iga."

The boy looked up at him.

He looked for a long time. Hanzō did not hurry him. He watched the boy's face, and saw nothing in it, and knew that nothing was the wrong word for what he was seeing. There was something there. Something being weighed, very fast and very coldly, the way he would have weighed it himself. The old man on one side. The scroll on the other. What each of them was worth. What each of them would cost.

The boy nodded.

Slowly. Once.

Hanzō held out his hand.

The boy looked at the hand. Then he let go of one sword, and took it, and Hanzō pulled him up out of the leaves.

Hanzō turned his head. Daichi was at the edge of the ring, broad and still, a dark grey sash wound twice around him, with his blade still out, watching the Manslayer. Hanzō nodded to him.

Daichi sheathed. Around the slope, one after another, the others did the same. The sound of it went around the ring like a single long breath.

The boy did not look at Hanzō. He turned his head and looked at the Manslayer.

Only looked.

The Manslayer looked back at him. A long moment. Then he sheathed his sword. The one against the tree put his knives away. The loud one let his hands drop. The small wild one, last, and slowest, put the thing with the cord back in his bag.

Steel away. For now.

Hanzō looked around the slope at the two circles of people standing among the cedars, his and theirs, and the red leaves coming down between them.

Nobody had won anything. Nobody had lost anything. Everyone was exactly where they could be of use.

It was, he thought, a beginning.

Chapter 46

The Approach

They came up onto the ridge in the last hour before dark, and there it was.

Kōga.

Shigure had seen it on the map for three days and a hundred times before that, in the lines he had drawn in the dirt, on the backs of bills, on the floor of the house with a finger in tea. He had it in his head the way he had every place he had ever meant to go into. It was still not the same as seeing it.

The valley lay below them like the inside of a bowl. The fog had already come up out of the low places and was lying in the folds of the hills, white, flat, so that the ridges stood up out of it like the backs of animals asleep in water. Down in the white, where it thinned, there were roofs. Thatch, tile. A village scattered along the valley floor. Paths between the fields, going pale in the dusk. And at the head of the valley, on a rise above the rest, a larger group of buildings inside a wall, one roof taller than the others, dark, heavy, with a single light burning in it.

Nobody spoke.

There were eleven of them on the ridge. The five. Hanzō. Daichi, and Jin, and three more of Hanzō's people whose names Shigure had learned and filed away and did not need. They lay in the leaves along the crest, under the edge of the cedars, and looked down.

Shigure looked.

He looked at all of it at once, the way he looked at everything, and then he began to take it apart.

The paths. The walls. The places where the fog was thickest and the places where it was not. The fields, cut, the stubble pale. The roofs of the village. The wall around the buildings on the rise. The gate in the wall. The single light.

And then he began to look for the things that should have been there.

Smoke. It was the hour for cooking. Every village in every valley he had ever lain above at this hour had had smoke going up from it, thin and blue, one thread for every house. There was no smoke. Not one thread.

Dogs. There were always dogs.

Sound. A door. A child called in. A bucket on a rope. Anything.

There was nothing. The fog lay in the valley and the roofs stood in it and the one light burned on the rise, and the whole of Kōga lay below them as still as a painting of itself.

He felt Kurogane, on his left, go still in a different way. Not the stillness of a man lying in leaves. The stillness of a man whose hand has found his hilt without being told.

"They're waiting," said Shigure.

He said it softly. Nobody answered him. Nobody needed to.

Beside him, Hanzō lifted one hand from the leaves. One finger.

"There."

The finger pointed down the valley, across the fog, to the rise. To the tallest roof inside the wall. The one with the light.

"That's where they keep prisoners."

Ren got up.

He did not look at anyone. He came up out of the leaves onto his feet in one movement, the way he did everything now, with nothing wasted and nothing left over, and began to walk. Down the slope. Toward the light.

He had gone three steps when Hayate's hand closed on his arm.

Ren stopped.

He turned around.

Shigure saw his eyes.

It was the thing Hayate had not told them about. Shigure had known there was something Hayate had not told them. He had seen it on Hayate's face the second night, in the places the story went around. Now he saw what it was. Ren's eyes had nobody in them. They looked at Hayate's hand on his arm, and then at Hayate's face, and they were not Ren's eyes looking. They were something else's.

Then they were Ren's again.

It went out of them like breath going off a mirror. Ren looked at Hayate. At the hand. At the ridge, and the others lying in the leaves looking up at him.

Nobody said anything.

Hayate let go.

Shigure watched Ren's face for a moment longer. Then he looked back down at the valley, at the light, and put what he had seen away where he kept the other things he did not yet know what to do with.

They went down.

***

The fog took them at the foot of the slope.

Hanzō walked in it the way he walked everywhere, neither fast nor slow. His people were around him, where he had put them. The five were ahead and to the left, the boy in front, the Manslayer at his shoulder. The fog was thick here, wet on the face, and in it the shapes of the others went soft at the edges and came back and went soft again.

He counted steps. He counted the distance to the wall. He listened.

Nothing.

They were halfway across the stubble of the lower field, where the ground was open and the fog lay flat on it like water, when the field stood up.

Men. All around them. Rising up out of the white where there had been nothing but stubble, where Hanzō would have sworn on his own name that there had been nothing but stubble. Dark shapes in grey, low, silent, with blades out. Ten. Twenty. More. They did not shout. They came up out of the ground the way fog comes up out of a valley, all at once and from everywhere.

Fūma.

He knew them by the way they stood. Not in a ring. Not in lines. In no shape at all, and every one of them exactly where the shape was not.

And then, last, out of the fog directly in front of the boy, one more.

He did not rise. He was simply there. A man of middle height in plain grey, with a sword held low and loose, and a face that was not hidden and did not need to be.

Hanzō looked at him.

He had read about this one too. Every report said the same thing, in different hands, in the same few words. *Raiun. One of their elites. He is already where you are going.*

Hanzō looked for it now. The small signs. The weight going forward before the foot. The breath taken before the cut. The eyes going to the place the blade will go. He had read those things in men all his life, the way other men read writing.

There was nothing to read.

The man in grey stood in the fog with his sword low and there was no intention in him at all. None. He could have been about to kill every one of them. He could have been about to walk away. His body did not know which, and so there was nothing on it for anyone else to know.

Hanzō felt something he had not felt in a long time. It was very small. It was the feeling of looking at a board and not being able to see the next move.

"Fūma," he said.

Then the fog moved again. Not in front of them. Behind. On the slope they had just come down, and in the stubble on either side, and along the line of the wall above. More shapes. Different ones. Darker. Standing up out of the ground and out of the hedges and out of the fog on every side, closing the way back.

Four-pointed stars in their hands.

Hanzō turned his head slowly and looked at them.

"And Kōga?"

Nobody answered him.

The Fūma came first.

They did not come at the eleven all at once. They came at the spaces. Between Hanzō's people and the five. Between the Manslayer and the boy. Between Daichi and Jin. A blade came out of the fog at every gap there was, and every gap closed by being made wider, and in the space of three breaths there were no longer eleven people standing in a field. There were small groups, pulled apart, fighting in the white, each one unable to see the others.

Hanzō stepped aside from a cut he had known was coming. He stepped aside from the one after it. He looked for the boy.

The boy was gone into the fog.

***

Shigure was at Kurogane's back.

Kurogane did not have to look to know it. He knew it the way he knew where his own left hand was. He could feel Shigure behind him, the shape of him, turning when he turned.

Grey shapes. Four. Five.

One came in.

Kurogane cut once. The shape stopped being a shape.

Behind him, a knife went into someone. He heard it. He did not look.

"Left," said Shigure.

Kurogane went left. There was a man there who had not been there when Shigure said it. He was there when Kurogane arrived.

Another.

Another.

Kurogane did not count them. Shigure counted them. Kurogane cut.

The fog was full of them. It was full of them in every direction and they kept coming and none of them were the ones that mattered. He knew that the way he knew most things, without words. These were the ones who were sent. The ones who sent them were somewhere else.

Behind him, Shigure's breath. Steady. In. Out.

"Right," said Shigure.

Kurogane went right.

***

"Ha!"

Enji threw.

The clay ball went up into the fog spitting sparks and came down somewhere in the white where the grey men were, and the fog went orange, all at once, from the inside, like a paper lantern, and the sound came after. Somebody screamed. Somebody else was thrown out of the white and landed in the stubble and did not get up.

Enji laughed.

He could not help it. He never could. The fog was full of orange and noise and men, and the ground was shaking a little under his sandals, and everything that had been one thing a moment ago was now another thing, and he loved it. He loved it the way he loved the moment when the paper stopped being paper and started being a bird.

Beside him Hayate was a blur. Low, and then high, and then gone, and then back, needles going out of his fingers in bright lines, a grey man falling with his hands at his face.

And in front of them, Ren.

Enji stopped laughing.

Ren was not a blur. That was the thing. Hayate was a blur. The grey men were blurs. Ren was the only thing in the whole field that was perfectly clear. He was not moving fast. He was not moving slow. He was only never where they cut and always where they were going to be, and they went down around him one after another, in the fog, with no sound, the way rice goes down in front of a sickle.

He did not look at them when they fell.

Enji had seen Ren fight a hundred times. He had seen him at the castle and at the boss's house and in Iga with the smoke all around him. He had never seen him like this. It was very beautiful. It was the most beautiful thing Enji had ever seen, and it made the back of his neck go cold, and he did not know why.

A grey shape came at Enji out of the fog.

Ren was there. Ren's sword went through it. Ren did not look at Enji. Ren's eyes were already on the next thing.

Enji reached into his bag.

His fingers found the big one. The one from the storehouse. The one that smelled like a burning pig.

He grinned.

The fog closed around the three of them, orange and white, and the grey men kept coming.

Chapter 47

The Assault

Enji's big one went off at the foot of the wall.

Hayate felt it through his feet before he heard it. The ground jumped. Then the sound, so large it was not a sound, and the fog in front of the gate turned into fire and then into a hole, and in the middle of the hole the gate was not there anymore. Only the posts, burning, and the red leaves of a maple on the far side coming down through the smoke like sparks.

They went through.

All of them, from wherever the fog had put them. The field emptied toward the gap in the wall the way water empties toward a drain, and on the other side of it was the compound, and the compound was worse.

It was a place built to lie.

Hayate saw it at once, because lying was a thing he understood. Long buildings with paper walls, lamps burning behind them, so that the whole courtyard was lit from inside the houses. And the lamps were moving. Someone was carrying them. The shadows on the paper went long and then short and then went the wrong way entirely, so that a man's shape would be there on the wall, clear, a sword in his hand, and there would be no man. Somewhere in a corridor a bell was ringing. Then another, the other side. Nobody was ringing them. Nobody Hayate could see.

A voice called out to his left. Loud. Close. He turned toward it.

The blade came from the right.

He was already moving. It went past his ear. He had been lied to on roads his whole life and his body did not believe anything anyone said, and it had saved him before and it saved him now.

Hanzō's people were taking the corners. Hayate saw that too. They did not chase. They went to the edges of the courtyard, to the angles of the buildings, to the places where one man could stand and see two walls at once, and they stood there. Like pieces set down on a board. The Kōga came at them and broke on them and went back into the smoke. The corners held.

And through the middle, where nothing held, where the shadows were wrong and the voices came from nowhere, Karasu went.

Then the timing went strange.

A man came out of the smoke at Hayate. Short. Lean. His eyes over a strip of cloth. He cut, and Hayate met it, and the cut was not there. It arrived after. Half a beat after, when Hayate had already answered the cut that should have been, so that his blade met air and the real one came in underneath.

Hayate went low. It saved his ribs. It did not save his sleeve.

He had never met anything like it.

Jin came in from the side. Fast, young, bright-eyed, the one who had followed the ravens. The two of them went at the short man together, one high and one low, the way two men should never lose to one.

They could not settle him.

Every exchange was half a beat off. Hayate would come in and the short man's blade would be late, and he would adjust for it, and then it would be early. Jin went in on the rhythm and there was no rhythm. It was like dancing to a drum played by someone who hated you. Hayate could not find the beat. He could only keep moving and keep not being where the late cut arrived, and it was the hardest thing he had ever done.

Then the short man stepped back out of it, as if someone had called him, and was gone into the smoke. Through the gap where he had been, Hayate saw Ren.

And the one who had come for Ren.

***

Raiden had known where the boy would be.

It was not hard. He had watched him on the Kusatsu road. He had watched him from the ridge above the hunting grounds, sitting against a cedar with his chest open. He had not needed the papers on Kikyo's table. He had seen enough himself. The boy went through the middle. The boy always went through the middle. He went straight at what he wanted.

So Raiden went to the middle and waited.

The boy came out of the smoke.

Raiden went at him.

He did not feint. He did not test. He never had. He went in the way he always went in, forward, all of him, the first cut already the last one if it landed, and he had killed men who were very good with that cut before they had understood it was coming.

The boy was not there.

The boy's left sword had taken the cut and turned it and the right was already answering. Raiden took it on his guard. It was heavy. It was faster than it should have been. He went forward again, through it, and the boy met him again, and again, cut for cut, each answer arriving exactly as Raiden's blade arrived, as if the boy were not reacting at all but simply already there.

Raiden had watched him on the Kusatsu road. The boy had been good then. He had taken a man's sword out of the fight in five cuts. He had been very good.

This was not that boy.

This one did not waste anything. There was nothing in his movement that was not movement. No breath held too long. No weight left behind after a turn. And his eyes. Raiden looked into them over the crossed blades for the length of one breath and there was no one there to look back. Only the next cut. And the next. And the one after that, already chosen.

Raiden's eyes narrowed.

He had not expected that.

Something went past them in the air, trailing sparks.

Raiden knew what it was. Everyone in Kōga knew what had happened to Iga's wall. The small wild one. He moved before it landed, back, away, one long step out of the exchange, and the clay ball came down between them on the packed earth and the world went white and loud.

When he could see again, the boy was on one knee, twenty paces off, shaking his head. The small wild one was pulling at his arm. Between them and Raiden, dust and smoke hung in a ragged wall.

Raiden looked at the boy through the gap in it.

Then he turned his back.

He did not run. He had never run from anything. He walked across the courtyard toward the main building, through the smoke, between the wrong shadows, and the Kōga in the courtyard moved out of his way without being told.

At the step he stopped.

He looked back once. Across the courtyard, through the smoke, at the boy getting to his feet.

He waited until the boy's eyes found him.

Then he went inside.

***

Ayame had counted three of them before the smoke closed, and then she had stopped counting, because counting was for people who had time.

Kenshiro was at her left. The wall of the storehouse was at her back. It was a good corner. Master Hanzō had pointed to it on the ridge with one finger, among twenty others, and she had come to it through the fog and taken it and held it, and it was still hers.

Barely.

The pleasant-faced one came at her again. He fought the way he looked. You forgot him while you were looking at him. His blade was always coming from the place she had stopped watching a moment ago. Behind him, heavier, older, came a man in a dark blue robe who did not need to be introduced. Takeru. Kōga itself, in one body. And at Kenshiro's side a third, quick and hard and silent, a man who fought the way a door slams.

Three. Two of them. A storehouse wall.

Kenshiro took a cut on the forearm and did not make a sound. Ayame took one on the thigh and did.

They held.

They did not win. They did not try to. Master Hanzō had not told them to win. He had told them to hold the corner, and the corner was held, and as long as it was held the Kōga could not come around the back of the storehouse into the middle of the courtyard where the others were.

A lamp moved on a paper wall behind the pleasant-faced man, and his shadow went the wrong way, and for half a breath Ayame watched the shadow.

His blade came from where the shadow was not.

She got her own in front of it. Barely.

Barely was enough. Barely was all Master Hanzō had ever asked.

***

Shigure could not finish it.

He had known he would not be able to from the moment she came out of the smoke. A woman in dark clothes, slender, unhurried, with a long needle in each hand, and eyes that went over him once the way his went over a room, and came to rest on his, and stayed there. Something at the corner of her mouth moved.

He had never seen her. He knew her anyway, the way you know a hand from its writing. Everything that had happened since the house in the capital had her writing on it.

He moved. She had already answered it. He had planned for that, and moved again, into the answer, the way you step into a door you knew would open. She had planned for that too. Her needle came where his next step would go. His next step went somewhere else. She was there.

It went on. It went on and on. Every move he made, she had already answered. Every answer she gave, he had already planned for. Neither of them could get one step past the other, and neither of them could stop, and in the middle of it, in the smoke and the wrong shadows, with the bells going in the empty corridors, he saw her face, and her face was almost smiling.

He knew why. He could feel something at the corner of his own mouth that was trying to do the same.

Behind him, Kurogane.

Not beside him. Everywhere. Kurogane was cutting through everything that came near the two of them. A Kōga came out of the smoke to Shigure's right and was not there anymore. A grey one came at the woman's shoulder, a Fūma, to help her, and was not there anymore either. Kurogane did not choose sides in anything that came near. He only made the space around Shigure and the woman clean, so that the two of them could go on doing the impossible thing they were doing.

And a little way off, at the edge of the courtyard, where the smoke thinned, Hanzō and a man Shigure did not know.

The man was not tall. He wore grey, and a strip of dark cloth over his face, and nothing else that told you what he was. His long blade hung from one hand, point down. He was standing with his weight on one foot, the way a man stands at a market stall deciding whether he wants the fish.

Hanzō was standing across from him. Four paces. Not moving.

Neither of them had moved since Shigure first saw them. Not once. They stood and looked at each other, the one with his hands folded and the one with his blade hanging loose, and the whole fight went on around them like water around two stones. Each of them waiting for the other to be wrong.

The woman's needle came at his eye. Shigure turned his head. It went past.

He did not see what was behind him.

That was the thing. He saw everything, always, all of it at once. He had the whole courtyard in his head, every corner, every shadow, every one of Hanzō's people and where they stood. And he was looking at the woman with the needles, because she was the only thing in the courtyard that could not be looked away from, and at his back there was a space he was not looking at.

Someone else was.

Ren came through the courtyard like a thrown blade. Shigure did not see him come. He heard him. A sound behind him, very close, of steel moving faster than steel should, and a grunt, a woman's, cut off, and something heavy going away from him across the ground.

And a line of fire across the top of his left shoulder.

Shigure turned.

A woman was on the ground ten paces off, curled around herself, holding her side. The short blade was in the dirt beside her. And between Shigure and her, already past, already going, was Ren.

Shigure looked down at his shoulder.

The cloth was open along the top of it, cleanly, a hand's length. Under it, a line. Shallow. It was nothing. It was barely a cut at all. It had begun to bleed, a thin dark thread, and the thread was running down into his sleeve.

He looked at it.

The follow-through. The cut that had taken the woman off his back had gone on after she was gone, one hand's width further than it needed to go. Not much. Almost nothing. The kind of thing that did not happen. Ren's cuts stopped where they were meant to stop. Shigure had watched him train for more than two years and never once seen a blade go a finger's width past where Ren had sent it.

He looked up.

Ren was already gone into the smoke. Toward the main building. He had not stopped. He had not turned his head.

He had not noticed.

Shigure stood there with the thread of blood running down into his sleeve.

He felt eyes on him and knew whose they were before he looked. Kurogane had stopped. For the first time since the gate came down, Kurogane had stopped cutting and was standing in the smoke with his sword low, looking at Shigure's shoulder. Then at the place where Ren had gone.

Kurogane's face did not change. It never did.

But he had noticed.

Across the courtyard, the woman with the needles had stepped back.

She was not fighting anymore. She was standing in the smoke with her hands at her sides, the two needles held loosely, and she was watching the main building. Watching the smoke Ren had gone into.

She could have stopped him. She was closer than anyone. Shigure saw her see him go, and saw her decide, and saw what she decided.

She let him go.

The corner of her mouth moved.

Then she turned back to Shigure, and lifted her needles, and it began again.

Chapter 48

Smoke

Inside the main building, the fighting was far away.

He could still hear it. He could hear all of it. That was the trouble. Every blade in the courtyard. Every foot on the packed earth. A man breathing hard behind a paper wall three rooms off. The bells, still going, in the corridors on the far side of the building, first one and then the other. He heard all of it at once and all of it was very clear and all of it was very far away, as if it were happening in another village, over a hill, to other people.

The corridor was full of smoke.

It came along the ceiling in a slow grey river and hung down from it in rags. Pine resin burning somewhere, sharp and sweet. Wet wood hissing where the fire had found a place the rain had gotten into. His eyes stung. He did not close them. He could see through it well enough. He could see through everything well enough now.

He went where the building told him to go.

It was not hard. It was built the way Takeda's house was built, the way every house of men who kept things was built. The important room at the back. The corridor that went there narrower than the others. The boards that spoke and the boards that did not.

A door. Heavy. Not paper. He put his shoulder to it.

Inside, small and dark and cool, smelling of cedar and old paper. Shelves. Boxes. And on a shelf by itself, with nothing on either side of it, a long box of pale wood.

He did not think about it. He opened it. He took out what was inside, rolled and tied, brown at the edges, and put it inside his robe beside the other one, against his ribs, under the belt Shigure had given him.

Two scrolls.

They were heavier than paper should be. He felt them there, one against the other, pressing on him when he breathed.

He went out.

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He stopped.

He did not decide to stop. His feet stopped under him, on the boards of the corridor, in the smoke, and the rest of him stopped with them.

Raiden.

Standing in the corridor ten paces off, where it opened into a wider room. His sword in his right hand, low, the point toward the floor. His left hand closed on a fistful of cloth.

And in front of him, held up by that fist at the collar, standing because he was being held and because he would not have done anything else, Musashi.

Ren heard everything.

He heard Raiden breathing. Slow. Even. In through the nose and out through the nose, as if he were sitting by a fire.

He heard his own heart. Too fast. Much too fast. It was a sound he did not know. He had heard it go fast before, in fights, on roads. Not like this. It was going like something trying to get out.

He heard a drop fall.

From Musashi's sleeve. The left one. It gathered at the edge of the cloth where the sleeve was torn, dark, and hung there, and let go, and hit the floorboard with a small flat sound he could hear through all the other sounds in the building.

Then another.

Three.

He was counting them. He did not want to count them. He could not stop.

Four.

Musashi's face was bruised along one side, from the temple to the jaw, dark and swollen. His hair had come loose from its tie and hung down on one side. His clothes were torn at the shoulder and the sleeve and dark in places that were not the dye. He was thinner. He was so much thinner. The bones of his face stood up under the skin.

He was standing straight.

Even like this. Even with a fist in his collar and his feet only just on the floor. His back was straight. His shoulders were level. His hands were at his sides, open, still. He stood the way he sat in front of the fire.

Five.

Ren looked down at his own hands.

They were trembling.

Not much. The way a leaf trembles when there is no wind. He looked at them. He told them to stop.

They did not stop.

Raiden spoke.

"Before I arrived..."

A pause. The smoke moved along the ceiling. Somewhere far off, in the other village, a man screamed and stopped.

"He killed six..."

A pause.

"...elite Kōga and Fūma."

Ren kept looking at Musashi.

Six.

The cave.

It came to him all at once, the way the shape of a fight came. The fire burning for no one. The bowls clean on the shelf. The blanket folded. The wooden sword fallen across the stone, with the star in it.

He had crouched there and read it. No blood, he had read. They had not needed to.

He had read it like a child.

There had been no blood because the old man had not needed any. Six of them had come in out of the dark, and he had gotten up from his fire with a wooden sword in his hand, and they had gone down on the floor of the cave one after another. And afterward someone had carried them out, all six, and left the fire burning. And then Raiden had come.

Ren had stood in the mouth of that cave and seen a quiet room. He had not seen any of it.

Musashi coughed.

Once. Short. Dry. Like a stick breaking under a foot.

Raiden's fist did not move.

Then Musashi's eyes moved.

Not to Raiden. Not to the smoke. Not to Ren's face.

To his feet.

Ren felt it. He felt the old man's eyes go down him and stop at his feet on the boards, and stay there, and he knew what they were seeing before he looked down himself.

His weight was too far forward.

He had stopped with it on the balls of his feet, leaning, the way a man stands who is about to run at something. His front knee was too bent. His back heel was off the floor. It was wrong. It was a stance that would carry him forward and could not bring him back. Any child who had stood in the clearing with his legs shaking under a bamboo rod would have known it was wrong.

Musashi saw it.

Even now. With a fist in his collar and the blood coming off his sleeve and six men left behind him on the floor of a cave. His eyes went to Ren's feet and measured them, the way they had measured everything Ren had ever done, the way they had measured the bucket and the water on the path and the wood stacked by the wall.

Ren saw him see it.

And for a moment, less than a moment, he was not in the corridor. He was six years old, in the clearing in front of the cave, with the cold coming up through his sandals and his legs burning and the rod in the old man's hand, and he was waiting. For the tap. Wider. For the word.

It did not come.

Musashi did not say anything. He did not lift a hand. He only looked at Ren's feet a moment longer, and then his eyes came up, slowly, and stopped somewhere below Ren's face. And stayed there.

Behind them, the fire had reached the wall.

Ren heard it go. A long soft rushing, and a crackle, and then the light came. Down the corridor from somewhere behind Raiden, orange and moving, and it came across the room and lay on the floor, and it came up across Musashi's face.

Warm. Moving. The same light.

The same light that had been on that face every morning of Ren's life. Across the ring of stones. In the cave, before the sun, the old man sitting with his hands on his knees and his eyes closed and the fire moving on his face just like this, going up and down, the shadows under the cheekbones coming and going.

Seven.

Raiden did not look at the fire. He did not look at the old man in his hand. He looked at Ren.

"The scrolls."

Ren looked at him.

At Raiden's face, which was calm, and had nothing on it but what was needed. At the sword, low, the point toward the floor. At the fist in Musashi's collar, which had not moved once.

"Return them."

Ren did not answer.

He felt them. Against his ribs. The two of them, one against the other, under Shigure's belt, pressing on him every time he breathed. He breathed, and they pressed.

His hands were still trembling.

Eight.

Ren did not move.

Chapter 49

Burn

The fire moved on Musashi's face.

Up, and down. The shadows under the cheekbones coming and going. The light warm on the forehead, on the closed lids, on the grey at the temples. The old man sitting with his hands on his knees in front of the ring of stones, before the sun, the way he had sat every morning Ren could remember, and the fire going up the rock behind him and the smell of pine and cold stone and the rice pot not yet on.

It was there, in front of him. It was as clear as the corridor.

Then it was the corridor again.

Nobody moved.

Ren did not move. His feet were where they had stopped, too far forward, his back heel off the boards. His hands were at his sides. They were still trembling.

Raiden did not move. His sword was low in his right hand, the point toward the floor. His left fist was in Musashi's collar. It had not moved since Ren came into the corridor.

Musashi did not move. He stood where he was held, straight, his hands open at his sides, his eyes somewhere below Ren's face.

Behind Raiden, in the doorways of the wider room, there were men now. Three. Four. Dark clothes, grey clothes. Ren had not heard them come. They stood in the doorways with their blades out and did not come in. They were looking at Raiden. Waiting to be told.

Nobody told them anything.

The smoke went along the ceiling. The fire went along the wall behind. Somewhere far off, in the other village, the bells had stopped.

Ren felt the scrolls against his ribs. He breathed. They pressed.

Raiden was looking at him.

He had been looking at him the whole time. Ren knew that. But now it was different. Something in Raiden's face had come to rest. Not much. The way a stone that has been rolling settles into the place it is going to stay. He looked at Ren's hands, which were trembling. He looked at Ren's feet, which were wrong. He looked at Ren's face.

He had asked twice. He was not going to ask again.

"You hesitate."

The words came quietly. There was nothing in them. No anger. No scorn. The way a man says what the weather is.

Ren heard the fire.

"That's why people die."

Ren heard his own heart.

A drop came off Musashi's sleeve and hung, and let go. Ren did not count it.

Raiden looked at him a moment longer.

"I don't."

And Ren was in the cave.

The fire in the ring of stones. The old man in front of it. Not looking at the fire. Looking at him. The light moving on his face, up and down, warm, and the voice, the one time, at the mouth of the cave in the dark with the swords through his sash —

Raiden's arm moved.

That was all. Ren saw it the way he saw everything now, all of it, very clear and very far away. The sword came up from where it had been hanging, low, as if it had always been going to come up, as if it had only been waiting at the bottom of its arc to finish it. It went in under the ribs on the left side. It came out.

Raiden let go of the collar.

Musashi stood for a moment without being held.

Then he did not.

He went down onto the boards the way a robe goes down when it slips off a peg. No sound. No word. His eyes were still open. They were still looking at the place below Ren's face where they had been looking. They did not move from it. They did not come up.

The fire moved on his face.

Silence.

Nothing in the corridor made a sound. Not the men in the doorways. Not the smoke. Not Raiden, who stood with his sword at his side and a dark line running down it to the point, and did not look down.

Ren did not breathe.

He did not know how long. There was no way to know. The fire moved on the wall and on the ceiling and on the old man's face on the floor, and nothing else moved anywhere in the world.

Don't hesitate.

It was the old man's voice. It was Raiden's.

It was the same.

***

Ren did not decide anything.

There was nothing in him to decide it. There was a sound, and he did not know that it was coming out of him, and then the boards were going past under him and both swords were out and he was on Raiden.

He cut.

Not a cut. Not anything with a name. His arms went and the swords went with them, left, right, left, down, across, as fast as they could be made to go and faster, and none of them went anywhere. None of them had a place they were going. There was no ground under him. There was no line from his feet to his hands. His weight was everywhere it should not be, forward and forward and forward, and every step he took carried him on past where the cut ended, and he did not care, and he cut again.

Raiden was not there.

He was a pace to the left. He was a pace back. He was turning, and the swords went through where he had been turning. He did not hurry. He did not raise his blade to meet anything. He only moved a little, each time, the way a man moves his head to let a fly go past, and the swords went past.

Ren screamed at him. He did not know what. It was not words.

Something struck his face.

The hilt. Raiden's hilt, backhand, across the cheekbone, and the corridor went white on one side. Ren did not feel it. He came back through it and cut and Raiden was not there and something hit him in the ribs, low, the flat of a foot, and the breath went out of him and he did not need it. He cut. He cut. A line of fire opened across the top of his forearm, shallow, a warning and nothing more, and he did not look at it.

The wall came up beside him. A post. He did not see it.

He brought the old sword down with everything he had left, two hands, over his head, the way a man chops wood, the way no one had ever taught him and the old man would have taken the rod to him for, and Raiden stepped aside from it, and it went into the post.

It bit deep. It stuck.

Ren pulled.

Raiden's sword came down on the flat of it, close to the guard.

It made a sound Ren had never heard. High, and short, and wrong. Like a bell struck with a stone.

The blade broke.

Ren stood there with the hilt in his hand. The black cord, shiny with use. The plain iron guard. A hand's width of steel standing out of it, and then nothing. The rest was in the post. It hung there, quivering, the grey of it catching the fire.

He looked at it.

Raiden's foot took him in the chest.

The boards came up and struck his back. His head went against them. The ceiling was above him, full of smoke, orange and moving. He could not get the breath back into himself. The hilt was still in his hand. His other sword was somewhere. He did not know where.

He turned his head.

The old man was lying on the boards an arm's length away. His face toward Ren. His eyes open. The fire on his face.

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Feet in the corridor.

Behind Ren. A great many of them, and fast. The boards spoke under them, the ones that spoke and the ones that should not have. Someone shouted his name. Hayate. Someone else, very close, did not shout anything at all.

In the doorways of the wider room, the men in dark and grey were stepping back. One and then another. Not running. Going back into the smoke the way they had come out of it, the way water goes back down the sand. Nobody had told them to. They went.

Ren lay on the boards and saw Raiden's feet.

They had not moved.

Past them, the room was emptying. Behind Ren, the corridor was filling. He heard Kurogane. He did not hear him; he knew he was there, the way you know where a wall is in the dark. He heard Enji breathing hard, high, like a dog after a run. He heard the long even steps of a man who did not hurry anywhere, and knew whose they were.

Raiden was alone.

Ren saw him understand it. Nothing on his face changed. His sword was at his side, with the dark line on it.

He looked down at Ren.

For a long moment. The way he had looked at him across the courtyard, through the gap in the smoke, before he went inside.

Then he looked up. Past Ren. Down the corridor, over Ren's head, at someone standing there. Ren did not have to turn to know who it was. Hanzō, neither fast nor slow.

Raiden looked at him.

Then he turned, and went into the smoke, and was gone.

Nobody went after him.

The fire came along the wall. It came across the ceiling. It lay down on the boards and on the old man's face and on the broken steel standing in the post, and Ren lay on his back with the hilt in his hand and looked at the smoke, and did not get up.

Chapter 50

Home

By morning Kōga was smoke.

It lay in the valley the way the fog had lain the night before, low and grey, filling the folds of the hills. The tall roof on the rise was gone. Where it had been there were black posts standing up out of the smoke, and some of them were still burning, small and orange, like the ends of incense sticks. Nobody was putting them out. There was nobody left to.

Ren sat in the wet grass on the slope above the wall.

He did not remember coming out. He remembered the corridor, and the ceiling full of smoke, and then he remembered the grass, and in between there was the weight of the old man in his arms, very light, much lighter than he should have been, and the heat on his back, and the boards and then the stone and then the earth under his feet. He did not remember any of it. He only knew it had happened, because the old man was lying in the grass beside him now, under someone's cloak, and Ren's arms still felt the shape of him.

The sword Shigure had given him was in his sash. Someone had found it on the floor and put it back in his hand, and he had put it there. The other scabbard held the broken one. The hilt, and a hand's width of steel, and the rest of the scabbard empty.

The others were around him. Not close. Karasu on one side, sitting in the grass, black with smoke to the eyes. Hanzō's people on the other, standing, the way they always stood, where they had been put. Nobody was talking. One of Hanzō's men had his forearm bound in a strip of someone's sleeve. Ayame was not there. Jin was not there.

They came up the slope together as the light came.

They came out of the smoke at the bottom of the hill and up through the wet grass, not fast. Ayame was limping. Jin's face was black and his eyes were very red in it. They came to where Hanzō was standing, and stopped, and Jin bowed.

"Master Hanzō."

Hanzō waited.

Jin looked at the ground. Then back up.

"We looked everywhere."

Nobody said anything. Ren heard the posts cracking down in the valley.

"They must've fled with it."

It was against Ren's ribs.

He felt it there, under Shigure's belt, rolled and tied and brown at the edges, pressed against the other one. He had felt it all night. He felt it now, while Jin said the words, and he did not move, and his face did not do anything, and he did not know whether that was because he was hiding it or because there was nothing left in him that could have moved his face.

Hanzō did not look at him.

He looked at Jin for a moment, and then at the smoke in the valley, and then he nodded once, as if Jin had told him something he had already known, and Jin stepped back.

Ren stood up.

He put his hand inside his robe and found the one wrapped in oiled cloth, the one that had come out of Iga, and drew it out. Only that one. The other stayed where it was.

He walked across the grass to Hanzō and held it out.

Hanzō looked at it. Then at Ren's face.

It was the same look as in the forest, when Ren had been lying in the leaves. Weighing. Ren let it weigh him. There was nothing in him for it to find.

Hanzō took the scroll.

He did not open it. He did not look to see that it was what it should be. He held it a moment in both hands, the way you hold a thing that is heavier than it looks, and then he put it away inside his own robe, and that was the end of it. He had said he would help them. He had brought his people across the stubble and through the gate and into the corners, and held the corners, and one of his people had not come back from the corners. He had done what he said. He did not ask for more than he had been promised. He did not say anything about the old man under the cloak.

He bowed.

Not deeply. The way a man bows to another man across a board, when the game is finished.

Then he turned, and lifted two fingers, and his people went with him. Down the far side of the slope, away from the valley, into the trees. They did not look back. In a little while there was nothing on that side of the hill but the flattened grass where they had been standing.

Hayate was looking at Ren.

Ren did not look back. He looked at the cloak in the grass.

After a while Shigure stood up. Then Kurogane. Then Enji, slowly, and last of all Hayate. They stood there. Shigure looked at Ren for a long moment. Then at the cloak. Then he turned and went down the slope the other way, toward the road, and the others went after him, one by one, and Hayate went last, and stopped once, and then went on.

Ren stayed.

***

He built it himself.

There was a stand of cedar at the top of the slope and deadfall under it, dry at the heart where the rain had not reached. He carried it out of the trees an armful at a time and laid it the way the old man had taught him to lay a fire. The long pieces at the bottom. Crossed. Then the next layer the other way. Then the next. So that the air could come up through it. So that it would burn clean.

It took most of the day.

When it was high enough he went back to the cloak and knelt and lifted the old man, and he was still very light, and Ren carried him up the slope and laid him on the wood. He straightened his robe. He put his hands where they went. On his knees, almost, the way they had always been. His face was grey. It was only a face.

Ren took out the flint.

Two strikes.

It caught.

He sat down in the grass a little way off and watched it.

It went slowly at first, in the kindling at the bottom, feeling its way, and then it found the cedar and went up all at once, with a sound like a breath drawn in, and the heat came across the grass and pushed at his face. He did not move back from it. The smoke went up straight. There was no wind.

He sat there.

The sun went down behind the hills and the fire was brighter than the sky. It went on burning. The stars came out over it, and it went on burning. He did not get up. He did not eat. When the wood at the edges fell in, he got up and pushed it back with a branch, and sat down again.

Somewhere in the night it stopped being a fire and became a bed of coals, red, breathing, and the dark came in close around it.

Then the red went out of the coals, one place and then another, the way lamps go out in a town.

When the sun came up over the valley, there was nothing on the top of the slope but a low grey shape in the grass, soft, still warm. Ash. The morning wind came across the hill and lifted a little of it and carried it away over the trees.

Ren watched it go.

***

He found them on the road in the afternoon.

They had stopped at a place where a stream crossed under the road, and they were sitting on the bank, and they all looked up when he came out of the trees. Nobody said anything. Enji started to get up and then sat back down.

Ren sat on the bank a little way from the others and took off his sandals and put his feet in the water. It was very cold. He did not feel it.

Hayate was looking at him.

Ren could feel it. He did not have to look. Hayate had looked at him that way at the mouth of the cave, and on the ridge above Kōga, and every time since. As if Ren were a thing that had been dropped and Hayate was waiting to see whether it had cracked.

Nothing about him was different. He knew that. He had washed his face in the stream. He had tied his hair. His swords were in his sash. He walked the same way. He sat the same way.

Hayate kept looking.

When they went on, Ren walked where he always walked, second from the front, behind Shigure. When Enji asked if anyone had any of the dried persimmon left, Ren did not answer, and when Enji asked him directly, Ren shook his head. That was all he said all afternoon.

It was not very different from other days. He had never talked much.

Hayate knew the difference. Ren could feel him knowing it, walking behind.

***

That night they made a fire in a hollow off the road, under an old oak.

Ren did not make it. Kurogane made it. Ren sat on a root at the edge of it and watched Kurogane lay the wood, the long pieces first, and strike the flint, three strikes, four, and blow on it, and it caught.

They sat around it. The same places. Shigure on Ren's left. Hayate on his right, and Enji beyond him. Kurogane across.

Nobody talked.

It was heavy. The quiet. It sat on all of them like wet clothes. Enji turned a stick in the edge of the fire and did not look up from it. Kurogane cleaned his sword, slowly, over and over, the way he did when there was nothing to clean. Hayate looked at the fire and then at Ren and then at the fire.

Shigure opened the bundle of food and passed it around.

Everyone ate except Ren.

He sat with his eyes on the fire. He was looking at it. He was not seeing it.

Shigure reached beside him, took one piece of rice pressed with fish, and held it out.

Ren did not look at it.

A moment passed.

Shigure kept his hand there.

Ren shook his head once.

Shigure lowered his hand.

No one spoke.

Ren stood.

No one spoke.

He turned, and walked out of the light, under the oak and past it, into the dark. Behind him, someone moved. The sound of cloth. Someone getting up.

His feet stopped. He did not tell them to.

He looked back.

From the dark, they were very clear. The fire in the middle and the four of them around it, lit, orange, the way people look from outside a house at night. Hayate was halfway up, on one knee, his face turned toward the place where Ren had gone.

Shigure's hand was on his sleeve.

Hayate looked at him.

Shigure did not look back. He kept his eyes on the fire.

"Not now, Hayate."

Hayate looked toward the dark. Toward Ren. He looked for a long time at the place where Ren was standing and did not see him.

Then, slowly, he sat back down.

Ren turned and walked on into the dark.

***

He walked all night, and all the next day.

He did not decide where he was going. His feet knew the way. Off the road, and up, through country that got steeper and colder, and then onto a path he had not walked since the maples were red at the edges. They were red all the way through now. Some of them were already bare. The chestnut husks on the path had gone black.

The river. The four stones. He crossed them. One. Two. Three. Four.

The cherry tree, bare.

The clearing.

He did not look at the dark places in the earth. He went around them.

The cave mouth was a black shape in the grey rock, the way it had always been. He came up to it.

Something moved inside.

A crow came out of the dark, all at once, low over his head, so close he felt the wind of its wings on his face. It went up into the grey sky and away down the valley, calling once, and did not come back.

He went in.

***

Everything was where it should be.

That was the first thing. That was the thing that was wrong.

The bench against the wall, where the old man had sat every morning and watched him train in the clearing. The stack of wood, split and dried and laid in order, the long pieces at the bottom and the kindling on top. The ring of stones.

The fire was out.

It had been out a long time. There was nothing in the ring but ash, grey, fine, settled flat, with a few black ends of wood lying in it that had not burned all the way through. He had fed that fire himself for days, with the scroll on his knees, and never once looked down into it. No warmth came off it. He could have put his hand in it.

He did not.

He stood and looked at it.

The old man had built that fire every morning. Every morning of Ren's life. It could have burned for days, the way he laid it. He could have fed it a log at night and blown on it in the morning. He never did. Every morning, before Ren woke, the ring was swept clean and the new fire laid in it. Ren had never once seen what was in the ring before that. He had never once seen it like this.

This was what had been in it. Every morning. The old man had cleared it away in the dark, every morning for eleven years, so that it would never be the first thing a boy saw when he woke.

Ren had thought the fire was simply there in the mornings, the way the light was there. He had thought it was a thing that happened.

It was not a thing that happened. It was the old man.

The sword rack against the wall was empty.

The pegs. Nothing on them. The lacquer marks on the wood where the scabbards had rested for years, darker than the rest.

He looked at it for a long time.

Against the far wall, the wooden swords. One standing, perfectly straight, not a finger's width out of true. The other still lying on the floor where it had fallen, across the stone, at an angle, with the dark iron in it.

He did not pick it up.

He went through the cave slowly. He did not touch anything. He looked. The broom in its corner. The water jar with its lid on. The place on the floor in front of the fire, worn smooth and a little hollow, where a man had sat so long the stone had given way to him. Everything folded. Everything swept. Everything put where it went, and nothing, nothing at all, out of its place, except the one wooden sword on the floor.

He had never understood it. The order. The same bowl on the same shelf. The same sandals by the same wall. He had thought the old man was only like that. He had thought it was the way a stone is the shape it is.

It was not. The old man had done it. Every day. With his hands. Without saying one word about it, for eleven years, he had put every single thing back where it went, and then he had sat down in front of the fire and let Ren see that it could be done.

The cave was full of him.

It was full of him and he was not in it. Both at once. Ren stood in the middle of it and could not tell which was worse.

***

Further in, where the cave went back into the rock and the light from the mouth did not reach, was the shelf they had built.

Two boards on two uprights. Pegged. No iron in it anywhere. He had cut every peg himself, with the old man on his bench saying *Loose*, and once *Hm*, and nothing had gone on it the first night.

Something was on it now.

A bundle. Long. Folded over and over on itself and laid on the lower board, square to the edge, under the two bowls.

He knew the cloth before he touched it. Brown. Coarse. Darned at one corner with thread that did not match, where he had put his foot through it when he was seven. It had been on him every night, in the cold months, for years. He had not thought about it since he left. He had not thought about it once.

He lifted it down.

It was heavy. Heavier than a blanket.

He knelt and laid it on the floor and opened it. Fold by fold. The way he had opened the grey cloth, once, a long time ago, in front of the fire, with the old man not looking.

A sword.

The long one from the rack. Black scabbard. The lacquer worn at the mouth where the old man's hand had held it. The cord on the hilt dark and smooth with use, the guard plain iron. He had seen it on the rack every day of his life, and he had seen it in the old man's sash when they went down to the village, and he had seen it drawn against a man only once.

It had been wrapped carefully. The blanket folded around it twice, and tucked, and folded again.

Under the sword, under the last fold of the blanket, flat, there were papers.

He took them out.

They were his.

Grey smears. Water pulled through ink until it softened and bled. Rain, most of them. The rain at the cave mouth, the first time, when he had not known what to paint and the old man had told him to paint what he saw. The trees across the clearing in the rain. The river. A bowl. One that was only the fire, black on grey, badly, the ink run where he had used too much water.

He had thought they were thrown away. He had thought they had gone into the fire years ago, the way paper went.

The old man had kept every one.

Ren knelt on the floor of the cave with the papers in his hands.

It was not like finding a sword. He had found swords. It was like opening a box and finding the house inside it. The whole of it. Every morning, folded small.

He sat there for a long time.

Then he put the papers back, flat, the way they had been.

He stood up. He took the broken sword out of his sash. The hilt, the black cord, the hand's width of steel. He looked at it. Then he crossed to the empty rack and laid it on the lower pegs, where the old man's short sword had been, and left it there.

He picked up the long sword out of the blanket and put it through his sash in its place.

It settled at his hip. It weighed what it weighed. On the other side, the sword Shigure had held out to him across his palms in the lamplight, the grey steel with the pattern in it like mist lying on water, the one that had been very old and of the highest quality and that the dead lord would not need.

One on each side.

He put a hand on each hilt. A thumb against each guard.

***

He went back to the fire.

He sat down against the cave wall beside the ring of stones, in the place across from the worn hollow in the floor, where he had always sat. He pulled the old blanket around his shoulders. It smelled of the cave. Of smoke and cold rock and pine.

He looked at the ash.

It lay in the ring of stones, grey and fine and flat, and did not move.

He did not move either.

Chapter 51

Challenge

It was Hayate's idea.

Ren knew that without being told. He had come down off the mountain on the fourth day with the blanket rolled on his back and the old man's sword at his hip, and they had been waiting for him at the bottom of the path, all four of them, sitting on the stones by the river as if they had only stopped there a moment ago. Nobody asked where he had been. Enji looked at the new sword and opened his mouth and Shigure looked at Enji and he closed it again.

Two days later, on the road, Hayate said there was a festival in the town below the pass, and that he had not eaten anything grilled on a stick in half a year, and that if he did not eat something grilled on a stick soon he would die of it, and that they would all have to carry him, and he was heavy.

Nobody argued. Ren understood that nobody was supposed to.

So they went down into the town.

***

It was full.

Lanterns on every eave, red and white, strung across the street on ropes so that the whole length of it was roofed with them. Drums somewhere, two of them, answering each other. Smoke from the stalls, and the smell of it, soy and syrup and charcoal and roasting chestnuts. Children running under everyone's elbows with masks pushed up on their heads, foxes and old men and red-faced demons. And everywhere, among the townspeople in their good clothes, men with two swords.

Many of them. More than Ren had seen in one place since the lord's castle. In pairs, in fours, strolling, laughing, their topknots oiled, their hilts set just so. On the big lanterns at the shrine gate, painted large, the same crest over and over: three leaves inside a ring.

Shigure saw it too. Ren saw him see it, and count, and put it away.

They bought things. Hayate bought everything. Rice cakes toasted on a stick and brushed with something sweet and dark. Little river fish grilled on skewers. A paper of roasted chestnuts that he held out to each of them in turn, and to Ren last, and Ren took one because Hayate was still holding it out. It was hot. He held it in his hand until it was not hot anymore.

Enji bought a mask. A fox. He put it on and took it off and put it on again and looked at them through the eyeholes and laughed.

In front of the shrine there was a stage. Boards on trestles, a painted cloth hung at the back, pine branches tied to the posts. Players on it, two of them, a master and his servant, and the servant was drunk and the master did not know it, and every time the master turned his back the servant drank more out of the master's own jar. The crowd in front of the stage was thick and loud and laughing. Karasu found a place on a bench toward the back, under the eaves of a teahouse, and sat.

Ren sat on the end.

He watched the stage. The servant drank. The master turned around. The servant hid the jar behind his back and smiled with his whole face, and the crowd roared.

Ren did not laugh. He did not not laugh. He watched.

Beside him, Hayate had his legs stretched out and his arms folded and a long thin needle between his teeth, working it slowly along the gums, the way another man would use a twig. Every so often he took it out and looked at the end of it and put it back.

Enji was laughing. Really laughing. Kurogane was not, but he was watching the stage and not the crowd, which for Kurogane was the same thing. Shigure had his hands in his sleeves and his eyes half closed.

It was warm under the eaves. The drums went on. The servant fell off the stage, and climbed back on, and the master had not noticed.

Behind Ren, somebody spoke.

"Which one is Musashi's boy?"

Ren did not move.

Everything in him moved. All at once, the whole of him, from the soles of his feet to the top of his head, the way the fire had gone up the cedar when it found the dry wood. It was not a thought. It was a heat. It came up through him and filled him and there was no room left in him for anything else.

His hands were on his knees. They did not close. He kept them from closing.

Beside him the needle stopped moving in Hayate's mouth.

Ren did not look at him. He felt it. Hayate had heard it too, and Hayate had looked at him, and whatever Hayate saw had made him take the needle out of his teeth.

They turned around.

Men. Six of them, seven, standing in the lane behind the bench, in good clothes, with good swords. Young, most of them. One older at the front, not old, forty perhaps, broad in the shoulder, with a long face and a long sword, longer than the others, worn on his back. One at the side with a spear, the shaft upright, its blade sheathed in black. They had been drinking. Not much. Enough.

The one at the front looked along the bench. At Enji, in his fox mask. At Kurogane. At Shigure. At Hayate. At Ren.

His eyes stopped at Ren. At the two hilts. Both long.

"You," he said.

Ren looked at him.

"I'm a disciple of Sasaki Kojirō."

He said the name the way men say the names of gods. Some of the people on the next bench turned around.

"You know the name. Of course you know it. Everybody knows it, because of him. Because of your master." He said the word as if it were something he had stepped in. "Thirty years ago. The island. My master had waited on the shore since morning, dressed, ready, as a man should be. And your master came when he pleased. Hours late. In a boat. Unshaven, with a rag around his head. With an oar he had carved on the way over, like a fisherman. And he struck him down with it on the sand, and got back in his boat, and left him there. Left him lying there. Never came back. Never once answered for it."

He was speaking louder now. People were turning. On the stage the players had stopped.

"I went to find him. Three times I went looking. Up every mountain in this country. He hid from me. He hid in a hole in the rocks like an animal and let the years do his work for him."

He smiled.

"I heard Musashi is dead."

Ren heard the drums. Somewhere far away. In another town.

"So you will have to pay for it and join him in death."

Ren stood up.

He did not decide to. He was sitting and then he was standing, and the bench scraped behind him, and the heat in him was all the way to his hands now, and his hands were on his hilts.

Beside him, the bench scraped again. And again. Hayate. Shigure. Kurogane, all at once, like something unfolding. Enji last, pushing the fox mask up onto his head.

Five of them. Standing.

In the lane, the samurai's hands went to their swords. All of them. The sound of it, six hands on six hilts, a soft hard rustle. The one with the spear brought it down from upright and leveled it, and his thumb went to the black sheath on the blade.

Something went past Ren's ear.

It made no sound. There was only a small flat knock, like a knuckle on a door, and the man with the spear looked down.

A needle was standing in the wooden shaft of his spear. A hand's width below his fingers. Driven in so deep that only the last of it showed, still trembling.

The man did not move his thumb.

Ren turned his head.

Hayate was standing with his right hand still out, low, open, the way it had come to rest after the throw. His face was one Ren had never seen on him. Not in the forest. Not at Iga. Not on the mountain, when Ren had knelt on his chest. There was nothing loose in it. Nothing laughing. It was white, and very still, and his eyes were on the man with the spear and then on the man next to him and then on the next, one after another, the way a man counts coins.

"Anyone else moves," said Hayate, "slaughter them all."

Nobody moved.

***

The man with the long sword did not look at the spear. He did not look at Hayate. He was looking at Ren.

He reached over his shoulder and drew.

It was very long. Longer than any sword Ren had seen in a man's hand. It came out of the scabbard on his back in one smooth pull, over his shoulder and down, and the lantern light ran along it the whole of its length.

The crowd pulled back. It went back all at once, like water from a dropped stone, and there was a space in the lane, and the two of them were in it.

Ren drew.

Both. The old man's sword in his left hand. Shigure's in his right.

The man came in.

He was good. Ren knew it from the first step. He had trained a long time, with that sword, with a man who had been very good, and he had trained for this, for exactly this, for thirty years, and it was in every part of him. The long blade came at Ren's head from farther away than a blade should be able to come. Ren went under it. It came back, a flat cut, fast, turning in the air the way a swallow turns, and Ren took it on the old man's sword and felt the weight of it go all the way to his shoulder.

The man stepped back. Came in again. The long sword kept Ren away from him. That was the whole of it. The length. Wherever Ren went, the point was there first, a hand's width farther than it should have been, and Ren could not get inside it. He went left and the point was there. He went right and it was there. It cut his sleeve. It cut the skin above his knee.

Ren did not feel it.

He heard the man breathing. Hard now. He heard the crowd. He heard, somewhere, a child crying.

Your master came when he pleased.

Like an animal.

Join him.

The heat came up in him again, and this time there was nothing to keep it from his hands.

The long sword came at him, the flat turning cut, the swallow's cut, and Ren did not go under it and did not go away from it. He went into it. The old man's sword met it and held it and turned it, and Ren's body was already past the point, inside, where the long sword could not come, where the man's face was. The man's eyes went wide.

Shigure's sword came across.

Level. From the right. At the height of the man's eyes.

It did not stop.

For a moment the man stood there. Then the top of his head was not there anymore. Everything above his nose. It went away from him, sideways, into the lane, and what was left of him stood a moment longer with the long sword still in his hands, and then his knees went, and he folded down onto the ground.

Nobody screamed.

Not at first. The lane was perfectly quiet. The drums had stopped. The lanterns swung a little on their ropes. Then, somewhere at the back of the crowd, a woman began to scream, and then everyone was.

Ren stood over the man.

Shigure's sword was in his hand. It was dark to the guard. It had gone through bone and not felt it. He looked at it. He did not feel anything about it. He did not feel anything at all except the heat, which had not gone out. Which had not gone anywhere.

The other samurai had not moved. Not one of them. The one with the spear was staring at the needle in his shaft. None of them looked at what was lying in the lane.

***

Shouting. At the end of the street. Then at the other end. The hard clack of wooden clappers, the town watch.

Feet. Many of them, running, in step. The crowd broke apart in front of them, screaming, and through the gap came men in dark coats, and lanterns on poles above them with the crest painted on the paper. Three leaves inside a ring. Staves. Spears. Iron truncheons with a hook at the guard. More of them behind, and more, coming down the lane from both ends, and the space around Ren closed into a ring.

Ren turned to face them.

Both swords up. The old man's in his left hand, clean. Shigure's in his right, dark to the guard. He looked at them. At the staves and the spears and the hooked truncheons. At the faces over them.

He did not see faces. He saw where each of them would be.

"Ren! Time to go!"

Hayate. From behind him. From very far away.

Ren did not move. He looked at the ring of men. The heat was in his hands. It wanted them. It did not care which.

"REN!"

It came through.

Not the words. The voice. Hayate's voice, cracked, too loud, the way it had never once sounded in all the time Ren had known him.

Ren turned his head.

Hayate was standing at the end of the bench with his hand out toward him. Not reaching. Just out. His face was white. He was not angry anymore. He was something else.

Ren looked at him.

Something moved at the edge of the lane, to the left. Enji. The fox mask pushed up on his head, his arm going back and forward, and a clay ball went over the heads of the crowd trailing sparks and came down on the packed earth between the men with the crest and Karasu.

The street went white and loud.

When Ren could see again, the air was full of dust and falling lantern paper, and the ring of men had broken, and something small and round was rolling at his feet, hissing. Another beside it. Another. Shigure was walking past him, not fast, dropping them one after another from his sleeve the way a man drops seed, and the grey smoke came up out of them thick and fast and bitter and filled the lane from wall to wall.

A hand closed on Ren's arm.

Kurogane.

He did not pull. He only held on, and walked, and Ren's feet went with him.

Into the smoke. Out of the lane. Between two houses, over a fence, through a garden where the lanterns had been hung in the trees and the paper was burning. Behind them the clappers, and the shouting, and a long way back, the crowd still screaming.

Ren looked down as they went.

Shigure's sword was still in his hand. Still dark.

He had not wiped it. He did not know how long he had been holding it like that.

Chapter 52

Mind

The fog came every morning now and did not always go.

It came up off the river before light and lay in the valley and climbed the slopes, and some days by noon it had burned off and the hills stood up red and brown and bare, and some days it stayed. The last leaves were coming down. The maples were sticks. In the mornings there was frost on the thatch of the hut, and the water in the bucket by the door had a skin on it that broke when Ren put his hand in.

It was a charcoal-burner's hut, high up, empty for the season, with a kiln behind it gone cold and a path down through the cedars to the river. Shigure had found it. Nobody had asked how. After the town, they had needed somewhere nobody would think to look, and nobody would think to look here.

They had been there eight days.

Ren was with them. He ate when food was put in front of him, most days. He sat at the fire in his place. He trained in the flat ground behind the kiln, alone, before light. He did the things he did.

He was not with them very much.

Nobody knew about the scroll.

It was in the blanket. The old blanket, the brown one, darned at the corner. He kept it rolled at the back of the hut where he slept, against the wall, with the scroll inside it, wrapped in the middle of the roll where nobody's hand would find it unless they unrolled the whole thing. Nobody would. It was an old blanket. It was his.

He slept on top of it, most nights. He did not sleep much.

***

He could not sleep.

The others were asleep. He could hear them. Kurogane, who breathed so quietly you had to know he was there. Enji, who talked a little in his sleep, words that were not words. Hayate turning over. Shigure, who slept the way he did everything, and made no sound at all.

Ren lay on his back and looked at the dark where the roof was.

He was in the corridor.

He did not go there. He was there. He was always there, when he closed his eyes and sometimes when he did not. The smoke along the ceiling. The fire on the wall. The old man's face.

The sword coming up from where it had been hanging.

He made himself go past it. He made himself go on, to after. To the part where he had both swords out and Raiden was in front of him.

He went through it. Every cut.

Left. Raiden was not there.

Right. Raiden was not there.

Down, across, the two swords together. Raiden was not there. Raiden was a pace back, a pace to the side, turning, the swords going through the place he had been.

He went through it again. Slower. Every cut, one at a time, the way the old man had made him go through a form when a step was wrong, until he could find the step.

And he found it.

Raiden had not been faster.

That was the thing. Ren had been fast. He had been faster than he had ever been, faster than he knew how to be, faster than was any use. And Raiden had not been faster than that. He had not needed to be.

He had been earlier.

Every time. Before the cut. Before the swords had started to move. Raiden had moved and then the cut had come and he had not been there, and it looked like speed from the outside, and it was not speed. He had gone to the place the cut would not reach before the cut knew where it was going.

He had not been watching Ren's swords. He had not been watching Ren's body.

He had been reading what Ren was about to do.

Ren lay very still.

Since the cave, he had been sharp. He could feel it every morning behind the kiln, in his feet and his hands, the way the body did what it was told before it was told, the way nothing was wasted. He was better than he had been in the spring. He was better than he had been at Iga.

It would not be enough. Not against that. He could make his body as sharp as a body could be made, and cut as fast as a cut could go, and Raiden would already be somewhere else. Because it did not matter how fast the body was, if the man in front of you was reading the thing behind the body.

He would never touch him.

He lay in the dark and knew it, the way he knew the cold.

Unless.

***

He got up without making a sound. He took the blanket.

Outside the fog was down on the slope, thick, white, grey where the dark came through it. He went down the path through the cedars by feel. The roots. The step of rock. The place where the path turned and you had to put your hand on the trunk.

The river.

It was wide here, and slow, and the fog lay right on it, so that the water came out from under the white and went back under it again and you could not see the other bank. The stones along the edge were cold and wet. He sat on one.

Above him, the clouds moved. The moon came through them, low and white, and the fog on the water went silver, all of it at once. Then the clouds closed, and it went grey again.

He unrolled the blanket on his knees.

The scroll.

Brown at the edges. Tied. It had come out of a pale wood box on a shelf by itself, in a room that smelled of cedar, in a building that was not there anymore. He had carried it against his ribs out of the smoke, beside the other one. He had carried it past Jin, and past Hanzō, and past everyone. He had not opened it.

He untied it.

The moon came through again, and it was enough to read by.

He read.

It did not hurt.

He waited for it. He had read the other one in front of the fire in the cave, and the pain had come at the first line and grown with every line after, deep and nowhere and everywhere, the pain of a bone being set. He had read through it. He knew how. He sat on the cold stone with the scroll open on his knees and waited for it to come.

It did not come.

There was no pain. His hands did not shake. His breath went in and out. The words did not pull at him, the way the words of the other had pulled, down and down like water down a slope. They only opened. One behind the other. Like doors. He read one and it opened, and there was the next one behind it, and he read that and it

opened, and there was another behind that, and the doors went back and back into a place he could not see the end of.

That was what was wrong with it.

He knew it was wrong. He did not know how he knew. The other one had hurt. This one did not hurt at all.

He read on.

It was not about the body. The other one had been the body. How to stand, how to breathe, how to be where the blade was not. This was not that. This was the other man. What he wanted. Where his eyes went before his hands did. How a man's mind showed on him before his mind had finished deciding, the way the weather shows in the grass before the wind gets there. How to see it. How to see it before he did.

How to see not the one thing he would do, but all the things he could.

The moon came and went. The fog lay on the water. Ren read.

He read until the moon was gone, and the clouds were grey and flat all the way across, and the river was the only sound.

He rolled it. He tied it. He wrapped it in the blanket.

On the path back up, in the cedars, a crow called.

From the trees to his left. Close. Loud in the fog.

He turned his head to the left.

The crow was on the right.

On a low branch, a few paces off, black against the grey. It looked at him with one eye. Then it turned its head and looked at him with the other.

He stood on the path and looked at it.

It had called from the left. He had heard it on the left.

The crow opened its wings and went up into the fog and was gone.

***

Hayate wanted to spar.

He said it in the morning, over the rice, the way he said most things, loudly, to everyone, as if it had only just occurred to him. He had not done anything in eight days but eat and sleep and complain about the cold, and he was going soft, and look, he could pinch it. He pinched something at his side. Enji laughed.

Ren looked at him across the fire.

Hayate was not looking at him. Hayate was looking at his rice. But he had said it for Ren, and Ren knew it.

"Hm."

They went out behind the kiln, onto the flat ground, with two lengths of green bamboo cut to the length of a sword. The fog had thinned. The others came out and sat on the woodpile to watch. Enji with his knees up. Kurogane with his arms folded. Shigure a little apart.

Hayate bounced on his feet. Rolled his shoulders. Grinned, and told Ren not to hurt him, because he was delicate.

He came in.

Ren saw it.

Not the one thing. Three of them. All at once, laid over each other like three drawings on thin paper held up to the light. Hayate going left, the feint, the bamboo going out wide and his weight going with it. Hayate going left and then not, turning back, the real cut coming low from the right. Hayate going left and then stopping, and waiting, and letting Ren come to him.

Three. All there. All at once.

And one of them was a little darker than the others.

Ren's bamboo was already low on the right. Already there. Already waiting.

Hayate had only started to go left.

He had not turned yet. His weight was still going out wide with the feint. And then it came back, the way Ren had seen it come back, and his bamboo came around low from the right, and met Ren's, which had been there the whole time.

Clack.

Hayate stepped back. His eyebrows went up.

He came again. Faster. Different. Straight in, high, and Ren saw it before it was straight in, and saw it going high and saw it not going high, saw it drop at the last moment under his guard, and saw it stop short and come again. Three. Four. One darker than the others.

Clack.

Again. Again. Hayate went in every way he knew and Ren saw every way he knew before he went, all of them at once, laid over each other, moving, and picked the one, and was there. Every time. He did not have to be fast. He hardly moved at all. He was only already where Hayate was going to be.

Hayate stepped back out of range. He was breathing hard. He was laughing.

"Since when are you this good?"

On the woodpile Enji whooped.

Ren stood with his bamboo low and watched Hayate laugh. Behind the laugh, laid over it, he could see the next thing Hayate would do. A step in, from the left. The bamboo high. He could see it the way you see a shape through fog.

He moved his bamboo up to meet it.

Hayate's laugh faded.

He was looking at Ren's bamboo. At where it was. High, on the left, in the place his own would have come to.

He had not moved yet.

He looked at it for a long moment. Then at Ren.

"I didn't do that yet."

Ren did not answer.

On the woodpile, Enji had stopped whooping. Kurogane had not moved. Shigure was looking at Ren's hands.

Hayate lowered his bamboo. After a moment he laughed again, a short one, and said something about how he was going to go and lie down, and went past Ren toward the hut, and did not look at him as he went.

***

That night at the fire, Shigure asked him something.

Ren saw his mouth move.

Then, after, the words came. As if they had had further to come than the width of a fire. As if they had been said somewhere else, a long way off, and had only now arrived.

Whether he wanted more tea.

Ren looked at him. Shigure was holding the pot. He was waiting. He had been waiting, Ren understood, for a moment already. A moment longer than he should have had to.

Ren shook his head.

Shigure put the pot down. He did not say anything. He did not look away, either. He looked at Ren the way he looked at the map, when he had found something on it he had not put there.

Ren looked at the fire.

***

He went back down to the river when the others were asleep.

The fog was on the water again. The moon was up behind the cloud, a pale place in the grey, and gave just enough light to see the water by. The river came out of the white and went back under it.

He knelt on the stones at the edge and put his hands in the water. It was very cold. He brought it up to his face. Once. Twice. It ran down his neck into his collar.

He opened his eyes.

His face was in the water. Dark, a shape, the fog grey behind it. He looked at it. He lifted his hand to push the wet hair back off his forehead.

The face in the water lifted its hand.

After.

A moment after. Not much. Less than a breath. But after. His hand was already at his forehead and the hand in the water was still coming up to meet it.

He stayed very still.

He looked at it.

It was still. Perfectly still. His own face, dark on the dark water, looking up at him. His hand at his forehead. Its hand at its forehead. Nothing moving.

Had it moved?

He did not know.

He knelt there on the cold stones until his knees had no feeling in them, and looked at it, and it looked back, and did not do anything he did not do.

Then he got up, and went and sat on the stone where he had sat the night before, and unrolled the blanket on his knees.

He read.

The doors opened, one behind the other. He went through them.

He did not look up.

Chapter 53

The Overlap

Shigure set the board down between them on the floor of the hut, close to the fire, where the light was.

It was the small board. The one he carried. The squares were drawn on it in ink gone brown, and one corner had been mended with a peg, and the pieces lived in a cloth bag that Shigure untied and emptied out onto the floor in a small wooden clatter. Five-sided, flat, worn smooth. He turned them over one by one and set them out in their rows, his side and then Ren's, without looking at them, the way a man sets out bowls.

Outside it was dark already. It got dark early now. The wind had come around in the afternoon and was pushing at the door, and the fog had gone with it, and it was cold, a hard dry cold that came in under the walls.

Enji was asleep in the corner with his mouth open. Hayate was on his back with his hands behind his head, watching the smoke find its way out through the thatch. Kurogane was sharpening.

Shigure moved first. A foot soldier, one square.

Ren looked at the board.

It had always been easy. That was the thing about it. Not the winning; he did not always win. Shigure was very good, and Shin had been very good, and he had lost to both of them more than he had beaten them. But it had always been easy to see. He would look at the board and the move would be there. One move. Standing up out of all the others the way one tree stands up out of a hillside when the light is on it. He would see it and his hand would go out and play it, and then he would look at the board again and the next one would be there.

He looked at the board.

His foot soldier, in front of the rook. It could go forward. It was a good move. It opened the rook's file and pressed on Shigure's left.

His silver general. It could go up and to the side. It was a good move. It began to build the wall around his king, which was what the old man would have done, what any careful man would do.

His bishop's foot soldier. It could go forward and open the long diagonal. It was a good move. It was the move Shin had liked, the one that made the game fast and sharp.

His king. It could step aside, early, into the corner. It was a good move. It was a slow move, a patient one, and against Shigure patience was worth something.

His lance. His knight. His gold.

He looked at each one and each one had a move, and each move was good. Not good the way a move looks good and has a hole in it. Good all the way through. He could follow each of them out, three moves, five, ten, and each of them went somewhere, and each of them was right.

And none of them finished.

That was what he could not get past. He followed each one out to where it went, and it went somewhere good, and then it opened, the way the doors opened, onto more moves, and each of those was good, and none of them were the end. None of them stood up out of the others. They lay on the board all at once, all of them, over each other, every piece with five good roads going out of it and every road branching, and there was no light on any of them. They were all lit the same.

His hand went out.

It stopped over the silver general.

It moved to the rook's foot soldier. Stopped.

It came back.

He put it on his knee.

He looked at the board.

It went out again. Hovered over the bishop's file. The fire moved on the backs of the pieces. It went to the king.

It came back.

Across the board, Shigure was not looking at the board.

Ren could feel it. He did not have to look up. Shigure's eyes were on his hand. They had been on his hand since the first time it went out and came back. They followed it out over the board and back to his knee and out again, and did not go anywhere else.

Ren moved the silver general.

It was a good move.

Shigure moved. Ren looked at the board and it was all there again, all of it, every piece with its roads, and his hand went out and came back and went out, and in the end he moved something. It was a good move. He did not know why it was that one and not the others.

It went on like that.

Every move he made was a good move. He could see that. He could see, every time, that it was correct. And every time Shigure answered it with one move, one, the way Ren used to, and every one of Shigure's moves was a little more than good. It went somewhere. It closed something. It finished something, a small thing, and then the next one finished something else, and while Ren's hand went out and came back over the board, Shigure's pieces came across it one after another, quietly, like water filling a field.

Ren's king was in the corner. He had built the wall around it. The wall was good.

Shigure dropped a captured silver onto the square in front of it.

Ren looked at it.

He could see every way out. There were four. He looked at each of them and each of them was good, and followed them out, and each of them went two moves and ended on the same square, which was not his.

He had lost.

He had lost badly. Worse than he had ever lost to Shigure, worse than he had lost to anyone since he was a boy. He looked down the board at his own pieces and half of them had never moved. They sat in their rows where Shigure had set them out, each one with five good moves it had never made.

The wind pushed at the door.

"Again?" said Shigure.

Ren did not answer.

He was still looking at the board. At the silver on the square in front of his king. At his own pieces. At the other games. They were still there. He could see them, laid over the one on the board. The game where the rook's foot soldier went first. The game where the bishop's file opened. The game where his king stepped aside early, and Shigure's knight came around the other way, and it was Ren's silver on the square in front of Shigure's king. All of them. All of them good. All of them going on, over each other, the pieces moving through each other like reflections on water, and none of them the one that had happened.

Shigure waited.

Then he began to pick the pieces up, one at a time, and put them back in the bag.

Ren watched his hands. He did not look up at his face. He knew what was on it. He had seen it at the fire the night before, and it had not gone away.

***

The job came the next morning.

A man from the village below the pass had climbed up to the hut in the dark with a lantern and a sack of rice and a story. There was a bridge on the road, half a day's walk down the valley. Four men had come to it at the start

of the month. Masterless men, rough, with swords. They had put a rope across the bridge and made anyone who wanted to cross it pay, and anyone who could not pay, they took from, and the week before a carter had argued with them and they had thrown him in the river with his cart. Nobody had seen the carter since.

Shigure listened to all of it. He looked at the rice. He said they would go.

It was a small job. Ren knew it the moment the man said four. It was the kind of job they had done a hundred times in the first year, before Iga, before any of it. The kind of fight he would have ended in a breath.

They went down in the afternoon. The wind had dropped. The sky was high and white and very cold, and their breath went up in front of them, and the road went down through the bare trees along the river toward the bridge.

The bridge was plank, on stone piers, narrow, with a rope across the near end at the height of a man's waist. There was a fire on the bank beside it. Four men around the fire. Ragged, the way Ren had known they would be. Old armor, pieces of it, tied on with cord. A jar going around.

They saw Karasu coming and got up.

Ren stepped out ahead of Shigure.

The first one came away from the fire toward him. Big. Thick in the shoulders, a beard, a sword that had been a good sword once and was not looked after now. He said something about the toll. He said something about the two swords Ren was wearing, and what they would fetch.

Then he drew.

Ren saw it.

All of it. At once.

The man's sword coming out and up, high, over the right shoulder, a big cut, a man's cut who had never needed any other. And Ren could cut low, under it, across the thighs, before it came down. And he could step left, off the line, and let it go past and take him on the back of the arm as it went. And he could go through, straight in, inside the cut, the old man's sword up to take it and the other already in. And he could go around, to the right, where the man was slow to turn, and be behind him before the cut was finished.

Low. Left. Through. Around.

Every one of them good. Every one of them finished the man. He could see each of them all the way to the end, to the man on the ground, and each end was correct.

He waited for one of them to be the right one.

For one of them to be darker than the others. The way it had been with Hayate. The way it had been every morning behind the kiln.

None of them was. They lay over each other, all the same, all lit the same, and he stood inside all of them at once, and waited.

It was a fraction too long.

He knew it while it was happening. He saw it happen. He saw the man's sword come down, not high, not over the shoulder, but short and across and lower than any of the ones he had seen, because the man had changed his mind at the last moment, the way men do, the way Ren had used to be able to see them do, and it was not one of the four.

It opened his left forearm.

He felt it go in. Cold, and then not cold.

The man's sword came back up for the second cut.

Something went past Ren's ear.

A wet sound, close. The man's head went back. He stood a moment with the sword up over his shoulder and a knife standing in his throat, a plain knife with a wrapped handle, and his eyes went wide and then went nowhere, and he went down backward onto the planks of the bridge.

Ren knew the knife.

He had seen it before. In the ford, in the dark, in the throat of a man who had been at his back. The first night. Before either of them had a name for the other.

The other three were coming.

Ren went to meet them.

It was clean. He did not wait now. He did not look. He went, and his body went the way it had been made to go, and there was nothing in it that was not movement. The first of them was down before his sword was all the way out. The second turned to run and did not get to turn. The third stood his ground at the rope and lifted his sword to guard and Ren went through the guard and through him, and it was over.

It had taken less than a breath. The way it would have, a year ago.

It did not matter. It was too late to matter.

He stood on the bridge with both swords out and his left sleeve going dark from the elbow down, and the four of them lying around him on the planks and the bank, and the river going on underneath.

Footsteps behind him on the planks.

Kurogane came past him to the big man, and bent, and drew his knife out of the man's throat, and wiped it on the man's sleeve, and put it back in his sash.

Then he straightened, and looked at Ren's arm.

At the cut. At the blood running down over the back of Ren's hand and off his fingers onto the boards.

Then he looked at Ren.

He did not say anything.

Ren saw it anyway. Kurogane had seen the man draw. He had seen Ren stand there. He had seen how long Ren had stood there, and he had counted it, the way he counted everything that happened in front of him with a sword in it. And he had had time. He had had time to see it was too long, and to take out his knife, and to throw it.

Kurogane turned away and went back along the bridge to the others.

***

That night Ren bound the arm himself.

He sat at the edge of the fire with his sleeve off his shoulder and a strip of clean cloth in his teeth. The cut was long and not deep. It had gone along the outside of the forearm, between the wrist and the elbow, through the skin and into the muscle under it, and stopped against nothing. Shigure had offered. He had shaken his head. Shigure had put the cloth and the little jar of salve down beside him and gone back to his place.

He washed it with water from the pot. He put the salve on it. He wound the cloth around, from the wrist up, tight, the way the old man had shown him the first winter, when he had cut his hand on the axe, and the old man had looked at the cut and said *Hm*, and nothing else. Around, and over, and around. He tied it off with his teeth and his right hand.

He knew exactly what had gone wrong.

That was the worst of it. He could see it. He could lay it out in front of him the way he had laid out the corridor, one step at a time, and look at it, and it was all there. He had seen four good answers. He had waited for one of them to be better than the others. None of them had been. And while he waited, the man had done a fifth thing, a stupid thing, a thing Ren would have seen a year ago before the man knew he was going to do it. Ren had not seen it. There had been too much else to see.

It was not fear.

He had hesitated before. In Iga, with his blade under her jaw. He knew what that had been. It had had a face.

This had no face. It was not fear and it was not love. It was only too much. Too many roads, all open, all good. He had stood at the place where they all went out and not been able to take one, because taking one meant not taking the others, and he could see the others. He could see all of them.

He could see what was wrong.

He could not fix it.

He sat with the bound arm across his knees and looked into the fire. Kurogane was across it, cleaning the knife. He did not look up.

The fire moved. The wind had come back and was at the door.

"Don't hesitate."

Ren heard it.

The old man's voice. Low, even, the way it had been at the mouth of the cave in the dark, with the swords through his sash. It came out of the fire, or out of the dark behind him, or out of nowhere, the way it had come once before, when he was training alone.

He sat very still.

Then he heard it again.

The same voice. The same words. But from a little way off. From a little to the left of where it had been. As if the old man had said it and then moved, and said it again, and the two of them were both still there, a hand's width apart, in the dark behind him.

He did not turn around.

Chapter 54

The Spear

The snow came to Iga in the eleventh month and did not leave.

It lay on the roofs and on the terraced fields and on the ridges all around, so that the valley sat in a white bowl under a white sky, and the only colors in it were the black of the cedars and the grey of the smoke going up from the houses. It squeaked underfoot in the mornings. By noon it was trodden to brown slush in the lanes, and by night it froze again, and in the morning there was new snow over it, and it squeaked.

Aoi walked to the training ground the way she had walked to it every morning of her life.

Across the bridge. Along the stream path, where the water ran black between banks of snow and the stones in it wore white caps. Past the bench outside Shin's house, empty. Her breath went up in front of her, white, and hung, and she walked through it.

The ground was full.

It always was, at this hour. The young ones in their rows on the trodden snow, breath going up off them like steam off a pot, blades going up and down together. The older ones at the edges, at the racks, pairing off. The sound of it, the thin clack of wood on wood and the scuff of feet and one voice over it all, calling the count.

It was not her voice.

Kōsuke stood where she had stood. At the head of the ground, by the rack, with his arms folded and his breath going up. He was calling the count the way he called everything, a little too loud, and when a boy in the third row let his elbow drift he went down the row and put it back with two fingers, the way she would have.

Not quite the way she would have.

She walked along the edge of the ground toward the far side.

The rows did not stop. Nobody stopped. But she felt it go along them as she passed, the way wind goes along a field. A boy in the second row looked at her. Then a girl beside him. Then three at the back. They looked, and their blades went on going up and down, and then they looked away. All of them. As if she were something they had been told not to stare at.

She did not look back at them.

Kōsuke saw her. He did not stop the count. He nodded once, the small nod you give someone you have known all your life and do not know what to do with anymore, and then his eyes went back to the rows.

At the far side of the ground, near the path up to Takeda's compound, a small figure in a padded coat was standing in the snow with her hands in her sleeves.

Hina.

She saw Aoi. Her face lit up the way it always had. She took one hand out of her sleeve and lifted it to wave.

A hand came down on her wrist.

Takeda. Beside her, in dark brown, very straight, with snow on his shoulders. Aoi had not seen him there. He did not look at Aoi. He took his daughter's wrist gently and lowered it, and held it a moment at her side, and let it go.

He did not say anything.

Hina looked up at him. Then at Aoi. Her face did not understand.

Aoi walked past them. She did not stop. She did not bow. She did not know what she would have bowed for.

***

The spear hung on the wall of the main room, on two pegs, above the place where her father used to sit.

Nobody had touched it since the funeral.

Daigo had carried it back from the courtyard that morning, dragging the butt of it along the gravel because it was too long for him to carry any other way, and Aoi had taken it from him at the door without a word and cleaned it and put it up on the pegs, and that was where it had stayed. Through the rest of the summer. Through the autumn. Through the first snow. Daigo did not look at it. At night the lamp threw its shadow across the wall and the ceiling, long and straight, and it lay there over the two of them while they ate.

Aoi stood under it.

The house was quiet. Daigo was out. The brazier ticked. Snow slid off the eaves outside with a long soft sound and landed in the drift below.

She reached up and took it down.

It was heavy.

She had known it would be. She had watched him carry it all her life, on his shoulder, across the ground, through the village, as if it weighed nothing. It weighed a great deal. The shaft was oak, dark with years of his hands, smooth at the two places where his hands had always gone and rough everywhere else. The head was long and straight and sheathed in black lacquer. When she stood it upright on the floor the sheathed point went up past the lintel, and she had to tip it to keep it off the ceiling.

It was too long for her. It was too heavy for her. She held it in both hands and felt it want to go down, the point dragging toward the floor.

Everything she knew was close.

That was the thing she stood there knowing. Everything her body had ever learned was close, and quick. The short blade. The feint. The step in, inside the other man's reach, where his long weapon was useless and hers was not. She had spent her whole life learning to get past things like this. To get inside them. She had gotten inside her father's spear a hundred times in practice, when she was small, laughing, and he had let her, and laughed with her.

The spear did not want her close. It wanted distance. It wanted the other man out there, at the end of it, where he could not reach. It wanted patience. It wanted her to wait.

She stood in the empty room with it, under the pegs.

She did not put it back.

***

She went before sunrise.

The village was dark. The snow was blue in the dark and the stars were very sharp and very many, and the cold went into her chest with every breath and sat there like a stone. She carried the spear on her shoulder, the way he had. It dug into the bone. By the bridge she had moved it to the other shoulder, and by the stream path she was carrying it in both hands in front of her, like a pole across a ditch.

The training ground was empty.

Nobody came this early. Nobody ever had. The snow lay on it unbroken, smooth, grey in the first thin light coming up behind the eastern ridge, and the racks stood at the edge with snow on their crossbars, and the stream went by beside it black and loud.

At the near end, by the water, there was a place.

She knew exactly where it was. There was nothing to show it. Snow over it like snow over everything. But she knew it. The place where he had stood. Every morning, before anyone came. Alone, with his two swords, going through the same shapes over and over, every step landing in the print of the one before, so that by the end of summer there had been a worn place in the grass there, two worn places, where his feet went.

It was this hour. This exact hour, with the light just coming. She used to come early to see it. She had told herself it was for other reasons.

She did not stand there.

She walked past it, to the middle of the ground, and stood somewhere else.

She set her feet. She set her hands on the shaft, the way she had seen him set his, one near the butt and one forward. She pulled the lacquer sheath off the head and set it down in the snow. The steel was grey, and clean. She had cleaned it herself, the morning of the funeral, before it went up on the wall. She did not remember doing it.

She tried the first form.

Her father's first form. She had watched it ten thousand times. The step, and the thrust, straight out from the hip, the whole body behind it, and the draw back, and the step. It was the first thing he had ever shown her, when she was Hina's age, with a broom handle. She had done it with the broom handle for a year before he let her do anything else.

The spear dragged.

It came out from her hip slow and low and heavy, and the point wandered, and her front foot went out on the frozen snow and kept going, and she caught herself, barely, and the steel point went down and struck the frozen ground with a sound like a dropped pot.

She stood there, bent over it, breathing.

The light was coming up behind the ridge. Grey, then a little less grey.

She pulled it up out of the snow. She set her feet.

"Again," she said.

Out loud. To nobody. Her own voice, small in the cold.

It was the same word. She heard it as it came out of her. The same word she had said to him on this ground, across a blade, in the summer, over and over, every time she touched him and he did not touch her. *Again.* She had not known what it was doing to him. She had only known she was winning.

She thrust.

It dragged.

Again.

It dragged. The point went wide. Her back foot slipped.

Again. Again.

By the time the first of the young ones came down the path to the ground, yawning, blowing on their hands, she had done it a hundred times and it had not once gone where she sent it. She put the sheath back on and put the spear on her shoulder and walked off the other end of the ground before they reached it.

Her hands were red and raw along the insides of the fingers. By the next morning they had blistered. By the morning after that the blisters had broken, and the shaft was dark and sticky where she held it.

She tore a strip off an old underrobe and wrapped them and went on.

***

A few mornings later, there was someone on the fence.

She saw him when she came down the path. A shape on the top rail at the far side of the ground, sitting with his knees drawn up and his arms around them, the way he had sat on walls and fences and roofs since he could climb. A padded coat too big for him. Their father's coat.

Daigo.

He did not say anything.

She did not either.

She walked past him to the middle of the ground and set her feet and pulled off the sheath and began. Thrust. Draw. Step. Again. She did not look at the fence. She could feel him there, the way she could feel the cold, the whole time, all through it, watching.

When the light came up he climbed down and went home.

The next morning, he was not on the fence.

There was a cup on the fence post.

A plain cup, brown glaze, one of theirs from the shelf at home. Steam going up off it into the cold. She saw it as she came onto the ground, and looked up the path toward the village, and there he was, a long way off already, a small dark shape in the too-big coat, walking away with his hands in his sleeves and his head down.

She went to the post and picked it up.

It was hot. It burned her broken hands through the wrapping and she held it anyway, in both of them, and drank it standing there in the snow by the fence. Tea. Strong and bitter and very hot. It went down into the stone in her chest and sat there, and the stone was a little smaller.

She put the cup back on the post, empty.

The next morning there was a cup.

And the next. And every morning after that. She never saw him put it there. She never saw him take it back. She would come down the path in the dark and the steam would be going up off the post, and when she left at sunrise the cup would be empty on the post where she had put it, and the morning after that it would be full again.

Neither of them ever said anything about it.

***

Shin wrapped her hands one evening.

She had not gone to him. She had been walking home past his house in the dusk with the spear on her shoulder, and he had been sitting on the bench outside it in a padded coat with a brazier by his feet, and he had looked at her hands as she went by and said her name.

She stopped.

He did not say anything else. He only moved the brazier a little with his foot, to make room.

She sat.

He unwound the old wrapping, which had gone stiff and brown, and looked at what was under it. He did not make a face. He never did. He washed her hands in warm water from a pot on the brazier, and put something on them that smelled of pine resin and stung and then did not sting, and wrapped them again in clean cloth, neatly, each finger, the way he had once dressed a long shallow cut across a stranger's chest, the first day.

When he was finished he picked up the spear from where she had leaned it against the bench.

He held it. He did not do anything with it. He only held it a moment in his long careful hands, the way she held it, and then the way her father had, and looked at the place on the shaft where her hands had been going. The dark place. Where the blood had come through.

He handed it back to her.

"Your father held it lower," he said.

That was all. He picked up the pot and went inside.

She sat on the bench a while longer in the dark with the brazier ticking, and looked at the shaft. At the dark place where her hands had been. And below it, a hand's width lower, the smooth place. The old place. Where the oak had been worn to the color of tea by thirty years of his grip.

The next morning, she held it lower.

***

It took weeks.

The snow went and came back. The stream froze at the edges and then all the way across, so that the sound of it stopped and the ground was very quiet in the mornings, and then it thawed a little and the sound came back. The cups came. The blisters healed and broke and healed again and then stopped breaking. Her hands went hard along the insides of the fingers, in the places where his had been hard.

And somewhere in it, she could not have said which morning, the spear stopped dragging.

She noticed it after. She was halfway through the first form, the hundredth time that morning, and the thrust went out from her hip and she felt it go. Straight. Where she had sent it. The weight of it no longer something she was lifting. Something she was riding, the way you ride the swing of a door.

She stopped and stood there with it out in front of her in the grey.

Then she went on.

It came slowly after that, and then faster. The spear began to move with her. Not the way it had moved with him. He had been heavy. Solid. He had stood in the middle of the ground like a pine and let everything come to him and broken on him. She could not do that. She did not have the weight.

So she did not stand. She moved. She kept the spear moving, all the time, never stopping at the end of a thrust but letting it come around, and back, and out again, in one line that did not break. Where he had been heavy, she was quick. Where he had been solid, she was continuous. She took the close, quick things her body already knew, the feint, the step, the turn inside, and she put them into the long weapon, and the long weapon took them.

It was not his.

It was hers.

***

Riku found her there one morning in the last of the winter.

She did not hear him come. She was in the middle of it, the spear going around her in its long unbroken line, and she turned at the end of a pass and he was standing at the edge of the ground in the grey, by the rack, watching her.

She stopped.

He looked at her. At the spear. At her hands on it, low, in her father's place.

He did not say anything for a long time. His face had changed over the winter. It had gone thin and hard and older, and the thing that had been in it on the night in Takeda's hall, the wet, the shaking, was gone, and what was there instead had nowhere to go.

He came out onto the ground.

He drew. Not practice blades from the rack. His own. The real ones. Both came out with the long clean sound that the wooden ones never made, and the steel was grey in the grey light.

"Show me."

It was not friendly.

He came at her the way he had wanted to come at the stranger in the forest, the first day, fast, faster than he needed to be, and angry. At her. At the spear. At the snow and the empty racks and the hall and the white cloths on the gravel and every one of the mornings she had walked the stranger down this path. All of it went into the first cut.

She did not let him inside.

That was all it was. The thing her father had done to Ren, in the smoke, in the study. The thing she had spent her whole life getting past. She kept him out there, at the end of the spear, where he could not reach. He came in and the point was there. He went around and the point came around with him, the butt swinging after it, and he had to go back. He came in again, harder, and she did not stand and meet it the way her father would have. She moved. The spear went around, and the shaft took his blade on the oak just below the steel and turned it, and kept turning, and did not stop.

Once. Twice. Three times.

The fourth time he came in, the shaft caught his long blade near the guard and the spear went on around, the way it always went on around now, and his sword went with it.

Out of his right hand. Up. Over.

It landed in the snow ten paces off, point first, and stood there.

Riku stood with his right hand open.

He had never lost his sword to her. Not once. Not in all the years they had trained on this ground, since they were children, since before either of them could lift a real one. He had beaten her more often than she had beaten him, and when she had beaten him it had been with the short blade, inside, close, and never, not once, like this.

He stared at her.

She stood with the spear still out, the point at the height of his throat, not quite touching.

She drew it back.

He looked at her a moment longer. Then he walked across the snow to his sword, and pulled it out of the ground, and wiped the snow off it on his sleeve, and put both swords away.

He did not look at her again.

He walked off the ground and up the path toward the village without a word, fast, his shoulders up, his hands in fists at his sides.

She watched him go.

She knew where it would go now. What was in him. It had been going at her all winter, at her and at everything, because she was the one who was there. It could not go at her anymore. Not after this.

It would go where it had always wanted to go. North, and west, down every road out of Iga, until it found the one who had walked in through their gate at her side and walked out through a hole in the wall.

***

The snow was going.

It went all at once, at the end, the way it does. Three days of rain, and a warm wind up the valley, and the white went grey and then brown and then was gone from everywhere but the north sides of the ridges and the deep places under the cedars. The stream was loud and full and the color of tea. The fields were black and wet and steaming in the first sun. There were buds on the plum by the gate, hard and tight and red.

She stood at the southern gate at sunrise.

She had not meant to come here. She had meant to go to the ground. She had come out of the house in the dark with the spear on her shoulder, and her feet had taken her the other way, down through the village, past the last houses, to the gate.

The same post. The same place. The fields going away from it into the mist.

Sunrise. Southern gate. Don't be late.

She had said that. In the street, with the sun low, and she had turned away before the smile was finished so he would not see it.

You're always late, he had said.

She was early.

She was very early. The sky was only just going grey. The man on the gate was asleep sitting up with his chin on his chest, the way he always was.

Nobody was coming.

She knew that. She had known it all winter. She had known it on the gravel in the grey light with the paper bird in her open hand.

She waited a moment anyway.

The mist lay in the fields. A bird started, somewhere, and then another. The light came up behind her over the eastern ridge and laid her shadow out long across the wet road, and the shadow of the spear beside it, longer.

Then she turned around.

She walked back up through the village, and across the bridge, and along the stream path, and onto the ground, where it was still empty. She set her feet. She took the sheath off.

She trained.

Chapter 55

Misalignment

The hearth was cold.

Nobody had lit it. Shigure noticed that before he noticed anything else, coming in from the yard with the map rolled under his arm and snow on his shoulders. The pit in the middle of the floor, the iron kettle hanging over it on its hook, the ash in it grey and flat and three days old. It was the first real cold of the winter. Their breath was white in the room. And the four of them were sitting around a fire that was not there, in their coats, with their hands in their sleeves, as if it had not occurred to any of them.

It had occurred to all of them. Nobody had done it.

In the spring Ren would have done it without being asked. He would have done it before any of them were awake.

Shigure knelt at the edge of the pit and unrolled the map on the boards.

He had drawn it himself over four days, from two men who talked in a teahouse in Ōtsu and one who did not talk but could be watched. A fold of hills north of the lake. A track going up it. At the top of the track, where it bent around a shoulder of rock, a place he had marked with a square. A wall. A gate on the south side, facing the track. A long house inside, and a smaller one, and a bell on a post. A wall at the back, on the north, against the slope.

"Kōga," he said. "A waystation. Men coming and going. Messages. Since the fire, everything that is left of them goes through here."

Nobody said anything. They were looking at the square.

"There are papers in it. There will be names in the papers." He did not look at Ren. "It is the closest thing to a road to Raiden that we are going to find this winter."

He took the stones out of his sleeve.

Five of them. River stones, smooth, the size of a thumb joint. He had used the same five since the beginning. He knew each one by its weight in his hand. He set them on the map one by one, and each time he set one down he said a name, though he did not need to.

"Kurogane." East, at the corner where the wall met the rock. "Hayate." South and a little west, below the gate, in the trees where the track came up. "Enji." The gate. "Me." Above, on the shoulder of rock, where he could see the whole of it.

He set the last stone down.

"Ren." North. At the back wall. Against the slope, where nobody looked because nobody came from there.

He sat back on his heels.

"Nobody moves before the signal. The signal is Enji at the gate." He looked at Enji. "When the moon clears the ridge. Not before. You will have light to see your own hands, and they will have light to see the gate go, and every one of them will look at it. Then Kurogane takes the east corner, and Hayate comes up the track behind them, and Ren comes over the back wall into a yard where everyone is facing the other way."

He went around them with his eyes.

Kurogane nodded. Once.

Hayate nodded. He had his arms wrapped around himself and his chin down in his collar and he nodded into it.

Enji nodded, and grinned, and rubbed his hands together over the cold pit as though there were something in it to warm them.

Ren nodded.

Then he went on looking at the map.

At his stone. North, at the back wall, by itself. He looked at it longer than any of them had looked at theirs. Shigure watched him do it. Watched his eyes go to the stone and stay there, and not move, and then move a little, to the left of it, and to the right, and to the space in front of it on the paper, the yard, the long house, the bell, as if the stone were not a stone but a place from which a great many lines went out.

Then Ren looked up.

Shigure rolled up the map.

Nobody lit the fire.

***

The snow came down very slowly, the way it does when there is almost no wind. Big flakes. They came out of the dark over Hayate's head and turned, and drifted, and landed on his sleeves and did not melt.

He was in the trees below the gate. Flat on his belly behind a fallen cedar, with the track twenty paces off and the wall above it, black against a sky that was a little less black. The gate was shut. There was a lantern over it. Under the lantern, a man with a spear stamping his feet.

Hayate breathed into his collar so the white would not show.

It was very quiet.

He had never heard a quiet like it. The snow did that. It took every sound out of the world and folded it away, the wind and the trees and the far-off water, and what was left was only his own breath and the tick of snow landing on snow. Behind the ridge to the east the sky had gone grey at the edge. The moon was back there. Coming. When it came over, Enji's thing would go at the gate, and the whole world would stop being quiet all at once, and Hayate would come up the track behind it laughing.

He was not laughing now. He had not laughed very much since the bridge.

He thought about the bridge. About Ren standing there with his sword out, doing nothing, while a drunk with a beard took his time. About Kurogane's knife. He had been on the bank. He had seen it. He had been too far away to do anything, and he had seen it, and he had not said anything, because Kurogane had not said anything, and if Kurogane was not going to say anything then there was nothing to say.

He thought about the bamboo. *I didn't do that yet.*

The grey behind the ridge got brighter.

Not yet. Soon.

Somewhere up the slope, north, behind the wall, a man shouted.

Hayate's head came up.

It was one shout. Short. Cut off in the middle, the way a shout is cut off when there is suddenly no breath behind it.

It was not the signal. The signal was a noise you did not mistake for anything. This was a man.

This was too early.

The grey behind the ridge was still grey. The moon was still behind it.

Hayate lay very still behind the log with the snow landing on his back and every part of him listening.

Nothing. For the space of three breaths, nothing. As if the shout had been something he dreamed.

Then the bell.

It went off inside the wall like a thing struck in a temple, huge, iron, over and over, and every sound the snow had folded away came back at once. Doors. Feet. Voices. Somebody screaming an order. The man at the gate spun around and looked back into the yard, and then the gate itself was opening, dragged inward, and men were coming out of it with torches.

Coming out. Down the track. Toward the trees.

Toward him.

It was all wrong. They were meant to be looking at the gate. They were meant to be looking at Enji. They were meant to be facing the wrong way, and Hayate was meant to come up behind them. Instead the gate was open and they were coming out through it and the torches were throwing light across the snow on the track, orange, moving, and the snow was white and flat and showed everything, every shadow, every log.

He had to move. Now. Before the light got to him.

He went.

Out from behind the log, low, fast, sideways along the slope toward the next cover. And there was no next cover. There was open snow, thirty paces of it, white, with the torchlight coming across it, and he was in the middle of it.

Someone shouted. The torches turned.

Three of them came at him. He threw. A needle, a second, a man went down clutching his face. The second one swung and Hayate was not there. He was under it, and his shoulder came up into the man's belly behind the swing, and the man went over onto his back in the snow. The third one he did not see. He felt it. A cold line along the outside of his left forearm, from the elbow down, opening, and then heat, and then his sleeve going heavy.

He went down on one knee in the snow.

The third man was over him. The torch in one hand and the sword going up in the other, black against the sky that was still not bright enough, the moon still not come.

The man stopped.

He stood a moment with the sword up. Then his head was not where it had been. It went away to the side, and the rest of him went the other way, and the torch fell in the snow and hissed.

Kurogane.

He had not been there. He was there. He came out of the dark between one breath and the next, from the east, from where his stone had been, thirty paces away, and he did not stop at Hayate. He went past him. He stood in front of him in the snow with his sword low and his back to Hayate, between Hayate and everything else that was coming down the track, and did not say one word.

The next one came. Kurogane cut once.

Hayate knelt in the snow behind him holding his arm and watched Kurogane's back, and thought, very clearly, the way you think things when you are bleeding: *he left his corner.*

He left his corner for me.

***

Enji was not at the gate.

He was forty paces short of it, on his knees in the snow at the edge of the track, with the big one in his arms and the cord of it not even uncoiled yet, when the bell went.

He looked up.

The gate was opening. The wrong way. In, with men coming out through it. Torches. Shouting. And the moon was not up, the moon was nowhere, the ridge was still just a ridge with grey behind it, and everything he had carried up this hill on his back for half the night, wrapped in straw and oiled cloth and held against him like a baby, was meant to go off in a gate that was shut, with the moon on it, with everyone inside looking at it.

The gate was not shut. Nobody was inside. They were all coming out.

He laughed.

He could not help it. He never could. It came up out of him high and bright, and he heard it go out across the snow, and he thought, well, there's that, and then his hands were already moving. The cord. The flint. There was no time to get to the gate. The gate had come to him, or near enough. He set the big one down in the snow where it

was, where it had no business being, at the side of the track between two stones, and he struck the flint once and the cord took and began to spit.

Then he ran.

It went off behind him when he was twenty paces up the slope. Not at the gate. Down the track, at the wrong place, in the middle of the men who were running down it. The world went white and then orange and then very loud, and he was thrown flat in the snow, and things were landing all around him, snow and earth and a piece of somebody's spear, and somebody was screaming, and the torches were everywhere, rolling, going out.

He lay on his back in the snow and laughed at the sky.

It was chaos. It was the most chaos he had ever seen in his life. The gate open, men running every way, the bell still going, going, going, and snow coming down through the smoke, and somewhere to the south Hayate yelling something and beside him the sound of Kurogane's sword, and it was everything he had ever loved.

He stopped laughing.

He lay there with the snow landing on his face.

It was not his.

That was the thing. That was what was wrong with it. He had made a thousand of these. He had made every one of them himself, with his hands, in the storehouse, grinding, mixing, packing, knowing exactly where every piece of it would go when it went. The chaos was his. It came out of his hands. He was the one who decided when the world stopped being one thing and started being another.

This one he had not decided. This one had been decided somewhere up at the back wall, in the dark, by somebody else, before the moon, and Enji had only been running along behind it trying to catch up.

He did not like it.

He had never not liked it before.

He got up. He wiped the snow off his face. There were still men in the yard. He reached into his bag for the little ones, and went.

***

They won.

Kurogane knew it before the bell stopped. You could hear a fight turn. The shouting changed. The feet went from coming to going. Some of the Kōga went over the east wall into the trees, and Kurogane let them, because there was no one to cover Hayate if he went after them. The rest did not go anywhere.

When it was over he went to the north wall.

He did not know why. He went the way a man goes back to a door he is not sure he shut.

The snow was falling on it. Three of them, lying at the foot of the wall on the inside, in the angle where the wall met the slope. Three guards. They had not drawn. One of them had his hand on his hilt. One was on his face. One was sitting against the wall with his head on his chest as if he were asleep, and the snow was already building up on his shoulders, and there was one line across his throat, very fine, very straight.

Each of them, one cut.

Kurogane looked at them for a long time.

It was perfect. There was nothing wrong with it. He could not have done it better. He was not certain he could have done it as well. Three men, awake, on guard, and they had died before any one of them knew the other two were dying.

He looked up along the wall. At the house. At the path that came around the end of the long house from the guardroom at the front. There were footprints on it, filling up with snow. A lot of them. Four men, walking together, coming this way. They had stopped at the corner of the long house. They had not come any further.

The guard change.

It had been coming around the corner. Four fresh men to take the place of three cold ones. In another twenty breaths there would have been seven at the back wall, not three, and the three would have been awake enough to talk and the four would have been fresh.

Ren had seen it coming.

He had seen it before it came. And he had moved, and the three were done, and the back wall was his, perfectly, exactly as the stone had said it would be.

Before the moon.

Kurogane stood at the foot of the north wall with the snow coming down on him.

Across the yard, by the gate, Shigure was kneeling beside Hayate, winding a strip of cloth around his arm. Enji was sitting in the snow with his bag in his lap, black to the eyes, not laughing. Nobody was talking.

And at the far edge of the yard, alone, with both swords sheathed and his hands at his sides, Ren was standing looking at the long house. At the door of it. At nothing.

He was not looking at any of them.

Kurogane watched him.

They had won. Everyone was alive. There were papers in the long house, and Shigure would find them, and there would be names in them.

Nobody said that it had gone well.

***

The hearth was still cold when they came back.

Nobody lit it. Hayate lay down in the corner with his arm across his chest and his face to the wall. Enji went out to the storehouse and did not come back. Kurogane stood in the doorway to the yard, where the snow was still coming down, grey now in the first of the light.

Shigure knelt at the edge of the cold pit and unrolled the map.

He took out the stones.

He set them down again. Not where they had been in the plan. Where they had been. He did it slowly, the way he did everything, and for each one he closed his eyes a moment first and saw the hill again, the snow, the track, the wall.

Kurogane. East, at the corner. And then not at the corner. He moved the stone across the paper, south and west, thirty paces, to the track, to the open snow in front of the trees, where Hayate had been. It made sense. It was the right thing. Shigure would have done it.

Hayate. In the trees below the gate, and then out of them, sideways, into the open, where the torchlight was. It made sense. There had been nowhere else to go.

Enji. Forty paces short of the gate, at the side of the track, where the big one had gone off in the wrong place. It made sense. He had been exactly where he would have been, at exactly that time, if the bell had gone when it did.

His own. On the shoulder of rock above it all, watching every one of them do the thing that made sense.

Four stones. Every one of them was where it should have been, once you knew where the bell had rung. Every one of them had moved the way a stone moves, from one place to the next, because of the thing that came before.

He picked up the fifth.

Ren's.

He held it over the map. Over the back wall, where he had put it the night before.

It had been there. And then the three guards were dead. And then the bell. And the bell was the thing all the other stones had moved because of. The bell was the beginning of every line on the paper.

And the bell had come from this stone. Before the moon. Before the signal. Before anything on the paper said it could.

He could see why. He had walked to the north wall after, and seen the footprints at the corner of the long house. He understood the guard change. He understood that it had been the right thing, at the back wall. It had been perfect, at the back wall.

He could not put the stone down.

There was nowhere on the paper for it. Every place he held it over, the lines went wrong. If it was at the back wall, the bell should not have rung until the moon. If it was not at the back wall, the three guards should still be alive. It was in both places. It was in neither. It had moved the way the others had not moved, not from one thing to the next, but from somewhere he could not see to somewhere he had not drawn.

He knelt there with it in his fingers.

On the lake road at Ōtsu, in a room above a rice-seller's, he had laid three stones beside a sheet of paper for three men he had never met. A loud one and a silent one and one with a single sword and a cloth-wrapped length beside it, looking for a smith. He had set one of them down before any of them had done anything at all. That night had not gone the way he set it either. But every piece of it had been true, and afterward he could have drawn every step any of them took.

Now he could not put one of them down after it was over.

He held the stone a long time.

It was smooth and cold in his palm. He had carried it through every job they had ever done.

In the doorway, Kurogane had turned his head. Shigure did not have to look up to know it. He could feel it, the way he felt most things in a room: Kurogane was watching his hand. He did not come in. He did not say anything.

Shigure did not look up at him. He looked at the stone.

Behind him, across the room, in the corner where the old blanket was usually rolled against the wall, there was nothing. Just the wall.

Ren was not in the room.

Chapter 56

Breaking Point

Hayate found him in the yard.

It had been snowing since dusk and it had not stopped. It came down out of the dark over the wall, slow and thick and silent, and lay on the roof of the storehouse and on the bare wisteria over the gate and on the bamboo behind the house, which bent under it and every so often let it go with a soft sound like someone setting down a sack. There was no moon. The only light was the lamp in the house behind him, coming out through the paper of the door and lying on the snow in a long pale square.

Ren was sitting at the edge of it.

On the ground. In the snow. By the ring of stones in the middle of the yard where they had made their fire every night of the summer, and which nobody had made a fire in for a month. The stones were white humps now. Ren was sitting beside them with his knees up and his arms loose around them and the old brown blanket over his shoulders, and the snow was on the blanket and on his hair and on his knees, and he had not brushed any of it off.

He was not shivering.

Hayate stood on the step and looked at him for a while.

He was not shivering, and he was not hunched, and he was not rocking or staring or doing any of the things a man does when he has gone out into the snow at night to be alone with something. He was just sitting. His face was turned a little toward the gate. His breath went up white, slow and even. He looked the way a stone looks. Not cold. Not anything.

Hayate came down off the step.

The snow squeaked. Ren did not turn his head. Hayate walked across the yard and stood beside him, and then he sat down, in the snow, a little way off, the way you sit down next to someone on a bench. The cold came through his trousers at once. His arm hurt, under the binding, where the cut was. He did not say anything about either.

They sat.

The snow came down between them and on them.

Hayate looked at the side of Ren's face. Then he looked down at Ren's sash, where it showed at the edge of the blanket. The purse was there. The same one. Old, dark, on its cord, tucked behind the swords.

He did not decide to do it. He had been doing it for so long it did not need deciding.

His hand went out. Slow. Sly. Along the snow, and up, the fingers loose, not reaching, just drifting that way, the way a leaf drifts. The way he had done it on the road outside Nara, the first week, with the knife and the purse, when the boy had turned around in the road with his mouth open and nothing coming out of it. *But... why?* The way he had done it a hundred times since, at fires, on roads, in the backs of teahouses, just to see the look on Ren's face when Ren found his own purse in Hayate's hand.

His fingers were a hair's width from the cord.

Ren's hand closed on his wrist.

It did not move fast. That was the thing. It did not snap out. It was simply there, closed, around Hayate's wrist, as if it had been waiting there in the air and Hayate's wrist had come to it. The grip was not hard. It was exact.

Ren had not looked.

He was still looking at the gate. His face had not changed. His eyes had not moved.

Hayate looked down at the hand on his wrist.

The snow landed on it. On the knuckles. It did not melt.

"You used to laugh," said Hayate, "when I did that."

Ren let go.

He put his hand back on his knee. He did not say anything.

Hayate drew his own hand back and put it in his lap. His wrist was cold where the fingers had been.

Silence.

The snow came down. On the wall, on the roof, on the white humps of the stones. Somewhere behind the house the bamboo let go of its load, softly, and was quiet again.

"What happened to you?" said Hayate.

He said it plainly. He did not make it a joke. He did not know how to make it a joke anymore.

Ren turned his head then. For the first time. He looked at Hayate, and his eyes were clear, and there was nothing hidden in them. Hayate had seen a great many faces lie to him. He knew all the ways. This was not one of them. Ren had never lied to him. Not once, in all that time. He did not know how.

"I see more now," said Ren.

He said it the way he would have said it was snowing.

Hayate looked at him.

At his face in the edge of the lamplight. At the snow in his hair. At his eyes, which were looking back at Hayate, and seeing him, very clearly, and seeing, Hayate felt, a great many other things at the same time, all laid over him, and none of them Hayate.

"Then why do you look lost?"

Ren did not answer.

He did not look away, either. He only did not answer. After a moment his eyes went back to the gate, and stayed there.

Hayate breathed out. The white went up between them and was gone.

"Shigure can't place you anymore," he said.

He said it quietly. He was not accusing anyone. He was only saying what was there. He had seen Shigure that morning at the cold pit with that stone in his fingers, not putting it down. Shigure, who knew where everybody was before they knew it themselves.

"Kurogane doesn't say it, but he's watching your back like you're a stranger."

Kurogane, who had left his corner on the hill. Who never left his corner.

"Enji hasn't made anything in a week."

He had gone into the storehouse yesterday. Enji had been sitting at the bench with his hands in his lap, and nothing on the bench at all.

Ren listened.

Hayate could see him listen. He did not turn away from it. He did not close up. He did not argue, or tell Hayate he was wrong, or tell him he did not understand. He took all of it. Every word. Hayate watched it go in, the way you watch stones go into a pond, and there was no splash.

Hayate looked at the snow on the stones.

Then, quietly, the way he had said it once before on a summer night with the red moon coming up and the cicadas going:

"You miss him."

Silence.

It went on.

Hayate waited for it.

He knew this silence. He had sat in it before. On the hill above the hollow after Iga, with the moon going from red to white, and Ren beside him with his arms around his knees, not saying anything, and the not saying had been

so full that Hayate had been able to hear everything in it. The girl. The vault. All of it. That silence had been an answer. It had been the loudest thing Ren had ever said.

He waited for this one to be that.

The snow came down.

Ren sat with his arms loose around his knees and looked at the gate.

The silence was only silence. There was nothing in it. Not grief. Not anger. Not a door closing. Hayate listened to it the way he listened to a man's breath in the dark to know if he was lying, and there was nothing there to hear.

That was when he understood.

It came to him all at once and very quietly, the way the cold had come through his trousers. Ren was not hiding from him. Ren was not angry with him, or with any of them. Ren was not even far away. He was right there, an arm's length off, in the snow, and if Hayate had reached out again he could have touched him.

He was just not coming from the same place anymore.

Whatever place it was that Hayate was talking from, the place where you missed people and laughed when somebody took your purse and sat in the same place around the fire every night, Ren was not in it. He had not left it in anger. He had not been driven out. He had only gone on, somewhere else, somewhere Hayate could not see into, and was sitting there now, perfectly calm, and listening, and hearing every word, and none of the words could get to where he was.

Hayate sat very still.

It did not hurt the way he had thought it would. It did not hurt like the cut on his arm. It hurt like something that has already happened a long time ago, that you are only now being told about.

After a while he stood up.

His legs were stiff. The snow had gotten into his clothes. He brushed it off, the front of him, his knees, his sleeves, slowly, one side and then the other. He did not look at Ren while he did it.

Then he looked down at him.

"Come inside when you're cold."

Ren looked up at him. "Hm."

Hayate turned and walked back across the yard. The snow squeaked. He went up the step and put his hand on the door, and stopped, and looked back once.

Ren was sitting where he had been. The blanket over his shoulders. The snow on the blanket. His face toward the gate.

He did not get up.

Hayate went in and slid the door shut behind him.

***

The house was warm. Someone had lit the hearth at last, while he was outside. Enji, maybe. The fire was small and low and the kettle was ticking on its hook. Kurogane was asleep against the far wall with his sword across his knees. Shigure was asleep, or pretending. Enji was a lump under a quilt in the corner.

Hayate stood by the door with the cold coming off him.

On the shelf over the hearth, in a row, stood the figures.

Enji's. The little clay ones. He had made them one at a time, and fired them in the pit behind the storehouse at night when everyone was asleep, and the ones that had come out whole he had kept in a row above his bench in the storehouse, until the cold came and he carried them in here. Hayate with his mouth open. Shigure sitting very straight. Kurogane with his arms folded. There was not one of Enji.

And at the end of the row, Ren.

A young man, standing. Two swords at his hip, both long. His head a little down. Looking at something on the ground in front of him that was not there.

Hayate looked at it.

The firelight moved on it. On the little clay face, which Enji had made with the end of a stick in three strokes, and which was, somehow, exactly Ren. The way he had been. The way he had stood on the road outside Nara with his purse in one hand and his knife in the other and his mouth open.

Hayate looked at it for a long time.

He did not pick it up. He did not touch it.

Then he went to his place by the wall, and lay down, and pulled the quilt over his shoulder, and turned his face to the wall.

Outside, the snow went on falling on the yard, and on the stones, and on the one who was sitting beside them.

Nobody heard the door open again that night.

Chapter 57

Shogi

Shigure cooked.

He had bought the fish that morning in the town below the hill, from the man with the stall by the bridge who always tried to sell him yesterday's and always failed. Mackerel, silver and blue, firm under the thumb. He had salted it at noon and let it stand, and then washed the salt off, and laid it in vinegar, and let it stand again. The rice he had washed until the water ran clear, and cooked, and turned out into the wide shallow tub, and fanned while he turned it with the flat of the paddle, so that every grain came up shining and separate.

It took most of the afternoon. It did not need to. He could have made something in the time it took to boil water. He did not want to make something. He wanted to make this.

Outside it was snowing again. Not hard. It had not stopped, really, in three days, only changed its mind about how much.

He wet his hands. He took up the rice, a little at a time, and pressed it, not hard, the way you press something you do not want to break. He laid the fish over it, a thin slice, the silver side up, and pressed it once more with two fingers, and set it on the plate. And again. And again. Each one the same size. Each one the same shape. The fish lying over the rice like a hand over a hand.

Five plates.

He had set them out before he thought about it. His hands had taken them down from the shelf, one and then the next, the way his hands did every night. Five. He looked at them in a row on the board, when he noticed. He did not put one back.

He made five plates. Every one of them perfect.

***

They ate in the main room, around the hearth. The fire was lit now. It had been lit every night since the night Hayate had come in from the yard with snow on his clothes and gone to the wall without speaking, and in the morning somebody had simply built it up again, and nobody had said who. The kettle ticked on its hook. The light went up the walls.

Hayate ate quietly.

That was the first thing Shigure noticed, because Hayate had never eaten quietly in his life. He ate with his right hand, his left arm still bound against his side, and he ate everything on the plate, one piece and then the next, and said it was good, once, and meant it, and said nothing else. Shigure had cut his pieces smaller than the others. Hayate had not noticed. That was all right. He was not meant to.

Enji ate with his hands, half asleep. He had been in the storehouse most of the day. There had been sounds from it again, for the first time in a week, a scrape and a tap and a long quiet, and he had come in at dusk grey to the elbows with clay and fallen onto his cushion and not really woken up since. He ate with his eyes half closed and his head nodding, and every so often he smiled at nothing, at the rice, as if it had told him something. Shigure had given him two more than the others. He would notice that. He would not say anything about it. He never did.

Kurogane ate.

He ate the way he did everything, without hurry and without waste, and when he had finished he set his chopsticks down across the plate exactly parallel, and looked at the fire.

The fifth plate sat at the fifth place.

Beside Shigure, at his elbow, where it had always been. Where it had been every night since the beginning, on the road and in teahouses and here, at this fire, in this house. The rice shining. The fish silver side up.

Ren had slept in the small room off the passage since the night in the snow. Its door was shut.

Nobody looked at it. Nobody looked at the plate. They ate around it the way water goes around a stone, and when they had finished, Shigure gathered up the four empty plates and did not touch the fifth.

***

Later, when the others had gone quiet, Shigure took down the board.

He set it by the fire, on the boards, square to the hearth. He lifted the lid of the box.

The pieces went out of it onto the board with a small, sharp clatter. Wood on wood. Sliding.

He stopped with the box still tipped in his hands.

It was the same sound. Exactly. He had not expected it to be, and it was. A morning in the spring with the fire going beside the step and the grey light coming, and a young man with his swords in his sash and a belt on the table that he had said he would not need, and Shigure standing behind him with this box. *One game before you go?* And the young man had smiled, and sat down, and lost, and then stood up when Shigure said again.

Next time. I have to go now.

Shigure set the box down.

He turned the pieces over one by one and set them in their rows. His side. Then the other side. He did it slowly, and each piece went down with a small click, and when they were all out he sat back with his hands on his knees and looked at the other side of the board, where nobody was.

He waited.

The fire ticked. The snow went on outside, soft against the paper of the door. Somewhere in the house, Hayate turned over.

Ren's door stayed shut.

Shigure did not look at it. He looked at the board. At the rows of pieces on the far side, set out and waiting, every one of them in its place, and nobody's hand over them.

He did not know how long. A long time.

Then the boards creaked.

Kurogane came across the room and stood by the board, looking down at it. He had his sword in his hand, the way he always had it when he was not wearing it. He looked at the pieces. Then at Shigure.

Then he sat down on the far side of the board, and laid the sword on the floor beside him, and put his hands on his knees.

Shigure looked at him.

In all their time together, Kurogane had never asked to play. Not once. He had sat by the fire a thousand evenings while Shigure and Ren bent over the board, and watched, or cleaned his sword, or slept, and never said a word about it, and never come near. Shigure had not been sure he knew how the pieces moved.

Kurogane did not ask now, either. He only sat.

Shigure moved a foot soldier.

***

Kurogane was bad.

He knew how the pieces moved. That was all he knew. Every piece he touched went straight forward. The foot soldiers, one after another, in a line, like men going up a ladder. The lance, straight up its file. The rook, straight up the middle. He did not feint. He did not build a wall. He did not look at what Shigure was doing, except to take whatever was directly in front of him when it was there to be taken.

It was exactly like watching him fight, and it lost in the same number of moves that it would have taken Shigure to say so.

Shigure dropped a gold beside his king, and the king had nowhere to go.

Kurogane looked at the board.

He looked at it for a while. At his own pieces, all of them gone forward and none of them come back. At the gold. At the king with nowhere to go.

"Again."

Shigure almost laughed.

It came up in him out of nowhere, out of the bottom of his chest, where he had not felt anything come up from in a long time, and got as far as the back of his throat before he caught it. He did not let it out. But Kurogane saw it. Shigure saw him see it. Something at the corner of Kurogane's mouth moved, a very little, and went still again.

Shigure began to set the pieces out.

***

While they played, he laid out tomorrow.

He took the map from inside his coat and unrolled it on the boards beside the shogi board, and weighted the corners with the kettle lid and his own knee. The place the papers had pointed to. He had read them all, every one, in the three days since the hill, twice and then again, and put together what they said with what the two men in Ōtsu had said and what he had seen with his own eyes on the road, and it was on the map now, in his own hand. A road. A narrow place. A house at the end of it.

He took the stones out of his sleeve.

He set his own down first. In the middle. Where the road narrowed, where everything that happened would have to come past him, where he could see all of it and all of it could see him.

"You," he said. "Here." Kurogane's stone went to the right of his, close. "Hayate, wide. Out here, on the slope, where he can see the road both ways and they can't see him." He set it down. "Enji behind. Back here, at the bend. If anything comes the other way, it comes into Enji first, and it doesn't come out."

Kurogane watched the stones go down. He moved a foot soldier straight forward on the other board without looking at it.

There was one stone left.

Shigure picked it up.

It was smooth and cold and the size of a thumb joint. He knew it by its weight. He held it over the map.

He held it a long time.

The fire ticked. Kurogane had stopped moving his pieces. He was not looking at the board. He was looking at Shigure's hand.

Shigure looked at the map. At the road, and the narrow place, and the four stones, and the empty places around them where the fifth could go. At the slope. At the bend. At the house. He could have put it anywhere. He could have put it somewhere that made sense.

He set it down on his left.

Close. Beside his own. Touching it, almost. On the side where Kurogane was not.

Where Ren always was.

Where Ren had been on the step in the grey light with the board between them. Where he had been at the lord's hall, and on every road and in every fight since, at Shigure's side, where Shigure did not have to look to know he was there.

Shigure took his hand away from it.

Kurogane looked at the stone.

He looked at it for a while, the way he had looked at the king with nowhere to go. Then he looked up at Shigure.

"If it fails?"

Shigure did not look up from the board. He moved his silver. He looked at where it had gone, and at what it did now, and at what Kurogane would have to do about it.

"Then you fully commit," he said. "You don't hesitate."

He said it quietly, the way he said everything. As if it were only another move.

Kurogane did not answer. He nodded once. Then he looked back down at the board.

Shigure watched him take it. He knew the way Kurogane took things. They went in and they did not come out again, and nobody ever saw where they went, least of all Kurogane. It went in now. Shigure saw it go.

He did not know why he had said it. He had not planned to.

His hand went to his shoulder.

He did not notice it going. It went on its own, the way it had been going on its own all winter, to the top of his left shoulder, under the coat, where there was a line. Thin. Healed. A hand's length. He could feel it through the cloth under his fingers, a little ridge, smooth now, the skin gone shiny and pale. The follow-through that had gone a hand's width further than it needed to, in the smoke at Kōga, while the woman with the short blade went sprawling. He felt it all the time now.

Kurogane was looking at the hand.

"He'll be there," said Kurogane.

Shigure took his hand down from his shoulder.

"He always is."

He moved a piece. Kurogane moved a piece, straight forward. Shigure took it.

***

He won again.

It took a little longer this time. Not much. Kurogane had moved one piece sideways, once, near the end, as if he had just remembered that pieces could. It had not helped. Shigure put a silver in front of the king and the king had nowhere to go, the same as before, and Kurogane looked at it, the same as before.

He did not ask for a third.

He sat a moment longer with his hands on his knees. Then he picked up his sword from the floor and stood, and went back across the room to his place against the wall, and sat down there with the sword across his knees and his head back against the wall, and closed his eyes.

Shigure put the pieces away.

One at a time, into the box, and the lid on. He rolled up the map with the five stones inside it, the way he always did. He put it inside his coat.

Then he got up and went to the fifth plate.

It was where it had been. At the fifth place, beside his own. The rice had gone a little dull on top. The fish had not changed.

He took a clean cloth from the shelf and laid it over the plate. He folded the edges under, neatly, the way you tuck in a child.

He carried it down the short passage to Ren's door.

The door was shut. There was no light behind it. There was no sound. He did not know if Ren was in there, or awake, or sitting on the floor with his back against the wall and the old blanket over his shoulders looking at nothing. He did not knock.

He bent and set the plate down on the boards outside the door. Square to the frame.

He stood a moment.

Then he went back to the hearth and banked the fire for the night, and lay down in his place, and slept.

***

In the morning the snow had stopped.

The light came in grey and clean through the paper of the doors, and the house was very cold and very quiet. Shigure woke the way he always woke, all at once, knowing where he was and what the day was. He lay a moment looking at the ceiling.

Then he got up and went to the passage.

It was grey. At the end of it, outside Ren's door, on the boards, square to the frame, was the plate.

It was empty.

Not scraped. Not pushed aside. Empty and clean, as if it had been washed and dried. The cloth was folded beside it, in a small neat square, the edges lined up. And the plate itself had been set down again exactly where Shigure had set it. Exactly. Square to the frame. The way you would set it down if you had been taught, a long time ago, by someone who put every bowl back in the same place on the same shelf every night, that that was how things were set down.

Ren's door was still shut.

Shigure looked at the plate for a while.

At the clean plate, and the folded cloth, and the door.

Then he smiled.

It came up all at once, and quickly, the whole of it, the way it always had, and this time he did not put it away. He stood in the cold passage in the grey light and let it stay on his face, for nobody, for as long as it wanted to stay.

Chapter 58

Irreversible

The road went into the hills the way Shigure had drawn it.

Kurogane had walked behind a great many plans in his life. Most of them had been wrong about something by the time the road ran out. The distance, or the ground, or the number of men at the end. Shigure's were never wrong about the ground. The road went up between two slopes of bare oak and snow, and narrowed, and narrowed again, until the slopes came down close on either side and the road was only wide enough for two men walking abreast, and it was exactly where the ink had said it would be.

At the end of it, where the valley opened a little, a house. Thatch heavy with snow. Smoke coming up out of the ridge of it, thin and blue. A fence. A shed.

The snow had stopped in the night. The sky was high and white and the air was very still, and every sound they made on the road went a long way.

They took their places.

Hayate went up the right-hand slope first, into the oaks, and was gone. Enji dropped back to the bend behind them with his bag held against his chest, and knelt in the snow there, and began to lay things out. Kurogane went to his place, on the right of the narrow part, a pace from the slope, where the stone had been.

Shigure stood in the middle of the road.

And on his left, where the stone had been, Ren.

He had come out of the house that morning with the others and walked the whole way in his place, second from the front, and said nothing, and when they came to the narrow part he had gone to Shigure's left and stood there, as if there were nowhere else he could have gone. Kurogane had seen Shigure feel him arrive. Shigure had not turned his head. Something in his shoulders had only gone still, the way a man's shoulders go still when a weight he has been carrying is set down.

He'll be there.

He always is.

Kurogane looked at the house.

It was quiet. The smoke went up. Nothing moved in the yard.

It was the kind of quiet Kurogane had heard before. On the ridge above Kōga, in the fog, when Shigure had said *they're waiting* and nobody had needed to answer him.

His hand went to his hilt.

On the slopes on either side of the road, all at once, the snow stood up.

***

Ren saw all of it.

That was the thing. He always saw all of it now.

The men came up out of the snow on both slopes, grey on the white, low, the way they had come up out of the stubble at Kōga. The ones who stood in no shape at all, and every one of them where the shape was not. And from the house, from the door and the shed and from behind the fence, others. Dark. Four-pointed stars in their hands.

He saw where each of them would go. He saw the lines they would make, and the gaps between the lines, and how they would close on the narrow place from both sides and from the front. He saw Shigure see it. Shigure's hands had come out of his sleeves with the knives in them before the first of the grey men had finished standing, and his voice was already going, low and even, placing them. *Kurogane, hold. Hayate, the left slope, now. Enji.*

And he saw his own place in it.

On Shigure's left. Where the stone was. Where he was standing now. The slope on that side was steep and the grey men would come down it fast, and the place he was standing in was the place they would come to. It was the place between them and Shigure. If he stayed in it, they would come to him, and not past him. It was clear. It was all perfectly clear.

Then he looked up.

Above the house. On the slope behind it, among the bare oaks, standing in the snow a little apart from everything. Not coming down. Not moving at all.

A man in plain dark clothes with his sword low in his right hand and the point toward the ground.

Raiden.

He was looking at Ren.

Only at Ren. Across the yard and the fence and the house and the whole of the valley, over the heads of all the men coming down the slopes, as if there were nobody else there. As if he had been standing there all morning waiting for Ren to look up.

The heat came.

It came up from the soles of his feet the way it had come in the festival town, all at once, and filled him, and there was no room in him for anything else. The corridor. The smoke. The sword coming up from where it had been hanging. The fire on the old man's face.

And laid over it, the way everything was laid over everything now, he saw the two ways.

He saw the one where he stayed. On Shigure's left, in his place, with the grey men coming down onto him, and it went on, and it was good, and it was right, and it did not finish. It went on and on into more fighting and more fighting and somewhere at the end of it Raiden was still standing on a slope.

And he saw the one where he went.

Up. Through the grey men, who were slow, who were all slow now. Past the fence. Up the slope behind the house. And at the end of it, Raiden, with his sword low. Close. Close enough.

It was darker than the other.

It was the darkest thing he had seen since the river.

His body was already moving. It had been that way since the cave. It did not wait for him. It had seen the darker road the moment he did, and it had gone, and he went with it. Out of his place. Out from Shigure's left. Along the road and up the slope toward the house, both swords out, through the first of the grey men before the man knew he was there.

Behind him, Shigure's voice. Still low. Still even. Still placing them.

He did not hear what it said.

***

Shigure had them.

He had all of them. He had the slopes and the house and the grey men and the dark ones with the stars, the whole of it at once, the way he had always had it, laid out in him like the map. It was wrong. The papers had been a door, and they had walked through it, and the room on the other side had been waiting for them. He saw that. He had seen it the moment the snow stood up. It did not matter now. What mattered was where everyone was.

Kurogane, hold. Kurogane was holding. The right of the narrow place was a wall with a sword in it.

Hayate, the left slope, now. Hayate was coming, across the road behind him, fast, low, to the left slope, where the grey men were thickest.

Enji. At the bend. The first of the dark ones had come around from the house the long way, to take them from behind, and gone into Enji at the bend, and they were not coming out.

It was holding. It was bad, and it was holding.

And on his left, Ren.

He did not look. He had never needed to look. He could feel where Ren was the way he could feel his own left hand. He did not have to think about it. He had put the stone there with his own fingers.

He turned to the left to meet the grey men coming down the steep slope on that side, and he turned into the place where Ren was, the way you step onto a stair in the dark knowing it is there.

It was not there.

There was nobody on his left.

He saw it all at once. The empty snow where Ren had been standing. The footprints going away from it, along the road, and up. And up there, far, going away up the slope behind the house through the grey men, not looking back, both swords out, Ren. Going toward something. Toward a man in dark clothes standing among the oaks above the house, who had not moved.

Shigure understood it all at once, the way he understood everything. The man on the slope. Why he was standing where he could be seen. Why he had not moved. What he was for.

And the gap.

On his left. Where the stone had been. Where no one was.

Someone came through it.

Not down the slope. Not from the house. From nowhere, out of the grey men on the left, where there had been no one a moment before, and there was someone. Short. Lean. Grey clothes. His eyes over a strip of dark cloth.

Shigure read him.

He read him the way he read everything, all at once, the feet and the shoulders and the hands and the eyes, where the weight was, where the blade was, where the next thing would come from. It was there. He saw it. The cut coming, from the right, high, at the neck. He was already moving to answer it. His knife was already coming up to where it would be.

It was not there.

It had not come. It was going to come. It was half a beat behind where it should have been, and his knife was in the air answering nothing, and the man's eyes over the cloth were perfectly calm.

There was no time to answer the real one.

He knew that. He had time to know it. He had time for one thing, and his body did not choose it and he did not choose it. It came up out of him on its own, the way the smile had that morning in the passage.

"Ren."

It was not a shout. It was not loud. He said it the way you say a name in a house when you want to know if someone is there.

The cut arrived.

***

Ren heard it.

Halfway up the slope. The grey men falling away on either side of him. Raiden above him among the oaks, twenty paces. Fifteen. Close enough.

His name. From below. From behind him. Not called. Said.

In Shigure's voice.

His feet stopped.

He did not tell them to. They stopped under him on the slope in the snow, and the rest of him stopped with them, and he turned around.

Shigure was on the road. In the middle of it. Where the stone had been.

He was standing very straight.

A short man with a cloth over his face was stepping back from him, away, lightly. A long blade in his hand. The man did not look at Shigure. He did not look at anything. He took one step back and then another, into the grey men on the left slope, and there was a moment when Ren could see him and then there was not.

Shigure stood a moment longer.

Then he went down.

He went down onto the road without any sound. His knees, and then the rest of him. On his side, in the snow, in the middle of the narrow place, with one hand still out a little in front of him, open, where the knife had been.

On his left, where the stone had been, there was no one.

Everything stopped.

Not the fighting. The fighting stopped too, but that was not what stopped. The grey men on the slopes stopped. The dark ones at the fence. Kurogane on the right of the road with his sword out. Hayate halfway across it, on one knee, his face turned. Enji at the bend with his hand in his bag. Everyone. All at once. As if the whole valley had been holding its breath for this and now it had been let out.

Ren stood on the slope with both swords in his hands.

He could not move.

It was not the heat. The heat was gone. It had gone out of him the moment he turned, like water out of a cracked bowl, and there was nothing where it had been.

It was not the doors. The doors were gone too.

For the first time since the river, since the moon on the fog and the first line of the second scroll, there was only one thing. Not three laid over each other. Not five. Not every good road going out from every piece on the board. One. One thing, in front of him, perfectly clear, perfectly still, and there was nothing laid over it and nothing behind it and nothing else anywhere.

Shigure on the road. On his side. In the snow. In the place where the stone had been, with the empty place beside him.

Ren had seen everything.

He had seen every one of them, every line, every gap, every man on every slope. He had seen the road where he stayed and the road where he went. He had seen them both all the way out.

He had not seen this.

It had been there. It had been there the whole time, in the road where he went, at the very beginning of it, before any of the rest, and he had not seen it, because he had been looking at the end.

Behind him, above, on the slope among the oaks, something moved.

He turned his head.

Raiden had not come down. He had not raised his sword. He was standing exactly where he had been standing, with his sword low and the point toward the ground, and he was looking at Ren.

Then he looked past Ren. Down the slope. At the road, and what was lying on it.

Then back at Ren.

His face did not change. It never did. He had not needed to do anything. He had only needed to be seen.

He turned and walked away through the oaks, and was gone.

Somewhere on the slope, a whistle. Short. Low.

The grey men went. All of them at once, the way they had come. Back into the snow, into the trees, up and over the slopes, and the dark ones went with them, back through the fence and around the house and away. In the space of three breaths the valley was empty.

Nobody went after them.

Nobody moved at all.

***

Enji made the fire.

Nobody asked him to. Nobody said anything. When the light began to go he got up from where he had been kneeling in the snow at the bend, and went to the shed behind the empty house, and began to carry wood out of it. Split wood, dry, stacked for the winter by whoever had lived there. He carried it into the road, into the narrow place, an armful at a time. Kurogane got up after a while and carried too. Hayate carried, with one arm.

Ren did not carry.

He was standing a little way off, at the edge of the road, where he had come down off the slope. He had not moved from there. He had not sheathed his swords. They hung at his sides in his hands, and the snow had started again, lightly, and it was landing on the blades.

Enji built it the way you build a thing that has to burn well. He knew how. Air under it. The big pieces crossed. The small ones in the middle. When it was high enough Kurogane lifted Shigure and laid him on it, and straightened his coat, and put his hands where they went, and stepped back.

Enji took something out of his bag. Small. Round. A clay ball, one of the little ones.

He looked at it in his hand.

He had made it. He had made it in the storehouse, grinding and packing, yesterday, when his hands had finally started working again. He had made it for today. For the bend. For anything that came around the other way.

He broke it open with his thumbs and poured what was in it into the kindling at the bottom, and struck the flint once, and it took.

It went up fast. Faster than wood alone. It went up bright and white and then orange, with a sound like a breath, and the heat came out across the road and pushed at their faces.

It was his. Every bit of it. He had made it with his hands and he had decided when it went, and it had gone exactly where he meant it to go.

He hated it.

He had never hated anything he made before.

They stood in the road.

Nobody had decided where to stand. They had only stopped where they were when the fire went up, and where they were was close. Hayate at Enji's shoulder. Kurogane beside Hayate, his sword in his hand, the point down. And a little way off, at the edge of it, but near, nearer than he had been to any of them in a month, Ren. With his swords still out. With the snow on them.

Nobody spoke.

The fire went up into the grey. The smoke went straight up, the way it had gone up from the house that morning, thin and then thick, and above them on both slopes, in the bare oaks, all along the branches, black against the white, the crows had come.

They did not call.

They sat on the branches in rows and looked down at the fire, and at the four of them standing near it, and at the one who was lying in it.

The snow came down.

Nobody moved.

Chapter 59

Collapse

They came back to the house on the second morning.

Hayate walked in front. He had not meant to. Somebody had to, and the one who always had was not there, and Hayate's feet had simply gone to the front of the line on the road out of the valley and stayed there, and nobody had said anything about it. Behind him Enji. Behind Enji, Ren. Kurogane last, where he always was, with his sword in his hand and not in his sash.

The gate. The wisteria, bare, with snow in the crooks of it. The yard, white and untrodden, the ring of stones in the middle of it a row of soft humps. The storehouse with its door shut. The house.

Hayate stopped in the yard.

He did not know why he had stopped. He stood there with the snow to his ankles and looked at the house, and the others stopped behind him, and nobody went past him to the step.

It looked the same. That was the thing. The same thatch. The same paper doors. The same step, worn in the middle. It looked exactly the way it had looked two mornings ago when they had walked out of it, when Shigure had come out last and slid the door shut behind him and checked it, once, with two fingers, the way he always did.

Nobody had checked it since.

Hayate went up the step and slid it open.

***

The house was cold. The hearth was ash. The kettle hung over it on its hook, empty.

On the board by the hearth, in the corner where Shigure kept things, were the plates. Five of them. Stacked, clean, the way Shigure had left them the morning they went, one inside the next. The top one had a little rim of grey dust on it.

Hayate stood looking at them.

He did not know what to do next. That was the thing he found out, standing there. It was a very small thing, and he found it out all at once, the way you find out in the dark that a step you thought was there is not.

He did not know what they did next.

Not tomorrow. Not the road to Raiden, or the man with the cloth over his face, or any of that. Now. This morning. Who lit the fire. Who went to the town for rice and fish. Whether they ate, and when, and who cooked it, and who set the plates out, and how many. Whether they slept here tonight, or whether it was safe, or whether anywhere was. Whether somebody should be on the roof. Whether somebody should go and look at the road.

Shigure had known. Shigure had always known, before anyone asked, before anyone thought to ask. He had just done it. He had gotten up in the morning and it had been done, the fire and the water and the rice and the watch on the road and the map on the floor with the stones on it, and all any of them had ever had to do was walk into it.

Hayate knelt by the hearth.

He cleared the ash. He did it badly, with his one good hand, and got it on his knees. He laid the kindling. He could not remember how Shigure laid it, whether the long pieces went first or the short ones. He laid them the way he thought. He struck the flint.

It took on the fourth strike.

It was a poor fire. It smoked. He sat back on his heels and watched it smoke, and did not fix it.

Behind him, the others had come in. Enji had gone to his corner and sat down in it with his bag in his lap and his back to the wall. Ren had gone to the far side of the room, to the wall by the passage, and sat down against it with the old blanket around his shoulders and his swords across his knees, and was looking at the floor in front of him.

Kurogane had not sat down.

He was standing just inside the door. Looking at nothing. His sword in his hand.

Nobody spoke.

The fire smoked. Hayate did not fix it.

***

Kurogane knew.

He had known on the road. He had known before the fire went up. He had known, standing in the narrow place with his sword out, the moment Shigure went down onto his side in the snow with his hand open in front of him.

He did not need to think about it. He had never needed to think about things like this. They came to him whole, the way the shape of a fight came, and he looked at them, and they did not change.

He went and knelt on the far side of the hearth, away from the others, and took the map out of his coat.

He had taken it from Shigure's coat before he laid him on the wood. He had not decided to. His hand had gone inside the coat and found the roll of paper there, where Shigure always kept it, and taken it out, and put it inside his own coat, and he had not looked at it since.

He unrolled it on the boards. The stones fell out of it into his palm. Five. Smooth and cold.

He set them out.

Not the way Shigure had. He did not know how to do that. He only put them where they had been in the narrow place, at the moment it happened, because he had been there and he could see it.

His own. On the right. Holding.

Hayate's. Crossing the road, low, going to the left slope. Late.

Enji's. At the bend, behind.

Shigure's. In the middle. Where the road narrowed. Where everything had to come past him.

And the fifth.

He held it.

He did not put it on the left, where Shigure had put it. He knew where it had been. He put it there. Up the slope. Far. Behind the house. Almost off the edge of the paper. Going toward a man who had stood among the oaks with his sword low and never once raised it.

He looked at the map.

At the place on the left of Shigure's stone. The place Shigure had held his hand over for a long time by the fire, and then set the stone down in, close, touching almost. The place where there was nothing now. Just the paper. Just the line of the road.

That was where the man with the cloth over his face had come through.

He had seen it. He had been on the right, holding, with three of them on him, and he had turned his head at the moment it happened, because some part of him had been listening for Shigure's voice all morning and had heard it stop. And he had seen the man. Short. Lean. The strip of cloth. Coming through the empty place on the left as if it had been left open for him. As if it had been a door.

It had been a door.

He looked at the fifth stone, far off up the slope.

He did not blame it. That was not how things came to him. The stone had gone where it had gone. It was a thing that had happened, like the snow.

But it had made a door.

And someone had walked through it.

Kurogane looked at the empty place on the left of Shigure's stone for a long time.

If it fails?

Then you fully commit. You don't hesitate.

He had not meant to remember it. He had not known he was keeping it. It had gone into him by the fire three nights ago, over a board he did not know how to play, and gone down wherever things went in him, and he had not thought of it once since. And now it was there. All of it. The voice, quiet, not looking up. The silver moving on the board. *As if it were only another move.*

It had failed.

Kurogane picked up Shigure's stone.

He held it a moment. It was warm from the hearth. Then he put it inside his sash, against his body, where it would not fall out.

He left the others on the map. He did not roll it up.

He stood.

***

Enji saw him stand.

He was in his corner with the bag in his lap. He had not opened it. He had been sitting with his hands on it and not opening it since they came in, and it was the longest he had ever sat with his hands still in his life. He did not know what to do with them. They had always known before. They had always been doing something, grinding, packing, pinching, tying, shaping, and he had never once had to think about it. Now they were lying on the bag like two things somebody had set down and forgotten.

Kurogane stood up from the hearth.

He did not look at any of them.

He went to the wall where his things were, and knelt, and took them. It did not take long. Kurogane had never had very much. The three knives, one after another, into his sash. A cloth bundle, small, knotted at the top. A straw hat. His sandals, the winter ones, bound with cord. He put them on. He tied them. Both feet. Tight.

He put his sword through his sash.

He stood up.

Enji watched him.

He knew what it was. Everyone in the room knew what it was. Nobody had to say. Kurogane had come to them, Hayate had told it a hundred times, on a riverbank, kneeling on a mat with his hands bound and a board with his name on it, and he had never once since then picked up his things like that, all at once, all of them, and put his sandals on and tied them tight. He had never needed to. Everything he needed to take with him he was already carrying.

He was going.

Enji opened his mouth.

Nothing came out of it. He did not know what would have. He did not know a single thing he could have said that would have been the right size.

Kurogane walked to the door.

He did not look at the hearth, where Hayate was kneeling by the smoking fire. He did not look at the corner, where Enji was sitting with his hands on the bag. He did not look at the wall by the passage, where Ren was.

He did not look at anyone.

At the door he stopped. Only for the space of a breath. His hand was on the frame. He stood there with his back to all of them and the grey light coming in around him from the yard, and the snow beyond, and the gate.

Hayate had turned his head. He was looking at Kurogane's back. His face was very still. His good hand was on his knee, and Enji saw it close, slowly, and then open again, and stay open.

Hayate did not get up.

He did not say anything.

Enji looked at Ren.

Ren was sitting against the wall with the blanket over his shoulders and the swords across his knees. He had not moved. He had not looked up. His eyes were on the floor in front of him, on the boards, on nothing, and they did not lift to the door, and his hands did not move on the swords, and his face did not do anything at all.

Kurogane took his hand off the frame.

He stepped down off the step into the snow.

Enji watched him go across the yard. The way he always walked, as if the ground were a thing he had already decided about. Past the white humps of the fire ring. Past the storehouse. To the gate, under the bare wisteria.

He did not look back.

He went through the gate, and turned onto the path down through the bamboo, and the bamboo closed behind him, and then there were only his footprints going across the yard, one after another, very straight, filling up slowly with the snow that had started again.

Nobody moved.

Enji sat with his hands on the bag.

He did not open it. He did not grin, or laugh, or say something about what Kurogane had forgotten, or run after him with a bundle of rice cakes, or throw something at the wall to make a noise. He did not do any of the things he always did. He sat there and his hands lay on the bag and the room was very quiet.

The fire smoked.

Hayate knelt by it and did not fix it.

Ren looked at the floor.

On the boards by the hearth, the map lay open where Kurogane had left it. Four stones on it. One on the right, one crossing the road, one at the bend, one far up the slope behind the house, almost off the paper.

And in the middle, where the road narrowed, nothing at all.

ACT V
MIST

Chapter 60
Distance

It was still dark when Ren got up.

He did not wake. He had not been asleep. He had been lying on his back in the cold with his eyes open, the way he lay most nights now, and at a certain point in the dark, with no sound and no reason, it was time, and he got up.

The house was very quiet. Hayate was a shape under a quilt by the wall, breathing slow. In the corner where Enji slept there was another shape, sitting up, but Ren did not look at it.

He folded the blanket first.

The old one. Brown, coarse, darned at the corner. He folded it the way he had folded it on the mountain, on the last morning, when the old man sat in front of the fire with his back to him and did not turn around. Once. Twice. Three times. Into a square. Then he rolled the square tight, and tied it with a cord at each end, the way you tie something that has to ride a long way without coming loose. Inside it, in the middle of the roll, where no hand would find it unless it unrolled the whole thing, the scroll.

Then clothes. The spare coat. The leggings. The cloth for the feet. Folded. Laid on a square of cloth. The corners of the cloth brought up and knotted, and pulled once to test the knot.

The belt.

He took it from the peg by the wall. Dark leather, oiled. The slots and loops sewn along it. The needles in their places, and the sealed shells, and the short blade, and the clay balls, two of them, each with its tail of cord, and the empty loop where the third had been since Kōga. He put it over his head and across his chest, from the right shoulder to the left hip, and pulled the strap through, and drew it tight, and tied it off. It sat against him. It sat well. Somebody had measured it for him a long time ago.

He did not think about who.

The blanket roll went on his back. The bundle over it.

The swords.

He put them through his sash. The old man's on the left. The grey one on the right, with the pattern in the steel like mist lying on water. One and then the other. The guards touched with a small iron knock.

He checked them.

Once.

He stood up.

The hearth was in front of him, in the middle of the floor. He looked at it. The ash was grey and flat and old. The kettle hung over it, empty, on its hook. Nobody had built a fire in it before light since the morning they had walked out of this house and come back without Shigure. Later in the day, sometimes. Hayate, badly, with one hand. Never before light. Nobody had gotten up in the dark to do it. That had been one of the things Shigure did, and nobody had known it was one of the things until it was not done.

Ren could have done it.

He could see himself do it. Kneeling at the pit. Clearing it. Laying it new. The long pieces first. Crossed. Two strikes. He could see the fire catch, and the light go up the walls, and Hayate wake to it, and turn over, and see who was kneeling there. He could see what Hayate's face would do.

He saw it all the way to the end.

He did not kneel.

He walked across the room to the door.

Something rolled across the floor.

It came out of the dark by the wall, slowly, over the boards, turning, with a small dry sound like a pebble on a step. It came across the room toward him the way something comes that has been sent, not thrown. It slowed. It stopped against the side of his foot.

He looked down at it.

A clay ball. Small. The size of the ones on his belt, but plain. No cord. No seal. Nothing inside it. Just clay, rolled round between two palms and fired in the pit behind the storehouse, the way Enji rolled them when his hands needed something to do and there was nothing yet for them to make.

He looked up.

Enji was sitting against the wall in the dark, in his corner. His knees up. His arms around them. He was awake. He had been awake, Ren understood, the whole time. The folding. The belt. The swords. All of it. He had sat there in the dark and watched every piece of it and not moved and not said anything.

He did not move now. He did not say anything now.

He only watched.

Ren looked back down at the clay ball against his foot.

He knew what it was. He had seen it before. On a night in the spring, when they had all sat around a fire in the open and Hayate had been telling a story badly, and Enji had rolled one of these across the ground, slow, turning, and it had stopped by Hayate's knee. And Hayate had picked it up, carefully, and looked at it, and set it down beside him. And gone on talking. And nobody had said anything about it, because there had been nothing that needed to be said. It had meant *you are here. I am here.* It had meant *stay.*

Ren looked at it.

He could see all the ways. He could see himself bend and pick it up, and hold it, and turn it in his fingers, and look across the dark at Enji. He could see himself set it down beside him. He could see himself put it in his sleeve and take it with him. He could see himself say Enji's name. He could see each of them all the way out. Where it went. What it did. How it ended.

None of them finished.

He stepped over it.

He slid the door open. The cold came in, grey and sharp, smelling of snow going soft. He stepped down off the step into the yard, and slid the door shut behind him.

He did not check it.

He walked across the yard. Past the humps of the fire ring, which were not white anymore but grey and sunken, with the dark stones showing through. Past the storehouse. To the gate.

At the gate he did not stop.

Once, a long time ago, in a room full of red light and smoke and a hole in the wall and a girl standing in it with her dagger gone, he had looked back. Just once. Just at the end. He had not meant to, and he had, and it had cost something, and he had never known what.

He did not look back.

He went through the gate, and down through the bamboo, and the bamboo closed behind him.

***

Hayate woke up cold.

That was the first thing. Before he knew where he was, before he knew what day it was, he was cold. The kind of cold that gets under a quilt from below, through the boards, and settles in your back. He lay with his eyes shut and felt it and thought, somebody should light the fire, and then he opened his eyes and remembered who that had been.

No fire.

The light was coming in grey through the paper of the doors. The hearth was ash. The kettle hung over it, empty.

He sat up.

He looked across the room, the way he looked every morning, before he had decided to. At the wall by the passage.

Ren's place was empty.

Not empty the way it was empty when Ren had gone out to the yard in the night and would come back. Empty the way a place is empty when there is nothing left in it. The blanket was gone. Not rolled against the wall. Gone. The peg by the wall was bare where the belt had hung. The boards where the swords had lain every night across Ren's knees were only boards.

Hayate looked at it.

In the corner, Enji was sitting against the wall.

He had not moved. Enji had been sitting there all night, in that exact place, with his knees up and his arms around them, and he was sitting there now, and he was not looking at Hayate. He was looking at the door.

By the door, on the boards, a small clay ball.

Hayate looked at it for a long time.

He did not get up and run to the door. He did not go out into the yard and shout. He did not go down to the gate, or through the bamboo, or down to the road to look along it both ways. He could have. His legs knew how. On any other morning before this one they would have had him through the door before he knew he was standing.

He did not need to.

He already knew.

He had known in the snow. Sitting in the yard with the cold coming up through his trousers and Ren's hand on his wrist, exact, not hard. He had known it then, all of it, the whole of it, the way you know a thing that has already happened a long time ago and that you are only now being told about. Ren had gone that night. He had gone before that. He had been going for a long time, somewhere Hayate could not see into, a step at a time, and the snow had only been the night Hayate finally saw how far.

This morning was not the leaving.

This morning was just the part you could see.

Hayate got up.

He crossed the room to the door. The boards were cold under his feet. He bent and picked up the clay ball.

It was small and plain and cold, and it fit in the middle of his palm. No cord. Nothing inside. Just clay. He could feel the marks of Enji's fingers in it, the little flat places where it had been rolled.

He held it a moment.

Then he went back across the room to the corner, and sat down on the boards beside Enji, close, their shoulders almost touching. He did not say anything.

He set the clay ball down beside Enji. Carefully. On the boards. The way he had set one down beside himself once, by a fire, a long time ago, in the middle of a story he was telling badly.

Enji looked at it.

He did not pick it up. He did not look at Hayate. After a while his head went down, onto his arms, onto his knees, and stayed there.

Neither of them said anything.

The cold came in under the door. The light came up grey through the paper. Somewhere outside, water was dripping off the eaves, slow, one drop and then another, the way it does when the snow on a roof has finally started to go.

And past the yard, past the wall, along the path down through the bamboo where nobody was walking, the plum trees were starting to bloom.

Chapter 61

Patterns

Outside, Osaka was loud with the spring. Boats on the canals again, now the ice had gone out of the edges. Carts on the bridges. Hammers in the timber yards. The whole city turning over after the winter like a man turning over in his sleep, and the sound of it coming in through the walls as a single low murmur, like water far off.

Inside, the room was dark and still.

The long hall. The floor of polished boards. No windows. The light coming in through the slats high up under the roof in thin bars that lay across the floor at an angle and did not move. Cedar, and oil, and nothing else.

Four figures moved in it.

Hanzō stood at one end and watched them.

Jin, and Ayame, and Daichi, and Kenshiro. Four points of a square that turned and closed and opened and turned again. Ayame's thigh had healed. Kenshiro's forearm had healed to a long pale line between the dark grey bindings he wore at wrist and elbow. They moved as if nothing had ever been cut. Daichi went low in the east corner and Jin came over him, and the two in the west and south crossed behind, and not one foot came down anywhere but where Hanzō had drawn it.

No one was out of place. No one was early. No one was late.

He watched the spaces between them.

A door slid open at the far end of the hall. White light came in, and a man with it, and the door closed. The man crossed the edge of the floor, not the middle, and knelt a few paces from Hanzō with his head down.

"Master Hanzō."

A folded paper, held up in both hands.

Hanzō took it. He opened it.

Five lines, in the small plain hand he knew.

A Kōga house in the hills above Kusatsu, nine days past. Five dead. One cut each. The fire still lit. The next, a Fūma camp in the Suzuka forest, four days past. Burned. Eleven. Before either was found, crows.

He read it.

He read it again. Not the words. The shape of it.

Behind him, in the hall, the square turned and closed and opened. He could hear it. He did not need to look.

In the spring of last year he had stood exactly here, with a paper exactly like this in his hand, and read about a boy bleeding in a valley between Kōga and Fūma, and folded the paper along its creases, once, twice, and put it in his sleeve, and turned back to the square, and watched it until the light had gone off the floor.

He did not fold this one.

"Stop," he said.

The square stopped.

All four of them, at once, where they stood. Daichi still low in the east corner. Jin over him, one foot still in the air, and then down. Ayame and Kenshiro halfway through their crossing, turned to each other. The bars of light lay across them, very still.

It had never stopped before. Not once. Not in all the years he had stood at this end of the hall. They looked at him. None of them spoke. Jin's breath was going in and out, a little fast, the only sound in the room.

Hanzō walked out onto the floor.

He knelt in the middle of it, where the square had been, in a bar of light, and took a map from inside his coat and unrolled it on the boards. The Kinai. The lake. The roads out of the capital. The hills. He weighted the corners with his fan and his hand.

From his sleeve, a small bag. He emptied it into his palm. Stones, black and white, the kind men play with on a board.

He set down a white one. Above Kusatsu.

He set down another. In the Suzuka forest.

He set down a third, and a fourth, and a fifth, from what the paper said and from what the three papers before it had said, and from what he had been told in the street and in the teahouse by the Tenma bridge and by a monk on the road from Nara who did not know he was being asked anything. A line of white stones across the map. Not straight. But not scattered.

Then the black ones. Kōga. Where the survivors of the fire had gone, and the houses they still kept, and the roads they were using, and where, in the hills north of the lake, a snowbound house at the end of a narrow road had been left open for four men and a boy to walk into.

A line of black stones.

He looked at the two lines.

They were not the same line. But they were going to the same place. He could see it the way he could see, on a board, a move that was twenty moves away and already made.

The four of them had come in close without being told. They were standing around the map in a ring, looking down.

"Jin. Ayame." He touched the white line. "Him."

Jin's eyes went to the stones and stayed there.

"Daichi. Kenshiro." The black line. "Kōga."

Daichi nodded once.

"Don't engage," said Hanzō. "Follow."

Silence.

Jin looked up.

"He'll know we're there."

"Yes."

Jin hesitated. His eyes went to the white stones again. Hanzō knew what was in them. The forest last autumn. The cedar slope. The leaves. The boy in the leaves, and the boy getting up out of them, and every one of Hanzō's people on that slope looking at him and understanding, for the first time, what it was they were looking at.

"And if he does?"

"Then he'll know he's being followed," said Hanzō. "That changes nothing."

He looked at the map.

A year ago, the boy had been a piece he did not have a name for. A loose piece, on the edge of the board, that might be useful and might not. He had moved other pieces around it. He had waited to see which way it would go.

He did not do that now.

He picked up one more white stone. He did not put it on the white line. He put it in the middle of the map. In the middle of everything. Where the two lines were going.

Then he set the rest of the stones around it. Kōga. Fūma. Iga. His own. Not in lines now. In a ring.

The four of them looked at it.

Nobody said anything.

***

The house was on the quiet street behind the castle. The lamp stood on the floor between them and made its small round world of light, and held the two trays, and the two of them, and not much else. The hearth at the end of the room was cold. It had always been cold.

Yukino had cooked. Rice. Clear soup. Grilled fish, the skin crisp. The first butterbur buds of the year, bitter and green.

Behind Hanzō, on the shelf against the wall, was a box. Plain wood. Long. Tied with a cord. It had been on that shelf since the autumn, and he had never once taken it down in front of her, and she had never once asked what was in it.

Yukino looked at it.

Once. Only once. Her eyes went past his shoulder to the shelf, and rested on the box, and came back.

Then she looked at him.

It was a long look. She had been looking at him like this for many years, and he had always let her, because it was her house as much as his and she could look at what she liked. But this was longer than usual. He could feel it go over his face, and his hands, and the way he was holding his chopsticks, and the bowl, and the amount of rice that was left in it.

"Something changed," she said.

He raised his eyes and met hers.

The same as before. He knew she knew.

"There's movement."

She did not ask where. She had asked that the last time. She did not need to ask it again.

"Are you going to stop it?"

The lamp burned. Outside, far off, the night watchman was walking his round, knocking his two sticks together at the corners, and the sound came and went.

Hanzō paused.

"Yes."

Yukino looked at him.

She did not say anything. It was there between them in the lamplight, the whole of that other evening, laid under this one like a sheet of paper under another.

She did not pick up her chopsticks.

Hanzō went back to eating.

He took a mouthful of rice. And another. The fish. The butterbur buds, which were very good, which were the first of the year and which he would have told her were very good on any other night.

He put his chopsticks down across the bowl.

There was rice left in it.

He had not left rice in a bowl at this table in all the years she had cooked for him. She looked at it. He looked at the lamp.

Behind him, on the shelf, the box sat where it had sat all winter.

***

The house was high in the hills above Kusatsu, at the end of a track that nobody would take by accident. Jin found it on the third day, following a woodcutter's rumor and then the crows.

They were on the roof when he came up the track. Eight or nine of them, sitting along the ridge, black against the grey. They did not fly when he came. They turned their heads and looked at him and stayed where they were, as if he were late.

Inside, five men.

Kōga. He knew them by their dark blue and by the stars in their sleeves. They lay where they had been, in the main room and the passage and one just outside the back door, on his face in the mud. Nobody had moved them. Nobody had buried them.

And the hearth in the middle of the floor had been laid and left.

Cold now. Someone had built it with the long pieces at the bottom and the short ones crossed on top, and it had burned down slowly, clean, with no smoke, until there was nothing left to burn.

Jin knelt beside the nearest of them.

He looked at the cut. One. Across the throat and down, from the right, and nothing else anywhere on the man. He went to the next. One. The next. One. Every one of them the same. One cut each, and every cut exactly as long as it needed to be and not a finger's width longer, and not one of them had drawn.

He knelt by the one in the passage for a long time.

He had seen the boy fight twice. Once in the forest, on the slope, before any of them knew what he was. Once at Kōga, in the fog, from a distance, with the grey men going down around him like rice in front of a sickle. He had seen the style under it. Two swords, both long, one answering the other. The old man's style. Everyone who had fought in the last ten years knew about the old man's style, even if they had never seen it.

It was there. Under it. The way the cut began.

But there was something on top of it now. Something that had not been there in the forest. The cuts did not look like they had been answered. They looked like they had been waiting. As if each man had walked, of his own accord, into a place where the blade had already been.

Out behind the house, where the track went on into the trees, there was a ring of stones.

Small. Neat. The ash in it cold and flat. Somebody had made a fire there, a morning fire, before light, and cooked something and eaten it and let the fire go out, and gone on.

Jin stood up.

That night, by a fire of his own, a long way down the hill, he took out the paper and the ink for the report and wet the brush. He looked at the paper for a long time.

He wrote one word.

Him.

***

The map was on the table in the room with the brazier. The same room. The same map. Only the season outside it had changed.

Kikyo stood over it with a handful of reports in one hand and a handful of needles in the other.

She read the first report. She put a needle into the map where it said. At the top of the needle she tied a small thread, and knotted it, once, for the number of dead.

One.

The second. Two knots.

The third. Four.

The fourth. Six.

She went on. The fifth. The sixth. The needles went into the paper one after another, and the knots on them grew, and she did not hurry. When the reports were finished she put the rest of the needles down on the table in a neat row and stepped back.

She looked at what she had made.

They made a line.

Not a straight one. It wandered, the way a road wanders, around the hills and along the river and back. But it was a line. Every needle a little further on than the one before. Every one a little closer to the edge of the map.

She stood looking at it.

"He isn't hiding," she said.

At the head of the table, by the brazier, Takeru had not moved. He was looking at the needles too. He looked at them the way he looked at everything, as if it were a thing that could be weighed.

"Where is he going?"

Kikyo did not answer at once.

She looked at the last needle. At the end of the line. Where it pointed.

Then she lifted her eyes and looked across the room.

Raiden was standing against the wall by the door, where he always stood. His arms were folded. His sword was at his hip. He had not come to the table. He had not looked at the map once since she began.

He was looking at her.

Kikyo looked back at him for a moment.

Then she looked down at the map again, and did not answer.

***

The camp had been in a hollow among the pines in the Suzuka forest, where the ground was dry and a spring came out of the rock. Twelve men. It had been a good place. Shinmei had chosen it himself.

It was black now.

He walked through it in the grey of the morning, slowly, with his hands in his sleeves. The shelters had burned down to their frames and fallen in. The ground was black and soft underfoot and the smell of it was everywhere. There were crows in the pines all around, waiting. He did not look at them.

He looked at where the bodies had fallen.

Eleven. He knew where each of them had been standing, because he knew where each of them would have been standing, because he had put them there. The two on the rise, watching the path. The three by the spring. The four at the fire. The two at the far end, by the horses.

He walked to each place.

He stood where each man had fallen and looked at which way he had been facing.

The two on the rise had been facing the path. That was right. That was where they should have been facing. And they had died facing it, and the cuts had come from behind.

The three by the spring had been facing the rise, where the shouting had started. They had died facing it. The cuts had come from the side, low.

The four at the fire had turned, all four of them, toward the spring. They had died like that. The cuts had come from the fire itself. From the place they had just turned their backs on.

Every one of them. Every single one. Facing the right way. The way Shinmei would have faced them. The way anyone would have faced them, if they were reacting to what was happening.

And for every one of them, it had been the wrong way.

Shinmei stood in the black ground in the middle of the camp.

He understood.

He had spent his life making distance lie. Making a man a pace from where his eyes said he was. Making a fight happen three steps to the left of where it seemed to be happening. He knew what it looked like when something was not where it appeared to be.

This was not that. This was the opposite.

The boy had not been hiding where he was.

He had simply not been reacting to them at all. Not to where they were. Not to where they were looking. He had been going, each time, to the place they were about to be, and waiting there, and they had arrived.

Shinmei looked up.

The crows were in the pines. All around the hollow. Dozens of them. They had been there, the one who got away had said, before the fire. Before anything. They had been in the trees all evening, silent, and nobody had thought anything of it.

He did not look away from them for a long time.

***

The market was full. The first market of the spring, with the snow gone off the fields and the roads open again, and everyone who had been shut in all winter out in the lanes with something to sell and something to say.

Aoi walked through it.

She did not carry the spear to market. She carried a basket. She bought what she had come for. Salt. Dried fish. A bundle of the first greens from the lower fields. She did not stop to talk. People did not stop her to talk, either, much. She was used to that now.

But she could hear them.

At the salt seller's. At the stall with the pots. At the corner by the well where the old men sat. The same thing, in different words, in pieces, going from one mouth to the next the way everything went in the spring.

A man, somewhere in the hills. Two swords. Killing Kōga. Killing Fūma. Whole houses. Whole camps. Nobody saw him. Nobody ever saw him. You only found them after. One cut each. And the crows, the crows were always there first, sitting on the roof, waiting, as if they had been told.

Aoi kept walking.

She did not ask. She did not turn her head. She did not slow down.

She went past the salt seller and the pots and the well, and out of the market by the lane that went down toward the stream.

Only once, at the end of the lane, where nobody could see her, her free hand went to her sleeve.

It stayed there for a moment. Resting on the cloth. On the small shape inside it, which she could feel through the cloth, one wing bent, the head on one side.

Then it came away, and she walked on.

***

Jin and Ayame lost his tracks again on the fifth day.

They had been following them since the house above Kusatsu. Following was not the right word. There were no tracks, most of the time. There was a morning fire in a ring of stones, cold, and then nothing for a day. Then a place where a man had crossed a stream and come out the other side, and then nothing. Then a woodcutter who had seen someone on the ridge at dusk, or thought he had. And then nothing again.

It was worse than following a man who was running. A man who was running left a path. He left it because he was running. This one was not running. He was only going. And he did not leave anything he did not mean to.

They stood on a ridge in the grey afternoon with the wind coming up it, and looked out over the forest, and there was no one in it.

Ayame sat down on a rock.

She had not complained. She had not complained once in five days. Her thigh had healed, but it ached in the cold, and he had seen her favor it on the steep places and say nothing.

"How do we follow someone who leaves no path?"

Jin did not answer.

He was looking out over the trees. At the grey. At nothing.

Then something moved in it.

A long way off. Above the forest. Black specks, a handful of them, and then more, rising up out of the trees to the south, and turning together in the wind the way a shoal turns, all at once, and going. Not scattered. Not wheeling. Going. In one direction, low over the treetops, steady, as if they knew exactly where.

East.

Jin watched them go.

He watched until they were very small, and then gone.

"We don't follow him," he said.

Ayame looked up at him.

Jin was still looking east, where the crows had gone.

"We follow them."

Chapter 62

Separation

He woke before the sun.

He did not know where. It did not matter where. A hollow under a bank, out of the wind, with the roots of a chestnut over him and last year's leaves under him, damp and cold. The sky through the branches was the color of charcoal going to ash. No birds yet.

He got up.

He made a fire.

He did not need it. He had eaten the night before and would not eat again until the evening. He would be gone from this hollow before the sun was clear of the hills, and the fire would burn on without him, or go out, and it would not matter which.

He made it anyway.

A ring of stones, from the bank. The dead leaves scraped away from the middle. Tinder, dry, from the pouch at his belt. The long pieces first. Crossed. Two strikes.

It caught.

He made it every morning now. Every morning since the house. He did not think about why. His hands did it before his thoughts were awake, the way the old man's had every morning of eleven years in the cave, and the way his own had every morning on the road after that, and every morning in the yard of the house with the wisteria over the gate, until they had stopped.

They had started again. He had not asked them to.

He sat in front of it.

For a moment. Only a moment. He sat with his hands on his knees and his back straight and watched it go up small and steady in the grey, the flames standing up the way they stood when the wood was laid right, no smoke. The light moved on the roots over his head.

He did not think anything.

Then he got up, and went a little way off, to a flat place between the trees, and drew both swords.

***

The sequence was one he had made himself.

Not the old man's. Not any of the old man's. It had come out of him over the winter, a piece at a time, in the yard and on the flat ground behind the kiln and in the snow, and it was his, and it was long, and it went through every way he knew of meeting a man who was already where you were going to be.

He went through it.

Left. Right. Low. The turn, and the step back that was not a step back. The two swords together, and apart, and together.

It was good.

He stood at the end of it with both swords lowered and his breath going white in front of him.

It was not good enough. The third movement had come a hair's width after it should have. Nobody could have seen it. He had seen it.

"Again," he said.

Out loud. To nobody.

He heard it go out into the trees.

It was the old man's word. The one word. The one the old man had said ten thousand times, on the path with the bucket, in the clearing with the legs shaking, by the fire with the whetstone going.

It was his own voice saying it.

It sounded wrong.

He did not know why. The word was the same. The breath was the same. He had said it the way it was meant to be said, quietly, not asking. But it went out of his mouth and into the grey among the trees and there was no one standing behind it. Nothing holding it up. It went out into the trees and was only a sound.

He ran it again.

It was perfect.

Every movement where it should be. The third came exactly when it should. The turn. The step. The two swords together and apart and together, and at the end of it they came to rest, and his breath went out white, and there was nothing wrong anywhere in it.

He stood there.

He did not feel anything.

Not the thing he used to feel. Not the small, quiet, complete thing that had come at the end of a form done right in the clearing, when the old man had not said again, and Ren had understood that the not-saying was the praise. Not that. Not anything.

He sheathed the swords.

He went back to the hollow and put the fire out with earth, and kicked the stones apart, and put on the blanket roll and the bundle, and went.

***

The raven went ahead of him on the road.

It had come with him from the house. He had not asked it to. On the first morning, going down through the bamboo in the dark, he had heard it behind him, and then over him, and then in front, and it had been there every day since. It went ahead. It landed, on a branch, on a post, on the roof of a shed by the road. It waited. When he came near it went on again, a little way. Landed. Waited.

Further back, the others.

Crows. Not his. Not anyone's. A handful of them in the mornings, more by afternoon, always a long way behind, going from tree to tree the way you follow a cart you think might drop something. He did not look at them. He knew they were there.

And further back than that, the two.

In the trees. On the ridges. Keeping their distance, a long way off, never on the road. A young man, quick and light, and a woman who favored one leg on the steep places. He had seen them three days ago, from a ridge, in the grey, two shapes going down into a valley he had crossed the day before. He knew whose they were. He knew the young man's face. He had fought him on a cedar slope in the autumn, in the leaves.

He did not change his road.

He did not go faster. He did not go into the forest where they would lose him, though he could have. He did not double back, or wait for them in a narrow place, or do any of the things he could see himself doing, all the way to the end of each of them.

Let them watch.

It did not change anything.

***

In the afternoon he came through a village.

A small one. A handful of houses along the road with their fields going away on both sides, the rice not in yet, the paddies still stubble and mud with a little grey water standing in them. Smoke from one roof. A dog that got up to bark at him and then thought better of it and lay back down.

By the well, children.

Four or five of them. Small. Playing some game with sticks and a circle drawn in the mud. As he came past, one of them, a boy, stooped and picked up a pebble and threw it at a girl, not hard, and it hit her on the shoulder, and he shrieked with laughter and ran. And she went after him, shrieking too, and they went away down the lane between the houses in a flurry of bare feet and mud, and the others went after them.

Ren stopped.

He watched them go.

Something came up in him. From very far down. A stream path in the evening, with the light low and gold on the water. Two children running toward him along it, kicking up dust that caught the light and hung. A girl with her head tipped all the way back to look up at him. A boy with a grin. *Your sweetheart?* And beside him, someone whose face had gone red all at once, from the neck to the ears, in the low sun, with nowhere for any of it to go.

It came up in him.

It went through him.

It went out the other side and left nothing. Not a place where it had been.

He went on through the village.

The raven was waiting on the last roof.

***

The rain came in the middle of the afternoon.

It came from the west, grey, in long slanting lines that walked across the fields toward him and then were on him, cold, steady, the first real rain of the spring. It ran off his hair and down the back of his neck. It soaked the bundle and the blanket roll and got in under the belt.

He did not look for shelter.

The road went up into hills. Rock came through the earth on either side. In the side of a slope, a little above the road, among ferns and dripping bamboo, there was a cave. A dark mouth in the grey stone, low, dry inside, the rain not reaching past the lip of it. A place a man could sit out an afternoon. A place a man could make a fire and sit in front of it with his hands on his knees and watch it and not move.

He saw it.

He did not stop.

He did not turn his head to look at it as he passed. He walked by it in the rain the way he had walked by the village, and the children, and everything else, and went on up the road into the hills, and the cave went by on his left and was gone behind him.

***

In the evening the rain stopped.

The clouds broke up in the west and the last of the light came through low and yellow, and every puddle on the road caught it. He knelt at one at the edge of the road, beside a field, and put his hands in it, and drank.

The water was cold. It tasted of earth and rain.

He looked down.

His face was in it. Dark against the yellow light. Still.

He lifted his hand from the water.

The hand in the puddle lifted with it.

Together. At the same moment. Not after. Not a breath behind. Exactly.

He looked at it for a while.

It did not move when he did not move. It moved when he moved. It was only a reflection, in a puddle, at the side of a road, with the evening light on it.

Whatever had made it move had stopped.

Or he had stopped noticing when it did.

He did not know which. He looked at it a moment longer and found he did not need to know. Either way, it was only a face in the water, and either way, it was his.

He stood up.

He looked east.

The road went on over the hills, into the dusk, toward Kōga. What was left of it. Its houses in the hills. Its roads. Its men, gathering, the way men gather when a thing has been coming toward them for a long time and they have finally understood it will not stop.

And somewhere among them, with his sword low in his right hand and the point toward the ground, one man.

Behind him, a long way back in the dusk, two shapes on a ridge, keeping their distance.

Further back than that, and to the south, and to the north, more. Grey ones. Dark ones. The ones who had been in the snow on both sides of the road. The ones with stars in their sleeves. All of them, from every side, closing, slowly, the way the dark closes on a fire at the end of the day, not all at once, but from everywhere.

He could feel it.

He had been able to feel it for days. Everything, from every direction, drawing in toward one place. Toward him. Toward where he was going.

He did not mind.

He was going there anyway.

The raven lifted off the fence post beside the field and went ahead of him down the road, into the east, and landed, and waited.

He walked toward it.

There was nothing behind him that he was going back to. There was no place he was going to stop. There was only the road, and the dusk, and the direction.

He kept walking.

Chapter 63

Manslayer

Kurogane came into the town after dark.

He had not meant to come into it at all. He had meant to go around it, the way he had gone around every town for twenty days, through the fields and along the edges of the woods, where nobody would see a man walking alone with a sword in his hand. But the road he was following went through it, and the tracks he was following went down the road, and he did not lose tracks.

A post town. One street, long, the road running down the middle of it between two rows of houses. Inns with their signs hung out. A teahouse. A shrine at the far end, under old cedars, with a stone lantern at the gate. The kind of place where men walking the road stopped for the night and drank and slept and went on in the morning.

It was not late. The first hour of dark.

He stopped at the edge of it, by the last field, in the shadow of a storehouse wall, and looked down the street.

Far off, somewhere over the hills to the east, crows were calling. The last of them going to roost. The sound came thin and broken across the dark and then stopped.

The street was quiet.

It should not have been.

He stood in the shadow and did not move, and let the street tell him what it was.

No lamps. Not one. At the first hour of dark, in a post town on a road, every inn should have had its lantern lit over the door, and the teahouse, and the shrine. There was nothing. The street lay grey under a thin moon, and every door was shut.

No sound. No voices. No one drinking. No one singing badly in an upper room. No dog.

He looked at the doors.

Shut. And not only shut. Barred. He could see it on the nearest ones. The bars were on the outside. Somebody had barred the people of this town into their own houses, and they were in there now, in the dark, not making a sound.

He looked along the eaves.

And he saw the first sword.

It was leaning under the eave of the inn nearest him, against the post, in the shadow, where a man coming along the street would not see it unless he looked. A plain sword, drawn, the blade bare. Just leaning there. Ready for a hand.

He looked at the next house.

There was one there, too. Stuck upright in the earth by the rain barrel, point down.

The next. On the edge of the roof, laid along the tiles above the door, where a man coming off the roof could put his hand on it.

The next. And the next. All down the street, on both sides, as far as he could see in the moonlight. At the doors. Under the eaves. On the roofs. By the well. Stuck in the earth at the foot of the shrine gate.

Swords. Dozens of them. Bare. Waiting.

He stood very still.

Swords on the houses.

It was not his voice. It was not any voice. It came into him the way a thing comes into you when you have heard it said many times in one particular way, low and even, not looking up, and you hear it again without anyone saying it.

So they don't have to carry them. So they can fight a long time. So they can drop one and have another. The whole street is a rack.

He knew whose voice it would have been. He did not think about that.

Ambush.

Kurogane looked at the roofs.

He looked at the dark places between the houses. The alleys. The gaps under the verandas. The black mouths of the doorways that were not barred.

He knew what was in them.

He could have gone around. He could have gone back into the field and along the edge of the woods and around the whole town and on down the road on the other side, and they would have waited in the dark all night for a man who did not come.

He did not go around.

He put his hand inside his sash, against his body. The stone was there. Smooth. The size of a thumb joint.

He walked out into the street.

***

He had gone twenty paces when they came.

From everywhere. From the roofs, down onto the street, without a sound, the way snow slides off a roof when it is ready. From the alleys. From under the verandas, flat, rolling out and up onto their feet. From the doorways. Grey. All of them grey. Twenty. Thirty. More behind them. They did not come at him. They came into the street, and took the swords from the eaves and the posts and the roofs as they came, and stood.

In no shape at all. And every one of them exactly where the shape was not.

Kurogane knew them. He had cut through them at Kōga, in the fog. He had cut through them in the snow on the narrow road, while Shigure placed him.

Nobody placed him now.

The first came in from the left.

Kurogane cut once. The man went down.

The second, from behind, and the third, from the right, together. He turned. He cut once. He cut once. They went down on either side of him, and their swords went out of their hands and rang on the packed earth.

A fourth. A fifth. He did not count them. He cut. They came into his reach and they went down, each one, one cut, and there was always another sword on another post for the next one to take up, and the next one came.

It was going well. It was going the way it always went.

Then the grey men stepped back.

All of them, at once. Out of his reach. A ring, wide, around him in the middle of the street. Breathing. Waiting.

And through the ring, from the direction of the shrine, one man walked.

Short. Lean. Grey. His eyes over a strip of dark cloth.

He did not hurry. He did not take a sword from a post. He had his own, long, in his hand, low. He walked into the ring and stopped, a little more than a sword's length away, and looked at Kurogane.

Kurogane looked at him.

The man in the narrow place. The man who had come through the empty space on the left. The man who had stepped back from Shigure, lightly, the way you step back from a door you have just closed.

Kurogane went in.

He went in the way he always went in. He read the man. He had always read them. The feet. The shoulders. The weight. Where the blade would come from. He saw the cut coming, from the right, high, and he was already moving to meet it, his blade already going to the place where it would be.

It was not there.

It was coming. It had not come. It was half a beat behind where it should have been, and Kurogane's blade was in the air meeting nothing, and the man's eyes over the cloth were calm.

He knew. He knew even as it was happening. It was what had happened to Shigure. He had seen it from the right of the narrow place, and now he was inside it.

He twisted.

It saved his life. It did not save his side. The real cut came in half a beat late and caught him across the ribs on the left, low, through the coat and the skin and the flesh under it, and opened. Cold. Then hot. Then wet all down his side into his sash.

He stepped back. One step. His free hand went to his side and came away dark.

The man with the cloth over his face had stepped back too. Lightly. He looked at the blood on Kurogane's hand, and then at Kurogane's face.

"You're dead, Manslayer Kurogane," he said.

He said it quietly. Not boasting.

***

Kurogane stood in the street with his hand on his side and the blood coming through his fingers.

He had been reading the man. He had done what he always did. He had seen the cut and gone to meet it, and it had been a lie, and the real one had come after. And it would do it again. It would do it every time. Every time he read the man, the man would be half a beat behind what he read, and the reading would be the thing that killed him.

He could see how it would go. The next exchange. And the one after.

He did not have to see very far.

And then it was there.

Not a voice. The inside of a room, at night, with snow against the paper of the door. A fire in the hearth, small and low. A board between them. His own pieces, all gone straight forward, none come back. A stone held a long time over a map, and set down on the left. And a question he had not known he was going to ask, asked.

If it fails?

And the answer, not looking up from the board. Moving a silver. Quiet, as if it were only another move.

Then you fully commit. You don't hesitate.

Kurogane stood very still.

His hand came away from his side.

Something went out of him. All at once. The way a lamp goes out when the oil is gone. Everything he had been doing with his eyes, the reading, the watching of the feet and the shoulders and the weight, the seeing where the cut would come from and going to meet it, went out of him, and he let it go, and it did not come back.

What was left was very cold.

It came down over him like a winter settling on a valley. From the top of his head to the soles of his feet. It came into his hands. It came into his face. It came into his eyes and stayed there. In the ring, one of the grey men, close enough to see his face in the moonlight, took a half step back without knowing he had.

Thank you, brother.

He did not say it. His mouth did not move. It was only there, in him, once, and then gone, into wherever things went.

He stood in the middle of the street with his sword low.

He did not move.

***

The grey men came again.

All of them. The whole ring. Closing, from every side, the way they had closed on the narrow road in the snow. No shape. Every one of them where the shape was not. Every blade coming from a place Kurogane was not looking.

He was not looking.

He did not read them. He did not see where they were going to be. He did not wait for them to be anywhere.

He went.

Straight. The way his pieces went on the board. Straight through the first of them, before the man had finished taking the step that would have put him in front of Kurogane. The man's head went off his shoulders and rolled in the dust. Kurogane was already past it. Into the place where the next man was going to arrive, and he arrived, and Kurogane was already there, and his head went too.

Left. A head.

Right. A head.

He did not turn to meet them. He did not answer. He was not answering anything. He was only going, forward, through the places they were about to be, and his sword was going with him, level, at the height of their necks, and they kept arriving into it.

The street was full of them, and then it was not.

They went down all around him. Grey on the packed earth. Heads in the dust. Swords from the eaves falling out of hands that had only just picked them up. Behind him, a man screamed and stopped. In front of him, one turned to run, and Kurogane was already where he was running to.

It went on until there was no one left in the ring to come.

Kurogane stopped.

He stood in the middle of the street with his sword low and the blood running off the point of it into the dust. His side was bleeding. He did not feel it. His breath went in and out, slow, even.

The man with the cloth over his face was standing where he had been standing.

He had not moved. He had watched all of it. His sword was still low in his hand, and his eyes over the cloth had changed.

***

They met in the middle of the street.

The man came in first, and the cut was half a beat late, and Kurogane did not meet it.

He did not go to where it was going to be. He did not wait for it to arrive. He cut, straight, his own cut, in his own time, and the man's blade and his met where they met, and the steel rang, and they went apart.

Again. The man came in. The timing broke, half a beat, a quarter, then early, then late, and Kurogane did not follow it anywhere. He cut straight. The blades met. They went apart.

Again.

Again.

Neither of them touched the other.

And then the man with the cloth over his face began to understand.

Kurogane saw it. Not because he was watching for it. Because it was on the man's body, plain, in the way his feet came down. The man was breaking his timing, and breaking it, and breaking it, and there was nothing on the other side to break against. Kurogane was not listening for a beat. There was no beat for him to lose. There was only the cut, straight, coming, whenever it came, and the man had to meet it every time, and every time it was a little heavier than the time before.

The man stepped back. Out of reach.

Kurogane stopped.

They stood in the street. Five paces. The moon on the dust between them, and the grey men lying all around, and the swords on the eaves, and the barred doors.

The man with the cloth over his face was breathing hard. Kurogane could hear it. It was the first time he had heard it.

"You're not waiting for it," said the man.

Kurogane looked at him.

"No," he said.

It was the only word he said that night.

The man with the cloth over his face looked at him a moment longer.

Then he stepped in.

He came in the best way he knew. Kurogane could see that. It was the best cut he had. Everything he was, the whole of him, the half beat and the quarter beat and the early and the late, all of it at once, from the right, low and turning up, and the timing broke into so many pieces it was not timing at all.

Kurogane did not read it.

He went.

The first cut took the man's sword hand off at the wrist, and the sword with it, turning in the moonlight.

The second, coming back, took the other arm at the elbow.

The third went low, across, and the man's right leg went out from under him at the knee.

The fourth took his head.

The man was coming in, and then he was not anything. He came apart in the moonlight in the middle of the street, and the pieces of him went down into the dust among the grey men he had brought, and his sword rang once on the ground a little way off, and lay there.

Kurogane stood over him.

His sword was low. His breath went in and out. His side was bleeding into his sash, where the stone was.

He did not look down.

***

Far off, over the hills to the east, the crows had started calling again.

It was not morning. It was nowhere near morning. But something had woken them, and they were calling, thin and broken, across the dark, the way they had been calling when he came to the edge of the town. And then they stopped.

The street was very quiet.

Behind the barred doors, the people of the town were still not making a sound.

Kurogane wiped his sword on the grey coat of the nearest man, one side and then the other, slowly, and looked along the blade in the moonlight, and put it away.

He put his hand inside his sash.

The stone was there. Warm now. Wet.

He held it for a moment.

He did not take it out.

Then he took his hand away, and turned, and walked on down the street the way he had been walking when they came, past the teahouse and the inns and the swords under the eaves, to the far end, past the shrine under the cedars, and out onto the road on the other side, and into the dark.

He did not look back.

Nothing had been answered. Nothing had been put right. The man with the cloth over his face was dead in the street, and Shigure was still dead, and the stone was still in his sash, and it would be in his sash in the morning.

That was all.

That was the whole of it.

Chapter 64

Identity

Hanzō stood in the middle of the road and waited.

It was a mountain road in the hills of Ōmi, where it climbed between cedars toward the passes that went down into Kōga. Narrow. Rutted. The spring had come up it in the last week, and the banks were green with the first ferns, and water was running everywhere, in the ditches and down the rocks and across the road in thin bright sheets. Nobody else was on it. He had made sure of that.

He did not hide. He did not stand at the side, or in the trees, or anywhere a man might stand if he wanted to see before he was seen. He stood in the middle of the road, the way he had stood on a cedar slope in the autumn, with his hands folded in his sleeves, and he waited.

He heard the raven first.

It came over the trees from the west and dropped onto a branch above the road a little way down, and folded its wings, and looked at him. Then it looked back the way it had come.

Then the boy came around the bend.

Hanzō watched him come.

He walked the way he had walked in every report for a month. Not fast. Not slow. Not looking at anything and seeing all of it. The blanket roll on his back and the bundle over it, and the belt across his chest, and the two swords at his hip. He did not look at the raven. He did not look at the trees on the slope behind him, where Jin and Ayame were, two hundred paces back, keeping their distance, the way they had kept it for three weeks. He knew they were there. Hanzō could see that he knew.

He saw Hanzō.

He did not stop at once. He came on another three paces, four, as if the road in front of him were empty and a man standing in it were only a thing to walk around. Then he stopped.

Ten paces. The water ran across the road between them.

His right hand moved. Not to the hilt. Near it. Resting a finger's width from the guard, the way you rest your hand near a door you might or might not open.

Hanzō did not move his own hands out of his sleeves.

"You're walking toward Kōga," he said. "They move every night. You'll find empty camps for a year."

The boy said nothing.

Hanzō had not expected him to. He let it sit. The water ran. The raven shifted on its branch.

"We know where they'll be."

He paused. He let that sit too.

"Raiden will be with them."

The boy looked at him.

Hanzō had been looked at by a great many men, in a great many ways. Men who hated him. Men who feared him. Men who were deciding whether to try to kill him. He knew every kind of look there was.

He did not know this one.

It did not weigh him. It did not measure him. It went over him the way water goes over a stone in a stream, all of it at once, and on the other side of it, Hanzō understood, the boy had seen every way this could go. The road. The deal. The knife in the sleeve, if there was one. The men in the trees, if there were any. All of it, laid out, and looked at, and set down.

"What do you want?"

"Nothing you'll refuse."

"Hm."

The boy did not ask anything else.

He did not ask what. He did not ask how, or where, or when, or why Hanzō should be trusted, or what it would cost him. He took his hand away from his sword. He came forward, across the water, and past Hanzō on the road, and Hanzō turned and began to walk, east, the way the boy had been going.

The boy fell in behind him.

Not beside him. Behind. Three paces. Exactly where a man walks when he is following the road and not the man on it.

Hanzō noticed.

He did not turn his head. He could feel where the boy was the way he could feel the slope of the road under his feet, and the boy was not with him. The boy was going the same way. That was all.

He was not joining.

He was using the road.

Hanzō walked on, up through the cedars, with the water running across his sandals and the raven going on ahead from branch to branch, and the boy three paces behind him, and he thought: *good*. That was simpler. That was a thing he understood. A piece that used the board.

He thought it, and it was true, and something about it sat in him wrong all the way up the mountain.

***

The house was in a fold of the hills above the Kōga border, where the old charcoal road came down to a spring. A farmhouse, once. Nobody farmed there now. Hanzō's people had been using it since the winter.

They were waiting in the main room when he came in. Daichi and Kenshiro, back from the black line. Jin and Ayame, who had come in by the back way a quarter of an hour before him, their sandals still wet. The four of them stood when he came through the door.

Then the boy came in behind him, and they did not sit back down.

Nobody said anything.

Jin was looking at the boy. So was Ayame. Daichi was looking at the boy's swords. Kenshiro was looking at the boy's hands. Hanzō saw all four of them see him, and saw what it did to them, and did not say anything about it.

The boy looked at the room.

Once. The four of them. The map on the floor by the hearth, with the stones on it. The doors, both of them. The window. The rafters. Then he went to the wall by the far door, the one that led out the back, and sat down against it with his swords across his knees.

Not at the hearth. Not with them. At the wall, by the door, where a man sits who might get up and go through it at any moment.

Hanzō knelt by the map.

He told them. The black line. Where Kōga had been in the last ten days, every night a different place, and where they were going. The hollow above the old shrine road. The night after the next new moon. How many. Who. Takeru would not be there. Kikyo would not be there.

Raiden would be.

He did not look at the boy when he said it. He did not need to.

He told them where each of them would be. He set the stones down. Jin here. Ayame here. Daichi and Kenshiro on the ridge.

He picked up the last stone.

He looked across the room at the boy.

The boy was looking at the map. He had been listening. Hanzō could see that he had heard every word, the way he had heard every word on the road, and put each one where it went. He was looking at the stones. At where they were. At the hollow above the shrine road, and the ridge, and the gaps between.

He did not come to the map. He did not ask where he would be.

Hanzō held the stone.

Then he set it down, not in the hollow, not on the ridge, but at the edge of the map, apart from the others. Where the boy was sitting. Where he would be, whatever Hanzō put down.

The boy looked at it.

Then he looked up, at Hanzō.

And Hanzō looked into his eyes.

He had looked into them once before. On the cedar slope, in the autumn, with the boy on his back in the leaves. He remembered what he had seen then. Something going away. As if someone had been standing in a doorway and had stepped back into the dark behind it. And then coming back. The boy had come back into his own eyes, that day, and looked up at Hanzō out of them, and weighed the old man against the scroll, and nodded.

There was no doorway now.

There was no one standing in it, and no one stepping back from it, and no dark behind. There was nothing there to go away or come back. There were only the eyes, very clear, and in them the room, and the map, and the stones, and the four people standing around it, and Hanzō, all of it laid out and seen and set down. Pieces. Places. What each one would do and where each one would go and what each one was worth.

Hanzō knew that look.

He had not seen it from the outside before. He had only ever seen it from behind. From inside. In the mornings, shaving, in the dark water of the basin, for longer than he could remember.

He was looking at himself.

He did not move. His face did not change. He had not let his face change in front of anyone in thirty years, and it did not change now.

But something went through him. Small. Very far down. The way a crack goes through ice on a pond in the spring, one sound, deep, that nobody standing on the bank would hear.

The boy looked away first. Back at the map. At his stone, alone at the edge.

Hanzō stood up.

"Rest," he said to the room. "We have until the new moon."

He went out into the yard. The spring was running over the stones by the old charcoal road. He stood beside it for a long time, with his hands in his sleeves, and did not look at anything.

***

He went home to Osaka three nights later, for one night, because there were things there that needed his hand on them before the new moon.

That was what he told himself. It was true. It was also not the reason.

The house on the quiet street behind the castle. The lamp. The two trays. Yukino had cooked, and he had eaten, and he did not remember what.

The hearth at the end of the room was lit.

He had noticed it when he came in. It had not been lit in all the years they had lived in this house. Not once. They did not use it. And tonight it was lit, small and low, with a kettle on the hook, and he had looked at it, and at her, and she had said nothing, and neither had he.

The trays had been taken away. The lamp had been put out. There was only the fire in the hearth now, and a single candle on the stand beside him, burning straight up in the still air.

He was looking at the candle.

Not at it. Into it. His eyes were on the flame and they had been on the flame for a long time, and he was not seeing it. He was somewhere else, a long way down, and the flame was only the thing his eyes had stopped on while he went there.

Yukino was across the hearth from him, with her hands in her lap.

"Something is different," she said.

He did not answer.

The candle burned. The fire in the hearth ticked and settled.

It was a long time before he raised his eyes.

When he did, she was looking at him. She had been looking at him the whole time. She was always looking at him. It was the first thing he had ever known about her.

"Your eyes," said Yukino.

A long pause.

"...are different."

He did not look away.

The fire moved on her face. She looked at him the way she had looked at him every night for many years, and something in it was different too. Not afraid. She had never been afraid of him. Something more careful than that.

"Is it the boy?" she asked.

Another long pause.

"He read it," said Hanzō calmly.

The fire ticked.

"How long?"

A pause.

"Too fast."

She waited.

He looked back at the candle. The flame stood up straight and still. He had not said this to anyone. He had never said it aloud, not in all his life, not even to himself. He did not know, until he began, that he was going to say it now.

"They take a whole life to read," he said. "Not a year. Not ten. A life. You do not read them the way you read a letter. You wait for each word to go down into you. Into the body. Into the hands and the feet and the breath. Until it is not a word anymore, only something you are. That is how they were written to be read. I have been reading them my whole life, and I have not finished. I know every word I have read. I know what each one did to me. What they take comes slowly that way. The way age comes. You have time to learn them." He was quiet a moment. "He had no time. They came on him all at once."

"One word," Hanzō said.

Silence.

"Read it."

Pause.

"Then stop."

Yukino waited.

"Sit with it."

Silence.

"Carry it."

Pause.

"Train it."

Silence.

"Only then..."

Pause.
"...the next word."
The fire cracked softly.
"The degradation is slower that way."
Silence.
"He read the Ninpiden too quickly."
Yukino looked at him.
"Ninpiden?"
Hanzō's eyes remained on the fire.
"The three scrolls."
Pause.
"Iga's Ninpiden."
Silence.
"Kōga's Shōninki."
Longer pause.
"My Bansenshūkai."
The wind moved through the trees outside.
She did not look at the box on the shelf behind him. She did not need to.
"The Ninpiden sharpens the body."
Pause.
"Breathing."
"Posture."
"Reaction."
"Movement."
Silence.
"It removes hesitation."
Yukino said nothing.
"The body begins acting before the mind finishes thinking."
Silence.
"The Shōninki sharpens perception."
Pause.
"Awareness."
"Prediction."
"Sight."
"Intuition."
Silence.
"But eventually..."
Pause.
"...the mind stops distinguishing possibility from truth."
The fire settled lower.
"And yours?" Yukino asked quietly.
Hanzō did not answer.
A long silence.
Long enough.
"What did it take from you?"
Hanzō watched the flame in the hearth fold down into ash.

"Back in Iga..." he said softly,
"...I believed mastery meant removal."
Silence.
"Remove fear."
"Remove doubt."
"Remove inefficiency."
Pause.
"So I kept refining."
The fire cracked.
"And refining."
Silence.
"And refining."
Long pause.
"The Bansenshūkai sharpens structure."
"Position."
"Timing."
"Order."
"Control."
Silence.
"It allows a man to see systems inside people."
Pause.
"How they move."
"How they break."
"How they can be guided."
Silence.
Yukino watched him carefully now.
Hanzō's voice became quieter.
"...Eventually..."
Long pause.
"...you begin seeing people the same way."
Silence.
"Not as people."
Pause.
"As outcomes."
The fire shifted.
Hanzō finally looked at her.
"And one day..."
Pause.
"...you realize you no longer feel anything when choosing them."

Chapter 65

Echo

Behind the farmhouse there was a threshing floor.

A square of beaten earth, flat and hard, where the people who had farmed here once had spread their rice out after the harvest and beaten it. Nobody had threshed anything on it for years. The grass had come in at the edges, but the middle was still bare and packed, and in the early morning, with the mist lying in the fold of the hills below and the spring running over the stones by the old charcoal road, it was the only flat place for a long way in any direction.

Hanzō had drawn on it before light.

A stick. Five marks in the earth. Four of them at the corners of a square, a little more than two sword lengths on a side. The fifth outside the square, behind it, alone. At the far end of the floor a stake had been driven into the ground, as high as a man's chest, with a strip of dark cloth tied around the top of it.

The stake was a man in a hollow. The square was the way to him.

The four of them had run it a thousand times, in the long hall in Osaka, in the bars of light. They did not need the marks. The marks were for the fifth.

Hanzō stood at the side of the floor with his hands in his sleeves and told the boy how it went. The square moved. It turned, and closed, and opened, and turned, and moved a step toward the stake each time it turned. On the fourth turning the corner nearest the stake went low and the corner behind it came over, and for the space of a breath there was a gap in the square where there had not been one. The fifth waited behind until the gap opened. Then the fifth went through it, and reached the stake, and the square closed behind him.

That was all. Every foot where he had drawn it.

The boy listened. He did not ask anything. When Hanzō was done, he went and stood on the fifth mark, with a wooden sword in each hand, and waited.

The four took their corners. Daichi east. Jin north. Ayame west. Kenshiro south. They held the wooden swords low. They did not look at the boy. They had been taught not to look at anything but the spaces between each other, and they did not.

Hanzō lifted one hand.

The square moved.

It turned. It closed. It opened. It was a good square. It had always been a good square. He watched the spaces, the way he always watched them, and they were right, each one, the width they should be, changing the way they should change.

It turned a second time. A third.

The boy moved.

Not on the fourth turning. Before it. Between the third and the fourth, when there was no gap, when there was nowhere to go, the boy was already going. Not through the gap. Through the place the gap was not yet. Daichi had only begun to go low. Jin had only begun to come over him. And the boy went between them, low and to the left, into a space that was not a space, and Jin had to check his step in the air to keep from coming down on him, and came down short, and Ayame, crossing behind, saw Jin come down short and turned her head to see why, and her line broke.

The boy was at the stake.

His wooden sword was resting against the dark cloth. Lightly. The way you set a cup down.

Behind him the square had not finished its fourth turning. It was not a square. It was four people standing in the wrong places, looking at each other, and at the boy.

He had reached the stake a full breath before the plan said anyone would.

Hanzō looked at the stake. At the sword resting against the cloth. At Jin's feet, which were a hand's width from where they should have been. At Ayame, who had turned her head. Ayame had never turned her head in the square. Not once, in all the years she had run it.

It had worked.

It had worked better than the square.

And the square was broken.

He looked at the boy. The boy was looking back at him, from the stake, and there was nothing in his face at all. Not pride. Not a question. Only the look of a man who had done a thing and seen it come out the way he knew it would.

Hanzō did not let his face change.

"Again," he said.

***

Again.

It went into him and did not stop.

It went down, the way a stone goes down a well. It went past the place where it should have landed. There was a place in him where that word had always landed, for eleven years. On the path from the stream, with the bucket knocking his shins. In the clearing, with his legs shaking under him. By the fire, with the whetstone going. The old man had said it and it had gone into that place and sat there, and it had meant someone was watching, and would keep watching, until it was right.

Shigure had said it, over a board on a veranda, laying his hand flat beside the pieces. Aoi had said it on the training ground, and under her voice, the old voice, the same word.

In the grey among the trees, one morning on the road, he had said it himself. To nobody. And it had gone out into the trees and there had been no one standing behind it.

Now this man had said it.

It went into him, and down, and where the place had been there was nothing for it to land on. It went on down. It went on and on, into the dark at the bottom of him, and he listened for it to hit something, the way you listen at a well.

It did not hit anything.

There was someone behind this one. He could hear that. There was a man standing behind the word, and he was watching. But he was not watching the way the old man had watched. He was not waiting for it to be right. He was waiting to see what it was.

Ren walked back to the fifth mark.

He stood on it. The four went back to their corners. The broad one in the east. The young one from the cedar slope in the north, quick and light, who had checked his step in the air. The woman in the west, who favored one leg on steep ground and did not favor it here. The one in the south with the long pale line across his forearm where a cut had healed.

They did not look at him. They were trying very hard not to look at him.

Hanzō lifted his hand.

The square moved.

Ren watched it.

Not the people in it. The square. It turned. It closed. It opened. It moved a step along the earth toward the stake, and he could see it move, the whole of it at once, the four of them and the spaces between them, the way you see a flock of birds turn in the air and understand that it is one thing and not many.

It turned a second time.

He was closer.

He had not decided to be. His feet had taken him a step off the fifth mark and a little to the left, while the square was turning, and he was standing now where the gap would open, a little behind it, waiting. Not in it. Near it. Where it was going to be.

The fourth turning. The broad one went low. The young one came over him.

The gap opened.

Ren was already in it.

He went through before it had finished opening, and the young one came down where he should, this time, exactly, and did not have to check, and Ren was past him. At the stake. The wooden sword against the dark cloth.

The square closed behind him.

It was a square this time. Nearly. The woman was a hair late on her crossing. She had been waiting to see where he would be. She had watched for him instead of the space, and it had cost her a hair.

He looked at Hanzō.

Hanzō looked back at him. His face did not change. His hands were in his sleeves.

"Again."

***

The third time, Ren did not watch the square.

He did not need to.

He stood on the fifth mark with the wooden swords low, and the four of them took their corners, and before Hanzō's hand came up, before anyone had moved, he could see it.

All of it. The way he had seen the old man's cave in the dark, when he was small, every stone in it, every place his feet would go between the fire and the water jar without light. It was not a thing he did. It was just there, laid out, in front of him, like ink on paper.

The first turning. The broad one would step there. The young one there. The woman would cross behind, left foot, right, and her left foot would come down on that stone, the flat one, a little pale. The one with the healed arm would turn on his heel and his sword would come around at the height of a man's hip.

The second turning. There. There. There. There.

The third.

The fourth.

Every foot. Every space. Where each of them would be, and when, and how long they would be there, and where they would go next. The whole of it. Somebody had drawn it, once, with a brush. Somebody had run it and run it until there was nothing left in it that could go anywhere else. It was very good.

And it was always the same.

That was all it was. It was always the same. It went where it had been drawn, every time, and anyone who had seen it go there twice could see where it would go the third time. It did not know he was there. It could not know. It had been drawn before he came.

Hanzō lifted his hand.

The square moved.

Ren moved with it.

Not through it. With it. When the broad one stepped, Ren was already beside the place he was stepping to. When the woman crossed, he was already past the stone she would come down on. He did not look at any of them.

He did not have to. He went where they were not going to be, a breath before they were not there, and the square turned around him the way water turns around a stone in a stream and does not know it is doing it.

On the second turning he was inside it.

On the third he was at the front of it, where the gap would be.

On the fourth, when the gap opened, he was not in it. He was already on the other side. Standing at the stake, with the wooden sword resting on the dark cloth, and his back to them.

Behind him the square finished turning. It closed. It was perfect. Every foot where it had been drawn. It closed on the place where the fifth should have been, and there was no one in it.

Ren turned around.

The four of them were standing in their square, very still, looking at him.

***

Hanzō did not say it.

He had it ready. It was in his mouth. He had said it a thousand times, at the end of a hall, to a square that turned and closed and opened. It was the word that came when something was not yet right, and it was always the next word, and he knew exactly how it would sound.

He did not say it.

The four of them were waiting for it. He could see them waiting. Daichi's weight still low in the east. Jin with his wooden sword half raised. Ayame with her eyes on the boy. Kenshiro turned, very slightly, toward the stake. None of them looking at the spaces between each other. All of them looking at him, and at the boy, and at the thing that had just walked through the middle of them.

The square had been perfect.

He had watched every foot. Every one had come down where he had drawn it. Nobody had checked. Nobody had been late. It was the best the square had ever run, and it had run around nothing, and closed on nothing, and the boy had been standing at the stake with his back to it before it finished.

He had not broken it.

That was the thing that sat in Hanzō the wrong way. The first time, the boy had broken it, and it had been simple to see. A piece off its mark. A piece that did not fit the board. Hanzō had seen a thousand men do that, and he had put every one of them back on the mark or taken them off the board.

The third time, the boy had not broken anything. He had not touched it. He had let it run exactly the way it was drawn, and gone around it, and through it, and past it, and it had worked. Everything he did came out the way the square was meant to come out. The stake reached. The man in the hollow dead. Better than the square. Faster. Cleaner.

And every time he did it, the square was a little less.

Not because he broke it. Because he showed it. Three runs, and he had it. All of it. Every foot. Hanzō had drawn it in ink a long time ago, in Iga, and had refined it, and refined it, and taught it to the best people he had, and they had run it until it was not a thing they did but a thing they were, and the boy had read it in three runs and walked through it as if it were written on the ground.

It was written on the ground. Hanzō had drawn it there himself, with a stick, before light.

He looked at the marks in the earth.

He had always known that a plan could be read. That was why the plan was never shown. That was why it lived in his sleeve and in the bodies of four people and nowhere else. It could be read, but it could not be seen, and so it was safe.

The boy had not seen the plan. He had seen the square. And the square was the plan. There was nothing else in it. It went where it was drawn. It could not go anywhere else. That was what made it good. It was always the same, and it was always right.

It was always the same.

Hanzō stood very still at the side of the threshing floor.

In the fog on the stubble field below Kōga, in the autumn, there had been men in grey who came at the spaces. Every gap there was. As if they had known where the gaps would be. He had thought, that night, that they were very good. He had thought it for months.

He thought now that perhaps they had only been watching.

His right hand moved inside his sleeve. The folded paper was there, where it always was. He did not take it out. He had not needed to look at it in years. He knew every line on it.

He stood with his hand against it and did not know, for the first time in a long time, whether it was right.

Not whether the four of them had run it right. They had. Whether *it* was right. Whether the thing he had drawn, and refined, and refined, and trusted every day of his life since Iga, was a way to the stake or only a way that could be seen.

He did not know.

He looked at the boy.

The boy was standing at the stake, with the wooden swords low, waiting. He was not waiting for the word. Hanzō could see that. He would stand there until something happened, and then he would do what came next, and whether the word came or did not come was only another thing that might happen.

Hanzō did not say it.

He watched.

The four of them stood in their square and did not move. The mist was going up off the fold of the hills below. The spring ran over the stones by the old charcoal road. Somewhere in the cedars above the farmhouse the raven made one low sound, and was quiet.

He watched the boy, and the boy watched nothing, and the stake stood between them with the dark cloth on it, not moving in the still air.

He watched.

Chapter 66

The Observer

The temple sat on a shelf of the mountain, above a valley with no village in it.

It was old, and small, and most of it was falling down. A gate at the bottom of a long flight of stone steps, with its roof sagging in the middle. A main hall with moss on the tiles. A bell tower at the corner of the yard, four posts and a roof and the bell hanging dark inside it. A wall around the back, against the slope, where the cedars came down to meet it. Nobody had prayed there in years. The monks had gone down the mountain one winter and not come back.

Kōga had come to it that evening.

Hanzō knelt on the floor of the safehouse with the map in front of him and the lamp beside it and told them how it would go.

Five pieces.

"Jin." A stone on the east side of the yard, where the wall was low and the storehouse stood against it. "Ayame." A stone on the bell tower. There was a man who slept in the tower, and his whole task was to ring the bell if anything came up the mountain in the dark, and the bell would be heard in the valley and on the next ridge, where there were more of them. "Daichi. Kenshiro." Two stones at the gate. "Him." The last stone, at the back wall, where the cedars came down.

He looked across the room. The boy was sitting against the wall by the back door, where he always sat. He was looking at the stone.

"Everyone moves on the signal."

The signal was a lantern with a cloth over it. Hanzō would be on the ridge across the valley, where he could see the whole of the temple laid out below him like a board. When the lamp in the main hall went out, and the men inside were asleep, he would lift the cloth, once, and let it fall. The five of them would see it from wherever they were. And they would go, all at once, from five sides, and it would be over before the man in the bell tower had his hands on the rope.

He had done it this way a hundred times. Every foot where he drew it.

***

Night. Cloud over the moon, and no light through it.

Hanzō knelt in the ferns at the edge of the ridge with the lantern beside him, the cloth over it, his hand on the cloth. Below, across the valley, the temple was a grey shape against the black of the mountain. One lamp in the main hall. A glow through the paper, orange, small.

He could not see his people. He was not meant to. But he knew where each of them was, the way he knew where his own hands were. Jin in the dark under the east wall. Ayame at the foot of the bell tower, flat in the grass. Daichi and Kenshiro in the shadow of the gate at the bottom of the steps. The boy somewhere in the cedars above the back wall.

The lamp in the main hall burned.

He waited.

Somewhere down in the valley an owl called, twice, and then did not call again.

The lamp went out.

Hanzō's fingers tightened on the cloth.

And below him, at the bottom of the steps, the gate opened.

Slowly. By itself. The two leaves of it swinging in, heavy, one a little behind the other, the way a gate swings when someone on the inside has lifted the bar and stepped back. There was no one in it. It stood open on the black of the yard.

Hanzō did not lift the cloth.

He knelt on the ridge with his hand on it, and did not lift it, and watched. Down at the bottom of the steps, two shadows came out of the shadow of the gate and went up through it, fast. Daichi and Kenshiro. They had seen it open. They had not waited for the light. The gate was open and it was not supposed to be, and when a thing was not where it was supposed to be, you went to your mark and made the plan true again. He had taught them that.

At the corner of the yard, a shape went up the posts of the bell tower. Ayame. Quick, the leg not slowing her.

On the east side, Jin, over the low wall.

All four of them going. All four of them to their marks. Exactly the way he had drawn it.

He watched them arrive.

Daichi and Kenshiro were through the gate and into the yard, and turned, and stood, one on either side, where they had been put. There was no one to meet them. Ayame came up over the rail of the bell tower and stopped. Hanzō could see her stop. She was looking down at the floor of the tower, at something there, and she did not reach for the rope, and she did not draw. Jin came around the end of the storehouse, low, fast, his sword out, and stood where he should be standing. Nobody came at him either.

The four of them were in perfect position.

Exactly where they were supposed to be.

There was nothing left for them to do there.

Hanzō took his hand off the cloth.

***

He came down into the valley and up the long steps and in through the open gate.

The yard was very quiet. Daichi and Kenshiro were standing by the gate. Ayame had come down from the tower. Jin was at the corner of the storehouse. None of them had moved from their marks. They were standing where they had been put, and looking, all four of them, at the middle of the yard.

The boy was standing in the middle of the yard.

Both swords were in his hands, and both swords were clean. Around him, on the stones, in a loose ring, as if they had come out of the hall toward him from every side and stopped, there were men. Seven. Eight. Lying still, in the positions men lie in when they have gone down without a sound. Nobody had cried out. Nobody had reached the bell.

The door of the main hall was open. Inside it was dark. Up in the bell tower, the man who was supposed to ring the bell was lying on the boards on his side, with his hand a long way from the rope.

Jin looked at the bodies.

He looked at them one at a time. Hanzō watched him do it. Then Jin looked up at the boy.

"That wasn't the plan."

The boy looked back at him.

"It worked."

Jin did not answer. He stood at his mark with his sword still out, and his jaw tightened, and he said nothing.

The boy sheathed his swords, the left and then the right, and walked out through the gate and down the steps into the dark, and nobody stopped him.

***

Back at the safehouse, when the others were asleep, Hanzō knelt by the map and moved the pieces.

He did it the way he did it after every night. He took the stones and put them where they had started, and then he walked them, one at a time, along the paths they had gone, to where they had ended. It was how you learned what a night had been.

Daichi's stone. From the shadow of the gate, up through it, into the yard. To its mark.

Kenshiro's. The same.

Ayame's. Across the grass, up the tower. To its mark.

Jin's. Over the low wall, around the storehouse. To its mark.

Four pieces. Each one along the line he had drawn. Each one exactly where he had put it.

He picked up the fifth stone.

He held it over the back wall, where it had started.

He did not know where to put it next.

He did not know when it had come over the wall. He did not know how it had gone through the hall, or which of the men had died first, or how it had come to be at the gate with the bar in its hands, and then at the foot of the bell tower, and then in the middle of the yard. He had watched the whole temple from the ridge, every roof, every shadow, and he had not seen it move. There was no path. There was the back wall, and then there was the middle of the yard with eight men lying around it, and nothing in between.

He set the stone down in the middle of the yard.

It had not gone there. It was only there. At the end.

He looked at the map a long time.

Then he took out paper, and ground his ink, and wrote the report. The temple on the mountain shelf. One night. The bell not rung. Nine dead. None of theirs. He wrote it in the small plain hand, the way he always wrote it.

The mission succeeded.

He wrote that. It was true.

He put down the brush.

He sat for a long time after the ink had dried, in the light of the lamp, looking at the map. At the four stones standing at their marks. At the gate, and the bell tower, and the corner of the storehouse. Each one exactly where it should be.

Standing in empty places.

***

Three nights later, a house in a valley below the old shrine road, where four of Kōga were keeping watch on the road for the others.

The same.

Four nights after that, a camp in a ravine, under an overhang, with a fire hidden in a pit.

The same.

Hanzō drew it, and set the stones down, and said *everyone moves on the signal*, and every time, before the signal, something had already happened. A door already open. A watchman already down. Four people arriving exactly where they were meant to be, into a place where there was nothing left to do, and the boy somewhere in the middle of it, with his swords clean.

His people began to change.

He saw it before they knew it themselves. They left their places a breath sooner. They moved a little faster than he had drawn them, to get there before the thing that was going to happen had happened. At the ravine, Kenshiro reached his mark before Daichi reached his, and had to wait there, alone, in the open, for the space of three breaths. Hanzō had never seen Kenshiro wait for anyone. Their shape drew in on itself, tighter, the spaces between them

closing. Jin came down the side of the ravine too fast and a stone went out from under his foot and rattled away into the dark, and every one of them stopped, and listened, and it was a long time before they went on.

They were not moving the way he had drawn them anymore. They were moving the way the boy was moving. Trying to get there first.

They never did.

Hanzō stood on the ridges and watched it, and he understood it the way he understood everything he watched. Very clearly. All of it at once.

The plan still worked. Every night, the plan worked. Every night he wrote *the mission succeeded* in the small plain hand, and it was true.

But it was not working the way he had built it to work. It was working the way a dog works that has been tied to a cart that has started to roll. It was running to keep up.

It was chasing one man.

***

He had noticed things before the night in Osaka. He noticed everything. It was what he was.

But since that night, since the candle and the fire in the hearth and Yukino across it with her hands in her lap, he had begun to notice other things. Things that had no use. Things the system had no place to put. The sound of the spring on the stones by the charcoal road. The way the raven sat on the roof of the woodshed every morning, at the same corner. The way Ayame put her hand on her thigh, at the end of a long night, where the old cut had been, and took it away again before anyone saw.

He did not know what to do with any of it. He noticed it anyway.

In the mornings, he watched the four of them train on the threshing floor at first light. He had watched them every morning for years. It was where the day began.

This morning he walked the other way.

Along the edge of the yard, past the woodshed, down the slope to where the old charcoal kiln stood at the edge of the grounds. A hump of clay and stone, half fallen in, with a lean-to against the side of it where the charcoal burners had slept once. The boy slept there. He had slept there from the first night. Not in the house. Not near the others. At the edge, alone, where a man sleeps who might get up and go at any moment.

The boy was awake.

He was sitting in front of a fire.

It was a small fire. A ring of stones, set in the bare earth in front of the lean-to. The long pieces laid crossed, and burning well, no smoke, the flames standing up straight in the still air. The boy was sitting in front of it with his hands on his knees and his back straight and his two swords beside him, and he was looking at it.

Hanzō stopped.

He knew where the boy would be within the hour. He had put him there himself, last night, with a stone on the map. The ridge above the valley road, before the sun was clear of the hills. The boy's blanket roll was already tied. His belt was already across his chest. In a little while he would get up, and kick the stones apart, and put the fire out with earth, and go. He had eaten already. It was not cold. He did not need the fire for anything.

It had no purpose.

Hanzō looked at it.

He had never in his life built a thing that had no purpose. He did not know how you would begin.

"Why do you make a fire every morning?"

The boy did not answer.

He did not look up. He went on looking at the fire, and he went on looking at it, a moment too long, the way a man looks at a thing when a question has gone in somewhere and he is waiting to see what comes back up.

Something moved in his face. Not much. Something around the eyes. As if he had heard the question before, from somewhere, a long way off, and was listening for where.

"I like the fire."

Hanzō waited.

He waited for the rest of it. There was always a rest of it. Every answer he had ever been given had something under it, a reason, a use, a thing it was for, and you waited, and it came, and then you knew where to put it.

Nothing came.

The boy did not say anything else. He did not look up. He sat with his hands on his knees and watched the fire, and whatever had moved in his face had gone back down to wherever it had come from, and his face was only his face again.

Hanzō did not understand it.

He stood there and turned it over, the way he turned over everything, and it did not turn. There was no reason under it. There was no use. There was only a boy who would be gone within the hour, sitting in front of a fire that would be earth by then, because he liked it. Or because something in him did, somewhere Hanzō could not see.

He should have gone back up the slope. There was nothing more to learn here.

He did not go back.

He stood at the edge of the charcoal burners' ground with his hands in his sleeves, a long time, longer than he had any need to. The fire burned. The boy watched it. Hanzō watched the boy watch it.

Up on the threshing floor, the four of them were training without him. He could hear them. The square, turning and closing and opening. Once, he looked up the slope, and Jin had stopped at his mark and was looking down at him, across the yard, over the roof of the woodshed. Jin's face did not do anything. Then the square turned, and Jin turned with it, and did not look again.

The boy got up.

He kicked the stones apart. He put earth on the fire, with his hands, until there was no fire. He put his blanket roll on his back and his swords through his sash, and went past Hanzō up the slope, without looking at him, to the road.

Hanzō looked at the place where the fire had been.

***

He went home to Osaka two days later, and stayed.

In the evenings, at home, he had taken to laying out the map on the floor by the lamp, with the stones on it, the way he did at the safehouse. He had never done that before either. The work had always stayed in the long hall, and the house on the quiet street behind the castle had been a place where there was no work at all.

Yukino did not say anything about the map.

She had said nothing about it the first night, or the second. On the third evening she cooked, and he ate, and she cleared the trays away. And then she did not go to the back of the house. She came and knelt across the lamp from him, and folded her hands in her lap, and looked at him.

He knew what she was seeing. He had always known what she was seeing, and he had always let her see it.

She was seeing that he had not moved the stones on the map in two days. Not one. They stood where they had stood when he came home. The four of them at their marks around a ravine in the hills, and a fifth, a little apart, that he had set down in the middle and not touched since.

She was seeing that he had eaten slowly. He had always eaten at the pace he always ate, in the order it was placed. Tonight he had stopped, twice, with the bowl in his hand.

She was seeing that he was looking at the lamp again. The way he had looked into the candle, that other night. Not at it. Into it. As if it were only the thing his eyes had stopped on while he went somewhere else.

"You're watching him," she said. "Not guarding him."

Hanzō did not answer.

He did not deny it.

The lamp burned. Outside, far off, the night watchman went by on his round, knocking his two sticks together at the corners, and the sound came and went.

It was a long time before he spoke.

"Why would someone make a fire they don't need?"

He heard it go out of him and into the room. A question. He could not remember the last time he had asked her one. He had told her things. He had answered her. He had not asked. There had not been anything, in all the years, that he did not already know, or know where to find.

Yukino looked at him.

She did not answer at once. She looked down at her hands in her lap, and then at the lamp, and he could see her thinking. Not the way he thought, with the pieces laid out. Some other way. Slower.

"For someone else," she said.

Hanzō looked at her.

She did not look away. She never had.

He did not say anything else that night.

***

He woke before light.

The house was dark and cold and still. Yukino was asleep. Outside, the street behind the castle was quiet, and the city beyond it was not yet awake, and no sound came through the walls at all.

He got up.

He went to the end of the room, where the hearth was. It had been lit once, three weeks ago, for the first time in all the years they had lived in the house, and she had lit it. It was cold now. The ash lay in it grey and flat.

He knelt in front of it.

He did not know how to begin. He had never done this. There had always been someone. His people, in the field. Yukino, here. He had never once in his life gotten up in the dark and knelt in front of a cold hearth and made a fire in it with his own hands, because there had never been any need.

There was no need now.

He cleared the ash to one side. He found kindling in the basket by the wall. He laid it, badly, and then took it apart and laid it again. He struck the flint. It did not catch. He struck it again. It caught. A small flame, orange, went up into the kindling and stood there a moment, deciding. Then it took.

He sat back on his heels.

The light went up the walls. It moved on the beams, and on the paper of the doors, and on the box on the shelf behind him. The kettle hung over it on its hook, and in a little while it began to tick as the iron warmed.

Hanzō sat in front of the fire with his hands on his knees and watched it.

He did not know why he had done it.

He did not know who it was for.

Behind him, in the dark at the back of the room, he heard Yukino turn over in her sleep, and then lie still.

Chapter 67

Mirror

The tracks went down to the water.

Six sets. Ren had been reading them since before light, along the spine of a ridge and down through a stand of old cedars and out onto a slope of bracken wet with dew, and they had not tried to hide. They did not know anyone was behind them. Six of Kōga, moving from one place to another in the hills, the way the ones who were left moved now, never two nights in the same place.

The four went ahead of him.

They always went ahead of him now. They had started doing it at the temple, and they had not stopped. Down through the bracken, spread out, fast, the young one from the cedar slope in front. Ren came behind at the pace he always went. It did not matter. He knew where the tracks were going. He had known for an hour.

The slope ended in a stream.

A wide one, shallow, loud, running over stones in the grey light at the bottom of a narrow valley. In the middle of it a long bar of gravel, pale, with the water going around it on both sides. The six were on the bar. They had stopped to cross, and some of them were already in the water on the far side, knee deep, and two of them had turned at the sound of the four coming down out of the bracken, and their hands were going to their blades.

And on the far bank, at the same moment, two people came out of the trees.

Ren saw the first one and knew him. A head shorter than most. Thin now. Harder. A face that had been quick to laugh on a training ground once, a long time ago, and was not quick to anything anymore. His hands were already on his swords.

Then he saw the second.

He saw the spear first.

Long. Straight. In her hands. He had watched it carried across a training ground all summer on a broad back. The shaft was dark oak. The head was sheathed in black lacquer. He knew the length of it. He knew the weight. He knew exactly how it felt lying across his legs on a floor of boards in the smoke, when the hands that had held it had stopped holding anything.

He looked at it.

He did not look at her. He looked at the spear. At the place on the shaft where her hands were. Low. A hand's width lower than hands like hers should have been. In the old place. Where the oak had gone the color of tea.

He was still looking at it.

He did not know how long. A breath. Less. Long enough that the Kōga on the gravel bar had drawn, and the four had reached the edge of the water, and the man on the far bank had seen him.

He caught himself.

He took his eyes off it. It was only a spear. He put it where things went, and looked at the man instead.

The man was looking at him.

Nothing else. Not the six on the gravel between them. Not the four coming into the water. Not the woman beside him with the spear. Only Ren. As if everything else in the valley had gone out, and there was only the one thing left in the dark.

Then he came.

Straight into the water, the far channel going white around his knees, and up onto the gravel bar, and through the Kōga on it. Past two of them as if they were posts, and one of them turned to cut at him and he did not even look, and the cut missed, and he was through, and coming down the length of the bar toward the near end.

Behind him, on the bar, the two at the back of the six had turned the other way. Toward the far bank. Toward the one who was closest.

Her.

Ren drew both swords, and went out through the near channel onto the end of the bar to meet him.

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The man came down the bar and cut.

It was a good cut. It was fast. Faster than it needed to be. It came from the right, high, with everything behind it, the way he had wanted to come at a stranger in a forest on the first day, and Ren saw it before it left the man's shoulder and moved his head the width of two fingers, and it went by.

The man cut again. Ren's left sword turned it. Not much. Just enough.

Again. The right sword. Just enough.

The man stepped back. He was breathing hard already. The water was running out of his trousers onto the gravel. He looked at Ren, and his face did the thing it had been waiting a whole winter to do.

Ren could read it. He could read all of it. It was very easy to read. The vault. The smoke. A broad man going down onto his side on the boards. Whatever had come after, in the morning and all the mornings after that, that Ren had not been there to see. All of it was in the man's face, and all of it was going to go into the next cut, and Ren could see exactly where the next cut would come from, because hate did not hide anything. It only pointed.

The man came in.

Ren moved.

Not much. He did not need much. He had stopped needing much a long time ago. The man's blades came down and Ren was not where they came down, and he had not gone far. A half step. A turn of the hips. The two swords lying quiet in his hands, and then one of them moving, a little, from here to there, and the man's cut sliding off it into the gravel. Nothing extra. Nothing left over. Every movement the shortest way from where he was to where he needed to be, and then no further.

Direct. Precise. Inevitable.

The man cut, and cut, and cut, and every cut went where Ren was not.

Ren's eyes went across the water.

He had not meant them to. They went.

On the far bank, at the edge of the trees, she was fighting the two of them.

A man and a woman. Kōga. They moved as a pair, the way people move who have moved together for years: the man coming in high with the blade, the woman going low beneath it, so that you had to answer both at once, and could not. It was a good pair. Ren could see how good.

She was not answering them.

She was not standing still for them to come at. She was moving. The spear was moving. It went out, and came around, and came back, and went out again, all one thing, never stopping at the end of a thrust but going on through it into the next, so that there was no end, and no beginning, and no place in the whole long line of it where a man could come inside. When the man came in high the point was already there. When the woman went low the butt was already coming around to meet her. Her feet went across the wet stones as if the stones were not wet. Her whole body went with the shaft, and the shaft went with her, and it was not a woman holding a spear. It was one thing, turning.

Elegant. Fluid. Controlled.

Continuous.

The man in front of him cut.

Ren moved his head. The blade went by his ear. He did not look at it.

He looked back at her.

Her father had stood in the middle of a room with his feet apart and let everything come to him and broken on him. She did not stand. She did not let anything come. She went out to meet it and was gone before it arrived and was already coming back around. It was not her father's. Ren could see that. The hands were in her father's place on the shaft, and nothing else was. She had taken it and made it hers.

It was very good.

It was as good as anything he had ever seen.

The man in front of him was shouting now. Ren had not noticed when he started. No words. Only sound, going out of him with every cut, and the cuts coming faster, wilder, the whole winter going into them, and not one of them touching Ren anywhere. A star came out of the man's left hand, flat and spinning, thrown hard, and Ren tipped his head and heard it go past and did not look where it went.

He could have ended it. He had been able to end it since the first cut. He could see every place it could end. Ten of them. Twenty. The man opened a new one every time he came in, and Ren saw it open, and saw it close again, and did not go into it.

He did not know why.

He knew why.

As long as the man kept coming, Ren could keep looking across the water.

The man came again. Ren turned it, and turned it, and his eyes went across the water.

She was ending it.

He could see it the way he saw everything, a breath before it happened. The Kōga man on the far bank was already down, a long way back, on the stones, not moving. Only the woman was left. And the spear was going out, and coming around, and going out, and at the end of this turning there was going to be a place where the woman was, and the point was going to be there.

The man in front of him came in, low, both swords, with everything he had left.

Ren moved.

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Aoi saw him look at the spear.

That was the first thing. Before the Kōga on the gravel had finished turning, before Riku had finished drawing, before the four strangers who had come down the slope with him had reached the water. She saw him stop. She saw his eyes go to the spear in her hands and stay there.

Not on her. On it.

She had not seen his face since a night in the smoke with red light on it and a hole in the wall. She had thought about what it would be when she saw it again. She had thought about it on the ground in the snow and at the southern gate in the mist and on every road out of Iga for twenty days, walking beside Riku, following the stories. Houses in the hills with the fire still lit. One cut each. Crows.

She had not thought it would look at the spear.

Then he took his eyes off it, and the thing in his face went back to wherever it had come from, and Riku went into the water.

She did not go after Riku. She could not have stopped him. She had known that since the morning in the snow, when his sword stood ten paces off with its point in the ground.

Two of the Kōga were coming at her.

She took the sheath off the spear and let it fall.

They came the way she had been told Kōga came. Together. A man with a long blade, high, and a woman a little behind him and to the side, low, so that when you answered the one the other was already under you. They had done it many times. She could see that in how they moved. They did not look at each other. They did not need to.

She did not let them inside.

The spear went out. The man turned it and came on, and the point was not there anymore, it was coming around, and the butt came after it and met the woman where she was going low, and the woman went back. The man came again. The spear was already out to meet him. She did not stop it. She never stopped it now. She let it go on through, around, back, out, one line, the way she had found it on the frozen ground in the dark with her hands bleeding into the wrappings, and every time they came at the line it was somewhere else along it.

Across the water, at the edge of her eye, Ren and Riku.

She did not look. She did not have to.

Riku was fighting the way Riku had always fought, fast, hard, too hard, everything in every cut. And Ren was hardly moving. That was the thing she saw, at the edge of her eye, over and over. He was hardly moving at all. A turn. A half step. His hands barely going anywhere. Riku's blades coming down and down and down, and every time, Ren was not where they came down, and he had not gone anywhere to not be there.

It was not what he had been on the training ground.

On the training ground he had been slightly somewhere else, always. You could learn where he would be, if you worked at it for a summer. She had.

This was not that. This was a man who had stopped being anywhere, except exactly the one place, and then the next.

The man in front of her came in high.

She turned it, and let the spear go on around, and the point came back across at the height of his chest, and he was there. He had not been going to be there. He had been going to be a little to the left. But the woman had gone low on the left, the way she always did, and he had stepped right to give her room, the way he always did, and the spear had known it before he did.

He went back a step. He looked down at himself. He sat down on the stones, slowly, and then he lay down on his side, and did not get up.

The woman stopped.

She looked at him on the stones. Only for a moment. Then she looked at Aoi, and her face did not do anything at all, and she came.

She came alone now, low, fast, all of it at once, with no one high to cover her.

Aoi let the spear go around.

Out. Back. Around. Out. The woman came in under it and got her hand on the shaft. Aoi's knee came up into her ribs, and the shaft turned out of her fingers, and she went sideways off it and came again, and the point was there, and she went back, and the whole of it went on turning, and Aoi's feet went across the wet stones, and her breath went in and out, and there was nothing else in the valley. Only the line of the spear, going around, and the one place along it where the woman was going to be.

At the edge of her eye, across the water, Riku went in low, with both swords.

The spear came around.

She sent it.

It went straight out from her hip with the whole of her behind it, the way the first form went, the one with the broom handle, and the woman was there, and it went in.

At the same moment, across the water, Ren moved.

She saw it at the edge of her eye. She did not see the cut. There was nothing to see. There was Riku going in low with both swords, and then there was Riku going past Ren, one step, two, and slowing, and going down onto his knees in the shallow water at the edge of the gravel, and the water going around him, and Ren behind him, not facing him, with one sword out to the side and lowered.

The woman on the end of the spear was very light.

Aoi drew it back. The woman went down onto the stones at her feet and did not move.

Riku did not get up.

The water ran around him in the shallows, pale over the stones, and he knelt in it with his head down, and then he was not kneeling. He went forward, slowly, onto his face in the stream, and the stream went on over him, and he did not move again.

Aoi stood with the spear lowered.

She looked across the water at Ren.

He was standing on the gravel bar with his swords down. He had turned. He was facing her. And for the space of one breath, across the stream, over the two bodies on her side and the one in the water on his, he looked back at her.

Then he looked away.

At the water. At the stones. At nothing.

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The four strangers had finished.

She had not seen it. They were standing on the gravel bar and at the edges of the water, breathing, and the rest of the Kōga were lying around them, four, in the stream and on the stones. One of the strangers had a cut along his forearm, over an old pale scar. The young one, quick and light, the one in front, was standing a little apart. He was looking at Ren. Then at her. At the spear. His hand was still on his sword.

He did not know who she was. She could see him not knowing. She could see him deciding what she was, and what she meant, and whether to come across the water.

Ren did not look at him.

"Go," he said.

It was the first thing she had heard him say since the smoke. His voice was the same. It was quieter.

The young one looked at him.

He looked at him for a long moment. Then at her again. Then at the others. The broad one said nothing. The woman said nothing. The one with the cut on his arm was binding it with a strip of cloth, and did not look up.

The young one let go of his sword.

They went. Up the slope on the far side, into the bracken, not fast now, not racing anyone. The young one went last. At the top of the slope he turned and looked back down, once, at Ren standing alone on the gravel bar. Then he turned and went into the trees, and the bracken closed behind him.

Ren did not watch them go.

He stayed.

He stood on the gravel bar in the middle of the stream, with his swords down at his sides, and the water going around both sides of him, and he did not move.

She did not move either.

The stream was very loud. It was the only sound in the valley. It went over the stones and around the bar and over Riku in the shallows, and on down the valley, and did not stop for any of it. The light was coming up now over the eastern ridge, and the mist on the water was going white, and then going.

Aoi looked at him.

She did not look away. She did not know how long. She stood on the stones at the edge of the trees with her father's spear in her hands and the woman at her feet, and she looked at him across the water, and she kept looking.

He did not look at her.

He looked at the water. At the stones under it. At the far bank, and the bracken, and the trees. He looked at everything in the valley but her. Once, his eyes came toward her, across the stream, the way a man's hand goes toward a door he has told himself he will not open. They came as far as the spear.

Then they went away again. To the water.

She kept looking.
He kept looking away.
Neither of them said anything.
The stream went on.

Chapter 68

Formation

It came into him the way water comes into a jar left out in the rain.

He did not go looking for it. Nobody showed it to him. Nobody put a scroll in his hands and told him to read. It came in the mornings, on the threshing floor, in the grey before the sun, when the four of them took their corners and the square turned and closed and opened, and he watched it. And it came at night, on the ridges, in the ferns, in the dark above a temple and a valley house and a ravine, when the stones Hanzō had set down on a map became people, and the people went where the stones had been.

Every morning. Every night. The same shape.

He did not try to learn it. He only saw it, again, and again, and again. And somewhere in the seeing, without his knowing when, it stopped being a thing he saw and became a thing he knew.

He knew the young one from the cedar slope always took his first step toward the light. Toward the east, or the lamp, or the open side. He did not know he did it. He had been taught to do it so long ago that it had gone down into his feet.

He knew the broad one always went low on the second count, never the first, and always a little to his left, because his right knee was the one he trusted.

He knew the woman crossed behind, always behind, and that her left foot still came down a finger's width shorter than her right, on stones and on earth and on the boards of a bell tower, though the cut on her thigh had closed long ago.

He knew the one with the scar on his forearm turned on his heel, and that when he turned his sword came around at the height of a man's hip, and that it always would.

And he knew the spaces.

That was the thing. Not the four of them. The spaces between. Two sword lengths and a little more, always, whatever the ground. Closing, on the count. Opening, on the count. Every space the width it had been drawn. Every opening where it had been drawn, and for exactly as long. He could stand on the fifth mark with his eyes half shut and know where every space in the square was, and where it would be on the next count, and the one after that.

It was not only the square.

At the temple, he had known where they would be before the lamp went out. In the valley house, before they left the ridge. In the ravine, before he had seen the ravine. It was the same shape everywhere. Stretched to fit a yard, or a valley, or a cut in a hillside. But the same. The same angles. The same spacing. The same way of leaving one place open, always, so that whatever came in would come in there.

It was the shape Hanzō drew with people.

He could see it now. The whole of it. Not written down. Not in ink. In them. In their feet, and their breath, and the way their eyes went to each other's backs and not to their own. He could see it in the way they stood at the hearth in the evenings, without thinking, each one a little apart from the next, the same distance. He could see it in the way they slept.

He could see what they were going to do before they had decided to do it.

He had not read a word.

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Night.

He had come back from the stream two days ago. He did not think about the stream.

The house was dark. The four were asleep in the main room, in their places, each one a little apart from the next. The fire in the hearth had gone down to a red eye in the ash. Outside, the spring was running over the stones by the charcoal road, and above the woodshed the raven had put its head under its wing.

Ren came in by the back way, for water.

The jar was in the passage behind the kitchen. He filled his gourd from it with the dipper, without a sound, and stopped it, and turned to go back out the way he had come.

The door to Hanzō's room was open.

It was a small room at the end of the passage. It had been where the farmer slept, once. Hanzō had come back from Osaka three days ago, and had been in it every night since, late, with the lamp. Ren had seen the glow of it under the door from the kiln.

The lamp was still lit. Low. The wick trimmed down to a bead.

The room was empty.

Ren knew where Hanzō was. He was outside, by the spring, standing with his hands in his sleeves. He had been standing there every night since he came back. Ren did not know why. He did not need to know why. He knew where.

He stopped at the open door.

On the low desk under the lamp there was a map.

He knew it. The temple on the shelf of the mountain. The gate at the bottom of the steps. The hall. The bell tower in the corner of the yard. The wall along the back, against the slope. Drawn in Hanzō's hand, in ink, very fine.

The stones were on it. Four of them at their marks. The gate. The gate. The bell tower. The corner of the storehouse.

And the fifth. Back at the back wall.

Where he had been put. Where he had started.

He looked at it.

He did not go in. He stood in the passage with the gourd in his hand and looked at the map in the low light, the way he had looked at the square on the threshing floor.

There were other marks on the map.

Small ones. He had not seen them in the briefing, because the lamp had been behind Hanzō and the stones had been on the map and nobody had looked at anything but the stones. Small marks in the same fine ink. Not stones. Not names. Only small circles, drawn with the tip of the brush, very lightly, so lightly you had to be looking for them.

One at the gate. Inside it. Where the bar was.

One on the floor of the bell tower.

One in the middle of the yard.

He looked at them for a long time.

The gate. Where he had gone, after the hall, to lift the bar. The bell tower. Where the man with the rope had been. The middle of the yard, where he had been standing when the four of them came through the gate and found nothing left to do.

He had gone to those places on his own. Nobody had told him to. Nobody had set a stone there. He had come over the back wall and gone where the night went, the way he always went, and the night had gone to the gate, and the tower, and the middle of the yard.

And the circles had been there first.

He could see that. The ink of the circles was the same as the ink of the wall and the gate and the hall. The same brown at the edges, where it had dried. The same hand. The same brush, the same day, before the first stone had been set down on it. Before anyone had gone up the mountain. Before the lamp in the hall went out.

He looked at the other maps.

They were stacked beside it on the desk, under a stone to keep them flat. He could see the edges of them. He did not touch them. The top one was turned a little, and he could see the valley house on it, the road below the old shrine, and the small circles. There. And there. Where he had gone. Where he had chosen to go.

The ravine, under it. The edge of it showed. A circle at the lip of the overhang. He had come down from the lip of the overhang.

Every time.

Every time he had gone off his mark, every time he had gone early, every time he had broken the plan and walked through the middle of it and stood in the place where it ended with his swords clean, there had been a small circle on the map, in fine ink, waiting for him.

Hanzō had not planned around him.

Hanzō had planned with him.

He had set a stone at the back wall, and said *everyone moves on the signal*, and set the four of them at their marks, and all of it had been true. And under it, in circles so light you had to be looking, he had drawn where Ren would go when he did not wait for the signal. When he broke it. When he was free.

The breaking had been drawn.

Ren stood in the passage.

He did not know how long. The lamp burned down a little more. Outside, the spring ran on over the stones. Once, the broad one turned over in the main room, and settled, and was still.

He was not angry.

He looked for it, a little, the way you put your hand to your side after a fall to see if it comes away wet. There was nothing. He was not surprised, either. There was nothing there to be surprised.

He only saw it.

He saw it the way he saw the four of them now. The angles. The spacing. The way the shape left one place open, always, so that whatever came in would come in there. He had thought he was the thing that came in. He had thought he was the thing that went where the shape was not.

He was one of the places.

He had been inside it the whole time. The square on the threshing floor, and the temple, and the valley, and the ravine. He had been walking around inside a drawing, and every time he found a way out of it, the way out had been drawn.

He looked at the circle in the middle of the temple yard.

It was a very good drawing.

It was the best he had ever seen. Better than the square. The square could only go where it was drawn. This had been drawn to hold a thing that went where it liked. Drawn around the edges of him, so lightly he had never felt it.

He waited for it to change something.

It did not stop him. It did not put him back on his mark. It did not make his hands want to be anywhere other than where they were.

It went into him, and down, and where it landed it did not hurt anything. It only made something clear. The way a whetstone makes an edge clear. Not by adding. By taking away everything that was not the edge.

He knew the shape now.

All of it. The square, and the stones, and the circles under them. Where the walls were.

He turned from the door, and went down the passage, and out the back way, and down the slope to the kiln. He did not look toward the spring, where Hanzō was standing in the dark with his hands in his sleeves.

He lay down in the lean-to with his swords beside him and his eyes open.

He did not sleep.

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In the morning the four took their corners on the threshing floor.

The grey was coming up over the hills. The mist lay in the fold of the valley below. The stake stood at the far end of the floor with the dark cloth tied around the top of it. Hanzō stood at the side with his hands in his sleeves.

He had watched them every morning since he came back. He was watching now.

Ren stood on the fifth mark.

He looked at the square.

The young one in the north. The broad one in the east. The woman in the west. The one with the scar in the south. Two sword lengths and a little more. He could see every foot. Every space. Every count.

And he could see where Hanzō thought he would go.

Not on a map. In the square itself. In the way it was set this morning, a little differently from yesterday, the young one a half step further around, the woman a half step closer in. In the openings it would make. Three of them. Three places the fifth could go that were not the fifth mark. Early, between the broad one and the young one, the way he had gone the first time. Late, around the outside of the woman's crossing. Or through the middle, on the fourth count, when everything opened at once.

Three places. He could see all three. Each one would work. Each one would bring him to the stake before the square did, with his wooden sword resting on the dark cloth.

Each one had a small circle drawn around it, somewhere, in fine ink.

Hanzō lifted his hand.

The square moved.

Ren moved.

Not early. Not late. Not through the middle.

He went to a fourth place.

He walked off the fifth mark, at an angle, away from the square. Away from the stake. Across the corner of the threshing floor to the edge of it, where the packed earth gave way to grass, and the grass ran down toward the spring. He stopped there. In the grass. Nowhere. Facing nothing.

It did not make sense.

It did not help. It did not bring him to the stake. It did not break the square, or go through it, or around it. The square turned, and closed, and opened, and on the fourth count the gap opened for the fifth, and there was no fifth, and it closed again. The four of them finished at their marks, in perfect position, with nothing to open for.

He was not in the drawing.

He was only standing in the grass, outside it, with the wooden swords low.

He felt Hanzō's eyes.

He had felt them every morning. On the square. On the spaces. On the fifth mark, and on him, wherever he went, already there, already waiting at the place he was going. They had always been there first.

They came to him now.

They came across the threshing floor, from the square, to the edge of the grass, where he was standing. And they were late.

Not by much. A fraction. The time it takes a man to look for something where it should be, and not find it, and look again.

For the first time, they were late.

Ren looked back at him.

Across the corner of the floor, over the grass, in the grey light, with the square standing silent at its marks behind them. Hanzō's face did not change. His hands did not move in his sleeves. He looked at Ren, and Ren looked at him, and neither of them looked away.

Behind them, the four stood in their places and did not know where to look.

Ren knew where the walls were now.

So now he knew where to break them.

Chapter 69

Choice

It had rained all day, and stopped at dusk.

The ground was soft with it. Under the cedars the needles were dark and wet and gave underfoot without a sound, and the ferns along the track were bent over with water, and every branch let go of a drop when anything brushed it. Mist came up off the slope in thin threads where the last light still reached. Spring had gotten into everything. The whole hillside smelled of it, green and cold and rotting at the same time.

Ren lay in the ferns above the track and watched the shrine.

It was small. A wayside thing, a roof on four posts over a stone the height of a child, with a rope tied around it and a paper streamer gone grey in the rain. It stood where the track forked in a clearing among the cedars, one way going down to the valley and the other going up over the ridge toward the old shrine road.

A man was sitting under the roof, out of the wet, waiting.

Ren knew what he was. He had known since the map.

The night before, in the main room, Hanzō had knelt with the lamp beside him and set the stones down. The shrine at the fork. A man from Kōga who came there every fourth evening to meet a runner, and took what the runner brought, and sent back what he had been given. Not a fighter. A man who carried things. The places. The nights. Where each of them would sleep, and when they would move, and who would be where on the night after the new moon.

The line. Everything that was left of Kōga, going through one man sitting under a roof in the rain.

"Alive," Hanzō had said.

He had said it once, and looked around at all of them, and last at Ren. The man knew things, and they needed the things he knew, and a dead man did not tell anyone anything.

Then the stones. Daichi and Kenshiro on the track below, where it went down to the valley, to close it. Jin on the left flank, in the cedars above the upper track. Ayame on the right, in the rocks. Ren in the center. Straight down from the ferns to the shrine.

Everyone moves on the signal.

There was no signal tonight. Hanzō was not on the ridge. He had stayed at the house with the map. The signal was the runner: when the runner came, and the two of them were bent together under the roof over whatever the runner had brought, they would go.

Ren had looked at the map a long time the night before, from his place by the back door. There had been no small circles on it that he could see. He did not think that meant there were none.

The runner came up the valley track at the last of the light, a boy, quick, in a straw cape black with rain.

He ducked in under the roof. The man in the shrine leaned toward him. Their heads went together.

On the left, in the cedars, Jin moved.

On the right, in the rocks, Ayame.

Ren went down through the ferns.

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He was halfway to the shrine when the Fūma came.

They came out of the cedars below the fork, on the valley side, between the shrine and the place where Daichi and Kenshiro were waiting on the lower track. Grey. Four of them. Five. They had not been on the map. They had

not been anywhere. They came out of the mist the way they always came, from where nothing was, and they did not come at the shrine.

Two of them went for Jin.

Jin had come out of the cedars on the left and down onto the upper track, fast, the way he always came now, faster than he needed to, to be there first. He was in the open. He had been going for the runner. The two grey men came at him from below and behind, one high and one low, the way they came, and Jin turned to meet them.

The man in the shrine was on his feet.

Ren saw all of it.

He saw it the way he saw everything now. Not one thing and then the next. All of it, at once, laid out in front of him in the wet dusk like the stones on a map. The shrine. The man, on his feet, his hand going to the short blade in his sash. The runner, already turning to run up the ridge track. Ayame coming out of the rocks on the right, too far. The three other Fūma going down the valley track toward Daichi and Kenshiro, to hold them. And Jin, on the left, on the open track, with two grey men on him.

And behind every one of them, the doors.

Every man had a door in him, and behind that door another, and behind that another, all the things he could do, going back and back. You did not see the one thing a man would do. You saw all of them.

They opened now. All of them. Every door, in every one of them, back and back.

If he turned left, to Jin, he would reach him. Eight steps across the wet ground. The first grey man would be turning to him on the seventh, and the second would not have finished his cut. Jin would live. And the man in the shrine would be up the ridge track, into the cedars, into the dark, and gone, with every night and every place and every name in his head.

If he went straight down to the shrine and took the man alive, he would have him. He would have him on the ground with his arm behind him in four steps. And then the grey men who were on Jin would finish Jin, and turn, and come across the clearing at him with the man on the ground between them, and one of them would put a blade into the man before Ren could stop it, because that was why they were here. The Fūma did not want him alive either. Either way, the man would be lost.

If he went straight down to the shrine and killed him, it was over. Kōga's line cut. No nights. No places. No names going up the ridge. Nothing for the Fūma to take. The hunt done in one cut.

He saw all three. All the way to the end of each.

He saw Jin.

Jin on the upper track, turning the high cut, and the low one coming in under it. Jin was good. Jin had been good on a cedar slope in the autumn, and he was better now, after all the mornings, and the nights racing to get there first. He turned the high cut, and he turned the low one, and he was holding them.

He was not going to hold them.

Ren could see the door. There was an opening, on Jin's left side, low, where the second grey man would come in when Jin turned to the first. It was open now. It would stay open for the space of one breath. If Ren went left, now, he would be in it before the grey man was.

He watched the opening.

He watched it close.

He did not go left.

He went straight down.

***

The man in the shrine had his hand on his blade. He did not draw it.

Ren came in under the roof and past the stone with the rope around it, and his right sword went across once, and the man sat down against the post behind him with his hand still on the hilt. His eyes were open. They did not look at anything.

The runner was gone up the ridge track. Ren let him go. The runner did not know anything. The runner only carried.

It was clean.

It was against every word that had been said over the map.

He turned around.

Across the clearing, on the upper track, ten steps away, Jin was still fighting.

He was fighting two of them. Jin was good. He was not good enough for two. The high cut came and he turned it, and the low one came in under it, into the opening on the left that had closed and opened again, and it went into his side.

Jin made a small sound.

He went down onto one knee on the wet track. His sword was still up. His other hand had gone to his side, and it was dark.

He looked up.

Not at the grey men. Past them. Across the clearing. At Ren.

He did not call out. He did not say Ren's name, or anyone's. Ren could see him know it. Everything. The ten steps. The eight steps it would have been, a breath ago. The door on his left side, and Ren watching it, and watching it close, and going the other way. Jin knew. He had been following Ren for weeks, through the hills, and he had learned to read him a little, and he read him now. He knew Ren had seen.

Ren looked back at him.

He did not look away. He did not move. He stood under the roof of the shrine with the dead man at his feet and his sword lowered, and he looked at Jin across the clearing, and Jin looked at him.

The second blade came down.

Jin went over onto his side on the wet needles, and lay there, and did not move again.

Ren stood still.

With Shigure, he had not been there. He had been on the wrong road, in the snow, out of his place, gone after the darker road because his body had seen it and gone before he could think. He had not known, until after, what the leaving had cost. He had not chosen it. It had happened to him, the way weather happens.

This was not that.

He had been ten steps away. He had seen the door open. He had seen it close. He had seen exactly what was behind each of the three ways, all the way to the end, and he had chosen one of them.

He had known exactly what he was choosing.

He had chosen it.

***

Ayame came across the clearing from the rocks, running. The leg did not slow her.

She was too late. She had been too late since the moment the grey men came out of the cedars, and she had known it, and she ran anyway.

The two Fūma on the upper track saw her coming. They did not wait for her. They stepped back off the track into the cedars, one and then the other, and the mist took them. Down on the valley track, the other three were gone too. Ren had not seen them go. Nobody ever did. There was only Daichi, and Kenshiro behind him, coming up the lower track at a run, with their swords out and nobody in front of them.

Ayame reached Jin.

She went down on her knees beside him in the wet. She did not touch him at first. She looked at him. Then she put her hand on his shoulder, the way you touch someone who is asleep, and turned him a little toward her, and looked at his face.

She stayed like that.

Ren took a cloth from inside his coat. He wiped his sword on it, one side and then the other, slowly, the way the old man had taught him. The cloth came away dark. He looked along the blade in the last of the light.

Ayame lifted her head.

She looked at him across the clearing. At the shrine, and the man sitting dead against the post. At the cloth in his hand. At his face.

"You could have reached him."

Her voice was not loud. It was very steady. It was the voice of someone who already knows the answer and is asking anyway, so that it will have been said.

Ren did not lie.

He had not lied to the old man, or to Shigure. He did not see any reason to lie now.

"Yes."

He put his sword away.

Ayame looked at him a moment longer. Then she looked down at Jin again. Daichi had reached them. He stood over the two of them with his sword still out, breathing hard, and looked at Jin on the ground, and then at Ren, and his face did something Ren had never seen it do, and then did nothing at all. Kenshiro came up behind him and stopped.

Nobody said anything else.

Up in the cedars, a crow landed.

Ren heard it before he saw it. The wet clap of wings, and a branch dipping, and a drop of water falling a long way through the dark. Then another. And another, on the far side of the clearing. And another, above the shrine.

They were coming in from everywhere. Out of the dusk, over the ridge, from down the valley, one and then five and then more than he could count, dropping into the cedars around the clearing and folding their wings and going still. Black on the black branches. Not calling. Only landing, and settling, and looking down.

Daichi and Kenshiro had not even lifted Jin yet.

Ren knew these crows. Not these birds. These crows. The ones that went ahead of him, and came after him, and sat in the trees around every house and every camp before anyone knew anything was coming. The ones Jin had followed for three weeks across the hills, from ridge to ridge, a long way behind, keeping his distance, looking for the trees where they gathered, because where they gathered, that was where Ren would be.

They were here now.

Ayame looked up at them. All around the clearing, in every tree. Then she looked at Ren. She did not say anything.

Ren did not look up at the crows.

He stood by the shrine, with the dead man against the post behind him and the rope around the stone and the grey paper streamer hanging wet and still, and he looked at Jin on the ground, and at Ayame's hand on Jin's shoulder, and he did not look away.

The light went.

In the cedars all around them, the crows sat and waited, and did not make a sound.

Chapter 70

Mist

It was the last hour of the night, and the moon had come up.

What was left of it. A thin paring, low over the eastern ridge, the old moon, wasting toward nothing. It gave very little light. Enough. It came down between the cedars in pale bars and lay on the ground of the clearing and on the flat stone where Ren sat, and on the swords across his knees.

He was a long way from the house. He had not wanted to be near the house.

The forest was very still. No wind. The cedars stood up black all around the clearing, and nothing moved in them. Somewhere below, out of sight, a stream ran over stones. Otherwise nothing. Not an owl. Not a bird. Not the raven, which had stayed at the house on the woodshed roof, and had not come after him.

He took up the first sword. The old man's.

He drew it and laid the scabbard beside him on the stone. The blade lay across his palms in the moonlight, long and dark, with the light running along its edge in a thin line.

He turned it, and found the pin.

A small peg of bamboo, through the hilt, holding the blade inside it. He had put it in and taken it out a hundred times, in the cave, by the fire, with the old man watching. He took a needle from his belt and set the point of it to the end of the peg and pressed, and the peg went through, and he drew it out from the other side and set it down on the stone.

He held the sword upright by the hilt, the point to the sky.

He struck the hilt once, lightly, with the back of his other hand.

The blade gave. He felt it go, loose, inside the hilt. He struck again, and it slid, and he let the hilt come away down off it, slowly, and the guard with it, and the collar of copper under the guard, and set them all down on the stone in the order they had come off.

The blade was bare in his hand.

He held it by the tang, the iron that went inside the hilt. It was dark and rough and cold, not like the rest of it. Old. Brown with years of being shut away in the dark of the hilt.

He took the cloth from inside his coat and began to wipe the blade.

From the guard to the point. Slowly. One side, and then the other. The way the old man had shown him, the cloth folded so the edge could not go through it, the hand moving always away from the body. The moon moved on the steel as the cloth went over it. There was nothing on the blade. He wiped it anyway, the whole length, once, and again.

Then the tang.

He turned it to the moon, to wipe it, and saw the marks.

Cut into the iron. Two characters, chiseled in by hand, a long time ago, near the end of the tang where the hilt had always covered it. He had seen them before. He had seen them in the cave, by the fire, when he was small, and had not known what they were, and had not asked.

He read them now.

Masamune.

He looked at the name a moment.

Then he finished wiping the tang. He set the collar back on the blade, and the guard, and slid the hilt back down over it, and found the hole, and put the bamboo peg back through, and pressed it home with his thumb. He put the sword back in its scabbard.

He laid it down on the stone beside him.

He sat for a while.

The moon had moved a little. The bars of light had moved with it, across the clearing, and one of them lay across his knees now.

He took up the other sword. The grey one.

He drew it. The pattern was in the steel, the way it always was, the grey mist lying on water, and the moon went into it and lay there too. He found the pin. He set the needle to it and pressed, and it went through, and he drew it out. He held the sword upright. He struck the hilt with the back of his hand, once, twice, and the blade gave, and slid, and the hilt came away, and the guard, and the collar, and he set them down on the stone in their order.

He wiped the blade. Guard to point. One side and the other. The moon in the mist in the steel.

He turned it to wipe the tang.

Two characters, cut into the old dark iron. Younger than the other, but old. The strokes worn soft at their edges, as if a great many hands had held this iron before his, over a great many years.

Muramasa.

He did not think anything.

He did not have time to think anything. The name was in front of him, in the moonlight, cut into the iron, and before he had gotten any further with it than that, before it had gone into him to wherever things went, there was a sound.

Very faint.

So faint that at first it was not a sound at all. Only something in the stillness that had not been there before. A breath, far off, going through something hollow. Low. Longer than a breath should be.

He went still.

It came again. A little louder. From somewhere in the cedars, beyond the clearing, down toward the stream. A note. Low, and breathy, and wavering, the breath rough at the start of it and then smoothing out and going on, and on, and then bending, very slowly, up, and breaking off.

Silence.

Then again. Nearer.

Ren did not move. The blade was in his hand, bare, the tang in his fingers and the long grey steel lying across his other palm. He did not put it down.

The note came again, nearer still, and rose, and fell, and the mist came with it.

He did not see it come. It was not there, and then it was. It came down out of the cedars all at once, the way snow comes off a roof, white, soft, settling. It filled the clearing. It lay on the ground and came up around the stone and around his knees and his hands, and the moonlight went into it and turned it pale and shining, and the cedars at the edge of the clearing went grey and then went away.

There was only the white, and the moon in it, and the sound.

It was very close now.

Ren raised his head.

Something was moving in the mist.

At first there was only a shape. Round. Large. Coming slowly between the cedars on the far side of the clearing, at the height of a man's head. A great round hat of woven straw, like a basket turned over, coming down all the way to the shoulders, so that there was no face under it. No face at all. Only the hat, pale in the moonlit mist, moving.

Then, as it came nearer, and the sound came with it, the rest.

A robe, dark, to the ankles. A stole of cloth across one shoulder. A string of beads at the waist, swinging a little with each step. Straw sandals, going down soft on the wet needles, one and then the other, not hurrying.

And the flute.

A long flute of bamboo, thick, with the knuckle of the root still on the end of it. Held in both hands, up, under the edge of the hat, where the mouth would be. That was where the sound was coming from. Out of that length of bamboo, out of the dark under the hat, one long breath at a time.

A monk.

He came out of the mist on the far side of the clearing and walked across it, a little way off from the stone where Ren sat, and did not turn his head. Did not stop. Did not change his step. If he knew there was a man sitting there in the moonlight with a bare blade in his hands, he gave no sign. He only walked, and played.

The sound filled everything.

It went up, slowly, a long rough breath smoothing into a note, and the note hung there in the white, and wavered, and bent, and came down again, and broke, and there was a silence in the middle of it that was part of it. Then another breath. Another note, lower. It did not go anywhere. It did not make a tune. It was only breath, going out through bamboo, one breath and then the next, each one whole, each one ending.

Ren sat on the stone and listened.

He did not know how long. He did not know that he was listening. He had not decided to. The sound had come into him the way the mist had come into the clearing, all at once, from everywhere, and there was nothing in him that it had to get past. It went all the way down. Past the place where the words went. Past the doors and the spaces and the shape. Down into the dark at the bottom of him, where things went and did not come back, and it did not come back either. It only went down, and down, and was there.

The blade lay across his hands. He had forgotten it. The moon lay in the steel, and the mist lay on the steel, and the name was under his fingers on the tang where he could not see it.

The monk walked on.

Across the clearing. Past the stone. Toward the cedars on the other side. Ren's eyes went with him. The great straw hat, pale, going away into the white. The dark robe. The beads swinging. The flute held up under the hat. His eyes followed it, and his head turned a little to follow it, and he did not know he was doing it.

The monk went in among the cedars.

The hat went grey. Then it was a shape. Then it was not anything.

The sound went on.

Fainter now. From among the trees. The long breath, and the note, and the bend of it, and the break. Fainter. Down toward the stream, perhaps, or up over the ridge. Ren could not tell. It did not seem to be going anywhere. It only seemed to be going away.

Fainter.

A breath, far off, going through something hollow.

Then only something in the stillness that had been there a moment ago, and was not.

Then nothing.

Ren sat on the stone.

Around him, the mist began to go. It did not go the way it had come. It went slowly, thinning, lifting a little off the ground, pulling back into the cedars the way water goes back down a beach. The trees at the edge of the clearing came back, grey, and then black. The ground came back. The moon, a little higher now and paler, with the first grey of morning coming up under it, came through clear again, in its pale bars.

He looked down.

The blade was in his hands. Bare. The grey steel with the mist lying in it, the mist that was always in it, that had been in it before the other mist came and was still in it now it had gone. The moon on the edge. His fingers on the tang, over the name.

He looked at it.

Silence.

The stream ran over the stones below, the way it had before. Nothing else. Not an owl. Not a bird. No sound of anyone walking anywhere in the forest, going away.

He sat there a long time with the blade in his hands.

Then he set the collar back on it. And the guard. He slid the hilt down over the tang, over the name, and found the hole, and put the bamboo peg through, and pressed it home with his thumb. He put the sword back in its scabbard, slowly, until the guard touched the mouth of it.

He laid it on the stone beside the other.

Chapter 71

Unleashed

The night after the new moon, there was no light at all.

No moon. No stars; cloud had come over at dusk and stayed. The hollow above the old shrine road was a bowl of black in the black hills, and the only thing in it that could be seen from the ridge was the fire. A small one, in a pit, under an overhang of rock at the bottom of the bowl, banked low so that it would not show from the road. Around it, shapes. Shelters of cut branches. Men sleeping. Men sitting up.

Kōga. What was left of it.

Ren lay on the lip of the hollow in the wet grass and looked down at it.

Two nights ago, at the map, Hanzō had set the stones down. Daichi on the ridge to the east. Kenshiro on the ridge to the west. Ayame in the hollow, low, where the path came in from the shrine road. Himself on the far ridge, with the lantern. And a stone for Ren, at the north lip, above the overhang, where the fire was.

Then Hanzō had set one more stone. A black one. He had set it at the bottom of the hollow, by the fire.

"Raiden," he had said. And then, looking around at all of them: "Alive."

Nobody had looked at Ren. Everybody had not looked at him very carefully.

Ren looked down into the hollow now and did not look at the fire.

Raiden was not by the fire.

He could see where the black stone should have been, and it was not there. He could see all of it. The shelters, the sleepers, the two men sitting up by the pit, the one on the path at the south with his back to a tree. The doors in every one of them. And none of them had Raiden in them. Raiden was not in the hollow.

He was where the hollow ended.

On the east side, where the bowl broke open into a notch between two shoulders of rock, and a path went up out of it and over into the next valley. The way out. The way a man goes when the thing he has been waiting for comes down into the place he was told to wait in. Ren could not see him there. He knew the shape of him the way he knew the shape of the square. A man who had stood in the middle of a courtyard in the smoke because that was where the boy would be. A man who knew where things would go before they went there.

He would be in the notch. Alone. Standing. With his sword low in his right hand and the point toward the ground.

On the far ridge, a light showed once, and went out.

The hollow woke.

Ren did not go down to the fire.

He went along the lip of the hollow, east, fast, low, through the wet grass, while below him the shelters came apart and men came up out of them into the dark and the steel began. He did not look down. He heard Ayame's voice once, sharp, a name, and then not. He heard a shelter go up, the branches catching from the pit, the light of it coming up orange and sudden across the whole bowl. He did not look.

He came around the last shoulder of rock, and the notch opened in front of him, and the firelight from the hollow came up into it, orange, moving.

Raiden was standing in it.

Alone. Standing. His sword low in his right hand, the point toward the ground.

He was looking at Ren. He had been looking at the place Ren would come around the rock, and Ren had come around the rock, and there was nothing on his face about it at all.

Ren stopped.

Ten paces. The firelight between them.

The last time he had seen this face it had been among the oaks above the road, in the snow, the day Shigure died. It had looked at him across fifteen paces and then turned away, as if it had only needed to be seen. Before that, over the old man's body. In a corridor, in the smoke, with Ren on his back on the boards and a broken sword in his hand. Raiden had looked at him both times the way he was looking at him now. As if he were a thing that had happened, and was over.

Ren drew both swords.

He did not feel himself do it. He felt something else. Something that came up from very far down, from under the doors and the spaces and the shape, from the dark at the bottom of him where things went, and did not stay there. It came up through him like fire comes up through a house. Into his chest. Into his arms. Into his hands on the two hilts.

It was not cold.

It was the first thing in a very long time that was not.

***

He went in.

Both swords. The old man's first form. The first thing he had ever been shown, on a cold morning, in a clearing, with his legs shaking. Right high, left low, the step, the turn, the cut from above and the cut from below coming in together, the whole of him behind them.

He did not hold anything back.

He had held back all spring. On the gravel bar, with the man shouting. At the shrine. In the square on the threshing floor, every morning, the shortest way from here to there, nothing extra, nothing left over. He had spent nothing he did not need to spend.

He spent it now. All of it. He went in with everything, and the two swords came down on Raiden like the sky coming down.

Raiden moved.

A finger's width. The upper cut went past his ear. The lower one met his blade, and turned, and slid, and was gone, and Raiden's sword came back from it without any sound at all and opened Ren's sleeve at the shoulder, and the skin under it.

Ren did not feel it.

He came around. Again. Both swords. Left, right, left, down, across, and it was not the corridor. In the corridor there had been no ground under him and no line from his feet to his hands. There was ground now. Every cut went into the earth through his feet and came back up out of it. Every cut had a place it was going. The old man's way of two swords, the way the old man had given it to him, thousands of mornings on the path and in the clearing, until they were not a thing he did but a thing he was.

Raiden was not there.

A pace to the left. A pace back. A turn. The swords went through where he had been. He did not hurry. He did not waste anything. He met what he had to meet and let the rest go by, and every time he met something his blade came back from it into some part of Ren. The back of the hand. The thigh. The cheek, a line of cold that turned hot.

Cold. All of it. Raiden fought the way winter comes. There was nothing in it. No breath held. No weight left over. No face. His eyes over the crossed blades were very calm, and they did not want anything.

Ren could see all of him.

The doors. Every one of them, back and back. And behind every door, the same thing. Nothing. No one. There was no one in Raiden to find. There was only a sword and the place it would go next.

Ren looked into it, over the crossed steel, and knew what it was.

It was the end of something. The end of the doors. A man who had gone all the way down, and let it take everything that was not the edge, until there was nothing left but the edge. It was where the doors went, if you went through all of them.

It was where he was going.

He broke off.

He went back three steps, fast, and stood with the two swords low and his breath going in and out of him, hard, loud in the notch. Raiden did not follow. Raiden stood where he had been standing, his sword low, the point toward the ground, and breathed in through his nose and out through his nose, slow, even, as if he were sitting by a fire.

Ren's hand went to his belt.

***

A sealed shell. He broke it on the rock at his feet.

The smoke came up white and thick and rolling, the way it had come through a side door once, when Shigure's hand went in low and came out empty. It filled the notch between them. The firelight went into it and turned it orange, and then there was nothing to see.

Ren went into it.

He came out of it with both swords, from the left, where there had been nothing, and the two blades came in one after the other, high and then low, as hard as he could make them come. Raiden's sword met the first. Met the second. Two sounds, bright, close together. And Raiden stepped aside, a half step, and Ren's weight went past him.

Ren did not stop.

He let the weight carry him. Past Raiden. Back into the smoke. Gone.

Raiden turned. Slowly. He stood in the notch with the smoke rolling around him and his sword low, and waited.

Ren came out of the smoke at his left shoulder.

High, feinting, the right sword going up. Then dropping. Under the line of Raiden's arm, and turning, and the left blade coming across, short, close, up, to the soft place under the jaw. The way she had done it. On the training ground in the morning, with the laugh coming out of him afterward. Her dagger at his throat. *Again.*

The edge was a finger's width from Raiden's throat.

Raiden was not there.

He had gone back, his chin lifting, the whole of him going back from the blade the way a reed goes back from the wind, and the edge went through the place his throat had been and touched nothing.

Ren was already gone. Back into the smoke.

Raiden stood still.

He did not follow. He did not turn his head. He stood in the orange smoke and let it tell him where things were.

From the smoke, straight, a blade.

The short blade from Ren's belt, thrown the way a man throws who has thrown ten thousand times and has never once thought about it. The whole arm behind it. Nothing left over. Straight at the middle of Raiden, the way Kurogane threw, the way Kurogane did everything.

Raiden's sword came up and it rang off the steel and went spinning away over the rock into the dark.

He had not looked where it came from.

And Ren came out of the smoke along the ground.

Low. On his hip, sliding, the wet earth going under him, his legs in front, the way Hayate went in under a man when Hayate was laughing and the man was not. Under Raiden's guard. Under everything. The right sword going out flat along the ground at the height of a man's heel, at the cords behind the ankles.

Raiden jumped.

Straight up. Both feet. The blade went under him through nothing, and Ren slid on through and out the other side, and rolled, and came up on one knee, facing him.

His left sword was standing point down in the earth beside him. The stars were already in his left hand.

Four of them. His own. Five points each, cut in a smithy in Iga, a long time ago, where every other star had six. He did not throw them at Raiden.

He threw them where Raiden would be.

Shigure had done it. At the map, with the stones, and on the board with the pieces, and in the snow, every time. Not where a man was. Where he was going. Where the next step would put him, and the one after that, before he had decided to take it. Ren saw Raiden come down from the jump. He saw where Raiden's feet would land, and where his weight would go when they did, and which way he would turn to meet what came next.

He threw.

Four stars. Into the dark. At the place.

Raiden landed, and saw them, and moved.

Of course he moved. He had known where they would go. He had known from the moment Ren's hand went to his belt, a breath before it happened. He did not go where the stars were. He went the one way that was left. Back, and to the right, one long clean step out of the line of them, onto the one piece of ground in the notch where nothing was coming.

He landed on it.

On the small round thing lying in the wet earth, that had been lying there since before the smoke. That had gone out of Ren's hand in the same movement that broke the shell on the rock, low along the ground, its cord touched first to the slow match he had carried smoldering in his sleeve all night, and the cord had been burning, very small, all this time, under the smoke, where nobody could see it.

One of Enji's.

Raiden's foot came down on it.

The notch went white.

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When Ren could see again, the smoke was gone.

The blast had taken it. It had taken it and thrown it back against the rock and it hung there now in rags, going grey. The firelight from the hollow came up into the notch clean and orange and lay across the ground.

Raiden was on the ground.

He was sitting. His back against the rock at the side of the notch. His sword was still in his hand. He had not let go of it. His left leg was stretched out in front of him on the earth.

His right leg was not there. Not below the knee. There was only the dark, and the ground, and the smoke going up off it.

He was not making a sound.

He sat against the rock with his sword in his hand and looked at Ren. His face had not changed. His breath went in through his nose and out through his nose. Slower now. Still even.

Ren pulled his left sword out of the earth, and stood up.

He was bleeding. His shoulder. His hand. His cheek. His thigh. He did not feel any of it. His breath was going in and out of him hard and loud, and he could hear his heart, and the two swords were in his hands, and the thing that had come up in him out of the dark was still there. It had not gone back down.

Feet on the rocks behind him.

Daichi came around the shoulder of the notch first, fast, his sword out, blood on it. Then Ayame, from the hollow side, climbing, the firelight on her face. Kenshiro behind her. They stopped when they saw.

The notch. The rags of smoke on the rock. Raiden against the rock with his leg gone. Ren standing over him with both swords out.

Ren walked toward Raiden.

Daichi moved.

He came across the notch and put himself in the way. Between Ren and the rock. His sword came up and across in front of Ren's chest, flat, a bar.

Ren's left sword moved.

He did not look at it. His eyes did not leave Raiden. The left sword came up and struck Daichi's blade aside, once, hard, near the guard, and the sound of it rang off the rocks, high, and Daichi's arm went wide with it and he had to step back to keep his feet.

Daichi came back. He put himself in the way again. Closer this time.

"We take him alive."

Ren did not say anything.

He did not look at Daichi. He looked past him. Over his shoulder. At Raiden against the rock. His eyes had not moved from Raiden since he came around the shoulder of the notch. They did not move now.

Ayame came in on his other side.

"It's orders!"

She did not draw on him. Her hand was on her sword. Her voice was not steady tonight. It cracked on the last word.

Silence.

The fire in the hollow cracked. Somewhere below, a man was groaning, and stopped. Kenshiro stood at the edge of the notch with his sword half up and did not move.

Ren looked at Raiden.

Raiden looked back at him. From the rock. His sword in his hand. His face very calm.

"If you stand in my way," said Ren, "I'll cut through all of you."

He did not say it loudly. He did not look at any of them while he said it. He said it the way you say how deep a river is.

Nobody moved.

Then Daichi's sword came down. Slowly. Until the point was toward the ground.

He stepped back. Out of the way. Ayame looked at Ren's face, and whatever she saw there, she stepped back too. Kenshiro did not move at all.

The way was open.

***

Ren walked toward Raiden.

Slowly. Across the notch, through the firelight, over the scorched ground. He did not hurry. Raiden was not going anywhere. Raiden knew it. He sat against the rock and watched Ren come, and his breath went in and out through his nose, and his face did not change.

He did not raise his sword.

He could have. It was still in his hand. He did not. He looked up at Ren, at the two swords, at Ren's face. The way he had looked down at Ren in the corridor. As if something had happened, and was over.

Ren stopped in front of him.

He did not say anything. There was nothing to say. Everything that could be said between them had been said in a corridor, in the smoke, by a fist in an old man's collar.

He moved.

Both swords together. From high, from either side, the old man's sword and the grey one coming down and in at the same moment, crossing. Not two cuts. One. The two blades meeting in the one place, at the one instant, the way a pair of hands meets to close. Perfectly even. Perfectly level. Neither one a hair ahead of the other. A clean, exact X, drawn once in the firelight, and finished.

Raiden's head came away from his shoulders.

It went down onto the scorched earth beside the rock, and rolled a little, and was still. His body stayed sitting against the rock a moment longer, with the sword in its hand. Then it went over onto its side.

The old man would not have said *again.*

He would not have said anything at all.

***

Silence.

The fire in the hollow had burned down. The shelter that had gone up was only a glow now. Below, nobody was moving anymore.

In the notch, nobody said anything.

Daichi looked at Ayame. Ayame looked at Kenshiro. Kenshiro looked at Daichi.

Then all three of them looked at Ren.

He was standing beside the body. His swords were down. He was bleeding from four places and he was not doing anything about it. He was not looking at them. He was not looking at anything.

They looked at each other again.

Then Daichi turned, and went back around the shoulder of the notch, down toward the hollow. Kenshiro went after him. Ayame went last. At the rock she stopped, and looked back once, at Ren standing in the notch in the last of the firelight beside what was left of Raiden. Her face did not do anything.

Then she went.

Ren stood beside Raiden's body.

The fire went down. The glow went out of the notch, a little at a time, until it was only dark, and the smell of the smoke, and the wet rock.

Chapter 72

The Killer

They brought him in after dark.

Four of them, carrying him between them on a door taken off its hinges somewhere, with a cloth over him. They came in without knocking. Nobody knocked tonight. They came across the room with the door between them, slowly, the way men walk when what they are carrying cannot be jolted anymore and they carry it carefully anyway, and they set it down on the mats at the foot of the table.

They did not look at her.

They stood a moment with their hands at their sides. One of them opened his mouth, and closed it. Then they went out, one after another, and the last one slid the door shut behind him, very quietly, as if someone in the room were sleeping.

Kikyo stood where she was.

She did not go to it at once. She stood at the head of the table with her hands resting on the edge of it, the way she always stood, and looked at the room.

The map. The needles in it, with their knotted threads. The lamp at the far end, burning low, the only one lit. Takeru's chair, empty; he had not come down, and she had not sent for him. The brazier by the chair, cold. Nobody had lit it. It was spring; there was no need.

The wall to the right of the door.

She looked at it a long time.

It was only a wall. Plaster, and a post, and the grain of the post dark with years. There was nothing on it. There was nothing in front of it. It was a wall she had looked across the lamplight at on a hundred nights, in every season, and every one of those nights there had been a man leaning against it with his arms folded, his weight on the wall and still, somehow, forward, the way a sword is there on its stand.

There was nothing there now.

She looked at it until she was sure of that.

Then she went around the table and knelt on the mats beside the door they had carried him in on, and lifted the cloth.

***

She knew before she saw it.

She had known since the men came in without knocking. She had known, if she was honest, since the night the needles began to make a line, and she had looked up from the end of the line across the room at the wall, and he had been looking back at her, and she had not answered Takeru's question.

But she looked. She made herself look at all of it.

The leg first. The right leg was gone below the knee, and what was left of it had been bound up in strips of someone's sleeve by someone who had known it did not matter. Fire had done that. One of the clay things that had opened Iga's wall. She had read the report.

Then the rest.

The head had been set back where it belonged, at the top of him, on the door, by whoever had carried him down from the notch. They had done it with some care. The cut was very clean. It went through level, from both sides at once, and met in the middle.

Two blades. Crossing. Neither one a hair ahead of the other.

She knew whose.

There was only one man she had ever heard of who cut like that. Musashi. And Musashi was dead, and there was only one person he had ever taught.

She looked at the cut for a long time.

It was very beautiful. That was the thing she could not stop seeing. It was the most perfect cut she had ever looked at, and she had looked at a great many. Whoever had made it had not been angry when they made it. Or had been, and had put it somewhere, and made the cut anyway, exactly, the way it should be made.

She looked at his face.

It was the same face. It had not changed. It had not changed in death any more than it had ever changed in life. Calm. Nothing on it but what was needed. His eyes were closed. Someone had closed them. She did not know who. It would not have been the boy.

She sat back on her heels.

***

She had been seventeen.

Barely more than a girl herself, and already the one they sent when a thing needed choosing. It had been winter. A yard behind a house in the hills, with the snow trodden to brown slush and the sky white and low over the ridges, and a line of children standing in it.

Eleven of them. Orphans. Kōga's, from the fighting that year, and the sickness the year before. The oldest perhaps seven. The youngest could barely stand straight. They had been lined up in the cold in their thin clothes and told to wait, and they were waiting.

Every one of them was crying.

Or trying not to. That was worse, somehow. The ones trying not to. Chins shaking. Eyes wet and held very wide so that nothing would fall out of them. A girl at the end with both fists in her mouth. A boy in the middle who had wet himself and was standing in it, crying without any sound at all, his shoulders going.

She had walked along the line.

She had not stopped at any of them. She had known what she was looking for before she came into the yard, and she walked the line the way you walk along a rack of blades looking for the one without a flaw.

And near the end of the line, there was a boy who wasn't.

Not crying. Not trying not to. There was nothing in his face at all. He was six, perhaps. Thin. His feet bare in the slush and gone red with the cold. He was not shivering. Or he was, but only his body, the way a body shivers on its own, and none of it came up into his face. He was looking straight ahead, past her and past the others, at the wall of the yard, at nothing, the way a man looks at the road ahead of him when there is nothing on it yet.

She had stopped in front of him.

He had not looked at her. He had not looked away from the wall.

She had chosen him for that.

***

She never raised her voice to him.

Not once. Not in all the years. There was no need. She had seen what raised voices did to children, in that yard and in others, and she wanted none of it. A child who was shouted at learned to listen for the shout. She did not want him listening for anything but the thing itself.

She never praised him.

That was harder to explain, and she had never tried to explain it to anyone. Praise was a thing a child did things for. She did not want him to do anything for anything. She wanted him to do it because it was the thing to be done, and for no other reason.

When he failed, she did not say anything. She only looked at him. She looked at him until he did it again. However long that took. In the yard, in the snow, with the practice blade too heavy for him and his arms shaking, she would stand and look, and he would lift it, and do it again, and she would go on looking until it was right, and then she would stop looking, and that was all.

When he was cold, she did not make a fire.

She let him learn to be cold. She let him learn that cold was a thing that happened to the body and did not have to happen to anything else. By the second winter he did not notice it. By the third, she was not sure he felt it at all.

When he did something perfectly, she said nothing.

Nothing was the reward. He learned that. He learned it faster than anything else she ever taught him. That when the silence came, it was because the thing had been done right, and there was nothing more to say about it.

She gave him his name.

He had come to her with another one, some small name a dead mother had called him, and she had never used it. On the first morning, in the yard, when he had stood in front of her with the practice blade and not cried when she took it away from him and gave it back and took it away again, she had looked at him, and said it.

Raiden.

Thunder. The kind that comes after the lightning, when it is already too late.

He had never asked what it meant. He had never asked for anything. He had never needed to be told a thing twice. When she looked at him across a room, he went. When she looked at a door, he went through it. When she looked at a man, the man was dead by morning.

He never hesitated.

Never once. Not as a child. Not as a man. Not on the ridge above the hunting grounds with a boy bleeding against a cedar below him. Not in a corridor in the mountains with his fist in an old man's collar.

She had made him that. She had made him with her own hands, out of a boy in a yard who did not cry, and he had been the answer to every question anyone in Kōga had ever asked her. What if they come from the north. What if the scroll is lost. What if he betrays us.

She had only ever had to look at the wall.

***

She came back into the room.

The lamp at the end of the table had burned lower. The shadows had come in closer around her. The cold of the night was in the mats under her knees.

She looked at his hands.

They lay on his chest, where the men had folded them. Long hands. Hard. She knew every callus on them. There, at the base of the forefinger on the right hand, the old thick one, and the one along the outside of the palm below the little finger. She had put those there. On a morning in the second winter, in the yard, she had taken his hand and moved it on the hilt, a finger's width, lower, and turned it, and let go, and looked at him. He had never held a sword any other way again.

The calluses were exactly where she had corrected his grip.

She did not touch them.

She thought about the other one.

Musashi's boy.

She had read about him for a year. Every report. Every needle on the map. She knew how he had been made, as well as anyone living knew it. A cave in the mountains. An old man who did not talk. Correction, and silence, and

repetition. The same form thousands of times. The old man would have looked at him, the way she had looked at Raiden, until he did it again.

The same. It had been the same.

And then he had hesitated.

At the girl's throat. With the blade already there. With everything that had been put into him, every morning of every year, telling his hand to go on. He had stopped. For a spearman's daughter, on a floor full of smoke, he had stopped.

She had not been there to see it. She had seen it anyway, in this room, when Suzuya lifted his eyes and said *alive.* She had felt it in her own hand, on the edge of the table. Half a breath. Nobody else in the room had seen.

That boy still had something in him. She had known it on that night, and she had called it valuable, and she had been right about that, too. There was something in Musashi's boy that answered when someone looked at him. Something that turned toward a face. Some door that had never quite been closed.

Raiden never had.

She looked down at him. At the calm face. At the eyes someone else had closed.

She had looked at him across a thousand rooms, and he had gone where she looked, and there had never once been anything in him that turned toward her face. Only toward where her face was pointing.

She had built that.

She had built it on purpose. She had stood in a yard in the snow at seventeen and looked along a line of weeping children for the one with nothing in him, and she had found him, and she had spent her life making certain that nothing would ever get in.

His loyalty is greater than his love.

She had said it in this room. About the other boy. She had stood at this table and said it to Takeru's face, sure of it, the way she was sure the lake lay to the north.

She had said it about the wrong boy.

It had never been true of Musashi's boy. His love had been greater. It had been greater at the girl's throat, and it was the only reason he had ever been worth a needle on her map.

It had been true of Raiden. From the first morning. Entirely true. There had been nothing in him that his loyalty had to be greater than. She had seen to that.

And his loyalty had taken him into a notch in the rocks above the shrine road, alone, to wait where she would have told him to wait. And the other boy had come around the rock with something in him that Raiden had never had, and had cut him down with it.

The old man in the cave had given his boy something.

She did not know what it was. She had read every report. She had looked at every needle. She knew what the old man had done, morning by morning, as well as anyone could. The silence. The correction. The same as hers.

There had been something else. Something that was not in any report. Something he had done, or not done, some small thing every day that she had never thought to do, because she had never thought there was any use in it.

She would never know what it was.

***

She sat a long time.

The lamp burned down. The moth was back, or another one. It went around the flame at the end of the table and touched the heat and fell away and came back.

Outside, the frogs had started in the wet fields below the house. Far off, a dog barked once and was quiet.

Nobody came to the door.

At last she got up.

His sword was lying beside him on the door, in its scabbard. The men had brought it down with him. Someone had wiped it and put it away. She picked it up. It weighed what it had always weighed. She had put it in his hand for the first time when he was twelve.

She crossed the room with it.

To the wall. To the right of the door.

She stood there a moment. Then she leaned the sword against the wall, upright, its hilt resting against the plaster and its point on the mats. Exactly where he had always stood. Exactly the angle he had always leaned at, his weight on the wall, and still, somehow, forward.

She stepped back and looked at it.

It was only a sword against a wall.

She went back to him, and knelt, and took the edge of the cloth, and drew it up again. Over his hands, and his chest, and the clean cut at his throat, and his face.

She sat back on her heels.

The lamp burned. The sword leaned against the wall in the edge of the light. The brazier was cold.

She did not cry.

She noticed that she did not.

She sat with that a long time, in the room, in the lamplight, beside him. Noticing it.

Chapter 73

Monster

He did not stay long.

The fire in the hollow went out, and the glow went out of the notch, and there was only the dark and the smell of the smoke and the body against the rock. He stood beside it until the dark was complete. Then he wiped his swords, one and then the other, and put them away, and went on.

Up. Through the notch. Along the path that went over into the next valley. The way Raiden had been standing in front of, all night, so that nobody would take it.

Ren took it.

He did not think about the notch. He did not think about the body, or the head in the scorched earth beside it, or the corridor, or the old man's face on the boards with the fire on it. He looked for them, once, going up the path in the dark, the way you feel for a stone in your sash to see if it is still there.

They were there. They were exactly where they had been. Nothing had moved them.

It was done. Raiden was dead. The old man's thread had been drawn to its end and cut, cleanly, in the firelight, the way it should have been.

And nothing in him was different.

The thing that had come up out of the dark in the notch, the thing that was not cold, had gone back down. He had felt it go, when the three of them turned and went around the rock. It had gone down into the place at the bottom of him where things went, and it had not come back up, and the cold had closed over it the way water closes over a stone.

He walked.

His shoulder was bleeding, and his hand, and his cheek, and his thigh. He did not bind them. He walked with the blood going cold on him, down the far side of the pass into the next valley, through pines, in the dark, and he did not look back.

***

They picked him up at the bottom of the valley.

He knew when. A little after the stream, where the pines opened out into a slope of grass and bracken and old stumps, and the cloud had thinned enough overhead to let a few stars through. He felt the first of them behind him on the left. Then another on the right. Then more, further off, spreading.

Grey. He did not have to turn to know.

He did not change his pace. He did not look for them. He let them come. They were a shape, the way the square was a shape, and he could feel where each of them was and where each of them would go. They were coming to close. A ring. Well back, and drawing in. He could have told anyone where every one of them would be in a hundred breaths.

He stopped in the middle of the slope.

They stopped too. All around him, in the dark, at the edges of the grass. He could hear them breathing. He did not draw.

Then one of them came out of the ring and walked toward him.

Only one.

Ren watched him come.

A giant. Taller than any man Ren had ever seen by two heads, and broad with it, so that the others in the ring looked like boys beside him. Grey like the others, but with nothing over his face. A plain face, high up in the starlight. A face you would forget while you were looking at it, on a body you never would. He walked across the grass, looking at nothing in particular. His sword was in its scabbard at his hip, and his hands were empty, and he did not look at Ren until he was ten paces off, and then he did.

Ren looked at him.

He opened the doors.

He had opened every man's doors since the rock by the river. He opened them now, and looked behind them, the way he had looked behind every one of them in the notch and found no one.

This was not that.

There was someone there. There was a great deal there. But the doors did not go back. They did not go anywhere. He opened one and there was a thing the man might do, and behind it, instead of another door, there was something else entirely, that had nothing to do with the first, and behind that, nothing, and then something again. None of it followed. None of it led. It was like reading a page where the words had been cut out and thrown up into the air and had come down in whatever order they came down.

Ren could not see where the man would go.

It was the first time.

***

The man did not draw.

Ren drew. Both swords. He went in the way he had gone in on the gravel bar and on the threshing floor and at the shrine. The shortest way. The half step, the turn, the blade going from here to there and no further, to the place where the man would be.

The man was not going to be there. He was not going to be anywhere. He stood where he was, with his hands empty, and let Ren come, and at the last instant, with both blades already committed, he drew.

Backward.

Stepping back, away, off balance, the sword coming out of the scabbard behind him, the wrong way, the way no one draws, the way that leaves every part of a man open. And it did leave him open. Ren saw it open. Everything. The whole of the man's front, from throat to hip, with nothing in front of it.

And the drawing blade came around from behind the man's own back, low, out of a place no blade should come from, and went across Ren's forearm.

Ren went back.

He looked at his arm. The cut was not deep. It was very clean.

The man stood with his sword out, off balance still, his weight all wrong, as if he might fall over. He did not fall over.

Ren came in again.

This time he did not go to where the man would be. He did not know where the man would be. He went to the man. Straight. Both swords. And the man did the thing no one does.

He dropped his sword.

He let go of it. In the middle of the exchange, with Ren's blades coming, he opened his hand and let it fall, and it turned once in the starlight going down. Ren's eyes did not follow it. He had been taught all his life not to follow a dropped blade. His eyes stayed on the man.

The man was not interested in the blade.

He came in. Bare-handed. Inside both of Ren's swords, where there was no room to be, chest to chest, closer than anyone ever stood in a fight, and his hand closed on Ren's right wrist and turned it, and Ren's own sword came around toward Ren's own face. Ren tore it away. He felt the edge go past his ear.

And the man's forehead came into his face.

Hard. Once. Like a stone. The world went white on one side, and Ren went back, and his heel caught on a stump in the grass, and by the time he had his feet again the man had stooped, easily, and picked his sword up off the ground, and was standing with it.

He had not hurried.

***

It went on.

Ren went at him with everything he knew. The old man's forms. Aoi's feint and drop. The square, turned inside out. Shigure's reading of where a man would step next. None of it had anywhere to go. Every door he opened on the man was a different room, and none of the rooms were connected, and none of them were the one the man was standing in.

The man sat down.

In the middle of it. With Ren's cut coming at the height of his neck. He sat down in the grass, all at once, the way a child sits when its legs are tired, and the cut went over his head through nothing, and from the ground, sitting, with no weight under it at all, his sword came up and opened Ren's thigh. The same thigh. Across Raiden's cut.

Ren's leg went.

He went down on one knee. He came up. He came up slower.

The man got up off the grass. He brushed at his trousers, once, as if they had gotten wet.

He turned his back.

He turned his back on Ren and walked away. Three steps. Four. Slowly. Across the grass, toward the edge of the ring, where the grey shapes stood in the dark and watched and did not move.

Ren went after him.

He could not help it. It was open. The whole of the man's back, turned, walking. There was nothing in the world as open as a man walking away from you.

The scabbard came back over the man's shoulder.

He had not turned. He had not looked. He had only reached up, walking, and taken the empty scabbard from his sash, and thrown it back over his shoulder without turning his head, and it came end over end through the dark and struck Ren across the face and the eyes.

Ren could not see.

For a breath. Less. Enough.

The man had turned. He was there. The sword came across Ren's chest, left to right, and opened his coat and the skin under it, and came back the other way, lower, across his ribs.

Ren went down.

He went onto his back in the wet grass. One of his swords went out of his hand. He did not know which. The other he still had. He could not lift it. The stars were over him, a few, between the thin places in the cloud.

He did not think anything.

He did not think *this is the end.* He did not think of the old man, or the cave, or the fire, or anything. There was no room in him for any of it. There was only the grass under his back, and the stars, and the wet coming through his coat, and the next thing, and there was no next thing.

The man came and stood over him.

He looked down at Ren. His plain face. His sword in his hand, low, the point toward Ren's throat. He did not say anything. He did not look pleased, or angry, or anything else. He looked the way a man looks at a thing he has picked up on the road and is deciding whether to keep.

The point came up.

Ren watched it.

***

A sound, on the left.

Very small. A stone, turning over under a sandal, in the dark at the edge of the slope. Once. The kind of sound nobody who walked the way the Fūma walked would ever make. The kind of sound a man makes on purpose, when he wants to be heard.

The point stopped.

The man turned his head.

Ren turned his too. On the grass, with the wet coming through him, he turned his head to the left and looked.

Hanzō.

Standing at the edge of the slope, where the bracken began. His hands folded in his sleeves. He had not drawn. He was not going to. And behind him, in the dark, spread out along the edge of the bracken, the others. Daichi. Kenshiro. Ayame. Their swords out. Standing where they had been put.

Nobody moved.

The man with the plain face looked at Hanzō.

Hanzō looked back. Neither of their faces did anything at all.

Then the man looked down at Ren again.

At Ren on his back in the grass, with the blood coming out of him in seven places, and one sword in his hand that he could not lift, and his eyes open, looking up.

The man looked at him the way he had looked at him before. A thing on the road.

Then he looked at Hanzō again.

He took his sword away from Ren's throat, and turned, and walked away across the slope. The way he had walked out of the ring. He did not hurry. He did not look back. He stooped once, on the way, and picked up his scabbard out of the grass, and put his sword in it, and put it back in his sash.

The grey shapes at the edge of the ring did not move. Hanzō did not move. The three behind him did not move.

The man walked to the edge of the grass, where the pines began, and went in among them, and the dark took him.

The grey shapes went with him. Ren did not see them go. He only knew, after a while, that they were not there anymore.

Silence.

***

Ren got up.

It took him a long time. He did it anyway. He got onto his side, and then onto his knees, and found the other sword in the grass by feel, and put them both away. Then he stood.

He looked at Hanzō.

Across the slope. In the starlight. Hanzō was standing where he had been standing, with his hands in his sleeves, and he was looking at Ren.

Ren did not thank him.

He did not nod, or bow, or lift a hand. He only looked at him. Long enough to have looked. No longer.

Then he turned.

Not toward the pines, where the man with the plain face had gone. The other way. Down the slope, across the grass, toward the dark on the far side of the valley, where there was nothing, no path that he could see, only the direction.

He walked into it.

His leg would barely hold him. He walked on it anyway. He did not limp more than it made him limp. He did not favor anything. He did not look for a path. He went straight, the shortest way, across the slope and through the bracken and on, and every step was only a step, and there was nothing in any of them that did not need to be there.

Behind him he could feel them.

The three of them, at the edge of the bracken. Turning their heads. Looking at Hanzō. Waiting for him to lift a hand, or say a name, or point, the way he had pointed for them all their lives.

He knew Hanzō did not lift his hand.

He knew Hanzō did not say anything.

He knew Hanzō stood there, with his hands in his sleeves, and watched him go, and let him.

Ren did not look back.

He went down into the dark on the far side of the valley, and the dark closed behind him, and there was nothing in front of him but the next step, and the one after that.

That was all there was now.

The next step.

Chapter 74

Pressure

The sword was still against the wall.

Nobody had moved it. Takeru had come down the morning after they carried Raiden in, and seen it there, leaning upright to the right of the door at the old angle, and he had looked at Kikyo, and she had not looked back, and he had not asked. Nobody had touched it since. The men who came in with reports went around it. They did not look at it. They knelt on the mats just inside the door, a little further in than they used to, and made their reports, and went out again, and went around it.

Takeru sat in his chair with his hands on his knees and listened.

A house on the Yasu road. Empty. The men who were meant to be in it gone, no one knew where. A runner who had not come back. Another who had, with a star in his shoulder, grey iron, not theirs. Fūma. On the east side now. On the south. Moving in from the edges of the map the way water comes in over a floor, not all at once, everywhere.

Kikyo stood over the map and did not put any needles in it.

That was the thing Takeru watched. Not the reports. He had heard reports all his life. He watched her hands. They rested on the edge of the table, the way they always rested, and they did not reach for the needles. The needles lay in their neat row by the lamp, where she had laid them the night the body came in. She had not picked one up since.

She was looking at the map. She was not reading it. He had watched her read it for twenty years, and he knew the difference.

The man finished his report, and bowed, and went out around the sword.

Takeru waited.

Kikyo did not say anything. She did not tell him what the report meant, or what they would do, or where the boy was. She stood at the table in the lamplight and looked at the mountains on the map, at the place where, a long time ago, she had pressed one needle in among the painted peaks where there were no roads.

The needle was gone. She had taken it out. He did not know when.

Takeru looked at the small round hole it had left in the paper.

He did not ask.

***

The box had come to the long hall ten nights after the valley.

Daichi had carried it himself. From the house on the quiet street behind the castle, through the dark, with Hanzō walking beside him and not speaking. A box of pale plain wood, the length of a forearm, with a lid that fitted so well you could not see the line of it. It was heavier than it looked. He had not asked what was in it. He had known.

Hanzō had set it on a low stand at the far end of the hall, under the slats. And then he had set a second thing beside it, a roll in oiled cloth, tied, that had lived inside his own robe since a hillside above a burning valley last autumn.

Then he had sent them away.

Every night since. He came to the hall at dusk, and lit one lamp, and knelt on the boards in front of the stand with his back to the box, and sent them away. Not to the safehouse. Not to the field. Home. To sleep. He did it

with a look at the door, the way he had always sent them anywhere, and the first night Daichi had stood a moment longer, waiting for the reason, and there had been no reason.

They had gone. The first night, and the second. And every night Daichi had lain awake in the dark and thought about the valley, and the grass, and the man with the plain face standing over the boy with the point of his sword coming up, and Hanzō at the edge of the bracken with his hands in his sleeves. And the boy getting up. And the boy not saying anything. And the boy walking away into the dark, and Hanzō letting him.

Nothing had gone right since.

Two houses in the hills, empty when they got there. A Kōga man they had tracked for four days, dead in a ditch with a grey star in his throat before they reached him. A morning, eight days ago, when Kenshiro had come to the door of the hall at first light and found one of those grey stars standing in the post beside the door at the height of a man's eye. No message tied to it. It was the message.

Hanzō had pulled it out of the post, and looked at it, and put it in his sleeve, and said nothing.

He was saying nothing about a great many things now.

On the fourth night, Daichi did not go home.

He did not tell Hanzō. He went out of the hall when he was sent, and walked to the end of the street, and waited, and came back by the lane at the rear, and went in by the storeroom door that nobody used, and stood in the dark at the far end of the hall behind the last pillar, where the light of the one lamp did not reach.

Ayame was already there.

He saw her after a while. A shape against the wall, very still. She did not look at him. A little later, a third shape came in by the storeroom door without a sound and went to the other side of the hall, into the dark behind the pillar opposite. Kenshiro.

None of them said anything.

None of them had been told to be there. Hanzō had told them not to be. They had never in their lives been where Hanzō had told them not to be.

They stood in the dark and watched the lamp, and the man kneeling in front of it with his back to the box, and waited.

***

Hanzō knew they were there.

He had known the night Ayame first came, and every night after, and he had known when Daichi came in by the storeroom door tonight, and when Kenshiro followed. He had heard every one of them. He did not turn his head. He did not send them away again.

He knelt on the boards with the lamp beside him and his hands on his knees and his back to the box, and waited.

It was very late. The city outside was asleep. The sound of it did not come through the walls at all. There were no bars of light across the floor from the slats; there was only the dark up there under the roof, and the lamp, and the small round world of light it made on the boards around him, and nothing past it.

He had sat like this for four nights.

He did not know how many more. He had not drawn it. He had not set down a stone for it on any map. There was no plan. There was only a box on a stand, and a man in front of it, and the dark, and the door at the far end of the hall.

The door opened.

He did not hear it slide. He saw it. A line of darker dark at the far end of the hall, widening, and then not widening. And then the door was open, and there was nothing in it.

And then there was.

The boy came in.

He came the way he came everywhere now. Not fast. Not slow. Along the middle of the floor, straight, over the polished boards, where the square had turned and closed and opened in the bars of light for twenty years. The boards did not speak under him. He did not look at the pillars. He did not look at the dark behind them. He came up out of the dark into the edge of the lamplight, and stopped.

Four paces.

His swords were at his hip. He had not drawn them. His hands were at his sides. He was thinner. There was a new line across his cheek, healing, and the way he stood told Hanzō where the others were, under his clothes, the chest and the ribs and the thigh.

He looked past Hanzō at the box.

Once. The way he looked at everything. All of it, at once, and set down.

Then he looked at Hanzō.

Hanzō looked back.

For a long time. Neither of them moved. The lamp burned between them, straight up in the still air.

"You're back," said Hanzō.

The boy did not say anything.

His eyes did not move from Hanzō's. They were the eyes from the safehouse, from the edge of the map. No doorway. Only the room, and the pieces in it, and what each piece was worth.

Hanzō waited.

"You're not back."

Nothing. The boy stood in the edge of the light, very still, and looked at him.

Hanzō looked back into those eyes and let the silence go on. He let it go on as long as it wanted to. He had nowhere to be. He had knelt here for four nights for this and nothing else.

"You can't come back."

A pause.

Long. Longer than any of the others. The boy's eyes stayed on his. Something happened in them. Hanzō could not have said what. Something far down. The way ice sounds once, deep, in the spring, that nobody standing on the bank would hear.

"I can only move forward," said the boy.

Silence.

The lamp burned. Neither of them looked away.

Above them, under the roof, something moved.

Hanzō did not look up. He smelled it first. Then he saw it, at the edge of the lamplight, coming down. Smoke. White and slow and thick, coming in through the slats high up under the roof, where the light came in by day, and coming down in the same long slanting bars the light made, only white now, and soft, and filling. It came down and spread along the floor and came in around the pillars and around the edges of the light.

The boy had set it before he came in. Outside. On the roof. So that when he went, there would be somewhere to go.

Hanzō did not move.

The smoke came in around them both.

***

Daichi came out of the dark on the left.

Hanzō saw him come. Low, fast, from behind the pillar, out of the smoke, the way he had been taught, the way Hanzō had taught him. His sword was not drawn. His hands were open. He was going to take the boy the way you take a man you want alive.

The boy did not turn his head.

He moved a half step. Daichi went through where he had been, and the boy's foot came up, flat, and took him in the side, and Daichi went away across the boards into the smoke and struck the pillar and stayed down.

Ayame, from the right.

The boy went left. His shoulders went left, his head, his weight. Ayame went left to meet him. And he was not there. He had gone right, the other way, the whole feint nothing, less than nothing, a breath, and as she went past him he put his foot where hers was going to come down, and she came down on it, and went over, and the boards came up and met her.

Kenshiro, behind.

The boy did not look. He dropped. Low, turning, one leg going out flat along the boards in a long curve, and it took Kenshiro's feet out from under him at the ankles, and Kenshiro went down on his back with a sound that went all the way down the hall.

It was over.

It had taken less time than the boy's one sentence. He had not touched a hilt. He had not drawn. He had moved through the three of them the way water moves through a hand, and every one of them had gone exactly where he had already known they would go.

The three best people Hanzō had.

The boy stood up, in the smoke, in the edge of the lamplight, where he had been standing before. His breath had not changed.

Nothing in the hall could stop him now.

Hanzō knew that. He had known it before the door opened. He had known it on the threshing floor, when his eyes came to the boy in the grass a fraction late. He had not knelt here for four nights to stop him.

The box was behind Hanzō on its stand. Four paces from the boy. Nothing between them but an old man on his knees with his hands on his knees.

The boy looked at him.

Hanzō looked back.

Across the lamp. Through the smoke coming down between them in its slow white bars. The boy's face did not change. His eyes did not change. They looked at Hanzō, and Hanzō looked into them, and waited to be betrayed.

He did not look away.

Neither did the boy.

It went on a long time. The smoke thickened. The lamp flame went dim in it and then bright again. Somewhere in the dark behind the pillar Daichi was trying to get up, and could not yet, and was quiet about it.

Then the boy turned around.

He did not look at the box.

He turned his back on it, and on Hanzō, and walked away down the middle of the hall, over the polished boards, into the smoke. The smoke took him a little at a time. His shoulders. His head. The two hilts at his hip.

Then there was only the smoke.

Hanzō knelt where he was.

He heard nothing. No door. No step on the roof. After a while the smoke began to thin, going back up toward the slats the way it had come, and the hall came back out of it, pillar by pillar. Daichi, sitting up against the pillar with his hand on his side. Ayame on her knees. Kenshiro lying on his back, looking up at the roof, not moving yet.

The door at the far end of the hall was open.

Behind Hanzō, on the stand, the box was where it had been. The lid fitted so well you could not see the line of it. Beside it, the roll in oiled cloth, tied.

Nobody had touched either one.

Hanzō looked at the door.

He did not get up for a long time.

***

Ren walked along the canal in the dark.

The city was asleep on both sides of him. The water was black and slow and smelled of mud and the sea. Boats knocked against their posts, very softly, the way boats do when nothing is moving them but the water. The smoke was still in his clothes. He could smell it when he turned his head.

His hands were empty.

He looked down at them, once, walking. There was nothing in them. There was nothing in his sash, or in his coat, or against his ribs. He had gone in with nothing and he had come out with nothing.

He could have taken it.

He knew exactly how. He had known before he went in. The three in the dark, and where each of them would be, and where each of them would go. The box on the stand. Four paces. Hanzō on his knees. There had been nothing in that room that could have stopped him.

He had stood in the smoke and looked at Hanzō, and Hanzō had looked back, and waited.

Once before, someone had waited for him like that.

A room full of red light and smoke. Eight men with blades, and a spear. And at the back of the room, in front of an iron-banded door, the one person who had known he was coming, and had stood there anyway, in front of the thing he had come for, and looked at him.

He had taken it anyway. He had stopped only at the very end, with his blade at her throat, and then he had gone out through the wall with the thing he came for against his ribs.

He had not been able to take it from Hanzō.

He did not know why. He turned it over, walking, the way he turned over everything, and it did not turn. There was no reason under it. There was only Hanzō on his knees with his hands on his knees and his back to the box, looking up at him, waiting. And something in Ren, far down, that had looked back.

You can't come back.

He had not come back. He had only gone in, and stood there, and gone out again.

The canal went on. The boats knocked against their posts.

He did not know what it was that had stopped him.

He knew it would not stop him twice.

ACT VI
FIRE

Chapter 75
Incomplete

Hayate left before light.

He did not mean to be quiet about it. He had never been quiet about anything in his life. But the house was very quiet now, all the time, and you caught it the way you catch a cold, and he found himself going about the room on the balls of his feet, rolling the blanket, tying it, finding his sandals in the dark, without a sound.

His left arm was stiff. It was always stiff in the mornings. The cut had closed over the winter into a long ridge of new skin, pink and shiny, from the elbow almost to the wrist, and the arm worked. It lifted. It held. It did not do anything quickly anymore, and it did not do anything well, and he had stopped expecting it to.

He tied the last knot with his teeth.

When he turned around, Enji was sitting up in his corner.

He had his knees drawn up and his arms around them, the way he always sat now, and he was looking at Hayate across the dark room. He did not say anything. He never did.

Hayate stood with the blanket roll in his good hand and looked back at him.

He told him. Somebody had to say something, and it was always going to be Hayate. Iga. He was going to Iga. They would want the scrolls; everyone wanted the scrolls. So he would tell them they could have them. All of them. Every one. If they helped him get Ren back, before whatever was coming came, before Ren walked into the middle of it and did not walk out.

He heard himself saying it. It sounded as stupid out loud as it had sounded in his head for three nights, lying on his back looking at the dark where the roof was. It sounded worse.

The stories had come up the road all spring. A man in the hills with two swords. Houses with the fire still lit. One cut each. And then, five days ago, from a charcoal burner at the market in the village below: the one they called Raiden, the one from the corridor, dead in a notch above the shrine road with his head in the dirt beside him. Cut from both sides at once.

Hayate had gone out behind the storehouse after that, and stood there a long time.

They would probably kill him at the gate. He said that too. He said it was fair. He said he would have killed himself at the gate.

Enji did not smile. He did not do anything.

Then he unwound one arm from around his knees, and put his hand down on the boards beside him, and rolled something across the floor.

Slow. Turning. With a small dry sound, like a pebble on a step. It came across the dark room toward Hayate and slowed and stopped against his foot.

A clay ball. Plain. No cord. Nothing inside it.

Hayate looked down at it.

He knew what it was. He had set it down beside Enji himself, on the morning Ren went, on the boards, the way you set a thing down beside someone to say *I'm here.* Ren had stepped over it.

Hayate bent down and picked it up.

It fit in the middle of his palm. He could feel the flat places where Enji's fingers had rolled it.

He put it inside his coat, against his ribs.

He did not say anything. Neither did Enji. After a moment Enji put his arm back around his knees, and his head went down onto them, and Hayate slid the door open, and went out into the grey, and slid it shut behind him.

***

It was four days to Iga, the way he went.

He did not take the roads. He took the ridges and the charcoal paths and the stream beds, south, the long way around the lake and then down through the hills where Kōga used to be and was not anymore. The spring was nearly over. The rice was going into the fields in the valleys below him, men and women bent over in the water in long lines, and the frogs never stopped, day or night.

He talked to himself.

He always had. He talked to himself the way other men breathed, and now there was nobody to hear it but the trees, and he talked to them. About Iga. About what he would say at the gate. About Ren. About Shigure, once, on the second night, by a fire he had made badly with one hand, until he heard what he was saying and stopped, and did not start again for a long time.

On the fourth day, at the end of the afternoon, he came up onto the last ridge.

Below him, a long way down, was the valley. Terraced fields going down in green steps to a river. Smoke from roofs. A bridge. And at the near end of it, where the road came up out of the fields, a gate. He could see a man sitting beside it, very small.

Iga.

He stood at the top of the ridge in the long light and looked at it. He had come into this valley once before, at night, with the others, through the smoke and the fire, and gone out of it again with half of what he had come in with. He had never seen it by day. It looked like any valley. It looked like a place people lived.

He started down.

He had gone a hundred paces, into the cedars on the slope, when he knew he was not alone.

He did not hear anything. He did not see anything. It was the other way. It was that he had been hearing the frogs in the valley below the whole way down, and the wind in the tops of the cedars, and a bird somewhere to his left, and now the bird had stopped.

He stopped too.

He turned around.

A man was standing on the path behind him.

Middle height. Plain grey. A sword held low and loose in one hand, the point toward the ground. A face with nothing over it. Not old, not young. A face that was not doing anything at all.

Hayate knew him.

He had seen him once, in the fog, on the stubble below Kōga, in the autumn. He had come up out of the white last of all, not rising, simply there, directly in front of Ren. Hayate had been twenty paces off with his hands full of someone else, and he had looked across, for one breath, and seen Ren go at this man, and seen Ren's swords go through nothing.

The man in grey looked at him.

Hayate looked back.

It was him. Of course it was him.

***

He knew in the first exchange.

He went in the way he always went in. Fast, and low, and a little sideways, the way nobody expected because it made no sense, with his short blade in his good hand and a needle already sliding out of the cuff of the other. It was how he had beaten men twice his size in alleys since he was eight years old. It was how he had stayed alive.

The man in grey was not there.

He had not moved to be not there. That was the thing. Hayate had watched a great many men get out of the way of a great many things, and there was always a moment before, a little lean, a breath, a look. The body telling you, a hair before it went, where it was going.

There was nothing. The man stood, and then he stood somewhere else, and nothing in between had told anyone anything. And his sword came back from somewhere Hayate had not been watching and laid Hayate's shoulder open.

Hayate went back three steps and looked at it.

He threw the needle.

It went at the man's eye, flat, from the fingertips, almost nothing. The man's head moved a finger's width. The needle went by.

Hayate threw two more. The man was not where either of them went.

He came in again. And again. The short blade, the needles, the elbow, the knee, a handful of cedar needles off the path into the man's face. Everything he had, the way he had always done it, all at once and in no order, whatever his hands found. And every time, the man in grey was already somewhere else, and every time, his sword came back out of nowhere and took something.

The thigh. The side, low, under the ribs. The back of the good hand.

The man never hurried. He never breathed hard. He never did anything that was not the thing to be done. He was the cleanest thing Hayate had ever seen. There was nothing extra in him anywhere. No weight left behind. No breath held. No face.

It was like fighting Ren.

It was like fighting what Ren was turning into.

Hayate went down on one knee on the path. He came up again. He was bleeding from four places now and his left arm would not lift above his shoulder and his breath was going in and out of him like a bellows with a hole in it.

The man in grey stood on the path and waited for him. He had not said a word. He was not going to. Hayate, who had never in his life been in a fight without talking through it, found he had nothing to say to him either.

***

He did not remember, afterward, all of what he did.

He remembered pieces. He remembered going sideways off the path down the slope on purpose, falling, rolling, letting the hill take him, because a man cannot read where you are going when you do not know yourself. He remembered coming up in a stream bed at the bottom of a gully, soaked, with the grey man coming down the slope after him, not hurrying. He remembered throwing a sandal. He did not know why he threw the sandal. He had nothing else in that hand. It went past the man's head and into a fern and the man's eyes did not follow it.

He remembered laughing.

Not because anything was funny. Because it came up out of him, the way it always had, in the worst places, and he let it. He stood in the stream bed with the water around his ankles and the blood going down his side into it and laughed, and thought about the sandal, about how he had liked that sandal, and he came in again, badly, off the wrong foot, with his bad arm leading, the stupidest way there was to come in.

And the man in grey was a hair late.

Only a hair. Hayate almost did not see it. The sword came to where Hayate should have been if Hayate had been doing anything sensible, and Hayate was not, and the edge went past his ribs close enough to cut the cloth and nothing else, and Hayate's short blade went across the man's forearm.

A thin line. Red.

The man stepped back.

He looked at his arm. Then at Hayate.

Something had changed in his face. Hayate could not have said what. Nothing had moved. But the man was looking at him now the way you look at a thing you had thought you understood, and have just found you had put down in the wrong place.

For the first time since the path, he waited.

Hayate did not. He came again.

And again, it was a hair. The man in grey did not read him. Could not. There was nothing to read. Hayate did not know what he was going to do until his body was already doing it, and half the time what his body did was stupid, and the man in grey could not see stupid coming, because the man in grey had never done anything stupid in his life. He had taken it all out of himself a long time ago. Every wrong step. Every wasted breath. Every sandal thrown for no reason. There was nothing left in him that could guess at a man who still had all of it.

And he was still better.

Hayate knew that. Even with the hair, even with the thin red line on his forearm. The man was still better, cleaner, faster, and he was not tired and Hayate was bleeding out into a stream, and the hair was not going to be enough, not by itself.

He put his hand inside his coat.

The clay ball was there. Against his ribs. Warm from him.

He took it out and threw it.

Not hard. The way Enji threw them. A long low arc, turning, through the green light in the gully. Straight at the ground at the man's feet.

The man in grey moved.

Everything in him moved. For the first time since the path, Hayate saw him go the whole way, all at once, a long flat leap to the side and back, out of the gully, up onto the bank, his free arm coming up across his face. Because he knew what a clay ball was. Everyone did now. Everyone knew what had happened to Iga's wall, and to the notch above the shrine road, and to Raiden's leg.

The ball hit the stones in the stream bed.

It broke in two. The halves rolled a little way in the shallow water, and stopped. Plain clay. Nothing inside it.

The man in grey looked at it from the bank.

Hayate was already there.

He had gone the moment it left his hand, because he knew what it was and the man did not, and he came up the bank on the man's blind side, low, with the short blade, and put it into the man's leg above the knee, and pulled it out, and went on past before the sword could come around.

The man went down on one knee on the bank.

Hayate went down too. On the other side of the gully, on his hands, in the ferns. He could not help it. His legs had stopped.

He knelt there breathing.

There was something wrong with his hand.

***

It had started in the good hand. The back of it, where the man's sword had gone across, a long time ago on the path at the top of the hill. It had been cold there for a while, and he had thought it was the cut. Now it was not cold. It was not anything. He could see his fingers in the ferns and he could not feel them.

It was going up his arm.

He knew what it was. He had grown up in the alleys; he knew what it was when a man's hand went dead from a scratch. Something on the edge. Something from the mountains, that the grey ones put on their blades, that went up the arm and into the chest and stopped a man's heart from the inside, slowly, while he sat there and knew it.

His chest was already going tight.

He looked across the gully.

The man in grey was standing up. His leg was bleeding, badly. He stood on it anyway. He looked across at Hayate on his hands in the ferns, and Hayate saw him see it. The hand. The way Hayate was breathing. The color of his face, whatever it was now.

The man knew what was on his blade. He knew exactly how long it took.

He did not come across.

Why would he. Hayate could see him think it, or not think it, only know it, the way he knew everything. There was no need. A man walking across a gully to finish something that was already finishing itself was a wasted step, and he had not wasted a step in his life.

Hayate's arms gave. He went down onto his face in the ferns.

He lay there.

His heart was doing something strange. Fast, and then slow, and then fast. His chest would not open all the way. He could hear the stream, very loud, and under it, far off, the frogs in the valley, and the blood in his ears.

He could hear the man in grey.

Coming down the bank. Across the stream. Not hurrying. Up the near bank. Into the ferns. Standing over him.

Hayate did not move.

He lay on his face with his eyes half open and the ferns in front of them and did not move. His body was shaking. It was shaking on its own and he let it. He let it shake the way the poison wanted it to, all the way, and then, slowly, he let it stop.

He let everything stop.

He did not breathe.

A sandal came and pushed at his shoulder. It turned him a little, onto his side. His face came around toward the sky, through the ferns, the eyes half open, looking at nothing. His mouth open. He kept it open. He did not breathe.

The man in grey looked down at him.

Hayate could see him, at the edge of his eyes, without looking. A shape against the green light. Standing. Looking.

Then the shape turned.

It turned away, the way a man turns away from a thing that is over. It started back down through the ferns toward the stream. One step. Two. On the bad leg, carefully.

It did not look back.

Why would it. It had never needed to look back at anything.

Hayate got up.

He did not know how. He did not have anything left to get up with. He got up anyway, all at once, out of the ferns, the way he had done everything his whole life, badly, without deciding, with his dead hand hanging and his

chest locked and his heart going like a bird against a shutter. His good hand had the short blade in it. It was the other hand that was good now. He did not remember changing.

He took two steps down the bank.

The man in grey heard him. He started to turn.

He was a hair late.

Hayate drove the blade into the back of his head, at the base, where the skull meets the neck, all the way, with everything he had left behind it.

The man in grey stopped.

He stood a moment on the bank with the stream going by below him. Then he went down, forward, onto his knees, and then onto his face in the ferns, where Hayate had been lying, and did not move again.

Hayate stood over him.

He was swaying. The trees were swaying. He looked down at the grey back, and the hilt standing up out of the neck above it, and his own hand still on the hilt.

"I won," said Hayate.

***

He did not remember going down the rest of the hill.

He remembered pieces. The stream, and walking in it, because it went down. The light going. Falling, and getting up. Falling. The edge of the cedars, and then no cedars, and then the terraced fields opening out below him, green, going down in steps, with the water standing in them and the last of the light lying on the water.

The frogs, very loud.

He went down one step of the terraces, and then another, sliding on the wet bank, and at the third he did not get up.

He lay on his back on the bank between two flooded fields and looked up.

The sky was going from gold to grey. There was a bird up there, very high, going somewhere. His chest would not open. His heart was doing the bird thing again, against the shutter, and then not doing it for a while, and then doing it again.

He put his good hand inside his coat, against his ribs, where the clay ball had been.

It was not there. He had thrown it. He left his hand there anyway.

Voices.

Somewhere below him, along the edge of the fields. Two, three. A shout. Someone running along the bank, the sound of sandals slapping on wet earth. He could not turn his head.

A face came over him, against the grey sky.

He did not know it. Young. A boy, or nearly not a boy anymore. Staring down at him with his mouth open. Then turning his head and shouting something, to someone, back along the bank toward the gate. Hayate heard the word *Iga* in it somewhere. Or he did not. He could not tell anymore what he heard.

Hayate tried to say something to it. Nothing came.

The face went away. Other faces came.

He looked up past them at the sky.

He thought about Enji, sitting in his corner with his knees up. He thought about the clay ball, broken in two in the stream at the top of the hill, the halves rolling a little way in the shallow water. He thought: *the one with nothing in it.* He thought: *that one saved me.* He thought he would tell Enji that. He thought Enji would not say anything, and would not smile, and would look at him for a long time, and that would be the same as smiling.

He thought about Ren.

Then the sky went, and the faces, and the frogs, and there was nothing.

Chapter 76

Movement

The table was hard, and smelled of vinegar.

That was the first thing. Before the light, before the pain, before he knew whether he was alive or only dreaming he was. Vinegar, and something bitter boiling somewhere, and roots. And under his back, hard wood, scrubbed.

Hayate opened his eyes.

A low ceiling. A lamp. A wall of small wooden drawers along one side, dozens of them, each with a paper label. A thin man with long careful hands bent over his arm, doing something to it that Hayate could see but, for a moment, not feel. Then feel. He shut his teeth on it.

The thin man did not look up. He went on with what he was doing, slowly, the way a man mends a net.

Hayate turned his head.

There was someone in the doorway.

The lamp was behind her, in the room, and the dark was behind her, outside, and she stood between them with the light on one side of her face. A woman. Straight. Still. A long spear upright in her hand, the butt on the boards, the head in its black lacquer sheath going up past the lintel, so that she had to hold it a little tipped.

He knew her.

He knew her the way you know a thing that has hit you. A room full of red light. A turn, a whole body coming around, and a foot out of the end of the turn, and the boards coming up. He had been fast that night. He had been as fast as he had ever been in his life, and he had gone in under her guard from an angle nobody could have expected, and she had not been there, and then he had been on the floor looking at her sandals.

"You," said Hayate.

He tried to laugh. It came up out of him the way it always did. It did not get far. Something in his chest caught it and turned it into something else, and he lay there with his eyes shut until it went away.

When he opened them she had not moved.

She was looking at him. Not the way she had looked at him in that room. Not the way anyone had ever looked at him. The way you look at a thing that has been carried in off the fields at dusk and laid on a table, and you do not know yet what it is.

His heart was doing the bird thing again. Slower now. The thin man had given him something, a long time ago, bitter, that had gone down and sat in him like cold water. The hand was still dead. The arm up to the elbow was dead. But his chest opened, most of the way, and he could breathe through it, and he could think.

He thought: *this is the only time I'll get.*

"Help me bring him back," said Hayate.

His voice was not much. He made it go as far as it would.

"Stop what's coming. You get the scrolls." He breathed. "All of them."

The thin man's hands stopped, for a moment, on his arm. Then went on.

The woman in the doorway did not move. The lamp moved on the side of her face. The spear stood upright in her hand, still, the black sheath catching the light.

"He killed my father," said the woman.

Hayate looked at her.

He had been there. He had been on the floor of that room with the red light on the ceiling and a man with a spear coming out of the smoke. He had heard the sound the spear made, going down. He had not seen the rest. He had not needed to.

"I know," said Hayate.

Silence.

Outside, the frogs. The stream going by under the bridge. Somewhere in the house, a pot ticking on a fire.

Hayate lay on the table and looked at her, and she looked back, and neither of them said anything for a long time. His heart went slow, and fast, and slow.

He had been on the floor. He had been lying on the boards with his sword gone and the room going around, and he had turned his head, and seen it. Ren, in the smoke. Ren's blade at her throat. The whole of Ren going forward behind it, the way Ren went forward behind everything.

And stopping.

"He spared you," said Hayate.

She did not answer.

Her face did not change. She stood in the doorway a moment longer with the light on one side of her and the dark on the other and the spear upright in her hand.

Then she turned, and went out into the dark, and the doorway was empty.

Hayate looked at it.

The thin man tied off the cloth on his arm, and laid the arm down across Hayate's chest, carefully, the way you put down a thing that belongs to someone else. Then he went to his wall of drawers and began pulling them out, one and then another, not hurrying.

***

In the morning Takeda sent them out.

He did it from his study, at his low desk, with the brushes laid in their row and the map open on the boards beside him. It was not a large map. It showed the valley, and the hills around it, and the roads out of it in every direction, and a good deal of paper beyond the roads where nothing was drawn at all.

He had sent men after the ronin before. Last summer, and in the autumn, and all through the winter, when Riku had asked, and asked again. Good men. They had gone out looking for tracks, the way men were taught to look, and they had come back with nothing. There were never tracks. There were only places where tracks should have been.

He did not send them for tracks.

He sent them for endings.

Wherever something had ended, he told them. A house where the fire was still lit and nobody left to tend it. A camp gone quiet. A road where men had stopped using it and nobody knew why. A place where the crows were. Go there. Do not follow. Do not look for him. Look for what he leaves. Find where things stop, and come back and tell me where.

They went out in the grey, in twos, by every road.

When they were gone he sat a long time with the map.

It was the only way he could think to find a man who did not go anywhere. You could not follow him. You could only stand where he had been and look at what was left, and put a mark there, and another, and wait for the marks to become a line.

He did not know yet where the line would go.

He picked up his brush.

At the edge of the valley on the map, at the foot of the terraces below the gate, he made a small mark. The place where they had found the Karasu's loud one, three nights ago, face up between two fields with his heart going like a bird.

Something had ended on that ridge, too.

***

Kikyo gave one order.

She gave it standing at the table, in the lamplight, with the map in front of her and the needles still lying in their row where she had laid them, and Raiden's sword still leaning against the wall to the right of the door. She did not look at the sword. Takeru was in his chair. Six of them knelt on the mats inside the door, the last six she had who could still carry an order to every man Kōga had left.

She looked at the map a long time before she spoke.

Everything on it had become something the boy could read. Every house they kept. Every road they used. Every place they had stood twice. He had read them the way she had once read him, one needle at a time, until the needles made a line, and then he had walked down the line.

There would be no more lines.

"No camps," said Kikyo. "No fixed paths. No place used twice."

The six bowed. They went out, around the sword.

By the next night there was no Kōga.

Not in any house on the map. Not on any road. Men who had slept under the same roof for ten years slept in ditches, in ones and twos, and moved before light, and did not tell each other where. Runners went by paths that had never been paths. Nobody stopped anywhere long enough for it to be a place.

It went out of the hills the way smoke goes out of a room when a door is opened. Not all at once. Everywhere. Thinning. Until you could not have said where it had been, or where it was.

Kikyo stood over the map, with nothing on it to mark.

***

Hanzō stood on the bridge at Seta and watched them go by.

It had been raining since dawn. A fine, grey, early summer rain, the first of the long rains, that did not fall so much as hang in the air and settle on everything. It lay on the river under the bridge and on the long grey back of the lake beyond it, and it beaded on the lacquer of the helmets and ran in small streams off the edges of the straw rain capes and darkened the banners until they hung heavy on their poles.

Banners.

They came over the bridge in a line that had no end he could see. Foot soldiers four abreast, in step, their spears all at the same angle against the grey sky. Then bowmen. Then a gap, exactly measured. Then men with matchlocks, the long barrels wrapped in oiled cloth against the wet, the slow match coiled at their belts and kept dry under their capes. Then pack horses, loaded and roped, a man at every bridle. Rice. Powder. Arrows in bundles. Then another gap. Then more foot.

Officers on horseback rode up and down the line, not shouting. There was no need. Every man was where he had been put.

Every crossing on the roads east of here had a post on it now. Every bridge. Every ford. Men with papers, and a table under a roof, and a register, and a pole across the road that went up for anyone with the right seal and did not go up for anyone without one. The roads into the hills had been counted and cut into lengths, and each length had been given to someone, and each someone had been given a number of men, and a number of days.

Slow. Heavy. Correct.

It was the most correct thing Hanzō had ever watched. It was his own square, grown to the size of a country. Every foot where it had been drawn. It would go where it was drawn, and nowhere else, and it would get there, and when it got there it would close, and nothing inside it would get out.

He had believed in it all his life.

He stood on the bridge in the rain with his hands in his sleeves and watched it go past, and thought about a boy walking off the fifth mark into the grass. Nowhere. Facing nothing.

He thought about how long it would take this line to turn around, if what it was looking for were behind it.

The banners went on over the bridge, east, into the hills, dark with rain, one after another, all at the same angle.

***

The outpost had been Fūma.

It was not anything now. A clearing on a spur above a river, with a lookout's platform of lashed poles at the edge of it, and three shelters, and a fire pit. The shelters had burned in the night. The platform had burned too, and fallen, and lay across the edge of the clearing in black pieces. The rain had put out what was left. It was still smoking a little, here and there, in the wet. Grey threads going up and bending over in the air.

There were men in the grey ash. Ren did not look at them. He had already looked at them.

He stood at the edge of the clearing, where the ground fell away to the river, with the rain on his face.

He looked east.

The hills went away that way, ridge behind ridge, going grey and then paler grey in the rain until they were only shapes. He could not see anything on them. He could feel it. Something coming. A great many feet, all in step. A weight. A long, heavy, slow thing, moving the way a river moves in flood, not fast, not anywhere in particular, only everywhere at once, filling.

He looked north.

Something else there. Smaller. Scattered. A lot of small things, moving fast in no direction, never twice the same way. Coming apart. And behind them, somewhere, grey. The grey ones. Not coming apart. Waiting at the edges of everything, the way they always waited, for the place where the shape was not.

And from the west, behind him, from the valley with the terraces and the gate, something slow and careful and quiet, going from place to place. Stopping wherever something had stopped.

And from further west, one man, alone, with his hands in his sleeves.

Everything was moving.

He could feel all of it. From every side. Not toward him. Not exactly. Toward something. Toward somewhere. The way water on a floor finds the low place without anyone telling it where the low place is.

It was getting closer.

He stood at the edge of the burned clearing in the rain and let it get closer. He did not go toward it. He did not go away from it. He only stood, and felt it, the whole shape of it, drawing in.

Behind him, in the ash, one of the grey threads of smoke went up and bent over in the rain and went out.

***

In Takeda's study, a line of small brush marks was going east across the map, from the terraces below the gate, into the hills.

In the room with the brazier in Kōga, nothing new had been marked. There was only a small round hole in the paper where a needle had been, among the painted mountains, where there were no roads. The last runner in from the hills had knelt inside the door and said where he had slept the night before. Kikyo's eyes had gone to the map, to where that was, and stayed there.

In a room in the shogun's castle in the capital, an officer of the shogun's deputy stood over a table with a brush in his hand and moved a column of small wooden markers one day's march further along a road, into the hills, where the road bent south around a shoulder of mountain toward a river.

In a room above the bridge at Seta, Hanzō knelt in front of a map with a single stone in his hand and did not set it down.

Four rooms. Four maps. Nobody had drawn the same thing.

And on every one of them, if you had laid them side by side, the pieces were drifting toward the same place. The same fold of the hills. The same valley, where the road bent south around a shoulder of mountain toward a river.

Nobody had put them there.

Nobody had meant to.

Chapter 77

The Fire

The rains had stopped for three days, and the bamboo had dried.

Enji worked.

The storehouse was dim and warm and smelled of what it always smelled of. Sulfur. Charcoal. The sour green smell of saltpeter drying on its trays. Oil, and paper, and clay. The door stood open a hand's width for the light, and the light came in and lay across the floor and across the bench, and dust went up and down in it, slowly, and he did not mind the dust.

On the bench in front of him there were things.

Clay balls, a row of them, the size of a plum, drying. Shells, sealed with wax. A coil of cord, slow-burning, and another coil, fast. Jars with their mouths stopped. Paper, folded, and paper not folded yet. A tray of fine black powder that he was working with the flat of a bamboo spatula, turning it, turning it, the way you turn rice to dry it.

He had been working since before light.

He did not know why today. He did not know why any day. The house had been quiet since Hayate went, and it had been quiet before that too, since Ren, and before that since Kurogane, and before that since the morning they walked out of the snow without Shigure. Every one of them had taken some of the sound with him. Now there was none left. There was only the stream in the bamboo, and the birds, and the small dry sound of the spatula on the tray.

He did not mind that either.

That was the strange thing. He noticed it the way he noticed everything, sideways, without meaning to. He was not afraid. He was not anything. His hands were doing the work and they were steady and they knew what they were doing, and for once there was nothing in his head that did not belong there. No noise. No red. No smoke that was not the smoke he was making.

He was calm.

He did not remember the last time.

He folded a paper. He filled it. He twisted the end and laid it with the others. He took up the spatula again, and turned the powder on the tray, and turned it.

And stopped.

He did not know why. His hand stopped, and then he did, and then he lifted his eyes.

Above the bench, on the shelf on the wall.

The figures.

He had carried them back out from the house when the others were gone. Out of the main room, off the shelf over the hearth, where nobody was left to look at them. He had set them back where they had started, above the bench, in a row, where he could see them when he looked up.

Hayate, with his mouth open.

Shigure, sitting very straight.

Kurogane, with his arms folded.

Ren, standing, his head a little down, looking at something on the ground in front of him that was not there.

And at the end of the row, the new one.

Small. Pale, still, from the pit; he had fired it three nights ago, alone, at night, long after there was anyone left in the house to be asleep, and it had come out whole. A figure sitting with its knees drawn up and its arms around them. Its face was only three strokes of a stick. It was looking at the others.

He had never made one of himself. Not in all the time he had been making them. He had made the others one at a time, the way you learn a face, and there had never been one of him, and nobody had ever asked, and he had never known why.

Then, three nights ago, he had.

He looked at the five of them in the dust and the light from the door.

The powder lay on the tray under his still hand.

He did not think anything. He only looked.

Outside, very close, the bamboo went up.

***

Not one. A great many. One and then three and then more than he could count, cracking and thudding and booming one into the next all around the house, through the grove, down the slope, along the path, the ground under the storehouse jumping with each one so that the jars on the bench walked a little toward the edge and the clay balls rolled against each other. The dust came down off the rafters in a sheet. The light in the door went orange, and then white, and then orange again.

Enji sat at the bench and listened.

He knew every one of them. He could have told you, by the sound, which was which. The jar under the stepping stone at the bend in the path. The three in the bamboo on the east side, strung on one cord so that the first one pulled the second and the second pulled the third. The paper ones in the eaves of the gate, that went up when the gate moved. The one buried under the wisteria. The ones along the stream.

He had been putting them there all spring. One a night, some nights. Two. Whenever his hands needed something to do, and there was nothing yet for them to make. He had not put them there for anything. He had put them there because the ground was there, and he was there, and the powder was there.

The booming went on.

It went on longer than it should have, if it had been only a few of them coming. It went around the house, all the way around, from every side at once. From the bamboo and the stream and the path and the slope behind the kiln. They had come from everywhere. The way the grey ones came.

Then it stopped.

In the quiet after it he could hear the fire.

Enji stood up.

He did not hurry. He pushed the fox mask up onto his head. He took the satchels off their pegs, one and then another, and hung them across himself. Canvas, heavy, with the flaps tied down. He filled his sash. Clay balls, the ones that were dry. A coil of the fast cord. The slow match, already smoldering, from the pot by the door, wound around his left wrist with the lit end out. The pouch at his sash. Deerskin, dark, soft with oil, with the loops sewn inside it in a row, the narrow ones and the wide ones, where he kept his needles and his fuses now. He put his hand on it. It was there.

He looked up once more at the shelf.

Then he went out.

***

The grove was burning.

The bamboo went up the way bamboo does, all at once, from the inside, each stem bursting with a crack like a thrown stone as the heat got into the hollows. Smoke, white and then yellow and then black, rolling up through the tops of the canes and out over the yard. The wisteria over the gate was burning, the old dry wood of it going up in a sheet, the flowers long gone. The fence was burning. Down the slope the stream was steaming where the fire leaned over it.

And there were men in it.

Grey. Everywhere. On the path, and in the grove, and along the stream, and against the fence. Some whole. Most not. Lying the way men lie when they have been walking carefully, very carefully, the way they were taught, putting each foot down where it looked safest, and the place where it looked safest was where he had put the jar. Twenty. More. Thirty, perhaps, when he counted the ones in the bamboo, which he did not.

None of them moved.

Enji stood in the middle of the yard with the smoke going over him and looked at them.

He did not feel anything about it. That was not new. That was the way it had always been with the things he made. They did what they were for.

At the edge of the burning grove, where the path came up out of the bamboo, one man was standing.

He was standing very still, in the heat, in the smoke, with the fire behind him. Tall. Grey. His face uncovered. A sword in his hand, low. There was ash on his shoulders, and one sleeve was burned through, and he did not seem to notice it. He was looking at Enji across the yard.

He was the only one left standing.

He had come up the path. Every other one of them had come up some other way, and every other one of them was lying in the grove. This one had come up the one way that did not have anything under it. Enji knew that path. He had left it. He had not known why.

He knew now.

The tall man looked at him, and at the satchels, and at the smoke going up off the slow match on his wrist.

Then he came across the yard.

***

The yard lied.

That was the first thing. Enji threw, from the hip, a clay ball in a long low arc, at the place where the man was, and the man was not there. He was a pace to the left. He had always been a pace to the left. Enji's eyes had told him where the man was, and his eyes had been wrong, and the ball went off in the empty place and the man came on through the smoke of it, closer than he should have been, and his sword went across Enji's arm.

Enji went back.

He threw again. Not at the man. At the ground between them. The ball went up with a sound like a door slammed in a stone room and the earth came up with it, and the man went back from the earth, and Enji was already going the other way, around the side of the storehouse, fast, low, with his hands in the satchels.

It went on.

Enji did not fight him. He did not know how to fight a man like that. Nobody had ever taught him to fight anybody. He knew how to make the place a fight happened in stop being a place. He did that. He threw at the ground, and the ground went. He threw at the fence, and the fence came down burning across the path. He went past the kiln pit and dropped a fast cord into it, and the pit went up behind him and the man had to go around.

The man went around.

He always went around. Wherever Enji broke the ground, the man was already on the other side of the break. Wherever Enji threw, the man was a pace from where he looked. He did not hurry. He did not try to catch Enji. He only came, a little closer each time, from a little further around, and every time he came Enji had a little less yard to go to.

The fire was everywhere now.

The storehouse was burning. The main house was burning. The roof of the main house was burning in long sheets, the thatch going up in a roar, and the heat came off it in a wall that Enji could feel on his face from across the yard. The bamboo around them had become a ring of fire, cracking, bursting, going up and falling in, and the smoke was so thick he could not see the sky.

He liked it. He had always liked it. He did not know why, and he had never tried to know.

The man came through it with the fire on him and did not seem to feel it.

Enji reached into the last of the first satchel and his hand came out empty.

The man was there.

The sword went across his chest. Enji went back. It went across his thigh, and his leg went, and he went down on one knee in the burning yard, and he threw from his knee, and the man was a pace from where he threw it, and the sword came again, and Enji went over onto his back in the hot ash with the sky black above him and full of sparks, going up.

He lay there.

He could not get up. Something in his chest was broken and his leg would not do anything and his hands were very slow. The satchel on his left side was under him. He had fallen on it. He had fallen on it on purpose, he thought, though he could not remember deciding. The slow match was still on his wrist. He had touched the end of it to the cord of the satchel as he went down. He thought he had. He could not feel his hand.

He closed his eyes.

***

He heard the man come.

Across the ash. Slowly. Not a pace to the left now. Not anywhere but where he was. There was no more need.

The steps stopped.

Enji could feel him there, above, the way you feel a cloud come over the sun. He could smell him. Smoke, and burnt cloth, and burnt hair, and blood. The man was hurt. Enji had not seen it, but he could smell it. The man had come through the fire and the fire had taken some of him.

The blade came down to rest above his head. He felt the air move.

"No more Kuroi Karasu," said the man.

Quietly. The way you say the name of a thing you have finished.

And there it was.

Not the yard. Not the smoke. A fire, small, on open ground, a long time ago, early on. Night. The five of them around it. Hayate talking, telling some story badly, his hands going, getting the end wrong and having to go back. Kurogane with his arms folded, not laughing, and something at the corner of his mouth. Shigure, sitting very straight, turning a stone over in his fingers. Ren, next to Hayate, the firelight on one side of his face, listening to every word.

And Enji, with a clay ball in his hand.

Rolling it across the ground. Slow. Turning. With a small dry sound like a pebble on a step. Along the ground to where Hayate sat. And it stopped by Hayate's knee, and Hayate looked down at it in the middle of his story, and picked it up, carefully, and looked at it. And set it down beside him. And went on talking.

Nobody had said anything about it.

There had been nothing that needed to be said.

Enji opened his eyes.

The man was above him, against the black sky and the sparks, burnt, bleeding, with the sword in his hand pointing down. His face was not doing anything. It was very close.

Enji grinned.

He felt it go across his face, through the blood and the ash. He had not grinned in a long time. It felt the way it had always felt. Like something coming loose.

"Too close and you die," said Enji.

His hand came up off the ash, slow, but not too slow, and closed on the man's ankle.

The man looked down at it.

Under Enji's back, the cord ran out.

The yard went white.

***

Nothing moved.

The house was gone. The storehouse was gone. The grove was gone, down to black stumps standing in grey ash, smoking a little in the still air. The fence was a line of charcoal. The gate was two black posts, and the wisteria that had grown over it was nothing at all.

In the middle of the yard there was a hollow in the earth, black, and round, and shallow, and nothing in it.

Nothing moved in any of it.

At the edge of the hollow, in the ash, lay a pouch.

Deerskin. Dark. Scorched along one edge. The flap had come untied, and lay open, and you could see the loops sewn inside it in a row, the narrow ones and the wide ones, empty.

A long way off, over the hills, crows were calling. Thin, and broken, and far. Coming closer.

Chapter 78

Closer

They left Iga by the east road, before the sun.

Aoi carried the spear across her back on a strap, the way her father had carried it on long roads, the head in its black sheath riding up over her left shoulder. It was heavy. It was always heavy. She had stopped noticing, the way you stop noticing your own arm.

Hayate walked beside her.

He was not supposed to be walking. Shin had said so, in as many words as Shin ever used, which was four. Hayate had thanked him, and eaten everything in the bowl, and got up off the table the next morning and followed her out of the gate. His right hand was bound and hung in a sling of cloth across his chest. The fingers had come back, a little, in the last days; he could move two of them. The rest of him was grey under the brown, and thinner, and he stopped on the steep places to breathe, and pretended he was stopping to look at the view.

He talked.

He talked the whole of the first morning. About the road. About the rain that was coming, and the rain that had been. About a man he had known once in Nara who could tell the weather by his knee. About Iga, and how it was not at all what he had expected, and how he had expected it to be full of people trying to kill him, and it had been, but they had also given him soup. He did not seem to need her to answer. She did not.

She had the marks in her head.

Takeda's men had come back in twos, over eight days, and knelt in his study, and told him where. A spur above a river. A farmhouse in a fold of the hills. A camp in a pine wood. A ford. Every place where something had ended. And Takeda had put a small brush mark on his map at every one, and the marks had made a line, going east and a little north into the hills, and the line had not stopped.

She had stood in the doorway of the study and looked at it.

Then she had gone home and taken the spear down off the pegs.

***

The first was the outpost on the spur.

It had been Fūma. The poles of the lookout's platform lay across the edge of the clearing, black, where they had fallen. The shelters were three flat squares of charcoal. The rain had come since, and gone, and beaten the ash down into a grey crust over everything, and the smell of it was still there under the wet.

The dead were where they had fallen. Nobody had come for them.

Aoi knelt.

She did what she had been taught to do, on the training ground, from the time she was small enough to be lifted onto her father's shoulders to watch. She did not look at the faces. She looked at the cuts.

One each. Every man. She went from one to the next, kneeling, and looked at where the blade had gone in and where it had come out, and the angle of it, and which way the man had been facing when it came. The spacing between them. The order. She could see it the way her father had taught her to see a fight in the marks it left on the ground: where the man who made them had stood, and where he had gone next, and how many steps between.

She knew it.

She had watched it. At dawn, on the training ground by the stream, in the grey before anyone came. A young man with two swords, going through the same shapes over and over, every step landing in the print of the one before. The way the left answered the right. The way the stance sat low and still and everything happened from it.

It was here. In the ash. In the way each of these men had been turned, and met, and finished.

But it was not the same.

On the training ground there had been something in it she had never been able to name. Something left over. A breath held a moment too long at the end of a form. A step that went a little further than it needed to, as if he were enjoying the ground under his feet. She had spent a summer learning where he would be, and she had learned it by those small left-over things.

There was nothing left over here.

Every cut was the shortest way. Every step was the only step. There was nothing extra anywhere, nothing that was not the thing to be done, and nothing that was kind. It was the same shape, cut down to the bone and past it.

She stood up.

Hayate had not come into the clearing. He was standing at the edge of it, where the path came up, with his good hand on a tree. He was not talking.

She went around the clearing once more.

At the far edge of it, where the spur fell away toward the river, under a pine that the fire had not reached, there was a small ring of stones.

She stopped.

A fire had been made there. Not one of the shelters' fires. Not the Fūma's pit, which was in the middle of the clearing and full of rain. This was apart. A small ring, the stones set close and even. The ash in it was grey and fine and had been rained on. The ends of the wood were still there at the edges, where the fire had not reached them. Long pieces, laid first, crossed. Then the short ones. Made properly. The way her father had made a fire, on the long roads, when he had time to make it right.

It had been left to burn out.

She looked at it for a long time.

***

The second was a farmhouse.

It had been Kōga's, for one night. Nobody used a place twice now; the whole valley knew that. Three of them had slept in the loft, and in the morning they had not come down. Takeda's men had found them where they lay.

Aoi went up the ladder and looked. She came down again.

The same. One each. Nothing left over.

Outside, at the edge of the yard, by the wall of the woodshed, a ring of stones.

Long pieces first. Crossed. Burned all the way down, and left.

***

The third was a camp in a pine wood, on a slope above a stream.

It had been Fūma, and it had been a good place, dry, with the spring coming out of the rock and the pines close enough together that you could not see a fire from the valley. There had been eight of them. The pine needles were dark where they had fallen.

Aoi did not kneel this time. She walked through it once, and looked, and did not need to look long.

At the edge of the wood, below the spring, on a flat rock, there was a ring of stones.

She crouched by it.

The ash was grey. Fine. It had not been rained on. There had been no rain since yesterday. The long pieces, crossed, were white at the ends where the fire had eaten them down, and one of them, near the middle, still had a black core.

She put out her hand. She laid her fingers flat in the ash.

Warm.

Not hot. Not anything that would burn. The warmth of a stone that has been in the sun, and the sun has gone in. The warmth of a place where someone has been sitting, a little while after they get up.

She stayed like that, with her hand in the ash.

Behind her, Hayate had come down into the wood. He was breathing hard from the slope. She heard him stop.

He was looking at the ring of stones. She could feel him looking at it. At the long pieces crossed. He had gone quiet again, the way he had gone quiet at the first one, standing at the edge of the clearing with his hand on the tree. She did not ask him why. She thought she knew.

She took her hand out of the ash, and stood up.

"What is it?" said Hayate.

She looked down the slope, through the pines, the way the stream went. East. And a little north.

"He was here this morning."

***

The fourth was a ford.

A river, wide and brown with the rain, going over stones. A road came down to it on the near side and went up out of it on the far side into the hills. There were men in the shallows. Four. Kōga, by the dark blue, or Fūma, by the grey. It did not matter. They were lying in the water, and the water was going over them.

Aoi did not stop.

She did not go down to them. She did not kneel on the bank and look at the cuts. She knew what the cuts would be. She had known on the spur, and in the loft, and in the pine wood. She had understood him. She had understood him for a whole summer, on a training ground by a stream, better than anyone in Iga had ever understood anyone, well enough to know where he would be before he was there.

It had not saved anybody.

It had not saved her father. It had not saved Riku. It had not kept a blade from her own throat, in the smoke. It had only let her see it coming.

She was done understanding him.

She went past the dead in the water and across the ford, with the river cold around her knees and the spear riding heavy on her back, and up the road on the far side, and at the top of the bank she stopped and looked at the ground.

There. A heel, in the soft earth at the edge of the road, where the grass began. One. Then nothing. Then, further on, a bent stem.

It did not matter. She did not need them. She knew the direction. East, and a little north. She went that way.

Behind her, Hayate came up out of the river, slowly, holding his bad arm against him. He stood at the top of the bank with the water running out of his clothes, and watched her go.

She heard him come after her. It took him a while to catch up.

When he did, he walked beside her for a time without saying anything. That was new. She had not known he could.

"You're not trying to find him," said Hayate.

"No."

He walked. He was looking at her, sideways.

"You're trying to catch him."

She did not answer.

She put her hand up to the strap across her chest, where the spear hung, and pulled it tighter. One notch. Until the shaft sat hard against her back, and did not move when she walked.

***

That night they stopped in a hollow under an overhang of rock, out of the wind, with a stream going by below.

It was cold, for the season. The rain had cleared and the sky had opened up over the hills, deep and full of stars, and the cold came down out of it the way it does on a clear night in the mountains. Hayate sat against the rock with his knees drawn up and his bad arm against his chest and shivered, and did not complain about it, which was also new.

There was wood. Dry, under the overhang, where the rain had not reached. There was a place for a fire, flat and sheltered, where it would not be seen from the valley.

Aoi did not make one.

She sat at the mouth of the hollow with the spear across her knees and looked out at the dark, east, and a little north.

Hayate looked at the wood. He looked at the flat place. He looked at her.

He did not say anything.

She did not say why.

After a while he pulled his coat tighter around himself and put his head back against the rock and closed his eyes. She heard his breathing slow. She heard it catch, once, on something in his chest, and go on.

She stayed where she was.

Somewhere out there in the dark, east, and a little north, a long way off or not very far, there would be a ring of stones. Long pieces laid first, crossed. Made properly.

She did not know if he had made it yet tonight. She did not know if he made them at night, or only in the mornings.

She sat with the cold coming down on her, and the spear across her knees, and did not make a fire.

Chapter 79

The Boy

On the third morning Hayate turned off the road.

He did not say anything first. He had been thinking about it since the ford, since the night with no fire, since before that, lying on the table in the doctor's back room with his heart going like a bird and the woman with the spear in the doorway. He had thought about it all the way up the valley. He had not decided. And then the road forked at a stone marker grown over with moss, one way going on east into the hills after the line of cold fires, and the other going north, and his feet went north.

He heard her stop behind him.

He stopped too, and turned around.

She was standing at the fork with the spear on her back and the morning behind her, looking at him. Then past him, up the north road. Then east, the way they had been going. She did not need to look at the ground. She knew which way the fires went.

"That's not his direction."

"I know," said Hayate.

He waited. He did not explain. He did not know how to explain it in any way that would make her come, and he thought that if he tried he would talk too much and she would go east without him. So he stood in the road with his arm in the sling and waited, and did not say anything, which was the hardest thing he had done since the ridge above Iga.

She looked at him a long time.

Then she came.

***

He got lost.

Of course he got lost. He had gotten lost the first time, in the autumn, walking up the wrong mountain for most of a morning before he would admit it, with the raven sitting on a branch looking at him as if it had been asked to put up with a great deal. There was no raven now. The raven had gone with Ren.

North of the capital. A river. Four stones across it. A cherry tree at a bend.

That was all Ren had ever told them. That was all Hayate had.

There were a great many rivers. He knew that better than anyone.

He took them up one valley and down it again. He took them along a ridge that ended in nothing. He talked, a little, at the start, about how it had not been his fault the first time either, and how a man who could draw a whole compound from memory could not draw one path up one hill, and then he stopped talking, because Aoi was not answering and he had begun to hear himself.

She did not complain. She did not ask where they were going. She walked behind him with the spear on her back, and when he stopped and looked around at a valley and said nothing, she stopped too, and waited, and when he went on she went on.

On the second afternoon they came down through beeches to a river.

He heard it before he saw it. Loud, over stones, the water high and white from the rains. And across it, where the bank shelved down on both sides, four flat stones in a line, just showing above the water, with the white going around them.

He stood on the bank and looked at them.

One. Two. Three. Four.

He crossed. His feet were wet to the ankle on the third. He did not care. On the far side the path went up, and at the first bend of it, leaning out over the path from the slope above, there was a tree. Its blossom long gone. Its leaves dark and full and dripping.

A cherry.

He put his good hand on its trunk as he went past, the way you put your hand on a friend's shoulder in a crowd.

The clearing was at the top of the path.

He knew it the way he had known it the first time. The ground. Packed flat and hard, the way ground only gets packed by one pair of feet going over it every morning for years. The grass had come up at the edges of it since the autumn, and weeds in the cracks, but the middle was still bare.

And the dark places.

Still there. Gone paler, over the winter, and the rain had softened them, and the grass had started to come in over the edges. But still there. Three big ones, and a line of smaller ones going off toward the bend in the path. And by the biggest, near the cave mouth, the scraped place, where someone had raked the earth over and thrown down sand from the river and scuffed it in, and then stopped. The scraping went so far and no farther. A bucket had lain on its side there in the autumn. It was gone now. Someone had taken it back inside, or it had rolled away down the slope.

Nobody had finished.

On the rock at the edge of the clearing, above the river, a snake's skin lay along the stone. Whole. Pale. Empty from mouth to tail.

Hayate stopped at the edge of the clearing.

Behind him, he heard Aoi stop. He heard her see it. He did not turn around. He heard her hand go to the shaft of the spear over her shoulder, and close on it.

"What is this?" said Aoi.

Hayate looked at the cave mouth. Dark in the grey rock. No smoke coming out of it this time. No fire at the back. Nothing.

"Where he grew up," said Hayate.

***

It had started to rain.

Aoi stood in the mouth of the cave with the rain coming down behind her, soft and steady, on the clearing and the dark places and the trees, and let her eyes get used to the dark.

A fire pit. A ring of stones, in the middle of the floor, set close and even. Cold. There was ash in it, grey, fine, settled flat, and a few black ends of wood lying in the ash that had not burned all the way through. Nobody had cleared it. Nobody had built another on top of it.

A bench, against the wall, by the mouth, where a man could sit and look out.

A stack of wood. Split and dried and laid in order, the long pieces at the bottom and the kindling on top.

A shelf further back, two boards on two uprights, pegged.

A sword rack. Empty. The lacquer marks on the pegs, darker than the rest, where the scabbards had rested for years. On the lower pegs, laid there carefully, a hilt with a black cord and a plain iron guard, and a hand's width of steel standing out of it, and then nothing. A broken sword.

And against the far wall, the wooden swords.

One was standing. Upright, leaning against the rock, exactly straight. She looked at it and could not have said how she knew it was exactly straight. It was the way her father's spear had stood on its pegs above the place where he sat. Put there by someone who did not put things anywhere by accident.

The other was on the floor.

It lay across the stone at an angle, where it had fallen. Nobody had picked it up.

Aoi crossed the cave and crouched, and picked it up.

It was an old practice sword. Oak, worn pale and smooth at the grip by a great many years of one pair of hands. Halfway along the blade, driven deep into the wood, there was a piece of dark iron.

A star.

She worked it out of the wood. It came slowly. It had gone in hard, thrown by someone who meant it, and the grain had closed around it. When it came free she held it on her palm, in the grey light from the cave mouth, and turned it.

She counted the points.

Four.

Iga was six. She had cut her own at the forge when she was nine, with the old smith watching. Ren's were five; she had seen them in the post, in a close ring you could cover with one hand, and Takeda looking at them, and her father's hand moving on his spear.

Four was Kōga.

She stood up with the star in one hand and the wooden sword in the other, and turned around, and looked at Hayate.

He was standing in the mouth of the cave, just inside, out of the rain. He had not come further in. He was looking at the wooden sword in her hand.

He told her.

***

Not all at once. Not in order. He told it the way he told everything, in pieces, going back, going around, stopping to get something right and getting something else wrong. He did not sit down. He stood in the mouth of the cave with his bad arm against his chest and the rain behind him, and talked, and she let him.

An old man. Who lived here. Who had taken in a boy, a long time ago, and brought him up that path, and never said why. Who had taught him the two swords, in that clearing, every morning, for eleven years. Who did not talk. Who made the fire every morning before the boy woke.

A cough. Short, dry, like a stick breaking. Once. Then more.

The boy, grown, coming down off the mountain to find someone who could stop it. Asking every doctor in every town between here and Nara. Hayate had gone in with him once. He had stood by the door and listened to Ren say *my teacher coughs,* and answer the questions, and pay for a thing that would not cure it, only ease it. And go out, and on to the next town, and ask again.

Kōga. A woman in Kōga who knew what the boy wanted, and said she could get it. A cure, if he did one thing for them. A door. From inside. Into Iga.

Aoi did not move.

The vault. Hayate did not tell her about the vault. She had been there. He only said *and then,* and stopped, and she saw him decide not to say it, and go on.

The scroll that came out of the vault, and did not go to Kōga. The boy had not taken it to them. Hayate did not know why. He thought Ren had not known either. He had carried it against his ribs all the way back to the house and never once gone east with it.

And Kōga had come here.

While the boy was gone. Up that path, over the four stones, past the cherry. The first ones had come in out of the dark, six of them, and the old man had gotten up from his fire with a wooden sword and they had gone down on the floor of the cave, one after another. Hayate did not know how he knew that. Ren had never told him. He

only knew it, from the way Ren had stood in the clearing afterward, looking at the dark places. And then someone had carried them out, and left the fire burning, and more had come. And taken him.

Because of what the boy had not brought them.

The corridor. A house in the mountains, full of smoke, fire coming down the walls. A man called Raiden, with his fist in an old man's collar. The boy on his back on the boards with his sword broken.

Hayate stopped there for a long time.

The old man had died on the floor of that corridor, in front of him. An arm's length away. His eyes open, and the fire on his face.

The rain went on outside.

Aoi stood in the middle of the cave with the wooden sword in one hand and the star in the other, and did not say anything. She had not interrupted him once.

She did not need him to tell her the rest. She could see it.

Kageyori, by the archive, in the morning, not looking at her. *He was seen with Suzuya of Kōga.* The pleasant face, the forgettable face. The boy walking in through the southern gate at her side, with a cut across his chest that someone had known exactly how deep to make.

The scroll that had gone out through the hole in the wall, and never reached Kōga. She had known that. Everyone in Iga had known that by the winter. Nobody had understood it.

And a star with four points, in a practice sword, on the floor of a cave in the mountains.

They had taken his teacher because of what he had taken from her.

She stood very still.

"His name was Musashi," said Hayate.

***

Aoi did not move.

The rain came down outside the cave mouth, grey, steady. The drip from the rock above the entrance fell in a line. The clearing beyond it was grey, and the trees were grey behind that, and then there was nothing.

A different cave. A different rain. Near Iga, in the summer, the two of them soaked through, and him on his knees at the back of it building a fire before she had even gotten the water out of her eyes. Quick. Too quick. As if his hands had done it ten thousand times and did not need him. Two strikes. And the fire standing up, and the light going up the wet rock, and she had asked him, sitting across it with her hair dripping, who had taught him.

He had thought.

He had looked at the fire.

"A man in the mountains," said Aoi.

Hayate looked at her.

He did not know what she meant. She could see him not knowing. She did not explain.

She had watched him say it. She had watched him smile, and not know he was smiling. She had understood that night that there was no second face in him because there was no first one; that whatever he said was what he meant.

He had meant this. This cave. This man.

She laid the wooden sword down on the bench by the mouth. Not on the floor where it had fallen. On the bench, straight, the way the other one stood. She put the star beside it.

Then she went further in, to the shelf.

There were two bowls on it. Clean. Dusty. And under the bowls, on the lower board, laid flat, a few sheets of old paper.

She took them down.

Paintings. Ink and water, on cheap paper gone soft and brown at the edges. A child's. You could see that at once, in how the brush had been held, too hard and then too loose. Trees in the rain. A river. A bowl. A fire, black on grey, badly, the ink run where too much water had gone into it.

And one that was only grey.

Smudges. Grey pulled through grey, and softened, and bled at the edges. No shape in it anywhere. No tree. No line. Nothing in it at all.

Aoi looked at it for a long time.

She did not know what it was. She turned it to the light from the cave mouth, and it was still nothing. She looked up from it, at Hayate, and he had come a little way into the cave and was looking at it too, over her shoulder, and he shook his head. He did not know either.

She looked at it again.

Behind her, the rain came down in the cave mouth. Grey. The drip from the rock above the entrance, falling in a line. Grey behind it. Grey above grey.

She did not turn around to look at it.

She laid the painting back with the others, flat, on the lower board, under the two bowls, exactly where it had been.

"Why are you showing me this?"

Hayate did not answer at once.

"So when you find him," said Hayate, "you know who you're looking at."

She looked at the shelf. At the two bowls.

"It doesn't change what he did."

"No." Hayate was quiet a moment. "It doesn't."

***

Night came down with the rain still falling.

It was cold in the cave. The cold came off the rock and up out of the floor and in at the mouth with the wet air. Hayate sat against the wall by the bench with his knees drawn up and his arm against his chest, and did not shiver, because he was trying not to.

Aoi knelt at the fire pit.

She cleared it. She swept the old ash out with her hands, carefully, onto a board, and carried it to the mouth of the cave and put it out into the rain, the way you would clear a hearth for someone coming home. She took wood from the stack. The long pieces first. Crossed. Then the short ones. Kindling from the top of the stack, dry, split fine. Her flint. Two strikes.

It caught.

Quick. Clean. The flames went up small and steady and the light went up the rock walls and across the ceiling and into the back of the cave, over the shelf, over the rack with the broken sword on it, over the one wooden sword standing straight against the wall and the other lying straight on the bench.

Hayate watched her do it.

He watched her all the way through, the clearing and the laying and the two strikes. When it caught, he looked at it for a while.

"He never let me make one either."

Aoi sat back on her heels.

"You can't make one."

"No." He smiled. It was the first time she had seen him smile since the ford. "I can't."

She sat down across the fire from him.

Neither of them said anything else. The fire burned. The rain came down outside, grey on grey. The cave was warm, a little, at the front.

Aoi looked at the flames.

Above her, in a fold of the rock where the wall met the ceiling, the light had found something. She did not look up at it. She could see it anyway, in another cave, in another rain. A web, strung across a corner, every thread of it lit red and gold, moving a little in the warm air rising. A spider in the middle of it that did not move at all.

I only know winning, he had said. Looking at the fire. A moment too long.

Winning won't solve anything, she had said.

And he had looked back at her across the fire, and neither of them had said anything, and neither of them had looked away.

She had thought he meant the fights. The training ground. The throws. The cuts with nothing left over. She had thought she was telling him something about the kind of person he was.

She looked at the fire.

She looked at the place on the floor in front of it, worn smooth and a little hollow, where a man had sat every morning for so long that the stone had given way to him.

He had been trying to win the old man.

Every doctor in every town. Every door in Iga. Every step through the smoke. Every one of the fires with the long pieces laid first, left to burn out on spurs and in farmyards and on flat rocks in pine woods, all the way across the hills. He had been trying to win one thing, and there had been nothing in the world he could do that would win it, and he had done all of it anyway.

He had lost it on the floor of a corridor, an arm's length away, with the fire on the old man's face.

And he was still trying.

Aoi sat across the fire from Hayate, in the cave where the boy had grown up, and understood, and did not move for a long time.

Chapter 80

The Inevitability

The map was covered in needles.

They stood up out of the paper all over it, dozens of them, in the light of the one lamp. The old ones, from the spring, in their long wandering line across the hills, each with its small knotted thread for the dead. The ones from before that, in Iga, in the capital, in the forest, along the roads. Every place anything had happened in a year. She had stopped putting new ones in.

Kikyo stood at the head of the table and looked at them.

It was night. The house was very quiet. Kōga did not sleep in houses anymore, or not in the same one twice, and the rooms around this one were empty, and the yard outside was empty, and the only sound was the frogs in the wet fields below, going on and on, and the lamp.

Across the table from her, Suzuya knelt on the mats with his hands on his knees.

He had come in from the hills an hour ago with mud to his knees and knelt there and made his report, and she had listened to all of it without moving. He was waiting now for her to say something. He had the pleasant face, the forgettable face. There was nothing on it now. There was never anything on it that he had not put there.

To the right of the door, against the wall, the sword.

Upright. The hilt against the plaster, the point on the mats. The angle it had always leaned at. Nobody had moved it. Nobody looked at it. Suzuya had not looked at it once since he came in, very carefully, and she could feel him not looking at it the way you feel a draft on the back of the neck.

"Raiden is dead," said Suzuya.

He said it quietly. As if it were the first item of a report, and not the thing that had been in the room with them since he knelt down.

"The Fūma have lost Kagetora. The Oniwabanshū are losing men to their own weapon. Iga is moving."

He paused.

"We should strike now. While they're weak."

Kikyo did not look up from the map.

"Strike who?"

Suzuya opened his mouth.

Then he closed it.

She let the silence sit. The lamp burned. The frogs went on.

Then she began to walk.

Slowly. Around the table, the way she had walked around it on a hundred nights, with her hands in her sleeves and her eyes on the paper. Past the corner where the capital was. Past the long grey stain of the lake. Past the mountains, and the roads, and all the needles standing up out of them with their threads.

At the eastern roads, where the long lines of the shogun's men were drawn in brush, going into the hills, she stopped. She took a needle from her sleeve and set it there, in the paper, among the marching lines, and pressed it in.

"Tokugawa wants order."

She looked at it.

"They're right."

She walked on. To the south. To the valley with the terraces and the gate, where a line of small marks had begun to go out across the hills, from ending to ending. Another needle, from her sleeve.

"Iga wants what was taken from them."

She pressed it in.

"They're right."

On. Around the corner of the table, to the hills in the middle of the map where Kōga had been. Where there was nothing drawn now, no houses, no roads, only the painted ridges, because there was nothing there anymore that stayed in one place long enough to be drawn. Another needle.

"We want to survive."

She set it down among the empty ridges.

"We're right."

She stopped.

She stood at the side of the table with her hands back in her sleeves and looked at the three new needles, standing up bright among the old ones.

"Everyone is right. That's the problem."

Suzuya did not move.

"When everyone is right," said Kikyo, "nobody can stop."

The lamp burned. The needles stood up out of the map in their dozens, and their shadows lay out across the paper, all in the same direction, away from the flame.

Suzuya looked at the map a long time.

"And the boy?"

Kikyo did not answer at once.

She put out one finger, and touched the needle that stood apart.

It was not in any of the lines. It was not on any road. It stood alone in an empty place on the paper, at the edge of the hills, where nothing was written. She had taken it out of the mountains weeks ago and carried it in her sleeve, and two nights ago she had put it back. Not where it had been. Here. Apart from everything. She did not know why she had chosen that place. She had only known it was the place.

"The boy showed us that."

She took her finger away.

"He doesn't belong to any of them. So he's the only one who can see they can't all win."

Suzuya looked at the needle standing alone.

"Then what do we do?"

"We don't make it happen."

Kikyo looked up from the map. At him. For the first time since he had come in.

"It's already happening. It's not something you win." She looked back down at the paper. At all of it. "It's something you reach."

Suzuya was quiet.

He looked at the needles. At the three new ones. At the one alone. At the lines, all of them, the shogun's and Iga's and the ones that had been Kōga's, going across the hills from every side, and bending, and bending, until they were all going toward the same place without any of them having been drawn to go there.

"And Kōga's role?"

Kikyo turned her head.

She looked at the empty wall. The plaster, and the post, and the grain of the post dark with years, and the sword leaning against it at the old angle.

She looked at it a long time.

"To be there when it arrives," she said. "And to see it through."

Silence.

Suzuya bowed. Low. His forehead near the mats. Then he rose, without a sound, and went to the door, and around the sword, and out, and slid the door shut behind him.

Kikyo stayed.

She stood at the table with the lamp burning low and the frogs going on outside and looked at the map. At every needle on it. At the one alone.

She did not move a single piece.

***

The hill was high and bare on top, and the wind came over it from the west and did not stop.

Below it, on the east side, the ground fell away through pines and scrub into a valley. A wide one. Fields in the bottom of it, the rice planted and standing in water, green, in long flat mirrors that held the sky. A river along one side, brown and full. And a road, coming in from the north and going along the edge of the fields and then bending, south, around a great shoulder of mountain, toward the river, and on.

She had not needed a map to find it. She had drawn it so many times without knowing she was drawing it.

Kikyo stood at the top of the hill in the wind with her sleeves blowing and looked down at it.

It had rained in the night. The path up the hill was mud, and in the mud, all along it, there were petals. Pale pink, from the azaleas on the slope below, beaten down by the rain. They lay pressed into the ruts, and in the prints of her own sandals, and in the prints of the runners' sandals coming and going.

The runners had been coming all day.

One at a time. Up the hill from different sides, never the same way twice, and kneeling in the wet grass at the top, and telling her, and going. She read each one the way she had always read them. Standing. Not looking at the man. Looking at the valley. Taking what he said and setting it down in her head where it went.

And then letting it go.

The Tokugawa column, a day out. On the north road. Banners.

Iga, in twos, in the hills to the south. Moving from ending to ending.

Hanzō, alone, somewhere to the west. Nobody could say where.

The Fūma, everywhere and nowhere, the way they always were. Fewer than before.

And the last runner, a boy, very young, with mud to his thighs, kneeling in the grass with his eyes down.

The Karasu house was gone. There had been a great many Fūma. They were dead. There was a crater in the middle of the yard. The artist had died there.

Shinmei had died there with him.

Kikyo stood in the wind and did not say anything for a while. The boy knelt and waited. After a time she moved her hand, a little, and he rose and bowed and went back down the hill the way he had not come.

She put her hand into her sleeve.

The needles were there. She had been carrying them for weeks, since she stopped putting them in the map. The ones that had been standing for people when the people stopped standing. She felt through them with her fingers until she found the two she wanted, and drew them out, and looked at them on her palm.

Two needles. Iron. Very straight. One had stood for a man who made things out of fire and clay and never said anything. One had stood for a man who made distance lie.

She turned her hand over.

They fell into the wet grass at her feet, among the petals, and she did not look to see where.

The others were in her sleeve too. Some of them. Raiden. Yoru. Natsume. Kagetora and Raiun, from the Fūma, whom she had never met. Hanzō's young one, Jin, from a clearing by a wayside shrine.

There was only one left in her hand now.

She had not put it in her sleeve with the others. She had carried it in her fingers since the dark room, since she took it up off the map, in the empty place at the edge of the hills where it had stood alone.

The one that had moved furthest.

She had thrown it into the capital on the first night, across the lamplight, into the tiny squares of the streets, when he was a rumor at a crossroads with two swords and an old man with a cough. She had moved it to the mountains, where there were no roads, when he did not come east with the scroll. She had moved it into Iga, and out of Iga, and into Kōga, into the heart of Kōga, where it had stood in the smoke. Across the hills. Along the line of dead she had knotted, house by house. Everywhere.

Every map she had ever drawn, it had crossed.

She held it up.

Between her finger and thumb, at arm's length, against the valley below. A thin dark line, very straight, standing up against the green fields and the brown river and the road bending south around the shoulder of the mountain. From where she stood, it stood exactly in the middle of the valley. As if it had been set there.

The wind pulled at her sleeve. The needle did not move.

Beside her, a little behind, Suzuya had come up the hill. She had heard him come. He stood in the grass and looked at the needle in her hand, and at the valley behind it.

"We could still move him," said Suzuya. "One message. One lie."

He paused.

"Like the first time."

Kikyo looked at the needle for a long time.

She thought about the first time. The lamplight. The report from Kusatsu, and the boy at the crossroads, and the old man in the mountains with a cough in his chest that no doctor could name. A cure. One word. One door. It had been the easiest thing she had ever done. She had barely had to move her hand.

"The first time," said Kikyo, "he was a boy looking for a cure."

She lowered her hand.

Not all the way. Only until the needle was no longer between her and the valley. Until she could see the valley itself, and not the needle standing in it.

"Now he's the only thing in that valley that isn't a system."

Suzuya did not say anything.

Kikyo did not throw the needle. She did not put it back in her sleeve with the others. She did not drop it in the grass.

She held it.

She stood at the top of the hill in the wind with the petals in the mud at her feet and two dead men's needles lying somewhere among them, and held the last one in her fingers, and did not do anything with it at all.

At first light, below, on the north road, where it came into the valley between two low hills, something moved.

Color. A long way off. Small, and bright, and then another beside it, and another behind. Lifting and falling in the wind over the heads of men she could not yet see.

The first banners.

They came around the hill and onto the road into the valley, one after another, all at the same angle, and more behind them, and more behind those, and the sound of them came up the hill very faint against the wind, a sound like rain beginning a long way off.

Kikyo watched.

Chapter 81

The Raven

The fire had been made properly.

Kurogane crouched over it in the grey before the sun, on a flat rock by a stream, with the mist lying in the cedars all around. A ring of stones. The ash inside it fine and pale. Burned down, and left.

He put the back of his hand near it. Not in it. Near.

Still warm.

He had seen that fire made a hundred times. In the yard, in the ring in the middle of the yard, in the grey before anyone else was up. He had never once seen it made badly. He had never once seen it made by anyone else.

He stood up.

The stream went on over its stones. Somewhere up the slope a cuckoo was calling, the same two notes, over and over, the way they call at the start of the rains. The cedars dripped. Everything smelled of wet bark and earth.

He looked the way the ground went. East. Up out of the stream and over the ridge and down the other side.

Then he looked the other way, back, the way he had come, into the trees.

He had heard them an hour ago. Not heard. There had been nothing to hear. The cuckoo had stopped, for a while, down the valley behind him, and then started again, further off. And a jay had gone up out of the cedars, scolding, and then another, a little further along. And then nothing, for a long time, in a line, going the same way he was going.

They were coming.

A great many. He could not have said how many. More than the street. They were not trying to be quiet about the direction. Only about everything else. They were coming through the forest the way water comes down a slope, spread out, not in any shape, and every part of them going the same way.

The way the ring of stones pointed.

Kurogane put his hand inside his sash.

The stone was there. Smooth. The size of a thumb joint. It had been in his sash since the morning he took it off the map by the hearth, and it had been wet in the street and dried again, and it was dry now.

He held it.

He had never been placed by anyone but one man. He had gone where the stone went, and when he got there it had always been the right place. He had not had to think about it. He had never been any good at thinking about it.

He thought about it now.

He looked at the ridge, and at the trees behind him, and at the lie of the ground between. The place where the forest came down to the edge of the stream and stopped, and there was a strip of open ground, stones and bracken, before the slope went up the other side. Anyone going east would have to come out of the trees there. Anyone.

He took his hand out of his sash, and left the stone where it was.

He went and stood there.

***

He stood at the edge of the forest, with the open ground in front of him and the forest below it, and waited.

He did not sit. He did not lean on a tree. He stood with his feet a little apart and his sword in its scabbard at his hip and his arms folded, the way he had stood at the corner of the yard on all the nights, while Hayate talked. The

mist went through the trees behind him, slowly, and thinned. The light came up grey. His side, where the man in the street had opened it, pulled a little when he breathed. He did not mind it.

The cuckoo stopped.

He unfolded his arms.

They came through the trees in front of him, below, where the forest went down to the stream. Grey. A long way apart from each other, and then closer, drawing together where the ground narrowed, the way water does. He saw one. Then three. Then more than he could count between the trunks, all moving, none of them looking at him, because none of them knew yet that there was anything to look at.

And in the middle of them, one who was not like the others.

Not only in his size, though he stood two heads above every one of them, broad as a door, so that they looked like boys around him. He moved the way they moved. He was grey like the rest. But he had nothing over his face, and he was not looking where they were looking. He was not looking anywhere. He was walking through the wet forest the way a man walks down a road he has walked every day of his life, with his hands loose, and his eyes on nothing.

The others were keeping their distance from him. A little. Without knowing they were.

Kurogane took one of the knives from his sash.

He did not think about it. He did not aim. He threw the way he had always thrown, the whole arm behind it and nothing left over, straight, at the man with the plain face.

The man moved.

Before the knife left his hand. Kurogane saw it. Not after. Before. The man's head went a little to the side, not quickly, not looking, and the knife went by where his throat had been and into the trunk of a cedar behind him with a sound like an axe, and stood there, shivering.

The man had not looked at it.

He had not looked at Kurogane either. Not yet. He stopped walking.

All around him, the grey men stopped.

Then the man turned his head, and looked up the slope, through the trees, to the edge of the forest, where Kurogane was standing alone with his empty hand.

***

A long time.

Neither of them moved. The forest dripped. The grey men stood where they had stopped, between the trunks, and did not look at each other.

The man with the plain face looked at him.

It was not the way men looked at him. Kurogane knew the ways men looked at him. He had been looked at on a riverbank, kneeling on a mat with his hands bound and a board with his name on it. He had been looked at in the street in the moonlight by men who had just seen what he did. This was not either of those.

The man looked at his face. Then at his hands. Then, for a long moment, at the sword at his hip.

The way you look at a thing you have been told about.

Something went across the plain face. Very small. Kurogane could not have said what it was. It was there, and it went, and after it had gone the man's face was the same as before, and it was not the same.

The man knew him.

Kurogane did not know how. He did not wonder.

The man said something to the others. Low, without turning his head. Kurogane did not hear the words. The grey men began to move again, all at once, the way they did everything. Not toward Kurogane. Away from him. Around him. Some to the left, down along the stream, and some to the right, up into the trees, spreading out

through the forest on either side of the open ground and going on east, around, toward the ridge, the way they had been going.

Kurogane let them go.

He could have gone after them. He could have gone down into the trees and cut through them the way he had cut through them in the street, one after another, until there were none. He did not. He watched them go past on either side of him, grey, among the trunks, a long way off, and did not turn his head to follow them.

They did not matter. They had never mattered. The ones who were going on east would find what was east of the ridge, and what was east of the ridge would do what it did.

This one mattered.

The man with the plain face came up out of the trees.

Alone. Not hurrying. Up the slope, across the stones and the wet bracken, the way he had walked through the forest. Past the cedar with the knife in it. He did not look at the knife. He stopped on the open ground, a little more than a sword's length away, with his hands empty and his sword in its scabbard at his hip.

He looked at Kurogane.

Kurogane looked at him.

Behind the man, down in the forest, the last of the grey ones went out of sight among the trees, and the cuckoo, somewhere, started again.

***

It did not start. It was already happening.

Kurogane drew, and the man was not there. He had not stepped. He had not moved his feet. He had leaned, the way a reed leans, and Kurogane's cut went through the place where he had been standing, and the man's sword was out. Kurogane had not seen it come out. It was out, and it was coming back across, low, from behind the man's own leg, from nowhere a sword comes from.

Kurogane did not go back.

He did not see where it was coming from and he did not try to. He went forward, into it, straight, the way his pieces had gone across the board, and cut. The man's sword opened his thigh. His own went across the man's shoulder and opened it to the bone.

They went apart.

The man looked at his shoulder. Then at Kurogane's thigh. Then at Kurogane's face.

Again.

The man dropped his sword.

In the middle of it, with Kurogane's cut coming. He opened his hand and let it go, and it turned once going down, and Kurogane did not look at it. He was not looking at anything. He cut through the place where the man was, and the man was not there, he was inside, chest to chest, closer than there was room for, with his hand on Kurogane's wrist and his forehead coming.

It came into Kurogane's face like a stone.

Kurogane did not go back. He did not go anywhere. He took it, and something in his face broke, and the blood came down into his mouth, and he did not stop. His free hand came up and took the man by the throat.

The man tore away. He went down, and rolled, and came up with his sword in his hand again, from the ground, where it had fallen. And there was blood on the man's neck where Kurogane's fingers had been.

They stood.

Kurogane breathed. It went in and out through the blood.

He did not wipe his face.

***

It went on.

It went on longer than anything he had known. The man did things that no one did. He sat down in the bracken with Kurogane's cut coming, and cut up from the ground. He turned his back and walked away, and when Kurogane came after him the scabbard came back over his shoulder end over end, and Kurogane did not close his eyes, he let it strike him across the face and went on through it. He cut early. He cut late. He cut from the left with the sword in his right hand. He stood with his arms open, everything open, and waited, and when Kurogane came into the opening there was nothing there but the edge, waiting for him.

None of it was a way. There was no way to it. There was nothing to learn, and nothing to read.

Kurogane did not read it.

That was the thing. That was the only thing. He had stopped reading in the street, in the moonlight, and he had not started again. The man was making a hundred moves and there was no one reading any of them. There was only the cut, straight, coming, whenever it came, through whatever was in front of it.

And so the man had to meet it.

Every time. Whatever he had done. Wherever he had gone. The cut came through the place he was, and he had to be somewhere else, or meet it, or take it. He was somewhere else. He met it. He took it. And every time he took it, a little more of him went.

His shoulder. His side, above the hip. His left hand, two of the fingers.

And every time, the man's sword came back.

Kurogane's thigh. His arm, the left, from the elbow to the wrist, so that the hand on that side did not close properly anymore. His ribs, on the right, the other side from the old one. His face again. Something low in his back that he did not see go in and did not feel come out.

He did not slow.

He knew what was happening to him. He could feel it. The heat going out of his hands. The wet all down him, into his sash, into his sandals, so that his feet slid a little on the stones. The forest going far off at the edges, and coming back, and going.

He did not slow.

He had nowhere to go that he needed to keep anything for.

***

The man stepped back.

Out of reach. Five paces. He stood on the open ground with his sword low and the blood running off his left hand, and his breath going, fast, and he looked at Kurogane.

Kurogane stood.

He did not step back. He did not step forward. He stood with his sword low and his feet a little apart and the blood coming out of him in a dozen places, and he looked back.

The man was looking at the cuts.

At every one of them. Kurogane could see his eyes go. The thigh, the arm, the ribs, the face. The back, where it was coming through the coat in front. As if he were a man adding up a sum, and it would not come out.

And then Kurogane saw it arrive.

On the plain face. For the first time. Not the small thing that had gone across it down among the trees. Something else. Something that stayed.

The man understood.

Kurogane could see it go through him. The man had been fighting a man who wanted to live. That was the only kind there was. Everything he did was made for it. A man who wants to live will go back from a blade, or around it, or away from it, and every trick the man had was waiting in the place he would go. He had been setting them all morning.

And there had been no one going there.

Kurogane was not trying to get out of this. He had not been trying since the edge of the forest. Since the street. Since before that. Since a room at night, with snow against the paper, and a board between them, and a question, and the answer.

The man's breath had gone slow.

He was not afraid. Kurogane did not think he was a man who could be. But his feet had changed on the ground. His weight had come back, a little, onto his heels, the way a man's weight goes when he looks down and sees how far it is to the bottom.

The cuckoo had stopped. Kurogane did not know when.

***

Kurogane went.

Straight. Across the five paces. With his sword low and all of him behind it and nothing left over, the way he had gone across the street toward the man with the cloth over his face, the way he had done everything he had ever done that mattered.

The man met him.

He did not try anything. There was no time for it, and no use in it. He did the only thing left, the thing any man would have done. He put his sword straight out in front of him, level, into the place where Kurogane was coming.

Kurogane did not go around it.

He went onto it.

He felt it go in. Under the ribs. Through. He felt it come out of his back. He felt the guard of it come up hard against him, and the man's hands on the hilt, and the man's face, suddenly, very close, bent down over him, the plain face, a hand's breadth away, with its eyes open.

There was no more distance.

There was no more anything.

Kurogane's sword went in under the man's jaw.

Through the neck. Out the other side. And on, with all of Kurogane behind it, everything he had left, the whole of the last step, and the two of them went back across the last pace of open ground together, and the man's back met the trunk of a cedar at the edge of the forest, and Kurogane's sword went through him and into the tree, and stopped.

The sound of it went out through the forest.

Then nothing.

***

Kurogane stood.

He was holding the hilt. Both hands, though the left one would not close properly. The blade went from his hands through the man's neck and into the cedar behind, deep, and it held. The man's own sword was in Kurogane, through him, the hilt against his coat, and the man's hands had come off it.

They hung at the man's sides now.

Kurogane looked at his face.

A hand's breadth away. The plain face. The eyes open, and looking at him, and then not looking at anything. He watched them. He watched them until there was nothing in them, and after that, a while longer, to be sure. The man's head was a little to one side against the bark. The blood went down into his collar and did not come any faster, and then it came slower, and then it did not come.

Nothing moved in him.

It was done.

Kurogane's legs had gone. He could not feel them. He was standing because his hands were on the hilt and the hilt was in the tree, and he did not let go.

He did not let go.

The forest was very quiet. Water dripping off the cedars. The stream, below, on its stones. Nothing else.

And then it was there.

Not the forest. A fire. Small, in a ring of stones, on open ground, at night. The light going up on faces.

Ren, beside Hayate, with the firelight on one side of his face, listening.

Hayate with his hands going, telling it wrong, having to go back.

Enji with a clay ball in his fingers, turning it over, turning it.

And across the fire, sitting very straight, with a stone in his hand, looking at all of them, and knowing, before any of them knew it themselves, exactly where each of them was.

Shigure.

Kurogane's mouth moved.

"Kuroi..."

It did not come out as a voice. It came out as breath, with the blood in it.

"...Karasu."

Something went down his face.

Through the blood, and the dirt, and the place where the man's forehead had broken it. One line. Slow. It went down to his jaw and stopped there.

He breathed in.

It did not go very far.

He breathed out, and did not breathe in again.

He stood at the edge of the forest with his hands on the hilt of his sword, and the man he had killed pinned to the cedar in front of him, and the man's sword through him, and he did not fall.

***

Silence.

The mist had gone out of the trees. The light had come up, grey and even, the light of the rains, lying on the open ground and the stones and the wet bracken and the two of them at the edge of the forest, standing, very close, as if one of them were telling the other something that nobody else was meant to hear.

In the cedar down the slope, the knife was still standing in the bark.

Far off, over the ridge, east, a crow was calling.

Chapter 82

Revenge

The box was empty.

It stood on its low stand at the far end of the long hall where it had stood for a month, pale plain wood, the lid set beside it. Hanzō had lifted the lid that morning, alone, before the light, and taken out what was inside, and put it in his robe. Then he had taken the roll in oiled cloth from where it lay beside the box, and put that in his robe too.

He could feel them now. Both of them. Against his ribs, one against the other, under the belt. Heavier than paper should be.

He had carried one of them for most of his life. He had never carried two.

He knelt on the boards in front of the empty stand with his hands on his knees and waited for them to come.

It was raining. It had been raining for days, the long rains, fine and grey, and the light that came in through the slats high up under the roof came in grey, and lay across the floor in pale bars, and did not move. The hall smelled of wet wood. Somewhere a gutter was running over, and the water fell past the eaves in a thin rope, and struck a stone, over and over.

They came in by the front door.

Not by the storeroom. Not by the lane at the back. By the front, one after another, and slid it shut behind them, and came down the length of the hall over the polished boards, and knelt in rows in front of him, the way they had knelt when he was younger and there had been more of them.

There were not so many now.

He did not count them. He knew the number. He had known it every morning for a year. The rows were short. There were places at the ends of them where the rows stopped too soon, and nobody looked at the places.

Kenshiro, at the front, on the right. Ayame beside him. Daichi on the left.

And on the far left, at the front, where the fourth had always knelt, nobody.

They had not left it empty on purpose. Nobody had said anything. They had only come in and knelt where they always knelt, and the place was where it had always been, and there was nobody in it.

Hanzō looked at them.

They looked back. They were waiting for the stones. For the map on the boards, and his hand going over it, and each of them set down where they would be. They had waited for that their whole lives.

There was no map.

"The boy," said Hanzō.

Nobody moved.

"We go and bring him in."

That was all.

He watched it go into them.

He watched it the way he had always watched things go into people. Not the faces. The hands. Kenshiro's hand, on his knee, closed. Slowly. All the way. Behind him, in the second row, a young man looked sideways at Ayame, and Ayame did not look back, and something went out of the young man's shoulders that had been in them since the valley. Further back, someone let out a breath he had been holding for a month.

Daichi did not do anything at all.

They had heard something. It was not what Hanzō had said.

He saw what it was. He saw it go along the rows from one to the next, the way the wind goes along a field of rice and every stem bends the same way. Nobody said it. It was the thing they had been kneeling on for a month, in their own houses, at night, with their eyes open.

A clearing by a wayside shrine. A rope around a stone. A boy on the ground with Ayame's hand on his shoulder.

And a man standing by the shrine, who could have reached him, and had watched.

Hanzō did not correct it.

He could have. He had the words. He could have told them what he had seen on the bridge at Seta, in the rain, with the banners going over it one after another at the same angle. He could have told them about the map in the room above the bridge, and the pieces on it drifting toward the same fold of the hills. He could have told them about the boy on the threshing floor, walking off the fifth mark into the grass, facing nothing.

He did not have the words for why that meant they should go. He only knew that it did.

And they would go faster for the other thing.

He looked at the rows, and at the empty place at the end of the front one, and let them believe it.

"We leave at dark."

They bowed. All of them, together. Then they rose and went back up the hall, over the boards, in the grey bars of light, and out by the front door, one after another, to get ready.

Daichi did not go.

***

He stayed where he was, kneeling, on the left, at the front. When the door had slid shut behind the last of them he did not look around at it. He looked at the boards in front of his knees.

Hanzō waited.

The water fell off the eaves outside onto its stone.

"They want to read them," said Daichi.

He said it to the boards.

Hanzō did not answer.

"The scrolls." Daichi's hands were flat on his thighs. They were very still. "Everyone knows you have them. Everyone knows what they did to him." He stopped. "They want what he has."

He lifted his head.

"For Jin."

Hanzō looked at him.

He had known Daichi since Daichi was eleven years old and had come to the hall with a split lip, from a street near the river, because somebody had told him there was food. He had taught him to kneel. He had taught him to go low in the east corner of the square, so that the one above him could come over. He had watched him go low in that corner ten thousand times, and every time, the one who came over him had been Jin.

"He didn't draw," said Daichi.

Quietly. Not to Hanzō. To the hall.

"In here. He came in, and he stood there, and he put us on the floor, the three of us. And he didn't draw." His jaw moved. "He didn't need to. He didn't even look at us, Master Hanzō. We weren't worth his hand on a hilt."

He was quiet a moment.

"Jin wasn't worth his hand either."

Hanzō said nothing.

There was nothing to say that Daichi did not know. Daichi had been on the floor, against the pillar, with his hand on his side, and watched it. He had been in the clearing. He had stood over Jin with his sword out, and looked at the boy, and his face had done something, once, and then nothing.

It was doing nothing now.

Hanzō could feel them against his ribs. Both of them. One against the other. The one he had spent his life reading, a word at a time, a year at a time, and was still not finished. And the one that had come out of Iga in a boy's robe, through a hole in a wall, and made the boy's body do things before the boy had decided to do them.

He did not reach for them.

He did not say no.

Daichi looked at him a long time, kneeling on the boards in the grey light. Then he bowed, low, his forehead to the floor, and held it there. And rose. And went up the hall, and out.

Hanzō stayed.

He knelt in front of the empty box with his hands on his knees and the two scrolls against his ribs and listened to the water fall off the eaves onto its stone, over and over, until the light in the slats went from grey to darker grey, and then to nothing.

***

They went out of the city by the Kyō road, in the dark, in the rain.

In twos and threes, the way they always went, a long way apart, so that no one watching the road would have seen more than two or three men walking. Straw capes. Hats pulled low. No lanterns. They did not need them. They had walked this road so many times they could have walked it blind, and some nights they had.

Hanzō walked at the back.

He had always walked at the back. Where he could see all of them. He could see them now, in the dark, in the rain, the long thin line of them going up the road ahead of him toward the capital. Or he could not see them, and knew where they were, which was the same thing.

At Hirakata, where the road ran through the post town, a man under the eaves of the post station looked up at the sound of them, and saw Hanzō's face, and looked down again.

They went on.

It was near dawn, and the rain had thinned to almost nothing, when Daichi dropped back.

He came down the line, past the others, not hurrying, until he was walking beside Hanzō at the back. He did not say anything. Ayame was with him. Hanzō had not seen her drop back. He had known she would.

They walked, the three of them, for a while.

The road went along the river here. The water was high and brown with the rains and very loud. The sky over the hills to the east had begun to go pale behind the cloud. There was enough light to see faces.

Daichi held out his hand.

Palm up. Between them, as they walked. He did not look at Hanzō. He looked at the road ahead.

Hanzō looked at the hand.

It was a big hand. Scarred across the knuckles. The hand of a boy from a street near the river who had come for the food and stayed. It did not shake.

On Hanzō's other side, Ayame walked with her eyes on the road, and did not hold out her hand, and did not need to.

Hanzō put his own hand into his robe.

He found the roll in oiled cloth first. Iga's. He drew it out. It was warm from his body. He held it a moment, walking, the way you hold a thing that is heavier than it looks.

Then Daichi's hand closed on it, and took it, and it was gone.

He put his hand back into his robe.

The other one was still there. Alone now. He had carried it for most of his life. He knew the weight of it the way he knew the weight of his own head. He had never once in thirty years let it out of his hands on a road.

He drew it out.

Ayame took it.

She did not look at him when she took it. She only reached across, walking, and put her hand on it, and he felt her fingers close, and felt it go out of his hand, and then there was nothing in his hand at all.

He put his hand into his sleeve.

"One word," said Hanzō.

He did not know if they heard him. The river was very loud.

Up the road, Kenshiro had stopped at the edge of it and was standing in the grey, looking back. He looked at the paper in their hands. Once. Then at Hanzō. Then at the road.

He did not hold out his hand. He waited until Hanzō came level with him, and fell in at his right shoulder, and walked there.

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They read as they walked.

He had known they would. They did not wait for a halt. They did not wait for a roof, or a fire, or a quiet place to sit. Daichi untied the oiled cloth as he walked, and let it fall on the road behind him, and did not stop to pick it up. Ayame unrolled the other a hand's width, and held it low in front of her, against the grey light coming up over the hills, and bent her head to it.

They walked on up the road, side by side, ahead of him now, reading.

Hanzō walked behind them, and watched.

It came on Daichi first.

Hanzō knew what it was. Anyone in Iga who had ever been let near that scroll knew what its first lines did. The paper not moving in Daichi's hands, and then Daichi's step checking, once, on the wet road, the way a man's step checks when a pain goes through him that he was not expecting. Not in any one place. Deep. The pain of a bone being set. Daichi's shoulders came up with it. His breath went out of him, hard, through his teeth.

He did not stop reading.

He did not stop walking. He walked through it, the paper in front of him, his head bent, his shoulders up around his ears, and read the next line. And the next. And the next, while the pain went through him, and he let it.

Too fast.

Hanzō had told him. One word. Daichi had read three lines in the space of a hundred steps.

And then, a while after, his walk changed.

It was a small thing. Nobody else on the road would have seen it. Daichi's feet had always come down hard, heel first, the walk of a big man from a street near the river. They did not come down hard now. They came down exactly where they were going, flat, without a sound, the whole weight of him settling into each step and out of it again as if there had never been any weight at all. His shoulders came down. His breath went slow.

He was not doing it. It was being done.

Hanzō looked at Ayame.

She had not flinched. There was no pain in his scroll. There never had been. That was what had made it so easy to go on reading, for thirty years.

She walked with her head bent over it and her lips very slightly moving, and her eyes going along the lines, and Hanzō watched her eyes. He knew where she was in it. He knew every word under them.

She lifted her head.

Not all the way. Only enough to look up the road. At the long thin line of their people going ahead of them, in twos and threes, a long way apart, in the grey light.

Her eyes went along them.

From one to the next. Not the way a woman looks at the backs of people she has knelt beside all her life. Hanzō had seen that look on her face ten thousand times. This was not that. Her eyes stopped on each of them for exactly

as long as it took, and moved on. Where each of them was. Where each of them would be. The spaces between. How far. How long.

Then she turned her head, and looked at Hanzō.

He looked back.

He had seen that look before. He had seen it every morning of his life, for thirty years, in the water in the basin, before he put his hands in it.

Ayame looked at him the way he looked at a map.

Then she looked down again, at the scroll, and went on reading.

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The sun did not come out. The light only came up, grey, and lay on the road and on the high brown river and on the hills ahead, where the road went up out of the plain toward the capital, and on, east.

Hanzō walked at the back.

His hands were in his sleeves. There was nothing in his robe. Nothing against his ribs. He could feel the place where it had been, the way you feel the place where a tooth was, with your tongue, for a long time after.

Kenshiro walked at his right shoulder, and did not say anything, and did not look at the scrolls.

Ahead of him, Daichi and Ayame walked side by side with their heads bent, reading. Daichi's feet did not make a sound on the road. Ayame's lips moved.

Ahead of them, their people. In twos and threes. Going east.

On the road behind him, a little way back, a piece of oiled cloth lay in the mud where it had fallen, with the rain beginning again on it, very lightly.

He did not go back for it.

Chapter 83

Stones

It had rained in the night, and stopped, and rained again before the light, and stopped.

Kikyo stood at the top of the hill in the wet grass, with Suzuya a little behind her, and watched the valley fill.

The petals were still in the mud on the path behind her. More of them now. The azaleas on the slope had given up the last of their color in the night, and the rain had brought it down and beaten it into the ruts, pale pink going brown, pressed flat under the prints of sandals. Nobody had come up the path since dawn. Nobody needed to. There was nothing left for the runners to tell her that she could not see.

Below her, on the north road, the banners.

They had come in at first light, between the two low hills where the road entered the valley, and they had not stopped coming. They came down onto the flat ground beside the fields and turned, company by company, and spread, and stood. Foot soldiers in their ranks. Spears all at one angle. The bowmen behind them. The matchlock men behind those, the long barrels wrapped against the wet, the match kept under their capes. Horses at the back, and the officers going up and down between the ranks without hurrying, and the banners over all of it, dark with rain, lifting a little when the wind came.

Drums.

A slow beat, from somewhere in the middle of it. The ranks moved on it. A step. A step. A whole company going forward across the edge of the fields, every foot coming down at once, and stopping when the drum stopped, and standing.

She had drawn that on a map a hundred times. She had never seen it done.

It was very beautiful.

Around her, in the rocks on the slope below the hilltop, and in the scrub, and in the pines along the ridge to the north, there was Kōga.

She could not have said where. That was the point. There was no camp. There was a man lying flat in the bracken fifty paces down the slope, and another in the fork of a pine, and two more somewhere in the rocks above the river, and the rest of them everywhere else, alone or in twos, none of them knowing where more than one or two of the others were. Nobody had been told where to stand. They had been told only not to stand where anyone would look.

And in the rocks, and in the trees, and on the ledges above the valley where nobody was standing at all, the lanterns.

Paper lanterns. Lit, in the grey morning, in the wet. Hung from branches and set in the clefts of rocks and tied to stakes in the scrub. Dozens of them, spread along the whole west side of the valley, each one burning small and yellow in a place where there was no one.

She had not ordered them. Somebody had thought of it in the night, and somebody else had seen it and done the same, and by dawn there were lanterns all along the slope. She had looked at them, when she came up, and understood them, and let them burn.

Kōga could no longer say where it was. So it would say it was everywhere.

Overhead, a single crow went around.

Wide and slow, over the whole valley, on the wind. Not calling. Not landing. It went around once, over the banners and the fields and the river, and came back over the hill, and went around again.

Kikyo watched it.

Then she looked down at the valley, and at the ranks moving on the drum, and at the lanterns burning in the rocks where nobody was, and at the long green slope of trees below her on the west side, going down toward the fields.

Something was moving in the trees.

Fast. Low. A long way down the slope, among the trunks. Not Kōga. Kōga did not move like that anymore. Kōga lay still in the bracken and waited.

She watched it come.

***

Hanzō ran.

Down through the pines on the west side of the valley, in the wet, with the ground falling away steep under him and the rain dripping off every branch he went under. His people were around him, ahead of him and on either side, spread out among the trunks, going fast and low and silent, the way he had taught every one of them to go. He could not see all of them. He did not need to.

He could see Daichi and Ayame.

They were ahead of him, a little to the left. Running side by side. And reading.

They had not stopped since the river. Three days. They read on the road and they read in the rain and they read in the dark, by feel, with the paper held close to their faces. They read at the halts. They read while they ate, and they did not eat much. He had not seen either of them sleep.

One word. Then the next. Then the next.

Faster than he had told anyone was safe. Faster than he had ever told anyone.

Daichi went down the slope in front of him with the scroll open in one hand and the other hand free, and his feet found the ground without looking for it. Every one of them. Down through the roots and the wet needles and the loose stones, at a run, reading, and not one step went wrong. He did not put out his free hand to a trunk. His body went where it went, and it went there before he had thought of going.

There was blood on his lip.

It had come out of his nose, some time in the night, and run down, and dried, and come again. It was coming now. A thin dark line from the left side, down over his mouth and his chin, and a drop going off his jaw now and then as he ran.

He did not wipe it. He did not notice it. His eyes were on the paper.

Ayame's eyes were not on anything.

They were on the paper, and then they were not. They went up off the scroll, and out, to the trees ahead, and moved. Trunk to trunk. Man to man. From one of their own people running through the pines to the next, and the next, and back, and out again to the gap in the trees where the slope opened, and back to the paper. And off it again. They did not stop anywhere. They did not settle. It was as if everything in front of her had become a board, and she could not stop counting the pieces, and every time she counted them they had moved.

Hanzō saw all of it.

He said nothing.

He had said it once, on the road, by the river, and the river had taken it. He did not say it again. He ran behind them down the slope, with his hands empty, and watched the blood come down Daichi's chin, and watched Ayame's eyes go around and around the trees, and did not say anything at all.

Kenshiro ran at his right shoulder.

He had been there since the river. He had not asked for anything, on the road, when the others took the scrolls. He had looked at the paper in their hands, once, and then at Hanzō, and then at the road, and had waited at the side of the road for Hanzō to come level, and walked where he was walking now. He did not read. He ran the way he had always run, the way Hanzō had taught him, and his eyes went where Hanzō's went, a moment after.

The trees were thinning. Below them, through the trunks, Hanzō could see the grey light of the open valley, and the green of the fields, and the banners.

He had known they would be there. He had stood on the bridge at Seta and watched them go by. They were his masters' banners. He had served under them all his life.

He saw a line of men at the edge of the fields turn, all together, and look up at the trees.

He saw the bows come up.

***

The captain of the bowmen had been told there would be Kōga in the hills.

He had been told it on the road, every day, since the bridge. Kōga in the hills. Hiding in the rocks and the trees, the way they did. Watch the slopes. They will come fast and they will come low and they will not show themselves until they are on you.

He watched the slopes.

He stood at the end of his line, at the edge of the rice, with the water standing in the fields behind him and the rain coming and going, and his thirty men in their rank with their bows held under their capes against the wet, and he watched the long wooded slope on the west side of the valley, the way he had been told.

The drum went. His line stood. Two companies over, the spearmen went forward a step, together, and stopped. It was right. Everything was right. Every man was where he had been put.

And there was something in the trees.

Shapes. Dark. Black or blue, in the rain he could not tell. Coming down the slope through the pines, fast, low, spread out, not on any path. He could not count them. They went between the trunks and were gone and were there again further down. They did not show themselves. They did not call out. They came the way he had been told Kōga would come.

He did not wait for an order. He had been told not to wait.

"Nock!"

The bows came out from under the capes, thirty of them all together, the way they had drilled it a thousand times in the yard at home. Arrows out of the quivers. Nocked.

"Loose!"

The arrows went up into the rain, all together, and came down into the trees.

***

Hanzō heard them coming.

He had heard that sound a long time ago, at a castle, when he was young. A great soft rushing, like a flight of birds going over. He knew what it was before he looked up.

"Down."

His people went down. All of them, at once, flat among the roots, the way they had gone down a thousand times on the floor of the long hall.

Not all of them. Not quite.

The arrows came through the pines, hissing, and struck. Into trunks. Into the earth. Into the wet needles, standing up out of them in rows. And into a man on Hanzō's right, one of the young ones, who had been a half step slower than the others going down, and went down now the rest of the way, and did not move again.

Daichi had not gone down.

Hanzō saw it. Daichi had not heard the word. Or his body had heard it and decided for itself. He was standing, still, in the middle of the slope with the arrows coming down all around him and the scroll open in his hand, and

he moved. A half step. A turn of the shoulder. An arrow went past his ear. Another into the ground where his foot had been. He did not look up. He did not stop reading.

Ayame was flat in the needles. Her eyes were open. They were going along the edge of the trees, and the line of bows at the edge of the fields, and back, and back, counting.

Kenshiro was flat beside him.

He had gone down before the word was finished. Before the arrows came. His face was in the needles a hand's breadth from Hanzō's, and his eyes were open, and they were not on the trees or the bows or the sky.

They were on Hanzō. Waiting to be told.

Another flight went up from the valley. Hanzō heard it go.

Below, at the edge of the rice, the bowmen were nocking again, together, all at one angle, exactly as they had been drilled. He could see the captain at the end of the line with his arm up. He could see the banner over them. He had knelt in front of men who carried that banner. He had carried their orders in his robe.

They thought he was Kōga.

He could have stood up. He could have gone out of the trees with his hands open and shown them his face and his papers, and the captain would have looked at it and lowered his arm. It would have taken a quarter of an hour. There was no quarter of an hour.

The second flight came down.

Hanzō lay in the wet needles with his cheek against the ground and his hands flat on the earth, and listened to it come, and understood that the square he had drawn his whole life had just drawn itself around him, and found him on the wrong side of it.

***

The second company had seen the lights.

Kikyo watched it happen from the top of the hill.

They had been standing in their rank below the lower slope, the second company of spearmen, to the right of the bowmen, on the drum, exactly where they had been put. And on the slope above them, among the rocks, a lantern had been burning. And another beyond it. And another. A line of little yellow lights in the grey, going up and along the slope to the north, away from the trees where the arrows were falling.

Their officer had seen the lights. He had looked at the trees where the bowmen were loosing, at the dark shapes gone down among the roots. And he had looked at the lanterns, going away north along the rocks. And he had done what he had been taught to do when the enemy runs.

The company turned. Right, all together, spears coming around at one angle. And went. Up onto the lower slope, along it, north, after the lanterns, at a trot, in good order, every foot where it should be, toward the rocks where there was nobody at all.

A gap opened behind them.

Between the bowmen and the next company along. Where they had been standing. Thirty paces of open ground at the edge of the fields, with nobody on it.

Kikyo looked at the gap.

Then she looked at the trees on the far side of the valley. The east side. The forest there came down almost to the river, dark and close, old cedars, and nothing had come out of it all morning.

The crow went around over it.

She did not move.

***

The Fūma had found them the evening after.

Standing. That was what none of them could stop seeing. Two of them standing, at the edge of the forest above the stream, in the grey light. The Manslayer on his feet with his hands on his sword, and his sword through Kotarō's neck and into the cedar, and Kotarō's sword through him. Neither of them fallen. As if they had stopped in the middle of saying something to each other, very close, and would go on saying it when the others had gone.

Nobody had gone near them for a long time.

Then someone had. And had taken Kotarō down from the tree. And the Manslayer had fallen then, at last, forward, onto his face in the bracken, and they had left him there.

There was nobody after Kotarō.

There had been Kagetora. There had been Raiun, and Shinmei. There were only the ones who were left, and there was nothing that told them where to go, and nothing that told them what to do when they got there.

They had never needed telling.

They had gone the long way around, in the dark. They came out of the forest on the east side of the valley in no shape at all, down through the old cedars toward the river, grey, not together, not apart. Nobody had called them. Nobody had set them down anywhere. Each of them had simply gone the way the ground went, and the ground went down, into the valley, toward the drums.

There was something in all of them that had not been there before.

It had no name. They would not have given it one. It sat low in them, in the chest, in the hands, heavy and hot. It came out in the way they moved: a little faster than they needed to, a little closer to the open than they should have been. It came out in the way none of them looked at each other. It was the thing that had made someone go up to the cedar in the end, and take Kotarō down, and let the Manslayer fall on his face. It had not let them bury him.

They came across the river at the ford below the bend. The water was high and brown and fast, to the waist, and they went through it without slowing. They came up the bank on the far side into the edge of the fields.

In front of them, across the rice, the long ranks of the shogun's men stood in the rain with their backs half turned, watching the trees on the other side of the valley where the arrows were going.

And in the ranks, a gap. Thirty paces. Nobody in it.

Nobody had to point at it.

They went in.

***

On the ridge to the south, Aoi stood in the wet grass with her father's spear in her hand and watched it all come apart.

She had watched it from the beginning. From the first grey light, when the banners came in on the north road. She had watched the ranks form on the drum, and the lanterns burn along the west slope where nobody was, and the shapes come down through the pines. She had watched the bows go up. She had watched the second company turn and go north after the lights, and the gap open behind it.

And she had watched the grey come out of the forest on the far side, across the river, and go into the gap.

She had seen them once before, in the forest, the tall one who was never where he was. She had heard the rest from Takeda. They did not come at you. They came at the spaces between you. They came at the gap, and made it wider, and in the space of a few breaths there was no longer a line of men standing at the edge of the fields. There were knots of men, pulled apart, turning, each one fighting something he could not see, and the grey going between them.

The drum stopped.

It started again, faster. Different. Somebody down there had seen what was happening and was trying to say so with the drum, and the ranks further along the field heard it and began to turn, all together, at one angle, toward

the sound. And as they turned, the grey were already somewhere else. And the bowmen were still loosing into the trees on the west slope, flight after flight, at whoever was lying flat in the needles there.

Nobody down there was fighting the battle they had come for.

Every one of them was doing exactly what they had been taught. The bowmen were loosing where they had been told the enemy would be. The spearmen were chasing where they had been told the enemy would run. Kōga's lights were burning where Kōga was not. And every one of those things was in the way of every other one, the way a hand gets in the way of a hand when two men try to catch the same falling thing.

Behind her, on the ridge, in a long line along the crest among the pines, Iga was waiting.

She could feel them there. She did not need to turn around. Takeda's men, and the ones who had come back from the hills with brush marks, and the young ones who had been old enough to hold a blade on the night the vault opened. They were waiting for her to move.

Beside her, Hayate was not waiting for anything.

He stood at the edge of the ridge with his bound arm across his chest and his good hand hanging open at his side. It did not hold anything. There was no blade in it, no needle, nothing. He had not reached for anything since they came up the ridge in the dark.

He was not watching the fight.

His eyes were going over the valley. Not at the banners. Not at the grey going through the gap, or the bows, or the trees. Over all of it. Slowly. Back and forth across the fields, and the river, and the raised paths between the rice, the way she had seen men go over a crowd in a market looking for one face.

She knew whose.

The spear was cold and wet in her hand. She closed her fingers on it until she could feel the grain of the shaft through the lacquer.

Hayate's eyes stopped.

She did not see what they had stopped on. She did not look. She watched his face instead. It did not do anything. It did not break, or open, or close. It only went very still, the way she had seen it go still once, in the pine wood, looking at a ring of stones.

His hand at his side closed. On nothing.

Aoi lifted the spear.

Behind her, along the whole crest of the ridge, she heard Iga come up off the ground.

She went down the slope into all of it.

***

Ren walked down the middle of the valley.

Along the raised paths between the rice. The paths were narrow and slick with the rain, a foot wide, the earth packed hard by a hundred years of feet, with the water standing flat on either side in the long fields and the young rice coming up green out of it in rows. The petals were here too. Somebody had carried them down on their sandals from the slopes, or the rain had, and they lay in the mud of the paths, pink and brown, and he walked on them.

He did not hide.

There was nowhere to hide, in the middle of a valley, on a path a foot wide between two fields of water. He did not look for anywhere.

He could feel all of it.

On his left, the west slope. Arrows going into the trees in flights, and men lying in the needles, and a man among them with his cheek on the ground who was listening to the arrows come. Two others among them. One standing among the falling arrows, moving without deciding to. One whose eyes would not stop.

On his right, toward the river, grey going through a gap in a line of men like water through a broken dike. Not together. Not apart. Angry. He could feel the anger in them from here, low and hot, and under it, nothing. No one telling them anything. No one at all.

High on his left, on the hill to the west, a woman standing very still, with lights burning all around her in places where nobody was.

Ahead of him, the drums. The ranks turning, all together, at one angle, toward whatever the drum was telling them, and the thing they were turning toward already gone.

And behind him, from the south, down the ridge, into all of it, a line of people coming fast through the wet grass. And at the front of them, one spear.

He did not look at any of it.

It was all there, the whole shape of it, every piece of it moving, and none of the pieces where anyone had put them. Nobody had put them anywhere. They had put themselves down, each one, in the place that had seemed right, and every place had been right, and every one of them was in every other one's way.

Nobody was in control of it.

He had felt it drawing in for days. From every side. The way water on a floor finds the low place. He was in the low place now. He had walked down into it on purpose, down the middle, along the path between the fields, where anyone could see him.

An arrow came down into the water of the field to his left, a long way off course, and stood up out of it, shivering.

He did not stop.

Overhead, the crow went around. Once. Over the fields and the banners and the river and the trees. And came back over him, and went around again.

In the middle of all of it, Ren kept walking.

Chapter 84

Disruption

He came to the end of the paddy path, where it met the road, and the battle was there.

It had come across the fields to meet him. Or he had walked into it. He could not have said which, and it did not matter. The rain had stopped again. The air was full of noise. Drums, and men shouting orders, and men shouting nothing, and somewhere the flat crack of a matchlock that had been kept dry long enough to fire, and then no more of them. The smell of wet earth and slow match and blood.

He knew it.

Not this place. He had never been here. But he knew it the way he knew a room he had lived in, in the dark. Where the walls were. Where the floor was uneven. Where something had been left lying that a man who did not know the room would put his foot on. It was all there, laid out, every piece of it where it was and every piece of it where it was going, and he walked into it the way he would have walked across that room. Without looking down.

He did not choose a side.

There were no sides. There were only the pieces, and the spaces between them, and the place he was going.

***

A line of spearmen held the road.

Thirty of them, perhaps. Two ranks, shoulder to shoulder, spears level, across the road where it came out between the fields, the way the drum had put them. They had not broken. Everything else around them had begun to come apart, the bowmen turning, the company that had gone north after the lights coming back in pieces, grey going through everything, and this line had not moved. Their officer stood at the end of it with his sword out and his face set, and the line held.

It was a good line. It was drilled. Every spear at one angle. Every man's shoulder against the next man's shoulder.

There was a gap in it.

Not a space. There was no space. The shoulders touched all along it. But the fourth man from the left in the front rank had a sandal that had come loose in the mud, and every time the drum went and the line leaned into it, he leaned a little late, because of the sandal. And the man beside him leaned on time. And for the space of the drum's beat, between the one and the other, there was a place where two shoulders were not quite together.

The line did not know it was there. The officer did not know. The man with the sandal did not know.

Ren walked toward it.

Not fast. Along the middle of the road, straight at the spears, with his swords at his hip and his hands at his sides. Some of them saw him come. The spears in front of him came around a little, toward him, and the men behind them set their feet. The officer shouted something.

The drum went.

The line leaned into it. The man with the sandal leaned late.

Ren went through.

He did not push. He did not cut. He turned his shoulder a quarter and went through the place between the fourth man and the fifth in the moment it was there, and through the second rank behind them the same way, where a man had turned his head at the officer's shout. And he was out behind the line, on the road, walking.

Behind him the line tried to turn.

All of it, together, on the officer's shout, toward the place he had gone. And the men on the left turned left, and the men on the right turned right, because that was the shortest way around for each of them. And they met in the middle. Spears crossed. Shafts caught on shafts. Men who had stood shoulder to shoulder all morning were suddenly face to face, and stepped back from each other, and trod on the feet of the rank behind. The line folded in on itself like a sheet of paper with a hand closed on it.

He did not look back.

***

The road went up a little, between a wall of stacked stones and the slope of the hill. There were rocks there, and scrub, and a lantern burning in a cleft of the rock, small and yellow in the grey.

Then another, further up. And voices.

From the left. From up among the rocks. Two men, three, calling to each other, low and urgent, the way men call when they are closing on something. *Here. There. Go around.* Moving up the slope, away, toward the lanterns.

He did not look at the lanterns.

He did not look at the voices. They were not there. There was nobody on the left. There was a lantern that somebody had hung and left, and a boy crouched in the rocks behind it with his hands cupped around his mouth, throwing his voice up the slope and making it sound like three.

Ren was already facing right.

The man came out of the scrub on the right, low, from behind the stacked stones, where a man who had turned to the voices would have had his back. A short blade. Very fast. A good cut, a quiet one, meant to go in under the ribs from behind.

Ren was not behind. He was in front of it. He had been in front of it since before the man moved.

He put his hand on the man's wrist.

Not hard. The way you put your hand on a door that is already swinging. The blade went past him. The man went with it, the whole of him, all the speed he had put into it going on without anywhere to go, past Ren and off the edge of the road and down into the flooded field below, face first, into the water and the young rice.

Ren walked on.

Up in the rocks, the voices had stopped.

***

Around the shoulder of the hill, the road came out onto open ground above the river.

And there were two of them coming.

From the left, down off the slope, out of the rocks: Kōga. Eight, ten. Dark blue, low, spread out, fast. From the right, up from the river road: a Tokugawa company, spearmen, in a column of twos, at a trot, with an officer at the front on foot. They could not see each other. There was a knoll between them, a hump of ground with a single pine on it. In the space of thirty breaths they would come around either side of it and meet.

He could see the meeting. He could see it the way he could see the next move on a board. They would meet at the foot of the pine. The Kōga would go at the column's flank. The column would turn. There would be a short hard fight and then the Kōga would scatter, the way they did now, back into the rocks, and the column would reform, and go on.

He walked out between them.

Onto the open ground in front of the pine. Where both of them, coming around the knoll, would see him first.

They saw him.

The Kōga saw him from the left and turned toward him, all of them, together. The column saw him from the right, and the officer at its front shouted, and the spears came down. Both of them coming at the same thing. At him. From both sides at once, faster than they had been coming at each other, because now there was something to come at.

He walked on. Across the open ground, past the pine, and out the far side.

And they were already running. Neither of them could stop. They came around the knoll at a run, from either side, at the place where he had been, and he was not there, and what was there was each other.

They went into each other at full speed.

He heard it behind him. Not a fight. Worse than a fight. A collision. Spears going into men who had not known there were men there. Men going down under the rush of men behind them. The officer's shout going up and breaking. The Kōga, who never stood, standing, because there was nowhere to go that was not a spear.

It was harder than it would have been. Much harder. He had not made it happen. He had only walked through the middle of it. Everything had done the rest.

He did not look back at that either.

***

He was not trying to break anything.

He knew that. He had known it all morning. He was not cutting. He had not drawn. He was only walking, toward the place he needed to be, the low place, the middle, and taking the shortest way there. And the shortest way went through things. Through lines. Between companies. Past the blades that had been meant for somebody else's back.

And wherever he went through, the thing he went through fell apart.

Not because of him. Because of itself. Every one of them had been built to meet something that would meet it back. A line to meet a line. A decoy to meet a man who would turn to it. A column to meet a charge. He did not meet anything. He went through, and the thing that had been built to push against something found nothing to push against, and fell over.

It was very quiet, in him, while it happened.

***

They came out of the smoke from a burning shelter on the edge of the field.

Two of them. Fast. Faster than he had ever seen them go. He had seen them go in the square, in the long hall, on the threshing floor, a hundred mornings in the grey, and they had been fast then, and this was not that. This was something else. They came across the wet ground toward him the way water comes down a slope, and their feet did not seem to touch it.

Daichi. Ayame.

He stopped.

They stopped. Five paces off. Both of them.

Daichi's face was grey. There was blood down it from his nose, dried, and fresh over the dried, over his mouth and his chin and down the front of his robe. He did not seem to know it was there. His sword was out. His other hand was empty, and there was something in the front of his robe, rolled, pressing against it.

Ayame beside him. Her sword low. Her face was very white. And her eyes.

Her eyes were going. Over him, and off him, and to the left of him, and to the right, and back, and never stopping. As if she were looking at a board and could not find the piece she wanted on it, and every time she looked it had moved.

Daichi looked at him.

"For Jin," said Daichi.

Ren looked at their eyes.

He knew eyes like those.

He had seen them in the river. In the grey, at the water's edge, on his knees on the cold stones, with his hands wet, looking down. His own face, dark on the dark water. And his hand coming up, and the hand in the water coming up after. Less than a breath. And his own eyes, looking up at him out of the river, going and going and not able to stop.

He had read by the river, alone, with the moon going in and out. And it had done that.

They had gone further than he had.

He could see it. He could see exactly how far down in them it had gone, and what was left above it. Not much. In Daichi, almost nothing. The body, and the blade, and two words, and under the two words, Jin.

They came.

Together. The way they had come in the square a thousand times, one high and one low, one from the left and one from the right, the spaces between them measured to the width of a hand.

Daichi was first.

His body went before he did. Ren saw it. The feet moving, the hips turning, the blade already coming, and behind it, a long way behind, Daichi. His eyes arriving where his body had already gone. It was fast. It was the fastest Ren had ever seen a man move. And there was nobody driving it. It went where it went because that was where a body went when a sword was coming at it, and a body that goes where a body goes is a body that anyone can find.

Ayame, from the right. Her blade came in hard and clean and sure.

At the wrong one.

She had cut where he had to be. He saw her see it: the square, the spaces, the one place a man could stand when one came high and one came low. Her blade went to it, to the left of him, where he was not, where he had never been. It went through the air a pace from him, very fast, very certain, and her face as it went was the face of someone who has found the piece at last.

Ren stepped in.

One exchange.

Daichi's blade came where Daichi's body had sent it. Ren was not there. He was inside it, where Daichi's body had not known to look, because it did not know anything, it only went. And Ren's right sword came out of its scabbard, the first time that morning, and went once, across, and Ren stepped past.

Clean.

Behind him, Daichi stood a moment longer, the way a man stands after a thing has already happened to him and he has not caught up with it. His sword went out of his hand into the mud. Then he went down after it. On his side. In the wet grass at the edge of the field.

He did not say anything else.

Ren turned to Ayame.

She was still coming. Her blade was coming around again, from the empty place on the left where she had cut, toward another empty place. Her feet were moving. Her eyes were going.

Then she stopped.

All at once. The blade stopped in the air, and her feet stopped under her, and she stood there in the wet with her sword out to the side, pointed at nothing.

Blood came from her nose.

A line of it, dark, fast, down over her lip and her chin. She did not lift a hand to it.

She was not looking at him.

She was looking past him, over his shoulder, at the field, at the air, at something there. Something that was not there. Her eyes had stopped going. They had found what they were looking for, and it was not anything he could see, and they stayed on it.

Her sword went down. Slowly. The point into the mud.

She went down after it. Onto her knees. In the wet, with her hands open at her sides and the blood on her face, looking at the thing that was not there.

Ren stood over her.

He did not raise his sword. He did not touch her. There was nothing to do. He had not done this. The scroll had done it. It had gone into her, and kept going, further than anything could go into anyone and leave them standing, and now it was all the way down, and there was nothing left above it.

There had been nothing in her to stop it.

He knew what it did. He did not know why.

Something fell from the front of her robe.

Rolled. Tied. It came loose as she knelt, and slipped, and fell into the mud by her knee, and lay there.

On the grass behind him, where Daichi lay on his side, the other one had come out too. Out of the front of his robe as he went down. In its roll. Half in a puddle, the water going slowly into the paper.

Two scrolls. In the mud.

Ren looked at them.

He had carried one of them against his ribs, once, all the way from Iga, and read it in front of a fire, and given it away on a hillside. The other he had never touched. He had gone into a hall full of smoke for it, and stood four paces from it, and turned his back.

They lay in the mud. The rain began again, lightly, and fell on them.

He looked at them a long time.

Then he stepped past them.

Past Ayame on her knees. Past Daichi in the grass. Out onto the open ground, toward the middle of the valley, where he needed to be.

He did not pick them up.

He kept walking.

Chapter 85

Arrows

The arrows had stopped.

Hanzō did not know when. He had been lying with his cheek in the wet needles, listening for the next flight, and it had not come, and after a while he understood that it was not going to. Below, at the edge of the rice, the bowmen had turned. Something had come into them from the other side. He could hear it from the slope. Men shouting who had been drilled not to shout.

He stood up.

Kenshiro stood up beside him. Around them, one by one, his people got up out of the needles, and looked at him, and waited. The young one on his right did not get up.

Daichi and Ayame were gone.

He had not seen them go. He had been lying with his face in the ground, and they had not been, and when the arrows stopped they had gone on down the slope, reading, into whatever was at the bottom of it. He knew which way. He did not need to see it. He knew where a body goes when it no longer waits to be told.

He went down after them.

***

At the edge of the trees, he stopped.

The valley was in front of him. All of it. The fields and the river and the road and the knoll with the single pine, and the rain coming and going over it in grey curtains, and the smoke of a burning shelter lying low along the ground.

He looked at it.

He had looked at a great many fields. He had stood on ridges above them, and in the towers of castles, and on the tops of walls, and he had looked down, and the field had always told him what it was. A battle had a shape. It had it the way a body has bones. Where the weight was. Where it was leaning. Where it would give. You looked, and it came up out of the confusion to meet you, the lines of it, the way a face comes up out of the grain of a board if you look long enough.

He had spent his life learning to see it. It was the first thing the Bansenshūkai taught, and the last, and everything written between.

He looked.

There was no shape.

There were men. There were a great many men. Tokugawa spearmen in knots of five and six, facing different ways, their banners going down and coming up again in the wrong places. Kōga, where Kōga should not have been, out in the open, standing, which Kōga never did. Grey going through both of them like smoke through a lattice, and never where either of them turned. And down off the ridge to the south, coming fast through the wet grass, a line of people with a spear at the front of it, going into all of it.

And bodies. Everywhere. In the rice. On the road. Along the edge of the river. Lying where they had fallen, in every direction, facing every way.

He waited for the line that joined them.

It did not come.

He had never been afraid on a field. He had been afraid of other things. Of a letter. Of a face across a table. Of Yukino, once, a long time ago, before he knew her. But never of a field. A field was the one place in the world where he knew what everything was.

He did not know what this was.

His face did not change. His hands stayed in his sleeves. Beside him, Kenshiro was looking at him, and he knew what Kenshiro saw, because he had made sure of it for thirty years. Nothing. A man looking at a field.

He went on down.

***

He found them at the edge of a field, below the burning shelter, where the smoke lay along the grass.

Daichi was on his side in the wet.

One cut. Hanzō did not need to turn him over to know it. He could see it from the way he lay. Across, and out, and nothing more. The cleanest thing on the field. Daichi's sword was in the mud beside him where it had fallen out of his hand, and his face was turned a little toward the ground, and the blood from his nose had run down over his mouth and his chin and dried there, and new blood had not come after it.

Ayame was a little way off.

She had gone down on her knees, and then further, onto her side, in the mud at the edge of the field, with her knees still drawn up under her. Her sword was near her hand. Her hand was open.

She was breathing.

Barely. He could see it in her back, a very little, and then a long time, and then a very little. The blood had come from her nose and run down over her mouth and her chin and dried there.

Her eyes were open.

They were not moving anymore. They had been moving for three days, around and around, counting, never settling. They had settled now. They were looking at something a little above the grass, a little to the left of where he stood, very steadily. Something that was not there.

Hanzō knelt.

In the mud, between the two of them. Kenshiro stopped a pace behind him and did not come closer.

They were in the mud. Both of them. The one that had come off Daichi when he fell, half in a puddle, the water gone into the edge of it and darkened it. And the other by Ayame's knee. His. Rolled loosely, the way it had been unrolled and rolled on a run, the cord hanging.

He picked them up.

One and then the other. He wiped them on his sleeve, the mud off the paper, carefully, the way you wipe a child's face. He could not get it all off. There would be a stain on the Ninpiden where the water had gone in. There would be mud in the grain of his own for as long as it lasted.

He put them into his robe.

Against his ribs. One against the other. Heavier than paper should be.

Then he looked at Ayame.

***

He knew what was behind her eyes.

He knew exactly. He could have told anyone who asked what she was looking at, a little above the grass. She was looking at the board. The whole of it, every piece, every line, where every piece would go and what it was worth and which of them could be spent, laid out in front of her so clearly that there was no room left anywhere for anything else. Not her own hands. Not the rain. Not him.

It was at the bottom of the scroll. It had always been at the bottom. He had been walking toward it for thirty years, one word at a time, slowly enough that he could learn each step before he took the next. Slowly enough that he could still get up in the morning and eat his rice and look at his wife across the hearth, and see her, most of the time.

Ayame had gotten there in three days.

He had told Yukino. By the fire, with the candle, the only time in his life he had said it aloud. What it sharpened. What it took. How a man began to see people as outcomes. How one day he realized he no longer felt anything when he chose them.

He had never told them.

He had told them two words, on a road, by a loud river. He had not told them why. He had knelt in front of the empty box and felt the scrolls against his ribs and let Daichi bow and go. He had held the scrolls out on the road and let their hands close on them. He had watched them read, and walked behind them, and said nothing, for three days.

He put out his hand.

Two fingers. He laid them on her eyelids, one and then the other, and drew them down.

They closed.

It did not do anything. Her eyes would go on looking at the board behind the lids. Her breath would go on, a very little, and then a long time, until it did not. Nobody would see her face on the field. Nobody would stop because her eyes were open. There was no reason for it at all.

He took his hand away.

It was the first thing he had done in years that served no purpose. He knew that as he did it. He looked at his two fingers, with the rain on them, and thought about it, and could not remember the last time.

Behind him, Kenshiro had not moved.

***

Hanzō stood up.

He turned to the valley.

He looked at it the way he had looked at it from the edge of the trees. He gave it time. He let his eyes go out of focus, a little, the way he had taught himself as a boy, so that the pieces stopped being men and became only weight and direction, and waited for it to come up out of the grain.

It always came.

Every battle had a shape. Every crowd had a pattern. Every man had a way he broke. He had never in his life looked at a thing long enough and not found it. It was not a skill. It was what he was.

He waited.

Tokugawa ranks, tangled. A company of spears going one way and its own banner going the other. Kōga in the open, in twos and threes, among the Tokugawa, fighting them hand to hand, which Kōga had never once done in all the years he had watched them. The grey going through both, not together, not apart, and never where either of them was looking. Iga coming off the ridge into the south end of the fields and meeting the grey, and the grey not being there.

Bodies. Everywhere. And no line between any of them.

Nothing came.

And through the middle of it, one path.

Not a path. There was nothing there to see. There was no one walking it that he could see, from here, through the smoke and the rain. But he could see where it went. He could see it by what was on either side of it. A spear line folded in on itself like a closed hand. A man face down in a flooded field. A knot of Kōga and Tokugawa at the foot

of a pine, torn into each other. A shelter burning. Daichi. Ayame. Going down the valley, one after another, the places where things had come apart, in a line.

It was the only line on the field.

Ren.

Hanzō looked at it for a long time.

He did not feel the thing go out of him that he had thought, for most of his life, he would feel on the day this happened. He had imagined this day. Not often. A few times, late, with the lamp out. He had thought it would be like falling. He had thought the floor would go.

It was not like that.

It was like setting down something he had been carrying for a very long time, and finding that his arms did not know what to do without it.

The system could not hold this.

It never could. He saw that now, quite clearly, standing in the mud with the rain on his face. It had never been able to hold everything. It had only never met anything large enough to show him where it stopped. He had drawn his squares on smaller and smaller floors, and filled them with better and better people, and they had held, and he had believed that was because the squares were right. It was because the floors were small.

This was not a small floor.

He did not panic. He had not panicked in thirty years and he did not know how to begin. He only stood, and looked, and let it be true. Quietly. The way he let everything be true. The way he had let the boy walk off the fifth mark into the grass.

It would go on. The system. He would still see weight and direction. He would still see where men would step. He would still know, most of the time, what came next. He could not unread what he had read.

He would only never be certain again.

He put his hand into his sleeve.

The stone was there. He had carried it since Seta. A white stone, from the set he had used all his life, smooth, the size of a thumb joint. It had stood on the map in the middle of everything, in the ring of all the others, where the lines were going. He had picked it up off the map in the room above the bridge at Seta, and he had not been able to put it down, and he had put it in his sleeve instead.

He took it out.

He looked at it on his palm. White, with the rain on it.

Then he bent, and set it down in the mud at the edge of the field, beside Ayame's open hand. Not on anything. Not anywhere. On the ground.

He straightened.

Kenshiro was looking at him.

Hanzō looked back at him, once. Then at Ayame. Then back.

Kenshiro understood. He came forward the pace he had not come, and knelt in the mud beside her, and did not look at the valley.

Hanzō turned.

He walked out onto the open ground, into the smoke, toward the only line on the field.

Chapter 86

The Demon

Hayate hit a man with his elbow.

He did not know whose man. It did not matter. The man had come at him out of the smoke with a spear, a Tokugawa spear, a long straight one with a banner-man's sash on the fellow who held it, and Hayate had gone in under the point the way you go in under a low branch, and put his elbow into the man's throat, and the man sat down in the rice.

"Sorry," said Hayate. "Didn't have a hand free."

He did not. His right arm was bound across his chest where it had been bound since Iga, two fingers of it working and the rest not, and his left hand had a short blade in it that he had taken off a dead Kōga man on the way down the ridge. He did not know the blade. It was too heavy at the tip. He was using it anyway.

Something grey came at him from the left.

He did not see it come. Nobody ever saw them come. He saw the rice move, and the rain move, and he threw himself sideways into the flooded field because that was the stupidest thing to do, and the grey blade went through the place where he had been standing. He came up out of the water soaked to the neck, spitting, and the Fūma was already somewhere else, and Hayate threw a handful of mud at where he thought the Fūma would be, and missed, and laughed.

"Fine. Fine. Next time."

A Kōga man went past him at a run, low, and turned, and saw Hayate, and saw the Iga people coming down the field behind him, and made a decision about which of them Hayate was. Hayate saw him make it. He kicked the man's knee sideways as he came in and the man went down into the same water Hayate had just gotten out of.

"Not Iga," Hayate told him. "Not anything. Just in the way."

He did not wait to see if the man got up.

He looked for Ren.

He had been looking for Ren since the ridge. Every time there was a breath. Every time a man went down in front of him and the next one had not arrived yet. He looked up, and out, across the field, over the heads and the spears and the smoke, and found him, and looked back down in time to get out of the way of whatever was coming.

There. On the open ground past the burning shelter. Walking.

Still walking. Not hurrying. The smoke went across him and he came out of it, and a knot of men broke apart around him like water around a post, and he came out of that too. Everything around him was running and falling and turning, and Ren walked through the middle of it as if it were a road on a quiet morning.

Hayate got hit.

In the side, by something, a shaft, a pommel, he did not see what. He went down on one knee in the mud. He came up swinging the heavy blade, and it hit something, and he did not look to see what it had hit.

He looked for Ren again.

Ren had stopped.

He was standing on the open ground, in the rain, with his hands at his sides. And in front of him, ten paces off, a man was standing too. Not tall. Not young. Hands in his sleeves. A plain dark robe, wet through. Standing in the middle of a battle as if he were waiting for a ferry.

Hayate knew him.

He had seen him on a hillside once, above a burning valley, taking a scroll out of Ren's hand without looking at it. He had seen him bow the way a man bows across a board when the game is finished.

"Oh, no," said Hayate.

He started to run.

***

Hanzō took his hands out of his sleeves.

The boy was ten paces off. The rain was coming down between them, lightly, the way it had been coming all morning. The noise of the field went on all around them and neither of them looked at it.

He had not seen the boy for a month. Not since the long hall, and the smoke coming down through the slats, and the boy turning his back on the box. He was thinner. There were more cuts on him, healed and healing. His eyes were the same.

Hanzō drew.

He did it slowly. There was no reason to do it fast. The boy watched the blade come out, the whole length of it, and did not move until the point was clear. Then he drew too. Both swords. The same speed. Not faster. Not slower. As if he had been shown how by the man in front of him.

They stood.

Then they began.

***

It was the cleanest thing Hanzō had ever done.

He knew it while it was happening. He had fought a great many men. He had fought them in rooms and on roofs and in the dark, and every one of them, sooner or later, had given him something. A weight a little too far forward. A breath taken at the wrong time. An eye going to the place the blade was about to go. He had read it, and gone there first, and that had been the end of it.

The boy gave him nothing.

Hanzō read him anyway. He read the feet, the hips, the shoulders, the angle of the left blade against the right. He read where the boy would be. And the boy was there. And Hanzō was there already, to meet him. And the boy was not surprised. He had read that Hanzō would be there. He was already turning it.

Hanzō turned it back.

Cut, and met. Step, and closed. Every door the boy opened, Hanzō was standing in it. Every door Hanzō opened, the boy had already shut. They went around each other on the wet ground in the rain, very close, very fast, and nothing got through, from either side. Not once.

It was like playing a game against himself.

Against the man he had been. Before the long hall. Before the valley. When the board had been small enough to see all of it.

He did not gain anything. Neither did the boy. They went apart, three paces, and stood, breathing, and looked at each other. And came in again. And it was the same. Every movement read. Every movement answered. It was as if somebody had drawn a line down the middle of the field and set them on either side of it, exactly even, and it could have gone on until the sun went down, and neither of them would ever have crossed it.

The system had met its equal.

Hanzō understood that, going around the boy in the rain. He had spent thirty years making himself into the thing that could see everything. And here, in front of him, was the other one. The only other one.

It was very quiet, inside that.

Then Hanzō stopped reading.

***

Ren did not see it happen.

That was the first thing. He was reading the man the way he had read him since the first cut. The feet, the weight, the line of the blade. The doors, one behind the other, and Hanzō behind each of them, meeting him, the way he had been meeting him since they began.

And then there were no doors.

Not closed. Not empty. There were no doors at all. The man in front of him was not going anywhere. He was not coming from anywhere. He was just there, all of him, at once, in every place Ren's blades were going, and in every place they were not going yet, and in the places in between.

Ren cut.

The blade was met before it began. Not blocked. Met. As if the man had put his sword there a long time ago and waited for Ren's to arrive.

Ren went left. Hanzō was there.

Right. There.

Low, the turn, the two swords together and apart, the thing that had come out of him over the winter, all of it, everything he had. And everywhere he went, the man had already been standing, for a long time, patiently, like a wall that has been in the same place for a hundred years.

He had heard the name once.

On a road, in a teahouse, from a carter who had lowered his voice to say it, and looked around as he said it. *The Demon.* He had not thought about it. He had thought it was the kind of thing carters said.

It was not.

The man did not move like anything Ren had fought. Not like the grey ones, who were never where they were. Not like Raiden, who was always exactly where he was, and heavy with it. Not like Aoi, not like the square. Hanzō moved like the ground moves. Like the weather. Like something that did not need to decide anything, because it had already decided everything, a long time ago, and was only now arriving.

Ren's left sword went.

He did not see how. His wrist was there, and then there was a weight on it, and then there was nothing in his left hand, and the sword was turning over in the rain somewhere off to the side.

He went back.

Hanzō came with him. Not fast. Not slow. Every step Ren took backward, Hanzō took one forward, the same length, the same moment, so that the distance between them did not change at all. As if they were tied.

Ren's heel found the edge of a paddy wall.

He had not known it was there. He always knew. He always knew where everything was.

He went over it.

Onto his back. Into the mud of the field, with the water coming in around him, cold, and the sky over him grey, with the rain coming down out of it into his eyes.

Hanzō stood on the wall above him.

His sword was low. The point toward Ren's throat. Not touching. It did not need to. The rain ran off the end of it in a thin line and fell on Ren's collar.

Hanzō looked down at him.

"If you win," said Hanzō, "everything will burn until it's ashes."

***

Ashes.

The word went into him and did not stop.

Ash on the road. A skin of it, grey and soft and smooth over everything, over the step stones and the water barrels and the shapes in the doorways, so smooth his feet left marks in it. Ash that was hot underneath. Ash in his mouth, the taste of it, burned straw and burned wood and something under that. A hand by the well, holding a ladle. A village, under a shelf of smoke that did not move.

Ash.

And ash in a ring of stones.

In the cave. In the morning. The fire burning in its ring, clean, new, the wood pale at the ends. And no ash in it. There had never been any ash in it. Not one morning in eleven years. He had woken, every morning, to a fire already burning, and the stones around it swept, and the old man sitting in front of it with his hands on his knees.

He had never seen the ash while the old man lived.

He had never once thought about where it went.

Somewhere out on the field, somebody was shouting.

"Ren!"

He knew the voice.

"Ren! Up! Again!"

***

It went through him.

He had heard it before. Ten thousand times. In the clearing, with his legs shaking. On the path, with the bucket. By the fire, with the whetstone going. He had heard it in his own voice, in the woods, in the snow, and it had gone out of him into the trees and been only a sound, with nobody standing behind it.

This was not that.

For a moment, less than a breath, there was somebody standing behind it.

A road. At the end of a day. The sun going down behind a man in the road, directly behind his head, so that his face was dark and the light came around the edges of him and made a burning line of him against the sky. And the man looking down at him in the mud. *Up.*

A bench. At the mouth of a cave. A man on it with a rod across his knees and a piece of wood in his hands and the knife not moving, and his eyes. On him. Only on him. Every morning. Watching him go through the forms in the clearing, and seeing everything, and saying nothing that did not need saying. *Again.*

And the fire.

He saw it. He had never seen it. He saw it anyway.

The cave, black, before the birds. A man getting up in the dark while a boy slept. His knees stiff with the cold. Kneeling at the ring of stones. Gathering the ash from last night's fire in his two hands, warm underneath, soft, clinging to the hair on his wrists. Carrying it out to the edge of the ledge in his cupped palms, and opening his hands, and letting the dark take it. Going back for the rest. Three trips. Sweeping the stones bare.

Every morning. Eleven years.

So that when the boy woke, there would only be the fire.

Ren lay in the water with the rain coming into his eyes.

The old man's face was there. Just for a moment. Not on the road, not on the bench. Only his face. Looking at him. The way it had looked at him across the fire on the first night, when he could not lift the cup.

Then it was gone.

Ren got up.

***

Hanzō stepped back off the wall.

He did not know why. He had the boy on his back in the water with a sword at his throat, and he stepped back, one pace, onto the open ground, and let him get up.

The boy came up out of the field.

Slowly. Water going off him. His right sword still in his hand. He stood on the paddy wall where Hanzō had stood, and looked at Hanzō, and Hanzō looked at his eyes.

He had looked into them on a cedar slope, with the boy on his back in the leaves. He had seen something going away. As if someone had been standing in a doorway, and had stepped back into the dark behind it.

He looked now.

The doorway was still dark.

But there was someone in it.

Not all the way. Not in the light. At the back, where the dark was deepest, standing. Looking out.

Hanzō raised his sword.

The boy came down off the wall. He did not pick up his other blade. He came in with the one.

And it was close again. Closer than before. Closer than anything Hanzō had ever fought. Every cut met, every step answered, and something else in it now, something that had not been there in the first exchange, that Hanzō could not read, because it was not in the feet or the weight or the line of the blade.

It was behind the eyes.

It was standing in the doorway, and it was looking at him.

Chapter 87

The Eyes

Aoi turned the spear and the man went down.

She did not look at what he was. Tokugawa, by the lacquer on his hat. It did not matter. He had come at her, and she had turned, the whole of her body coming around behind the shaft the way her father had taught her on the training ground by the stream, and the butt of the spear had taken his legs and the head had come around after, and he was in the mud.

Another. Grey. From the left, where there had been nobody.

She did not look for him. She had learned that, in the forest, when the Fūma came. You did not look for them. You made a circle with the spear, wide, the whole length of it, and whatever was inside the circle when it came around was inside it. The shaft struck something. The something was not there anymore.

She looked for Ren.

She had not meant to. Her eyes went. Across the field, over the heads, through the rain, to the open ground past the burning shelter. The way they had gone to the training ground in the grey before anyone came, the whole of one summer, before she had let herself know why.

He was there.

Not walking now. Fighting. And the man in front of him was not like anything she had seen him fight. A man in a plain dark robe, not young, with one sword, and his feet moving on the wet ground as if they had been moving there for a hundred years. The two of them very close. Going around each other. Nothing getting through.

A Kōga blade came in under her guard.

She turned it with the shaft, late, and felt it open her sleeve and the skin under it, and put the butt of the spear into the man's chest and put him down. She did not look to see if he got up.

She looked for Ren.

He was down.

On his back, in a field, in the water. The man in the dark robe standing over him on the wall of the paddy with his sword low. And she stopped. In the middle of everything. With the spear across her body and the rain on her face and men going past her on both sides. She could not move.

She heard Hayate shout. Somewhere to her right. The words went out across the field and she did not hear what they were.

And Ren got up.

She saw him come up out of the water. Slowly. She saw the man in the dark robe step back from the wall and let him. She did not understand why the man had done that. She did not understand anything about it. She only saw Ren standing on the paddy wall with one sword, and the rain going off him, and she started to walk.

Toward them.

Through everything. Her spear going around her, wide, and men going down or going away. She did not decide it. Her feet did it. The way they had once gone, before a fight, to the place where he was going to be.

***

They had not stopped looking at each other.

Hanzō knew it the way he knew the weight of his own sword. Since the first cut. Since before it, since they stood ten paces apart in the rain and drew at the same speed. The boy's eyes on his. His on the boy's. Every step, every turn, every exchange, their eyes had met in the same place, exactly, the way two blades meet.

It was how he read him. It was how the boy read Hanzō.

You could not look away. Not for the space of a breath. The moment you looked away you were reading half of him, and half was not enough, and the other half would kill you.

So they looked.

They went around each other on the open ground with the rain coming down, very close, one sword each now, and neither of them looked at anything but the other one's eyes. The boy's were not the same as they had been at the start. There was something in them now. Standing in the dark at the back. Looking out. Hanzō could not read it, and it did not change anything the boy's feet did, and so for a while it did not matter.

It was still even. Every cut met. Every step answered.

Hanzō took a step.

An extra one. The kind he took ten times in a fight without thinking. Forward and to the left, half a pace further than the exchange needed, to close a door the boy had not opened yet. It put him a little off the line.

The boy's eyes did not move.

They stayed where they had been. On the place where Hanzō's eyes had been, a half pace ago.

And Hanzō was not there anymore.

***

Ren's eyes went past him.

Over Hanzō's shoulder. Through the rain. Across the open ground, and the dead lying in it, and the smoke from the shelter going low along the grass. To a long way off.

To her.

She was standing on the open ground behind Hanzō. Forty paces. More. With a spear in her hands, upright, the butt on the ground and the head going up past her shoulder. Her sleeve was torn and there was blood on her arm. The rain was on her face.

She was looking at him.

Not at the fight. Not at Hanzō. At him. The way she had looked at him across a fire once, a long time ago, with the rain outside.

Winning won't solve anything.

The cave.

The rain, a grey wall across the mouth of it, so loud it filled everything. The fire he had made, in the ring of stones, two strikes. Her across it, with her hands held out to the warmth and the water running out of her hair. The web in the corner of the rock, lit up red and gold, and the spider in the middle of it, not moving.

I only know winning, he had said.

He had looked at the fire a moment too long. He remembered that now. He had not known it then. He had looked at the fire, and the smile had gone off his face, and he had said it, and it had been true.

And she had looked down from the web and across the fire and said it back to him, the other way.

Winning won't solve anything.

He had not understood it.

He had heard it. He had kept it. It had been somewhere in him the whole time, all through the winter and the snow and the notch and the hall full of smoke, the way a stone stays at the bottom of a river. He had never once taken it out and looked at it.

He did now.

Hanzō's sword was coming. From the left, from where Hanzō had stepped to, low, rising.

Ren met it.

Not the way he had met every cut since the beginning. Not in the one place, the only place, the shortest way. He met it a little early. He did not know why. He took a breath first. A whole breath, in and out, that there was no

time for, that did nothing, that served no purpose. And the cut arrived, and he was there, a hair to the side of where he should have been, and it went past.

He did not understand it.

He did it again.

An extra step. Past where the step should have ended. A little further, onto the wet ground, as if he wanted to feel it under his foot. Hanzō's blade went to where the step should have ended and Ren was not there.

An extra movement. His shoulder, turning, when it did not need to turn. The blade following it, when it did not need to follow.

One less movement. The next cut, he did not answer. He let it come. He did not go to meet it. He let it go by him in the rain a finger's width from his ribs, and did nothing at all.

He was not reading.

He was reading. He could not stop. It was all still there, the doors and the rooms and the pieces on the board. But there was something else now, on top of it, that did not come from the board. It came from somewhere else. From a cave, and a fire, and a road with the sun going down behind a man in it. From a girl with the rain running out of her hair.

It did not make sense.

It did not need to.

He began to go faster. Not faster. More. Every exchange a little more, a little further past where the system ended. An extra breath. An extra step. A cut that went a little further than it needed to, and came back a little slower. A stillness where there should have been a movement. A movement where there should have been nothing.

Hanzō met the first of them.

He met the second.

He did not meet the third.

***

Hanzō did not know what he was looking at.

He had stopped reading. He had gone past reading, into the place where there were no doors, where he did not decide anything because it had been decided long ago. He had put the boy on his back in the water from there.

He was still there.

And the boy was somewhere else.

Not in the doors. Not in the place past the doors, where Hanzō was. Somewhere Hanzō had never been. Somewhere the Bansenshūkai had never gone, because there was nothing there to write down.

The boy took a breath that did nothing.

Hanzō's blade went to where the boy would be after that breath, if the breath had been for anything. The boy was not there. He had taken it for nothing, and so he was somewhere else.

The boy took a step too far.

Hanzō's blade went where the step should have ended.

The boy turned his shoulder, for no reason.

Hanzō could not follow it. There was nothing to follow. Every one of the things the boy was doing was a thing that served no purpose, and Hanzō had spent thirty years cutting away everything in himself that served no purpose, one word at a time, until there was nothing left in him that could see it.

He had closed Ayame's eyes with two fingers, an hour ago, in the mud.

He had not known then what it was.

The boy's sword came in. Hanzō met it. It went on past the meeting, a little further than any cut had ever gone, and came back slower, and it was not where he had met it anymore, and it went across his forearm.

He went back.

A step. He had not gone back in the whole fight. He went back.

The boy came after him. Not the way Hanzō had come after the boy, the same length, the same moment, as if they were tied. The boy came after him any way at all. A long step and then a short one. A pause. A breath. A turn of the head, toward the far side of the field, toward whatever had been there when his eyes left Hanzō's, and back.

Hanzō's cut went into the pause and found nothing.

The boy's went into the place Hanzō had left for him.

It opened his shoulder.

Hanzō went back again. The rain was on his face. His sword was still in his hand and still exactly where it should have been, and it did not matter where it should have been.

Above the system.

He thought it, and did not know where the words came from. They were not in the Bansenshūkai. He had read every word of it, and they were not there.

The boy was above it.

Not outside. Not against it. Above it. Doing everything the system did, and more. The extra step. The extra breath. The thing that served no purpose. All the things Hanzō had taken out of himself, one by one, for thirty years, because they could not be read, and a thing that could not be read could not be trusted.

They could not be read.

That was all. That was the whole of it. They could not be read, and so nothing that only read could stop them.

The boy came in again.

Hanzō met him, and met him, and the third one went past his guard and across his ribs, and he went back, and the ground went soft under his heel, and he did not know, for the first time in his life, where his foot was going to land.

Somewhere behind him, far off in the rain, someone was standing. He had not seen who. He knew they were there by the boy's eyes, which had gone past him to them once.

They did not go there again.

They did not need to.

Chapter 88

Winning

Blade on blade.

Hanzō's sword and his, meeting, and sliding, and meeting again, in the rain, so close that Ren could hear the older man's breath. It had gone short. It had not been short at the start. It was short now, and there was blood coming down Hanzō's sleeve from the shoulder, and the ground was going soft under his heels.

He was still reading.

Ren could see him do it. Even now. Even going back. Hanzō's eyes on Ren's blade, and on his feet, and on his shoulders, and on the blade again, taking all of it in and putting it where it went and answering. Still answering. Not every time now. But still.

Still watching the blade.

Ren stepped in.

Not with the sword. Past the sword. Too close for swords, closer than there was room for, the way the man with the plain face had come in on the slope in the starlight, chest to chest. His shoulder went into Hanzō's chest. Not hard. The way a man stumbles into another man in a crowd. The way a boy's foot goes into an open drain in an alley, and his hand goes out, and catches at the robe of the man in front of him to keep his feet.

His left hand went across Hanzō's robe.

And out again.

He stepped back.

It had taken less time than a breath. Hayate's trick. The first week. A road, and a purse, and a little knife in a plain wooden sheath, and Hayate behind him holding them out, smiling. *To see how easy it is?*

It was easy.

Hanzō had not looked down.

His eyes were on Ren's sword. Where they had been. Where they had been all morning. He had felt a shoulder come into his chest and he had read it as what it looked like, a man too close, a clumsy step, and his sword had already gone to where Ren's sword would be after it. He was still watching the blade.

In Ren's left hand, against his chest, two rolls.

One bare, stained dark at one end where the water had gone in. One tied with a cord, the cord hanging, the paper grey with mud in the grain.

He set his sword point down in the mud beside him, and let go of it.

Hanzō's eyes went to it. To the sword standing there on its own. Reading it. What it meant. What came after a man put down his sword in the middle of a fight.

Ren reached back over his shoulder with his right hand.

The blanket roll was on his back where it had been since the house in the bamboo. Brown, coarse, darned at the corner. Tied with a cord at each end. He found the near cord and pulled it, and the roll came loose and fell down his back and opened as it fell, and out of the middle of it, where no hand would have found it unless it unrolled the whole thing, the third one came into his fingers.

Kōga's.

The one he had carried out of a burning house. The one he had read on a rock by a river, with the moon going in and out. The one nobody knew he still had.

Three.

He held them.

For a moment. All three of them, against his chest, one against the other against the other. Heavier than paper should be.

He could feel them.

He could feel what was in them. Every word he had read. Every word he had not read yet. The ones that sharpened the body, and the ones that sharpened the eye, and the ones that made the whole world into a board with the pieces on it, all of them, one against the other, pressing on him when he breathed. Everything they promised. Everything the old man had never had. All of it, in his arms, and nothing between him and the rest of it but the time it would take to read.

They pulled.

He felt them pull, the way a current pulls at your legs in a river when you are standing in it up to the waist.

He did not look at them.

He opened his arms, and they fell.

Into the mud at his feet. One and then the next and then the next. The stained roll. The grey paper. Kōga's, half unrolled, the first lines showing, black on pale, going into the wet.

He did not look at them there either.

His hand went to the belt across his chest.

Shigure's belt. Dark leather, oiled, with the slots and the loops sewn along it, that somebody had measured for him a long time ago. The needles were gone. The shells were gone. The short blade was gone, in the notch, in the smoke. There was one slot left with anything in it.

A clay ball. Small. Round. With its tail of cord.

The last of Enji's.

The slow match was around his left wrist, where he had wound it, lit end out, the way Enji had worn it. He had lit it at the burning shelter, going past, before the smoke gave up Daichi and Ayame. He had not known why. He had only known the shelter was there, and the match was around his wrist, and his hand had done it.

He knew now.

Too close and you die.

He touched the cord to the match.

It caught. A small hiss, a small red eye, going.

He bent, and set the ball down on the scrolls in the mud. Gently. The way you set down a cup.

He straightened.

He stepped back.

One.

Two.

Three.

Exact.

***

Hanzō's eyes came off the sword standing in the mud.

Ren saw them come. Down. To the ground in front of Ren's feet. To the three rolls in the mud, and the small round thing sitting on top of them, and the thin grey thread of smoke going up off it in the rain.

His hand went to his robe.

Ren saw that too. The hand going flat against the front of the robe, where they had been, one against the other, heavier than paper should be. And finding nothing.

Hanzō understood.

A heartbeat too late. Ren saw it arrive in his face, the whole of it at once. And Hanzō moved. Forward. Toward the mud. Toward the rolls. Fast, faster than Ren had seen him move all morning, his hand going out.

The ground went up.

***

It was very loud, and then it was very quiet.

Ren stood where he was, three steps back, with the sound of it still in his chest and his ears ringing and the rain coming down. In front of him, where the scrolls had been, there was a hole in the mud, black, shallow, and fire.

Fire in the rain. Paper burning.

It went up the way paper goes up when it has been dry for a long time inside a roll and is let loose all at once. Bright. Yellow and white. Hissing where the rain hit it and burning anyway. He could see the rolls in it, coming apart. The stained end, catching, going. The grey paper, curling back on itself, black at the edges, then all black, then bright, then nothing. Kōga's, half unrolled, the lines of writing showing for a moment in the flame, black on gold, very clear, every word, and then the gold went through the words and there were no words.

And the wind took it.

It came across the valley from the west, the way it had come all morning, and it lifted a few pieces of the burning paper up off the mud. Small pieces. Bright, and then dark, and then grey. Up. A little way. Into the rain.

Ash.

It did not go far.

A few flakes, grey and wet, turning over once or twice on the air before the rain caught them. On the water in the nearest field, where they lay a moment on the surface and went dark and sank.

He watched one piece go. On the wind. A scrap of paper, black at the edges, with the shadow of a line of writing still on it. It went over the paddy wall and a little way out over the field, turning, and the rain beat it down into the water, and it was gone.

The fighting stopped.

Not all at once. He watched it. A man near the hole, with his blade up, and a wet grey flake landing on the back of his hand, and the man looking at it. A man there, turning his head toward the smoke, to see where the sound had come from. Two men, Tokugawa and Kōga, with their blades locked, and a black scrap going down past their faces into the mud, and one of them stepping back. And the next. And the next. Out from the open ground, across the whole valley, the way a field of rice goes still when the wind drops. Men turning to the thin smoke in the middle of the field, and lowering their blades.

The drums had stopped. He did not know when.

Ren watched the scrolls burn.

He watched them all the way. Until the fire in the hole was only a few red edges, curling, going black. Until there was nothing in the hole but a few black scraps, with the rain coming down on them and darkening them.

He had never seen the ash of the old man's fire while the old man lived.

Not once. Not one morning in eleven years. The old man had gotten up in the dark, every morning, and knelt, and gathered it in his two hands, and carried it out to the edge of the ledge, and let the dark take it. So that when the boy woke there would only be the fire.

He saw this ash.

He saw all of it. The last of it, black and wet in the hole in the mud. Black flecks of soot on his own hands, and on his sleeves, going dark in the rain.

He did not brush them away.

***

Hanzō was standing a few steps away.

He had been thrown back, or had stopped. Ren did not know which. He was standing in the mud with his sword low in one hand and the other hand flat against the front of his robe, where there was nothing. His face was black down one side from the blast. His hair. His shoulders. The blood on his sleeve had mud in it.

He was looking at the hole in the ground.

He did not raise his sword.

He did not come forward. He stood there with his hand on his empty robe and the rain coming down on him, very lightly, very slowly, and looked at the place where the scrolls had been.

Ren did not pick up his sword. It was standing in the mud where he had left it, a little way off, with the rain running off the guard.

Neither of them moved.

***

A long way off, at the edge of the open ground, Hayate stood with his bad arm across his chest and a borrowed blade hanging from his other hand, and the rain coming down on him.

He had been running. He had stopped.

He had seen it. He did not think anyone else on the field had. A shoulder going into a chest, clumsy, a stumble, the way a man stumbles in a crowd. A hand going across the front of a robe. And out.

He knew that move.

He had done it in an alley, the first week, to a boy who walked in front of him and did not like to be walked beside. He had done it to see how easy it was.

He had taught it.

He had not known he was teaching it.

Hayate stood in the rain with the water running down his face, and laughed, once, very quietly, and could not have said why.

Chapter 89

Salvation

Nobody moved.

Hayate stood at the edge of the open ground with the rain coming down on him and listened.

There was nothing to listen to. That was the thing. A moment ago the whole valley had been noise. Drums, and shouting, and steel, and men dying the way men die, loudly or not. It had been noise since first light. He had stopped hearing it the way you stop hearing a river you are standing in.

Now it was gone.

The rain, very light, on the water in the fields. The fire in the burning shelter, low, ticking. Somewhere far off, a horse, blowing through its nose. That was all. All over the valley, men were standing where the sound had found them, with their blades in their hands, not using them. Tokugawa. Kōga. Iga. The grey ones, standing still, which he had never seen. Nobody going anywhere. Nobody knowing where there was to go.

It was not that they had stopped fighting. It was that there was nothing left to fight for, and all of them had felt it, one man after another, and none of them could have said what it was.

In the middle of it, on the open ground, Ren.

Alone. His sword standing in the mud a little way off. His blanket lying open on the ground behind him where it had fallen. His hands empty at his sides. The rain coming down on his hair and his shoulders, and him not wiping it away.

A few steps from him, Hanzō.

Hayate watched him. The old man had not moved since the fire went up. He was standing in the mud with his sword low and his other hand flat against the front of his robe, and he was looking at Ren.

Not the way he had looked at him before. Not reading. Hayate had seen the old man read people, on a hillside, over a map, and this was not that. He was only looking. For a long time.

Then Hanzō took his hand away from his robe.

He let his sword go down until the point was in the mud. He looked at Ren a moment longer.

And he bowed.

Not deeply. The way a man bows to another man across a board, when the game is finished. The way he had bowed on a hillside, over a burning valley, a long time ago, with a scroll in his robe.

Only this time there was nothing in his robe.

Hayate understood, watching him. The old man knew. All of it. What Ren had done, and why. Hayate could see it in the bow. It was not a bow to a man who had won. It was a bow to a man who had ended something, and knew exactly what it cost.

Hanzō straightened, and stepped back, and stood.

He did not leave. He did not come closer. He stood where he was, with the rain on his shoulders, and watched.

Hayate started to walk.

He did not decide to. His feet went. Out across the open ground, through the mud, past the men standing with their blades hanging, toward the middle.

He passed Ren's sword where it stood in the mud.

He stopped. He looked at it. The grey steel, with the pattern in it like mist lying on water, and the rain running off the guard.

He put down the borrowed blade, the one that was too heavy at the tip, on the ground beside it. He took Ren's sword by the hilt and drew it up out of the mud, with his one good hand.

He did not know why.

He knew why.

He went on walking.

On the far side of the open ground, coming the other way, slowly, through the same rain, Aoi.

***

She walked.

She did not hurry. There was no reason to hurry. There was nothing left in the valley that needed anyone to be quick. The spear was in her hand, upright, the butt coming down on the wet earth every other step, the way her father had walked with it on long roads.

She did not hesitate.

Her feet did not slow, and her hand did not change on the shaft, and she did not stop and stand and think about it. Her body knew where it was going. It had known since the ridge. Since before the ridge. Since a pine wood, and a ring of stones, and ash under her fingers still warm.

The rest of her knew too.

She knew it the way you know, when you are walking toward a door, what is on the other side of it. It was the end. Not of the fight. The fight had ended when the ground went up. It was the end of something much larger than a fight, that had been going on since long before she was born. The vault, and the scrolls, and the four stars and the six stars and the grey ones and the man with his hands in his sleeves. The whole of it. Everything she had been raised inside, since she was small enough to be lifted onto her father's shoulders to watch.

It was the end of the five of them. Hayate had told her about them on the road from Iga, in pieces, the way he told everything. The silent one. The one with the clay. The one with the stones. Himself, the loud one. And the boy.

It was the end of him.

She walked toward it.

Hayate was coming from the other side. She could see him through the rain. He had Ren's sword in his good hand, the grey one, and his bad arm across his chest, and his face was very still.

They came to Ren at the same time.

He was standing where he had stood when the fire went up. He had not moved. There was smoke-black on his face from the fire, and the rain on his hair and his shoulders and his eyelashes. His hands were empty.

He looked at them.

At Aoi first. Then at Hayate. Then back.

Something was in his eyes. She had spent a whole summer learning to read those eyes and she had never once seen it there. Not in the grey on the training ground. Not in the rain cave. Not in the red light of the vault, with his blade at her throat and his whole weight behind it and then stopping.

It was not the thing that had been missing. The thing she had spent a summer looking for, the second face, the thing behind. There was no second face.

It was only him.

All of him. Looking at her. Looking at both of them. And understanding. She could see him understand it, the whole of it, all at once, the way she had seen him understand a fight before it began. What he was. What he had done. What he had been made into, by the snow and by the cold. What was left. What would come after, if anything came after.

What they had come to do.

He was not afraid of it.

He looked at her, and at Hayate, and his face was quiet, and his voice when it came was quiet too. Not asking. The way you say a thing you have never been more sure of.

"Don't hesitate."

Aoi stepped forward.

She did not hesitate.

The spear came up and forward, the whole of her body turning in behind it, the way her father had taught her, and she drove it into him. Through the chest. Clean. Deep. All the way.

Ren did not fall.

He stood. With the shaft of her father's spear going into him, and her hands on it, and her body a pace from his. Standing, the way he had always stood, straight, his feet under him.

He was looking at her.

She was looking at him.

They stopped. The two of them. For a moment. There was nothing else. Not the valley. Not the dead. Not the rain. Only the shaft of the spear between them, and his eyes, and hers, a pace apart.

His eyes were wet.

Not with the rain. She could see the difference. A line, going down from the corner of one of them, slowly, through the smoke-black on his face.

She did not look away.

Then his eyes left hers. Slowly. They went past her shoulder, and up, a little. To Hayate.

***

Hayate was crying.

He had not known he was going to. He had not felt it start. His face was wet and his eyes were full and he could not see very well, and he stood there with Ren's sword in his one good hand and let it happen, because there was nothing else he could do about it.

Ren looked at him.

And there it was.

Hayate saw it come into Ren's eyes. He did not know how he knew what it was. He knew. Because it was coming into his own at the same time, the same thing, at once, the way it had always come into both of them at once.

A fire.

Small. In a ring of stones. On open ground, at night, a long time ago, early on. The five of them around it. Himself, telling some story badly, his hands going, getting the end wrong and having to go back. Kurogane with his arms folded, not laughing, and something at the corner of his mouth. Shigure sitting very straight, turning a stone over in his fingers. Enji, rolling a clay ball across the ground to him, slow, with a small dry sound, and it stopping by his knee.

And Ren. Right beside him. The firelight on one side of his face. Listening to every word.

Alive. All of them. Whole. Nobody gone yet. Nobody in the snow, or the fire, or the forest. Just the five of them, and the fire, and the night around them, and nothing to do but sit there.

Human.

Hayate saw it in Ren's eyes. He saw Ren see it too. He saw it go across Ren's face, just for a moment, and the corner of his mouth move.

The sword moved.

Hayate did not decide it. He had been told not to hesitate, and he did not. His arm went, and the grey steel went with it, across, level, the whole of him behind it and nothing left over, the way Kurogane threw, the way Kurogane did everything.

Clean.

The fire went out of his eyes. Out of both of their eyes. It went out in the middle, the way a memory goes when something cuts across it.

Ren's head fell.

It struck the mud, and rolled a little way, and lay still, turned up toward the grey sky, with the rain coming down on it.

His body stood a moment longer, held up on Aoi's spear. Then her hands opened on the shaft, and it went down, slowly, onto its knees, and forward, into the mud.

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Silence.

It was the same silence as before. Nothing had changed in it. The rain, very light, on the water. The fire in the shelter, ticking, going out. The last thin smoke going up from the hole in the open ground, and leaning away east on the wind, and gone.

Aoi stood with her empty hands.

Hayate stood with the grey sword, and the blood on it, and the rain washing the blood off it into the mud, and did not move.

Neither of them said anything.

A long way off, over the hills to the east, a single crow was calling.

Chapter 90

Remains

The rain was still coming down.

It came down on the hill the way it came down on everything. Lightly, steadily, out of the low grey sky. It landed on Kikyo's sleeves and darkened them. It landed in her hair. It landed on the wet grass at her feet, among the petals that had been trodden into the mud of the path, pink going brown, and beat the pink down into the brown.

She did not cover her head.

Below her, the valley was silent.

She had watched it go silent. From here, from the top of the hill, where she had watched everything since the first banners came in on the north road. She had watched the lanterns burn in the rocks where nobody was, and the arrows go into the trees, and the gap open in the line, and the grey go into the gap. She had watched Iga come down off the ridge. She had watched a man in a dark robe walk out into the open ground, and the boy stop walking, and the two of them go around each other in the rain for a long time.

She had watched the ground go up. A small white flash, and then the sound of it, a moment after, coming up the hill. And then the smoke. A thin grey thread of it, going up from the middle of the open ground, and leaning away east on the wind.

She had watched the valley go still around it.

Now there was no sound at all.

The banners were down. Not fallen. Lowered. Men had let them go down, one by one, and stood with the poles leaning on their shoulders. Nobody was fighting. All across the valley, on the fields and the road and the open ground and along the river, men were standing. Tokugawa. Kōga. Iga. The grey ones. In the same field. Among the same dead. Close enough to touch each other. Not touching. Not doing anything. Standing in the rain with their blades hanging from their hands, the way men stand who have woken in a place they do not remember walking to.

They did not know what they were.

She could see it from here. She could see it in the way they stood. Every one of them had come into the valley that morning knowing exactly what he was, and what he was for, and who the others were. They did not know anymore. It had gone out across the field from that thin smoke, one man at a time, and taken it.

She had seen the girl's blade.

She had seen it from here. The spear, going forward, the whole of the girl's body going in behind it. And the boy not falling.

She had seen the other one's. The loud one. The one with his arm bound. A grey line in the grey light, across, level.

She had seen him fall.

She had not looked away. She did not think she could have. She had watched him cross every map she had ever drawn, and she watched him fall, and then she watched the place where he had been, for a long time, while the rain came down on it.

Suzuya had not moved all morning.

He stood a little behind her in the wet grass with his hands in his sleeves and the rain on his shoulders, and looked down at the valley.

"It's over," said Suzuya.

"No," said Kikyo. "It's finished."

Suzuya looked at her.

She did not look back at him. She looked at the valley.

"Over is when someone wins."

Suzuya did not say anything.

He looked at the valley again. At the men standing in it. At the place in the middle of the open ground where the boy had been. He looked at it a long time. Then he nodded, very slightly, the way a man nods when he has been told something he already knew and did not want to.

Kikyo put her hand into her sleeve.

It was there. It had been there since the dark room. She had carried it in her fingers down the hill and up this one, and in her sleeve through the night, and she had held it up against the valley once, at arm's length, and not done anything with it.

She took it out.

A needle. Iron. Very straight. With the rain on it now, beading along it, near the point.

The one that had moved furthest.

She had thrown it into the capital, on the first night, across the lamplight, into the tiny squares of the streets. She had moved it into the mountains, where there were no roads. And into the valley, where it had stood alone in an empty place at the edge of the map, apart from every line, for the last two nights she had had a map to put it on.

There was no map now.

There was nothing to put it on. There was nobody left to move. Nothing to read, nothing to draw, nothing to direct. There was only the valley, and the rain, and the men standing in it, and the place where he had fallen.

She looked at the needle on her palm.

Then she threw it.

Not at anything. Not at a place. She did not aim. She drew her arm back and threw it the way you throw a stone off a bridge into a river, out, over the edge of the hill, into the air above the valley. It went up, very thin, very dark, catching the grey light for an instant. And then it was among the rain, going down with it, the same color, the same straight line.

She did not see where it went.

She did not look.

Suzuya had watched it go. He stood with his eyes on the place in the air where it had been.

"What is Kōga now?" he said.

Kikyo thought about it.

She thought about the men in the rocks, lying alone in the bracken, not knowing where the others were. The lanterns burning in places where nobody was standing. The houses on the map that were not houses anymore, the roads nobody used twice. The needles she had carried in her sleeve, and stopped carrying, and not gone looking for. A sword leaning against a wall to the right of a door, at an old angle, that nobody touched.

She thought about it for a long time.

"People," she said.

She turned.

She walked away from the edge of the hill, across the top of it, through the wet grass, and down the other side. The side away from the valley. The path went down through the pines toward the west, where the wind was coming from, and she took it.

She did not look back.

Suzuya stood on the hilltop a moment longer. Then he followed her.

Behind them, in the grass at the top of the hill, a crow that had been sitting there, black and wet, lifted off, and went up into the falling rain, and was gone.

Chapter 91

Again.

By afternoon the valley was emptying.

Nobody gave an order. Nobody had to. The Tokugawa went first, because they were the only ones who still knew how to go anywhere together. A drum, once, slow, and the banners came up off the men's shoulders, and the ranks formed on the road, not straight, with gaps in them, and went back the way they had come, north, between the two low hills. They took their dead on carts. They did not look at the fields.

The Kōga were not there. Hayate did not see them go. He looked up once and the rocks along the west slope were only rocks, with a paper lantern here and there burned out and hanging.

The grey ones were not there either. He did not see them go. Nobody ever did.

Iga went last. Takeda's people, and the young ones, going back up the ridge to the south in twos and threes with their wounded between them. Slowly. Looking back, some of them. Not stopping.

Hanzō he saw.

A long way off, on the open ground by the burnt shelter, the old man and one of his people, carrying someone between them on a door taken off the shelter's frame. He watched them go across the field toward the west slope and up into the pines. The old man walked at the back. He did not look around.

Then there was nobody.

The rice, and the river, and the road, and the dead. And the rain had stopped. And the light was going.

Nobody had come to tell anyone what happened next. Nobody knew. There was nothing that told anyone anything anymore. There were only people, going home, if they had homes, the long way around.

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They built it on a rise by the river, where the ground was dry, above the fields.

Aoi built it.

Hayate carried. The wood from the burnt shelter, the timbers that had not caught, and dead pine from the edge of the trees, one-handed, three and four pieces at a time, and set it down beside her and went back for more. He did not try to lay any of it. He knew better.

She laid it the way it should be laid. Long pieces first, crossed. Then the short ones. Then more long ones, crossed the other way, and more. Built up square and high and even, the way her father had built a fire on the long roads, when there was time to build it right.

Then they carried him to it.

They did it together, without saying anything. They laid him on it. All of him. Aoi straightened his coat. Hayate brought the blanket from where it had fallen, and she laid it over him, and tucked it in at his shoulders. Hayate put the grey sword down beside the pyre in the grass, and then picked it up again, and did not know what to do with it, and laid it across his own knees when he sat down.

It was dark when Aoi struck the flint.

Two strikes. The spark went into the tinder and she bent and breathed on it, and it caught, and she fed it into the bottom of the pile, and the long pieces took it, and it went up.

They sat.

Across the fire from each other. The fire between them, and him in it. The light going up on both their faces. The sound of it. That was all there was. The crackling, and the wood settling, and sometimes a sharp snap that sent sparks up into the dark and they went out against the sky.

Aoi looked at him across it.

Hayate did not know what his face was doing. He let it do it.

She stayed a long time. Longer than he would have thought. She sat very straight, with her spear lying on the ground beside her and her hands in her lap, and looked at the fire, and at him, and at the fire. She did not say anything. He did not.

Then, at some point, she stood.

She picked up her spear. She looked at the fire one more time. She looked at him.

Then she turned, and went down off the rise, into the dark, toward the south, toward the ridge, and he heard her feet in the wet grass for a while, and then he did not.

Hayate sat.

The fire went on.

He sat with the grey sword across his knees and his bad arm against his chest and looked at it. For a long time. There was nothing to look at but the fire. There was nothing to listen to but the fire.

Then he heard his own voice.

"...Idiot."

It went out into the dark and nothing came back.

Silence.

He looked at the fire.

"I still can't make a fire."

Silence again.

The wood settled. Sparks went up.

"Shigure would've hated this."

Silence again.

"Enji would've made it worse somehow. Kurogane would've just... stared and judged."

He stopped.

Silence.

He looked into the middle of it, where the light was brightest and he could not see anything at all.

"You know... this is the longest you ever listened to me."

And then he went on.

He did not know what he said. Afterward he could not have told anyone. Everything. Nothing. The man in Nara who could tell the weather by his knee. The soup in Iga. The sandal he had thrown at a man in a stream, and how he had liked that sandal. The road, the first week. A purse and a little knife. The alley with the drain in it. How he had never once gotten a story right the first time, and how nobody had ever minded, and how one of them had always been listening to every word, right beside him, with the firelight on one side of his face.

His voice went out into the dark over the fields, and the fire went up into the dark over his voice, and there was nothing else in the whole valley. Nothing else anywhere.

It went on a long time.

Then it went on less.

Then it was only a word now and then, with a long quiet between. And then it was only the fire.

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He woke to crows.

He did not know when he had slept. He was lying on his side in the wet grass by the fire ring with the sword under his hand, and the sky was grey and pale, and there was mist on the river below, and the crows were calling. Close. Not far off over the hills. Here.

He sat up.

Three of them.

On the ground, around the fire, in the grey light. Black, with the ash on their feathers. Sitting very still.

One across from him, upright, not moving. Where a man would sit with his arms folded and not laugh.

One on the left, a little back, very straight, with its head a little on one side, looking at everything. Where a man would sit turning a stone over in his fingers, knowing where everyone was.

One close in to the edge, low, with its feathers fluffed up around it. Where a man would sit with his knees drawn up and something round and small in his hand, turning it, turning it.

And Hayate, where he had always sat.

He looked at them for a long time. They did not fly. They looked at him.

Then he looked at the fire.

At the place in the middle of the ring where the long pieces had been laid first, crossed, and the short ones, and him on top of them.

There was no fire.

The smoke had stopped. There was nothing standing. Nothing burning. The rise was quiet and grey and still in the morning, and the mist was going up off the river, and the three crows sat around the ring in their places, and the place in the middle was grey and soft and fine, and when the little wind came up off the water it moved, a very little, and settled again.

By next morning, it was all ash.